

Author's Note

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Chapter 1: To New Beginnings

Mami stirred with a soft yawn, her body stretching beneath the quilted blanket as golden morning light spilled gently across the wooden floor. The cabin was quiet, wrapped in the hush of early day, and the air held the crisp clarity of a forest morning — cool, fragrant, and alive.

She rubbed her eyes and turned toward the opening in the wall, where sunlight filtered through the trees in dappled patterns, casting flickers of gold and green across her bed. Outside, the forest swayed with a soft breeze, the leaves rustling like whispers, the birds beginning their morning songs.

It was another peaceful, beautiful morning in the realm — the kind of morning that made her heart feel light and her soul feel clean. She inhaled deeply, letting the fresh air fill her lungs, and for a moment, everything felt still. Safe.

But beneath that calm, excitement stirred.

Today was the day.

She and dream-Kyoko would connect for the first time — not just emotionally, but in combat. Kyoko had been fired up yesterday, practically vibrating with determination to put on a good show.

She wanted to redeem herself in the eyes of the realm's watchers — the beings whose essences lingered in the area, who had witnessed Mami and Kyoko's disastrous fight against the six witches. The memory of them screaming and clutching each other in fear haunted Kyoko, and Kyoko was desperate to rewrite that narrative.

Mami had smiled at Kyoko's bravado, but she couldn't shake what Kasumi had said in response — how impressed she was by Kyoko's confidence, and how that confidence might inspire Kasumi to prepare something truly "nasty" for their fight. Something so intense that their previous humiliation would look graceful by comparison.

Mami frowned slightly as she slipped on her boots and walked toward the cabin door. What could Kasumi possibly prepare that would be *that* bad? She opened the door slowly, bracing herself for whatever awaited.

Outside, the forest was bathed in morning light. The trees shimmered with dew, and the air was filled with the earthy scent of moss and pine. In the clearing, Kasumi was already awake — doing stretches with comically exaggerated motions, her arms flailing like windmills, her legs kicking out in dramatic arcs. Her back was to Mami, and she moved with the theatrical flair of someone who knew they had an audience.

Mami smiled, amused by the sight.

“Good morning, Kasumi,” she called out warmly.

Kasumi froze mid-stretch, then straightened with a flourish.

“Good morning, Mami!” she replied, voice bright and energetic. “How did you sleep?”

She didn’t turn around.

Mami stepped closer, her smile lingering.

“Wonderfully, as always in this realm. It’s like the air itself sings you to sleep.”

She paused, her tone softening with hope.

“How did your and Lunaria’s adventure in Kamihama go yesterday? Did you... did you find another way? One that doesn’t involve me learning a fraction of dis-connect in just a few days?”

Kasumi turned around slowly.

Her eyes met Mami’s.

And then widened.

She stared.

Mami blinked, confused.

Kasumi raised a hand to her mouth, trying — and failing — to suppress the laughter bubbling up in her chest. A few chuckles escaped, then a full laugh burst out, echoing through the clearing like bells.

Mami tilted her head, her heart beginning to sink.

“Why are you laughing?” she asked, voice uncertain. “Did something funny happen in Kamihama? Did you and Lunaria find another path? Or... is Sayaka doomed?”

Kasumi continued to stare at her masterpiece — the glittery, metallic, absolutely hideous marker decorations she’d drawn on Mami’s face the night before. Swirls, stars, and chaotic scribbles framed Mami’s cheeks, forehead, and chin like a carnival gone wrong. It was glorious. It was terrible.

It was art.

Kasumi wiped a tear from her eye and finally spoke.

“If you want answers to those questions,” she said between giggles, “you and Kyoko will have to put on a *very* good show during your *special* fight today.”

She stepped closer, her grin mischievous.

“And don’t worry,” she added, voice dropping ominously. “I prepared something very... *special* for you two.”

She winked.

The word hung in the air like a spell.

Special.

Mami swallowed.

The day had only just begun.

Mami stood frozen, mouth slightly agape, stunned into silence. The morning breeze tousled her hair, but she barely noticed. Kasumi’s ominous emphasis on “special” echoed in her ears like a drumbeat. She was about to be thrown off the cliff again — not literally, but emotionally, spiritually, maybe even magically. Pushed off the deep end, just like before.

She chuckled softly, the sound half-resigned, half-amused.

“This reminds me,” she said aloud, her voice drifting into the forest air, “of when I first met Lunaria.”

Kasumi paused mid-stretch, listening.

Mami’s gaze wandered toward the treetops, her thoughts drifting back through time like leaves caught in a breeze.

“When I was teleported into that void realm... after Charlotte ‘killed’ me,” she said softly. “I thought it was over. I thought I was dead. The area swirling with light and shadow. And then Lunaria appeared.”

Her voice grew steadier, tinged with awe.

“She was... mysterious. Elegant. Impossible. Like something out of a dream. She told me Madoka and Sayaka were in danger. Lied, really. Just to manipulate me. To push me into breaking.”

She smiled faintly, remembering the ache in her chest, the confusion, the fury — the way her soul had felt like it was unraveling.

“She said she wouldn’t answer any of my questions unless I beat her in a fight. And I tried. I really did. But she absolutely destroyed me. I didn’t stand a chance.”

Kasumi snorted, amused.

“But later that night,” Mami continued, her voice softening, “I woke up here. In this realm. I wandered out into the moonlight, still aching, still lost. And there she was — Lunaria — sitting by the lake,

playing the flute and harp at the same time. The stars were out, the water was glowing, and her music...”

She paused, eyes distant.

“It was so achingly beautiful that I forgot about my troubles for a moment. Just one moment. It felt like my soul could breathe again.”

She took a breath, then continued slowly, as if unwrapping a memory she’d kept close to her heart.

“Then Lunaria explained everything to me. About magical girls. About witches. About soul gems. She told me that despair isn’t something to fear — that it can be used, transformed. That as long as my soul is at peace, I will never become a witch.”

Her voice trembled slightly.

“My life completely changed that day. For the first time since I became a magical girl... I had genuine hope.”

She turned to Kasumi, her eyes glinting with mischief and warmth.

“So I don’t have to win the fight today, right?” she teased. “You’ll answer some of my questions anyway? Maybe even give me a little more hope and insight?”

Kasumi chuckled, her grin sly, her eyes dancing.

“Who knows?” she said. “All I said was that you and Kyoko have to put on a *good show* during your special fight today. Against a *special* opponent prepared by yours truly.”

She emphasized the word *special* again, with theatrical menace.

“What ‘good show’ means,” she added, “I’ll leave to your imagination.”

Mami laughed, shaking her head.

She looked up into the clear blue sky, the sunlight warming her cheeks, the wind brushing past like a whisper of encouragement. Her imagination stirred — wondering who this “special” opponent could be, what kind of spectacle she and Kyoko would have to create, and what new abilities might awaken when they finally connected. According to Lunaria and Kasumi, they were bound only by their imaginations. That thought thrilled her.

She turned back to Kasumi, her eyes bright with excitement and resolve.

“I’m ready,” she said.

Kasumi clapped her hands together.

“Great! Let’s go to the arena then. There’s a good hearty breakfast waiting for you there — you’ll need it to fuel up for the big event.”

They laughed together, the sound ringing through the trees like bells.

And with that, Kasumi led Mami down the forest path, toward whatever awaited.

Momoko stirred.

A soft yawn escaped her lips as she stretched her arms above her head, her joints loosening with a satisfying pop. Her body felt light, as if she'd slept for days. She sat up slowly, rubbing her eyes with the heel of her palms, her breath steady, her heart quiet.

Wait...

She blinked, still groggy.

Where am I?

The last thing she remembered was Kasumi — her warm, happy, chaotic energy surging through her like sunlight — just as Momoko was fading, her body collapsing from the strain of saving the doppelified magical girls. She had felt herself slipping away, her soul unraveling. And then... nothing.

But now she was here.

Yawning. Stretching. Breathing.

Alive.

Or... was this the afterlife?

Her fingers brushed her cheeks, and she paused.

Wet.

Tears.

She hadn't noticed them at first, but now she felt the quiet heaviness in her chest — a lingering ache, not of pain, but of sorrow. Her heart felt full, tender. She realized it must be from the dream.

The dream.

It hadn't felt like a dream.

It had felt like memory.

Two magical girls — Mami and Kyoko — descending into an ancient pyramid, their footsteps echoing through stone corridors lined with murals. Each mural told a story — of grief, exile, and betrayal. Twelve girls, once beloved daughters of their village, had watched their families executed by fearful townsfolk who saw their magic as a curse. The pain of that day had split them in two.

Six of them were consumed by despair, their soul gems cracking under the weight of grief. They became witches — monstrous and beautiful in their agony — known by the names Velmira, Ruinelle, Catastrophia, Thornaria, Noctulisse, and Vexaphra. Their original names, the ones they bore as magical girls, were lost to time... or perhaps buried beneath the sorrow that transformed them.

The other six — Elira Mizunagi, Sylvette Prothea, Mirielle Calden, Hoshine Tsunagari, and two girls without soul gems — were left behind. Forced to fight their former friends. Forced to survive.

Then came Mami and Kyoko's battles — against the mummified guardians of the pyramid, against Aurellia Mizunagi, the spectral echo of a sister who had lost everything, and finally against the six witches themselves. Their names still echoed in Momoko's mind like a chant, like a warning.

And then the simulation.

The origin of Connect.

She saw it all — the epic and tragic fight between Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, Hoshine, and the two unnamed girls against the witches they once loved. The shadow monster that devoured the witches, then reached for the rest. The moment of final connection — raw, unintentional, born of desperation and love. The victory that came at a cost.

Three girls dead.

Three left behind.

The closing image — Hoshine Tsunagari and the two girls without soul gems collapsing onto the corpses of their fallen friends, wailing in grief — had carved itself into Momoko's soul. It wasn't just sorrow. It was history. It was truth.

And somehow, it had become part of her.

She remembered it all.

Every detail.

Every emotion.

As if she had lived it.

She opened her eyes.

And gasped.

She was in a room — a cabin, rustic and warm, with wooden walls and soft quilts. The air was gentle, filled with the scent of cedar and wildflowers. Morning light streamed through a round opening in the wall, casting golden patterns across the floor.

She turned toward the window.

And her breath caught.

Outside was a forest — lush, green, alive. The sky was a brilliant blue, cloudless and serene. A breeze danced through the trees, causing the branches to sway in rhythm, like nature itself was breathing.

Momoko closed her eyes and inhaled deeply.

The air was crisp, fresh, tinged with the scent of pine and blooming petals. It filled her lungs like a balm, soothing every ache, every sorrow. She exhaled slowly, her shoulders relaxing.

What is this place? she thought.

It's so beautiful. So peaceful. So full of life.

Her soul felt light.

As if something had been lifted.

She turned to the other side of the room.

And gasped again.

Mifuyu and Kuroe lay in separate beds beside her, their faces calm, their breathing steady. They looked like ordinary girls — not magical girls burdened by grief and sacrifice, but girls who had never known despair.

But then she saw it.

Thin lines of tears trailing down their cheeks.

Momoko smiled softly.

Maybe they had the same dream, she thought.

Maybe they felt it too.

She didn't know where they were.

She didn't know what came next.

But her heart burned with excitement at what was to come.

Momoko smiled mischievously as she tiptoed between the two beds. Morning light streamed through the cabin window, casting soft golden patterns across the wooden floor. The air was cool and fragrant, filled with the scent of cedar and wildflowers. She reached down, grabbed the edge of each blanket with theatrical flair, and took a deep breath.

“Gooood Mooooorning! Rise and shine!” she shouted, her voice bright and teasing.

Mifuyu and Kuroe groaned in unison, their bodies stirring beneath the covers. They rubbed their eyes, still groggy, their movements slow and heavy with sleep. The sound of Momoko's voice in the morning was familiar — comforting, even. She had always acted like the older sister among magical girls, the one who looked out for everyone, even when she herself was exhausted.

Mifuyu sat up, her hair tousled, her eyes still closed as she rubbed them with the heel of her palm.

“Good morning, Momoko,” she mumbled, voice soft and uncertain. “Are we... still alive?”

She paused, trying to piece together the last fragments of memory.

“The last thing I remember was my consciousness fading. I was dying... from our sacrifice to save the doppelified girls. And then... I felt Kasumi’s energy. Warm. Happy. Playful. It wrapped around me like sunlight. I submitted to it. And then... everything went blank.”

Kuroe stirred beside her, her voice hoarse and quiet.

“Good morning,” she said. “To both of you.”

She remained curled under the blanket, her eyes still shut, her breath slow and steady.

“I’m surprised you’re here,” she murmured. “I thought I was gone. I remember... despair. It swallowed me whole. I wasn’t even conscious anymore. It felt like death.”

She paused, her voice trembling slightly.

“But then... I heard a voice. Gentle. Soothing. It told me my life was still beautiful. That even though I’m weak, even though I have regrets... I should live with joy. That I shouldn’t throw away the bonds I’ve just begun to form. That I should keep living. With my friends. At Mikazuki Villa.”

Her hands shifted slightly beneath the blanket, fingers curling as if holding onto something fragile.

“Where are we?” she asked. “Are we... dead?”

Momoko chuckled softly, her voice warm and steady.

“Open your eyes,” she said. “And see for yourselves.”

Mifuyu and Kuroe yawned, stretched, and slowly opened their eyes.

And then they gasped.

The room around them was nothing like they expected. It was a cabin — rustic, cozy, and bathed in morning light. The walls were wooden, the quilts soft and hand-stitched. The air was fragrant with lavender and cedar. A gentle breeze drifted through the open window, carrying the scent of wildflowers and pine.

Mifuyu stood and walked toward the window, Kuroe following close behind.

Outside was a forest — lush, green, and alive. Birds flitted through the branches, singing as they flew. Forest critters darted through the underbrush, chasing each other playfully. The trees swayed gently in the breeze, their leaves shimmering in the sunlight.

Mifuyu closed her eyes and inhaled deeply.

The air was crisp. Clean. It filled her lungs with something she hadn’t felt in a long time — peace.

Kuroe did the same, her shoulders relaxing as she exhaled.

“This place...” Mifuyu whispered. “It’s so peaceful. So calming.”

“I forgot,” Kuroe added, “how beautiful nature can be. How much it can soothe your soul.”

Momoko joined them at the window, her gaze soft.

“I don’t remember the last time I stopped to enjoy something like this,” she said. “Ever since I became a magical girl, it’s been nonstop. Fighting witches. Gathering grief seeds. Surviving.”

Mifuyu nodded.

“Same. The fear of becoming a witch... it never leaves. And the only way to delay it is to keep fighting. Keep risking everything.”

Kuroe’s voice was quiet.

“The stress. The sorrow. It dulls everything. Even the things we used to love.”

They stood there together, watching the forest breathe.

And for the first time in a long time, they did too.

Mifuyu blinked, her gaze drifting downward as she touched her cheek. Her fingers came away damp. A thin line of tears had traced its way down her face while she slept. Kuroe, beside her, reached up instinctively and did the same — her fingertips brushing against the quiet evidence of emotion she hadn’t realized was still lingering.

They looked at each other, surprised.

Momoko chuckled softly, stepping closer.

“I had tears too,” she said, her voice warm. “First thing I noticed when I woke up. Guess we all had something worth crying over.”

She sat on the edge of the bed, her tone light but curious.

“So... what did you two dream about?”

Mifuyu and Kuroe exchanged a glance, then nodded.

“It was vivid,” Mifuyu said. “Beautiful. And sad. I remember it so clearly... like I lived it.”

Kuroe nodded slowly.

“It felt real,” she added. “Like we were there.”

They spoke together, their voices weaving the memory into the room.

“A dream about two magical girls — Mami and Kyoko — exploring a pyramid,” Mifuyu said.

“Learning about Connect. The murals... the stories they told... The battles they fought together — without even knowing how to connect.”

“And the simulation,” Kuroe added. “The tragedy. The origin of Connect.”

Momoko grinned, her eyes lighting up.

“That was some dream, huh? I liked the battles best. They were intense. Mami and Kyoko had great teamwork, even without Connect. If they’re that strong solo... I wonder how powerful they’ll be when they finally connect.”

Mifuyu chuckled, brushing her hair behind her ear.

“The fights were a spectacle,” she agreed. “But I’m surprised they didn’t know how to connect. That’s basic knowledge for magical girls in Kamihama.”

Kuroe tilted her head thoughtfully.

“They’re probably from somewhere else,” she said. “Somewhere with weaker witches. Maybe they never needed teamwork to survive.”

Mifuyu nodded.

“That makes sense. Kamihama witches are strong. And there are so many of them. We had to learn to work together.”

She paused, her voice softening.

“For me... the simulation was the most powerful part. It reminded me of the Memory Museum — when I’d show magical girls my own memories. Teach them the two sad truths of our kind. But this dream... it felt like it had more truths. Deeper ones.”

Kuroe looked down, her voice quiet.

“I liked the murals,” she said. “The story they told — about ordinary girls who made contracts with Kyubey. Who were caught using magic. Who lost their families to fear. Who were exiled. Hunted.”

She swallowed.

“It reminded me of our own struggles. Our regrets. What we’ve lost. But what happened in that story... it was so much worse.”

Momoko leaned back, her expression thoughtful.

“Isn’t it strange?” she said. “That we all had the same dream? That shouldn’t be possible.”

Mifuyu nodded slowly.

“Someone must have given it to us. The most likely candidates... are Kasumi and Lunaria.”

At the mention of their names, Kuroe turned to Mifuyu, her eyes searching.

“You said earlier,” she began, “that the last thing you remembered before everything went blank was Kasumi’s energy. Her warmth. So... does that mean the voice I heard — the one that told me to live, to hold onto my bonds — was Lunaria’s?”

Mifuyu and Momoko smiled gently.

“Yes,” Momoko said. “That’s right.”

Mifuyu added, “You became a witch, Kuroe. But Lunaria saved you.”

Kuroe stared at them, stunned.

“I’m... a witch?” she whispered. “Then how do I have a human body? How can I talk like this?”

She looked down at her right thigh, where she always kept her soul gem.

It was there.

Glowing softly.

She breathed a sigh of relief.

“Looks like I’m a magical girl again,” she said, smiling faintly.

Kuroe’s smile grew.

“I have to thank Lunaria the next time I see her. If witches can be saved... that changes everything. The last thing I heard before I everything went blank was ‘dis-connect.’ Maybe that’s the technique she used.”

Mifuyu and Momoko nodded.

“We owe Lunaria a lot,” Mifuyu said. “She gave us hope. The strength to sacrifice ourselves for the doppelified girls.”

“And Kasumi saved us,” Momoko added. “We’ll need to thank her too.”

“As for ‘dis-connect’...” Mifuyu continued, “we don’t know what it is. But we heard it too. Right before you and Lunaria vanished. It echoed through the entire Hotel Faint Hope.”

She paused, then looked around the cabin.

“Speaking of Kasumi and Lunaria... do you think this is where they live? Are they still alive? Are we still on Earth?”

Momoko grinned.

“Only one way to find out,” she said. “Let’s explore!”

Mifuyu and Kuroe laughed.

Momoko was always the cheerful one. The optimist.

They stood together and walked out of the room, their footsteps soft against the wooden floor. The cabin was simple, cozy, and steeped in nature — dried herbs hung from the beams, flowers and vines hanging down the walls, sunlight filtered through leafy windows, and the scent of pine and lavender lingered in the air. It felt like a place built for healing.

They reached the door.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe exchanged a glance.

Then nodded.

And together, they pushed it open.

Ready to see what lay beyond.

Chapter 2: Awakening

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe stepped outside, the cabin door creaking softly behind them. The morning air greeted them like an old friend — crisp, fragrant, and cool against their skin. Sunlight filtered through the canopy of trees, casting golden patches across the forest floor. The world around them felt alive, vibrant, and impossibly peaceful.

Just ahead, Lunaria was stretching in the clearing, her movements fluid and graceful, like a dancer mid-rehearsal. Her body flowed from one pose to the next with effortless precision, each motion balanced and serene. The sunlight kissed her features as she moved — her indigo hair catching the light like spun moonlight, her expression calm and radiant. She looked like she belonged to the forest itself.

She turned toward them with a soft smile.

“Good morning,” she said, her voice gentle and melodic. “How did you sleep? I hope you’re feeling refreshed.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe smiled back, their hearts light.

“Good morning,” they replied in unison.

“We slept really well,” Momoko added. “Actually... I don’t remember the last time I felt this refreshed. Or this at peace.”

Mifuyu nodded, her gaze drifting across the clearing.

“I think it’s the nature,” she said softly. “The scenery. It’s so beautiful.”

They looked around.

The cabin was nestled in a grove of lush green trees, their leaves rustling gently in the breeze. The grass was soft and vibrant, dotted with wildflowers in shades of violet, gold, and white. Shrubs and vines curled around the edges of the clearing, and birds flitted through the branches, singing to one another. Forest critters darted between roots and rocks, and insects buzzed lazily in the sunlight. It was a world teeming with life — untouched, unhurried.

Kuroe closed her eyes and inhaled deeply.

“I feel like I could just... live here,” she said. “Just exist. Without worrying about witches. Or grief seeds. Or soul gems. Just... be.”

They turned to Lunaria, their expressions soft with gratitude.

Momoko stepped forward first, her voice gentle but steady.

“Thank you,” she said. “For saving us. For giving us real hope yesterday.”

She paused, her gaze drifting toward the trees, then back to Lunaria.

“I’ve spent so long just surviving. Fighting witches, gathering grief seeds, trying to keep my soul gem from cracking. I didn’t realize how numb I’d become. But yesterday... something changed. You reminded me what it feels like to care again. To believe that maybe we’re more than just tools in a system that breaks us.”

Her voice trembled slightly.

“I was ready to die. And I didn’t regret it. But waking up here... I feel like I’ve been given a second chance. Not just to live, but to live with purpose.”

Mifuyu stepped beside her, her eyes thoughtful.

“I felt it too,” she said. “I’ve always thought of myself as fragile. But after seeing how you faced Ichizo — not with brute force, but with grace and clarity — something shifted in me. I realized I didn’t have to be strong in the way I thought. I just had to be willing.”

She folded her hands in front of her.

“That’s what gave me the resolve to act. To give everything I had to save those girls. And now I’m here... with Momoko and Kuroe. In a place that feels like it was made for healing.”

She bowed her head slightly.

“Thank you, Lunaria. For showing me that strength can look like peace.”

Kuroe stepped forward last, her voice quiet and raw.

“I became a witch,” she said. “I felt it. The despair. The loss. I was gone. I didn’t think I’d ever come back.”

She looked down at her thigh, where her soul gem shimmered faintly.

“But then I heard a voice. Yours. Telling me my life was still beautiful. That I could still live. That I didn’t have to throw away the bonds I’d just begun to form.”

She looked up again, her eyes full.

“I don’t know how you did it. I don’t know what I am now. But I’m here. I’m breathing. I’m... me.”

She smiled faintly.

“Thank you for saving me. For giving me a second chance.”

Lunaria listened in silence, her expression serene. When they finished, she placed a hand gently over her heart.

“You’re welcome,” she said, her voice soft and luminous. “You were brave yesterday. You gave everything. And you were willing to lose yourselves for the sake of others. That kind of courage... deserves to be honored.”

She gestured to the clearing, her smile deepening.

“Would you like to join me? Morning stretches are a good way to greet the day. I can explain everything as we move.”

The girls agreed, stepping into the clearing beside her.

Lunaria guided them through the routine — poses that required flexibility, balance, and grace. Her movements were elegant and precise, her body flowing like water. Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe tried to follow, but quickly discovered that some of the stretches were far more difficult than they looked.

Momoko wobbled mid-pose, arms flailing as she tried to regain her balance.

Mifuyu bent into a stretch, then collapsed onto the grass with a laugh.

Kuroe attempted a twist and ended up rolling sideways, giggling.

They laughed together, the sound light and unburdened.

It felt strange — and wonderful.

To be here.

To be doing something so simple.

So human.

Stretching in the morning sun, breathing in the forest air, letting their bodies loosen and their souls settle. It had been so long since they’d done anything like this. So long since they’d felt this relaxed. This safe.

They moved together, imperfect but joyful.

And the forest watched in silence, its leaves swaying in rhythm with their breath.

As they moved through the morning stretches, the forest seemed to breathe with them — the trees swaying gently, the birds singing in soft bursts, the sunlight warming their skin. Lunaria led with quiet grace, her movements fluid and precise, her voice calm and steady as she began to speak.

“You girls from Kamihama,” she said, “know more than most magical girls I’ve met. That’s something to be proud of. The Wings of the Magius... for all their flaws, they did spread knowledge. They forced truths into the open.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe nodded, their expressions thoughtful.

“You already understand Connect,” Lunaria continued. “You use it often — not just to fight, but to survive. You know the two sad truths: that your souls reside in your soul gems, and if those gems break, you die. And that magical girls are destined to become witches when despair overwhelms them.”

She shifted into a deeper stretch, her body folding like silk.

“And you know about Kyubey. About his goal — to prevent the universe from dying. That the transformation of magical girls into witches releases vast amounts of energy. That he makes contracts to keep feeding that energy back into the cosmos.”

Kuroe exhaled slowly, her voice quiet.

“I lived it,” she said. “I was taken over by my doppel. And then... I became a witch. I remember the despair. The darkness. It felt like drowning. Like my consciousness was fading. Like death.”

Mifuyu and Momoko exchanged a glance, then spoke together.

“We’ve seen it too,” Momoko said. “We sacrificed ourselves to save the doppelified girls. And we watched Mel — our teammate, our friend — become a witch.”

Mifuyu’s voice trembled.

“Our memories are used in the Memory Museum. To teach others. To warn them.”

Momoko’s eyes darkened with memory.

“I remember confronting Kyubey. After Mel... after we got back to Mikazuki Villa. I was furious. I demanded answers. And he gave the same explanation you just did.”

Mifuyu nodded.

“I remember the shock. The horror. The pain. I felt betrayed. Tricked. I hated him for hiding the truth.”

Lunaria looked up into the sky, her indigo hair catching the light.

“I’m not defending Kyubey,” she said softly. “But you can’t put all the blame on him. None of you asked about the full consequences of the contract. You were offered a miracle — a wish. Something supernatural. So it stands to reason that the cost would be supernatural too. A miracle... but a tragic one.”

She turned back to them, her gaze gentle.

“Regret is natural. Anger is natural. Almost every magical girl feels it when they learn the truth. But it’s important to remember — you made the choice. Without knowing. And that ignorance... was part of the price.”

The girls went quiet.

The forest held its breath.

Kuroe, Mifuyu, and Momoko stood still, their minds turning inward.

What Lunaria said was true.

They hadn't asked.

They hadn't wanted to know.

And when the truth came, they had blamed Kyubey.

Momoko spoke first, her voice low.

"He said something similar. Back at the villa. That all magical girls act this way. That they don't ask for details. And then blame him later."

Mifuyu nodded slowly.

"Back then... I didn't want to admit it. None of us did. But after yesterday — after seeing how magical girls can reach mutual understanding, even without agreeing — I think I understand him now. I still don't agree with what he's doing. But I understand."

Lunaria smiled, her eyes warm.

"That's a very mature perspective," she said. "To try to understand someone without needing to agree with them. That's growth. That's wisdom."

She paused, then added gently:

"Remember these experiences. Carry them with you. They'll guide you — not just through this realm, but through whatever comes next."

The girls nodded.

And the forest exhaled.

As the final stretch melted into stillness, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe sat back on the soft grass, their bodies warm and relaxed, their breaths slow and steady. The forest around them shimmered with morning light, the trees swaying gently as if listening.

Momoko tilted her head, curiosity blooming.

"So... what exactly is this realm?" she asked. "And what comes next?"

Lunaria smiled, her dark indigo hair catching the sunlight like ink brushed across silk.

"This realm," she said softly, "is a place between places. A space where the burdens of the world can be set down for a moment. Where you can find what was lost."

She looked out toward the forest, her voice like wind through leaves.

“It is not a place for the living. Nor for the dead. It is a place for those who need clarity... before they are called to move forward.”

The girls fell silent, taking in her words.

“So we’re not alive,” Mifuyu murmured, “but not dead either?”

“We’re here to heal,” Kuroe added. “To learn. To grow. Until... something calls us?”

Lunaria nodded.

“Yes,” she said. “You’ve all been through so much. You’ve suffered. You’ve fought. You’ve given everything.”

She turned her back to them, gazing out at the vast forest beyond — a sea of green and gold, stretching endlessly beneath the sky.

“You deserve time,” she said. “Time to rest. To feel peace. To rediscover joy. There is much to learn here. Much to feel.”

She fell silent, her figure still and contemplative.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe watched Lunaria in silence, her back turned to them, her gaze lost in the vastness of the forest. The morning light bathed her in gold, and the breeze stirred her indigo hair like a whisper. Something about her stillness — the way she stood, the way she breathed — made the world feel suspended.

The girls glanced at one another.

Their thoughts flowed into a shared telepathic stream, soft and private.

What is this place to her? Momoko wondered. *She speaks about it like it’s sacred.*

Is it her home? Mifuyu asked. *It seems important to her... the way she’s looking into the distance. Like she’s remembering something.*

Did she create it? Kuroe added. *Or was she entrusted with it? Does anyone else live here? Is she... alone?*

The questions hung between them like mist — delicate, half-formed, waiting for answers.

The forest held their silence, and Lunaria stood at its heart like a guardian of something ancient and tender.

Then, as if sensing their thoughts, Lunaria turned.

She gave them a soft smile and a playful wink.

“One day,” she said, “you’ll be able to share what you learn here. With your friends. With other magical girls. Back in Kamihama... and beyond.”

Their breath caught.

Something inside them stirred — a quiet excitement, a gentle awe.

They didn't know what this place was.

Not yet.

But they knew it mattered.

And they were ready to find out.

They already felt lighter. More at peace. As if the forest itself was beginning to heal them.

They wondered what kind of growth awaited them here. What truths they would uncover. What joy they might feel. And what they might carry back with them when the time came.

Lunaria smiled again, her voice playful.

“Now then,” she said. “Would you like to join me in gathering ingredients for breakfast? It'll be your first lesson in this realm.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe lit up.

“Yes!” they said together.

And with that, they followed Lunaria deeper into the forest, their footsteps light, their laughter ringing through the trees like wind chimes.

Chapter 2a: A new truth

They walked deeper into the forest, the soft crunch of leaves beneath their feet blending with the gentle rustle of branches overhead. The air was alive with sound — birds calling to one another in melodic bursts, the flutter of wings brushing against leaves, the distant chatter of squirrels leaping from branch to branch. Somewhere nearby, a stream murmured softly over stones, its rhythm steady and soothing. Insects buzzed lazily through shafts of sunlight, their wings humming like tiny strings on a harp. Occasionally, the wind would sigh through the trees, setting the canopy swaying with a sound like a thousand whispers.

The scents were just as rich — pine and moss, wildflowers and damp earth, and something faintly sweet, like ripe fruit warmed by sunlight. Every breath felt like a balm, cleansing and grounding.

Every few steps revealed something new: a cluster of mushrooms glowing faintly in the shade like tiny lanterns; a butterfly with wings like stained glass, hovering in the still air before vanishing into the trees; a vine curling around a tree trunk in a perfect spiral, its leaves trembling with dew. A family of foxes darted through the underbrush, their rust-colored fur flashing between the ferns. Overhead, a woodpecker tapped rhythmically against a tree, its drumming echoing like a heartbeat through the woods.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe couldn't help but marvel.

“This place...” Momoko whispered, her voice barely louder than the breeze. “It’s like a dream.”

“So much life,” Mifuyu said, her eyes wide as she watched a pair of birds weaving a nest high in the branches. “So much color. So much sound.”

Kuroe knelt to examine a flower with petals like velvet, its deep blue hue glowing faintly in the dappled light. She leaned in, inhaling.

“I didn’t know forests could smell this good,” she said. “It’s like... everything here is awake.”

They stood in silence for a moment, letting the forest speak.

And the forest did — not with words, but with the rustle of leaves, the trill of birdsong, the hush of wind and water. It was a symphony of life, and for the first time in what felt like forever, they weren’t fighting it.

They were part of it.

Lunaria, walking ahead with quiet grace, glanced back at them and smiled.

“You’re enjoying yourselves,” she said. “That’s good. Now, take a look at your soul gems.”

The girls paused.

Each of them reached instinctively for their soul gem.

Momoko touched the gem affixed to her chest, its surface warm against her palm. Mifuyu’s fingers brushed the choker at her neck, where her gem shimmered like a pendant. Kuroe slid her hand down to her right thigh, where her soul gem was secured like a quiet sentinel.

And then they saw it.

Their soul gems were glowing.

Not just clean — radiant. The colors were vivid, crystalline, almost luminous. They pulsed softly, like hearts brimming with energy.

“I haven’t seen mine glow like this in... I don’t even know how long,” Momoko said, her voice hushed.

“It feels alive,” Mifuyu murmured, eyes wide.

Kuroe held hers up to the light. “It’s beautiful.”

Lunaria nodded, her voice warm.

“That’s expected,” she said. “As you know, a magical girl’s soul gem reflects her magical power. When you use your power, or when you’re overwhelmed by negative emotions, the gem becomes dull. Tainted.”

Momoko nodded.

“We’ve seen it,” she said. “After battles, when we’ve pushed ourselves too far. The color fades. It looks... tired.”

“And when despair takes hold,” Mifuyu added, “it turns dark. Like it’s being swallowed.”

Kuroe’s voice was quiet.

“That’s what happened to me. Before I became a witch.”

Lunaria looked out into the forest, her gaze thoughtful.

“Yes,” she said. “That’s what you were taught. And what you’ve lived. But what if I told you... there’s more?”

She turned to face them.

“What if magical girls don’t need grief seeds to survive?”

The girls froze.

Momoko stepped forward, eyes wide.

“Is that true?”

Mifuyu’s voice trembled with hope.

“What do we need to do?”

Kuroe clutched her soul gem, her heart racing.

“If that’s real... it changes everything.”

Lunaria smiled, her expression serene.

“It is real. And it’s simpler than you think.”

She paused.

“All you need is rest. And a calm, peaceful mind and soul.”

The girls stared at her.

Momoko blinked.

“That’s it?”

Mifuyu frowned slightly.

“But we’ve felt peace before. Moments of calm. And our soul gems still got polluted.”

Kuroe nodded.

“Why didn’t it work then?”

Lunaria chuckled softly, her voice like wind brushing through leaves.

“Because those moments were fleeting. Rare. And even when you felt peace, you were still carrying the weight. The stress. The fear. Every time you fought a witch, every time you worried about grief seeds, that tension lingered. It clouded your soul. It dulled your gem.”

She looked at each of them in turn, her gaze gentle but unwavering.

“To truly heal,” she said, “you need more than a moment. You need space. Time. Safety. You need to let go.”

The girls fell silent.

But not for long.

Momoko exhaled slowly, her eyes distant.

“I used to think a quiet night at Mikazuki Villa was peace,” she said. “But even then, I was always bracing for the next fight. Always wondering if someone’s soul gem was too close to cracking. If mine was.”

She looked down at her gem, still glowing.

“I never really let go. Not once.”

Mifuyu nodded, her voice soft.

“I remember sitting in the Mikazuki Villa after Mel became a witch. I tried to meditate. To find calm. But all I could think about was how many girls would follow her. How many would break.”

She touched the choker at her neck, where her soul gem shimmered.

“I thought I was helping others find peace. But I never gave myself permission to feel it.”

Kuroe’s voice was quiet, almost fragile.

“I used to walk alone at night. Just to escape the noise. I’d tell myself I was calm. That I was okay. But I was always counting grief seeds. Always wondering how close I was to the edge.”

She looked at Lunaria, then at the forest around them.

“This is different. I don’t feel like I’m surviving. I feel like I’m... breathing.”

They stood together, surrounded by trees that swayed gently in the breeze, by birdsong and sunlight and the scent of wildflowers.

And they realized she was right.

They had felt peace — but never safety.

Never freedom.

Never this.

As they walked beneath the canopy of trees, the forest alive with birdsong and the scent of dew-warmed leaves, a quiet settled over the group — not heavy, but contemplative. The kind of silence that invites truth.

Momoko spoke first, her voice soft.

“It feels... strange,” she said. “To take a step back like this. To pause. To reflect.”

Mifuyu nodded, her gaze drifting to the sunlight filtering through the branches.

“We’ve changed so much,” she murmured. “Since becoming magical girls. I don’t think we ever stopped to really see it. All the sorrow... all the suffering... it became normal. Something we just accepted.”

Kuroe’s voice was quiet, almost fragile.

“I don’t even remember when that shift happened. When I stopped hoping things would get better. When I started believing that pain was just part of the job.”

Lunaria looked at them gently, her expression full of understanding.

“A lot of magical girls are the same,” she said. “When they first make their contract, they’re still themselves — full of dreams, wonder, innocence. But the cycle wears them down. The fights. The losses. The grief. It carves into them slowly, like water shaping stone.”

She paused, her voice tender.

“And before they realize it, they’ve changed. Hardened. Sad. Jaded. Life becomes a struggle to survive. They know they’ve changed, but they don’t always understand how quickly... or how deeply.”

The girls fell silent again, but this time it was different — not numbness, but recognition.

Lunaria smiled.

“But now,” she said, “you’re aware. And that awareness is the first step. You can begin to apply what I’ve told you. You can begin to live without relying on grief seeds.”

She turned to Kuroe, her eyes warm.

“What you said earlier — about how you felt like you could just live here, without worrying about witches or soul gems... just be — that’s a good beginning. Learn how to let go of the burdens. Learn how to live in the moment.”

She looked around at the forest, the light dancing across her indigo hair.

“You’re already doing it,” she said. “You’re stopping. You’re breathing. You’re seeing the beauty around you. That’s why I love this place. The nature here... it’s calming. It speaks to the soul.”

Then her tone shifted, gently instructive.

“But there are things you need to know. If you use a lot of magical power, your soul gems will dull. That’s true no matter how calm or peaceful you are. You need rest to restore your power. You can’t fight endlessly.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe nodded, absorbing her words.

“So if we want to stop relying on grief seeds,” Momoko said, “we need to rest. Really rest.”

Lunaria nodded.

“But even when your soul gems are dull from magical use,” she continued gently, “as long as you don’t succumb to negativity — as long as your soul remains calm and peaceful — you won’t become a witch.”

The words settled over them like sunlight breaking through storm clouds.

The girls froze.

It was as if a weight had been lifted from their shoulders — a weight they hadn’t even realized they were still carrying. A burden so old, so constant, it had become part of them. And now, in a single breath, it was gone.

Mifuyu gasped, her hand flying to her mouth.

“That... that changes everything,” she whispered. Her voice cracked, and tears welled in her eyes. “All this time, I thought it was only a matter of when. That no matter what I did, I’d end up like Mel. That we all would.”

She looked down at her soul gem, glowing softly against her throat.

“I thought I was just delaying the inevitable.”

Kuroe clutched her soul gem tightly, her fingers trembling.

“I’ve lived in fear of turning,” she said, her voice raw. “Ever since I made my contract. I thought it was written into me. That no matter how hard I tried, how careful I was... I’d lose myself. That I’d hurt the people I care about.”

She looked up at Lunaria, her eyes wide and wet.

“But you’re saying... I don’t have to be afraid anymore?”

Momoko’s breath hitched. She pressed a hand to her chest, over her soul gem, as if to steady herself.

“I haven’t felt this light in years,” she said. “I didn’t even realize how much of my life was shaped by that fear. Every decision. Every moment. Always wondering if this would be the day I crossed the line.”

She laughed, but it was shaky — the kind of laugh that comes when tears are too close.

“I used to tell the younger girls not to worry. That we’d protect them. But I was terrified. I just... never let myself say it out loud.”

The forest around them seemed to hush, as if listening. A breeze stirred the leaves, cool and gentle, brushing against their skin like a blessing.

Mifuyu wiped her eyes, her voice steadier now.

“To live without that fear... to know that peace can protect us... it’s more than I ever hoped for.”

Kuroe nodded, her voice small but fierce.

“It’s like... I’ve been holding my breath for years. And now I can finally exhale.”

Momoko looked at Lunaria, her expression full of wonder.

“Thank you,” she said. “You didn’t just save us. You gave us something we didn’t think we could have anymore.”

“Hope,” Mifuyu whispered.

“Freedom,” Kuroe added.

Lunaria smiled, her eyes luminous with quiet joy.

“You’ve carried so much,” she said. “Now it’s time to learn how to let it go.”

Lunaria chuckled, her voice like sunlight through leaves.

“Do you remember the dream I gave you last night?” she asked. “The one with the twelve girls? Even though only one of them could use a grief seed at a time, none of them became witches. They fought many battles. And they stayed whole.”

The girls laughed, a little breathless.

“So it was you,” Momoko said. “Another one of your mysterious abilities.”

They thought back to the dream, their expressions shifting.

Their eyes widened.

“The murals,” Mifuyu said. “The early ones — before the tragedy — showed soul gems that were dull, but not corrupted. They were just tired. Used.”

“And the last two murals,” Kuroe added, “showed soul gems turning black. That was despair. That was the difference.”

Lunaria nodded.

“Correct. Before the tragedy, those twelve girls — especially the ten magical girls — fought together. They supported each other. They were happy. They rested. They didn’t know the truths of magical girls, but they created an environment where none of them would fall.”

She smiled, wistful.

“Ignorance and innocence... can truly be bliss.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe chuckled, their hearts full.

“Twelve girls,” Momoko said. “Young. Innocent. Supporting each other. Living without fear.”

“It reminds me of when we were little,” Mifuyu whispered. “Curious. Playful. Happy.”

Kuroe smiled.

“Before everything changed.”

They stood together in the forest, the light warm on their faces, the air rich with scent and song.

They continued walking, the forest opening before them like a cathedral of green. Lunaria moved with quiet grace, pausing often to touch the leaves of a tree, to brush her fingers against moss-covered bark, to lean in and inhale the scent of a flower blooming in the shade. Her movements were slow, deliberate, reverent — as if she were greeting old friends.

Animals began to gather.

A pair of deer stepped softly from the underbrush, their eyes calm and curious. Birds fluttered down from the branches, landing on Lunaria’s shoulders and arms without hesitation. A fox curled around her ankles, its tail flicking gently. Rabbits, squirrels, even a badger — all drawn to her presence.

Lunaria knelt and pet them one by one, her smile warm and serene.

The animals responded with quiet joy, nuzzling her hands, blinking slowly, their bodies relaxed and unafraid. It was as if they knew her. As if she belonged to the forest as much as the trees and the wind.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe watched in awe.

“She’s... part of this place,” Momoko whispered.

“She’s not just living in it,” Mifuyu said. “She’s woven into it.”

Kuroe nodded slowly.

“It’s like the forest breathes with her.”

Lunaria looked up, her eyes bright.

“Let’s talk about something else,” she said. “Connect. What do you know about it?”

Momoko smiled.

“In Kamihama, it’s essential. It’s how we fight together. We join hands, sync our magic, and share abilities. It lets us create combo moves, new attacks. It’s saved our lives more times than I can count.”

Mifuyu nodded.

“It’s more than a technique. It’s a bond.”

Lunaria continued petting a rabbit nestled in her lap.

“Good,” she said. “And what do you feel when you Connect?”

The girls paused, then began to speak.

Momoko and Mifuyu looked at each other, then back at Lunaria.

“Yesterday,” Momoko said, “we Connected with Yachiyo. And later with Mitama.”

Mifuyu’s voice softened.

“With Mitama... we saw her. Not just her magic. Her soul. Her pain. Her frustration. Why she had to become apathetic just to survive. We felt it. Lived it.”

Momoko nodded.

“And we gained her powers. Her coordinator abilities. They were crucial in saving the doppelified girls.”

Mifuyu smiled faintly.

“But the one with Yachiyo... that was different.”

Her eyes shimmered.

“We spoke to Mel. And Kanae. Our fallen friends. We saw them. Heard them. It was... it was like they were still with us.”

Momoko’s voice trembled.

“It gave us strength. To keep going. To not break.”

Kuroe stepped forward, her expression thoughtful.

“I Connected with Iroha. When we fought the security guard bear Uwasa.”

She looked down at her soul gem, then back up.

“I was caught. It was dragging me in. I was about to use my doppel. But Iroha stopped me. She freed me. Told me not to rely on it.”

Her voice grew softer.

“And then we Connected.”

She smiled, wistful.

“I saw her life. Mikazuki Villa. The warmth of friendship. Shared meals. Shopping trips. Laughter. I understood why she didn’t need the Wings of the Magius. She already had what she needed.”

She looked away, then back.

“I wished I was there. With her. During those moments.”

Her voice brightened.

“And then we fought together. Our powers combined. I was strong. I was... having fun during a fight. For the first time.”

Lunaria continued stroking the fox curled beside her.

“Those are beautiful experiences,” she said. “Thank you for sharing them.”

She looked up, her eyes glowing.

“Kamihama has taught you well. You understand Connect deeply.”

She paused.

“But there’s more.”

The girls leaned in, hearts quickening.

More?

Could it be as life-changing as what she’d told them before?

That magical girls didn’t need grief seeds to survive.

That peace could protect them from becoming witches.

That rest could restore their soul gems.

They waited.

And the forest waited with them.

As they walked, the forest opened into a sun-dappled glade. Lunaria paused beside a flowering bush, gently brushing her fingers across its blossoms. A squirrel perched on her shoulder, nibbling a nut it had brought her, while a pair of birds chirped softly from a nearby branch.

Then her voice shifted — quieter, more solemn.

“There’s something I want to tell you,” she said. “About what happened yesterday. After you fell, Kuroe.”

Kuroe looked up, startled.

Lunaria continued.

“Iroha saw you become a witch. She broke down. She blamed herself. She thought she had failed you.”

Kuroe’s breath caught.

“She... what?”

Lunaria nodded, her expression gentle.

“Her doppel sensed her despair. It began to take over. Yachiyo, Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno tried to Connect with her — to pull her back. But the negativity was too strong. The Connect failed.”

The forest seemed to hush around them.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe exchanged glances, their expressions stricken.

“So... Connect can fail?” Mifuyu asked softly.

Lunaria nodded.

“Yes. The strength and success of Connect depends on the state of mind — and the willingness — of everyone involved. If magical girls truly understand and trust each other... if they’re willing to open up, to be vulnerable... the Connect is strong. Their magic syncs. But more than that — their souls sync. The very core of who they are.”

She looked at them, her eyes luminous.

“And when that happens, the abilities that emerge are only limited by imagination.”

She paused.

“But if there’s resistance... misunderstanding... fear... the Connect weakens. And sometimes, it fails completely. As it did yesterday.”

The girls were quiet for a moment, absorbing the weight of that truth.

Momoko spoke first.

“I never thought it could fail,” she said. “In Kamihama, we used Connect all the time. It was second nature. Like breathing.”

Mifuyu nodded.

“We relied on it. Especially in battle. It always worked.”

Kuroe’s voice was quiet.

“But I guess... we were always fighting together. Supporting each other. Even when we didn’t agree, we still trusted.”

Lunaria smiled, her voice warm.

“That’s exactly why it worked. The witches in Kamihama are strong. Abundant. You had to rely on each other. You had to support one another. That shared struggle — that shared understanding — made your Connects powerful.”

She turned, brushing her hand along a tree trunk as she walked.

“Hardship can bring pain. But it can also bring clarity. And great power.”

Then she looked back at them with a playful glint in her eye.

“And now that you know more — about soul gems, about yourselves, about Connect — and now that your souls are more at peace...”

She winked.

“I wonder what would happen if you Connected now.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe blinked.

Then they looked at each other.

Their hearts stirred.

Their imaginations bloomed.

What would it feel like — to Connect now, without fear? Without grief pressing down on them? With their souls light and open?

They didn’t know.

But they wanted to find out.

And for a moment, they were just girls again — young, curious, full of wonder.

Momoko grinned first, her eyes sparkling.

“What if,” she said, “when we Connect now... my encouragement ability doesn’t just boost your magic, but your emotions too? Like, if you’re scared, I could make you brave. If you’re tired, I could make you feel like you just woke up from the best nap ever.”

She laughed, the sound bright and unburdened.

“Maybe I could even turn into a comet again — but this time, with you two riding the tail!”

Mifuyu giggled, her voice soft and dreamy.

“And I could cast illusions that respond to your thoughts,” she said. “Like... if you’re thinking of a memory, I could make it appear around us. Not just as an image, but something we could walk through. Touch. Hear.”

She twirled her chakram in her fingers, then tossed it gently into the air, catching it with ease.

“Or maybe I could weave illusions into your attacks. Kuroe’s batons could look like birds or stars or... I don’t know, floating lanterns.”

Kuroe’s eyes widened, her smile shy but growing.

“That would be amazing,” she said. “And maybe... maybe my Existence Affirmation could extend to you both. Like, if we’re in disguise or trying to hide, people would just accept us as part of the scenery. Like we belong.”

She paused, then added with a quiet laugh.

“Or maybe I could even control my batons with all of your weapons at once—have them dance with your chakram, Mifuyu, or orbit Momoko’s sword like satellites. Just imagine it!”

Momoko’s eyes lit up.

“Imagine a combo move,” she said. “I charge forward like a comet, your illusions swirl around me like a storm, and Kuroe’s batons explode behind us like fireworks.”

Mifuyu clasped her hands together.

“And we’d be glowing. Not just from magic, but from joy.”

Kuroe nodded, her voice soft.

“I’ve never imagined fighting could feel like that.”

They stood in the forest, the light filtering through the leaves like golden confetti, their laughter mingling with birdsong.

For a moment, they weren’t magical girls burdened by fate.

They were dreamers.

Artists of possibility.

And the forest listened, smiling with them.

Lunaria laughed gently, the sound like wind brushing through petals.

“Those are all wonderful ideas,” she said. “And you’ll have many chances to test Connect with each other in this realm.”

Momoko blinked.

“Wait — really?”

Mifuyu tilted her head.

“You mean... we’ll be fighting here?”

Kuroe leaned in, curious.

“Or learning how to use Connect outside of battle? Do some kind of training like what those two girls did in our dream — Mami and Kyoko. Who were they?”

Lunaria smiled, but said nothing.

She turned and began walking back toward the cabin, her steps light, her indigo hair swaying behind her.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe exchanged amused glances.

“Lunaria being mysterious again,” Momoko said with a chuckle.

They followed her, wondering what she would reveal next.

When they reached the cabin and stepped inside, Lunaria raised her hands — subtle, graceful gestures like conducting a silent symphony. The air shimmered. The glow of the forest seemed to gather around them, threads of light weaving together.

And then, to their astonishment, ingredients began to form.

Fruits with jewel-toned skins. Grains that glowed faintly like starlight. Vegetables in vibrant hues. Cuts of meat wrapped in leaves, fresh and fragrant.

Momoko gasped.

“You made these appear out of thin air!”

Mifuyu stepped closer, eyes wide.

“How did you do that?”

Kuroe reached out to touch a cluster of berries, her fingers trembling.

“They’re real...”

Lunaria smiled, her eyes twinkling.

“Would you like to help me make breakfast?” she asked. “I’ll explain as we cook.”

The girls nodded eagerly.

They moved together through the cabin, gathering utensils, washing ingredients, chopping and stirring. The air filled with the rich scent of food — herbs and spices, sizzling oil, the sweetness of fruit warming over flame. Laughter bubbled between them, light and unburdened. The sound of cutting and cooking mingled with the crackle of the hearth and the birdsong drifting in through the windows.

As they worked, Lunaria spoke.

“Connect,” she said, “at its root, is about listening. Attuning yourself to life. When you connect with another being — magical girl, animal, plant — you resonate with its energy. You begin to see the world through its eyes. Its perspective.”

She stirred a pot with slow, deliberate movements.

“When we walked through the forest, I was connecting. With the trees. The flowers. The animals. I opened myself to them. And they opened themselves to me. We understood each other.”

Momoko paused mid-chop, her knife hovering over a sprig of herbs.

“That’s... beautiful.”

Mifuyu looked at the fox curled by the hearth, its eyes half-lidded in contentment.

“So that’s why the animals looked so peaceful around you?”

Kuroe leaned against the counter, her voice hushed.

“They trusted you. Completely.”

Their eyes widened as realization bloomed.

Momoko turned to Lunaria.

“Is that how you spoke to Ichizo? You connected with the witch?”

Mifuyu nodded.

“And through that... you reached Kuroe?”

Kuroe’s voice was quiet, trembling.

“When I became a witch... I don’t remember much. Just darkness. Drowning. But I do remember... a voice. Faint. Comforting. Reaching out.”

She looked at Lunaria.

“The last thing I heard was ‘dis-connect.’ Was that... something you used to save me? Is it related to Connect?”

Lunaria chuckled, her smile playful.

“Yes,” she said. “You’re starting to **connect** the dots.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe burst into laughter.

“That was a clever pun,” Momoko said, grinning.

Lunaria winked.

The cabin was warm with the scent of simmering herbs and sweet fruit, the soft clatter of utensils, and the gentle rhythm of shared movement. As steam curled from the pot, Lunaria stirred slowly, her voice low and steady.

“Yes,” she said. “I did use Connect on Ichizo.”

Momoko paused mid-stir, her eyes lifting.

“When I landed on her head,” Lunaria continued, “I sat down and placed my hand on her. I attuned myself to her essence. I opened my soul to hers. And through that... I understood her. And I understood Kuroe.”

Kuroe’s breath caught.

“You... understood me?”

Lunaria nodded.

“And I spoke to Yachiyo, Iroha, Sana, and Tsuruno as well. Telepathically. They heard everything.”

She turned to Kuroe, her gaze soft, touched with sorrow.

“That’s why I asked you to remember your promise to Iroha,” she said. “To reunite with her. To live together. To support each other at Mikazuki Villa. You were so close, Kuroe. So close to a happy future. With Iroha, Yachiyo, Sana, Felicia, Tsuruno... and the others.”

She paused.

“It would’ve been heartbreaking if it ended there. With you losing yourself and becoming a witch.”

Kuroe’s eyes shimmered. Her hands trembled slightly as she chopped a sprig of mint.

“I... I didn’t know anyone saw that,” she whispered. “I thought I was already gone.”

Lunaria smiled gently.

“You weren’t. Not yet.”

Kuroe blinked rapidly, her vision blurring.

“You’re right,” she said. “I still have so much to live for. So many memories to make.”

Lunaria continued, her voice like a lullaby.

“I also told you something else. Through Ichizo. That life — your life, and the lives of all magical girls — is beautiful. Precious. No matter how many regrets, mistakes, or heroic deeds you carry.”

She looked at each of them.

“Every breath. Every thought. Every bond you form. It’s a small miracle. A form of magic.”

Momoko’s hand stilled over the pan.

Mifuyu’s eyes widened, her lips parted.

“That’s why,” Lunaria said, “you should try to be joyful. To be happy. To enjoy life. You don’t need to earn happiness. You’re free to feel it. To embrace it.”

She smiled warmly.

“Joy is nourishment for the soul. Not a luxury. Not a reward. Just... something you’re allowed to have.”

The girls were silent.

Then they chuckled softly, tears glimmering in their eyes.

They looked down at their soul gems.

Already bright. Already radiant.

But what would they look like if they truly embraced joy?

If they lived not just in peace, but in wonder?

“What powers would we have then?” Momoko whispered.

“What kind of magic?” Mifuyu added.

Kuroe smiled, her voice quiet.

“I want to find out.”

Lunaria nodded.

“As you saw,” Lunaria said, her voice soft and luminous, “when I connected with the forest life, we were at peace. Happy. And from that connection, I attuned myself to their essence. I listened. I saw what they were willing to offer.”

She gestured to the ingredients laid out before them — fruits glistening like jewels, grains that shimmered faintly, vegetables vibrant with color, and cuts of meat wrapped in fragrant leaves.

“I didn’t consume their energy,” she continued. “I received a part of what they truly are. Their essence. And from that, I created these ingredients.”

The girls stared.

The air around them felt charged, like the moment before a song begins.

Lunaria looked at them, her eyes glowing with quiet joy.

“This is how magical girls gain new abilities through Connect. The essence of one magical girl — the core of who she is — is shared. And vice versa.”

She smiled.

“This magic is beautiful. And it can be used for many things. Only bound by imagination.”

Momoko gasped, her hand flying to her chest.

She looked down at her soul gem, then back at the ingredients, then at Lunaria.

“That’s... incredible,” she whispered. “We’ve always used Connect to fight. To survive. But this... this is creation. This is communion.”

Mifuyu’s eyes shimmered, her breath catching.

“It’s like... we’ve been using a single thread of a tapestry,” she said. “And now you’re showing us the whole weave. The whole story.”

She stepped closer to the table, her fingers hovering over a cluster of berries.

“To think that magic could come from understanding. From listening. From peace.”

Kuroe's voice was quiet, trembling.

"I've never thought of myself as someone who could give something beautiful," she said. "But if my essence... if the core of who I am... could help someone else..."

She looked at Lunaria, her eyes wide and wet.

"That means I'm not just a burden. I'm not just a risk."

She smiled, fragile but real.

"I'm... a gift."

The three girls looked at each other.

Their hearts full.

Their souls stirred.

What Lunaria had just told them was as profound as her earlier revelations — that rest and peace could protect them from becoming witches. That joy could strengthen their magic.

Connect wasn't just a battle technique.

It was a way of living.

A way of understanding.

A way of creating.

They felt it — not just in their minds, but in their bodies. In the warmth of the cabin. In the scent of food. In the quiet joy of being together.

Momoko reached out and took Mifuyu's hand.

Mifuyu took Kuroe's.

They didn't speak.

They didn't need to.

Their soul gems pulsed softly, brighter than before.

And they wondered — with hearts open and imaginations blooming — what else Connect could do.

Chapter 2b: Lunaria's and Mami's 1st interaction

They finished cooking and setting the table, the cabin filled with the rich scent of herbs, roasted vegetables, and warm bread. The table was a patchwork of color and texture — golden grains, jewel-toned fruits, steaming bowls of stew, and delicate flower-petal garnishes that shimmered faintly in the morning light.

Momoko's stomach let out a loud growl.

Everyone burst into laughter.

"Well," Lunaria said, smiling, "shall we dig in?"

"Yes, please!" Momoko grinned, already reaching for a slice of fruit tart.

The first bites were met with delighted hums and wide eyes.

"This is amazing," Mifuyu said, savoring a spoonful of soup. "It tastes like... like sunlight and spring rain."

Kuroe nodded, her mouth full. "And the bread is so soft. Did the forest really give us all this?"

Lunaria smiled, sipping her tea.

"As for your other questions," she said, "about Mami and Kyoko... about what you'll do in this realm... and about dis-connect..."

She set her cup down gently.

"Mami Tomoe is a magical girl from Mitakihara. She came here three days ago."

Momoko nearly dropped her fork.

"There are other magical girls here?"

Mifuyu's eyes lit up. "We get to meet them?"

Kuroe leaned forward. "That's amazing! How did she get here?"

Lunaria chuckled.

"Yes, Mami would love your company. She's been hoping to meet others."

She paused, then continued.

"Three days ago, Mami took two of her human friends — Sayaka Miki and Madoka Kaname — on a witch hunt. Kyubey had already spoken to them about making a contract. Neither of them had decided yet. Mami wanted them to see what it meant to be a magical girl. The truth of it. The danger. The cost."

Momoko's expression softened.

"She didn't try to trick them into it," she said. "She just... wanted them to understand."

Mifuyu nodded. "That's rare. Most girls are recruited in desperation. Or fear."

"She's kind," Kuroe said. "Really kind."

Lunaria smiled.

"She is. She wanted them to make an informed choice. She didn't want them to suffer the way she had."

She stirred her tea, her voice growing quieter.

“Before the battle, Madoka told Mami she would make a contract. She wanted to support her. She saw Mami’s strength. Her kindness. She wanted to follow her example.”

Lunaria looked up.

“Mami was overwhelmed with joy. She had been alone for so long. And suddenly, someone wanted to stand beside her.”

The table fell silent.

Momoko’s eyes shimmered.

“She must’ve felt... seen. Finally.”

Mifuyu nodded slowly. “Like she mattered.”

Kuroe’s voice was barely a whisper.

“She must’ve thought... she wasn’t alone anymore.”

Lunaria’s gaze turned somber.

“But that joy... it distracted her. In the middle of the fight, she let her guard down. The witch — Charlotte — killed her. Right in front of her friends.”

The words hit like a stone dropped into still water.

The girls froze.

Momoko’s fork clinked against her plate.

Mifuyu covered her mouth, eyes wide.

Kuroe stared at the table, her hands clenched.

“She was so close,” Momoko said. “To something better.”

“She was just like us,” Mifuyu murmured. “Fighting for others. Alone.”

Kuroe’s voice cracked.

“That could’ve been me. If you hadn’t come...”

She looked at Lunaria.

“You saved her, didn’t you? Like you saved me?”

Lunaria nodded, her smile tinged with sadness.

“Yes. If she had died there... it would’ve been a very sad ending.”

Mifuyu chuckled softly, trying to lift the heaviness.

“So you brought her unconscious body here? Let her rest, like you did with us?”

Lunaria laughed, her eyes twinkling with mischief.

“No,” she said. “That’s not what I did.”

Momoko leaned in, curious.

“Then what did you do?”

Lunaria’s expression shifted — playful, but edged with something deeper.

“Mami didn’t know the truth. That magical girls are fated to become witches. She didn’t know what she was becoming. So...”

She paused.

“I fought her.”

The girls gasped.

“You fought her?” Mifuyu echoed.

Momoko’s eyes widened. “That must’ve been... incredible.”

“I saw you fight Ichizo,” Mifuyu added. “You moved like water. Like light. I never thought fighting like that was possible.”

Kuroe nodded. “I can’t imagine anyone standing a chance against you. How did Mami do?”

Lunaria chuckled, her eyes distant, as if replaying the memory.

“Considering the circumstances, she did well,” she said. “Very well. But I had to show her. Not tell her. I believe — and so does Kasumi — that the best way to learn is to be thrown into the deep end. To feel the truth in your bones.”

She looked at them, her smile turning sly.

“You noticed, didn’t you? How Kasumi and I didn’t intervene at Hotel Faint Hope until the very end?”

Momoko laughed, a little breathless.

“We did wonder about that.”

She leaned back slightly, her gaze drifting.

“I remember when Kaede became a doppelified magical girl,” she said. “Her eyes were blank. Her voice was gone. I thought I’d lost her.”

She looked at Mifuyu and Kuroe, her voice trembling.

“But you didn’t step in. Neither did Kasumi. And somehow... we saved her. Me, Mifuyu, Mitama, Rena. We figured it out together.”

Her eyes shimmered.

“I didn’t think I had that kind of strength. But you did.”

Mifuyu nodded slowly, her expression thoughtful.

“And when Yachiyo confronted me... about the Wings of the Magius. About whether I was still trying to recruit her friends. You didn’t interfere then either.”

She stirred her tea absently, her voice quiet.

“I was terrified. I thought I’d lose her. But I had to face it. I had to speak my truth. And she finally listened and understood me.”

She looked at Lunaria.

“You gave me space to be honest. Even if it hurt.”

Kuroe’s voice was soft, almost fragile.

“And when I was fighting the security bear Uwasa with Iroha... you were there. Watching. But you didn’t stop me when I tried to use my doppel.”

She looked down at her hands, then up again.

“Iroha did. She reached me. She Connected with me. And I saw her life. Her joy. Her friendships.”

Her voice cracked.

“I don’t think I would’ve understood her — or myself — if you had stepped in.”

Momoko smiled, her eyes full of quiet wonder.

“You let us fall. But you also let us rise.”

Mifuyu’s voice was steady now.

“You trusted us. Even when we didn’t trust ourselves.”

Kuroe nodded, her gaze unwavering.

“You believed we could find our way.”

Lunaria’s smile was gentle, touched with pride.

“You all learned something important. About yourselves. About each other. That kind of learning... it’s worth the struggle. Worth the pain.”

Lunaria continued, her voice calm, almost clinical.

“Mami asked a lot of questions. About where she was. What had happened to her. How Sayaka and Madoka were doing. And who I was.”

She paused, her gaze distant.

“I didn’t answer any of them.”

Momoko blinked.

“You didn’t?”

Lunaria shook her head.

“I acted cold. Detached. I told her her friends were in danger. That they were defenseless against a witch like Charlotte. I lied.”

Mifuyu’s breath caught.

“You... lied to her?”

Kuroe leaned forward, eyes wide.

“You manipulated her emotions?”

Lunaria nodded.

“I needed her to break. To succumb to despair. To become a witch.”

The cabin fell silent.

The warmth of the meal seemed to fade, replaced by a chill of disbelief.

Momoko’s fork hovered above her plate, forgotten.

Mifuyu’s lips parted, but no words came.

Kuroe stared at Lunaria, stunned.

“That’s... not like you,” she said softly. “Not the you we know.”

Lunaria chuckled, but it was a quiet, rueful sound.

“Mami fought with everything she had. She used every last ounce of strength. Her desire to protect her friends pushed her past her limits.”

She looked down at her hands.

“But none of her attacks landed. I didn’t strike her once. I only defended. Blocked. Deflected. Just like I did with Ichizo.”

Momoko smiled faintly, the memory surfacing.

“You were beautiful when you fought Ichizo,” she said. “Graceful. Effortless.”

Mifuyu nodded. “Like dancing with light.”

Kuroe’s voice was soft. “I imagine you were just as breathtaking against Mami.”

Lunaria's expression darkened.

"She grew frustrated. Desperate. She couldn't touch me. And slowly... despair took root. She felt worthless. Like she'd failed. Like she hadn't just gotten herself killed — but two innocent humans as well."

Kuroe's gaze was solemn.

"So you waited for her to become a witch... and then used dis-connect?"

Lunaria smiled gently.

"Not quite."

She leaned forward, her voice lowering.

"The moment she was about to turn — the very edge of transformation — I rushed to her. I tapped her soul gem. And I used dis-connect."

The girls leaned in, breath held.

"I siphoned all the negativity out of her soul gem," Lunaria said. "And I stored it in myself."

Momoko's eyes widened.

"You... stored it?"

Mifuyu blinked. "Inside you?"

Kuroe's voice was hushed. "What does that mean?"

Lunaria laughed softly.

"Mami was confused. She realized she'd been on the brink. That she was about to become a witch. But somehow... she was still herself."

She stirred her tea, her smile unreadable.

"She asked questions. Was she really about to turn into a witch? What did I do? Did I save her?"

Her voice grew colder.

"I told her she was wasting time. That her friends were in danger."

Momoko frowned.

"You kept the act going."

Lunaria nodded.

"She was exhausted. Barely standing. But she prepared one final attack. A desperate strike."

She raised her hand, palm open.

“And when she launched it, I dashed forward. I concentrated the negativity I’d stored into my hand. And I struck her.”

Her voice softened.

“She fell unconscious.”

She looked at the girls, her smile warm again.

“And that’s when I brought her here. Let her rest. Just like I did with all of you.”

The girls sat in stunned silence.

Momoko’s eyes were wide.

Mifuyu’s fingers trembled around her cup.

Kuroe’s voice was barely audible.

“So... dis-connect is about siphoning negativity from a soul gem?”

Lunaria nodded.

“And you can store it. Use it. Shape it.”

Momoko leaned back, her mind racing.

“That’s... that’s a whole new kind of magic.”

Mifuyu whispered, “I’ve never heard of anything like it.”

Kuroe looked at Lunaria, awe in her eyes.

“You saved her,” she said softly. “By letting her fall. And catching her at the last second.”

Lunaria’s smile was quiet, touched with something bittersweet.

“Yes,” she said. “And through that, Mami learned the truth of what it means to be a magical girl. Not just in theory — she felt it. In her bones. In her soul.”

She looked toward the window, where sunlight filtered through the trees.

“That kind of understanding... it changes you. It deepens everything that comes after. Because now, Mami can appreciate what this realm offers — not just as a refuge, but as a chance to begin again. To live with clarity. With peace.”

She raised her cup in a quiet toast.

“To the deep end.”

The girls smiled, their hearts full, and clinked their cups against hers.

Laughter rose again — soft, genuine, healing.

And as they ate, the warmth of the food and the weight of Lunaria's words settled into them — not as burdens, but as nourishment. A kind of magic all its own.

Chapter 2c: New frontiers, new abilities – emotional control

They continued eating, the warmth of the meal grounding them as Lunaria's voice wove through the quiet clinking of spoons and the soft crackle of the hearth.

“As for how you'll begin testing Connect in this realm,” she said, “there are many paths. But first, we'll start with something foundational.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe leaned in, eyes bright with curiosity. Their minds flicked back to the dream from the night before — to Mami and Kuroe, fighting through trial after trial without using Connect, until that final moment of terror, when they reached for each other's hands in desperation. That single, instinctive gesture had changed everything.

“Will we do something like what Mami and Kyoko did from our dream?” Momoko asked. “Like... trials and battles?”

Lunaria smiled.

“Perhaps. But before that, you must understand something essential: emotional control.”

She set her cup down, her tone turning more serious.

“You're calm now. At peace. And you're learning to live with joy. That's beautiful. But it's not permanent. Life will still bring hardship. Pain. Despair. That's inevitable.”

The girls nodded, their expressions sobering.

“But emotional control,” Lunaria continued, “isn't about avoiding negativity. It's about what you do with it. How you hold it. How you shape it.”

She looked at Kuroe.

“Like when I used the negativity from Mami's soul gem to amplify my final strike.”

The girls blinked.

Momoko tilted her head. “Wait... you mean... you used despair as fuel?”

Mifuyu's brow furrowed. “I always thought negativity was something to avoid. Something that corrupted us.”

Kuroe's eyes widened. “You're saying we can use it?”

Lunaria nodded.

“It's a shift in perspective. Negativity isn't inherently evil. It's energy. Raw, volatile, yes — but not useless. If you can remain aware, if you don't let it consume you, you can channel it.”

Kuroe frowned thoughtfully.

“Then... wouldn’t it be better to always stay in a negative state? So you’d have more to use?”

Lunaria chuckled, her voice warm.

“That’s a logical thought. But not quite.”

She gestured to their soul gems, each one glowing with a soft, steady light.

“Magical girls are at their strongest when they’re at peace. When they’re relaxed. When they’re truly enjoying life. That’s when your soul gems shine brightest. That’s when your magic flows freely.”

She paused.

“Think of emotional control as a technique — a response. When negativity arises, you don’t have to fear it. You can hold it. Shape it. Use it. Just like a human might find a sudden burst of strength in a moment of fear or anger — enough to lift something heavy, or run faster than they ever have. But if a person lived in that state all the time... it would destroy them.”

Momoko nodded slowly.

“That makes sense. It’s not about chasing despair. It’s about not being ruled by it.”

Mifuyu added, “It’s like... learning to breathe through the storm. Not letting it drown you.”

Kuroe’s voice was quiet. “That’s... really different from everything we were taught.”

Lunaria smiled.

“And yet, what Kuroe said does have merit. There are levels to this.”

She held up a finger.

“The most basic form of emotional control is immediate use. When negativity arises — fear, anger, sorrow — you can channel it into a quick burst of power. A sharper strike. A stronger shield.”

She raised a second finger.

“But the more advanced technique is accumulation. You allow the negativity to settle inside you. You don’t suppress it. You don’t let it consume you. You hold it. Let it steep.”

She raised a third finger.

“And then, when the time is right — you release it. All at once. Into a single, devastating strike.”

The girls stared, wide-eyed.

“But,” Lunaria added, her tone firm, “this is dangerous. The more negativity you store, the closer you walk to the edge. If you hold too much... you risk becoming a witch.”

Momoko exhaled slowly.

“So many layers,” she murmured. “So many ways to use it.”

Mifuyu's eyes were thoughtful. "It's not just about power. It's about balance."

Kuroe looked down at her soul gem, its light steady and clear.

"I want to learn," she said. "All of it."

Lunaria's smile deepened.

"And you will. One step at a time."

Momoko set down her spoon, her expression thoughtful.

"This reminds me of what happened with the doppelified magical girls," she said. "When Mifuyu and I tried to take their despair into ourselves... we started to break. We couldn't hold it. Kasumi had to save us."

Mifuyu nodded, her voice low and steady.

"So you're saying... if we master emotional control, we could save them safely? Without breaking? Without dying?"

Lunaria smiled warmly.

"That's correct."

The girls froze.

Momoko's eyes widened, her breath catching in her throat.

Mifuyu's spoon hovered in midair, forgotten.

Kuroe leaned forward, her voice trembling with hope.

"Then we could help so many magical girls. In Kamihama. Everywhere."

Lunaria nodded.

"You could."

The air in the cabin seemed to shift — brighter, lighter, charged with possibility. The fire crackled softly in the hearth, but the warmth they felt now came from something deeper.

Kuroe's voice was soft.

"In our dream... the shadow monster corrupted the soul gems of Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, and Hoshine. Even the two girls without soul gems felt it. If they had known about emotional control..."

She looked at Lunaria, her eyes searching.

"Would things have ended differently?"

Lunaria's gaze softened. Her eyes shimmered with emotion, and she gave a small, forlorn smile.

“Yes,” she said quietly. “If they had known... maybe they would have survived.”

The girls looked at her with warmth, their hearts aching.

There was something in Lunaria’s expression — a deep, quiet grief. As if she had carried those girls in her heart for a long time. As if their loss had carved something permanent into her soul.

Momoko reached out, placing a hand gently on Lunaria’s arm.

“We’ll learn,” she said. “We’ll do better.”

Lunaria’s smile returned — bright, radiant.

“And you’ll have the perfect place to begin.”

She stood, her voice lifting with excitement.

“There’s an arena in this realm. A space for training, for growth. You can do tutorials, drills, even battles — against witches, monsters, and other magical girls.”

She gestured toward the window, as if the arena lay just beyond the trees.

“The essences of countless beings — witches, monsters, magical girls from across space and time — are stored there. They can be summoned at will. The shadow monster is one of them.”

Momoko’s eyes widened.

“You mean... we can fight it? For real?”

Lunaria nodded.

“The battles are real. But they don’t have lasting consequences. You can go all out. No fear of death. No permanent injuries.”

She gave a playful wink.

“And the Kyoko you saw in the dream? That was a magical girl summoned by Mami in the arena. A version of Kyoko from Mami’s past — when they were close friends. Partners. Before the current Kyoko’s family died because of her wish. Before she and Mami cut ties.”

Kuroe’s breath caught.

“Such a thing is possible?” she whispered. “To reunite with someone from your past?”

Lunaria nodded.

“Yes. The real Kyoko was broken. And Mami suffered deeply because of it. But her reunion with that past Kyoko — the one who still believed in their bond — was a moment of true happiness for her.”

She smiled, her voice softening.

“As you saw in your dreams, Mami and Kyoko fought very well side by side without even using Connect. That’s how strong their bond was. That’s what friendship can do.”

The room fell silent.

It was the most shocking thing Lunaria had said yet.

An arena where they could learn, grow, and fight without fear of loss.

A place where the past could be summoned. Where old bonds could be revisited. Where healing could begin.

Momoko and Mifuyu turned to Lunaria, eyes sparkling with awe.

“Does that mean...” Momoko began.

“...we could talk to Mel and Kanae?” Mifuyu finished. “Like when we Connected with Yachiyo?”

Lunaria chuckled, her eyes twinkling.

“If their essences are stored in the arena,” she said, “then yes. You can.”

The girls laughed — breathless, disbelieving.

It felt too good to be true.

They looked at Lunaria with reverence, hearts pounding with excitement.

And they waited, eager for what she would reveal next.

Chapter 2d: New frontiers, new abilities – magical control

As they continued eating, Lunaria set her cup down and smiled.

“Now that we’ve covered emotional control,” she said, “let’s talk about the second technique: magical control.”

Momoko tilted her head.

“Magical control?” she echoed. “We already control magic. We use it in battle — for attacks, shields, healing...”

Mifuyu nodded. “It’s part of who we are.”

Kuroe leaned in. “So what does magical control mean here?”

Lunaria chuckled softly and motioned toward their soul gems, each one glowing with a steady, vibrant light.

“Your soul gems are shining brighter than before,” she said. “Which means your magic is stronger. Your offensive, defensive, and supportive abilities have all grown.”

The girls looked down at their soul gems, watching the light pulse gently.

“But,” Lunaria continued, “if you use your magic recklessly — without thought or restraint — you’ll still deplete it. Your soul gem will dull at the usual rate. You’ll need rest to replenish.”

Momoko frowned slightly, thinking it through.

“So it’s not just about how strong our magic is,” she said. “It’s about how we use it. Efficiently.”

Mifuyu’s eyes lit with understanding.

“To preserve energy. To last longer in battle. To avoid burning out.”

Lunaria smiled.

“Exactly. Now that your magic is stronger, you don’t need to exert as much effort to achieve the same results. The key is learning how to tone your magic use depending on the situation.”

She leaned forward slightly.

“The ideal is to use the bare minimum magic required. When you begin an attack, your soul, body, and mind should be relaxed and in sync. Then — right before the moment of impact — you pour in your magical energy. That’s when the explosion happens.”

She gestured with her hand, mimicking a sudden burst.

“The same principle applies to defense and support. Relaxed control, followed by precise amplification.”

The girls nodded slowly, absorbing the concept.

Momoko spoke first.

“We’ve done something like that before,” she said. “Using our normal output most of the time, then powering up when facing a strong witch.”

Mifuyu added, her voice thoughtful, “But we’ve never really thought about using the bare minimum. Or timing the amplification precisely.”

Kuroe’s voice was quiet.

“It’s like... learning to breathe with your magic. Not just throw it.”

Mifuyu’s gaze grew distant.

“I remember... my and Yachiyo’s past. The scene with Kanae that’s shown at the Memory Museum. The one that teaches magical girls the truth about their soul gems.”

Her voice trembled.

“Kanae protected us. We were bound by a witch. She poured everything into her shield. She sent the attack back. She won.”

She paused.

“But her soul gem shattered. She died.”

Lunaria looked at Mifuyu, her eyes touched with sorrow.

“Yes,” she said softly. “Most magical girls only tone up their magic when they’re desperate. When they’re cornered. If done wrong... their soul gems break.”

Her voice grew quieter.

“Just like Elira, Sylvette, and Mirielle. When they fought the shadow monster.”

The girls felt it again — that deep empathy in Lunaria’s voice. The same ache she’d shown when speaking of emotional control. The same grief.

It wasn’t just sympathy.

It was something else.

Two times was too much to be a coincidence.

They began speaking telepathically, their thoughts weaving together in silence.

There it is again, Kuroe said. *That tone. That sorrow. Those eyes...*

It’s as if she knew them personally, Mifuyu replied slowly. *As if she regrets their deaths deeply.*

Momoko’s thoughts came next, quiet and reflective.

Was Lunaria there? Was she one of the girls without soul gems? Was that dream her showing us her past — like the Memory Museum does, Mifuyu?

That would make sense, Kuroe said. *If Lunaria was one of the girls without soul gems... then maybe Kasumi was the other?*

Mifuyu’s voice was steady in their minds.

I think we’re on to something. But let’s wait. Let’s find the right moment to ask. When the time is right.

All of them agreed.

And as they looked at Lunaria — her eyes still soft with sorrow, her smile quietly resilient — they felt something stir in their hearts.

A deeper connection.

A quiet promise.

And the sense that the truth, when it came, would change everything.

Momoko reached out, her voice gentle.

“They didn’t know. But we will.”

Lunaria nodded.

“Conscious magical control — using your energy efficiently, amplifying at the precise moment — will make your abilities stronger than if you simply poured everything in from the start.”

She smiled.

“Think of it like a whip. If you swing it hard in one direction, you’ll do damage. But if your arm is relaxed, and you snap it at the right moment — the strike is sharper. More explosive. More precise.”

The girls laughed softly, the analogy clicking into place.

“That makes sense,” Momoko said. “It’s about timing. About rhythm.”

Mifuyu nodded. “And restraint.”

Kuroe smiled. “And trust. In yourself.”

They began to talk — voices overlapping with excitement, hands gesturing mid-air as they tried to describe the sensations they were only beginning to grasp.

“What if,” Momoko said, eyes sparkling, “magical control lets me swing my sword with just a whisper of energy — and then, right at the moment of impact, it erupts like a comet? A burst of light and heat, but only where I need it.”

She mimed the motion, her hand slicing through the air, then snapping forward like a whip.

Mifuyu laughed.

“That sounds beautiful,” she said. “I think for me... my illusions could become more fluid. Like... they respond to my allies’ emotions. If someone’s scared, I could cast a comforting memory. If someone’s angry, I could redirect that into a mirage that confuses the enemy.”

She twirled her fingers, as if weaving threads of light.

“Maybe I could even create illusions that change mid-battle. Like a living story.”

Kuroe leaned forward, her voice soft but glowing.

“My batons... I want them to move like fireflies. Gentle at first, almost playful. Then — when the timing’s right — they detonate with perfect precision. Like stars falling exactly where they’re needed.”

She smiled shyly.

“And maybe... maybe I could learn to make them orbit my allies. Shield them. Dance with their magic.”

Lunaria chuckled, listening to their excitement.

She winked.

“More power isn’t the only benefit,” she said. “If you reach a certain level of mastery, your abilities will evolve. New traits. New effects. And maybe... new abilities entirely. Ones that don’t require Connect.”

She leaned back, her eyes twinkling.

“Just like with Connect, your imagination will be the key.”

The girls laughed — warm, breathless, full of wonder.

Momoko leaned back, arms stretched behind her head, her eyes shining with possibility.

“I want my sword to sing,” she said. “Not just in battle — I mean really sing. A melody that harmonizes with my teammates’ magic. Every swing a note. Every clash a chord. A rhythm that lifts them up, makes them feel stronger, braver.”

She sat up, her voice gaining momentum.

“If I can master magical control, maybe I won’t have to choose between offense and defense anymore. I can be a frontline attacker who supports from the front — someone who inspires just by fighting.”

She grinned.

“And maybe... when I strike, little comet sparkles will burst from the impact. Not just damage — but light. Sound. Like a bell chime or a chorus of stars. And those sparks could swirl around my teammates, boosting their magic, healing their wounds, reminding them they’re not alone.”

Mifuyu’s eyes lit up, her hands clasped in front of her chest.

“That’s beautiful, Momoko.”

She took a breath, her voice turning thoughtful.

“For me... I want my illusions to stop being tricks. I want them to become memories. Real ones. Echoes of moments that mattered. So when someone sees them, they don’t just see — they feel. They remember. They heal.”

She closed her eyes for a moment, then opened them again.

“And you know how I’ve used my illusions to manipulate perception — to push past my own limits, or help others do the same? It’s always been risky. Like walking a tightrope over a void.”

She looked at Lunaria.

“But if I master magical control... maybe I won’t have to manipulate anything anymore. Maybe I can truly expand my limits — and help others do the same. Safely. Temporarily. Like opening a door inside them they didn’t know was there.”

Kuroe’s voice was soft, but radiant.

“I want my magic to feel like belonging,” she said. “Like... when I cast something, it makes people feel safe. Seen. Like they matter.”

She looked down at her batons, then back up.

“Maybe I could strike the ground and raise walls — not just to block attacks, but to protect. To create space. And maybe those walls could bloom — with flowers, vines, even fruit-bearing trees.”

Her eyes sparkled.

“Like what you did for breakfast, Lunaria. I want to grow things. Living things. Plants that soothe the soul. That smell like home. That heal you when you breathe them in, or eat their fruit. Like the forest here — gentle, alive, kind.”

Lunaria watched them, her smile deepening with every word.

The girls kept going, their voices overlapping, their ideas growing wilder and more beautiful.

Momoko imagined her sword leaving trails of light that danced like auroras.

Mifuyu described illusions that could wrap around a teammate like a cloak, shielding them with a memory of someone they loved.

Kuroe wondered if her magic could one day create entire sanctuaries — little pockets of peace in the middle of battle.

The cabin glowed with more than firelight now.

It glowed with possibility.

And for a moment, they were just girls again — dreaming with the wild joy of children.

No grief seeds.

No despair.

Just hope.

Just magic.

Just the future, waiting to be shaped.

Chapter 2e: New frontiers, new abilities – Dis-connect

Dessert was served — delicate fruit tarts, honeyed pastries, and soft cakes infused with forest-grown spices. The girls savored each bite, letting the sweetness linger on their tongues, the flavors as gentle and nourishing as the morning light.

As they ate, Lunaria’s voice turned thoughtful.

“Now,” she said, “let’s talk about the third ability. The one you’ve been asking about.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe looked up, eyes wide, spoons paused midair.

Dis-connect.

The ability Lunaria had used to save Kuroe when she became a witch.

It had to be something special. Something advanced. Something revolutionary.

Lunaria saw their anticipation and chuckled.

“The concept,” she said, “is actually very simple.”

She gestured with her hand, tracing a slow arc in the air.

“Connect is about syncing with another person — their magic, their soul, their essence. Dis-connect is the opposite. It’s about disrupting a target’s energy when you make contact. When your attacks land.”

She paused.

“When mastered, you can sever your enemy’s magic. Drain their strength. Even take it for yourself.”

The girls froze.

Their breath caught.

Their spoons hovered.

Dessert forgotten.

Momoko’s mouth fell open.

Mifuyu blinked, stunned.

Kuroe whispered, “That’s... incredible.”

To weaken an enemy. To cut off their magic. To absorb their power.

It was simple in theory — but the implications were staggering.

Kuroe leaned forward, trying to piece it all together.

“So... when you saved me,” she said, “you siphoned all the negativity that consumed me when my doppel took over. When I became a witch.”

She looked at Lunaria.

“And with Mami — you did the same. You drained the negativity from her soul gem. And then used it to amplify your attack.”

Lunaria smiled.

“Exactly. Simple conceptually, right?”

Momoko exhaled slowly.

“Simple to understand,” she said. “But how do you even begin to learn something like that? It sounds... very hard.”

Mifuyu nodded.

“What Momoko and I did to save the doppelified magical girls — it was similar. We connected with them. Shared their despair. Told them it was okay to cry. That they were loved. We took their suffering into ourselves.”

She looked at Lunaria.

“But what you’re describing... it’s broader. More versatile. It can be used in battle. Not just to save someone drowning in despair.”

Lunaria nodded.

“That is a good interpretation,” she said. “What you did was similar. But as Mifuyu said — there are differences.”

The girls chuckled, their hearts warm at her compliment. It felt good to know that something they’d done — something born of compassion — was part of a greater magical truth.

Lunaria continued.

“There are many levels to dis-connect. Many applications. Let me share a few.”

She leaned forward.

“A basic application is to siphon negativity from your target. Similar to what you did — but in a forced manner. You sync with your target, disrupt their negativity, and disconnect it from them.”

The girls paused, absorbing the idea.

To force your way into someone’s magic.

To sever what was harming them.

To take it away.

Momoko’s brow furrowed.

“That’s... intense,” she said. “Groundbreaking. I’ve never thought about magic like that.”

Mifuyu asked, “What’s needed to do that?”

Lunaria smiled.

“What I’ve already explained,” she said. “Very precise magical control. And a deep understanding of Connect.”

The girls gasped softly.

Again — so simple in concept.

But the mastery required...

Momoko shook her head, smiling in disbelief.

“The amount of control you’d need...”

Lunaria chuckled.

“Yes. To use dis-connect, you must be excellent at controlling your own magic. If you can’t do that — how could you possibly control someone else’s?”

She looked at each of them.

“And you must understand Connect deeply. Because this technique involves the interaction of magic between multiple souls.”

The girls sat back, thoughtful.

They could feel it — the weight of the path ahead.

To learn dis-connect, they would need to master what came before.

Magical control.

Connect.

Only then could they begin to touch the edges of this power.

Lunaria nodded, her voice calm and steady, as if she were guiding them through a sacred truth. “Once you’ve siphoned your target’s negativity,” she said, “there are multiple ways to use it.”

She let the words settle, then continued. “The simplest is to release it — to dissipate it back into the universe as pure energy. It’s the safest option. And it fulfills Kyubey’s original goal: supplying energy to prevent the universe from dying.”

The girls paused, then chuckled softly, the irony blooming between them like a shared joke. Momoko leaned back, shaking her head. “So dis-connect could be used to fulfill Kyubey’s goal... the very goal that started everything. The contracts. The magical girls. The witches.”

Mifuyu smiled, her voice tinged with wonder. “Maybe if enough people learned dis-connect, Kyubey wouldn’t need to make contracts anymore.” Kuroe nodded, eyes wide. “The cycle of suffering could stop.”

Lunaria laughed gently, her eyes glowing. “That’s a beautiful way of looking at it. Maybe one day, that will be reality — a world where no one feels despair. Where no one feels tricked.”

Kuroe leaned forward, her voice thoughtful. “And the other way to use negativity... is to take it into yourself. To amplify your attacks. Like you did with Mami.”

Lunaria nodded. “Yes. But that path is difficult. Dangerous. It requires mastery of emotional control — the technique I taught you earlier.”

She gave them a playful wink. “I hope you’re starting to see how all knowledge **connects** — pun intended.”

The girls burst into laughter, the pun landing perfectly. Connect really was at the heart of everything — even Lunaria’s humor. But beneath the laughter, her words resonated deeply. The idea that every technique they learned could unlock new layers of magic, new applications, new truths — it made the world feel vast and intricate, like a living tapestry woven from threads of pain, joy, and possibility.

Lunaria’s voice grew more serious. “It’s already hard enough to control your own emotions when life gets hard. Now imagine taking someone else’s despair into yourself — their suffering, their fear — and trying to hold it steady. Especially in the middle of battle.”

The girls fell silent, the weight of her words pressing gently against their hearts.

Kuroe spoke first, her voice low and raw. “I couldn’t control my own despair when my doppel took over. I drowned in it. I became a witch.” She looked down at her hands, then up at Lunaria. “I can’t imagine trying to hold someone else’s despair on top of that. Especially while fighting. It’s too much.”

Momoko and Mifuyu nodded, their expressions solemn. “We remember how it felt,” Momoko said. “Every time we took in a doppelified magical girl’s despair... it was heavy. Crushing. But we kept going.” Mifuyu added, “We were about to die. We were falling apart. And then Kasumi saved us.”

Momoko looked at Lunaria. “We only got that far because we connected — with each other, with Yachiyo, with Mitama. If we’d tried to do it alone...”

“We wouldn’t have made it,” Mifuyu finished.

Lunaria smiled, mischievous and proud. “Exactly. That’s why Kasumi and I believe in the deep-end method. You’ve lived it. You understand — in your bones, in your soul — what it feels like to break. To lose yourself to despair. And because of that, you can truly appreciate what these techniques mean.”

The girls laughed again, this time from the heart. It was laughter born of recognition, of shared pain, of hard-earned wisdom. And in that moment, they understood Lunaria more deeply than ever — why she and Kasumi had waited. Why they had let them fall before lifting them. Because only by falling could they learn how to rise.

The fire crackled softly in the hearth, casting golden light across the table as the last of the dessert was savored in thoughtful silence. The sweetness of fruit and honey lingered on their tongues, but the warmth now came from something deeper — the quiet, electric hum of understanding beginning to take root.

Lunaria’s voice, low and steady, carried them further. “Once you’ve learned to siphon negativity,” she said, “you can begin to siphon magic itself.”

The words landed like a stone dropped into still water. The ripples spread slowly, touching something deep within each of them. It wasn’t just the idea of power that stirred them — it was the realization that magic, once thought to be a fixed resource, could be fluid. Transferable. Vulnerable.

“The first step,” Lunaria continued, “is to disrupt your target’s magical flow. To interfere with their casting, their defenses, their movement. Even that alone can shift the balance of a battle.”

Momoko’s spoon hovered, forgotten. “So it’s not just about overpowering someone,” she murmured. “It’s about unraveling them.”

Mifuyu’s brows drew together, her mind already tracing the implications. “If you can interrupt someone’s magic at the source... you don’t need to be stronger. Just more precise.”

Kuroe’s voice was soft, but charged with awe. “It’s like... fighting with silence. With stillness. You don’t need to shout to be heard.”

Lunaria nodded. “Exactly. And once you’ve mastered the technique, you can go further. You can drain magical energy from your opponent. Every time you make contact — every strike, every touch — they grow weaker. And you grow stronger.”

The room seemed to still. Even the air felt heavier, as if the world itself were pausing to listen.

Momoko exhaled slowly. “If we could do that... we could fight witches way stronger than us. And win.”

“There’d be almost no scenario where we’d be truly hopeless,” Mifuyu added, her voice quiet but firm.

Kuroe’s eyes shimmered with something like wonder. “It’s like... rewriting the rules. Turning the tide with every heartbeat.”

Lunaria smiled, pleased by their clarity. “As you may have guessed, this requires extremely deep knowledge of Connect, magic, and very precise magical control. You must understand how magic flows — not just within yourself, but between souls. Between intentions.”

Mifuyu’s gaze turned inward, her thoughts circling. “Are there no limits to dis-connect?” she asked. “Can it be used on anyone, at any time? It sounds... too powerful. Too convenient.”

Lunaria’s smile deepened, touched with something like pride. “Good,” she said. “You’re asking the right questions. That’s growth. Back then, when you accepted Kyubey’s contract... you didn’t ask enough.”

The girls exchanged quiet smiles — not bitter, but knowing. That contract had carved itself into their lives, a scar and a lesson both. It had taught them to be wary of easy answers. To question what they were told. To seek the truth beneath the promise.

“Dis-connect,” Lunaria continued, “is powerful. But it’s not invincible. The counter to it is simple — emotional and magical control. You don’t need to know dis-connect to resist it.”

Momoko blinked. “Really?”

“You don’t need dis-connect to counter dis-connect?” Mifuyu echoed, leaning in.

Lunaria nodded. “Exactly. That’s why the simplest application is siphoning negativity. Negativity is chaotic. It clouds judgment. It destabilizes emotions. When someone is sad, angry, afraid — they don’t think clearly. Their magic becomes easier to disrupt.”

The girls fell into a thoughtful hush.

It made sense. They had felt it themselves — the way despair made their magic flicker, how fear made their shields falter. Momoko and Mifuyu remembered the doppelified magical girls they had saved. The weight of their sorrow had been overwhelming, but also strangely permeable. It had flowed into them like smoke through cracks in a wall. But their magic — their core — had remained untouched. That had always felt sacred. Untouchable.

“Siphoning magic,” Lunaria said, her voice softer now, “is different. It mostly comes down to control — yours and theirs. If your target has strong magical control, even without knowing dis-connect, they can resist you. The best defense is to be calm. Relaxed. At peace. And to have good magical control.”

She paused, letting the truth settle.

“But if they’re not in a good state of mind... if their control is weak... you can take advantage of that. And if the magical power difference is vast, the stronger one can brute-force dis-connect. Overwhelm the weaker.”

The fire popped softly, sending a small ember spiraling upward.

Momoko folded her hands in her lap, her voice low. “It’s strange. The more we learn, the more I realize how fragile we are. And how powerful we could be.”

Mifuyu nodded. “It’s not just about strength. It’s about awareness. About knowing yourself. Knowing others.”

Kuroe looked down at her soul gem, its light steady and soft. “It’s terrifying,” she said. “But also... kind of beautiful. That we can protect each other. That we can grow.”

Lunaria watched them, her expression unreadable — but her eyes were full of something ancient and tender.

And in that moment, the girls weren’t just students learning a technique.

They were inheriting a philosophy.

A way of being.

A way of fighting that didn’t just rely on power, but on understanding. On empathy. On the willingness to carry another’s pain — and the wisdom to know when not to.

The last crumbs of dessert had barely disappeared when Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe leaned back in their chairs, their hearts full and their minds alight. The cabin still glowed with the warmth of the meal, but it was Lunaria’s words — her teachings, her presence — that lingered most. They looked at her

with quiet reverence, the kind reserved for someone who had not only saved their lives, but reshaped their understanding of what it meant to live.

“Thank you,” Momoko said softly, her voice steady but full. “For everything. For yesterday. For bringing us here. For giving us hope.”

Mifuyu nodded, her gaze gentle. “And for sharing so much with us. This knowledge... it’s revolutionary. It changes everything.”

Kuroe added, “It opens doors we didn’t even know existed. I can already imagine how much this will help us — not just here, but back home. With our friends. With every magical girl we meet.”

Lunaria smiled, touched by their sincerity. She didn’t speak right away, letting their gratitude settle like dew on morning grass.

Then Momoko stood, her grin wide and infectious. “Okay!” she said, hands on her hips. “I’m fired up. What do we do now? Do we go to the arena and start training?”

Mifuyu and Kuroe chuckled, their eyes sparkling with the same excitement. The heaviness of the earlier conversation had softened into anticipation — the kind that comes when you know you’re about to begin something meaningful.

Lunaria laughed, her voice light and melodic. “I love your energy,” she said. “But remember — you don’t need to learn everything at once. Choose one thing. Understand its fundamentals. Let it settle into your bones. Then, when you’re ready, you can go deeper. Or shift to something new. The journey of growth is yours to map.”

The girls nodded, her words grounding them again. It was true — she had given them so much in such a short time. Emotional control, magical control, dis-connect... each one a paradigm shift. Each one a doorway into a new way of being.

They began to talk among themselves, voices soft but animated, the glow of the hearth casting flickers of light across their faces. The conversation was no longer just about techniques — it was about who they were, what they’d lived through, and what they hoped to become.

Momoko leaned forward, her eyes bright with determination. “I think I’ll start with magical control,” she said. “I want to understand how to harmonize my sword with my teammates — not just fight beside them, but fight with them. If I can time my strikes just right, pour in magic at the perfect moment... maybe my attacks could explode like comets. Not just powerful, but beautiful. And if those bursts could lift others up, boost their strength, give them hope...” She trailed off, smiling. “That’s the kind of fighter I want to be.”

Mifuyu nodded, her expression more introspective. “For me, it’s emotional control,” she said quietly. “I want to learn how to hold despair without breaking. I’ve carried so much — my own, and others’. And I’ve always feared that one day, it would be too much. But if I can learn to shape it, to use it without being consumed... maybe I can help others do the same. Maybe I can be the one who holds steady when everything else falls apart.”

Kuroe was silent for a moment, her gaze lowered. Then she looked up, her voice soft but resolute. “I want to start with emotional control too,” she said. “Not just for myself — but for girls like Kuro. I know what it’s like to drown in despair. To lose yourself. I don’t want anyone to have to rely on grief seeds just to survive. If I can learn to stay grounded... maybe I can help others find their footing too. Maybe I can be the hand that reaches out before it’s too late.”

Their voices faded into a quiet hum of reflection.

Each of them had chosen a path not just for power, but for healing.

And in that moment, the techniques Lunaria had taught them were no longer just skills — they were promises. To themselves. To each other. To every magical girl still fighting in the dark.

Lunaria stood, her movements graceful and unhurried. “Let’s go to the arena,” she said. “Mami and Kasumi are already there.”

The girls looked up, eyes wide.

“Mami?” Momoko asked.

“She’s preparing for a special fight,” Lunaria said, her smile turning mischievous. “She’ll be using Connect for the first time — with dream-Kyoko. They’ll be facing a ‘special’ opponent Kasumi prepared. This will be a good opportunity to see some of the techniques I mentioned being used in a real fight.”

She winked at the word “special,” and the girls leaned in, intrigued.

Momoko’s eyes sparkled. “We get to see Mami fight? Awesome! This will be great!”

“And Kasumi,” Mifuyu added. “I want to thank her for saving us yesterday.”

Kuroe’s voice was quiet, but eager. “I wonder who the opponent is. A rematch with the six witches from yesterday? The shadow monster? Or someone else entirely?”

They all remembered the dream — how Mami and Kyoko had fought side by side, fluid and fearless, even without Connect. To see them now, using these techniques in real battle while using connect... it felt like witnessing the future unfold.

Lunaria turned toward the door, her steps light.

But before she could open it, the girls exchanged a glance — and began to speak telepathically.

This might be the right time, Momoko said. To ask her.

Kuroe nodded. *She’s been so open about magic. But not about herself.*

Mifuyu’s voice was gentle. *Every time she mentioned Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, Hoshine, and the two girls without soul gems... the sadness in her eyes. It felt personal. Like regret.*

Kuroe added, *I felt like I was looking in a mirror when I saw her. I regret not helping Kuro. Maybe she regrets something too.*

Momoko took a breath, then spoke aloud. “Lunaria?”

Lunaria paused, her hand on the doorframe. She didn’t turn around.

Mifuyu stepped forward. “When you were teaching us... you looked sad. Especially when you talked about the girls in our dream. About how things might’ve ended differently if they’d known these techniques.”

Kuroe’s voice was soft. “It felt like you knew them. Like you were one of them.”

Momoko’s voice was gentle. “Were you one of the girls without a soul gem? And... is Kasumi the other?”

Lunaria turned her head slowly, just enough for her eyes to meet theirs.

Dark. Calm. Ancient.

But this time — this time — there was something else. A flicker. A shimmer. Like moonlight on still water.

Her smile came slowly, quiet and unreadable.

“...Maybe another time,” she said, her voice gentle. Tinged with something they couldn’t quite name.

She turned back toward the door.

The girls didn’t press.

But they felt it — the same deflection she’d given Mitama yesterday. “Not yet.” A promise, not a refusal.

They spoke telepathically again, their thoughts braided with hope.

She’ll tell us one day, Mifuyu said.

Momoko nodded. *When she’s ready*.

Kuroe smiled. *We’ll be ready too*.

Lunaria opened the door.

Light shifted around them — soft, radiant, alive.

And together, they stepped into the arena.

Chapter 3: Introductions in the arena

The morning sun bathed the open arena in golden light, casting long, dappled shadows across the expansive grass plain. Hovering flower pods floated gently above the field, their petals shimmering like stained glass — empty for now, but soon to cradle spectators from across realms: magical girls, summoned beings, and quiet presences drawn by curiosity, reverence, or hope. The air was fresh and

fragrant, touched with the scent of dew and wild blossoms, and beneath it all, the aroma of breakfast lingered: warm bread, roasted vegetables, and something sweet and spiced that curled through the breeze like a promise.

At the long wooden table set near the center of the field, Mami and Kasumi sat side by side, savoring the last bites of their enchanted meal. Mami took another spoonful of hearty stew, letting it melt into her like sunlight through skin. It wasn't just delicious — it was invigorating. She could feel it in her limbs, in her soul gem, in the quiet hum of her magic waking up.

"This food..." she murmured, eyes half-closed, "it's giving me energy. I can feel it. Like it's waking up my magic."

Kasumi grinned, cheeks full, and waved her spoon with a flourish. "That's because it's special," she said, voice muffled with joy. "You and Kyoko are fighting a very special opponent today. You need to be in peak condition."

Mami raised an eyebrow, amused. "Special, huh? You always say that with such ominous emphasis."

Kasumi beamed, unbothered. "Because I mean it. And don't worry — the food won't sit heavy in your stomach. It's enchanted. You'll feel light and strong when you fight. So dig in!"

Mami laughed, watching Kasumi shovel another spoonful into her mouth with gusto. "You're eating like you're the one about to fight. Are you just really hungry, or...?"

Kasumi gave her a wink, her grin widening. "Let's just say I'm preparing for the special fight too. And yes, I'm also really hungry."

Mami chuckled, shaking her head. Preparing to be the host again, she thought. She remembered yesterday's "punishment" — how Kasumi had gleefully narrated her and Kyoko's battle against six witches, bouncing with energy like a magical girl game show host. That must be it. Kasumi was just fueling up for another round of theatrical commentary.

But as the laughter faded, a quiet weight settled in Mami's chest. She set her spoon down and looked across the table, her voice softening.

"Kasumi... assuming you and Lunaria haven't found another way to save Sayaka... how long do you think it would take me to learn even a small part of dis-connect? Just enough to siphon the negativity from her soul gem and release it into the universe?"

Kasumi paused, her spoon halfway to her mouth. She chewed thoughtfully, then set her bowl down and tapped her chin.

"Well... once you've experienced Connect — which you will today — and you really start practicing... I'd say, at minimum, a few weeks. That's just to siphon negativity from a stationary target. One that doesn't resist."

Mami's eyes widened. "A few weeks?" she echoed, barely above a whisper.

The words hit her like a stone dropped into still water. Her appetite vanished. She stared down at her plate, the warmth of the food now distant.

“That’s... too long,” she said, slowly, deliberately, as if each word had to be pulled from somewhere deep inside. “Sayaka doesn’t have weeks. If I can’t reach her soon... she’ll become a witch. And if that happens, Kyoko or Homura will have to...”

She couldn’t finish the sentence. The image of Sayaka’s soul gem cracking, of her transformation into something monstrous, was too much. Her hands trembled slightly in her lap.

But across from her, Kasumi’s smile didn’t falter. If anything, it grew brighter — radiant and unwavering.

“Don’t be so down,” she said, her voice full of warmth. “Advanced techniques take time. There’s no shortcut. But that just means you have more room to grow. More space to become who you’re meant to be.”

She leaned forward, eyes sparkling. “Live in the moment, Mami. Don’t let the future weigh you down before it even arrives. Focus on what you can do now — today. That’s how you get to where you want to be.”

Then she gave Mami a wink. “Besides, you’ve got a show to put on. Everyone’s excited to see you and Kyoko fight using Connect for the first time. And I did say I’d only tell you what Lunaria and I discovered in Kamihama if you two give everyone a good performance.”

Mami laughed, the heaviness in her chest lifting just a little. Kasumi’s joy was infectious — like sunlight breaking through storm clouds.

“You’re impossible,” she said, smiling. “But thank you. I needed that.”

Mami took the final bite of her dessert — a delicate tart filled with forest berries and drizzled with a honey-lavender glaze. The crust was buttery and crisp, the filling bright and tangy, with just enough sweetness to linger on her tongue like a soft echo of joy. She closed her eyes for a moment, savoring it. It was the kind of dessert that didn’t just satisfy hunger — it lifted the spirit.

Across from her, Kasumi was finishing her own: a spiced apple cake with a swirl of whipped cream that shimmered faintly with magical energy. She hummed with delight as she popped the last bite into her mouth, cheeks glowing with contentment.

Mami stood, brushing a few golden crumbs from her skirt, her soul gem gleaming with renewed light. The warmth of the meal, the comfort of Kasumi’s presence, and the anticipation of the fight ahead had all settled into her bones.

“Alright,” she said, her voice clear and strong. “I’m ready. Let’s do this special fight. I’ll live in the moment — and I’ll give it everything I’ve got.”

She winked, a playful glint in her eye. “And I hope Kyoko and I have fun.”

Kasumi clapped her hands, her energy bursting forth like a firework. “That’s the spirit! I’m sure you two will have a blast. And the audience is going to love it.”

Then, with a flourish, she twirled once — her skirt catching the breeze — and recited a string of nonsensical incantations: “Zibba-zabba, poof-a-la, sparkle-snap!” She clapped her hands, and in a shimmer of light, the table and food vanished, leaving only the scent of sweetness and the memory of laughter behind.

Mami gasped, eyes wide. “Wait... you made that breakfast?”

Kasumi placed her hands on her hips, grinning proudly. “Of course! I hope it made you feel energized, refreshed, and ready to shine.”

Mami laughed, warm and full. “It was perfect. Thank you — for the meal, and the company. I feel great.”

Kasumi gave a deep, theatrical bow. “Your compliments are accepted with honor and delight.”

Then, with a flick of her wrist, she manifested a microphone — sleek, glowing, and utterly out of place in the natural serenity of the arena. She strode forward, walking through the grass toward the center, her hair swaying in the soft breeze.

“Gooooood morning, everyone!” she shouted, her voice ringing with joy and mischief. “Are you all ready for Mami and Kyoko’s special fight today — where they’ll be using Connect for the very first time?!”

The arena erupted.

Shouts and cheers echoed from every direction as the space around them shimmered to life. Bright lights of magical energy swirled and danced, coalescing into shapes — silhouettes of people, witches, and monsters, all saved in the arena’s memory. The air pulsed with anticipation, with magic, with joy.

Mami turned slowly, eyes wide in wonder. The arena was alive — not just with light, but with presence. With hope.

And then, beside her, another silhouette began to form. Familiar. Fierce.

Kyoko.

The one from her past. The one who had gone through the entire beginner Connect training with her yesterday. The one who had reached for her hand in the dark.

Mami smiled, her heart warm.

She was ready.

As Kasumi’s voice echoed across the arena, the world around Mami began to shimmer.

Bright lights of magical energy swirled through the air like ribbons of stardust, weaving intricate patterns above the grass. The flower pods that had floated empty moments ago began to glow from within, their petals unfolding like blossoms at dawn. One by one, silhouettes began to take shape inside them — people, magical girls, witches, and stranger beings still abstract in form, their outlines flickering like candle flames in the wind.

And then, in a sudden shimmer of light, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe appeared in one of the pods.

“Wha—?!” Momoko gasped, blinking at the sudden shift in scenery. “Did she just... teleport us?”

Mifuyu looked around, wide-eyed. “I think she did. One second we were outside the cabin, and now...”

Kuroe leaned over the edge of the pod, gazing down at the vast arena below. “So this is how Lunaria and Kasumi got into Hotel Faint Hope yesterday without anyone noticing. They were already inside when Iroha and I went through the portal.”

“The surprises never end with those two,” Momoko murmured, half in awe, half in exasperation.

They looked around their pod, expecting to see Lunaria nearby — but she was nowhere in sight.

“She must be helping set up the fight,” Mifuyu said. “Or watching from somewhere else.”

But what truly stole their attention was the arena itself.

They were seated high above the field in their floating flower pod, the petals soft beneath them, the view breathtaking. Below stretched a vast grass plain, kissed by sunlight that bathed everything in a golden glow. The light shimmered on the blades of grass, catching on the swirling magical energy that danced through the air like fireflies.

All around them, the silhouettes continued to form — some humanoid, others more abstract, their shapes shifting like dreams. And even though they were still taking shape, the sound of laughter, cheers, and joyful chatter echoed through the arena, as if the beings were already fully present in spirit.

“It’s beautiful,” Kuroe whispered, reaching out toward a passing light.

The glowing wisp drifted through her fingers like mist, leaving behind a faint tingle and a trail of glittering motes.

Mifuyu followed suit, her hand brushing through another swirl of light. “It’s like... the air itself is alive.”

Momoko leaned forward, eyes wide. “It’s like watching stars being born.”

The lights continued to gather, coalescing into full forms. The arena filled with life — magical girls in vibrant costumes, witches with strange and elegant shapes, monsters with curious eyes and gentle postures. There was no fear, no tension. Only joy. The mood was electric, the energy infectious.

Mami could feel it too. Standing at the center of the field, she felt the weight of every gaze — not as pressure, but as warmth. The audience wasn’t here to judge. They were here to celebrate. To witness something new.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe leaned forward, their hearts racing. The joy of the crowd seeped into them, lifting their spirits. They couldn't help but smile.

"It's like..." Mifuyu began, then paused, searching for the words.

"...like everyone's together," Momoko finished. "No fighting. No fear."

Kuroe nodded. "Just... watching. Laughing. Existing."

For a moment, all four of them — Mami, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe — shared the same thought.

Is such a thing possible?

Could this kind of peace exist in Mitakihara? In Kamihama? On Earth?

A world where magical girls, witches, and monsters could sit side by side — not as enemies, but as witnesses to something beautiful.

It felt like a dream.

And then — the dream cracked.

A ripple of laughter burst through the arena, sudden and overwhelming. It started as a few chuckles, then grew into a wave of uncontrollable giggles, snorts, and howls of laughter. The entire audience — every being, every magical girl, every witch — was laughing.

And they were all looking in one direction.

Mami blinked, confused. "What...?"

From above in their flower pod, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe gasped in unison — then burst into laughter themselves.

"Oh my god—those magical girls down there must be Mami and Kyoko!" Momoko wheezed, clutching her stomach.

Mifuyu covered her mouth, trying to stifle her laughter, but tears were already forming in her eyes. "What... what happened to their faces?!"

Kuroe was doubled over, her voice barely audible between fits of laughter. "They look absolutely terrible... like a marker monster! Who did that to them?!"

Their laughter rang out across the arena, joining the chorus of delighted chaos.

The dream hadn't shattered.

It had simply taken a detour into comedy.

Mami blinked, her heart fluttering with confusion. The laughter was everywhere — rising like a wave, cresting with joy, and crashing down in a chorus of giggles and snorts. And all of it was directed at her.

She glanced around, trying to understand. Did she do something strange? Was her outfit wrong? Her stance? Her expression?

Then her eyes flicked toward Kyoko, who had just appeared beside her. Mami narrowed her gaze slightly. Kyoko was known to enjoy teasing her — maybe she'd done something mischievous again?

Mami turned toward her, brow furrowed.

Kyoko turned at the same time, equally puzzled.

Their eyes met.

And then — they both burst into uncontrollable laughter.

It hit them like a spell gone wrong. Mami doubled over, pointing at Kyoko, barely able to speak through her wheezing. “Wh-what happened to your face?!”

Kyoko's face was a disaster — streaked with jagged red lines, mismatched eyebrows, and what looked like a poorly drawn apple with fangs. It was chaotic, absurd, and utterly atrocious.

Kyoko, gasping for breath, pointed back. “Me?! You should look at your own face! It's a true disaster!”

Mami's face was no less ridiculous — her cheeks were covered in neon pink hearts, one eye ringed with glittery blue stars like a cosmic raccoon, and her lips outlined in thick, uneven black marker that gave her a permanent cartoonish pout. Across her forehead, someone had scrawled “MAGIC QUEEN” in bold, jagged letters, complete with a crooked crown doodled above it.

Mami's laughter faltered. Her hand flew to her cheek.

Kyoko's did the same.

And then — realization struck.

They froze.

Their eyes widened in horror. Mouths parted in dread. The color drained from their faces like water from a cracked vase.

Kyoko stepped forward, manifesting her spear with a flick of her wrist. She angled it so the polished metal caught the light, creating a mirror-like reflection.

They leaned in.

And what they saw stunned them.

Mami's face was covered in neon swirls, glittery stars, and a lopsided mustache. Her chin bore a giant smiley face, and her forehead had been scribbled with what looked like a magical girl's attempt at graffiti with her non-dominant hand.

Kyoko's face was no better — jagged lightning bolts, mismatched blush circles, and a chaotic mess of marker art that looked like it had been drawn by a sleep-deprived child with a vendetta.

Their faces went beet red.

They began touching their cheeks, their foreheads, their chins — as if the act of feeling the marker might somehow erase it.

Kyoko groaned. “Nononono... this must be a dream. This can’t be real. I already embarrassed myself yesterday in front of everyone fighting those six witches. Why is this happening to me?! The list of humiliating moments these people have on me just keeps growing!”

Mami, more composed but still deeply flustered, shook her head. “Who did this to us? Right before our special fight? In front of everyone in this arena?”

She paused.

“If this was a prank... it was cruel. And not funny.”

The word hung in the air.

Prank.

They both turned their heads slowly.

There, tiptoeing away with exaggerated stealth, was Kasumi.

Mami’s eyes narrowed into a glare. Her voice turned sweet — dangerously sweet. “Oh Kasumi? Where are you going?”

Kasumi froze mid-step. Her back remained turned, but her shoulders trembled.

Kyoko’s eyes twitched. Her grin was sharp, tinged with fury. “You were the one who decorated our faces, weren’t you?”

Kasumi turned slowly, her body visibly shaking, sweat beading down her forehead. Her voice was small. “Yes... I was the one who decorated your faces. But good luck with your fight!”

And then she bolted.

“Oh no you don’t!” Mami shouted, summoning her ribbons with a flick of her hand.

The enchanted strands shot forward, wrapping around Kasumi’s legs mid-run. She yelped as she was caught, tumbling to the ground in a flurry of limbs and linen.

Mami began dragging her slowly across the grass, ribbons pulling her like a cocooned worm. Kasumi squirmed, wriggling in protest, her voice a mix of panic and theatrical despair.

“Nooo! I’m too young to be punished! I’m innocent! I’m adorable!”

Mami and Kyoko couldn’t help it — they burst into laughter again.

It was déjà vu.

Just yesterday morning, when Mami and Lunaria left Kasumi wrapped in linen like a mummy, “starving” outside the cabin while they enjoyed breakfast. And now here she was again — squirming, dramatic, and utterly ridiculous.

Kyoko wiped a tear from her eye. “This suits her way too well. She looks hilarious. And everyone’s watching. Good payback.”

Mami nodded, still dragging Kasumi forward. “Agreed. Let’s make sure she gets a front-row seat to her own prank.”

The crowd roared with laughter and cheers, the mood brighter than ever.

The laughter in the arena reached a fever pitch.

Spectators clutched their sides, wiped tears from their eyes, and tried — mostly in vain — to form coherent sentences between fits of giggles. Some magical girls leaned against each other, wheezing with delight. A few witches cackled with theatrical flair, their voices echoing like bells. Even the monsters, strange and stoic, emitted rumbling chuckles that shook the flower pods.

Comments floated through the air like confetti.

“Did you see Kyoko’s eyebrows?!”

“Mami’s forehead! What even is that crown?!”

“They had no idea! Oh my god, they’re mortified!”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe were laughing so hard they could barely breathe.

“They didn’t know,” Momoko gasped, wiping her eyes. “They had no idea their faces were decorated before their big fight!”

Mifuyu nodded, her voice trembling with laughter. “They’re probably super embarrassed right now. And it looks like... Kasumi did it?”

Kuroe leaned forward, still giggling. “That’s such a Kasumi move. Funny, but also kind of cruel. Right before a fight in front of everyone?”

Momoko pointed down at the field. “Look at her! Wrapped in ribbons like a squirming caterpillar. She looks hilarious.”

Mifuyu smiled. “Maybe this was her plan all along — to start the fight with a comedic bang.”

Kuroe nodded. “It fits her. Chaotic. Joyful. Unpredictable.”

Down on the grass, Kasumi lay on her back, cocooned in Mami’s ribbons, her limbs twitching slightly as she tried to wriggle free. Her grin was weak, sheepish, but still unmistakably Kasumi.

“So...” she said, voice muffled, “are you two ready for your special fight?”

Kyoko walked forward, her boots crunching softly against the grass. Without a word, she sat down squarely on Kasumi's torso, leaned in, and tugged on both of Kasumi's cheeks with firm, unrelenting fingers.

"Ready?" Kyoko growled, her voice low and furious. "What do you mean ready? How can we be ready like this?! This fight was supposed to be my redemption! After yesterday's panic and horror against those six witches, I was finally going to show everyone I'm not a total disaster!"

She tugged harder, cheeks stretching comically.

"But now," she continued, "they've got even more embarrassing moments to tease me about! Why would you do this to us, Kasumi?!"

Mami stepped forward, arms crossed, her ribbons still taut around Kasumi's legs. "Especially after telling me to live in the moment and enjoy myself. This was supposed to be a special fight — not a public humiliation."

Kasumi's voice was barely audible, squished between Kyoko's fingers. "You... and Lunaria's clone... decorated my clone's face yesterday. So it's only fair..."

Kyoko blinked. "Wait, what?"

Kasumi nodded as best she could. "My clone already got revenge on Lunaria's clone. You two had fun watching them wrestle while my clone decorated her face. The audience saw it. They loved it. Hilarious. Hideous. A disaster."

As if on cue, a few voices rang out from the crowd.

"Kasumi clone's face was legendary!"

"Lunaria clone looked like a cursed fruit salad!"

"We took pics!"

Mami and Kyoko exchanged glances.

Their anger softened.

Kyoko released Kasumi's cheeks and stood up, brushing off her skirt. Mami's ribbons loosened and fell away, fluttering gently to the grass.

Kasumi sat up, rubbing her face, then laughed — warm, unbothered, radiant.

"That's only one reason," she said. "The other — and main — reason is that embarrassment and anger are negative emotions. You can channel them. Use them to empower your attacks. I'm helping you put on a good show."

Mami and Kyoko stared at her.

Then they laughed.

Kyoko shook her head. “You’re such a trickster. Sly as ever.”

Mami smiled. “We appreciate the help. But let’s be honest — you mostly did it to mess with us.”

Kasumi winked. “If you say so.”

Kyoko slammed her fist into her palm, her grin returning. “Well, thanks for the amp. I’ll gladly use this embarrassment and anger to fuel my attacks. I feel sorry for whoever we’re fighting.”

Mami nodded, her soul gem glowing softly. “Same here. Thanks, Kasumi. I’m ready to give them a show.”

The arena shimmered with anticipation.

The arena erupted in cheers and laughter, the sound rising like a wave and washing over the field in radiant joy. The flower pods shimmered with light, petals glowing as spectators clapped, whistled, and shouted their delight. It was no longer just a fight — it was a celebration.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe joined in, laughing hard with the crowd, their voices mingling with the chorus of joy. But beneath the laughter, their hearts were warm. Watching Mami, Kyoko, and Kasumi tease each other so openly — tugging cheeks, trading jabs, and laughing through it all — was more than entertaining. It was moving.

“They’re so close,” Momoko said softly, her smile lingering.

Mifuyu nodded. “They can confront each other in front of everyone without fear. That kind of honesty...”

Kuroe finished the thought. “That kind of bond... it’s what we want for all magical girls.”

A moment later, something caught their eyes.

Dark, shadowy swirls began to dance around Mami’s and Kyoko’s soul gems — faint at first, then more distinct, curling like smoke in moonlight. The girls gasped.

“That’s...” Mifuyu whispered, leaning forward.

“Emotional control,” Momoko said. “Lunaria taught us about it this morning.”

Kuroe’s eyes widened. “It must be the embarrassment and anger they felt earlier. But look — the taint isn’t spreading. It’s contained.”

They watched in awe as the soul gems shimmered with a strange duality — color and shadow intertwined, but not in conflict. The darkness didn’t corrupt. It waited. Stored safely, like a blade sheathed in velvet.

“It’s different from what we’re used to,” Mifuyu murmured. “Usually, when soul gems are tainted, they lose their shine. They get overtaken.”

“But this...” Momoko said, “this is controlled. Ready to be unleashed.”

Kuroe nodded slowly. “It’s beautiful. And powerful.”

Down below, Kasumi twirled dramatically, her ribbons fluttering as she struck a theatrical bow. Her voice rang out through the mic, bright and mischievous.

“And that concludes the introductory act of the show! How did everyone like it?”

The arena burst into applause and cheers. Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe clapped joyfully, their laughter still bubbling.

Mami and Kyoko broke into laughter again, their earlier embarrassment now transformed into lightness. Kasumi’s energy was radiant, infectious — and familiar. They bowed alongside her, their movements graceful and playful.

Kasumi straightened, her eyes gleaming. “But before the main act,” she said, “I’d like to introduce three special guests. Lunaria, would you be so kind?”

Mami and Kyoko’s eyes went wide.

This was just like yesterday — before their “punishment” trial against the six witches. Lunaria had introduced Elira Mizunagi, Sylvette Prothea, and Mirielle Calden, asking them to share their thoughts on Mami and Kyoko’s performance.

So who would it be today?

More magical girls from the mural? Three of the six who became witches? Or... their opponents?

Excitement stirred in their chests.

Lunaria floated forward, her presence serene and luminous. But instead of addressing the crowd directly, she drifted toward one of the flower pods — the one holding Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe.

The three girls sat up straighter, surprised.

“These,” Lunaria said, her voice clear and warm, “are magical girls from Kamihama. They arrived in this realm today. Everyone, please give them a warm welcome.”

The arena clapped and cheered, the energy rising again in waves of welcome.

Kyoko grinned, her eyes gleaming. “Magical girls from Kamihama, huh? That’s exciting. I’ve heard the witches there are tough. You must be strong.”

She cracked her knuckles. “Now I’m even more fired up to show you how we fight in Mitakihara.”

Mami’s reaction was different.

Her eyes widened. Her mouth parted in quiet surprise.

She recognized one of them — Kuroe. A magical girl Kasumi had mentioned meeting two days ago while exploring Kamihama. But the other two — Momoko and Mifuyu — were strangers to her.

She turned toward Kasumi, hope blooming in her chest.

“Kasumi...” she said, voice trembling slightly. “So you and Lunaria did find another way to save Sayaka? One that doesn’t require me to learn dis-connect? These girls... they can help? They know something?”

Kasumi didn’t answer.

She simply smiled — warm, radiant, and full of light.

Mami stared at her, heart pounding.

And then she understood.

She brought her hands to her heart, eyes shimmering.

“Thank you,” she whispered.

She felt lighter. Unburdened. Ready.

She turned toward Kyoko, her soul gem glowing.

“I’m ready. Lets do it!”

Kyoko grinned. “Let’s make it unforgettable!”

Lunaria hovered gracefully in the air, her presence calm and luminous. The laughter from the prank had faded into a gentle hum of anticipation, and now the arena waited — not for spectacle, but for connection.

She turned toward the flower pod where Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe sat, her voice clear and kind.

“Before the main act begins,” she said, “I’d like to ask our guests to introduce themselves. Tell us who you are — and share your thoughts. What do you think Mami and Kyoko’s very first Connect will look like?”

The crowd quieted, leaning in.

Momoko sat up straighter, her eyes bright. She gave a small wave, then spoke with her usual warmth and energy.

“I’m Momoko Togame,” she said, her voice ringing with cheer. “I’m from Kamihama, and I’ve been through a lot with my team — battles, losses, victories, and everything in between. Connect’s been a lifeline for us. It’s not just a technique — it’s a promise. That we’re not alone.”

She looked down at Mami and Kyoko, her smile widening.

“I think their first Connect will be messy,” she said with a laugh. “But beautiful. Like two stars crashing into each other and finding rhythm in the chaos. They’ve got history. They’ve got heart. And they’ve got fire.”

She raised her hand and gave them a big thumbs-up, her grin radiant.

“You’ve got this,” she called out. “Show us what Mitakihara girls can do!”

Mami and Kyoko looked up, startled — then smiled.

Kyoko gave a small salute, her grin crooked and fierce.

Mami placed a hand over her heart, her eyes shimmering with gratitude.

Then Lunaria turned to Mifuyu.

Mifuyu’s posture was elegant, her voice soft and composed.

“I’m Mifuyu Azusa,” she said. “Also from Kamihama. I’ve seen Connect mend broken teams, heal old wounds, and turn despair into strength. It’s not just about magic — it’s about trust.”

She glanced down at Mami and Kyoko, her expression thoughtful.

“I think their first Connect will be hesitant,” she said. “But honest. They’ll stumble. They’ll doubt. But they’ll find each other. And when they do... it’ll be powerful.”

She closed both eyes and gave them a gentle smile — serene, full of quiet encouragement.

Mami’s breath caught.

Kyoko blinked, then nodded slowly, her expression softening.

And finally, Lunaria turned to Kuroe.

Kuroe shifted slightly, her voice quiet but steady.

“I’m Kuroe,” she said. “I’ve seen what happens when magical girls lose connection — with others, with themselves. I’ve lived it. So I know how much it matters.”

She looked down at Mami and Kyoko, her gaze steady.

“I think their first Connect will be raw. Maybe even painful. But it’ll be real. And that’s what makes it strong.”

She raised her voice just a little.

“Good luck,” she said. “I’ll be cheering you on.”

Mami and Kyoko looked up.

Kyoko gave a small, fierce grin. “Thanks, Kamihama.”

Mami nodded, her heart full. “We’ll do our best.”

The arena shimmered with quiet energy.

And somewhere in the center of it all, the first Connect waited to be born.

Lunaria floated gently back toward the flower pod, her expression serene. “Thank you,” she said, her voice soft but resonant, “to all three of you for your introductions and your heartfelt thoughts.”

She turned to Kasumi, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe, and gave them a warm smile — one that held both pride and affection — before settling beside them, her presence like moonlight joining a quiet stream.

The girls barely had time to breathe before new voices reached them.

“You’re magical girls from Kamihama, right?” one voice called, bright and welcoming. “Welcome to this realm.”

Another chimed in, “We’re glad you’re here.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe turned toward the voices — and gasped.

Four figures were flying toward them, their silhouettes radiant against the golden sky. As they drew closer, their forms became clear.

Elira Mizunagi was the first to land, her small frame light as a feather. Her curly silver hair shimmered faintly in the sunlight, and her wide amber eyes sparkled with curiosity and mischief. She wore a pale blue cloak embroidered with tiny stars, and though her floating companions — the squirrel, the hummingbird, the sleepy fox — were absent today, her presence still felt like a sanctuary. Her soul gem glowed softly at her collarbone, nestled in a silver clasp.

Sylvette Prothea followed, her lean figure graceful and grounded. Her hair, silver at the roots and fading into deep violet tips, was tied back loosely, and her amber eyes flickered with playful intelligence. In her human form, her outfit was simpler — a fitted jacket and dark trousers — but her soul gem gleamed at her wrist, embedded in a shifting bracelet that pulsed with quiet magic.

Mirielle Calden landed next, her coral pink braids catching the light. Her mint green eyes were wide and curious, and her layered tunic — now more subdued — still shimmered with flecks of glass and clay. Her soul gem rested at her waist, tucked into a belt of woven threads and metal strands, like a charm she’d always worn.

And then came the fourth girl.

She was different.

Her form was humanoid, but her presence was unmistakably otherworldly. Her skin was a soft, luminous gray — pale like the moon’s surface, as if carved from starlight and shadow. Her long black hair flowed behind her like ink suspended in water, weightless and ever-shifting. Her eyes were deep pools of layered light — not bound to a single color, but a slow, mesmerizing swirl of hues that shimmered and echoed with impossible depth, like galaxies glimpsed through a veil.

She wore a sleeveless tunic of shadowy fabric that moved like a dark mist, its edges dissolving and reforming with each breath she took. A belt of silver thread cinched it at the waist, glinting faintly with each motion. Unlike the others, there was no soul gem visible on her body — no crystalline core, no

magical emblem. She bore no mark of contract, no tether to Kyubey's system. She was something else entirely.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe stared, stunned.

All four girls landed gracefully beside them, their expressions warm and open.

"Welcome," Elira said, her voice gentle.

"We're glad you're here," Sylvette added.

Mirielle smiled. "It's good to meet you."

The three Kamihama girls smiled in return, hearts full.

"We saw your story," Momoko said softly. "Lunaria gave us a dream yesterday."

Mifuyu nodded. "The execution of your families... your friends becoming witches... the battle against the shadow monster..."

Kuroe's voice was quiet. "It was tragic. And beautiful."

Elira's smile deepened. "We're glad it meant something to you."

Sylvette's gaze softened. "It's part of who we are."

Mirielle leaned forward. "And now you're part of this realm too."

Then Momoko turned to the fourth girl, her voice tentative.

"Who are you?"

Elira, Sylvette, and Mirielle all grinned.

The fourth girl smiled — and spoke. "Well met, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe."

Her voice was layered, harmonized, as if many voices were speaking together in perfect unity. It reverberated gently through the air as she spoke.

Momoko's breath caught.

Mifuyu's eyes widened.

Kuroe's hand flew to her mouth.

"That voice..." Momoko whispered. "It sounds familiar. From the dream..."

She hesitated, then asked, her voice trembling, "Are you... the shadow monster?"

Elira, Sylvette, and Mirielle burst into laughter — not mocking, but joyful.

The fourth girl chuckled, her voice echoing like a chorus. "Yes," she said. "I am the shadow monster."

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe were stunned.

Speechless.

This was the being who had corrupted soul gems, turned magical girls into witches, consumed despair like firewood. The one responsible for the deaths of Elira, Sylvette, and Mirielle.

And yet — here she was.

Sitting beside them.

Smiling.

Elira spoke first, her voice cheerful and innocent. “We may have fought in the past. But here, everyone is a friend!”

Sylvette nodded. “She caused us and our friends pain. She killed us. But in this realm... we live together. We support each other. We spar. We grow.”

Mirielle’s voice was bright, full of wonder. “She’s helped countless people here. More than you’d believe.”

Momoko turned to the shadow monster, her voice barely a whisper. “How?”

Mifuyu leaned in. “How can you help people?”

Kuroe’s eyes were wide. “After everything you did...”

The shadow monster chuckled, her many-layered voice warm and resonant. “I’m the one who makes emotional control training possible in this realm.”

She gestured toward the arena, its vast expanse shimmering with latent magic. “This place can replicate my abilities. It can seed corruption in anyone’s emotions — twisting a magical girl’s Soul Gem, or stirring despair in other beings. Humans, familiars, even witches and summoned spirits. All of it is controlled. Not meant to shatter you, but to strengthen you. To teach you how to hold your ground in the storm. To harness negativity, not be consumed by it.”

She winked. “Pretty cool, right? And if you want, you can fight me too. Mami’s fought me twice since she arrived three days ago.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe gasped, hands flying to their mouths.

It was incredible.

Unbelievable.

The shadow monster — the terrifying entity from their dream, the one who had corrupted and consumed — was now helping people build resilience. That the same force which once brought death could now offer strength.

And she was friends with Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle... and countless others.

The shadow monster laughed, warm and from the heart. “Your reaction makes perfect sense. Everyone reacts this way. Especially after seeing the simulation in the beginner Connect training — the one Mami and Kyoko did in your dream. A 180-degree shift like this is... a lot.”

She smiled, then winked — a gesture that shimmered with layered light. “You can call me by name, if you’d like. I am **Umbra Ambraciell**.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe chuckled, the tension melting away like mist in sunlight.

“Nice to meet you, Umbra,” Momoko said, her voice bright and sincere.

“Glad you’re here. We hope to learn from you,” Mifuyu added, her tone gentle and composed.

“We’ll be cheering you on too,” Kuroe said, her smile quiet but genuine.

Umbra’s many-layered voice softened into something almost playful. “And I’ll be cheering for you. I hope we get to fight soon.”

The girls blinked, surprised — then smiled.

Momoko leaned forward, eyes sparkling. “You want to spar with us?”

Mifuyu tilted her head, intrigued. “That would be... intense.”

Kuroe gave a small laugh. “I think I’d be terrified. But also honored.”

Umbra chuckled, the sound echoing like laughter in a canyon. “Don’t worry. You can fight here without any lasting consequences. It will be fun.”

She gave them a wink — a gesture that somehow felt like a promise.

Lunaria watched from beside them, her expression warm and full of quiet pride.

In this realm, even shadows could offer light.

Even monsters could become mentors.

Even despair could become strength.

And the story was only just beginning.

From the center of the arena, Mami and Kyoko watched as four figures glided through the air, their silhouettes framed by the golden sky. Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle — and the fourth girl, the one cloaked in shadow and silver thread — descended toward the flower pod where Lunaria, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe sat.

The four landed gracefully, greeted with smiles and laughter. The pod shimmered faintly with magic, a quiet gathering of old souls and new.

Kyoko grinned, hands on her hips. “Looks like those three magical girls — and the shadow monster herself, **Umbra Ambraciel** — are gonna be watching our fight with the Kamihama girls. They’ll keep good company.”

Mami turned to her, eyes wide. “That girl... she’s the shadow monster?”

Kyoko nodded, still smiling.

“Her name is Umbra?” Mami asked, stunned. “But... when I fought her in this arena, she didn’t have a form. Just shadows. And in the simulation — when the four magical girls and the two magical girls without soul gems fought her — she was this... shifting mass. A force. I didn’t even know she had a humanoid shape.”

Kyoko let out a heartfelt laugh. “There’s a lot more to her than you think. You just haven’t seen the real her fight yet.”

She gave Mami a wink. “In this realm, everyone’s friendly. We support each other, help each other grow. Sparring’s just another way of saying ‘I believe in you.’”

Mami looked back toward the pod, her gaze lingering on Umbra’s pale, moonlit form. The same being she had fought — twice — in desperate, one-sided matches. The same entity she had seen in the simulation, consuming despair, turning magical girls into witches.

And now... she was sitting beside the very girls she had once killed. Laughing with them. Watching over others.

Mami’s heart stirred.

So that terrifying monster... was the reason she had learned emotional control. It was Umbra’s abilities that allowed her to train in this arena — to feel despair without drowning in it. To harness it. To grow.

She saw Umbra in a completely different light now.

“I want to talk to her,” Mami murmured. “And fight her again. When I’m stronger.”

Kyoko gave her a sideways glance and smirked. “You’ll get your chance.”

Just then, a chorus of cheerful voices rang out from above.

“We’re done with introductions!” Elira called.

“Kasumi, you can start the main act!” Sylvette added.

“We’re ready!” Mirielle chimed in.

Umbra’s voice followed, layered and bright. “Let the show begin!”

Mami and Kyoko turned toward Kasumi, who was already grinning from ear to ear, mic in hand, her energy rising like the sun.

The arena shimmered with anticipation.

The main act was about to begin.

Chapter 4: The Special fight – the special opponent

Kasumi stepped forward, her voice ringing out across the arena with theatrical flair.

“Thank you, thank you!” she said, sweeping into a dramatic bow. “To Lunaria, Momoko, Mifuyu, Kuroe, Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, and Umbra — thank you for your beautiful introductions and radiant energy. You’ve set the stage perfectly.”

She straightened, her eyes locking onto Mami and Kyoko below. Her expression shifted — still bright, but now sharpened with fire and mischief.

“And now,” she said, her voice dropping into a mock-dramatic tone, “Mami. Kyoko. Are you ready to fight using Connect for the very first time... against a very *special* opponent prepared by yours truly?”

She drew out the word *special* with ominous glee, her grin widening.

Mami smiled, her soul gem glowing softly. “Yes,” she said, her voice calm but electric. “I’m ready to go wild and have fun.”

With a flourish, she summoned a dozen muskets in a radiant arc behind her, their barrels gleaming in the light. Her ribbons unfurled like banners, coiling and snapping with anticipation.

“I’m excited to see what new abilities Connect will give me,” she added. “Especially with Kyoko.”

Kyoko cracked her knuckles, her grin sharp and eager. “Bring it on. I’m ready to Connect with Mami and blow the minds of everyone watching.”

Kasumi’s gaze shifted to Kyoko, her eyes glimmering with mischief. She tilted her head, her smile radiant and sly.

“And there it is,” she said. “That big confidence you had yesterday too. The confidence that you and Mami would put on a good show when you finally used Connect.”

She leaned forward slightly. “Do you remember what my clone told you yesterday?”

Kyoko grinned, her stance firm, her energy rising. “Yeah, I remember.”

She pointed at Kasumi, her voice full of fire. “She said you might prepare a nasty fight for us. Something *extra spicy*. Something that would make the picture of me and Mami screaming and holding hands look *graceful*.”

She slammed a fist into her palm, the sound echoing like a drumbeat.

“But you already embarrassed us in front of the whole arena by decorating our faces,” she said, laughing. “So I’m *pumped* to use that embarrassment — and the anger — against whatever you’ve cooked up.”

She leaned forward, eyes gleaming. “So tell me, Kasumi. Who’s the *special* opponent?”

She mimicked Kasumi’s tone, drawing out the word with exaggerated flair.

“Is it the **same versions** of the six witches we fought yesterday? Because if it is —” she glanced at Mami, who gave a nod — “we can take them. No problem.”

Kasumi didn’t answer.

She just kept smiling — that same radiant, mischievous smile — her eyes locked on Kyoko’s.

Kyoko’s grin faltered slightly.

“...It’s not the witches, is it?” she said, her voice quieter now.

She hesitated, “... Is it Umbra?”

Her voice dipped further, tinged with uncertainty.

“I mean... we could probably handle her base level. Probably. But if she amps up even a notch...”

Kyoko exhaled sharply, cutting herself off before the doubt could settle. She straightened, forcing that familiar smirk back onto her face.

“Doesn’t matter. Even if we get wrecked, we’re gonna make it a damn good show. Something people won’t forget.”

The crowd murmured with anticipation, the energy in the arena rising like a tide.

Kasumi’s smile didn’t waver.

She said nothing.

Her eyes remained locked on Kyoko’s, glimmering with mischief, her radiant grin frozen in place — too radiant, too still.

And slowly, the silence, the stare, and the smile began to unsettle Kyoko.

Her confidence didn’t vanish, but it faltered — just slightly. Enough for the crowd to feel the shift. Enough for Mami to glance sideways, sensing the change.

Kasumi’s energy hadn’t dimmed.

But something was coming.

Something *special*.

Up in the flower pod, Momoko tilted her head, curiosity sparking in her eyes.

“Kyoko said something about Umbra’s base level and scaling up,” she murmured. “What does that mean?”

Mifuyu leaned forward. “Is there more than one version of Umbra?”

Kuroe nodded slowly. “Like... difficulty settings?”

Umbra smiled, her layered voice soft and luminous. “My base level is what you saw in the simulation — the battle between me and Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, Hoshine, and the two girls without soul gems.”

She paused, her gaze drifting toward the arena below.

“But since I was saved in this realm,” she continued, “I’ve trained. Learned. Grown. Just like Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, and many others who were brought here. We’ve all become much stronger.”

Her eyes glimmered. “If Mami and Kyoko fought me as I was in the simulation, they’d do very well. But if they fought me as I am now...”

She smiled gently. “They wouldn’t stand a chance.”

Lunaria nodded, her voice calm and clear. “Umbra is one of the most powerful battle opponents you can summon in the arena. She’s a perfect challenge if you want to push every aspect of your fighting technique — power, durability, speed, emotional control, magical control.”

She turned to the Kamihama girls. “When you summon opponents, you can choose the difficulty. Scale down or up as needed. It’s a great way to make steady progress and measure growth.”

She gestured toward the field. “The Kyoko down there is much stronger than her real self at that point in her life. She’s been scaled up for this fight.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe gasped in unison.

“That’s incredible,” Momoko said. “This arena is amazing.”

Mifuyu’s eyes sparkled. “We can fight anyone? At any level?”

Kuroe grinned. “I want to try everything.”

Mirielle chuckled, her voice light. “I love your energy. But start with the fundamentals. The arena has tutorials and drills — they’re worth doing before you jump into fights.”

Sylvette nodded. “Try an easier fight first. See your base level. Then pick a topic you’re interested in — emotional control, magical precision, movement, specific skills related to each of your unique abilities. Learn the fundamentals. Once you’re proficient, test yourself.”

Elira beamed. “Slow and steady wins the race. I’m excited to see how you grow.”

Umbra chuckled. “And once you’re ready, you can fight any of us. Anytime.”

She leaned in slightly, her voice playful. “Another feature of the arena — you can opt to have your memories of your opponent temporarily wiped. That way, the fight is fair, organic, and exciting. After the battle, your memories return, so you can reflect and measure your growth.”

She winked. “Pretty cool, right?”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe laughed, stunned and delighted.

“This is unbelievable,” Momoko said.

Mifuyu nodded. “We’re going to have a great time here. We’ll develop the abilities we need to help our friends — in Kamihama and beyond.”

Kuroe smiled. “The people who created this realm... they’re amazing.”

Mifuyu turned to Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, and Umbra. “Do you know who created this realm? Or how you were saved in this arena?”

The four looked at each other, then at the Kamihama girls.

Elira spoke first, her voice gentle. “We were saved in this arena a long time ago. As you can guess... the story in the mural is ancient.”

Sylvette’s gaze softened. “As for how we were saved... and who created this realm...”

They all looked up into the sky.

Their expressions grew distant. Reverent.

“We cannot say,” Mirielle whispered.

Their words hung in the air, ambiguous and elusive.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe turned to Lunaria, hopeful.

But Lunaria simply smiled — warm, radiant, and silent.

The three Kamihama girls exchanged glances, then spoke telepathically.

They only answered when they were saved. Not how.

And their answer about who created this realm... ‘we cannot say.’

Do they not know? Or do they know and won’t tell us yet?

More mysteries. More questions.

We’ll find the truth one day.

The arena shimmered around them, full of light, shadow, and possibility.

And the story continued to unfold.

Kyoko was starting to sweat.

Kasumi hadn’t moved. Her radiant smile remained frozen in place, her eyes locked on Kyoko’s with that same glimmering mischief. The silence stretched, and Kyoko’s confidence began to crack.

She glanced up at Umbra, hoping for confirmation — or escape.

Umbra laughed, her many-layered voice echoing across the arena. “Oh no, I’m not your *special* opponent,” she said, emphasizing the word with playful exaggeration. “Kasumi prepared someone else.”

Kyoko’s mind began to race.

Mami noticed the shift immediately. Kyoko’s posture had changed — no longer bold and cocky, but tense, searching. Her eyes darted, her brow furrowed. She was thinking hard.

Who could it be? Mami wondered. Kyoko had interacted with many beings saved in this realm — beings far stronger than anything Mami had faced. If Kyoko was this uneasy, the opponent must be terrifying.

Kyoko turned back to Kasumi, her voice tightening with caution.

“...So it’s the Advanced Witch, then? The Forgotten Queen?”

A ripple of murmurs passed through the crowd at the name, and Kyoko’s jaw shifted, just slightly.

“If that’s who we’re up against,” she went on, “then yeah—same deal as Umbra. We’re not walking out with a win.”

She lifted her chin, forcing a crooked smile that didn’t quite reach her eyes.

“But we’ll give everyone something worth watching. That much I can promise.”

Mami’s eyes went wide.

The Forgotten Queen

She remembered seeing the name on her first day here—another one of the highest-ranked opponents.

She’d never fought her — only read the description.

A witch of memory and silence, whose magic distorted time, manipulated memories, and could erase magic itself.

Mami had always wanted to face her... someday... When she got stronger.

Before she could ask more, a melodic, cheerful voice rang out across the arena.

“Nope! I’m not your *special* opponent either! Keep guessing!”

Mami looked up and gasped.

The witch hovered above the arena, smiling brightly.

She looked... human. Not monstrous. Her skin was porcelain pale, her eyes a soft lavender, and her hair a cascade of golden curls that shimmered like sunlight on water. Sparkles of light particles flowed around her, drifting like pollen in spring air.

She wore a flowing dress of layered silk and feathers, its colors shifting subtly with each movement — moonlight, frost, and dusk woven together. At her chest, something pulsed gently: a gem-like glow, soft and rhythmic. It looked like a soul gem... but Mami couldn't be sure.

Was she truly a witch?

Or a sorceress so powerful that the title had simply clung to her?

She looked like a dream — not a nightmare.

Kyoko didn't even glance up.

She was deep in thought now, her expression growing more and more uncomfortable. Kasumi hadn't blinked. Her stare, her smile — unchanged. Unrelenting.

Then Kyoko's eyes went wide.

She froze.

And then — she broke.

She burst into laughter. Not the confident kind. Not the cocky kind. It was the desperate laugh of someone who had just realized what they'd walked into. The laugh of someone who knew they were doomed.

Mami turned to her, voice shaky. "Did you figure it out?"

Kyoko shouted, "Oooooohhhhhhh noooooooooooooooooohohohoho!"

Her voice broke, wobbling between dread and disbelief.

Mami's heart dropped. That wasn't Kyoko's normal bravado.

Then Kyoko screamed, "AAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHH!"

The entire arena erupted in laughter. Spectators clutched their sides, witches howled, magical girls doubled over. They knew. Kyoko had figured it out. And her reaction was *perfect*.

Mami reached out, alarmed. "Kyoko? Are you okay? What's wrong?"

Kyoko tried to speak through another ragged laugh. "Are you kidding me?! Noooooohohohohoho!"

Mami grabbed her arm. "Please, Kyoko. Speak to me. Who are we fighting? Why are you acting like it's already over?"

Kyoko turned toward her—eyes wide, filled with dramatic despair.

"AAHHHHHHHH we have to fight *KASUMIIIIIIIIIIII!*"

Mami froze.

Her mouth opened wide.

Her voice came out in a whisper. "Kasumi? Right now?"

She swallowed. “That’s bad. That’s very bad.”

She remembered Kasumi’s fight against Umbra — how Kasumi had become, in Mami’s own words, a *deranged fiery freak of nature*. She remembered the chaos, the overwhelming intensity, the sheer unpredictability.

She’d fought Lunaria once. She couldn’t land a single hit. It was a one-sided slaughter.

And Kasumi and Lunaria both claimed they could beat each other.

If that was true...

Even with Connect...

They were doomed.

The arena burst into cheers and laughter.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe laughed along, but their curiosity was piqued.

“Why did Kyoko react like that?” Mifuyu asked, still giggling.

“She and Mami must know something we don’t,” Kuroe said.

Mifuyu nodded. “We saw Lunaria fight Ichizo. She moved with such ease, such grace. She’s stronger than anyone I’ve ever seen.”

Momoko turned to Lunaria. “Does Kasumi fight like you? Are you two evenly matched?”

Lunaria smiled — mischievous, radiant — and said nothing.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe turned to Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, and Umbra.

All four smiled back — just as mischievous.

No answers.

Just grins.

The Kamihama girls broke down laughing.

“Okay,” Momoko said, wiping her eyes. “From those reactions, it’s official. Mami and Kyoko are in *big* trouble.”

“This is going to be awesome,” Kuroe added.

The crowd leaned forward.

The arena shimmered.

And the fight was about to begin.

Chapter 4a: Mami vs Kasumi – part 1

Kasumi finally moved, breaking the tension with a low, sweeping bow toward Mami and Kyoko. When she spoke, her voice was bright, clear, and utterly thrilled.

“Bingo!” she cheered, snapping upright with a dazzling grin. “You’ll be fighting *yours truly*~”

“Welcome toooooo” Kasumi shouted, her voice echoing with theatrical grandeur, “***The Crimson Ribbon Overture: A Soul-Shattering Symphony of Blood, Chaos, and Destruction!***”

Her grin widening as she turned to Mami. “I was hoping you’d figure it out,” she teased. “Especially after I said I was eating all that food for breakfast to prepare for the *special* fight.”

Mami chuckled weakly, her voice trembling. “I assumed you meant you were preparing to be the energetic host again... like during our special trial punishment yesterday.”

She wiped a bead of sweat from her brow. “You know — the one where you got the crowd fired up while we were being humiliated.”

Kasumi laughed. “A reasonable assumption.”

She leaned in slightly. “But you assumed wrong.”

Mami laughed again — weaker this time. Her body trembled, sweat dripping down her face in slow, steady beads.

Kyoko was faring worse.

Her legs wobbled beneath her, and she was only managing to stay upright by leaning heavily on her spear. Her hands shook as she gripped it. Her gaze was locked on the ground, breath short, sweat pouring down her cheeks. Her eyes were wide — not with fear, but with the dawning realization of what was about to happen.

Kasumi smiled at both of them, her laughter light and infectious. “Where’s that bravado you had earlier?” she teased. “When you found out I was the one who decorated your faces? When you so boldly tied me up with ribbons, dragged me across the ground, and tugged at my poor cheeks like I was some kind of plush toy?”

Kyoko slowly looked up, her voice low and honest. “I usually love sparring with you, Kasumi. But today’s different. I’m trying to redeem myself in front of the crowd... not give ’em front-row seats to our funeral.”

Kasumi laughed — bright, cheerful, and full of life. “Then let loose and have fun! Try your best. Let’s make it a show to remember.”

Mami turned to Kyoko, her expression thoughtful. “I have a request.”

Kyoko blinked. “What is it?”

Mami took a breath. “I fought Lunaria once. After I was ‘killed’ by Charlotte. I couldn’t land a single hit. It was a complete slaughter.”

She looked down at her hands. “I’ve grown stronger since then — these past three days have changed me. But even now, I don’t think I could touch Lunaria.”

She turned to Kasumi, her gaze steady. “But when I watched you fight Umbra... your style was completely different from Lunaria’s.”

She paused, searching for the right words.

“Lunaria is fast. Elegant. Powerful. Everything about her movement is graceful. She doesn’t just fight — she dances. She dodges, parries, strikes with perfect efficiency. It’s truly... beautiful. Like watching a storm that knows exactly where it’s going.”

She turned back to Kasumi, her expression shifting — part admiration, part disbelief.

“But you... you start out flailing around with what looks like total nonsense. Wild swings, weird footwork, shouting things that don’t even make sense. And then somehow — somehow — you turn into this deranged, fiery freak of nature who beats a monster into the ground with sheer insanity and brute force. With your *battle-lust*.”

She gave a shaky laugh. “It’s like watching a fireworks show that accidentally sets the forest on fire... but somehow ends with the crowd cheering.

Kasumi beamed. “That’s the nicest thing anyone’s said to me today!”

Mami smiled faintly. “I want to see what it’s like to fight you. One-on-one. Watching someone fight is different than actually facing them. Just like how I finally appreciated Lunaria’s beauty when I watched her fight Umbra — not when I was the one being crushed.”

She turned back to Kyoko. “You’ve sparred with Kasumi before, right? That’s why you reacted so strongly.”

Kyoko nodded slowly.

Mami continued, “Let me spar with her first. Get a feel for her style. Then we’ll team up. Use Connect. Fight her together.”

Kyoko stared at her — then broke into a warm, heartfelt laugh.

Kyoko strode up to Mami and held out a fist, chin tilted in that familiar, cocky angle.

“If you really wanna take that flaming monstrosity solo,” she said, smirking, “be my guest. Knock yourself out.”

Kuroe winked, “Just... y’know. Try not to fold in the first minute, ‘kay?”

Mami smiled and tapped her knuckles against Kyoko’s. “Thank you, Kyoko. I’ll do my best.”

Kasumi smiled playfully. “That’s a great idea! I’m curious what you’ll think of my style when you’re the one facing it.”

Mami smirked playfully. “And once I get a feel for how you fight, maybe I can answer your question about who I think won the fight — you or Lunaria — with more confidence.”

Kasumi’s eyes sparkled as she planted her hands on her hips, standing tall with theatrical confidence. “Yes! You’ll finally realize that my *battle-lust* prevails over her graceful movements!”

Up in the flower pod, Lunaria chuckled — a soft, melodic sound that carried a calm but unmistakable intensity. “I’m quite certain Mami will recognize that my graceful and precise movements win over your chaos, Kasumi.”

The arena rippled with laughter.

Their rivalry was legendary — not bitter, but spirited. A clash of philosophies. Fire and moonlight. Chaos and control.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe laughed throughout the banter.

“Wow,” Momoko said between giggles. “The way Mami described Kasumi’s fighting style — ‘a deranged, fiery freak of nature.’ ‘Sheer insanity and brute force.’ ‘Battle-lust.’ I cannot even begin to imagine what that’s like.”

“She sounds very different from Lunaria,” Kuroe added, eyes glistening. “Both in personality and fighting style. What an interesting dynamic.”

“Even so,” Mifuyu said thoughtfully, “they seem to be very close friends. Although... I wonder who would actually win in a fight.”

Momoko grinned. “I don’t know, but I bet it would be a true spectacle. Something legendary.”

Kuroe and Mifuyu both smiled and nodded. It was a fight they all hoped to see one day.

With a burst of energy, Kyoko leapt up to the flower pod, landing beside Momoko, Mifuyu, Kuroe, Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, Umbra, and Lunaria.

“Hey!” she called out, grinning.

They all greeted her with smiles and waves.

Momoko leaned forward, smiling as she replayed the moment in her head. “Kyoko,” she said between soft chuckles, “why did you react so strongly when you realized you’d be fighting Kasumi? We’ve never seen anyone freak out like that. It was so raw... and honestly kind of hilarious.”

Kyoko laughed, rubbing the back of her neck. “Yeah, yeah, I know I looked ridiculous,” she muttered, cheeks a little pink. “But just watch Mami.”

She jabbed a thumb toward the arena, smirking. “You’ll understand *real* soon.”

Kuroe, Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, Umbra, and Lunaria all chuckled, nodding in agreement.

They knew.

They'd seen it before.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe giggled, their eyes wide with childlike excitement.

They leaned forward, eyes locked on the arena.

The fight was about to begin.

And Mami was about to learn what it meant to face the storm.

Kasumi grinned at Mami, her eyes blazing with energy, her stance loose and springy like a coiled flame.

“Ready or not,” she called out, voice bright and wild, “here I come!”

Mami braced for battle.

Dozens of muskets hovered around her in a slow, deliberate orbit — like satellites waiting for command. Her ribbons unfurled with a whisper, curling through the air like golden serpents, poised to strike or shield at a moment's notice.

“Bring it!” she said.

But even as the words left her mouth, her mind was spinning. Her heart pounded against her ribs like a war drum.

Her mind replayed what she had seen before.

Kasumi's fight with Umbra.

The opening moments had been... ridiculous.

Kasumi had thrown out simple, almost clumsy attacks — awkward punches, dramatic chops, exaggerated kicks — each one accompanied by an enthusiastic shout:

“BAM!”

“WHACK!”

“SUPER MEGA CHOP!”

None of it worked. Umbra hadn't even blinked.

Mami had watched from the sidelines, bewildered, wondering if Kasumi was simply messing around. Even now, she still wasn't sure.

But then Umbra had retaliated. Brutally. Relentlessly.

Kasumi had been torn apart — her clothes shredded, her body covered in cuts, bruises, and blood. She looked like she'd been dragged through hell.

And just when Mami thought she'd collapse...

Kasumi smiled.

Not a gentle smile. Not a brave one.

A *deranged* smile. Eyes wide, burning with something primal. Something terrifying.

Then she'd exploded into motion — raw, fiery, unstoppable. Kasumi had dismantled Umbra with only two devastating blows, her movements wild and unpredictable, her battle cries sounded half-mad and half-divine.

Later, Kasumi had explained it.

The deeper she fell into the heat of battle — the pain, the anger, the thrill — the stronger her *battle-lust* burned. And the stronger it burned, the stronger she became.

Mami swallowed hard.

She expected the same pattern now.

Kasumi would play first — teasing, provoking, laughing.

But once the battle's heat touched her, she would change.

Her fire would rise.

Her instincts would sharpen.

And she would become dangerous.

Truly dangerous.

A bead of sweat slipped down Mami's cheek.

How should I approach this?

Do I match her pace? Keep my distance? Strike quickly before the flames catch? Or... do I endure it?

Let her burn... and try to weather the blaze?

Her fingers curled tightly. Doubt tugged at the edges of her thoughts, mingling with fear and determination.

In the stands, the crowd leaned forward, collective breath held.

Kasumi bounced lightly on her heels, smiling with the innocent delight of someone about to open a forbidden gift.

The moment before the first move stretched thin.

And the battle was only seconds away.

Kasumi took a single step forward.

It was light. Easy. Almost playful — the kind of movement that didn't belong in a battlefield at all. Her bright smile never wavered.

Mami winced.

Her body tightened in an instant, every muscle drawn taut like a thread pulled too hard. Muskets floated around her in precise formation, shifting as if responding to the tension in her heartbeat. Her ribbons curled closer, ready to snap into motion.

She watched Kasumi with unwavering focus.

Here it comes, she thought.

The wild swings. The exaggerated poses. The nonsensical bravado Kasumi was known for.

But Kasumi didn't rush.

She didn't raise her voice.

She just kept walking — slowly, calmly — as though she were strolling through a quiet garden path. Her hands swung gently at her sides. Her smile stayed bright and unchanging.

Mami's breath caught in her throat.

Her stance didn't break, but something beneath it began to shift. A small seed of unease. A wrongness she couldn't name.

What is she doing?

Is she waiting for me?

Is this... a trap?

Each of Kasumi's steps echoed in Mami's chest more than in the arena. Her heartbeat drowned out the murmurs of the crowd. Her vision narrowed. A thin line of sweat trailed down her neck — cold, trembling.

She didn't understand.

And that alone was frightening.

Up in the flower-shaped spectator pod, Kyoko let out a soft, knowing laugh.

"Oh boy," she murmured. "So that's the angle she's going for."

Momoko blinked. "What angle? She's not even attacking."

Mifuyu leaned forward, brows drawing together. "She's only walking... She isn't projecting anything. No magic. No pressure."

Kuroe tilted her head, voice barely above a whisper. "She looks like she's out for a morning stroll..."

Kasumi's posture remained perfectly relaxed. No tension. No hostility. Just a bright, buoyant smile — as if greeting a friend rather than facing an opponent.

But Mami...

Mami looked as though she were gazing into the mouth of a labyrinth.

The contrast struck like a distant bell — soft, but impossible to ignore.

Momoko exhaled shakily. "Why is Mami reacting like this? She looks like she's facing a witch."

Mifuyu nodded, eyes narrowing in thought. "That kind of pressure... I've only seen it when someone believes the enemy is far beyond them. When their heart begins to distort under the weight."

"But there's no pressure at all," Kuroe murmured. "No aura. No spell. Just Kasumi, being... Kasumi."

Then the realization hit.

Mami's Soul Gem — once bright, steady, warm — now carried a faint, trembling cloudiness. Darkness swirled inside it like ink dropped into clear water.

All three girls gasped.

"Mami's Soul Gem... already tainted?" Momoko whispered.

"She hasn't even been struck," Mifuyu said, her voice soft with disbelief.

"Is this... Kasumi's plan?" Kuroe asked, almost breathless.

Kyoko's smirk disappeared, replaced by something quieter. More serious.

"She's rattled," Kyoko said. "Kasumi's fights never have a rhythm. You can't read her. Can't predict her. It's like waiting for lightning that never shows where it'll hit."

They watched silently as Mami stood frozen in place, her muskets trembling in the air beside her.

The battle hadn't even begun.

And yet the storm had already taken root inside her.

Umbra let out a low, velvety chuckle.

The other three turned toward her in surprise.

Umbra's eyes glinted with amusement. "You're all confused," she said gently. "I can see it."

She leaned forward, resting her chin on her hand. "My ability is simple. I corrupt emotions. I can stir the heart until it turns heavy with despair. Even joy becomes tainted under the right pressure. It's invasive. Direct. Like dark ink blooming in water."

Her smile held no malice — only understanding.

"But Lunaria and Kasumi... they don't need abilities like mine."

Her gaze slipped back to the arena, to Kasumi's calm, unbroken stride.

"They don't force negativity. They don't twist you from the outside. They let your own thoughts unravel you. They make you break yourself."

Umbra's voice softened. "Lunaria must have told you what happened when she first fought Mami, yes?"

"Yes," Mifuyu said. "She mentioned it this morning."

"She said her friends were in danger," Kuroe added. "That Mami needed to defeat her to save them."

Umbra nodded. "And Mami believed every word. She fought with desperation, not clarity. And Lunaria... simply avoided every strike. Calm. Precise. Untouchable. The more Mami missed, the more her resolve twisted into frustration... and then into self-blame."

Her voice lowered to a whisper.

"She nearly became a witch. Lunaria saved her just in time."

Silence fell again, heavy but familiar.

Umbra's eyes drifted toward Lunaria, her expression quiet — the kind of quiet born from losing to the same person more times than she could count.

"...Whenever I face her," Umbra said, voice low and steady, "the feeling never changes."

She closed her hand slowly, as if remembering the sensation of a strike that never landed.

"That frustration... that helplessness. She slips through every attack like moonlight passing through mist. After a while, it doesn't matter how determined you are. The doubt still gets in. Little by little."

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe all looked to Lunaria then.

Lunaria answered with a soft smile — graceful, unhurried, and carrying a quiet confidence that made it hard to tell where elegance ended and provocation began.

Kuroe spoke next, though her voice seemed to come from somewhere far away.

"...Ichizo felt it too."

The others turned gently toward her.

"I remember," Kuroe said. "Ichizo's anger... the way it kept growing. No matter how many attacks she launched, Lunaria kept moving forward. Calm. Light. Like she was dancing through the air."

She paused, lowering her gaze.

"It felt... unreal. As if Ichizo was fighting an illusion."

Momoko shivered. "So that's Lunaria... A beauty that makes frustration bloom."

Mifuyu clasped her hands neatly. "Graceful, precise... and quietly overwhelming."

Their gazes returned to the arena.

Kasumi was still walking. Still smiling.

Mami stood frozen, trembling around the edges.

Momoko whispered, “What did Mami see when Kasumi fought Umbra?”

Mifuyu swallowed softly. “What is this ‘fiery monster’ she described?”

Kuroe’s voice barely carried. “It doesn’t sound like Lunaria at all... so what exactly *is* Kasumi?”

Their imaginations raced — flickers of chaos, of heat, of something too wild to pin down.

And below them, the flame hadn’t even begun to burn.

Mami heard Umbra’s voice drift faintly from above — a soft confession wrapped in the ache of someone who knew Lunaria’s fighting style all too well. The way Lunaria manipulated your emotions to make you unravel from the inside out.

And Mami understood.

She remembered it all too well — the white lie, the desperation, the way her own thoughts had turned against her. How Lunaria had made her believe she was failing her friends. How close she’d come to breaking.

So it’s not just me, Mami thought. *It wasn’t weakness. It wasn’t just me.*

For the first time since the match began, she felt a flicker of warmth in her chest — not from courage, but from understanding. From not being alone.

She looked down at her soul gem.

It was clouded. Tainted. A swirl of fear, uncertainty, and shame churned inside it.

All because Kasumi had walked toward her slowly with a smile.

Mami closed her eyes and let out a soft, breathless chuckle.

“She didn’t even touch me...”

She raised her hands and slapped both cheeks — not hard, but sharp enough to sting. Then she bounced lightly on her toes, shaking out her arms, loosening her shoulders.

A deep breath.

Then another.

When she opened her eyes, her gaze was clear.

Kasumi was still smiling, still strolling with that same gentle brightness.

Mami smiled back.

Her soul gem pulsed with light. The taint didn’t vanish, but it stopped spreading. It stabilized. Contained. Ready to be used.

Kasumi's eyes widened in surprise. "Oh? You've gotten over your fear already?" she said, voice bright with delight. "So the battle can *finally* begin?"

Mami chuckled. "Yes. I'm done being frozen."

She looked up toward the flower pod. "Thank you, Umbra," she called. "Hearing your story... it helped. I thought I was the only one."

Umbra smiled, her warm voice carrying down like velvet. "Then go show her what you've learned!"

Mami turned back to Kasumi, her stance narrowing.

Her muskets pulled in tighter, aligning like stars on a single orbit.

Her ribbons coiled with purpose, glinting like golden serpents ready to strike.

"Get ready," she said.

Kasumi grinned, bouncing once on her heels. "Bring it! I want to see everything you've got!"

Mami didn't hesitate.

She poured her fear into her magic — not to suppress it, but to *wield* it. Her ribbons surged forward, dozens of them, slicing through the air from every direction. They moved like a storm of golden lightning, fast and precise, converging on Kasumi with overwhelming force.

Up in the pod, Kyoko's eyes sparkled. "Whoa." She grinned. "Look at her go! She was frozen solid a minute ago, and now she's launching a full-scale barrage!"

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe stared, wide-eyed.

"So this is it," Mifuyu whispered. "Emotional control. Just like Lunaria told us."

"She's using the fear that nearly broke her," Momoko said, awe in her voice. "And turning it into power."

The three of them exchanged glances, minds racing.

"What would *my* magic look like with that kind of control?" Mifuyu murmured.

"I want to try it too," Kuroe murmured. "I want to feel that level of clarity..."

They turned back to the arena, breath held.

How will Kasumi respond?

Mami wondered the same.

When she'd fought Lunaria, her ribbons had been met with elegance — dodged, parried, redirected with the barest flick of a wrist or twist of a shoulder. Lunaria had moved like a dancer, never wasting a motion.

But Kasumi wasn't Lunaria.

Would she try to block them with exaggerated, cartoonish gestures?

Would she shout "NOPE!" and slap them away with a frying pan?

No.

Kasumi didn't move at all.

She stood there, relaxed, smiling — as if waiting for a hug, not an ambush.

The ribbons struck.

They wrapped around her arms, her legs, her torso — layer after layer of golden silk binding her tight. In seconds, she was completely immobilized.

A soft gasp rippled through the arena.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe all leaned forward.

"She landed it," Momoko breathed. "She *actually* landed it."

"But... why didn't Kasumi move?" Mifuyu asked. "She just stood there."

Kuroe looked around the pod — at Kyoko, Lunaria, Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, and Umbra — searching for answers.

But all of them wore the same expression.

A knowing smile.

As if they'd seen this before.

As if they knew exactly what was coming next.

The tension in the air shifted — not fear, but anticipation.

Kasumi looked at Mami, still wrapped tight, and beamed.

"Wow," she said. "That was *ferocious*. You really channeled that fear. I could feel it right through the ribbons!"

She wiggled her shoulders a little, the bindings creaking. "You know, I'm starting to think I really *am* the realm's mummy mascot."

Mami chuckled. "At this point, I think you are."

Kasumi grinned wider. "First yesterday — when the spirits of the twelve girls' families wrapped me up like a burrito. Then this morning, when you and Kyoko caught me red-handed and tied me up for face-painting revenge. And now this!"

She gave a dramatic squirm, ribbons rustling. "Three times in two days. I'm starting to think it's my *thing*."

The arena erupted in laughter.

Even Mami couldn't help it. She chuckled, shaking her head.

"Thank you," she said softly.

Then her voice sharpened as her lips curled up into a bright smile.

"But I've got you now. So get ready for what comes next!"

Mami clenched her fist.

Her ribbons responded instantly — tightening, creaking, twisting in on themselves like living silk hungry for a command. Their edges sharpened into gleaming blades, the gold brightening with every ounce of emotion she fed into them. Embarrassment. Anger. Fear. All of it poured through her like molten metal.

A bead of sweat slid down her cheek as she pulled.

The bindings constricted around Kasumi's body, the pressure mounting, the air itself tightening as if it were bracing for the violence to come.

"Let's see how you handle this," Mami said, her voice quivering with adrenaline and something sharper. "Mrs. Mummy Mascot."

The ribbons responded with a metallic groan, the sound of golden chains being pulled past their breaking point.

This will cut. This will crush. This will—

But Kasumi didn't react.

Her body remained relaxed within the blazing coils of silk, unmarked, untouched. No bruises. No cuts. Not even a flinch.

Her grin stayed bright and unshaken, like she was being hugged by warm blankets instead of constricted by lethal magic.

Mami's breath hitched. *This isn't right.*

She squeezed harder. Her fist trembled. Sparks of golden magic rippled violently around her. The ribbons tightened so fiercely that the arena floor beneath Kasumi cracked in thin spiderweb lines.

Still nothing.

Kasumi simply tilted her head, smile widening as she blinked at Mami with childlike curiosity — as if wondering when she planned to get serious.

Up in the spectator pod, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe were already leaning so far forward their reflections shimmered in the barrier.

“I can feel it,” Mifuyu whispered. “Her attack is amplified by emotion. That pressure is— it’s absurdly high.”

“Any magical girl would be screaming,” Momoko breathed. “We’d be begging for mercy by now.”

“But Kasumi...” Kuroe’s voice cracked into a thin whisper. “She’s not even defending herself. I don’t sense any magic from her at all.”

Momoko’s hands shook. “Then what is she made of...?”

The three turned to Kyoko — who was grinning the whole time.

“Is this an illusion? A barrier? What’s happening?”

Kyoko looked at them and laughed, eyes reflecting Kasumi’s unshakable smile.

“Just keep watching,” she said, voice bubbling with excitement. “You’ll get it.”

Down below, Mami steadied her breath, staring at Kasumi — still wrapped, still immobilized, still smiling as if she were enjoying a warm day under the sun.

The realization hit her at once.

Kasumi wasn’t resisting.

She wasn’t enduring.

She was simply... unaffected.

“Wow...” Mami said with a shaky chuckle. “Looks like Ms. Mummy Mascot is immune to ribbons.”

Kasumi wiggled her shoulders, the ribbons creaking around her. “Maybe that’s my secret talent! If I ever retire from adventuring, I’ll go into mummy-based performance art!”

Mami rolled her eyes, but her smile held a flicker of genuine joy.

“If ribbons won’t do it... then how about this?”

Her muskets broke orbit — gliding smoothly into new formation, their barrels aligning on Kasumi like a constellation preparing to fire.

Mami’s heart thrummed.

“I’ll put everything into this. My embarrassment... my frustration... my fear.”

She inhaled, letting the tremors in her limbs settle into determination.

“And since you insist on remaining still—”

Her voice sharpened, eyes gleaming with excitement.

“—I’ll try something new.”

She raised her hand, two fingers pointed directly at Kasumi.

“Bare minimum magic in the shot. Then, right before impact... I’ll pour everything in.”

Kasumi’s grin lit up like a sunrise.

“Yes! Yes! That’s perfect!” she chirped. “I’ve seen you harden your ribbons at the last instant for defense — now I want to see your offensive magical control! Show me how you explode!”

In the pod, Momoko felt her heartbeat skipping.

“So her ribbons weren’t just for binding,” she murmured. “She can transform them defensively too...”

“And now she’s applying magical control to her muskets,” Mifuyu added. “Her first real attempt at offensive magical control.”

Kuroe clasped her hands, trembling with anticipation. “I need to see this.”

Mami closed her eyes.

Relax.

Breathe in.

Find the center.

Let the trembling settle.

Let the fear sharpen.

Let everything become purpose.

She opened her eyes — bright, golden, resolute.

Her muskets fired.

The bullets streaked across the arena with nearly no magic, plain and gray and simple — unremarkable metal slugs, almost mundane.

Kasumi’s smile widened, eyes sparkling like a child awaiting fireworks.

Then Mami thrust her palm forward.

Magic erupted from her.

It surged into the bullets like lightning seeking metal — and they ignited.

The transformation was instantaneous.

Each bullet burst into radiant gold, halos of shimmering energy glittering around them. Trails of light spiraled behind them, weaving glowing arcs through the air like constellations in motion.

It was beautiful — heartbreakingly beautiful.
Too beautiful.

The spectators had barely a heartbeat to admire the golden constellations streaking through the air.

Because then the world detonated.

A sunburst of blinding gold erupted midair — not a simple explosion, but a blooming star, radiant and newborn, swallowing Kasumi in a spiraling corona of fire and light. The blast unfurled outward with the force of a rising dawn, ripping across the arena in a roar that rattled bones and shook the spectator pods.

The ground trembled.

Wind screamed.

Light devoured everything.

Mami flinched and threw an arm over her eyes, ribbons instinctively shielding her as she staggered back under the sheer force. Her heartbeat hammered like a frantic drum, each pulse echoing in her ears.

That was stronger than Tiro Finale.

The thought hit her like lightning, splitting through her shock and sending adrenaline surging through her veins.

If I can do that with ordinary shots...

Then what will my Tiro Finale become?

If I can master magic control for both defense and offense—

She saw it, just for a moment — a vision of herself standing amidst blinding light, her magic honed to a razor's edge.

Her potential.

Her future.

Her lips trembled into a smile that felt both unreal and unstoppable.

High above, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe leaned so far forward that their reflections shimmered against the barrier.

Mami's attack bloomed across the smoke-filled air like a constellation torn open, each golden petal drifting and fading in slow, sparkling arcs. It was beautiful — heartbreakingly beautiful — and frightening in equal measure.

"This..." Mifuyu breathed, voice shaking with awe, "this is exactly what Lunaria meant. Last-second magic infusion... an explosive spike in output... her control is unbelievable."

Momoko nodded slowly, lips parted. “I’ve never seen a magical attack evolve in real time. It’s mesmerizing. Like she’s rewriting the rules.”

Kuroe pressed trembling hands to the railing. “If this is her first attempt... what happens when she masters it?”

None of them dared to imagine the answer.

They stared into the swirling smoke, waiting for the shape inside to appear — praying that Kasumi hadn’t been obliterated, fearing that she had, believing that she couldn’t be.

Surely this one had done something. It had to.

The arena’s haze curled and drifted, thinning like a curtain being slowly drawn aside.

Kyoko practically exploded with excitement.

“WHOOO!” she shouted, grinning with enough heat to rival the blast. “That was insane! You might actually be able to put up a good fight against me now, Mami!”

Mami looked up, her posture brightening as she slipped effortlessly back into their familiar rhythm.

“Oh, Kyoko, my dear student...” Mami said sweetly, folding her hands with exaggerated grace. “Are you getting a little too confident? Remember — I was your mentor.”

Kyoko barked out a laugh, throwing her head back. “Please. I’m not scared! You’ve got new tricks—that just makes this more fun.”

Their fiery banter crackled through the arena like sparks popping off living flame.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe couldn’t help but laugh.

“I want to see them go all out,” Momoko said, grinning ear to ear.

“Same,” Mifuyu agreed, eyes shining. “A duel between mentor and mentee... it would be incredible.”

Kuroe nodded eagerly. “I’d pay money to watch that.”

Kyoko spun toward them, winking. “Don’t worry. You’ll get your chance. I wanna fight all of you too. New people, new magic — that’s the best kind of match.”

Momoko snorted. “It’s a promise then.”

“Only after we learn some of the techniques Lunaria taught us,” Mifuyu added dryly. “Otherwise we’d be flattened in seconds.”

Kuroe giggled. “Absolutely crushed.”

Kyoko gave a little salute. “Then hurry up and learn already. I’ll be waiting.”

From their seats, Lunaria, Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, and Umbra all watched with warm smiles. Their eyes gleamed with pride — pride not just in the spectacle, but in the growth, the camaraderie, the bonds forming like constellations around one another.

It was the kind of warmth that magical girls rarely got to feel. And that was a kind of magic.

Down in the arena, Mami's excitement shifted back into a trembling anticipation as she stared into the clearing smoke.

Did it work?

Please... let it have done something.

The ribbons still binding Kasumi hadn't even frayed.

That wasn't a good sign.

The haze thinned.

A shadow appeared.

Mami inhaled sharply—

And then burst into a breathless laugh, disbelief mixing with genuine joy.

Because Kasumi was still standing.

Wrapped in ribbons.

Completely unharmed.

Kasumi threw her head back and let out an explosive cheer.

“YES!! That was amazing!!” she shouted, practically vibrating with joy. “Mami, that was BEAUTIFUL! Your first time using offensive magical control, and you made it look like a festival firework display!”

Her grin wobbled, as if trying to hold back tears. Then her voice cracked dramatically.

“I'm so proud— so proud— to see my little Mami grow up!”

Kasumi burst into theatrical sobbing. Since her arms were bound, she angled her head and used one of Mami's ribbons like a tissue, sniffing loudly into the golden silk. Whether she was actually crying or simply abusing the situation for maximum comedy was impossible to tell.

Probably both.

Mami let out a full-hearted laugh, warmth radiating through her chest.

“Thank you, Kasumi. Truly. I couldn't have reached this point without you.”

Her gaze lifted toward Lunaria in the stands.

“And without you as well.”

Lunaria’s smile softened, gentle as moonlight on still water.

“You’re doing wonderfully, Mami. Experimenting. Risking. Creating. That’s how magical girls grow. As long as you stay curious... you’ll continue to shine.”

Mami’s breath trembled with gratitude. She bowed her head slightly, her smile glowing.

The warmth of rivalry, mentorship, and friendship filled the arena — brighter than any explosion she could ever unleash.

And far, far more powerful.

Mami’s smile lingered only a moment before faltering. She stared at Kasumi — bright, cheerful, wrapped in ribbons and entirely unscathed.

“Despite all your compliments,” Mami murmured, voice soft but unsteady, “I didn’t do any damage at all. How... how did something like that do nothing? Who are you, Kasumi? What did you do? I couldn’t even sense you using magic to protect yourself.”

A tremor threaded through her words, fragile as glass.

She recalled aloud, almost to herself, the memory of Kasumi’s fight — or rather, Kasumi’s clone — against Umbra three days ago, her first day in this realm.

“Umbra struck you down. She dealt what looked like heavy damage. But instead of breaking you, it only fueled your battle lust. You grew stronger.”

Her gaze hardened, then wavered, uncertainty flickering in her eyes.

“If even Umbra’s attacks couldn’t stop you... does that mean mine are far weaker than hers?”

Kasumi didn’t hesitate. She winked and grinned with bright, playful honesty. “Yup. That’s correct. Umbra’s attacks are much stronger than yours.”

Mami’s heart dropped. The admission hit like a stone to the chest.

So I am still weak... so weak...

But then Kasumi’s tone shifted, unexpectedly gentle, unexpectedly warm.

“That’s not something to be sad about,” Kasumi said. “Or discouraged by. Umbra’s lived longer. She’s had more time to learn, to grow, to fight. Strength is just... a collection of everything someone’s been through. If you lived as long as Umbra, you’d be incredibly powerful in your own right.”

Sunlight radiated from Kasumi’s smile, bright enough to pierce the haze of doubt.

“And Mami? After only three days in this realm, you’ve already done all this. You should be proud. Really proud.”

Mami's chest warmed at her words. She bowed her head slightly. "...Thank you, Kasumi."

Then her eyes lifted, uncertain, searching. "But what now? I tried my best, and I still can't hurt you. Should Kyoko and I fight together? Use Connect? Even then... I doubt we could do anything against you."

Kasumi's grin turned mischievous, her eyes gleaming dangerously. "Not yet. There's still more I want to show you."

Mami's eyes widened, curiosity and dread mingling. "More? What do you mean?"

Kasumi's voice dropped, trailing off with a menacing lilt that sent a shiver down Mami's spine. "You passed my test. I expected you to bind me with your ribbons. And once I was immobilized, I thought you'd try something new. And you did — offensive magical control. Bare minimum magic to launch, then pouring it in at the last second. Efficient. Creative. And EXPLOOOOOOOOOOSIVE."

Her grin sharpened, playfulness giving way to predatory excitement.

"But tell me, Mami..."

Her eyes gleamed like embers catching flame.

"Can you do that against someone who isn't immobilized? Someone who's trying to attack you?"

Mami's eyes went wide. *So she's coming after me now...*

Before she could finish the thought, Kasumi brought her hands together.

The ribbons on her arms tore apart with a sharp rip.

Mami staggered back, gasping. "Impossible..."

Those ribbons had been strengthened with her negativity — embarrassment, anger, fear — hardened into something fierce and unyielding. And Kasumi ripped them casually, like paper.

She could have broken free at any time.

Kasumi had *chosen* to stay bound. To give Mami the confidence to try something new. To give her room to grow.

Mami let out a weak, incredulous chuckle. "You are using this battle... to teach me."

Kasumi finished tearing the ribbons from her arms, then her legs, each movement smooth and unhurried. The golden silk fell from her like shed skin. She stepped forward casually, unburdened, stretching her wrists as if warming up for a dance.

Her smile was bright, almost innocent. "Of course! What better place to learn than in the heat of battle?"

Her eyes narrowed, her grin sharpened. "Get ready, Mami. The next phase begins now."

Mami steadied herself, muskets orbiting gracefully, ribbons floating like golden serpents. She raised her chin. “Come. I’m ready.”

But then she felt it.

The air around Kasumi had changed. The pressure. The intensity. A heat that pressed against her skin, invisible yet undeniable.

Kasumi noticed her unease and placed her hands on her hips, grinning. “Good! You feel it. That’s my battle lust! My pride and joy. I’m starting to get fired up!”

Mami swallowed hard, sweat dripping down her cheek. She focused on Kasumi, her heart pounding.

So this is Kasumi’s battle lust...

She had thought it was just a metaphor.

A warrior’s flourish.

A dramatic exaggeration.

But now she could feel it — the pressure, the intensity, the raw fire emanating from Kasumi. It was real. Tangible.

She compared the two in her mind.

Lunaria had radiated calm power, an aura of grace and elegance, the serenity of moonlight on still water. Her movements had been swift, beautiful, precise.

But Kasumi... Kasumi radiated unbridled chaos. A storm with no warning and no center.

Mami shuddered, caught between curiosity, excitement, and dread.

What will it feel like, she wondered, breath catching, when Kasumi’s battle lust burns at its brightest?

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe could hardly breathe.

Kasumi had allowed herself to be struck by everything Mami threw at her — ribbons sharpened with fear, muskets infused with explosive magic — and she had taken it all without a scratch. Not only that, she had broken free of Mami’s bindings as casually as if they were threads of paper.

“How strong... how sturdy is she?” Mifuyu whispered. Her voice shook, as if the question itself was too large for her to hold.

Momoko pressed a hand to her chest. The air felt heavier now — thicker, hotter, trembling with Kasumi’s rising intensity. “And now her battle lust is burning brighter,” she murmured. “That means she’s even stronger than when she took all those attacks.”

Kuroe shivered, arms curling inward. “Fighting Kasumi must be terrifying. Like standing in front of a storm that only grows the longer you face it.”

Their eyes turned instinctively toward Umbra.

If Umbra's attacks had been able to wound Kasumi, then how powerful was Umbra? Mami's attack had been the strongest any of them had ever seen from a magical girl... and yet in this realm, that strength felt like the first line of a much larger story.

Umbra let out a soft chuckle, tinged with layered emotions — memory, frustration, respect.

"Fighting Kasumi," she said, "is as rage-inducing and disheartening as fighting Lunaria... but in a very different way. Lunaria dances around your attacks — graceful, beautiful, untouchable. Kasumi? She takes them. Every single one. She's already incredibly sturdy, so hurting her is difficult. And if you *do* hurt her, the pain only fuels her. Her battle lust burns brighter, and she grows stronger, more ferocious."

Her eyes softened, her smile faint but knowing. "And if you try to stall, to avoid hurting her, it doesn't matter. Her battle lust will burn brighter anyway, the deeper she dives into the fight. Fighting Kasumi is like being trapped between a rock and a hard place... or a ticking time bomb. If you can't put her down, she will overwhelm you with her intensity."

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe listened in awe, their minds racing. Lunaria and Kasumi — so different in personality, in style, in aura — yet both terrifyingly powerful in their own way.

Kyoko laughed, her voice sharp and fiery. "All my fights with Kasumi have been like training sessions. She uses them to help me grow — just like she did with Mami just now."

She winked at the three girls. "Sure, fighting Lunaria and Kasumi is frustrating and scary if you're trying to win. But if you let loose, if you give it your all... it's fun. That's why so many people here have learned so much from fighting them."

Elira, Sylvette, and Mirielle smiled warmly, nodding in agreement. "Every fight with Lunaria and Kasumi was intense," Sylvette said. "But fun. And unforgettable. We learned more than we ever thought possible."

Momoko turned to Lunaria, her smile bright with curiosity. "So... who's stronger? You or Kasumi?"

Lunaria chuckled, her voice calm and radiant with confidence. "I am," she said simply.

Her smile sharpened as she looked at Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe. "I can dodge or deflect Kasumi's attacks and retaliate with precision. She can only take so many of my strikes before collapsing."

From below, Kasumi's voice rang out, bright and offended in the most playful way. "I heard that!"

She looked up at the pod, flashing a confident grin, a wink, and two thumbs up. "Lunaria's leaving out the last part! When my battle lust is burning its brightest — when I'm at my peak — *she's* the one who can only hold out for so long before I overwhelm her!"

Lunaria and Kasumi locked eyes across the arena.

Lunaria's eyes narrowed in a glare that sparkled like polished steel.
Kasumi matched her instantly — fire meeting moonlight.

Their stares clashed midair like two blades sparking off each other — sharp, unyielding, charged with rivalry and respect.

The entire arena erupted in laughter.

Everyone loved them like this — two forces of nature, arguing with the fondness of old comrades and the pride of eternal sparring partners.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe laughed too, their hearts light.

“It's just like Kamihama,” Momoko said warmly. “Magical girl rivals teasing and challenging each other. Some things never change, no matter where you are.”

Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, and Umbra nodded in agreement.

“They spar often,” Umbra said. “And their battles are incredible. A true spectacle. You'll see for yourselves soon. Sooner than you think.”

Mami's eyes gleamed, anticipation lighting her features. She wanted to see it — Lunaria and Kasumi clashing at full power. There was too much to learn from both.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe looked to Lunaria.

Lunaria gave them a warm, reassuring smile — followed by a small nod.

Then they looked down at Kasumi.

Kasumi beamed back at them, flashing another pair of enthusiastic thumbs up.

Her grin was radiant enough to heat the air.

The three girls exchanged glances, hearts racing.

It was a promise.

Lunaria and Kasumi would spar for them soon.

And what a sight that would be.

Chapter 4b: Mami vs Kasumi – part 2

Kasumi stepped forward.

Slow. Relaxed.

The same unhurried rhythm as before — each footfall quiet, deliberate, as if she were strolling through a sunlit garden rather than advancing through the aftermath of an explosion.

Mami's eyes narrowed.

She's doing it again. Just like phase one.

But her instincts screamed that something was different. That the calm wasn't calm at all — that it was heat contained, pressure held in check, a storm quietly choosing when to break.

Her thoughts raced.

What will be different this time? What will she use her battle lust for?

Kasumi's footsteps echoed lightly across the arena, an unsettling contrast to the crackling heat in the air.

Mami snapped her ribbons forward.

Bare-minimum magic first — the threads sliding like liquid gold.

Then, at the last moment, she thrust her emotions into them: fear, anger, determination.

The ribbons ignited.

They struck.

They wrapped.

They tightened.

And Kasumi kept walking.

The golden threads shattered against her skin, falling away like fragments of broken sunlight. They hit the ground with soft, disappointing taps, fading into nothing.

Mami's breath caught.

So with this level of battle lust... my ribbons are useless.

Her pulse spiked.

Then I'll go all out.

She raised her arm. A massive gun materialized in a burst of radiant energy, the barrel gleaming with coiled potential.

"Tiro Finale!"

The cannon roared alive — magic pouring out in a breathtaking torrent. The initial blast glowed with colorful particles, the bare-minimum charge swirling in prismatic haze.

Then Mami poured everything into it.

Her fear.

Her hope.

Her pride.

Her desperation.

The world erupted.

A colossal expanding sphere of color blossomed from Kasumi's position — a kaleidoscope spiral blooming into a full starburst. The shockwave ripped through the arena, swallowing everything, even the elevated pods.

Light devoured all it touched.

The crowd erupted — not in fear, but in wild, thunderous cheers. A wave of awe swept through the arena as spectators jumped to their feet, dazzled by the grand, prismatic explosion. It was impossible not to be swept up in it; the blast was too beautiful, too spectacular.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe shrieked, throwing up their arms as the explosion engulfed their pod in searing brilliance. Their silhouettes were swallowed by colors.

Kyoko squeezed her eyes shut, but her grin was wild and fearless.

“YES, Mami! That's the best Tiro Finale I've ever seen from you!”

Her voice crackled with fiery excitement. “You're firing me up — I can't wait to unleash my own ultimate move when we fight Kasumi together!”

Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, and Umbra watched quietly — their expressions soft, proud, reflective.

Elira's eyes shimmered. “Soooo pretty! So many colors! It reminds me of my own magic. When I poured everything into it against Thornaria and Umbra long ago.”

Sylvette nodded, her voice tinged with memory. “Yes. It's just like our final attack with Hoshine and the 2 girls without soul gems — **Wishing Starfall Nova**. That explosion was just as grand.”

She paused, her smile gentle but bittersweet. “It was the last thing we ever did together.”

Mirielle leaned forward, her curiosity burning brighter. “I want to analyze Mami's magic someday. Her ribbons... her muskets... this Tiro Finale... How do they compare to other magical girls' constructs? Fascinating.”

Umbra chuckled softly. “I wonder how much damage that would do to me. Some, perhaps. But not much.”

Lunaria's smile was serene. “So this is Mami's maximum output—at least for now.” Her gaze drifted toward the inferno. “Impressive. But can she sustain it against Kasumi?”

Gradually, the explosion subsided.

Light faded.

Smoke thinned.

Silence rolled in, heavy and expectant.

Mami lowered her weapon, chest rising and falling in ragged breaths. Sweat trickled down her cheek.

She looked forward—
And froze.

Kasumi was still walking.
Slowly. Casually. Completely unharmed.

It was as if she'd stepped through fireworks instead of a supercharged Tiro Finale.

Mami's mind spiraled.
My ultimate attack Tiro Finale... even with magical control... useless.
What else can I do?

Her heartbeat thundered painfully in her ears.

Kasumi hadn't attacked. Not once. She didn't want to stop their fight... so what was she waiting for?

Her gaze locked onto Kasumi's gentle smile — warm, steady, patient.

The steps continued, unfaltering — calm amidst the ruin of her own explosion.

Then realization struck Mami like a lightning bolt.

Is this it?

Her breath trembled.

Is she waiting to see how I'll handle her attacks once she finally decides to strike...?

Kasumi's steps carried her closer, slow and casual, as if the battlefield were nothing more than a quiet garden path.

"You're doing great, Mami!" she exclaimed, her voice bursting with energy. Her smile was radiant, almost proud, her tone carrying the warmth of a cheerleader and the mischief of a trickster. "You applied magical control to your ribbons... even to your Tiro Finale. That **EXPLOOOOOOSION**—" she stretched the word until it echoed across the arena, arms flung wide as if conducting an orchestra — "was **AWESOME**! The audience loved it!"

Her encouragement glowed, but with each step the pressure around her thickened, the air growing heavier, denser, as though her cheerfulness itself carried weight.

"Don't worry about whether your attacks damage me or not," she continued, wagging a finger playfully. "Focus instead on how long you can last. Test your limits! Go wild! Get a feel for where you are now... so you'll know how far you've grown later."

Mami's breath trembled. Kasumi was close now — close enough for hand-to-hand combat.

Her ribbons floated around her like golden serpents, poised to sense any incoming strike. She braced herself, expecting Kasumi's trademark antics: wild windups, comical theatrics, exaggerated cries. But she didn't know at what intensity Kasumi would begin.

Kasumi did not disappoint.

She leaned back dramatically, right arm drawn far behind her, spine arching as if she were posing for a spotlight. Her voice rose in a warrior's cry, halfway between a battle chant and a stage actor's flourish. The motion was so exaggerated it left her wide open, riddled with vulnerabilities.

Mami seized the opening. Her ribbons shot forward, infused with only the bare minimum of magic, waiting for the critical moment to ignite. The rest hovered behind her, ready to sense Kasumi's strike.

Then Kasumi lunged.

Her battle cry shifted into a different pitch — louder, more theatrical, almost musical — as she swung her right arm forward in a dramatic punch. The movement was slow, predictable, almost laughable.

But it was enough.

Mami's concentration slipped. She failed to pour magic into her offensive ribbons at the right moment. They brushed against Kasumi's body weakly, feather-light, like strands of silk grazing her skin.

Still, Kasumi's punch was so sluggish that Mami sidestepped it with ease, without even needing her defensive ribbons.

She couldn't help it. A laugh burst from her lips.

"What was that, Kasumi? The huge wind-up, the lunging body, the ridiculous cries — it was all so hilariously bad. Atrocious. Pathetic. And yet... it was enough to disrupt my focus."

Her realization struck sharp: *This is the difficulty. Using magical control offensively is far harder in a real fight. You have to juggle everything — your opponent's movements, your own defense, your strategy — and still time the infusion perfectly. Even something silly can throw you off.*

Kasumi, her arm still extended from the punch, twirled theatrically until she faced Mami again. Her eyes widened into puppy-like innocence, tears shimmering at the corners.

"How could you call that atrocious and pathetic?" she whimpered, voice cracking with faux heartbreak. "I poured my *all* into that punch... and you dodged it so easily, just by stepping aside. How cruel!"

Mami erupted into more laughter, her shoulders shaking. The arena followed suit, laughter rippling through the crowd like a wave.

Up in the pod, Momoko and Mifuyu laughed too, their voices bright with memory.

"This reminds me of Mitama's projection," Momoko said between giggles. "When we saw Lunaria and Kasumi leap from the train onto Embryo Eve..."

Mifuyu nodded, grinning. "Lunaria landed with elegance. Kasumi... belly-flopped. Face-first. We didn't know if she was serious then, and even now we're still not sure."

They exchanged amused glances. “But it seems Kasumi loves being silly. In adventuring, in fighting... always playful.”

Kasumi sniffled, wiping away mock tears with the back of her hand. She turned to the audience, her voice quivering with exaggerated sorrow.

“You all think the same, don’t you? Everyone’s so mean to me... **Emotional damage!**”

The crowd roared with laughter again, some clapping, others whistling at her antics.

Kasumi swung back toward Mami, her smile tinged with mock sadness. “But you’re making good observations. You’re right — you were able to use magical control to create explosive power earlier because I was stationary, or moving slowly enough for you to focus purely on offense.”

Her tone shifted, playful but instructive, her words bouncing with rhythm. “But once you have to worry about everything else — defense, strategy, timing — even something as atrocious and pathetic...” She sniffled again, struggling to say the words, tears flowing in theatrical streams. “...as *that* is enough to disrupt your focus.”

Mami chuckled, shaking her head, unable to resist smiling at the absurdity.

Kasumi winked, her grin brightening like a sunrise. “Getting your feet wet with all these techniques is great! As Lunaria and I said, you don’t need to master everything at once. Get a feel for each skill. Then choose the one — or the few — that fit you: your style, your personality, your goals. Once you reach a level you’re satisfied with... then you can try something new.”

Her words hung in the air, equal parts playful and profound, like a lesson wrapped in laughter.

And Mami, still smiling, felt the lesson settle deep in her chest — a warmth that was both encouragement and challenge.

Kasumi shifted her weight forward, knees bending with exaggerated flourish — the kind of dramatic pose a stage actor would strike before the climactic final act. Her grin widened, bright and mischievous, eyes sparkling with childlike anticipation.

“Now that you’ve learned offensive magical control and its difficulties...” she declared, voice booming with theatrical grandeur, “...what will you do next, Mami? How will you deal with *this*?”

She charged forward.

Her eyes gleamed like a child sprinting toward a prize, her battle-lust burning brighter, the pressure in the air thickening with every step. The atmosphere itself seemed to pulse, heavy and electric, as though the arena itself was holding its breath.

And yet — her speed was unremarkable. Average. Human.

Mami braced herself calmly, ribbons floating around her like golden serpents, waiting to sense the strike.

Kasumi reached her in a burst of fiery excitement and unleashed a flurry of wild attacks — punches, chops, kicks, each accompanied by a different battle cry. Some were triumphant roars, others perfect parodies of old martial-arts films. One even sounded like a cartoon superhero's catchphrase.

Unlike her first atrocious punch, these strikes were executed with the earnestness of an ordinary person throwing hands.

It was chaos. Earnest chaos.

Mami chuckled. *Exactly like her clone against Umbra three days ago. Those attacks did nothing then... and now she's doing the same against me.*

She dodged gracefully, body turning with dancer-like precision, her ribbons swirling around her in golden arcs that shimmered like stage lights.

Curious, she hardened a ribbon in the path of one of Kasumi's chops.

Kasumi's strike passed through it effortlessly — the ribbon sliced apart like mist, dissolving into fragments of light.

Mami's eyes narrowed. *So my ribbons are useless for defense against her. Is it raw power? Or some technique that nullifies my magic? I can't sense any magic from her at all... but at least I can feel her strikes when they slice through my constructs.*

Her mind raced. *Maybe melee combat will do something. Maybe up close...*

She grinned at the thought.

Kasumi swung again. Mami twirled gracefully, dodging, then sprung upward, launching a jumping spin kick at Kasumi's side.

Her foot connected squarely.

But Kasumi didn't budge.

Mami's thoughts spiraled. *The sensation is strange. No recoil. No flinch. She absorbs it like stone. Like striking a statue that laughs back at you.*

Because Kasumi did laugh, delighted.

"Ohhh, you're throwing hands now? How fun! I love fighting foes up close and personal!"

Then she twisted dramatically, her full-body spin pushing against Mami's leg, using Mami's own momentum to fling her upward.

Mami's body arced into the air in a graceful spiral, ribbons trailing behind her like comet tails.

Kasumi followed immediately — a jumping spin kick of her own. Wide, exaggerated, utterly ridiculous. The kind of move you’d only see in a comedy martial-arts stage play. Her battle cry echoed like a parody of an old sentai show, complete with over-the-top intonation.

Mami reacted on instinct.

Her ribbons stabbed into the ground and exploded upward, launching her higher — just enough to clear Kasumi’s kick. The ribbon she used was shredded instantly, cleaved apart like paper as Kasumi’s attack passed through it.

Kasumi let out a gleeful laugh mid-spin.

“Nice dodge, Mami! And very stylish to boot! Very Lunaria-esque!”

Up in the pod, Lunaria chuckled softly, her voice carrying like silver bells. “That was very beautiful, Mami. That dodge was reminiscent of my style. And Mami herself admitted her mindset is closer to mine than Kasumi’s.”

Down below — Kasumi realized too late she was spinning with no way to land properly.

Her eyes widened.

“Oh noooooooooooooooooo—!”

She flailed helplessly through the air, limbs pinwheeling in chaotic arcs.

“WAAAAAAAAAH—!”

She crashed into the ground with maximum drama — a full belly flop, face-first, limbs splayed like a dropped ragdoll.

The arena erupted in laughter, the sound rolling like thunder.

Mami seized the moment. Her musket and ribbons shimmered, transforming into an array of melee weapons — blades, hammers, spears — each glowing with sharpened magical energy.

She poured power into them and struck Kasumi’s prone form.

A cascade of blows rained down — steel, light, and ribbons exploding upon impact in bursts of gold and color.

Kasumi slid across the ground from the force, dust billowing around her. The sound of clanging metal echoed through the arena like a symphony of chaos.

The crowd roared — some cheering, some laughing. The sudden escalation into close-quarters combat electrified them, and Kasumi’s absurd face-plant was the perfect setup. And Mami attacking Kasumi while she was face down, helpless — was the cherry on top.

Kasumi groaned theatrically as she pushed herself up. She was unharmed... except for a thin trickle of blood from her nose.

She grinned, rubbing her nose sheepishly. “I *meant* to land like that, you know. To give you another opportunity to try a new attack.”

Mami chuckled sweetly, mimicking Kasumi’s flair with gentle mockery. “Of course, you totally meant to do that. Thank you for another opportunity.”

Her smile turned playful, eyes gleaming. “But you don’t make any sense. All of my empowered attacks do nothing... yet your face-plant gives you a bloody nose. Does that mean your nose is your weakness? Or is smashing you into the ground the best way to hurt you?”

Kasumi winked, her grin mischievous, eyes twinkling with theatrical ambiguity. “Maaaaaybe! Or maybe not! Keep testing your theories, Mami. That’s the fun part!”

Her words rang with equal parts joke and challenge, playful yet profound, leaving the audience in stitches and Mami smiling despite herself.

Kasumi’s flurry intensified.

Her limbs blurred into a whirlwind — wild straight punches, looping haymakers, knife-hand chops, spinning backfists, sudden roundhouse kicks. Between them came bizarre surprises: a palm strike straight from old kung-fu movies, a crane-style pose she held for one dramatic heartbeat before launching forward, even a comical “HI-YAH!” accompanied by an overly earnest karate chop.

Each attack carried its own rhythm, each battle cry its own flavor — guttural roars, high-pitched squeaks, theatrical grunts ripped straight out of parody martial-arts cinema.

Chaotic. Unpredictable. Ridiculous.

And yet delivered with such sincere, wholehearted energy that it was impossible not to feel the earnest joy behind every swing.

Mami danced among them.

She twisted elegantly past a sweeping chop, leaning back just enough for Kasumi’s fingers to pass through her hair. She slid sideways under a looping punch, her feet gliding across the floor like she was skating on glass. A rising kick came at her side — she pirouetted away from it, ribbons swirling in golden spirals around her.

When Kasumi launched a flurry of jabs, Mami weaved between them, each movement delicate, precise, her body turning like a ballerina caught in a storm.

Her ribbons painted glowing brushstrokes through the air, their arcs tracing her paths, her timing, her heartbeat.

But her counterattacks faltered.

She attempted to pour magic into a ribbon strike — too late. The ribbon snapped weakly against Kasumi's shoulder.

She kicked upward, heel slicing through the air — but forgot to infuse at the last second; the blow was ordinary.

She fired a musket shot out of habit, and the bullet fizzled on impact, lacking the explosive brilliance she had felt earlier.

Still, she smiled.

Despite failing the timing... despite struggling... this was fun.

The joy of practice.

The joy of testing herself.

The joy of learning something new mid-battle.

But then—she noticed it.

The air.

The pressure.

Kasumi's battle lust was deepening — like a fire being fed oxygen. Heat pressed against Mami's skin, seeping into her lungs. Her heartbeat quickened, synced with the rhythm of Kasumi's strikes.

Kasumi's attacks were faster now.

Sharper.

Heavier.

The chaotic flurry condensed into something more focused — still wild, still playful, but carrying real force.

Mami's dodges shifted.

She no longer glided effortlessly. Her movements grew tighter, more urgent.

She ducked under a spinning kick and felt the wind graze her hair.

She twisted around Kasumi's elbow strike — barely.

Her ribbon-sense pulsed like radar, telling her how close each blow came.

I'll have to rely on my ribbons to sense her attacks soon...

Sweat trickled down her cheek.

Up in the pod, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe leaned so far forward they nearly pressed against the invisible barrier.

“She’s scaling up,” Mifuyu whispered. “Her battle lust... it’s stronger now.”

Momoko nodded, eyes tense. “Look at Mami’s dodges. She’s starting to strain.”

Kuroe hugged the railing, knuckles white. “Kasumi’s chaos... it’s becoming dangerous.”

Kyoko, however, grinned like fire. “Keep going, Mami! Push yourself! Last as long as you can!”

Kasumi lunged.

Mami twisted aside — but her ribbons snapped suddenly toward her right side, warning her—

Another strike.

Hidden behind the first.

Kasumi’s knee.

It swept in viciously from her blind angle, a deceptively sharp move disguised behind her sloppy overhand punch.

Mami reacted instantly.

Ribbons stabbed into the ground and detonated, hurling her sideways in a burst of golden propulsion.

Kasumi’s knee sliced through the space where she had been — clean and powerful.

Kasumi’s eyes sparkled with delight. “Beautiful! Dodging forward and sideways in completely different directions — so fast! You’re keeping up wonderfully!”

She charged again, battle cries mixing, overlapping — a chaotic chorus of intent.

Mami ducked under a wild hook, rolled backward from an axe kick, slid sideways to avoid a devastating elbow, spun around a heel kick that cut the air inches from her nose.

Her dodges grew smaller, sharper, tighter — conserving space, conserving breath.

I can’t keep this up... I need distance. I need to reset...

Kasumi lunged one more time.

Mami didn’t dodge normally.

She dropped — letting her body collapse backward, surrendering to gravity. Her ribbons instantly reacted, slamming into the ground and springing her upward like a golden catapult.

She shot into the air, ribbons trailing behind her like comet tails.

The distance widened beneath her.

Her chest heaved.

Her lungs burned.

Sweat shimmered against her brow.

Kasumi stared up at her, grinning wide — eyes ablaze, battle lust unfurling around her like a rising inferno.

The storm continued to brew.

Kasumi's eyes locked onto Mami as she soared upward, ribbons trailing behind her like golden comet tails brushing through the sky.

Her grin widened—mischievous, wild, and full of theatrical hunger.

“Oh no you don't!” she shouted, voice booming with the dramatic flair of a stage actor delivering their favorite line.

She bent her knees, coiling like a spring.

Then she launched.

Her ascent was explosive—her body rocketing upward with a speed that defied the lazy, chaotic flail of her limbs. Her arms windmilled, her legs kicked out in bizarre patterns, her silhouette a mess of motion. She didn't look like a martial artist leaping into the sky, but like a storm trying to remember how a human body was supposed to move.

Still—she was fast.

Mami's eyes widened. *She closed the distance so quickly...!*

She reached back, seized one of her trailing ribbons, and twisted her entire torso midair. The ribbon tightened, pulling taut as she redirected her momentum, curving her path like a dancer sweeping into a controlled arc.

Relief flickered across her face as Kasumi shot past her trajectory, overshooting by a clean meter.

But Kasumi turned her head mid-flight—just her head—her grin gleaming like a predator spotting prey, a spark of wicked joy dancing in her eyes.

And then—

In one smooth, whip-like motion, Kasumi snatched Mami's ribbon out of the air.

Before Mami could even gasp, Kasumi spun the ribbon like a lasso, golden light twirling in dizzying spirals. The ribbon coiled around Mami's waist, arms, and legs like serpents, tightening with every rotation.

Mami froze.
Bound by her own magic.

I didn't even see it—!

With a desperate thought, she dismissed the ribbons, releasing her magic. The golden coils evaporated instantly.

But the momentum was already there.
She was hurtling toward Kasumi like a magnet, helpless to stop herself.

Mami let out a small, defeated laugh.
“You used my own magic against me... so quickly I didn't even notice until it was too late.
Amazing...”

Kasumi twisted her body midair, pulling her fist back with long theatrical flourish—her grin blazing with feral battle-lust.

“You did extremely well, Mami,” she said, voice playful and commanding at once. “Now prepare yourself. Try to lessen the damage as much as possible. Let's see how well you can take a hit!”

Up in the pod, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe gasped.

“What—how did she—?” Momoko stammered, eyes wide.

“We didn't even see her bind Mami,” Mifuyu whispered, awe softening her voice. “She used Mami's own ribbons as restraints...”

Kuroe clutched her soul gem, stunned. “That's... incredible.”

Lunaria chuckled softly, serene and knowing.

“A lot becomes possible when you understand magical control. When you understand the nature of another girl's magic, you can interact with it in ways she doesn't expect. Many have been caught off guard when Kasumi turns their own abilities against them.”

The three girls exchanged glances—shock melting into admiration.
They smiled, watching the end of the fight unfold, proud of Mami's growth.
She had fought with heart. With joy. With courage.
And they had learned so much watching Lunaria's lessons come alive in real combat.

Kasumi's battle cry erupted through the sky—
“TAKE THIS!”

Her fist blazed with intent, her entire arm pulling back like a catapult.

Mami drew every ribbon she could muster, weaving them desperately into a barrier—a radiant cocoon of golden strands humming with raw magical energy.

Kasumi's punch hit.

It tore through the ribbons effortlessly—like shredding paper, like slicing through mist. Every strand snapped under her fist, unraveling into sparks.

Her strike slammed into Mami's forearm.

Pain exploded.

White-hot. Blinding.

Mami cried out as her body was launched downward, hurtling toward the arena floor like a falling star.

Instinct took over—her ribbons erupted beneath her, stabbing into the ground and detonating to create a cushioning blast.

The impact still rattled her entire body.

“Mami!!” Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe screamed, voices cracking with panic.

Kasumi's punch had been monstrous. The way Mami crashed into the ground looked devastating.

Was she—

Mami coughed blood—thin, bright, startling against her pale lips.

Her breaths were weak, but steady.

She let out a soft, trembling chuckle.

Her right forearm was shattered. Her ribs ached. Her magic reserves felt hollow.

Yet she smiled.

Her left hand gently cradled her soul gem, its light dulled from the immense strain.

“I did my best... That was fun...” Mami whispered, her consciousness slipping away.

The arena erupted in cheer.

To them, she had done wonderfully. Bravely. Beautifully.

Elira jumped up and down excitedly. “That was soooo cool! The way Mami used her ribbons was amazing!”

Sylvette nodded, nostalgia soft in her voice. “The way they danced around her... it was beautiful. Just like Hoshine's ribbons...”

Mirielle chuckled warmly, her expression tender. “Mm. Mami reminds me of her too. I wonder if Mami's ribbons might one day develop the same abilities as Hoshine's...”

Umbra crossed her arms, nodding with approval. “She's already sharper than she was yesterday. Much faster. Much cleaner.”

Kyoko grinned proudly. “She did great. Way better than I expected. As expected of my mentor.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe turned to Kyoko, worry etched across their faces.

“But... will she be okay?” Momoko asked.

Kyoko winked. “She’ll heal completely. That’s how this arena works. You can fight to the death here — with no lasting consequences.”

The three girls shuddered.

“Fight... to the death?” Kuroe whispered.

Kyoko laughed warmly. “Of course! Happens all the time. Especially between rivals. Those fights are the best — full of emotion, full of heart.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe exchanged glances, then smiled.

Momoko giggled nervously. “Imagine fighting each other or our friends in Kamihama to the death! I’m... not sure I could bring myself to land the finishing blow, even if it’s safe.”

Mifuyu exhaled softly, old pain flickering behind her eyes.

“Yachiyo and I fought nearly to the death once, when Yachiyo was hunting down Kuroe for interrogation. Thankfully, Yachiyo regained control of her doppel at the last second and spared me.” She smiled gently at her two friends.

“But now that we’ve reconciled... fighting her here wouldn’t be so bad. I wonder what the outcome would be.”

Kuroe looked down at her soul gem, recalling the soft pink glow it showed when she connected with Iroha.

“I wonder what would happen if Iroha and I fought to the death... I don’t think she could bring herself to finish me.”

Kyoko stretched, her grin widening.

“Well,” she said, cracking her knuckles, “guess it’s my turn to join the party.”

She looked back at them, eyes blazing with excitement.

“Wish me luck.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe laughed, cheering her on.

“Good luck, Kyoko! We can’t wait to see your abilities when you connect with Mami!”

Kyoko strode toward the edge of the pod.

She paused—her smile radiant, her aura shimmering with fiery battle-lust.

Then she jumped.

Her body arced downward, trailing a comet-tail of crimson magic as she plunged toward the arena floor.

The next storm was about to begin.

Mami yawned softly as consciousness drifted back to her.

Her eyes fluttered open to a serene landscape — a field of soft grass stretching across the arena floor, each blade glowing faintly under the clear sky. The air was crisp, almost sweet, filling her lungs with renewed vitality. Her body felt whole again, every ache erased, as if the clash with Kasumi had been only a fleeting nightmare.

Warmth washed over her.

Someone was standing above her.

Mami blinked up — and found Kyoko, hands on her hips, crimson hair haloed by the glowing light like a flicker of living fire.

Kyoko smirked, her voice playfully sharp.

“‘Bout time you woke up, sleepyhead. I wouldn’t stay knocked out that long after taking one of Kasumi’s hits.”

Mami laughed softly, brushing a strand of hair behind her ear. “How long are you going to keep up this sassy attitude with your senior?”

Kyoko’s grin deepened, equal parts mischief and affection. “Until it’s obvious — absolutely undeniable — that I’ve finally surpassed you.”

The words were bold, but her eyes softened. She crouched, offering her hand.

No bravado. No teasing.

Just Kyoko — sincere and warm.

Mami closed her eyes briefly, a gentle smile touching her lips. She placed her hand in Kyoko’s, their fingers threading together in a gesture built on years of trust. Kyoko pulled her up with effortless strength, but the real lift came from the quiet bond between them — the battles shared, the weight carried together, the unspoken loyalty that ran deep.

Standing again, Mami steadied herself. She turned to see Kasumi waiting nearby.

Kasumi beamed at her, posture relaxed, aura bright and inviting.

“Thanks for the fun fight, Mami! You did really, really well. You took my attack like a champ!”

Her sincerity radiated like sunlight. Mami smiled warmly back, her chest filling with gratitude.

But then — the air changed.

A slow, simmering pressure emanated from Kasumi, thick and charged.

Kyoko and Mami instinctively tensed, glancing toward her at the same time.

Kasumi's battle-lust thrummed like a heartbeat through the arena.

Playful, excited — and unmistakably intense.

Both magical girls exhaled soft, amused breaths.

“So that’s your excitement for the next phase?” Kyoko said, cracking her knuckles. “You’re itching for us to fight you together?”

“With Connect?” Mami added, smiling knowingly.

Kasumi responded with a sweeping bow so dramatic it bordered on theatrical, then straightened with a bright, radiant grin. She winked, her voice bubbling with anticipation.

“Exactly! I’m soooo excited to see what abilities you unlock when you Connect! I’m totally fired up!”

Mami and Kyoko exchanged a look — a gentle, shared laugh rising between them. Kasumi’s enthusiasm was contagious, her faith in them a buoyant warmth that settled in their hearts.

Then their gazes met fully.

For a moment, the world felt still.

There was no audience, no battlefield, no tension — only the two of them, standing together on a quiet field of glowing grass. Trust. Friendship. Mutual admiration. A pair of hearts aligned through hardship and growth.

Kyoko’s smile became fierce and bright, the kind of smile she only ever showed Mami.

“Ready, Mami?”

Mami’s own smile was soft, steady, serene.

“Yes.”

Their hands clasped again — not rushed, but intentional, firm, determined.

Golden light swelled from Mami’s soul gem in a gentle radiance.

Crimson sparks ignited from Kyoko’s, flaring like embers caught in the wind.

The two lights twisted together, spiraling upward in elegant arcs, gold and scarlet weaving into something new — something brilliant.

The world shimmered around them.

Their magic resonated.

And then — they **Connected**.

Chapter 5: Kyoko and Mami Connect

A pulse of magic surged from their clasped hands.

Red and gold light spiraled outward in twin helixes, swirling like galaxies beginning to merge. The air shimmered, vibrating with the resonance of their hearts; the arena itself trembled, as though the world was holding its breath.

Kyoko and Mami gasped together.

A warmth flooded into them — not heat, but something soft, encompassing, comforting. It felt like a hug for the soul, like sinking into a sunrise-colored blanket woven from trust and memory.

Kyoko's eyes widened, shimmering with awe.

"S—so this... this is Connect. I feel so much strength! So much magic! It's like it's pouring into me nonstop!"

Mami brought a hand to her chest, breath trembling, her eyes brimming with wonder.

"Yes... it's incredible. I've felt Connect before — with nature, and in the simulation yesterday.

Experiencing it through the perspective of those two girls without soul gems, when they joined with Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, and Hoshine... those moments were breathtaking. Transformative. To see life through another's eyes, to feel the world through their perspective..."

Her voice softened, intimate, fragile.

"But this... a Connect with you, Kyoko... my dear friend, in real life... it's incomparable. It feels like remembering a dream I never wanted to wake from."

Kyoko swallowed, cheeks dusted pink.

Their souls opened.

Their minds intertwined.

Their hearts echoed each other's rhythms.

Not only magic flowed — but essence.

Who they were at their cores.

They saw each other's prayers.

Their sadness.

Their rage.

Their hatred.

Their joy.

Their pleasure.

And lastly — their wishes.

Kyoko gave a half-smirk, half-nervous laugh.

"Heh... I'm kinda scared what you're gonna see in there. My past isn't exactly... y'know. Sparkles and sunshine."

Mami's answering smile was gentle, teasing but tender.
"I'll be gentle. I promise."

Kyoko snorted, grinning despite herself.
"That's what worries me."

They laughed together — a bright, clear sound that shimmered through the spiraling magical light.

Dream-Kyoko's prespective

Then—
—the visions arrived.

Dream-Kyoko found herself standing in a grassy park beside Mami.

Sunlight filtered through the trees, warm and dappled across the ground. The breeze carried the sweet scent of early autumn, stirring the leaves overhead.

On the grass lay a small picnic cloth — white with gold trim, just like Mami's ribbons — covered with neatly arranged pastries and fruit.

The real Kyoko sat beside Mami, legs crossed, biting into a taiyaki with joyful ferocity.

"Hey, hey! You see this?" real Kyoko bragged, wagging the taiyaki. "This one's stuffed with custard. I found this bakery behind the shopping district. The old lady running it is a total wizard. Like— real magic. Mami, I'm tellin' you—"

Mami giggled behind her hand. "Kyoko, please swallow before you continue lecturing me on pastries."

"Fine, fine," Kyoko huffed, cheeks puffed with food. "Miss Proper Lady."

Mami laughed even harder.

Dream-Kyoko felt it.
The warmth. The ease. The trust.

She felt the way Mami had looked at the real Kyoko — fond, exasperated, amused, deeply caring.

She heard their small talk:

Mami: "One day, I'd love to have a home where I can host tea properly. A table with real lace cloths. A kitchen full of sunlight."

Kyoko: "Heh. And you'll fill it with pastries. And I'll come over so often you'll get sick of me."

Mami: "I doubt that."

Kyoko choked on her snack. "G-gh—! Don't say stuff like that outta nowhere!"

And Mami only smiled with that soft, gentle glow she shared with so few.

Dream-Kyoko watched them tease each other, laugh, argue about nothing important, talk about their dreams for the future.

A perfect, gentle moment.
One she never lived.
One she never even knew existed.

Dream-Kyoko's smile trembled... then softened.
"So... after I was saved here in this realm... you two kept being friends."
It filled her heart with a warm ache.

But—

Her expression tightened.
Because she knew this memory was not where their story ended.
Mami had told her yesterday — in quiet, bittersweet words.
That this laughter had eventually fallen silent.
That she and Kyoko had drifted apart.
That pain, guilt, and grief had carved a gulf neither could cross.

And worse—

Dream-Kyoko braced herself, her voice a whisper.
"...This is right before everything went wrong, isn't it?"

She felt it.
The oncoming sorrow like a storm cloud.
The dread coiled behind the sunlight of the memory.

Kyoko's family.
Her father's breakdown.
The tragedy.
The blood.
The loss that shattered everything.

Dream-Kyoko swallowed hard.
Her hands trembled.
She steadied herself, lifting her chin.
"...Okay. I'm ready."

But her voice wavered.
Because even if she prepared...
Some truths always hurt.

Dream-Kyoko continued watching.

The real Kyoko walked home innocently, her steps light, her heart still glowing from the picnic she had just shared with Mami. The taste of custard taiyaki lingered sweetly on her tongue, laughter echoing faintly in her memory.

But as she approached her home, the air shifted.

Cries rang out from the church — desperate pleas for mercy.

Then a scream.

Her mother's scream.

Kyoko's eyes widened, her heart plummeting into her stomach.

Immediately, another scream followed — smaller, younger.

Momo's voice.

Then silence.

Kyoko's breath caught. Her chest constricted.

She sprinted toward the church, panic flooding her veins. Her mind raced in a storm of dread: *What's happening? What's happening to my family?*

The moment she entered, her legs gave out.

She collapsed to her knees, tears streaming down her face. Her voice broke into a whisper, trembling, disbelieving.

"This... this can't be real. This must be a dream. A nightmare..."

But it wasn't.

Her father stood in the center of the sanctuary.

His hands were shaking. His clothes were stained. His expression was twisted — grief and fury and something broken far beyond repair.

Her mother and Momo lay lifeless beside him, stabbed through the heart. Their clothes soaked in crimson, the church floor slick with blood.

Kyoko choked on a sob. Her hands fluttered uselessly at her sides, body frozen from despair.

Her father turned to her.

His eyes were hollow. Burning. The gaze of someone staring at something unholy.

"I know," he said. His voice was low, trembling with pain.

"I know everything."

Kyoko felt her stomach plunge. "E-everything...? What do you mean...?"

He began to pace, his gaze distant, as if recalling good times of old.

“I thought... I truly thought the congregation returned of their own free will. That they reflected on my words, saw merit, and understood them.”

His voice cracked, then hardened. He turned back to her, his eyes piercing, merciless.

Kyoko shuddered.

It was not the look of a father to his daughter.

It was the look of someone staring at the devil himself.

His eyes hardened. His voice sharpened to a blade.

“But it wasn’t their choice. It was yours.”

Kyoko flinched.

“You... you sold your soul to the devil. You made a wish to drag them back to me. To force them to listen to my sermons. You corrupted their hearts! You manipulated their souls!”

Her father’s voice rose, cracking with grief.

“My sermons... my words... all of it... a lie. Propped up by the devil you bargained with.”

His voice broke into a roar.

“Never have I felt so betrayed. So angry. So sad. That my own daughter — raised in the faith — would do such a thing!”

Kyoko’s breath caught. *How... how did he find out? Did Kyubey tell him?*

Her arm reached out, trembling, desperate, as if she could claw back what was lost.

“Father... that’s not true... I didn’t sell my soul to the devil... I—”

But he cut her off, his voice dripping with contempt.

“I will not hear the words of a demon.”

Those words pierced her deeper than any blade could.

His glare seared into her.

“Burn in hell, Kyoko! Burn with the devil you serve.”

Before she could plead, before she could breathe, before she could move, he turned the katana inward.

The blade pierced his stomach.

He collapsed, lifeless, beside the corpses of his wife and child.

Kyoko screamed.

Her voice tore through the church, raw and broken.

She sobbed heavily, crawling forward on weak legs. Her hands trembled as she caressed her mother's hair, her sister's face. She hugged them tightly, her cries echoing through the hollow chamber, reverberating against the stained glass.

Her sobs filled the space — agonized, helpless, begging for the world to rewind just a few minutes, just one moment, just enough to save them.

She clutched them like she could hold their warmth a little longer.

Her sobbing echoed against the stained glass until it felt like the entire church was crying with her.

Dream-Kyoko stood frozen.

The vision washed over her like a tidal wave. Her chest ached. Her breath trembled. She pressed her hand over her heart, her fingers curling tightly.

Mami told me what happened...

And my current real self explained it briefly to Sayaka in the projection yesterday...

But seeing it... feeling it through Connect...

It felt like the ground had split open beneath her.

It felt like her own family had been taken from her.

It felt like her own wish... had caused all of this.

Her fists clenched until her nails pressed into her palms.

"If... if this had happened to me..." she whispered, voice thick, shaking, "I—I don't know if I could have survived it. I don't know if I could have kept going..."

Her eyes squeezed shut. A breath shuddered out of her.

"...But I'm not the Kyoko who lived this," she whispered. "I'm different. I've learned so much here, from Lunaria, from Kasumi, from everyone. I've grown. I refuse to let this break me."

Her voice wavered — but behind the hurt, a spark of fierce determination flickered.

She opened her eyes.

Because she knew the next wound was coming.

The memory of the break.

The moment where real Kyoko and Mami's bond — the bright, happy friendship she had just witnessed — began to shatter.

Dream-Kyoko swallowed hard.

She had to see it.

She needed to understand.

Her eyes narrowed, bracing for the next blow.

“Show me...” she whispered.

Evening settled over Mitakihara like a gentle sigh.

The sky held the last glimmer of twilight — soft ribbons of violet, peach, and gold stretching across the horizon before fading into the deepening blue of night. The streetlamps had just begun to flicker awake, their warm halos shimmering through the cooling air. Far beyond, the city hum was distant, almost muted, like the world itself was holding its breath.

Mami waited where she and Kyoko always met — a quiet patch of grass beside an old stone walkway. It was a familiar rendezvous point, close enough to the city to hear life, far enough to feel like their own little refuge.

Her musket rested loosely against her shoulder, ribbons gently drifting, responding to the breeze like soft golden fireflies.

Then she saw her.

Kyoko.

Mami’s face brightened instantly. She raised her hand, waving with her usual lady-like enthusiasm.

“Kyoko! Over here!”

She expected the usual response — a big wave, a cocky grin, maybe Kyoko shouting something like *“Don’t start without me, granny!”* or *“Bet I’ll beat you to the first familiar!”* before sprinting over.

But Kyoko... didn’t even lift her head.

Mami blinked. Her smile faltered.

Kyoko’s steps were slow. Uneven. Heavy.

She walked like she was dragging chains behind her — invisible, but unbearably real.

Mami felt a prickling sensation crawl down her spine.

She called again, softer, uncertain:

“...Kyoko?”

Still nothing.

Mami broke into a run, ribbons trailing behind her like golden streamers.

When she reached her side, Mami’s breath caught.

Kyoko's eyes were swollen and red. Tears streamed freely down her cheeks, leaving shining tracks. Her lips quivered with every breath. Her shoulders trembled under the weight of something crushing — something unbearable.

But worse — her Soul Gem.

The crimson jewel that normally glowed with rebellious fire was dim. Clouded. Corrupted. Dark streaks pulsed visibly beneath the surface, twisting like storm clouds inside glass.

Mami's heart lurched.

“Kyoko...”

Kyoko didn't speak.

She didn't even look up.

She just... collapsed.

She fell into Mami with the full force of someone who had been desperately holding herself together until the very last second. Her arms wrapped around Mami's waist, her face pressing into her chest, her tears soaking through the fabric of Mami's outfit.

Then came the sound.

A raw, shattered wail — torn straight from the deepest part of her heart.

It ripped into the quiet evening, echoing across the empty grass. Mami froze, stunned. She'd never heard Kyoko cry like this. Not even close.

This wasn't frustration.

This wasn't anger.

This wasn't just grief.

This was *pure devastation*.

Mami's own chest tightened painfully. Hours ago, Kyoko had been smiling — laughing with her under the trees, crumbs of taiyaki on her lips, making stupid jokes. It had been peaceful, warm. Normal.

What could possibly have crushed her like this?

Kyoko's voice broke through her thoughts — tiny, muffled, trembling:

“They're... they're all gone... Mami... my family... they're... they're dead...because of me...”

Mami inhaled sharply.

Her world tilted.

Her mind reeled.

Her family? How? Why? What happened? Did a witch attack? Was she blaming herself for something she couldn't control?

She didn't know.

She couldn't process it yet.

But she didn't let go.

Mami wrapped her arms around Kyoko, firm yet gentle, one hand stroking her crimson hair with slow, soothing motions.

"Kyoko," she whispered, voice steady despite the trembling in her heart, "it's all right to cry. I'm here. I won't leave you. Not tonight. Not ever."

Kyoko's sobs shook her entire body. But slowly, painfully, they began to soften — not because she felt better, but because she was exhausted from crying.

After a long, aching moment, Kyoko pulled back just enough to speak. Her voice cracked like shattered glass.

"...Thank you, Mami."

She wiped her face with her sleeve, only for fresh tears to fall.

"I... I think I can talk. I'll... try."

Mami nodded, her smile warm but tinged with worry.

"Whenever you're ready. I'll listen."

They settled onto the grass, sitting close, knees almost touching. The faint glow of Mami's ribbons curled around them like a protective cocoon — not binding, not strict, but comforting. A gentle barrier between Kyoko and the rest of the world.

Kyoko stared at the ground, fists clenched tightly in her lap. Her tears dripped onto her knuckles. Every breath she took trembled.

Mami watched her with deep, unshaken compassion.

She didn't rush her.

She didn't push.

She simply waited — the way only Mami Tomoe could.

Her voice soft, kind, unwavering.

"I'm right here, Kyoko."

Mami's voice wavered as she leaned forward, hands folded in her lap, her ribbons gently curling and uncurling like worried fingers.

“Kyoko... please. Tell me more. What did you mean... when you said your family died because of you?”

Kyoko lifted her head slowly. Her eyes were swollen and rimmed red, lashes clumped together with tears. The moonlight caught the wetness on her cheeks, making them shimmer in uneven streaks.

She tried to speak, but her words came broken — stuttering, muffled by sobs, each syllable dragged out of her like it hurt to breathe.

“I... I was walking home...”

She swallowed, the motion stiff and painful.

“After our picnic...”

Her voice cracked on the word *picnic* — the memory too bright, too warm in contrast to what came after.

“I was still smiling,” she whispered. “Still thinking about you. About us. About the stupid taiyaki filling on your nose...”

A tiny, hollow laugh escaped her — instantly crushed by grief.

“And then... I heard it.”

Her entire body tensed. Her fingers curled into her skirt so tightly the fabric strained.

“The screams.”

Her breath hitched.

“My mother’s voice... begging. And then—”

She shut her eyes, tears spilling anew.

“My little sister. Momo. Just for a moment. And then... nothing.”

The final word fell like a stone.

Mami’s breath caught. Her ribbons quivered faintly in the air, reflecting her shock.

Kyoko’s tears fell faster as she continued, her words tumbling out in fragments.

“I ran... I ran as fast as I could... I knew something was wrong... I knew...”

She squeezed her eyes shut again, covering her face with trembling palms, fingers digging into her skin as if she could block out the memory.

“When I got there...”

Her voice broke completely.

“...they were already gone. My mother... Momo... both of them... dead. Killed by my father.”

The words were fragile, as if saying them aloud threatened to shatter her completely.

Her hand instinctively rose to her mouth. The horror in her chest felt physical — heavy, tightening, suffocating.

“Kyoko... no... that’s... that’s terrible... why... why would he...?”

Her words faltered. She couldn’t finish the thought.

Her hand reached out instinctively, resting gently on Kyoko’s trembling shoulder. She wanted to comfort her, but the enormity of what she had just heard left her speechless.

Kyoko’s sobs deepened, her body shaking violently now.

“And then he—he looked at me. My dad. And he said he... he knew everything.”

Mami blinked.

“Everything...? About your wish?”

Kyoko nodded, her voice breaking.

“He knew... that I made a wish... so people would listen to his sermons again. He knew it wasn’t because they chose to... it was because of me.”

Mami’s heart lurched.

How did he find out? Did Kyubey tell him?

But before she could ask, Kyoko’s voice rose, raw and trembling.

“He said... I sold my soul to the devil. That my wish corrupted people’s hearts. That everything in his life... his sermons, his faith... all of it... was a lie.”

Her sobs tore through her words. She pressed her hands over her face, shaking her head violently.

“He called me a demon, Mami. He looked at me... with such hatred... like I wasn’t his daughter, like I wasn’t even human. He told me to burn in hell... with the devil I serve...”

A choked sound tore out of her — half cry, half gasp.

“And then... he... he killed himself. Right in front of me.”

Kyoko collapsed forward, burying herself against Mami again, her cries echoing through the night.

“They’re gone!”

Her voice broke into raw, shaking cries.

“They all died because of me! Because of my wish! If I hadn’t—if I hadn’t—”

Mami’s arms wrapped around her tightly, her own eyes shimmering with tears. She stroked Kyoko’s hair, her voice soft, steady, unwavering despite the ache in her chest.

“Kyoko,” Mami whispered, her voice thick with her own unshed tears, “please... don’t say that.”

She stroked Kyoko’s hair, slow and rhythmic, the way one comforts a child awake from a nightmare.

“You made a wish because you loved them. Because you wanted to protect what you believed mattered.”

Kyoko shook her head wildly, sobs surfacing again.

Mami held her tighter — firm, warm, present.

“You aren’t a demon,” she whispered.

“You never were. You’re a girl who loved her family so much it hurt. A girl who wanted to save them. A girl who tried.”

Her words were gentle, but her heart was breaking.

Kyoko wailed louder, wrestling with the storm inside her. Conflicting thoughts tore at her — guilt, grief, rage, despair. Her world had shattered, and she was left clutching the fragments, bleeding from every edge.

Mami held her tighter, refusing to let go.

“You don’t have to carry this alone. I’m here. I’ll stay with you. Even if it hurts. Even if it takes time. I’m not leaving.”

Dream-Kyoko stood in the quiet shimmer of the Connect space, unable to move.

Her heart was heavy — swollen with warmth, aching with dread.

She had watched herself — the “real” her — collapse into Mami’s arms.

Watched Mami hold her with patience and tenderness.

Watched kindness ease agony, even if only for a moment.

It made her feel blessed — truly blessed — to have Mami as her friend. She was more grateful for their bond than ever before.

Mami tried her best. She stayed. She didn’t run away. She was there when the “real” me needed her most.

A tiny smile formed on Dream-Kyoko’s lips — a bittersweet, fleeting warmth.

“If that’s how she comforted me,” she whispered to herself, “then... how did we ever fall apart?”

Her chest tightened.

Mami and the real Kyoko had looked so close. So connected. So *right* together.

So then... what was “that day”?

The day Mami referenced with that sad look in her eyes.
The day real Kyoko hardened.
The day the fire inside her burned differently — no longer bright, but angry and lonely.
She braced herself. Her heart throbbed with anticipation and dread.

The memory shifted.

Warm twilight melted away in a blink, replaced by the sharp, cold air of late night.
The outskirts of Mitakihara stretched out in pale silvers and stark shadows.
The wind carried the metallic hum of magic — tense, unstable, ready to snap.
Mami and real Kyoko stood opposite each other.
Mami's ribbons hovered in a wide circle around her, pulsing gold.
Kyoko held her spear loosely, tipping it back and forth as if she had done this dance a thousand times.
Dream-Kyoko gasped.
“What—? We were just talking... just crying... how did it come to this?”

Mami's voice cut through the darkness, sharp and hurt.
“Kyoko! Why did you attack me? Why did you knock me aside when I was going after that familiar?”
Her golden musket flared into existence, glowing with righteous fury.
“It got away because of you!”
Kyoko scraped the heel of her shoe across the pavement, planting the butt of her spear into the ground with a thud.
“Why waste time?” she said flatly. “Familiars aren't worth the effort. They don't drop grief seeds. Better to wait until they turn into witches.”
Mami's face twisted with disbelief.
“Kyoko... familiars hurt people! They take lives. We have to stop them *before* they grow into witches!”
Kyoko shrugged — cold, dismissive.
“Not my problem.”
The words were a slap.
Dream-Kyoko flinched.
Wait, this is me?!
She didn't recognize her real future self — drained, brittle, apathetic, eyes hollowed by grief.

Mami's eyes widened in disbelief, her voice cracked.

"Kyoko... have you gone insane? You're not the same since your family died. You used to be kind. You used to fight to protect others."

Kyoko chuckled bitterly, her voice tinged with sorrow.

"Go insane? How could I *not*? My entire family died because of my wish."

She tightened her grip on her spear.

"And a part of me died with them."

Mami faltered, ribbons drooping slightly like wounded limbs. They had had this conversation before. She spoke slowly, gently, trying to reach Kyoko.

"I've told you many times, Kyoko... their deaths weren't your fault. Your wish was pure. Your wish came from love. You wanted to save them from starvation. Please don't keep blaming yourself."

Kyoko scoffed, her voice sharp.

"What do you know?"

Mami's froze, eyes wide.

"...What?"

Kyoko's gaze pierced her, crimson eyes burning.

"You made your wish *after* your parents died, didn't you? You made a wish just for yourself. You didn't carry the kind of regret I did."

Her voice cracked — but her words stayed sharp, cutting.

"You never had to live knowing your wish had consequences for the people you loved."

The words struck Mami's heart like a knife.

Her breath caught. Her ribbons faltered in the air. Her composure wavered.

Dream-Kyoko felt her own stomach twist.

"No... no, don't say it like that..." she whispered helplessly.

Mami's voice trembled, but she forced it steady.

"...Even if I can't fully understand your pain, Kyoko... Even if our situations are different... I know what loneliness feels like. I understand the pain of losing your family. I was alone for a long time."

Her eyes softened, her lips curving into a fragile smile.

"That is...until I met you. You saved me, Kyoko. You gave me someone to rely on."

She stepped forward, ribbons curling gently, not as weapons but as an embrace.

“Kyoko... please. Let’s keep working together. Let’s continue helping people. We both lost our families... but we don’t have to be alone.”

For a moment — a heartbeat — the night stilled.

Dream-Kyoko felt it.

Mami’s sincerity. Her longing. Her hope.

But real Kyoko...

Her eyes flickered.

Not with warmth — but with pain too deep to soothe.

Bitterness twisted into something harsher.

Her grip tightened on her spear.

Dream-Kyoko felt her breath catch.

“...This is it,” she whispered.

“This is where it starts. The moment we begin to slip away from each other.”

Regret welled in her chest — sharp and breathless.

She didn’t want to see it.

But she had to.

For Mami.

For herself.

For the bond they were building now through Connect.

The fracture had begun.

And the memory was about to show how deep it would cut.

Real Kyoko stood perfectly still, her spear balanced against her shoulder as if it weighed nothing. But her silence weighed on everything.

Dream-Kyoko felt her throat tighten.

Her future self’s expression was unreadable — neither angry nor calm.

Just... blank.

Quiet in a way that felt wrong.

Mami waited, breath trembling, ribbons flickering like candle flames struggling not to go out.

Finally, Real Kyoko spoke.

Her voice was cold, flat, stripped of its old warmth:

“Alone... yes. That’s a good way to live.”

Mami’s eyes went wide, disbelief flooding her face.

“What... what did you just say?”

Kyoko’s gaze hardened.

“Exactly what I said. I’ll live alone from now on. I’ll fight for myself, and only for myself. If you want to save people, then do it. But I won’t.”

Her words fell like frost.

Mami staggered as though physically struck.

“You can’t be serious... Kyoko, please—just listen—”

But Kyoko continued, each sentence firmer than the last.

“I won’t fight familiars. I won’t protect anyone. I’ll only fight witches for grief seeds. That’s all I need to survive.”

Mami reached out, her voice trembling, almost pleading.

“Kyoko... please reconsider. If you don’t want to fight familiars with me, fine. But at least help me fight witches. Witch battles are easier with you around.”

Her voice cracked.

“I... I need you.”

Kyoko scoffed, sharp and dismissive.

“What good would working together be? We’d have to share the grief seed. That’s inefficient. And besides...”

Her grip tightened on her spear. Her voice cracked faintly.

“...I can’t use my enchantment magic anymore. Not since my family died. I’d only slow you down.”

Dream-Kyoko’s eyes went wide, her breath catching.

So... my real self lost enchantment magic after my family died?

Her thoughts raced.

It must be a mental block. I blamed myself so deeply... that I unconsciously sealed away the very magic

tied to my wish. The wish to ‘enchant’ people to listen to my father’s sermons... the wish that ended in tragedy.

Mami’s voice rose, desperate, trembling at the thought of losing her only friend.

“I don’t care if you’re weaker! I don’t care if we have to share grief seeds! That just means you’ll have to grow stronger in other ways. I’ll help you. I’ll support you. Kyoko, please... don’t shut me out.”

Her hands trembled. Her voice was raw and earnest.

“You’re my friend. Isn’t that enough?”

Real Kyoko looked down for a moment — and for a heartbeat, Dream-Kyoko saw the sorrow flicker in her eyes.

Real Kyoko gave a forlorn laugh.

“Mami... I appreciate everything you’ve done for me. Truly. Even now, you’re trying so hard to help. You were the only one who stayed by me when everything fell apart.”

Her tone softened — then cracked.

“But I don’t want to drag you down. I don’t want you to sacrifice anything for me.”

Her voice grew sharper, bitter.

“Just like how I won’t sacrifice anything for anyone else anymore. I made a wish for others once — for my family — and look what happened. If helping people leads to nothing but tragedy, then I won’t help anyone ever again.”

Mami let out an anguished cry. Her ribbons fluttered wildly, her muskets orbiting faster, reflecting the storm inside her.

“That’s not living, Kyoko... that’s just punishing yourself! You don’t understand what you’re saying. Loneliness... it crushes the soul. I know. I lived it. I was depressed, broken, when I became an orphan. Fighting witches alone nearly destroyed me. I can’t bear to see you live like that.”

Her voice softened, tears spilling down her cheeks.

“And... I don’t want to be lonely again either.”

Dream-Kyoko felt her own chest tighten painfully.

Mami...

Kyoko watched her, sighing as she saw Mami's magic flare in anguish. The golden ribbons whipped around her, muskets spinning faster, her emotions bleeding into her power.

Kyoko's expression hardened.

"If you're going to try this hard to drag me back," Kyoko said, her tone both tired and defensive, "then I guess we're going to keep fighting."

She raised her spear.

Sparks flickered along its edge.

Her crimson eyes hardened — sorrow mixing with defiance.

"Mami... if you really want to stop me... then you'll have to make me."

Mami lifted her muskets, her ribbons snapping taut with tension.

Her voice trembled, but her resolve stood firm:

"Then come at me, Kyoko."

The night broke.

"Kyoko!"

"Mami!"

They charged, gold and crimson streaking across the empty streets.

Spear against ribbon.

Musketfire against diamond walls.

Magic collided with magic — each strike laced with emotion they couldn't voice.

Every crash of their weapons echoed with memories:

of taiyaki picnics,

warm smiles,

shared victories,

shared loneliness.

The battlefield lit up with sparks — the visible unraveling of what their hearts once relied on.

A bond tearing open under the weight of grief.

A friendship cracking apart in the space between them.

And Dream-Kyoko stood in the middle of it all — forced to watch the moment she wished she could have changed.

The clash between real Kyoko and Mami unfolded like a tragic ballet — a duet of gold and crimson painted across the darkened outskirts of Mitakihara.

Two magical girls who had once moved in perfect harmony, who had laughed together, eaten together, relied on one another... now fought with that very familiarity turned against them.

Every swing, every shot, every ribbon lash carried history.

Every block was born from knowing exactly how the other fought.

Every counter was a memory.

This was not a battle of enemies.

It was a battle of *ideals*.

A battle of *hearts*.

One trying desperately to preserve a bond that once saved her life.

The other trying just as desperately to sever it before it could hurt her again.

Dream-Kyoko watched with tight, burning eyes.

Her heart throbbed with grief — and, she admitted to herself, awe.

The intensity.

The passion.

The raw emotion carried in every spark of magic.

It was beautiful in the way only tragic things can be.

She let out a small, breathy chuckle.

“This could almost pass as a duel between close friends in the arena... a fight to test each other’s strength, to push each other’s limits, not to break hearts. If only it were that...”

A faint smile touched her lips.

“I wonder who ‘won’ this fight...”

But the smile faded, hollowing at the edges.

“...It must have been me. The real me. If they broke ties after this.”

The battlefield crackled with magic — gold meeting red in violent arcs.

Golden sparks from Mami’s ribbons.

Crimson sparks from Kyoko’s spear.

Mami and Kyoko stood panting, exhaustion weighing down their shoulders. Their Soul Gems dimmed, reflecting the toll not just on their bodies but on their hearts.

Mami extended her arm. A ring of muskets flared into existence and fired in a synchronized barrage.

Kyoko’s diamond barriers rose instantly, blocking the shots with sharp crystalline echoes. She dashed forward, pushing the barriers like battering rams.

Mami's ribbons lashed out, intertwining with her musket fire. The combined force shattered the diamond walls into shards.

Kyoko leapt acrobatically into the air, spear extending, its tip aimed straight at Mami with precision.

Mami jumped to meet her, muskets blazing.

Kyoko conjured more diamond walls midair, blocking the bullets.

Kyoko's spear split into segmented staves, whipping outward like chains. They coiled around Mami and wrapped her tight.

Kyoko's grin flashed — a familiar, mischievous grin, but twisted by exhaustion and grief.

"Checkmate," Kyoko said as she pulled Mami close.

Dream-Kyoko's eyes widened.

I... I actually won?

But as Mami was pulled close, she smiled.

Soft.

Sad.

Unshaken.

Her voice was calm, steady.

"Checkmate."

Real Kyoko blinked, startled.

"What—?"

Her segmented spear pieces fell away from Mami as if pushed aside.

In their place, Mami's ribbons unfurled — dozens of them — wrapping smoothly, inevitably, around Kyoko.

Mami and Kyoko crashed to the ground, Kyoko bound tight.

Mami stood over her, the glow of her ribbons softening into something pained and earnest.

"When I saw you trying to bind me, I wrapped myself in my ribbons. I knew you'd pull me in close, confident you had me. But when you did... I used my ribbons to push back your bindings and free myself. And then... I bound you instead."

Dream-Kyoko let out a warm laugh, her eyes soft.

"As expected of Mami... my mentor, through and through."

But real Kyoko only grimaced, refusing to look at her captor.

She had lost.

And Mami — heart trembling — looked down at her with pleading eyes.

“Kyoko... please.”

Her voice quivered.

“Please reconsider. Don’t throw everything away. We can still help people together. You don’t have to do this. You don’t have to be alone. Please stay with me...”

Kyoko closed her eyes.

Her voice came quiet — too quiet — but firm.

“No.”

Mami’s breath stuttered.

“Kyoko...”

But Kyoko continued, sharper now:

“I won’t use my magic for anyone else again. I’ll live for myself. Only myself.”

Mami’s shoulders shook. Tears gathered in her lashes.

“Please, Kyoko, just—”

But Kyoko snapped her eyes open, fury and grief intertwined.

“Please what?! Why can’t you accept my answer?! Why can’t you leave me alone?!”

Her voice cut like ice.

“I’ve already decided. You can’t change it.”

She smirked, defiant, almost daring.

“Go ahead. Hurt me. Crush me with your ribbons. Blast me with your muskets. Kill me if you want. It won’t change anything.”

Kyoko let the cruel smirk falter into something smaller — weary, broken.

“At this point, Mami... nothing can.”

Something inside Mami collapsed.

Her ribbons slackened.

Her muskets flickered out like dying stars.

Her knees buckled beneath her and she sank to the ground.

Her best friend — the light that once rescued her from loneliness — was shutting her out completely.

And she couldn’t bring herself to fight back, to hurt her friend.

The golden ribbons fell away.

Mami dropped forward onto her hands, shoulders shaking.

Dream-Kyoko felt her heart wrench painfully.

This... this is where Mami broke...

Real Kyoko stood slowly. She brushed dust from her cloak, from her hair — small, habitual motions to fill the silence.

“I knew it,” she muttered bitterly. “You’re too soft to force my hand.”

She gave a hollow, almost mocking smile.

“So I guess I got the last laugh. Checkmate.”

But when she looked down at Mami one last time, her expression softened — so quietly it almost wasn’t there.

“All teasing aside... thank you, Mami. For everything.”

Her voice was soft.

Earnest.

And impossibly sad.

“I wish you the best.”

She turned away, spear resting against her shoulder like old armor.

“Farewell, old friend...”

And she walked off into the night.

Mami didn’t follow.

Didn’t call out.

Didn’t stand.

She stayed kneeling there, folded in on herself, the weight of loneliness crushing her chest like a vice.

For a long moment, the world was silent.

Then Mami lifted her head, eyes burning with heartbreak.

A sound tore from her — a raw, anguished cry — echoing across the dark streets of Mitakihara.

A sound shaped by grief, isolation, and the shattering of the last fragile bond she had held onto.

A sound of a soul breaking.

Dream-Kyoko covered her mouth, trembling.

“...Mami...”

The echo of that scream lingered long after the memory dissolved.

And she knew:

This was the moment their paths diverged.

The wound they both carried for years.

The tragedy she wished she could rewrite.

Through Connect, Dream-Kyoko was pulled into Mami's world — into her past, into her pain.

Every emotion, every ache, every trembling thought vibrated through her like a second heartbeat.

She saw what Mami saw.

She felt what Mami felt.

The boundary between witness and sufferer blurred into a single, fragile thread.

Mami's broken cry rattled through her bones.

Mami's despair pressed down upon her heart like wet winter snow.

The battlefield dissolved.

The echo of that anguished scream stretched and faded, thinning into silence.

And then—

She was in Mami's room.

Morning sunlight spilled softly through lace curtains, casting delicate patterns across the floorboards — warm, peaceful, serene. It should have felt comforting.

But Mami was anything but warm and at peace.

“No... Kyoko... please! Don't leave me...”

Her voice was a shattered whisper in the morning light.

Mami awoke with a sharp inhale, breath catching as though surfacing from deep water. Tears clung to her lashes. Her pillow was damp. Her cheeks glistened. Her eyes carried that cold, prickling tightness — the unmistakable sting of having cried in her sleep yet again.

“That dream again...” she murmured, barely audible.

The memory resurfaced with cruel clarity — Kyoko turning away, her voice firm and final, the bond severed like a ribbon torn in half.

She pushed herself upright, pressing a hand against her chest as if to steady her heart. Her room was immaculate, elegant, every detail arranged with gentle care — soft pastels, delicate teaware, neat shelves.

But everywhere Dream-Kyoko looked, she saw them.

Photos.

Lots of them.

Warm snapshots capturing fleeting joy: Mami laughing beside Kyoko during training, Mami holding out a plate of pastries, Kyoko grinning with her cheeks full, both girls leaning close with an ease born only from love and trust.

To Mami, they were anchors. Pieces of a vanished happiness she refused to let go of.

Mami's fingertips brushed one frame — Kyoko mid-bite, stuffing taiyaki into her mouth while Mami hid a giggle behind her hand.

Her throat tightened.

"I can't throw them away..." she whispered, voice trembling.

"Even if it hurts... I want to remember that I wasn't always alone."

Dream-Kyoko felt the sting of guilt pierce through her — sharp, sudden, unsteady.

Mami prepared breakfast in silence: steamed rice, a perfect tamagoyaki, miso soup, tea. She ate quietly, mechanically.

Another day.

Another morning alone.

She showered, brushed her hair, dressed neatly in her uniform.

And then stood before the mirror.

Her reflection smiled back: elegant, mature, composed.

A model student.

A girl who couldn't possibly break.

Mami inhaled slowly, lifting her chin as the mask settled into place — a smile polished until it shone, a confidence practiced until it looked natural.

But no matter how lovingly she crafted the expression, that smile never reached her eyes.

It never reached her soul.

The vision shifted, colors blurring into the soft pastels of Mitakihara's hallways. Students streamed past in flocks — laughing, chatting, weaving around each other like currents of bright energy.

The hum of youth, warm and interconnected.

Mami walked among them like a ghost wearing flesh — flawless posture, perfect greetings, her serene smile a carefully maintained façade.

"Tomi-senpai!"

"You look beautiful today!"

"Good morning!"

"Good morning to you all as well," Mami replied gently, every motion smooth, elegant, immaculate.

A pair of girls approached her, excited and earnest.

“We’re going shopping after school! That limited-edition makeup is on sale—”

“And it would look SOOO good on you!”

“Wanna come with us? It’ll be fun!”

For a split second, something real flickered across Mami’s face — a tiny spark of warmth, fragile and bright.

A genuine smile, small but alive.

They’re asking me... they’re asking me...!

They want to spend time with me...

Are they... trying to be my friends?

But then — reality.

Mami had plans.

Not trivial plans.

Not optional plans.

A magical girl’s nightly duty: fighting familiars, hunting witches, protecting a city that never knew her name.

She needed grief seeds.

She needed time.

She needed to fight.

Alone.

Her fingers tightened around the strap of her schoolbag. Her smile softened — polite, grateful, distant.

“Thank you for inviting me. I’m truly honored. But I already have plans today. Maybe... some other time.”

The girls pouted in sympathy.

“Aww, bummer...”

“Next time then, Mami!”

“If your plans change, come find us!”

They waved cheerfully and walked off together, chatting excitedly about brands, colors, and sales.

When they disappeared down the hall, Mami closed her eyes.

Her shoulders trembled.

Her lips quivered.

Everyone is so kind to me... even though we aren’t friends.

So why...

Why can’t I have a normal life like theirs?

She blinked the tears away, forcing her breathing calm.

At lunch, Mami ate alone at her desk.

Her bento was beautifully prepared — bright, balanced, carefully arranged.

But she barely tasted it.

Her eyes drifted across the classroom.

Everywhere she looked, there were groups — friends leaning over each other's desks, sharing bites of lunch, laughing loudly, complaining about tests, whispering secrets.

The air was full of warmth.

Belonging.

Connection.

And there she sat — silent, isolated, staring into a world just out of reach.

Her chopsticks trembled faintly between her fingers.

It looked so much like the days she once ate alongside Kyoko.

Those moments felt impossibly distant, like dreams slipping through her grasp.

Dream-Kyoko's throat tightened.

Mami... you never had anyone to sit with...

Not after me?

Classes ended.

Mami's solitude lengthened, stretching behind her like a second shadow.

She walked alone through fading sunlight, down quiet streets toward the city's darker corners — the places where witches bred malice like rot beneath the floorboards.

Ribbons danced through the air in golden arcs.

Muskets flared in rhythmic bursts.

Her battles were elegant, almost beautiful — but each movement carried weight.

A hollow heaviness.

A tired ache deep in her soul.

She fought not because she wanted to — but because it was all she had left.

A duty that filled the time where friendship had once lived.

When battles ended, life continued around her, vibrant and unaware.

Parents walking home together.

Siblings teasing each other.

Couples laughing beside shop windows.
Groups of friends deciding on dinner plans, bumping shoulders as they teased each other.
Mami slowed, watching them quietly.

I'm glad...
I'm glad they can smile like this.
That they can live safely.

But each sight made her chest tighten.
Her eyes pricked with tears she forced down.
Her lips trembled.

If my parents were still alive...
If Kyoko was still with me...
We'd be like that.
We'd be happy.

She swallowed the thought and walked on.

Returning home, the silence greeted her like an old companion — familiar, heavy, suffocating.

Groceries down.
Dinner prepared.
Table set.

For one.

Then tea.

Dream-Kyoko's breath hitched when Mami set out a second cup — gentle, delicate, placed with the care one gives to someone loved.

She poured tea for the empty chair.

For a moment, the air shifted.
The apartment glowed warmly, as if lit from within by memory itself.

There was Kyoko — the Kyoko of Mami's heart — sitting casually with legs swaying, grin wide, cheeks stuffed with pastries, making loud slurping noises with her tea.

Mami laughed softly in the vision, telling her to slow down before she choked.

The illusion felt real. Warm. Alive.

Then Mami blinked.
And the world snapped back.

The chair was empty.
The room was silent.
Her hands trembled.

Her breath cracked.
Her face crumpled.

She covered her eyes and wept — openly, painfully — all the emotions she'd bottled throughout the day spilling out in broken sobs.

Dream-Kyoko felt the grief slam into her like a collapsing star.
Her knees nearly buckled from the weight of it.

At night, Mami curled beneath her blankets.
Her sobs were soft, muffled — the kind meant to remain unseen, unheard.
Sobs meant for no one.

Because there was no one to hear them.

Each tear echoed through Dream-Kyoko's chest like shards of glass.

This is what she lived with...

Every day...

Every night...

Because I walked away.

She pressed a hand against her heart.

Her whole body trembled with grief, sorrow, fury — all tangled into one unbearable knot.

"That idiot... that damn Kyoko..." she whispered, voice thick.

"She made Mami suffer like this. If I ever meet her — I'll beat some sense into her."

It wasn't hatred.

It wasn't spite.

It was pain.

Regret.

Self-directed fury.

Rage at the version of herself who had left Mami alone in a world too cold for one person to bear.

The memory began to dim, fading at the edges, but the ache it left behind did not.

It settled deep within Dream-Kyoko's heart, heavy and sharp, an inescapable truth:

Mami's loneliness wasn't merely tragic.

It was a wound — one she had never let heal.

A wound Kyoko herself had created.

A wound that had never stopped bleeding.

And Dream-Kyoko knew she could no longer turn away.

But then—

A spark lit in her eyes.

The grief did not vanish, but something else rose beside it — defiance, determination, a dangerous sort of hope.

“Wait... my real future self said she can’t use her enchantment magic anymore, right?”

A slow grin spread across her face — mischievous, bright, unmistakably Kyoko.

“Oh-hoh... I know exactly what to do with you, future me.”

She cracked her knuckles.

“You just wait!”

Mami’s prespective

Mami was enveloped by warm light.

It wrapped around her like a silken cocoon — soft, radiant, pulsing with a heartbeat not her own. Her breath caught. Her pulse fluttered with a mixture of anticipation and fear.

What will I learn about this version of Kyoko?

Dream-Kyoko had warned her.

Warned her with that shaky little smile.

Said she was afraid of what Mami might see — that her past wasn’t all sparkles and sunshine.

Would this Connect reveal hardship?

Loneliness?

A childhood as broken as her future counterpart’s?

But... this Kyoko, the summoned one, had been saved before tragedy struck.

Before bitterness sank its claws into her heart.

Before she severed their bond.

What kind of world raised a Kyoko like that?

The light pulsed stronger.

Her heart beat faster.

Excitement tangled with apprehension.

Then—

The light burst outward.

And Mami gasped.

She stood in a world unlike any she had ever seen.

A **celestial garden** floated in the sky, suspended between heaven and horizon.

The heavens above were a breathtaking expanse of clear blue, washed in a golden glow that felt both dawnlike and eternal.

Clouds in hues of rose and peach drifted lazily, glowing faintly like illuminated silk.

At the garden's center rose a crystalline fountain.

Its waters cascaded into a radiant pool, shimmering with an inner light that broke into a thousand tiny rainbows.

From that pool, countless miniature rivers branched out, flowing gently through the grass — silver veins threading across the landscape.

They twinkled as they wound around hills, trees, and clusters of luminous flowers.

The grass beneath Mami's feet was impossibly lush, soft as velvet, glittering faintly with dew that smelled faintly of sugar.

Trees of every color imaginable stretched their branches skyward — leaves shimmering like stained glass, fruit glowing like lanterns.

Flowers bloomed in radiant clusters, petals shining with pastel light.

Animals roamed freely:

Birds with iridescent wings spiraled through the sky, leaving trails of glitter.

White rabbits chased each other in dizzying circles.

Deer grazed peacefully under trees heavy with golden fruit.

Fish leapt playfully through rivers as though performing for the sun.

The air thrummed with harmony — a subtle symphony of rippling water, rustling leaves, soft wings. Every sound blended into a peaceful melody.

Mami's eyes widened.

Her breath trembled free of her lungs.

“This... looks like heaven...”

Her words dissolved into the air like a prayer.

Then she saw her.

Beside the radiant pool, lying on the soft grass, was Kyoko — Dream-Kyoko — sprawled peacefully, like a child napping on a warm afternoon.

Her eyes were closed.

Her breathing was slow, steady.

Crimson hair spilled around her shoulders in soft waves, catching the light like threads of ruby.

Mami's heart softened painfully.

*This must be Dream-Kyoko's past... the world that held her after her essence was saved in this realm.
Is this where her essence lives?*

Kyoko stirred.

Her lashes fluttered.

She yawned, slow and adorable, stretching like a lazy cat, rubbing her eyes with the heel of her hand.
Her expression shifted from groggy to bewildered in a heartbeat.

She sat up, blinking around.

The fountain's spray sparkled like falling stars.

The pool shimmered beneath her like liquid crystal.

Kyoko leaned forward, peering into the water.

Dozens of jewel-toned fish darted between ripples, their scales shimmering like gems beneath sunlight.

She reached down, brushing her fingers against the surface.

The water was impossibly cool, impossibly clean — so pure it felt like touching glass.

Fish swam up to nudge her fingertips, affectionate and curious.

Kyoko giggled — a bright, genuine laugh full of wonder.

She began moving her hand in a soft, fluid motion, like a jellyfish drifting in the sea.

The fish followed eagerly, weaving around her fingers, turning her simple gesture into a playful dance.

Kyoko looked up, eyes wide as she took in the garden.

The endless green.

The radiant fruit.

The animals leaping, chasing, singing.

Rivers dancing like silver ribbons.

She closed her eyes and inhaled deeply.

The air was crisp, floral, sweet — tinged with a strange fruity brightness that made every breath feel refreshing.

Her shoulders relaxed.

Her lips curved into a smile.

"It feels... alive."

She stood, wandering to the nearest tree — its branches heavy with glowing fruit.

One caught her attention, pulsing with a gentle pink light.

She plucked it.

Its skin was smooth and warm beneath her fingertips, as if filled with sunlight.

She took a bite—

Her eyes widened.

The taste was indescribable: sweet like honey, soft like peach, bursting with a delicate floral flavor. Juice trickled down her chin. She laughed softly, wiping it away with the back of her hand.

Then, quietly, almost to herself, she murmured:

“Where... where am I? I don’t remember... what happened before I woke up here...”

Her words floated lazily into the breeze, carried away before they could settle.

Mami watched her — this carefree Kyoko, this gentle Kyoko, this Kyoko untouched by bitterness — and her heart swelled.

Through Connect, their senses intertwined.

Mami didn’t just *observe* Kyoko’s world.

She **saw** everything Kyoko saw.

She **felt** everything Kyoko felt.

The warmth of the sun on Kyoko’s skin.

The soft tickle of grass beneath her palms.

The cool purity of the water touching her fingers.

The sweetness bursting across her tongue when she bit into the glowing fruit.

And beneath it all —

the gentle rhythm of Kyoko’s emotions.

Warmth.

Tenderness.

Peace so deep it felt like a lullaby humming through Mami’s chest.

This radiant world...

this celestial garden...

was Kyoko’s sanctuary.

A place where she could laugh freely,

where she could breathe without fear,

where she could simply **be**, untouched by the weight of tragedy.

And Mami realized, with a painful clarity:

This was the Kyoko she had always wished she could meet.

The Kyoko she had believed existed beneath the scars.

The Kyoko whose smile she had longed to protect.

A Kyoko who had never needed to harden her heart.
A Kyoko who had never needed to shut herself away.
A Kyoko who had never needed to walk away at all.

Kyoko's finished eating the fruit as she heard it — two voices, soft yet distinct, rising behind her like threads of music woven into the air.

The first was gentle, beautiful, carrying a resonance that seemed to ripple through the garden itself.
“Kyoko Sakura... so you have awakened. Welcome.”

The second voice followed immediately, bright and energetic — warm like sunlight breaking through clouds, brimming with pure, unrestrained cheer.

“Welcome to this dream-realm, Kyoko! I hope you'll be our friend — and friends with everyone here!”

Kyoko blinked, startled, the fruit's sweetness still lingering on her tongue.
Slowly, she turned.

Two girls stood before her, radiant against the celestial backdrop.

The first had hair like flowing silk, dark indigo that shimmered faintly as though dipped in starlight. Her eyes were deep indigo pools, calm and steady, reflecting the serenity of the garden itself. Her clothes were elegant — a harmonious blend of white, indigo, silver, and pink — delicate yet regal, radiating peace. She seemed to carry the hush of twilight within her, a presence that soothed simply by existing.

The second was her opposite — vivid, fiery, unmistakably alive. Her crimson hair was tied into high twin-tails that danced with every movement, catching the light like flames. Her eyes burned orange-red, bright with joy and mischief. Her outfit was bold, adorned with flame motifs, accented with gold and jet black, radiating energy and vitality. She seemed to embody the spark of dawn, the thrill of laughter, the pulse of life itself.

Kyoko's breath hitched. She didn't know their names. She was sure of that.

And yet... something stirred deep inside her chest, a flicker of half-remembered warmth.

“I... I feel like I've met you before,” she murmured, crimson eyes wide with confusion. “But I don't know where. Or when.”

She straightened, brushing loose strands of hair behind her ear. A small, hesitant smile softened her expression.

“I am Kyoko Sakura. Can you tell me... where I am? And who you are? Because... it feels like I've seen you somewhere before.”

Through Connect, Mami felt her own heart flutter — the echo of Kyoko's disorientation, her fragile curiosity, her instinct to trust.

She thinks she's met them before...

Does that mean Lunaria and Kasumi were the ones who saved her essence? Did they draw her into this dream-realm? Or... is Kyoko confusing them with someone else entirely?

The possibility pulsed through Mami, warm and uncertain.

The two girls exchanged a glance — a shared spark of understanding — before smiling.

The fiery one stepped forward first, twirling theatrically. Her twin-tails flared in arcs of red and gold. She delivered an exaggerated, sweeping bow that felt like a burst of fireworks, her grin wide and dazzling.

“Kasumi Hoshizora!” she declared proudly, her voice ringing like glittering bells. “That’s my full name. But you can just call me Kasumi. Everyone does!”

The indigo-haired girl followed with a graceful bow, her hands folded neatly at her chest. Her movements flowed like water, and when she spoke, her voice carried a soft, tranquil cadence.

“You may call me Lunaria,” she said, each syllable polished and serene. “It is an honor to meet you, Kyoko.”

Kyoko blinked at them both, still confused, still overwhelmed by the surreal beauty around her.

“Uh ... so this place... what is it?”

Kasumi’s eyes sparkled as she spread her arms wide, as if presenting an entire festival.

“This is a dream-realm! A place where the essences of people live. A peaceful world where everyone can learn, grow, and have fun together!”

Lunaria’s voice followed, grounding the exuberance with gentle calm.

“Here, no one suffers. No one is alone. It is a sanctuary for the heart and soul.”

Kyoko swallowed, glancing around — at the crystalline rivers, the glowing fruit trees, the soft grass beneath her knees. At the animals wandering freely, the sky that shimmered like a painted dawn.

“A dream-realm... essences of people...?”

Her voice trembled, caught between awe and fear.

“Does that mean I’m asleep right now? That I’ll wake up from this dream? Or... is this real?”

The words hung in the air — fragile, uncertain, quietly pleading.

Even Mami felt the emotion inside them, blooming in her chest like a delicate ache.

Lunaria and Kasumi chuckled warmly, their laughter soft and bright, blending into the garden's symphony of flowing water and rustling leaves. It was not mocking, nor dismissive — but gentle, like the laughter of older sisters watching a child discover something wondrous for the first time.

Their voices seemed to merge with the garden's natural music: the crystalline cascade of the fountain, the rustle of jeweled leaves, the distant chirps of luminous birds.

Lunaria stepped forward, her indigo hair shimmering faintly as though the starlight itself had leaned close to listen. Her voice was calm, melodic, carrying the weight of truth spoken with care.

“Every person has their own unique essence,” she explained, her words flowing like water over smooth stone. “It is the core of who they are — their soul, their heart, their truth. There are abilities that allow people to connect and share these essences with one another. Through such bonds, they can share their joys, sorrows, experiences, lives.”

She held Kyoko's gaze, steady and sincere.

“Kyoko... you shared your essence with someone. And that essence was saved here, in this dream-realm.”

Kyoko's eyes widened. Her lips parted slightly, trembling with a silent *what?*

The idea felt too big, too luminous, too unreal — like a secret carved from constellations.

Kasumi twirled lightly, her twin-tails flaring like ribbons of flame, her grin dazzling with unrestrained energy. She leaned forward, her voice bright, ringing like bells.

“So that means you here — this Kyoko here — are exactly the same as the real Kyoko your essence came from! Same memories, same values, same personality, same appearance, same abilities.”

She dramatically pointed at Kyoko with both hands, eyes sparkling.

“But starting now, you'll live differently. Your experiences will split and branch. Think of it like... two stories beginning from the same page, but then each book goes its own way. The real Kyoko will live *her* life. And you will live *yours*. Completely and independently!”

Kyoko stared, stunned — as if her heart had forgotten how to beat. Her mouth opened in awe.

“That's... incredible,” she whispered. “So I'm... me. But also... not me. I'm living my own life now, separate from her. That sounds unreal. Like a miracle. Like... **magic**.”

The word **magic** lingered in her thoughts, and her gaze sharpened. She studied Lunaria and Kasumi more carefully. Their clothes resembled those of magical girls — elegant, symbolic, radiant — but not quite the same. There were no Soul Gems glimmering at their chests or hands. No magical signatures pulsing from them.

Her brows furrowed.

So... *who exactly are they?*

She bowed her head slightly, her voice soft but earnest.

“Thank you... for explaining. But this is... a lot. I’m still trying to process everything.”

She lifted her eyes again, crimson irises burning with curiosity.

“You said I have the same abilities as the real me. So... you know I’m a magical girl. You know what I can do. But does that mean I’ll have to fight here? You said this realm is peaceful, a place where people can grow and have fun. So... are there no witches? No familiars?”

Hope flickered in her voice — fragile, wavering — as if afraid of being crushed.

“If that’s true... then how will I get grief seeds? My Soul Gem will get cloudy eventually.”

She hesitated, then pushed past her uncertainty, her tone turning urgent, sharp.

“And more importantly... who *are* you two? Kasumi. Lunaria. Were you the ones who interacted with the real me? Did you save my essence? Why am I here at all?”

Through Connect, Mami felt her own heartbeat race — Kyoko’s confusion, awe, and brewing hope pulsing through her chest like echoes.

Essence saving... a dream-realm... parallel lives...

She remembered the previous day — when she had asked dream-Kyoko how she was saved and who brought her essence here. Kyoko had only shaken her head, saying she didn’t know.

Mami’s eyes glimmered with anticipation.

Maybe now... I’ll learn a bit more about them.

About Lunaria.

About Kasumi.

About the purpose of this radiant realm.

About why Kyoko’s essence had been chosen — saved — preserved.

Kasumi laughed brightly, her voice ringing like bells scattered across the garden.

Lunaria’s chuckle followed — soft, velvety, warm. There was no mockery in either of them; only fondness, patience, and a quiet joy that felt like sunlight warming cool water.

Kasumi tilted her head at Kyoko, her crimson twin-tails bouncing like flames.

“Wow, Kyoko, you’re asking *so many* questions!” she teased, her grin dazzling. “It’ll take forever to answer them all!”

Lunaria’s smile was serene, her indigo eyes shimmering like calm waters under moonlight. She inclined her head toward Kyoko, her voice flowing like a gentle stream.

“Walk with us. We’ll answer your questions as we go. Let the realm itself show you.”

She turned gracefully, her steps light, and began to move ahead along a path of luminous grass.

Kasumi spun theatrically, her arms flaring wide, and beamed at Kyoko.

“C’mon, let’s go!” she said with infectious energy, her voice bursting like fireworks.

Kyoko blinked, caught between confusion and amusement, then gave a small, crooked smile.

“...Alright. Lead the way.”

And she followed.

As they walked, Kyoko’s eyes widened at what she saw.

Animals flocked around Lunaria as though pulled by threads made of trust. Birds fluttered down to rest on her shoulders, wings shimmering like stained glass. Rabbits hopped close and brushed against her ankles. A pair of deer approached quietly and dipped their heads in greeting as Lunaria reached out with a reverent touch.

Her presence was a lullaby — soft, grounding, soothing even to the wind itself.

Kasumi, meanwhile, was chaos and joy incarnate. Animals gathered around her too, but their energy reflected hers — bright, mischievous, buzzing. She laughed as she chased them, her movements dramatic and exaggerated, a playful predator in a world without fear. The creatures squealed and chirped, scattering and circling back, inviting her to chase them again.

Their laughter — hers and theirs — blended into a jubilant chorus that made the air feel alive.

Kyoko stopped in her tracks, stunned.

They’re so close to them... so comfortable...

A squirrel scampered toward her, tiny paws pattering softly against the grass. It paused at her feet, then tapped her shoe with a tiny paw — a playful little knock.

Kyoko blinked, then laughed — a genuine, surprised laugh. She knelt, reaching out. Her fingers brushed soft fur; instinctively gentle, she stroked its back. The squirrel chirped in approval, leaning into her hand.

A few birds swooped down, circling her playfully. One landed on her free hand, tilting its head and chirping happily at her.

Kyoko chuckled — warm, real.

“...This place... it’s beautiful. Peaceful.”

She shook her head, smiling with something close to wonder.

“I’ve never interacted with animals like this before. I didn’t know it could feel so... fun. So... gentle.”

Her voice was soft, almost reverent.

Lunaria and Kasumi exchanged warm smiles.

“This is only the beginning,” Lunaria said, her voice carrying a quiet promise. “There is much to learn from nature — from these lives that exist alongside ours. Lessons that will help you grow. Not just as a magical girl... but as yourself.”

Kasumi nodded vigorously, her grin wide.

“Exactly! This isn’t just about petting cute animals — though that part’s awesome. What you learn here will change how you fight, how you live, *how you feel*. Trust me!”

Kyoko tilted her head, crimson eyes narrowing with curiosity, confusion, and the beginnings of intrigue.

“...How can nature and animals teach me anything that’ll help me as a magical girl?”

She folded her arms lightly. “We risk our lives fighting witches. We need grief seeds. We... don’t exactly get time to relax with wildlife.”

Her voice was searching, not dismissive — trying to grasp something far bigger than her experiences.

Through Connect, Mami chuckled softly, her heart swelling with memory.

She recalled her second day in the realm — when Lunaria had taught her about Connect. How she had reached out, not to another magical girl, but to life itself. To plants, to animals, to the lake’s shimmering waters. How she had seen and felt the world through their perspectives — the patience of trees, the joy of birds, the quiet resilience of blooming flowers.

It was beautiful.

Since then, Mami had begun to appreciate all life — not just the lives she fought to protect, but her own life as a magical girl.

It had changed her.

It had soothed her.

It had strengthened her magic in ways she never thought possible — not through suffering, but through peace and joy.

Now, watching Kyoko — this Kyoko, unscarred and gentle — taking those same first steps...

Mami’s chest glowed with something warm and soft and impossibly tender.

So... this is where it begins for you, Kyoko.

Witches in the dream-realm

Suddenly, laughter rippled through the air.

It was not a single voice, but two layered together — one bright and girlish, the other warped, reverberating, distorted like echoes in a cavern. The harmony was uncanny, unsettling... yet strangely magnetic, like a melody that should not exist but somehow compelled the heart to listen.

The animals reacted instantly. Ears perked. Wings fluttered. Tiny paws scurried across the glowing grass.

But instead of fear, they moved toward the sound with unhesitating joy — as if the eerie laughter were a warm, familiar invitation.

Kyoko's body seized up.

Her pulse stuttered.

Her breath caught in her throat.

That distorted undertone — she would recognize it anywhere.

The laughter of a witch.

She spun toward the sound, crimson eyes wide, and gasped.

Floating before her was a figure wrapped in thorns.

Her body was bound in twisting vines, each limb blooming with flowers sharp and dangerous, their petals edged like blades. Her face was hidden beneath a mask of layered petals, obscuring her features, but her eyes glowed faintly green — luminous, eerie, venomous. Binding vines writhed around her like serpents, lashing at the air, restless and hungry.

She looked like a nightmare sculpted from brambles.

A monster born from a garden's darkest corner.

And yet... the animals flocked to her happily, their movements full of trust and delight.

Kyoko's instincts screamed. Her Soul Gem pulsed. She summoned her spear in a crackle of red light and dropped instantly into battle stance.

"Stay back!" she shouted to the animals, her voice sharp with panic. "Don't go near her! Run away!"

Her mind raced.

A witch? Here?! In this realm Lunaria said was peaceful? Did they lie? Is this the real truth — that I'll still have to fight, even here?

She tightened her grip until her knuckles whitened. Her heart pounded like a drum.

But to her utter shock, the animals did not flee. They didn't even hesitate.

They kept approaching the witch.

They gathered around her with delighted chirps and squeaks. A doe nudged her vines. A trio of birds perched on her thorned arms. A fox curled against her, tail swishing contentedly.

The witch laughed again, and this time her flowers released a fragrance — soft, sweet, calming. The animals melted beneath its influence, their bodies relaxing, their breaths softening.

She extended a few vines — these ones smooth and petal-soft — and stroked the creatures with careful tenderness. Rabbits leaned into her touch. Birds perched on her shoulders and wings. Deer pressed their heads against her vines, nuzzling warmly.

Kyoko inhaled the scent without meaning to.

Warmth seeped into her muscles.

Her grip slackened.

Her shoulders loosened.

Her mind spun.

What is this? Is she tricking them? Tricking me? Is this some witch tactic — lure us in with peace, then strike?

Her crimson eyes narrowed, torn between suspicion and disbelief.

Slowly, the witch turned toward her.

Her twin-layered voice echoed with gentle amusement.

“You must be the new essence welcomed to this realm,” she said. “Your reaction is natural.

Understandable. On Earth, magical girls and witches are bound by tragedy. It is only natural for you to fear me.”

Kyoko went perfectly still.

Her spear slipped from her fingers and hit the ground with a metallic clatter.

Her mouth fell open.

A witch... talking? To me? Calmly? Cheerfully?

I'm dreaming. I have to be dreaming—

The witch's tone softened, warm as sunlight filtered through leaves.

“My name is Thornaria,” she said. “A pleasure to meet you, Kyoko Sakura. I hope we can be friends here.”

She bowed her thorn-wrapped head, vines curling politely in a gesture of respect.

Her presence was paradoxical — monstrous in silhouette, yet her aura carried kindness, her laughter carried joy.

Kyoko remained frozen, eyes huge, jaw slack.

The animals looked up at her with innocent eyes, as if urging her to trust.

Then Kasumi giggled.

Lunaria smiled.

Thornaria covered her masked mouth with a vine, twin voices bubbling with delight.

They all burst into laughter — warm, bright, affectionate.

Not mocking.

Not cruel.

But delighted.

Because Kyoko Sakura — fiery, tomboyish — stood there utterly undone, bewildered past the point of speech.

And the sight was... adorable.

Kyoko remained frozen.

Her body locked in place, her mind a storm without center. Thoughts slammed together — denial, confusion, fear, disbelief — too many to hold, too many to outrun. Her lips parted, but no sound emerged. She could only stare, wide-eyed and trembling, at the thorn-laced figure before her.

Thornaria chuckled softly — a sound not cruel, but warm and strangely gentle — and drifted downward until her vine-wrapped feet brushed the luminous grass. She placed one elegant hand upon the earth.

The garden responded.

With a ripple of shimmering light, flowers erupted from the soil in a sweeping bloom. Roses, lilies, orchids, blossoms she had no name for — radiant colors spilling outward in concentric waves around Kyoko. Their petals glowed faintly, every hue shimmering like stained glass. Their fragrances mingled: honey, lavender, citrus, rain-soaked petals, earthy sweetness. The air thickened with perfume, soft and intoxicating.

Thornaria guided her vines — smooth, not thorned — weaving blossoms together with deliberate care. She braided stems and petals into a crown, her movements careful, reverent. Each flower was chosen with intention. Each vine-threaded loop added another curve of beauty, another whisper of life. When she finished, she lifted the crown and set it gently upon Kyoko's head.

Kyoko inhaled sharply, breath catching. The crown was cool. Alive. She felt its faint pulse — the rhythm of growing things — beating against her hair.

As she worked, Thornaria's voice flowed, layered with memory and quiet ache.

"I used to make flower crowns like this when I was a magical girl like you," she said. "My wish was to

bond with nature — to nurture life, to protect it, to grow with it. Because of that wish, I could speak with animals... and they spoke back. Plants bloomed at my touch. Forests healed under my care.”

Her vines extended in a soft gesture, brushing the flowers around them.

“I was close with eleven other girls. We played together, fought together, supported one another. We were happy.”

Kyoko’s eyes widened. Her shock broke through her silence.

“You... you were a magical girl?” she whispered, her voice trembling. “Then... how did you... become a witch?”

Thornaria’s tone softened, hesitant. Her vines curled inward, thorns tightening as if responding to an old wound.

“But then... tragedy struck.”

Her voice softened to a tremor.

“One day, the people of our village witnessed us using magic. They did not understand. They feared what they could not accept.”

Her words faltered.

“And so they acted on that fear.”

Kyoko leaned forward unconsciously. Her heart hammered painfully.

Thornaria’s voice grew smaller, cracked at the edges.

“They executed our families and hunted us like beasts. They cried for salvation, even as they destroyed the ones who protected them from the shadows.”

Her glowing eyes dimmed.

“We ran. We hid. But grief followed us like a shadow that would not loosen its grip.”

Kyoko’s heart clenched painfully, her vision blurred. She could hear the sorrow in Thornaria’s voice, the raw ache of grief that had never faded.

“That’s... awful,” Kyoko whispered, her voice breaking with empathy.

Thornaria nodded — a small, mournful motion.

“I lost everything. We all did. Six of us... me and five of my closest friends... fell into despair. The loss of our families, the betrayal of our village, the exile, the endless fear — it was too much to bear. We lost all hope, purpose, the will to keep fighting. And most importantly, our will to live.”

Her glowing eyes lifted, locking onto Kyoko’s.

“The despair poisoned our hearts. It seeped into our Soul Gems, tainting them, corrupting them. Until they shattered.”

Her voice deepened, layered with the echo of her witch-self.
“And we became witches, right in front of the rest of our friends.”
The last word reverberated through the garden like a mourning bell.

Kyoko gasped as if struck. Her knees buckled. She dropped to the grass, the living crown trembling on her head. Her spear lay forgotten at her side.

Witches... were once magical girls?

Her world cracked open. Her breath shook. Her chest constricted, panic stabbing through her like glass shards.

Kyubey had never told her this. Never told any of them.

The monsters she fought, the creatures she despised, the enemies she had sworn to destroy — they had once been girls like her. Girls who had made wishes. Girls who had fought for hope. Girls who had suffered.

Her crimson eyes stared blankly, her mouth open in silent horror.

So this is the truth. The world I knew... was a lie. Magical girls are fated to become witches. The very monsters we fight. This must be some kind of joke, right? That damn Kyubey!

The crown slipped slightly, its blossoms trembling as if echoing her despair.

Kyoko bowed her head and gritted her teeth, voice barely a whisper.

“...Then that means...”

Her eyes burned, tears threatening to spill.

“...I’ll become one too.”

Kasumi’s smile blazed like sunlight breaking through storm clouds.

She leaned forward, twin-tails bouncing with vibrant energy, her crimson-orange eyes sparkling with mischief and warmth.

“Cheer up, Kyoko! Sadness doesn’t suit this dream-realm. Turning frowns upside-down is rule number one!”

Her voice rang like bells scattering across the sky, bright and irrepressible.

Joyful.

Infectious.

A direct counter to the crushing weight that pressed upon Kyoko’s heart.

Kyoko lifted her gaze slowly.

Her eyes shimmered — not only with sorrow, but with growing frustration.
Her grief twisted into something sharper.
Hotter.
Angrier.

At herself.
At the world.
At everything she had blindly accepted.

I made a contract without knowing the truth.
I made a wish without understanding the cost.
If I had known... if I had known I'd become a witch... I never would've agreed.

Her breath stuttered. Her lips trembled.

Then Lunaria's voice drifted in — cool and steady, the moon's gentle reflection upon still water.

“Almost all magical girls react as you do when they learn the truth,” she said softly. “Sadness at the fate that awaits them. Rage at Kyubey for hiding the details. And anger at themselves for accepting the contract.”

Her indigo eyes glowed with calm empathy.

There was no judgment in her tone — only compassion, as if she had held the hearts of many girls breaking under the same revelation.

Kyoko swallowed hard.

Her voice cracked as she forced the question out:

“How... how can Kyubey be so cruel? What's his purpose? Why create something so horrible?”

The words shattered like glass, fragile and desperate.

Lunaria stepped closer, kneeling to meet Kyoko's eyes.

“From the human perspective, what Kyubey does *is* cruel,” she said gently. “Cruel enough to destroy countless lives. But you cannot place all the blame on him. You — and most magical girls — made a contract without knowing all the details.”

She placed a hand softly over her chest.

“Kyubey granted your wish. He gave you a miracle. And all miracles come with consequences... and in this case, a tragic one.”

Kasumi burst back into the conversation with her usual radiance, her grin unfazed by the darkness swirling around them.

“Kyubey’s whole mission is to stop the universe from dying!” she declared dramatically. “The universe is constantly losing energy. So he needs a way to refill the tank!”

She pointed at Kyoko with both hands as if delivering the punchline of a cosmic joke.

“And guess what he found? The strongest, most potent source of energy in existence is... the emotions of young girls!”

Her tone flared with theatrical intensity.

“That’s why magical girls exist. That’s why witches exist. When a magical girl falls into despair and becomes a witch, BOOM! Massive energy release. Enough to stabilize the universe for a little while.”

Then Kasumi’s cheerful smile softened, her eyes gentle as they met Kyoko’s.

“Kyubey doesn’t understand pain or sadness. He can’t feel emotions. So to him, it’s a fair deal. A miracle for a miracle. You don’t have to agree with him... but you should at least try to understand him.”

She winked, her smile radiant.

“And besides — you’re not trapped in that ending here. Look at Thornaria. She became a witch... but she kept her personality. Her memories. Her kindness. She can laugh and talk with you like a friend.”

Thornaria chuckled softly, her twin-layered voice carrying both warmth and shadow.

“I remember when I first woke up here,” she said. “I don’t recall what happened after I became a witch. Only the crushing despair, my consciousness fading into darkness. And then... suddenly.”

Her eyes softened.

“I opened them again in this very garden. Just like you.”

She placed a thorn-wrapped hand over her chest. Her glowing eyes softened with memory.

“And beside me were five of my friends — the ones who fell into despair with me. All six of us witches... waking together.”

Kyoko’s breath hitched.

Thornaria’s voice grew quieter, shadowed by old grief.

“And beside us were also three of my friends who never fell. They had watched us become witches... watched our Soul Gems shatter. They had been forced to fight us. To kill us. Their former friends...”

Kyoko’s heart clenched painfully.

Thornaria’s vines curled inward, echoing the tension in her voice.

“When we all woke up here, those three were terrified. They saw the same monstrosities they had fought... standing alive before them.”

For a moment, her voice faltered — the memory too raw.

“They screamed. They summoned their weapons. They thought they had been cursed... or that they had failed to save us even in death.”

She looked toward Lunaria and Kasumi — gratitude shimmering in her glowing eyes.

“But before any fighting could happen, Lunaria and Kasumi appeared. Calm and warm. They explained what they explained to you earlier — that this is a dream-realm, where essences are saved. That we are versions of our real selves, living lives different from those on Earth. That we can all live in peace and joy here.”

Her vine-wrapped body seemed to relax, softening like a plant returning to sunlight.

“They taught us many things. Lessons that changed our entire perspective of life, of magic, of bonds, of Connect. They helped us rebuild what was lost, and helped us understand ourselves again.”

Her thorned silhouette seemed to soften, her aura glowing faintly with joy. She turned back to Kyoko, her voice playful now, her eyes gleaming with mischief.

“And now it’s your turn, Kyoko Sakura,” she said, her vines curling like a teasing smile. “You will learn the same lessons. Grow the same way. And maybe...”

She leaned forward conspiratorially, her twin-layered voice bubbling with amusement.

“...maybe you’ll surprise all of us.”

She winked, vines curling lightly in a gesture of teasing affection

Kyoko stared at Lunaria, Kasumi, and Thornaria as if they were constellations she had never seen before — radiant, incomprehensible, too vast to grasp. Her crimson eyes were wide, unfocused, lost in the aftermath of truths too enormous to hold.

Kyubey’s system.

The fate of magical girls.

A realm where witches and girls lived side-by-side.

Witches — talking, laughing, smiling.

Her thoughts spun without anchor, colliding like shards of glass. Her lips parted, her voice quiet, trembling, uncertain — as if she were trying to stitch order into the chaos in her head by speaking each thought aloud.

“So this dream-realm... there are magical girls and witches saved from all over time? I don’t have to fight witches here? But then— if I’m not fighting, my Soul Gem... won’t it get polluted? Won’t it break eventually?”

Her breath shook.

“Unless... unless that’s why you brought me here. So I can learn to control it? Is that... my purpose?”

The three of them laughed softly — warm, gentle, delighted. Not mocking, but like the sound of teachers pleased by a student who was finally asking the right questions.

Kasumi bounced forward first, her smile dazzling, her twin-tails swishing like bright flame. “You’ve got it! Magical girls and witches from across all eras are here. And nope—no fighting required.”

She winked, eyes sparkling with mischievous pride.

“In fact, you can’t become a witch here. Not ever. That’s why I hoped earlier you’d join us as a friend — and a friend to everyone else here too. Because here, no one has to fear falling. Or dying. Or losing themselves.”

Her words chimed like bells, warm and reassuring, scattering Kyoko’s dread like petals in the wind.

Thornaria’s voice followed, layered with warmth and shadow.

“My friends and I have met countless others here. Magical girls, witches, even monsters and legends from across time and space. Each of them carries stories — of their homes, their cultures, their philosophies.”

Her vines curled gently, cradling memory and gratitude.

“We’ve learned so much from them. Every encounter has changed us, taught us something new about life, about magic, about ourselves.”

Then Lunaria spoke, her voice calm and steady, like moonlight flowing across still waters.

“Kyoko. Even though you cannot become a witch here, your Soul Gem can still be tainted by negativity. Normally, magical girls purify their gems with grief seeds.”

She paused, her lips curving into a serene smile, her indigo eyes shimmering with quiet mystery.

“But what if I told you there is another way? A way that does not require fighting nor grief seeds. A way to transform negativity and despair into strength rather than corruption.”

Her words glowed with promise, like a secret too luminous to ignore.

Kyoko inhaled sharply. The idea hit her like a spark catching dry tinder.

She thought of Mami — her quiet exhaustion, her gentle smile hiding fear.

She thought of her real self — surviving by fighting, by refusing to break, by leaning on Mami for support.

If there really was another path—

Her voice came out cracked, raw with conflict:

“Is this... really true? Or are you hiding something from me too? Just like Kyubey did?”

Kasumi laughed, the sound bright as fireworks.

“Smart girl! That’s exactly the question you should ask.”

Her grin widened, teasing yet sincere.

“You’re already way sharper than you were when you said yes to Kyubey’s contract.”

Kyoko sputtered indignantly, cheeks flushing, and Kasumi giggled harder, her laughter scattering tension like sparks.

Thornaria’s vines swayed gently as she stepped closer.

“This dream-realm has countless places for you to train, grow, heal, learn, play. Through those experiences, you’ll discover the truth yourself.”

Her masked face tilted, gentle and encouraging.

“Maybe everything we say is true. Maybe it’s even bigger than we know. But the answer? That is yours to find.”

Lunaria placed a hand over her heart, her voice glowing warm and steady.

“That is your purpose here, Kyoko Sakura. To step outside the cycle of tragedy. To explore a life where despair is not the end. To find your own answer to the question: *How do I want to live?*”

Her smile softened.

“And perhaps one day... you will take what you learn back to your real self. To Mami. To all your friends.”

Warmth surged through Kyoko’s chest.

Lunaria.

Kasumi.

Thornaria.

They weren’t forcing her.

They weren’t lying.

They weren’t manipulating her with half-truths and disguised consequences.

They were offering her freedom.

Knowledge.

Choice.

A path that belonged to her and no one else.

Her sorrow cracked — and through the fracture, her fire roared back to life.

She jumped to her feet, her crimson eyes blazing, her signature grin flashing like a spark igniting dry grass. She slammed her fist into her palm, her usual fiery spirit blazing outward.

“Alright then! I’m fired up! Teach me!”

Her smile gleamed fiercely.

“I wanna learn everything. I wanna grow stronger. And someday... I’ll help my real self. I’ll help Mami live a life that isn’t all fighting and fear!”

Her declaration burned through the air, bright and unyielding.

And the garden responded —

the light brightening,

the leaves shimmering,

the air humming —

as if the realm itself had smiled back at her newfound resolve.

Through Connect, Mami saw and felt everything.

Not as distant impressions — but as living sensations, raw and unfiltered, flowing through her heart as though they were her own.

Kyoko’s shock — sharp and jagged like a spear fracturing stone — when the truth of witches and magical girls struck her.

Her despair — crushing, suffocating, heavy as an ocean against fragile glass.

Her confusion, her grief, her anger — all tangled together like frayed threads desperately trying to hold.

And then...

a spark.

A flame.

Kyoko’s fire reigniting — hope catching on the edges of despair, determination blazing through the cracks.

It was her rebirth in real time.

It mirrored Mami’s own journey. She remembered her own trembling heart when Lunaria and Kasumi had first revealed these truths to her — the despair that hollowed her chest, the anger that burned like acid, the disbelief that left her breathless. And then, slowly, the quiet warmth of realizing there was another path.

Watching Kyoko now, Mami’s heart swelled until she thought it might burst.

We’re the same, she realized.

Deep down, beneath their differences, they were both scarred girls — fighting desperately to protect others while quietly drowning themselves. Both had carried burdens too heavy for their age, both had smiled through pain, both had believed they had no choice but to endure.

And now... both of them had been given a chance to breathe.

To learn.

To heal.

More than that — they both wanted to use what they learned not just for themselves, but for their friends. For Mami, it was real Kyoko, Madoka, Sayaka — the girls she had mentored, fought beside, and loved in her own quiet way. For Kyoko, it was her real self and Mami.

That realization warmed Mami's soul like sunlight breaking through clouds.

The murals she and Kyoko had seen yesterday shimmered in her memory — the carved and painted story of Thornaria and her eleven friends, painted in stone and sorrow.

But hearing Thornaria speak her own story... that was different.

The murals were beautiful.

But Thornaria's voice was **alive**.

Her laughter carried joy layered over wounds.

Her sorrow bore the shape of the moment it broke her.

Her words were not myth — they were memory.

And through Connect, the ache of her grief passed straight into Mami's chest.

It hurt.

But it was the kind of hurt that deepened understanding.

Mami wondered what truths lay beyond the sealed doors in the pyramid — the ones they could not open no matter how much magic they pushed into the stone.

What memories slept there?

What secrets?

What stories Thornaria had not spoken aloud?

One day, she promised herself. Kyoko and I will uncover them.

Her thoughts drifted to Thornaria and her friends.

Thornaria, Velmira, Ruinelle, Catastrophia, Noctulisse, Vexaphra — the six who had fallen into despair and awakened here as witches.

And the three who had not —
Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle —
the girls who had watched their friends transform into the very monsters they were forced to fight.

Mami's heart tightened.

She could imagine it too clearly — the horror, the helplessness, the grief of fighting friends whose names they still cried out mid-battle.

Hoshine was absent, as Kasumi and Lunaria had explained, her essence not saved in this realm.

And the two enigmatic girls without Soul Gems were missing as well, their identities lingering like shadows at the edge of the story.

Mami felt a shiver.

There was so much she did not yet know.

So much she *wanted* to know.

She recalled the punishment from yesterday — when she and Kyoko had been thrown against all six witches for failing to use Connect during beginner training.

It had been terrifying.

And exhilarating.

But something had been different.

In the simulation of the mural's history, Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, Hoshine, and the gemless girls had fought the witches without unity. The witches had been fractured, each one fighting alone, their movements chaotic and uncoordinated — exactly what Mami expected from normal witches, creatures consumed by despair.

But yesterday had been different. Entirely different.

The witches had been coordinated.

Unified.

A single overwhelming force.

They moved like a storm — stronger, faster, sharper. Their attacks flowed together seamlessly, their defenses layered, their strikes timed with precision. Too synchronized to be their original selves. Too coordinated to be ordinary witches.

Mami's pulse quickened as she remembered the battle. The punishment had been terrifying, exhilarating, and humbling all at once.

Kyoko's words echoed in her mind: *We can beat the "same versions" of the witches we fought yesterday if we Connect.*

The implication was clear. The witches they faced had been scaled down, their strength tempered for training. Their full selves, unrestrained, unscaled, would be far stronger.

Mami's breath caught. *So how strong are they at full power? Thornaria, Velmira, Ruinelle, Catastrophia, Noctulisse, Vexaphra... and the three magical girls who survived, Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle?*

The thought sent a shiver of dread and excitement through her. She could already imagine Kyoko demanding to spar with them, her fiery spirit refusing to back down. And Mami knew herself well enough to realize she would join her.

A smile tugged at her lips. The idea of her fiery student facing legends from another age filled her with both dread and excitement.

Mami exhaled softly.

Through Connect, she felt Kyoko's emotions still swirling — sorrow and hope, cracking and healing, despair and joy weaving together like golden threads of a new tapestry.

And in the midst of those emotions...

Mami felt her own.

Warmth.

Pride.

Excitement.

Life.

This realm was reshaping them both.

Teaching them.

Healing them.

And so Mami continued watching, her heart warm, her spirit alight.

Kasumi shot Kyoko an enthusiastic thumbs-up, her grin blazing like a comet tearing across the sky. "I **love** your energy!" she crowed, her voice ringing like a victory bell. "That's the spirit I wanna see!"

She swept her arm in a grand, dramatic gesture, beckoning Kyoko to follow as she and Lunaria turned to lead deeper into the dream-realm.

Lunaria's indigo hair shimmered like moonlit silk, each step light and poised, her presence serene as flowing water.

Kasumi's twin-tails bounced like dancing flames, bright, chaotic, impossible to ignore

But before they could take more than a step, Kyoko's grin sharpened, eyes narrowing with cunning.

"Hold up," she said, voice playful but edged with unmistakable suspicion. "You two still haven't answered *all* my questions."

Lunaria and Kasumi froze mid-stride, backs still facing her.

The silence stretched — not tense, but *intentional* — a soft rest in the middle of a song.

Kyoko folded her arms, her voice dropping beneath the bravado.

“And don’t pretend you didn’t hear me.”

Her tone softened, vulnerable beneath the fire.

“Who *are* you really? Were you the ones talking to my real self? The ones who saved my essence here? You greeted me when I woke up... and Thornaria said you welcomed her and her friends the moment they arrived.”

Hope and wariness tangled in her words, neither strong enough to hide the other.

Through Connect, Mami leaned in, her heartbeat quickening.

This was the question she herself had carried since arriving in the realm. She had asked Kyoko yesterday, but Kyoko hadn’t known. And now... she braced herself, knowing Lunaria and Kasumi’s gentle deflections were likely to follow.

Kasumi turned first. Her crimson-orange eyes gleamed — not evasive, but layered, too full of meaning to decipher in a glance. Her smile was as dazzling as always, but beneath it flickered something quieter, something almost... ancient.

“Well,” she said cheerfully, “you could say Lunaria and I are the **hostesses** of this dream-realm! We welcome everyone who arrives, help them settle in, and do everything we can to make sure they have fun!”

She giggled, her voice bright, but there was an undercurrent — truth wrapped in candy coating, mystery hidden in laughter.

Lunaria turned next, her expression serene, her indigo eyes shimmering like reflections on deep water.

“As for whether we interacted with your real self...” Her voice flowed soft and steady.

“Perhaps that is a conversation for another time.”

Kyoko pouted, glaring halfheartedly.

“So you’re open about every other big secret, but when it comes to who you two actually are, I only get... names?”

Her pout dissolved into a mischievous grin.

“Fine. I’ll figure you out myself. Don’t think you can stay mysterious forever.”

Lunaria chuckled softly, a sound like a quiet ripple.

Kasumi beamed as if Kyoko had just agreed to a game.

“Then try,” Lunaria murmured.

“Learn everything you can,” Kasumi added, practically glowing.

Kyoko turned toward Thornaria next. “What about you? Got anything to add?”

Thornaria simply smiled — warm, enigmatic, affectionate — and dipped her head as if encouraging Kyoko onward in her search rather than obstructing it.

Kyoko smirked.

“So either you’re hiding things too... or you really don’t know.”

Thornaria’s silence remained warm and unreadable.

Through Connect, Mami sighed with a fond smile.

There it is again — the same gentle veil Lunaria and Kasumi always draw. And Thornaria... does she know more? Or is she just as lost as we are?

It was the same uncertainty she and Kyoko had felt yesterday when they asked Aurellia — the same veil of mystery that refused to lift.

Kyoko stretched her arms, rolling her shoulders with a fresh grin.

“All right then, mysterious hostesses. Lead on.”

Kasumi beamed, her voice bursting like fireworks.

“Let’s go!”

As Lunaria, Kasumi, and Kyoko began walking, Thornaria’s vines stirred with mischievous intent. With a flick of unseen will, she coaxed three slender tendrils from the ground — one curling toward each of them — playful traps laid with the nostalgic precision of an old habit back when she was a magical girl.

Lunaria noticed instantly. Her indigo eyes sparkled, and she stepped forward with effortless grace, her motion so fluid it was as if she’d known the vine would be there before Thornaria even moved. Her stride flowing like water over stone.

Kyoko reacted with instinct rather than elegance — she stumbled, arms flailing for a heartbeat — then twisted her body, snapped into balance, and straightened with a fiery grin.

“Nice.”

On the other hand...

“WAAAAAAAAAAAAAAH!”

Kasumi... did not fare as well.

Her shriek of theatrical betrayal echoed across the garden an instant before she face-planted magnificently into the grass. Her laughter burst out even before she lifted her head, muffled by petals and dirt.

Immediately, the realm's animals went into playful uproar — tiny birds fluttering, rabbits bounding, small creatures scampering over to Kasumi as if she were a playground.

They swarmed her back, her arms, her hair, chirping and squeaking in delighted chaos.

Thornaria's layered laughter rang out — rich, affectionate, mischievous.

“Just like old times,” she said fondly.

“I used to tease my friends like this.”

She turned to Lunaria.

“As expected — graceful as always.”

To Kyoko:

“And you — impressive reflexes. You recovered faster than I anticipated.”

Finally, she looked down at Kasumi — still face-down in grass, covered in happy animals — and her voice softened with playful affection.

“And of course... Kasumi takes the fall in style.”

Kasumi gave a muffled thumbs-up from the ground, pride undiminished even beneath dirt and feathers.

Kyoko spun toward Thornaria, eyes blazing with competitive fire, grin sharp enough to cut sunlight.

“Nice try. You'll have to do better than that to trip *me*. Is this your way of picking a fight?”

Thornaria winked, her thorned silhouette rippling with anticipation.

“Yes,” she said easily. “We'll spar sometime in this dream-realm. I enjoy fighting new opponents. And I promise...”

Her smile grew, layered with challenge and delight.

“I'll try harder than that.”

Kyoko's grin widened, confident and hungry.

“Good. I'm looking forward to it. I'll fight you — and everyone else here.”

Her voice rang through the garden like a blazing declaration, bold enough to shake the petals from nearby trees.

Lunaria's and Kasumi's dream

Thornaria's layered laughter rippled through the garden, warm and mischievous, like wind rustling through a field of thorns. She inclined her silhouette toward Kyoko, Lunaria, and Kasumi, her vines swaying with gentle affection.

“I'll stay here a while longer,” she said, her twin-toned voice carrying both shadow and tenderness.

“The plants and animals still want my company.”

At her words, the creatures around her — birds, small beasts, fluttering familiars of the realm — erupted in joyful chatter, as if proudly claiming her as their own.

Her glowing eyes slid toward Kasumi, who was still half-buried in the grass, buried under excited animals.

“See you later today at the concert hall,” Thornaria teased. “I hope you did not forget about the performance.”

Kasumi shot upright with dramatic flair, springing to her feet like a stage performer. Her arms lifted high like a gymnast who just finished a flawless routine. Her grin blazed, her voice triumphant. “Yes!” she cried. “And Thornaria — I hope you’ve finished preparing your colorful smoke with those plant fumes!”

Thornaria winked, her vines curling with playful secrecy.

“They’re ready,” she said. “And as usual... I’ve prepared a surprise.”

Kasumi gasped theatrically, clutching her chest.

“Please tell me it’s not another **aroma of doom**. The atrocious stink bomb last time nearly killed us! Everyone gagged, ran for their lives, then chased you around the hall! That was legendary!”

She burst into ringing laughter, her voice sparking like firecrackers.

“And the *best* part?” she added, wiping a tear from her eyes. “The guest human musicians were so confused they thought they were hallucinating!”

Thornaria’s laughter deepened, warm with nostalgia.

“Yes... the guest performers.”

Her thorned mask tilted thoughtfully.

“The Kamihama High student orchestra... and that rock band, what were they called? Ah—**Second Period Detention**. It was their first time in the dream-realm, seeing magical girls and witches with their own eyes.”

A beat passed, faint with curiosity.

“How are they doing now?”

Kasumi’s eyes lit up, her grin radiant.

“Oh, they’re doing *great*! Yes, that was their first time here. Lunaria and I explained magical girls to them beforehand, so they had some idea—but seeing witches, monsters, legends—in real life?”

She giggled. “Their faces were priceless.”

Lunaria’s smile softened, her indigo eyes shimmering with quiet warmth.

“They said their time here was wonderful,” she said gently. “They want to come back and perform again. For now, they’re creating music and sharing it online. They’re reaching out to other guest

performers from around the world who've visited this realm, hoping to collaborate and spread their art even further."

Her voice grew gentler, her expression luminous with hope.

"I truly wish their music will comfort magical girls everywhere," Lunaria murmured. "That when they listen... their spirits will lift. Even if only for a moment. That their hearts will feel peace and joy — however brief."

Through Connect, Mami froze.

Her breath caught in her throat, awe blooming through her chest.

She had known Lunaria and Kasumi traveled the world.

She had known they reached out to magical girls, learned their stories, offered comfort, support, and friendship.

She remembered the Kamihama talent show three days prior — the shock and beauty of it.

Kasumi blazing across the stage with Second Period Detention, her voice fierce and raw.

Lunaria performing with the Kamihama High orchestra, her flute singing a melody that felt like a prayer.

Beside Mami in the audience, Iroha, Yachiyo, Felicia, Sana, Tsuruno — all of them — had felt it too.

It had been more than a performance.

It had been a message.

A warm embrace.

Something that reached into their souls and reminded them they were not alone.

But she had never imagined this.

That Lunaria and Kasumi had brought those human musicians into the dream-realm.

That humans — ordinary students — had walked these paths, met magical girls and witches, seen Thornaria's vines and these crystalline gardens with their own eyes.

Kasumi's offhand remark echoed in her mind:

"Lunaria and I explained magical girls to them beforehand."

Was that why their music struck so deeply?

Why their songs felt like letters written straight to magical girls' hearts?

Did Lunaria and Kasumi share the truth with humans all around the world?

Did they invite humans into this realm—musicians, artists, storytellers, scholars, ordinary people—letting them witness what magical girls endured?

The thought shook her.

Are they... building bridges?

Between magical girls and humans.

*Between a world that demands their sacrifice... and one that sees them, cherishes them, sings for them.
To have both worlds support each other?*

The dream-realm seemed to shimmer around her.

Her heart swelled — with awe, with wonder, with a fragile, blossoming hope.

And then, the comparison struck her.

This was similar to when she had invited Madoka and Sayaka to her witch hunts — so they could understand what they were getting into if they chose to make a contract with Kyubey. She had wanted them to see the truth, to know the cost, to prepare themselves.

But what Lunaria and Kasumi were doing was on a completely different scale.

They weren't just preparing magical girls for despair.

They were trying to change the narrative entirely.

To connect magical girls and humans.

To heal the silence magical girls had been trapped in for so long.

The idea was staggering.

Beautiful.

Revolutionary.

Kyoko leaned in, her crimson eyes glinting with curiosity, a teasing smirk tugging at her lips.

“Ooooh? So the two mysterious hostesses travel around the world, inviting human musicians here? Supporting magical girls everywhere?”

Her tone was playful, but there was real awe beneath it — a spark of admiration she didn't bother to hide.

Kasumi nodded eagerly, her twin-tails bouncing like blazing tassels.

“Yup, you nailed it!” she beamed. “Lunaria and I travel all over. We've had so many adventures—”

And then she launched into her stories like fireworks exploding in rapid, colorful succession.

“Okay, picture this,” she said, arms sweeping so wide she nearly smacked a bird out of the air. “We're in this tiny mountain village in Peru, right? They're holding this wild festival with masks and drums — so of course we join the parade. I stole—ahem, borrowed—a drum, Lunaria whipped out her flute, and boom! Suddenly we're the stars of the procession!”

Kyoko snorted.

“Figures. You probably made a fool of yourself.”

Kasumi puffed her cheeks with faux dignity.

“Excuse me, I was a sensation. Kids swarmed me like I was their new mascot! Lunaria had to drag me away before I started a cult.”

Kyoko barked a laugh.

“Yeah, that sounds like you.”

Kasumi leaned in conspiratorially, lowering her voice.

“And then—Paris. We walk into this tiny café where some jazz musicians are jamming. I grab a guitar, Lunaria pulls out her harp, and we just jump in. No warning, no introduction. The crowd absolutely lost it — thought we were a traveling duo.”

Kyoko raised an eyebrow, unimpressed but undeniably curious.

“You just barged in? Bold move.”

Kasumi flicked her hair proudly.

“Of course! We had a jazz face-off with them. It was epic.”

Kyoko grinned. “So who won?”

Kasumi winked. “That’s a secret~”

She bounced on her heels, words tumbling even faster.

“Oh! And Kyoto! We met this old storyteller who swore fox spirits walked the streets at night. He told us about one who could slip between the realms. And guess what? Later that night we found her — she was actually a magical girl! Gorgeous white fur, glowing eyes, and this regal vibe—”

Kyoko’s eyes widened, her grin sharpening like a blade.

“Now that’s cool. A fox-spirit magical girl who can slip between worlds? Bet she’d be fun to fight.”

Kasumi gasped dramatically.

“Fight?! She was elegant and mysterious, not a punching bag!”

Kyoko shrugged with a smirk.

“Magical girls fight. She’s gotta have a combat form. Maybe a fox demon?”

Kasumi laughed, shaking her head.

“You really are pure battle instinct.”

Kyoko thumped her chest proudly.

“That’s me — Kyoko Sakura!”

Lunaria’s voice flowed in next, calm and steady, like moonlight softening Kasumi’s fire.

“Beyond having fun and discovering cultures, we try to reach as many magical girls as we can on our

travels,” she said softly. “We listen to their stories. Their hopes. Their grief. We offer support where we can. Friendship. Understanding. There is so much to learn from them—what they endure, what they overcome.”

Her gaze turned toward Thornaria, her eyes shadowed with sorrow.

“As you heard... Thornaria and her friends were feared by their village. When their powers were exposed, the people... responded with violence.”

Her voice grew quieter, trembling at the edges.

“They executed their families. They hunted them. They destroyed everything they had.”

Lunaria brought her hands to her chest, her voice slowing, thick with emotion.

“We dream of a world where magical girls are not feared. Where everyone can share their lives — their joy, their sorrows — without hiding. Where they can laugh openly, cry openly, grow together, and even argue and banter with each other.”

Her eyes closed, her voice trembling with sorrow.

“If such a world had existed back then... Thornaria and her friends would not have suffered that tragedy. They would have lived with their families, their village, happily and fully without fear.”

Kyoko swallowed hard.

“Wow... so that is what both of you are...”

The vision was enormous — impossible — and yet it resonated so deeply she couldn’t deny it.

She thought of her own battles in shadowed alleys, unthanked, unseen.

She thought of Mami — strong, graceful, always smiling... yet forced to hide every wound behind a polite mask.

She thought of magical girls fighting alone until they broke, until despair swallowed them whole.

Her voice cracked, but her grin warmed, fiercer than ever.

“If normal people actually knew about magical girls... if they showed gratitude, gave support... we’d have more reason to fight. More joy. More purpose.”

She raised a fiery thumbs-up.

“I dig it! Good luck! I wanna see that world one day.”

Then she winked.

“And when that day comes, I expect you two to stop hiding and finally spill your secrets.”

Kasumi laughed, her eyes glowing with affection.

“Thanks, Kyoko! And yeah — if that day comes, you’ll know way more about us.”

Her voice brightened, like sunrise breaking through clouds.

“One way we’re trying to make that world real is by befriending humans during our travels. Once we trust them — and they trust us — we share the truth about magical girls.”

She gestured dramatically, her grin enormous.

“Like those musicians in Kamihama we were just talking about! Lunaria and I heard strange rumors about the city, so we went to check it out. We met normal students—some in the Kamihama High orchestra, others in the rock band *Second Period Detention*. They were energetic, kind, and passionate. We hung out, played together, built bonds. And once those bonds were strong enough... we shared the world of magical girls with them.”

Her eyes sparkled.

“We brought them here, to this dream-realm! They saw magical girls, witches, monsters, legends with their own eyes. They even performed here in front of everyone—it was awesome; they had the time of their lives!”

Her grin softened into something more tender, her voice softened.

“They were so touched by the experience and wanted to help. Afterwards, they asked us to help them write music to lift magical girls’ hearts. Songs that could speak to them. Encourage them. Give them strength.”

She pressed a hand to her chest.

“They want to perform for magical girls on Earth someday.”

Through Connect, Mami smiled, her heart blooming.

So that’s how Lunaria and Kasumi performed as guests in the Kamihama talent show with those students.

The memory shimmered in her mind—the stage lights, the music, the way it had resonated so deeply. Now, knowing the story behind it, the performances felt even richer, layered with meaning and connection.

She closed her eyes, her thoughts drifting.

The way Lunaria had described Thornaria’s tragedy was so full of sorrow, so heavy with regret. Mami could feel the ache in her voice, as if Lunaria carried the weight of those deaths in her own heart.

It reminded her of her dream last night—where she and Kyoko had replaced the two girls without Soul Gems in the mural, rewriting the ending. An ending where no one became witches. Where all twelve girls lived in peace and unity.

Her heart ached with the thought.

If only Lunaria and Kasumi had been there back then. If only they had saved those girls, as they saved me. How differently would their lives have gone?

Other dream-realm islands

Kasumi clapped her hands together — sharp, bright, the sound ringing like the crack of sunlight breaking through a veil of clouds.

“Alright! Enough heavy talk for today!” she declared, her grin blazing with irrepressible fire. “Time for the fun part. Lunaria and I are giving Kyoko Sakura a grand tour of the dream-realm!”

Her voice carried a playful authority — the kind no one could resist, not even Kyoko.

Thornaria’s layered laughter rippled through the crystalline garden, warm and mischievous, like wind slipping through enchanted vines. Her silhouette tilted toward them, glowing eyes softened with affection.

“Farewell for now,” she murmured. “Kyoko... you are in for a true marvel. This realm has a habit of blowing minds apart in the gentlest possible way.”

Kyoko snorted, tossing her crimson hair with a fiery flick.

“My mind’s already been blown six times in the past hour,” she shot back. “I’m honestly curious what’s left.”

Thornaria extended a thorn-wrapped hand. Kyoko clasped it without hesitation. Their handshake was firm, warm — the kind forged not in battle, but in shared revelation.

Lunaria and Kasumi waved as Thornaria’s form dissolved gently into drifting petals.

“See you later, Thornaria,” Lunaria said, her voice soft as moonlit water.

Kasumi winked. “And don’t cause *too* much trouble without us!”

Then she spun toward Kyoko, motioning grandly.

“Come on! The tour begins now!”

As they wove deeper into the garden, Kyoko’s confident stride melted into awe-struck wandering. She moved like a child rediscovering a forgotten playground, darting from one marvel to the next.

She knelt to examine blossoms shaped like crystalline teardrops, petals shimmering with inner starlight. Their perfume was sweet and bright, like citrus drifting on wind. She plucked a fruit pulsing with soft gold, bit into it with a loud crunch, and laughed as luminous juice dripped down her chin.

“Damn—this tastes like... sunshine?” she mumbled, baffled and delighted.

Butterflies with wings like stained glass flitted past her cheeks; she chased them on impulse, laughing with a freedom she had not felt since childhood. Her voice rang raw and honest across the open air.

“I haven’t felt this light in... I don’t even know how long,” she breathed. “Everything I’ve learned here — it’s like the weight on my heart finally broke apart. I feel like I can... live again. Like when I was a kid, before I became a magical girl.”

Lunaria and Kasumi exchanged a quiet look, their smiles tender, shimmering with unspoken joy. They didn’t comment — they didn’t need to. Their eyes said everything: *welcome back, Kyoko*.

The garden around them shifted subtly, revealing its full life in motion.

Magical girls rested beneath the shade of giant glass-petaled flowers, their conversations drifting like soft wind chimes. Others splashed in winding rivers of silver-blue water, droplets scattering into glittering arcs that refracted the warm sunlight. A few darted between columns of flowering vines, playing tag with breathless laughter. Some perched high in crystalline branches, reading, humming, or braiding each other’s hair.

And woven among them were witches — gentle, strange, dream-soft beings whose monstrous silhouettes had been smoothed and stylized by the realm’s benevolence. Their forms glowed faintly, as if carved from moonlit smoke or stained-glass shadow. They lounged peacefully beneath the trees, exchanged gestures of greeting, or helped younger girls catch floating seeds of light.

Everywhere Lunaria and Kasumi passed, smiles blossomed like flowers turning toward the sun. Hands waved. Names were called. Laughter rippled.

Kasumi waved back so energetically she nearly tripped over a cluster of luminescent mushrooms, and Lunaria responded with serene bows and warm, melodic greetings — like a flute acknowledging each person individually.

It wasn’t just friendliness.

It was *family*.

Then curious eyes turned toward Kyoko.

“Are you the new essence saved here?” voices whispered, full of awe and excitement.

Kyoko lifted her chin proudly, tossing her crimson hair with a fiery grin.

“Yup! Name’s Kyoko Sakura! Nice to meet ya!”

The introductions came in a bright, dizzying stream — names, smiles, laughter, personalities sparkling like facets of cut gems.

And then came the invitations.

A magical girl with star-shaped freckles leaned forward, eyes shining.

“Kyoko, want to race down the river with us? The current carries you like flying!”

A gentle witch shaped like swirling ribbons of velvet leaned in next.

“We were about to practice dances for the evening celebration. You’re welcome to join.”

A tall girl with wind-swept hair pointed deeper into the garden.

“Some of us are heading to the melody fields later — the flowers there play music when you touch them. You should come!”

A trio lounging in the grass waved her over.

“We’re planning a round of radiant tag. It gets *intense*. Wanna join?”

Another group — two magical girls and a willow-limbed witch — whispered conspiratorially.

“We know a hidden corner of the garden where the starlight pools like liquid. It’s beautiful. We can show you.”

And beneath every invitation, every gesture, every smile...

Kyoko felt the warmth of something she had long considered impossible:

Magical girls and witches playing together. Trusting each other.

Living in peace.

Kyoko barked a laugh — half overwhelmed, half delighted.

“Everything sounds awesome! I wanna meet all of you!”

The girls cheered, and a few witches spun their ribbonlike limbs in delighted spirals. Even the garden itself seemed to glow brighter, as if feeding on Kyoko’s revitalized fire.

But the invitations didn’t stop there.

A pair of girls carrying baskets woven from light approached, their scents fragrant with spices and sweetness.

One beamed.

“Kyoko! We’re all grabbing food later. You should come — there’s this place with noodles that sparkle like tiny stars, and fruit pastries that melt the moment you bite them.”

Her friend nodded vigorously.

“They even have savory skewers that taste different depending on your mood. You’d *love* them.”

Kyoko’s eyes widened, her grin igniting instantly.

“Oh hell yes, count me in! Food that changes flavor? I’m not missing that.”

The girls laughed, delighted by her enthusiasm.

Then another cluster jogged over — magical girls and a small, lantern-bodied witch who bobbed in the air like a cheerful balloon.

“Kyoko!” one called. “Later today we’re going somewhere with soaring tracks and gravity loops — it feels like falling and flying at the same time!”

The lantern-witch chimed with a crystalline “plonk,” bouncing up and down in excitement.

“It’s wild,” another girl explained, practically vibrating. “Your stomach flips, your soul flips — in a good way! You have to try it!”

Kyoko's eyes flashed with competitive fire.

"Anything that throws me around sounds awesome! I'm in."

A few steps later, a different group waved her over — three magical girls sitting among rainbow-colored lilies, surrounded by floating ribbons of cloth and shimmering palettes of color.

The boldest of the trio leaned forward, eyes sparkling.

"Kyoko, right? Come with us later! We're going to try on outfits and summon new looks. You'd be adorable in darker shades — or something fiery!"

Her friend giggled.

"We could even try different hairstyles on you~"

Kyoko froze mid-step.

"Uh—"

Her voice cracked faintly.

Then she coughed, straightened, and forced out a half-grin.

"Makeup and dress-up isn't really my thing, but... hanging out sounds cool. I'm down."

The girls cheered as if she'd agreed to a sacred pact.

Kyoko rubbed the back of her neck, muttering,

"Just don't expect me to wear frills."

A nearby witch with a soft, moss-like form patted her shoulder comfortingly, as if to say: *we'll go easy on you.*

And through it all, the invitations continued — each one a glimpse into something larger, stranger, and more wondrous than this single garden.

Kyoko's grin only grew.

Her heart raced with excitement, confusion, and something like joy.

Just how big is this place?

How many worlds are hidden inside this one? What else is here?

The realm didn't answer.

But the laughter, the invitations, the shimmering sky — they whispered promises of wonders she had yet to see.

Eventually, the trio reached the garden's edge.

And Kyoko froze.

Her breath left her in a stunned exhale, as if the sky itself had gently drawn it away.

Before them stretched a vast celestial ocean — an endless expanse of deep cerulean washed in molten gold, a horizon that looked like dawn caught in an eternal inhale. Clouds drifted lazily in hues of rose, amber, and peach, glowing like illuminated silk unfurling across the heavens. The air shimmered with soft radiance, warm in a way that felt less like sunlight and more like an embrace.

Then Kyoko saw them.

Suspended in the glowing distance — drifting with the slow majesty of islands sailing across a sunlit sky-sea — were countless floating realms.

Some small as drifting petals.

Some vast as kingdoms.

Some gleaming with waterfalls that slipped over their edges in ribbons of liquid starlight.

Some flickering with movement, lights, shadows, colors she couldn't yet name.

Some ringing faintly with music she could barely hear.

Some pulsing with unfamiliar energy, like great hearts beating in time with the realm itself.

All of them hovering in this impossible sky, like fragments of a world reborn from dreams.

Kyoko's lips parted, her voice a fragile whisper trembling with awe:

"This... this looks like heaven. A place where souls can finally rest. A sanctuary for the heart and the spirit."

Her words drifted into the glowing wind, tender and luminous, and for a heartbeat the dream-realm seemed to pause —

as if listening, as if agreeing,

as if welcoming her.

Kyoko turned to Lunaria and Kasumi, her crimson eyes wide, her grin softened into something almost reverent.

"This place... it's truly beautiful. I've never seen anything like it."

Her gaze drifted outward, toward the horizon where countless islands floated like fragments of a dream. Each one shimmered faintly with colors she didn't have names for — hues that seemed to exist only in this sky.

"I'm guessing that's where we're headed next?" she asked, voice hushed with awe.

Then she glanced downward — and froze. The garden itself was suspended high in the sky, its crystalline roots dangling into nothingness. Far below, pink clouds swirled like oceans of rose-colored silk, glowing faintly in the eternal light.

Her voice cracked with disbelief.

"...So how do we get there?"

Kasumi planted her hands on her hips, her grin blazing with theatrical confidence.
“We fly!” she declared, her voice ringing out like a trumpet fanfare echoing across the sky.

She cocked her head, winked, and added with mischievous sparkle,
“Prepare yourself—you’re about to witness something *legendary*.”

Kyoko smirked, folding her arms.
“Alright, hotshot. Impress me.”

Her imagination immediately ran wild: Kasumi erupting wings of blazing fire; Kasumi summoning a dragon-shaped glider; Kasumi shouting “Extreme Sky Dive!” while riding a meteor made of starlight. Something wild. Something loud. Something Kasumi.

Instead, Kasumi crouched low, her twin-tails bouncing like eager flames.
“Here I gooooo!” she shouted—and sprinted toward the edge like a cartoon heroine aiming for glory.

Kyoko leaned forward, eyes bright with anticipation.
Kasumi *launched* herself off the ledge, one arm raised in a superhero pose, the other curled dramatically at her hip.
She struck midair with all the confidence in the world.

Kyoko burst into laughter, leaning forward eagerly.
“Ha! You look ridiculous! What’s next, fireworks?”

But then—Kasumi’s upward momentum died.
Slowly.
Inevitably.

“Ohhhh nooooo! Not again!” Kasumi wailed as she began to sink.

Her grin twisted into theatrical despair.
“WAAAAAAAAAAH!” she screamed, spinning, flipping, flailing every limb in chaotic desperation. She tumbled downward, her voice echoing like a theatrical death cry, until she vanished into the rosy clouds below.

Kyoko’s laughter died instantly. She lunged to the edge, gripping crystalline vines.
“KASUMI!”

Her voice tore raw through the warm wind.
“KASUMI!”

Her heart pounded.
Then she heard laughter behind her.

She turned—only to see Lunaria laughing softly, her voice like tinkling bells, calm as moonlight.

Kyoko stared, incredulous.

“You’re laughing?! She *fell*! What do we do?!”

Lunaria’s indigo eyes shimmered with amusement.

“Go ahead and jump,” she said gently. “You’ll be fine.”

Kyoko blinked.

“...You’re joking. You want me to jump off the edge?!”

Her gaze dropped again to the endless depths of cloud and sky.

Her stomach tightened. Every instinct screamed *no*.

But she was Kyoko Sakura.

Her fire didn’t back down from anything.

She clenched her fists, hopped lightly on her heels, exhaled.

“Alright... fine. If Kasumi can do it, so can I.”

She sprinted forward and leapt.

For a heartbeat, exhilaration flooded her—wind rushing past her ears, the incredible freedom of open sky.

Then the velocity slowed.

Her body began to sink.

Her heart hammered, her breath quickened.

“Oh no... oh no, I’m falling too—”

But then, she stopped. Suspended weightlessly in warm, golden air.

Kyoko blinked, then broke into a fiery grin.

“Whoa! This is insane!”

She twisted, flipped, spun in wild arcs, experimenting with every motion. She darted upward, downward, sideways, laughing with unrestrained delight.

“I’m flying! I’m actually flying!”

Lunaria rose from the garden with serene grace, joining her effortlessly. Her motions were delicate, elegant—like moonbeams drifting through water. She twirled, her hair and ribbons trailing like soft starlight.

Kyoko swooped over to her, still laughing.

“How is this happening? And what about Kasumi? She fell straight through the clouds!”

Lunaria chuckled, her eyes mischievous.

“You said this place looks like heaven, didn’t you?”

She spread her arms wide, twirling gracefully as the sky shimmered around her.

“This dream-realm knows people’s hearts. Kasumi cannot fly because she is too naughty, unfit for the skies. But you... and I... the realm has deemed us worthy. Our hearts are pure.”

Kyoko barked a laugh, fiery and incredulous.

“Oh come on. You’re totally messing with her. Saying that just means you two must be super close.”

Lunaria’s smile softened, her eyes sparkling.

“We are. She’s very dear to me. I hope you have someone like that too—someone who stays beside you, even when the world collapses.”

Kyoko’s grin faded into something gentler. Her eyes softened, her heart warmed.

“...Yeah. I do.”

She looked up toward the radiant sky, her voice thick with emotion.

“Mami. She’s my best friend. Strong, graceful... and she always knows how to steady me when I’m losing it. She’s... someone I trust with everything.”

The dream-realm seemed to hush around her, as if listening.

Through Connect, Mami felt her breath hitch.

Hearing Kyoko say this—openly, freely, lovingly—struck her deeper than she expected. Kyoko said something similar to her yesterday, but now, hearing Kyoko speak of her like this to *others*... it warmed her soul like sunlight.

Lunaria’s expression glowed with warmth.

“Mami sounds like a wonderful person. I hope I can meet her someday.”

Kyoko nodded, her grin returning.

“She’d love this place. I hope we can bring her here one day.”

Through Connect, Mami smiled, her heart swelling. She had already met Lunaria and Kasumi, already glimpsed this realm through Kyoko’s eyes. But truly being here, meeting all the saved essences herself, was something she longed for.

Kyoko smirked, glancing down toward the rosy clouds.

“Speaking of friends... should we just leave Kasumi down there and explore without her?”

Lunaria giggled, her indigo eyes gleaming.

“Yes, let her flail. We’ll see her later—and she will absolutely guilt-trip us with her ‘How could you abandon meeee?’ face.”

Kyoko burst into laughter, her fiery grin flashing.

“Heh! I *have* to see that.”

Lunaria winked, then soared ahead into the open sky.

“Come, Kyoko. Let’s see what awaits.”

Kyoko laughed, kicked off the air, streaking after her with fiery joy—
two sparks of flame and moonlight weaving through the boundless heavens,
toward the drifting dream-islands waiting in the distance.

As Lunaria and Kyoko soared onward, a sudden wave of cheering and clapping rippled through the sky, like wind stirring chimes made of starlight. Kyoko turned her head—and her breath snagged in her throat.

Suspended in the air ahead was a dazzling constellation of rings, orbs, and star-shaped glyphs of living light. They twinkled like fragments of some celestial mural come undone, scattered lovingly across the heavens.

Threading through them were two magical girls in radiant flight.

They moved with effortless grace, their bodies arc’ing in fluid ribbons. Trails of shimmering dust streamed behind them—scarlet, pearly gold, brilliant violet—interlacing into swirling calligraphy across the sky-sea.

Whenever one passed through a ring, the glowing circle burst into motes that sank into her chest like blessings. When another brushed an orb of light, it rippled through her veins and left her glowing.

Sometimes they traced loops around the stars with their trailing sparkles, igniting them into bursts of brilliance. Their performance was not just skill — it was artistry. Grace, style, and personal flair shone through every motion. A language of movement, emotion, and magic.

Around them floated spectators — magical girls, witches, monsters, and legends alike — cheering, clapping, laughing, their voices ringing like bells across the sky.

Kyoko’s eyes widened, her grin breaking into astonished delight.

“...What the hell? I’ve never seen anything like this.”

Lunaria chuckled softly, her voice calm and melodic.

“This is one of the many sports people enjoy here, **Dreamweaving**. A blend of flight, dance, and challenge. The goal is to collect as many of the lights as possible while moving with grace and

precision. Some play alone, some in duos, some in larger teams. It's about finding flow — speed, elegance, and improvisation.”

Kyoko barked a laugh, shaking her head.

“Looks cool. But honestly? This is way more Mami's thing. She's all about grace and elegance. Me? I'd just brute force it — blaze through the course, smash every ring head-on, and call it ‘Kyoko-brand flair.’”

Her grin sharpened, mischievous.

“Imagine me and Mami teaming up for this. She'd be yelling at me to slow down, I'd be yelling at her to speed up. We'd spend more time arguing than flying.”

Through Connect, Mami laughed aloud, her composure breaking into warmth. She could already picture it — Kyoko charging recklessly ahead, herself trying to maintain poise, both of them bickering mid-flight while the audience roared with amusement. The thought filled her with both dread and fondness.

They continued upward, weaving through soft winds.

As they flew onward, Kyoko's attention was caught by another spectacle.

Ahead, a line of magical girls, witches, monsters, and legends moved chaotically in unison. Sparkles of light hovered around each of them, glowing like tiny stars tethered to their bodies. Some screamed with joy and exhilaration, others with fear and dread, some squeezed their eyes shut tight.

Then, on some invisible signal — they all *dove* downward in a spiraling free fall, vanishing into the rosy clouds below, just as Kasumi had earlier.

Kyoko gasped, her eyes wide.

“Is that... the soaring tracks and gravity loops those girls and the lantern-witch were talking about? So going below the clouds is safe?”

Lunaria nodded, her smile serene.

“Yes. It's like a roller coaster, but powered by ambient magic. The sparkles guide their descent. There's no set track — the magic moves them in chaotic, unpredictable ways. No two rides are ever the same.”

Kyoko swallowed, then broke into a feral grin.

“That looked way crazier than any roller coaster I've ever ridden. The adrenaline must be unreal.”

Her grin widened, nostalgic fire flickering in her voice.

“I'd love to go on that ride! Back on Earth, I loved roller coasters. I used to drag Mami along with me all the time. She hated the intense ones.”

She winked, her grin wicked.

“I’ve got embarrassing pictures of her on those rides. She gets this terrified face, clutching the bar like she’s about to die. She hates it when I bring those up.”

Through Connect, Mami pouted, her cheeks warming.

“Kyoko...” she murmured, mortified but smiling.

Kyoko laughed, imagining Mami’s reaction.

“If she went on *this* thing, she’d pass out halfway down.”

Mami chuckled despite herself, shuddering at the thought. The chaotic magic roller-coaster was far beyond earthly physics. If she ever came to this realm, she would need to invent some excuse to wiggle out of Kyoko’s inevitable insistence.

Lunaria laughed, her voice ringing like silver bells.

“You should see what happens when Kasumi takes control of the sparkles. The ride becomes absolute chaos — a thrill for some, a nightmare for others. Screams of joy and terror all at once. Truly unforgettable.”

Kyoko burst into fiery laughter, her grin blazing.

“Oh man, that I need to see. Kasumi steering a magic roller coaster? That’s a disaster waiting to happen.”

Her laughter echoed across the sky, mingling with the cheers and cries of the riders below, as the dream-realm unfolded more of its wonders before her.

The sky was alive with motion.

As Lunaria and Kyoko flew onward, they saw countless groups of magical girls and witches drifting through the heavens together — laughing, talking, weaving trails of light behind them. It reminded her of bustling city streets, if the streets were clouds and every passerby carried a spark of magic instead of a briefcase.

Far groups waved at Lunaria and Kyoko with radiant excitement. Lunaria returned the gestures with calm grace; Kyoko responded with exaggerated enthusiasm, waving so hard she nearly spun herself around.

Closer clusters approached—each bringing something new from the world of drifting islands.

The first group was a lively cluster of magical girls carrying baskets that shimmered with glowing ingredients. One girl with flour-dusted cheeks waved enthusiastically.

“Kyoko! We’re heading to the cook-off arena. It’s a competition — everyone makes something, the audience gets to taste and judge. You should join us!”

Her friend chimed in, holding up a glowing fruit.

“Last time, someone made noodles that sang when you slurped them. It was wild.”

Kyoko barked a laugh, her crimson eyes flashing.

“I can’t cook for jack. My specialty is throwing everything in a pan and calling it ‘Kyoko’s surprise.’ But judging? Oh yeah. Sign me up for free food.”

They cheered and zipped toward a distant island glowing like an enchanted kitchen stadium.

Next came a pair of witches, their forms softened into dreamlike silhouettes of ribbons and lanterns.

They twirled in the air, their voices melodic.

“We’re going to the karaoke hall,” one said warmly. “Singing, dancing, laughter — everyone joins in. No judgment, just fun.”

Kyoko smirked, her grin mischievous.

“Karaoke, huh? I’d belt out something loud enough to shake the walls. Just don’t complain if you all go deaf, ‘kay?”

The witches giggled, bowing before drifting onward, their laughter trailing like bells.

Then a group of magical girls streaked past, their movements sharp and competitive. One called out, her voice ringing with challenge.

“We’re racing to the coliseum! Sparring matches today — duels, team fights, all friendly. No despair, just skill and fun. You’d love it!”

Kyoko’s grin sharpened, her fire blazing.

“Now *that’s* my kind of place. Count me in sometime. I’ll fight anyone, anytime.”

The girls whooped, clapping her on the back before streaking off toward a golden island shaped like a vast arena, its arches glowing with anticipation.

Finally, a mixed group approached — magical girls, witches, and even a small monster with crystalline wings. Their laughter was chaotic, their formation zigzagging wildly.

“Kyoko!” one shouted. “We’re heading to the haunted dungeon. It’s like a magical haunted house — traps, illusions, monsters. You have to work together to fight your way out.”

Another girl added, eyes gleaming.

“It’s terrifying and hilarious at the same time. You’ll scream, you’ll laugh, you’ll fight — all at once.”

Kyoko’s eyes widened, her grin igniting instantly.

“Oh hell yes. That sounds amazing. I’d blaze straight through every trap. My good friend Mami would probably scold me for charging ahead, but hey — someone’s gotta break the walls down.”

Through Connect, Mami sighed, then laughed softly. She could already imagine it: Kyoko charging recklessly into illusions, herself trying to strategize, both of them arguing mid-dungeon while ghosts and monsters cackled around them.

Everywhere they went, Kyoko was greeted, welcomed, invited. Each group offered a glimpse of the dream-realm's endless wonders — cook-offs, karaoke halls, coliseums, haunted dungeons, and more.

Kyoko laughed, her heart swelling with warmth.

"This is just like back in the garden," she said, her voice raw with joy. "Everyone's so damn friendly. It's like... I'm part of something bigger."

Lunaria smiled, her indigo eyes shimmering.

"Yes. That's the heart of this realm. Connection. Joy. Freedom."

Kyoko's grin softened, her voice quieter now.

"...I haven't felt this welcome in a long time."

The dream-realm seemed to glow brighter around her, as if responding to her words.

Kyoko turned to Lunaria, her crimson eyes gleaming with restless fire.

"There are so many places, so many things to do," she said, her grin sharp with anticipation. "Where are we going first?"

Lunaria's indigo gaze softened, her smile serene.

"The coliseum," she replied. "That is where you will begin your training — to learn how to transform negativity and despair into strength. To discover a new way of living as a magical girl, without grief seeds."

She winked, her voice playful but edged with promise.

"And it is also where you can spar with others — magical girls, witches, monsters, even legends. You were invited earlier, weren't you? And I believe you love scrapping, right?"

Kyoko's grin widened, her fire blazing.

"You know it. Let's go."

Together they streaked across the sky, flame and moonlight weaving side by side.

When the coliseum island came into view, Kyoko's breath caught. She had expected something artificial — cold stone, rigid walls, a sterile arena. But what unfolded before her was seamless harmony, a place where nature and architecture had fused into something alive.

Mountains and cliffs rose into sculpted terraces, their stone faces carved into columns that resembled tree trunks, vines spiraling around marble. Archways draped in flowering plants stretched like living bridges, half-grown, half-crafted, as if the realm itself had sculpted them.

Water spilled from the coliseum walls in cascading waterfalls, mist drifting into luminous pools below. Springs fed clear channels that wound through walkways, their surfaces shimmering with faint magical glyphs. Fountains shaped like motifs of magical girls — bows, shields, ribbons — breathed streams of water that glowed faintly, as if alive.

Above, hanging gardens cascaded from balconies, vines and blossoms tumbling like green waterfalls. Floating flora drifted lazily in the air, petals glowing faintly, their fragrance carried on the wind. The ground was lush grass, dotted with flowers of impossible hues, soft beneath the feet of those who walked.

It was not a coliseum of stone. It was a coliseum of life.

At the summit, the arena revealed itself—a vast expanse of forest and field. Trees, rocks, shimmering ponds, and natural rises in the terrain shaped the battlefield. Massive flower-pods drifted above like suspended stadium seats, their unfurled petals forming platforms where spectators laughed, cheered, and clapped.

And within the arena, radiant chaos unfolded.

Teams of magical girls, witches, monsters, and legends clashed in brilliant combat.

Spells burst like fireworks.

Swords and scythes gleamed in spiraling arcs.

Wings of shadow and light cut through the air.

Laughter, shouts of triumph, and the roar of magic filled the expanse.

It wasn't war born of despair.

It was joy.

Connection.

Skill.

Heart.

Kyoko's eyes widened, her grin blazing into astonished delight.

"This... this is amazing. I've never seen anything like it. Looks like a full-blown magical war!"

Lunaria's smile deepened.

"This is the main coliseum. What you see now is a team battle royale. They are extremely popular here — not only for their intensity, but for the emotions and bonds forged between teammates. Victory is not just about strength. It is about trust."

Her voice grew softer, more reverent.

"There is a technique known as Connect. It allows people to open themselves fully — to sync their magic and their souls. They share their essences, the core of who they are. And from Connect, their powers are not merely added together. They are significantly magnified. They gain new abilities, new

forms, new possibilities — limited only by imagination. Connect is one of the highlights of these battles.”

She turned to Kyoko, her indigo eyes shimmering.

“And you will learn it here. It will serve you well. For your friends, and for your real self one day.”

Through Connect, Mami’s golden eyes narrowed, her polite composure cracking ever so slightly.

Wait... So Kyoko knew about Connect?

Then why... why did she act clueless during beginner training yesterday?

The memory rose sharply:

The title of the recommended beginner Connect training: **“Hold hands and walk through a nightmare together.”**

Mami had instinctively refused — cheeks warm, insisting it was “awkward” and “needlessly sentimental.”

Kyoko had agreed in a heartbeat — claiming it didn’t fit her personality either, that holding hands would be “too mushy.”

Because of that mutual refusal, they had failed to Connect throughout the entire training.

And Kasumi had “punished” them by throwing them against six witches at once: **Thornaria, Velmira, Ruinelle, Catastrophia, Noctulisse, Vexaphra.**

A full gauntlet of nightmares.

Mami’s thoughts churned, conflicted.

Did Kyoko do that on purpose? Did she want us to fail so she could fight longer? Was she messing with me? Or... did she just want to stay by my side for a bit more time?

But then — why had she sounded so shocked when they Connected today? Her awe had felt genuine, her voice raw with wonder at the magic flowing through her veins.

Mami’s lips twitched, an annoyed, affectionate pout tugging at them.

Kyoko... you’re reckless. Infuriating. Impossible.

Her breath softened, her heart aching with nostalgia.

And yet... maybe you just wanted to fight with me again. Like the old days. Maybe you wanted us to share that chaos together.

Her expression shifted into a mischievous, elegant smile — the kind she used to wear when scolding Kyoko between battles, half stern, half fond.

When this is over, I will be having a word with her. A very pointed one.

And yet, beneath the irritation, warmth bloomed.

A soft, warm laugh drifted through the Connect link — the sound of someone who was annoyed, nostalgic, and deeply relieved that Kyoko was still Kyoko.

Summary of Kyoko's experiences

Through Connect, Mami felt herself drawn deeper into Kyoko's memories — not fragments of battle alone, but the full tapestry of her time in the dream-realm. What unfolded before her was not a single story, but a journey, rich and layered, mirroring so much of her own struggles in the waking world.

Mami saw Kyoko in the coliseum.

A dim horizon shimmered into being, the battlefield dissolving into shadow.

Then Umbra Ambraciel stepped forward.

Her presence was quiet, yet it filled the air like the hush before a storm. She was humanoid in outline but impossibly otherworldly, her existence bending the light around her. Her skin glowed with soft lunar luminescence — pale gray, smooth as carved moonstone. Her long black hair drifted weightlessly as though suspended underwater, shifting in slow, fluid currents that breathed shadow.

But it was her eyes that caught Mami — that caught Kyoko.

Deep, layered pools of color and darkness.

Like galaxies glimpsed through a veil.

Like emotion itself distilled into light.

Her tunic of shadow flowed around her body like sentient mist, dissolving at its edges, reforming with each subtle breath. A thin silver-thread belt at her waist glinted like a captured constellation. She bore no soul gem, no emblem, no contract. She was not a magical girl — nor a witch. She existed outside Kyubey's system entirely.

And still, Kyoko faced her head-on.

Mami felt the hammering of Kyoko's heart, the pulse of instinctive fear, the animal urge to recoil from the abyss. Yet beneath it was something steadier — the spine of a girl who refused to bow.

Umbra raised a hand — elegant, patient, frightening in its simplicity.

The world dimmed.

A tendril of shadow extended from her palm and touched Kyoko's soul gem.

A gasp punched through both girls at once — Kyoko's past breath echoing in Mami's present chest. Darkness spilled into the gem like ink unfurling in water. Cold. Heavy. Absolute.

It was the same shadow Mami had once fought — the same power that had tried to swallow her whole, twist her thoughts, drag her into despair. Mami felt a phantom echo of that terror, the memory of corruption pressing against her mind.

But Kyoko...

Kyoko didn't break.

Mami felt it — Kyoko's raw fear, her instinct to tear the gem away, to run, to fight, to purge the taint before it could consume her. But behind the panic was something else, bright and stubborn:

Not this time. Not here. Not me.

Umbra's voice, soft as dusk and resonant as a cathedral's heart, brushed through the memory:

"Yes... good. You are starting to get the hang of this. Keep it up."

The corruption pushed deeper. Kyoko's knees buckled. Her breath shattered. Her emotions roared — anger, grief, hunger, loneliness, guilt — all the terrible things she tried to bury.

Mami felt all of it.

It hurt.

It was beautiful.

Kyoko did not suppress her emotions. She didn't let them master her either. She took hold of them — gripping the darkness like a burning chain — and bent it. Let it twist, coil, move through her. Let it fuel her instead of breaking her.

Her flame, once wild and erratic, flared into a controlled, blazing line. The shadow around her gem stopped spreading. Then it swirled within Kyoko's soul gem, contained, ready to be unleashed.

Umbra smiled, proud.

"Excellent. You did it. Now the next step is for you to use that negativity to amplify your attacks. Here... let me show you."

A memory rose unbidden — Mami fighting Umbra in that other realm. Her first encounter ending in complete terror and defeat. Her second battle still ending in utter defeat, but she had done better, striking back, leaving the faintest mark. She remembered the joy and pride of seeing her own growth, even in loss.

Now, watching Kyoko, Mami felt that same pride bloom again.

A small smile touched her lips — proud, wistful, fond.

Kyoko's journey mirrored hers.

Both of them had faced the shadow.

Both had learned not to fear despair, but to master it.

And Mami's heart whispered, with quiet relief:

She's growing. She's learning. She's still Kyoko... but stronger.

Mami saw Kyoko in the garden island.

The memory shimmered into being — a grove alive with impossible colors, blossoms glowing faintly as if lit from within, rivers of silver-blue water winding through the grass like veins of light. The air itself seemed to breathe, fragrant and warm, carrying the pulse of life.

Kyoko sat at the center, her crimson hair blazing against the verdant expanse. She was restless at first, shifting her weight, arms crossed, eyes darting. Meditation was not her style. Stillness was not her way. But Lunaria and Kasumi had guided her here, told her to try.

Then Kyoko closed her eyes.

Mami felt it through Connect — the moment Kyoko opened herself.

The world surged inward. Vines, blossoms, rivers, the hum of insects, the whisper of wind — all of it poured into her. Kyoko's soul gem glowed faintly, threads of light weaving outward, linking her to the grove itself. She was not simply standing in nature. She was *part* of it.

Her perception shifted. She saw through the roots, felt the slow patience of trees, the resilience of flowers blooming even after storms. She felt the clarity of water, the persistence of grass pushing through stone. Every fragment of life carried its own rhythm, its own wisdom.

And Kyoko understood.

Her fire was not meant to burn alone. It was meant to resonate, to harmonize, to draw strength from the world around her. Her magic flared brighter, steadier, because her mind had found clarity.

Mami's breath caught.

She remembered her own journey — sitting in the grove beside Lunaria, meditating by the lake, learning to quiet her thoughts. She had felt the same pulse of life, the same resonance. She had learned that Connect was not only between magical girls, but between herself and the world.

Now, through Kyoko's memory, she felt it again — but different.

Where Mami's Connect had been serene, Kyoko's was fiery. She did not dissolve into the grove. She blazed within it, her flame weaving into the rhythm of nature without losing its edge. She was not water smoothing stone. She was fire tempered by wind, sharpened by earth, fueled by blossoms.

Mami's golden eyes softened. *She sees life differently now. She sees herself differently. Her magic is stronger because her heart is clearer.*

Kyoko's laughter rang in the memory, raw and unrestrained.

"Heh! Mind blown! I can feel everything. The trees, the rivers, even the bugs. It's like they're all cheering me on."

Her grin was wild, but her voice carried awe.

"I get it now. What Lunaria and Kasumi said... about nature helping us grow stronger. It's true. I'm not just fighting alone anymore. I'm fighting with all of this."

She raised her hand, her soul gem blazing. Sparks of crimson fire burst outward, weaving into the air — not chaotic, but precise, controlled, radiant.

Mami's heart swelled.

She remembered her own hesitation, her own doubts, the way she had struggled to trust Connect. And now she saw Kyoko embracing it fully, finding her own way to balance fire and clarity.

A small smile touched her lips — proud, wistful, deeply fond.

She's learning. She's growing. And she's doing it in her own way.

Mami saw Kyoko in another memory — not alone this time, but surrounded.

The dream-realm shimmered into a gathering place, a meadow of luminous grass where petals drifted like snowflakes and the air itself hummed with quiet anticipation. The ground glowed faintly beneath their feet, as if every blade of grass carried a heartbeat.

Magical girls stood in a circle, their essences saved here, each carrying the faint glow of their soul gems. Some were radiant, others dimmed by sorrow, but all of them alive in a way that transcended despair.

Kyoko stepped forward, her grin softened into something rare — vulnerable, open. She extended her hand.

One girl reached back. Their palms touched.

Mami felt it instantly through Connect — the opening of Kyoko's heart.

It was not just warmth. It was everything.

Prayers whispered in silence.

Sadness heavy as stone.

Rage sharp as broken glass.

Hatred coiled like smoke.

Joy bursting like fireworks.

Pleasure soft as sunlight on skin.

And finally... wishes. Fragile, luminous, trembling with hope.

Each connection was a thread woven into Kyoko's soul. Laughter, sorrow, fragments of stories — all of it became part of her. She carried them not as burdens, but as strength.

Kyoko's fire blazed brighter with each hand she held, each soul she opened herself to. She was not diminished by their pain. She was magnified by their truth.

Mami's breath caught.

She felt the bittersweet ache of it — happiness that Kyoko had opened herself to so many, shared her essence freely, received theirs in return. But beneath the joy was a quiet melancholy.

So... You do know how to Connect, Kyoko. I wasn't the first.

The thought pressed against her heart. Kyoko had already Connected with others, already shared pieces of herself, already felt the rush of souls intertwining.

And yet...

Mami's lips trembled into a smile. *At least we are Connecting now. At least I am part of this journey. My first experience with Connect is amazing — just as Kyoko felt with each of these girls in the past.*

Her golden eyes softened, shimmering with pride and wistful longing.

Kyoko's laughter rang in the memory, raw and unrestrained.

"Whoa! This is crazy. I can feel everything — your pain, your joy, your wishes. It's like we're all carrying each other."

Her grin was wild, but her voice carried awe.

"I get it now. Connect isn't just about fighting stronger. It's about living stronger. Together. I feel like I can take anyone on now!"

The circle of magical girls tightened, hands clasped, gems glowing. Their essences flared in unison, weaving into a radiant tapestry of light.

Mami felt it — the surge of collective strength, the magnification of power, the beauty of souls resonating.

It was overwhelming.

It was beautiful.

It was Connect.

Mami's heart swelled, bittersweet and tender.

She whispered inwardly, through the link:

Kyoko... you've shared yourself with so many. And now, you're sharing yourself with me. I may not have been the first, but I am here. And this... this is enough.

Kyoko vs. Elira — The Telekinetic Sanctuary

The coliseum's stone floor dissolved, shimmering away into a surreal, gravity-defying grove. Massive boulders and severed tree branches drifted lazily through the air, while woodland animals perched calmly on empty space as if physics were merely a suggestion. At the center of it all stood Elira. Her pale-blue cloak twinkled with embroidered stars, and she hummed a soft, sweet melody as an entire ecosystem orbited her in gentle harmony.

Kyoko rested her spear against her shoulders, a sharp, confident grin splitting her face.

"Alright, kid. Let's see what you've got."

Elira giggled, the sound bright and entirely devoid of malice. "Heee, try not to get too hurt, okay?"

With a casual flick of her wrist, the gentle harmony shattered. The floating stones and heavy branches surged forward, weaving into a blinding, hyper-dense storm of projectiles. Kyoko lunged, shattering the first boulder into splinters with her spear, but a dozen more immediately slammed into her flank, sending her skidding sideways across the air.

“Yeow—*tch*, that actually hurt!” Kyoko hissed, rubbing her arm but keeping her eyes locked on the girl. “What, you scared of me or something? Why are you playing sniper from all the way over there?”

Elira’s laughter rang out like bells. Around Kyoko, the ghostly shapes of the floating animals darted playfully, almost as if they were mocking her sluggishness.

“Me? Scared?” Elira beamed. “Okay then, let’s play tag!”

Elira broke into a cheerful sprint straight toward Kyoko. As she ran, the dream-realm reacted to her whims. Stones, heavy logs, and streams of water ripped themselves from the environment, gravitating toward her small frame. They clicked, fused, and swarmed together, assembling a colossal, terrifying golem armor around her—a nightmarish monster born straight from a child’s untamed imagination.

Every step Elira took shook the fabric of the grove, the golem swelling larger and more intimidating with every stride.

Kyoko’s grin faltered. Gritting her teeth, she leveled her weapon. “Like hell you will!”

She thrust her spear forward, triggering the shaft to extend at blinding speed. *Clang!* The tip struck the outer shell of the golem’s rocky armor, but it barely left a scratch. Before Kyoko could retract it, a torrent of swirling water snaked up the shaft, locking the weapon in a telekinetic vice. Kyoko pulled, but the spear refused to budge—Elira was already hijacking its movements.

Sensing the overwhelming shift in momentum, Kyoko didn’t hesitate. She let go, letting the spear dematerialize into red sparks, and immediately spun on her heel to sprint in the opposite direction.

“I take it back!” Kyoko yelled over her shoulder, her boots pounding against the floating debris. “Go back to the sniper stuff! The sniper stuff was fine!”

Behind her, the massive, chaotic face of the golem split into a wide, playful grin. “I will,” Elira’s booming, superimposed voice cheered, “but only after I tag you!”

Kyoko vs. Sylvette — The Predator’s Dance

The battlefield shifted into a magical jungle. Tree bark bled into jagged obsidian, and hanging moss dissolved into a heavy, glowing mist. At the center of the clearing stood Sylvette. She was poised like an apex predator, her amber eyes burning with a feral intensity. Her form was a hypnotic, unsettling blur—half-human, half-beast, always in flux as feathers, fur, and claws rippled across her skin.

Kyoko leveled her spear, her smirk sharp and undeterred by the display.

“Let me guess,” she called out, shifting her weight. “You consider me your prey, right?”

Sylvette’s lips curved into a wicked, predatory grin, her voice carrying a dual-toned, animalistic echo. “Let the hunt begin.”

Kyoko exploded forward, kicking up a cloud of shifting dust as she swung her spear in a vicious, horizontal arc. But Sylvette was impossibly fast. With the coiled tension of a hunting cat, she leaped straight into the air, landing with perfect, weightless balance right on the flat of Kyoko's blade.

Anticipating the move, Kyoko’s smirk widened. *Gotcha.*

With a mental command, her solid spear shattered into a dozen glowing, interlocking segments. The weapon dissolved into a tangle of heavy red chains, snapping upward to bind the shapeshifter.

Sylvette didn't panic. A pair of massive, feathered wings erupted from her shoulder blades, snapping outward to launch her straight up into the canopy.

“Not so fast!” Kyoko yanked her arm back with a violent snap of her wrist. The loose end of the chain whipped through the air like a snake, coiling tightly around Sylvette’s left ankle.

Kyoko dug her boots into the earth, looking up with a triumphant grin. “I got you! Looks like the hunter just became the hunted, huh?”

High above, Sylvette slowed her ascent. She looked down over her shoulder, slowly licking her lips as her eyes narrowed into dangerous, playful slits.

Before Kyoko could even register the lack of panic on Sylvette’s face, the chain went taut.

Sylvette didn't try to break free—she just flew. With an explosion of power from her wings, she accelerated into a blinding, supersonic sprint through the sky. The sudden, immense kinetic force yanked Kyoko completely off her feet. She was jolted violently through the air, her shoulder screaming from the tension as she stubbornly refused to let go of the chains.

Sylvette banked hard, executing a brutal, sweeping aerial loop. Kyoko was whipped through the sky in a massive, helpless arc before being hurled straight downward.

CRASH!

Kyoko slammed crater-first into the shifting forest floor, the wind violently knocked out of her.

Sylvette descended gracefully, hovering just above the dust cloud as her wings folded back into her skin. She looked down at Kyoko, her smile utterly serene.

“I like to make my prey feel safe,” Sylvette purred, her eyes gleaming with satisfaction. “It makes the hunt so much easier when they let their guard down.”

Kyoko vs. Mirielle — The World Rewritten

The forest of shifting textures collapsed, dissolving into an arena of utter, surreal chaos. The solid ground beneath Kyoko's boots suddenly turned brittle and translucent like thin glass, the air hummed and shimmered with intense, localized heat, and the surrounding walls rippled like liquid mercury. At the epicenter of the madness stood Mirielle. Her coral-pink braids glinted with metallic gold, and her mint-green eyes were wide with a manic, childlike curiosity.

Kyoko adjusted her grip on her spear, a reluctant grin breaking through her exhaustion. "Okay... I gotta admit, that looks really damn cool."

Mirielle's smile twisted into something delightfully mischievous, her voice bubbling over with pure excitement. "Thanks! Let's see how you handle a world that doesn't play by your rules."

Mirielle knelt and tapped the ground with a single finger. The reaction was instantaneous. The harmless grass beneath Kyoko's feet crystallized into an explosion of jagged, razor-sharp glass spikes.

Reacting on pure instinct, Kyoko slammed the butt of her spear into the ground, shattering the rising crystals into harmless dust. Using the momentum, she charged forward, bringing her spear around in a lethal, flashing arc aimed right at Mirielle.

But mid-stride, the ground completely forgot how to be solid. Kyoko's boots sank into the earth as if it had turned to thick mud, throwing off her balance and sending her pitching forward.

"Tch—!"

Thinking fast, Kyoko jammed the shaft of her spear into the muck, using her forward momentum to vault herself high into the air and clear of the trap. Mid-flight, she flicked her wrist, her spear snapping into a long, segmented whip that lashed out toward Mirielle like a striking snake.

Suddenly, the whip dead-stopped. The very air around the weapon thickened into a dense, gelatinous syrup. Kyoko watched in disbelief as her whip slogged through the empty space in slow motion, stripped of all its kinetic power.

Before she could process it, gravity pulled her back down. "Whoa! What the—?!"

Kyoko's boots hit the ground, but the mud was gone. It was now as slick and frictionless as ice. Her feet instantly shot out from under her, and she went down hard, faceplanting directly into the glossy floor.

For a second, she just lay there. Then, groaning, Kyoko pushed herself up onto her forearms and knees, spitting out a mouthful of whatever the floor was made of.

"Okay, scratch that," she grumbled, rubbing her aching nose. "It's officially *not* cool when you're the one fighting against it."

Mirielle beamed, practically vibrating with excitement as the air and ground warped around her like a funhouse mirror. "There is so much more I want to show you! Come on, come at me again!"

Kyoko vs. Velmira — The Howling Spiral

The arena warped again, this time twisting into a roaring, claustrophobic cyclone of crimson and black wind. Velmira hovered dead in the eye of the storm. Her skeletal form was draped in tattered, phantom veils that whipped violently in the gale, her hollow eye sockets glowing with a faint, ethereal light. All around her, translucent, ghastly spirits howled and wailed, swirling through the tempest like a living, screaming vortex.

Kyoko dug her heels into the ground, raising her spear to shield her face from the biting wind.

“Geez,” Kyoko called out, trying to sound casual despite the chill creeping up her spine. “Those spirits are seriously creepy. They look exactly like the kind of demons my old man used to preach about in his sermons. Can't you call up some of your gentler ones instead?”

Velmira's low, rattling chuckle echoed through the roar of the wind, clearly pleased by the seasoned fighter's unease.

“I could...” the Witch purred, her voice carried on a dozen overlapping drafts. “But where is the fun in that? I can see the demons unsettle you, Kyoko. Brace yourself.”

The cyclone surged inward. Kyoko lashed out with her spear, her movements a blur of practiced precision, but the blade passed harmlessly through the vaporous entities. The spirits didn't even slow down; screeching in piercing, discordant frequencies, they reached out for her with emaciated, terrifying hands.

Kyoko grit her teeth, executing a frantic leap backward to narrow her profile. “Definitely creepy,” she muttered to herself, her breath hitching. “Maybe one of those prayers my dad taught me would actually work right now. Now, what was that one against demons again...?”

Velmira's hollow eyes flared brighter, her skeletal lips curling into a grin. “You mean... this one?”

The crimson wind fractured. From the howling vortex, three distinct, horrifying shapes began to coalesce. Kyoko froze. The demonic spirits took the unmistakable, haunting forms of her father, her mother, and her little sister, Momo.

They drifted toward her, their eyes locked onto Kyoko with vacant, accusatory stares. In overlapping, distorted, and echoing voices, they began to chant the very religious phrases Kyoko's father used to preach, the words reverberating painfully through her skull.

The heavy gaze of her dead family and the weight of those sacred, twisted phrases hit Kyoko like a physical blow, stripping the warmth right out of her chest.

She took a slow step back, her knuckles turning white around her spear. A weak, forced chuckle escaped her lips, hollow and devoid of its usual bite.

“No...” Kyoko whispered, her voice trembling slightly as she stared at the ghosts of her past. “Not that one.”

Kyoko vs. Ruinelle — The Fractured Path

The battlefield cracked violently beneath Kyoko's boots, jagged, red-black fractures webbing across the ground like shattered glass. Ruinelle hovered gracefully above the destruction. Her form was serpentine and heavily segmented, her limbs bending and twisting at unsettling, impossible angles. As she drifted, thick, ink-like shadows leaked constantly from the tip of her tail, instantly corrupting and decaying every inch of reality they brushed against.

Kyoko smirked, fluidly twirling her spear into a defensive stance. "Do those flashy shadows of yours actually corrupt Soul Gems? Because if they do, I've got this in the bag."

Ruinelle let out a bright, bubbling laugh that sounded entirely too cheerful for a creature of ruin. "Alrighty then! Let's test that theory out!"

With a sudden burst of speed, Ruinelle began to loop and dive through the air around Kyoko, her flight path leaving a continuous, twisting ribbon of dark energy in her wake. She circled closer and closer, corrupting the very oxygen in the arena. Kyoko's breath caught in her throat. The oppressive atmosphere pressed down on her chest, and with a sudden jolt of panic, she noticed the vibrant crimson of her Soul Gem rapidly clouding over with a murky, suffocating despair.

"*Tch...!*" Kyoko gritted her teeth. "Oh no, you don't. I am not falling for this!"

She planted her feet, forcing her eyes shut to tune out the swirling spectacle around her. *Come on, Kyoko—remember your training with Umbra.*

Focusing every ounce of her mental fortitude, she reached deep inside herself, actively wrestling against the encroaching darkness. She visualized the corruption, gripping it and forcing it to a standstill. Slowly, the dark murk inside the gem stopped spreading, tightly contained by her sheer willpower.

Kyoko snapped her eyes open, a triumphant grin breaking across her face. "Yes! I actually did it—!"

BAM!

Before the sentence could even finish leaving her mouth, something massive and devastatingly heavy slammed directly into her ribs.

"Ack—*gark!*"

The breath was violently driven from her lungs as she was sent hurtling sideways. Kyoko hit the fractured ground hard, rolling violently across the dirt in a cloud of dust before finally skidding to a halt. Ruinelle had effortlessly used the momentum of her looping flight to whip her heavy tail right into Kyoko's flank.

High above, Ruinelle executed a series of playful, aerial somersaults, twirling through her own trail of corruption with effortless whimsy.

“Geez, Kyoko!” the Witch giggled down at her, entirely unbothered. “You can’t just go standing completely still like a statue in the middle of a fight!”

Kyoko vs. Catastrophia — The Skybreaker

The entire coliseum groaned and trembled as Catastrophia loomed over the battlefield, a towering, cataclysmic manifestation of a living apocalypse. Her massive form was composed of swirling, hyper-dense storm clouds and veins of glowing, molten stone. Blinding arcs of violet lightning crackled violently across her colossal limbs, a blood-red flood surged around her feet, and twin tornadoes spiraled furiously from her shoulders. When she spoke, her voice rumbled with the deafening weight of thunder.

Kyoko looked up at the literal god of weather, a sharp, wild laugh bubbling up from her chest. She leveled her spear anyway.

“Dang,” Kyoko called out, her hair whipping wildly in the gale. “Now *that* is a storm if I’ve ever seen one!”

Catastrophia’s reply was a booming growl, yet it carried an underlying, ancient sense of commanding serenity. “I like your fire and energy But can you handle the fire and energy of nature itself?”

With a sudden tilt of Catastrophia’s head, a jagged spear of violet lightning arced violently across the sky, tracing a path straight for Kyoko’s chest.

Kyoko grinned, her reflexes snapping into place. With a sharp flick of her wrist, she summoned a multi-layered network of glowing, interlocking red lattice walls. The violet lightning slammed into the barriers with a deafening *CRACK*, the raw electricity pulsing and spiderwebbing harmlessly along the glowing red grid.

“Whoa—!”

Before Kyoko could celebrate, a massive, violent earthquake ripped through the arena, tearing the ground apart beneath her. The lattice walls shattered instantly. Kyoko stumbled, her arms flailing frantically as she desperately struggled to maintain her footing on the bucking earth.

Catastrophia’s storm-cloud eyes gleamed with immense amusement. “Oh? You have impressive reaction times, and your balance is commendable. But let us see how you handle this.”

A sudden, freezing hurricane wind roared through the grove, and Kyoko looked up. Her blood ran cold. A towering, apocalyptic tsunami of blood-red water was cresting high above the horizon, pushed forward by gale-force winds and barreling straight toward her.

Kyoko’s eyes went completely wide. Without a single second of hesitation, she spun on her heel and started bolting in the opposite direction, her boots a blur as she ran for her life.

“No, no, no, no, no!” Kyoko screamed over the roar of the wave, her usual pride completely evaporated. “I can’t swim! I literally can’t swim!”

Behind her, Catastrophā's booming laughter echoed through the rain, rich and utterly delighted. "Well then, it's time for you to learn!"

Kyoko vs. Thornaria — The Blooming Maw

The battlefield blossomed into a nightmare garden. Thorned vines writhed across the ground, flowers hissed and spat fumes, and towering stalks bent like serpents hungry for prey. Thornaria emerged from the nest, her body wrapped in living vines, her petal-mask glowing with venomous green light.

Kyoko twirled her spear, grinning.

"Alright, plant-girl. You failed to trip me when I first got here. Let's see what your 'I'll do better when we fight' looks like."

Thornaria chuckled, her grin mischievous, vines restless and eager.

"Oh ho, trust me, Kyoko. I'll do more than just try to trip you this time."

With a sudden snap of her fingers, the surrounding flowers opened their jaws, exhaling a thick, choking cloud of bright pink fumes.

"Oh no you don't!" Kyoko barked. "I already know what that nasty stuff does!"

Planting her feet, Kyoko spun her spear in a blindingly fast, propeller-like motion right in front of her. The sheer kinetic force generated a powerful gust of wind, forcefully blowing the sweet-smelling poison cloud right back toward Thornaria.

But it was a distraction. Out of the corner of her eye, Kyoko caught a sudden flash of movement. A dozen massive, thorned briars erupted from the earth, lashing out at her from every single angle.

Kyoko didn't panic. Twisting her body with fluid, acrobatic grace, she unleashed a flurry of smooth, devastating strikes, slicing through the incoming wooden tendrils with practiced ease. Severed vines rained down around her.

But the moment the blades cut through the wood, Thornaria's trap sprung.

From the raw, bleeding edges of the severed stems, grotesque, parasitic blossoms instantly bloated and burst open. They didn't just release a cloud—they exploded into a concentrated, hyper-dense wave of toxic, choking fumes.

Kyoko's eyes widened in shock as she inhaled the sweet poison. A violent fit of coughing wracked her chest, her vision blurring instantly. Blood dripped from her lips, and her legs gave out, sending her crashing hard onto her knees as she used her spear just to prop herself up.

Thornaria stepped through the settling dust, tilting her head with a playful, wicked wink.

"Gotcha."

Kyoko vs. Noctulisse — The Dream-Eater

The arena's walls bled away, swallowed whole by an oppressive, suffocating darkness. Noctulisse stood cloaked in the absolute void, her silhouette barely visible save for a pair of piercing, crimson eyes that burned through the rising fog. Around Kyoko, the shadows began to warp—twisted reflections of herself, fractured nightmare images, and impossible geometric shapes flickered in and out of existence. Reality itself bent inward, refusing to hold steady.

Kyoko tightened her grip on her spear, forcing a sharp, defiant grin onto her face. “Creepy illusions, huh? Trust me, lady, I’ve seen worse nightmares inside my own head. Let’s go.”

Noctulisse’s voice answered as a chilling whisper, layered with a ghostly echo of her old serenity. “Oh? Then how about *this* nightmare, Kyoko?”

The shadows surged violently, violently twisting Kyoko’s vision. Suddenly, she wasn’t in the arena anymore. She was sitting on the cold floor of her father’s empty, dilapidated church. Her family sat around her, hollow-eyed and skeletal, starving to death in the dim light. Instantly, a phantom ache ripped through Kyoko’s gut. Her stomach growled, a deep, agonizing emptiness clawing at her insides as if she hadn’t eaten a single bite in weeks.

Kyoko staggered, dropping to one knee and clutching her head as the simulated starvation threatened to double her over. “Oh wow..., that is incredibly low,” she hissed through gritted teeth. “Showing me my family starving—and actually making me feel it, too?”

Then, the vision shifted.

Right in front of her, a massive, impossible feast materialized. Piping hot meat buns, colorful sweets, and stacks of savory snacks piled high. The rich, mouth-watering aroma of fresh food drifted right past her nose. Kyoko’s eyes glazed over. Desperate and completely overwhelmed by the phantom hunger, she drooled slightly and reached out a trembling hand.

The moment her fingertips brushed the surface of a meat bun, it turned to ash. The entire feast burned away into nothingness, and the sweet aroma turned instantly into the choking, acrid stench of smoke and burning flesh.

The illusion dissolved into chaos. The church was suddenly engulfed in roaring, blood-red flames. Standing in the center of the inferno was her father, his face twisted into a maniacal mask, a blood-slicked katana gripped tightly in his hand. Behind him lay the lifeless, burning corpses of her mother and her little sister, Momo.

Her father snapped his head toward her, his eyes burning with pure, unadulterated hatred as he raised the blade. “*Two down,*” his distorted voice bellowed over the roar of the fire. “*One more to go.*”

The breath was completely stolen from Kyoko’s lungs. She froze, utterly paralyzed by shock. Her bravado vanished, leaving her exposed and trembling as her spear shook violently in her hands.

From the depths of the burning void, Noctulisse’s amused whisper echoed directly into her ear. “That look on your face... I hit the mark, didn’t I? Is *this* your worst nightmare, isn’t it?”

Kyoko vs. Vexaphra — The Vanishing Blade

The battlefield fractured, the very fabric of space warping and tearing. Vexaphra flickered violently in and out of existence like a glitched hologram. Her insect-like body was a nightmare of jagged, hyper-sharp angles, her multiple blade-limbs gleaming under the surreal light. One microsecond she was hovering directly ahead; the next she was entirely gone, her manic, mocking laughter echoing from everywhere and nowhere at once.

Kyoko swung her spear with reckless abandon, cutting through empty air. “I’m gonna land a hit on you, just you damn watch!”

Vexaphra’s voice hissed from the shadows, playful and deeply mocking. “You can’t fight what your eyes can’t track. You’ll bleed out before you even figure out where I’m standing.”

Without warning, invisible blades slashed out from the void. Clean, agonizing cuts opened up across Kyoko’s arms, her legs, and her flank. She spun wildly on her heel, unleashing a flurry of desperate, defensive sweeps with her spear, but she hit absolutely nothing. Blood sprayed into the air, her body battered and rapidly accumulating damage.

“Ngh! Damn it—stop hiding!” Kyoko spat, wiping a smear of blood from her cheek. “Come out and fight me fair and square!”

“As you wish.”

Space distorted, and Vexaphra materialized directly in front of Kyoko. Her physical form stuttered and strobed, as if reality itself was struggling to anchor her to a single spot.

Kyoko’s bloody face split into a triumphant grin. “Finally!”

Lunging forward, Kyoko poured all her remaining speed into a brutal, straight-line thrust, aiming to impale the insectoid Witch. *Clang!* Vexaphra raised a single, gleaming blade-limb, blocking the spear-tip dead in its tracks.

But at the exact millisecond their weapons collided, a sudden, blinding spike of pain ripped through Kyoko’s right arm.

“Ah!” Kyoko gasped, her grip failing completely. She dropped her spear, staggering back as she clutched her right forearm with her left hand. Looking down, her heart skipped a beat. A second, completely separate blade-limb had pierced clean through her arm—even though the Vexaphra standing in front of her hadn’t moved an inch.

Vexaphra chuckled, the sound distorted and layered. “You really should be looking at the bigger picture, Kyoko.”

Kyoko forced her gaze upward, and the remaining color drained entirely from her face.

She wasn't just fighting one opponent. Surrounding her in a perfect, suffocating circle were dozens of razor-sharp blade-limbs, all detached from any central body, silently flickering in and out of sight like a trap about to spring. The Vexaphra she had attacked was just a single piece of a shattered puzzle.

Vexaphra's main torso glitched into view right above her, her face twisting into a mocking grin. "But hey, look on the bright side—at least you managed to hit *one* of my blades."

Kyoko vs. Lunaria — The Dance of Frustration

The coliseum shimmered into moonlight. Lunaria stood at the center, her indigo cloak flowing like liquid night, her posture relaxed, serene. Kyoko lunged at her with blazing speed, spear cutting arcs of crimson fire. Yet every strike was met not with resistance, but with effortless grace. Lunaria's movements were fluid, almost playful — a sidestep here, a gentle deflection there. It was less a fight than a dance, her body weaving through Kyoko's fury as if the two were partners in choreography.

Kyoko panted heavily, sweat dripping, her soul gem darkening with frustration.

"Damn it... fighting you is like trying to hit the moon's reflection in water. No matter how hard I swing, you just ripple away."

Lunaria chuckled, her voice soft but teasing, eyes shimmering with quiet amusement.

"I can feel your frustration growing. But if you let it consume you, your movements will only grow more sloppy. Instead, let it sharpen you. Controlled aggression, Kyoko. Let frustration become fuel, not poison."

Kyoko laughed, wild and reckless, her fire flaring brighter.

"Oh yes, I'll do that! I'll turn this frustration into fire — and one day, I'll land a clean hit on you!"

The negativity swirling in her soul gem drifted outward, coiling around her spear like smoke made solid. She charged again, spear blazing, eyes alight with determination.

Lunaria smiled, settling into a relaxed stance, her body poised like a dancer awaiting the next step.

"Then come. Show me how frustration becomes strength."

And Kyoko and Lunaria continued their clash. Kyoko's movements grew sharper, her attacks heavier, her fire more focused — yet Lunaria flowed through it all, untouchable, serene.

Kyoko vs. Kasumi — The Berserker's Trial

The arena trembled as Kasumi charged forward, her energy wild, her grin blazing. She moved like a berserker, fists swinging with raw abandon. Kyoko met her head-on, spear flashing, diamond walls rising to block. But Kasumi's punch shattered the walls, splintered the spear, and sent Kyoko staggering back, barely leaping aside in time to avoid the crushing blow.

Kyoko wiped sweat from her face, panting, her grin crooked.

“What the hell are you made of? None of my attacks even scratch you. What do I need to do?”

Kasumi winked, her grin bright, her voice bubbling with joy.

“Simple. You just need to hit harder.”

Kyoko closed her eyes, laughed, muttering under her breath.

“Of course you would say that.”

Her soul gem flared, and suddenly the arena was filled with crimson light.

“**Rosso Fantasma!**” Kyoko shouted.

A legion of Kyoko clones burst forward, each grinning with reckless fire, each brandishing a spear.

They surrounded Kasumi, their eyes gleaming with the same wild determination.

Kasumi’s eyes sparkled, her grin widening.

“Oooohhh! This is your enchantment ability, isn’t it? So cool!”

Kyoko manifested a new spear, pointing it forward.

“These clones aren’t just illusions. They can fight just like me. Get ready for an omnidirectional barrage!”

The clones roared, charging from every direction, spears flashing.

Kasumi laughed, her battle lust burning hotter, the pressure in the air thickening like a storm.

“Perfect! Let’s gooooooooo!”

She charged into the swarm, fists blazing, her laughter echoing through the coliseum.

But it wasn’t only battle.

Through Connect, Mami glimpsed Kyoko laughing in the cook-off arena, devouring magical food that shimmered with life. Platters glowed faintly, each bite bursting with warmth and color, as if the essence of nature itself had been distilled into taste.

Later, she saw Kyoko learning to create snacks herself — weaving threads of essence from flowers, rivers, and soil into treats that sparkled like jewels. They were simple, playful things: candied blossoms, fire-red buns, crystalline fruits. Yet they became beloved across the realm, passed from hand to hand, Kyoko’s laughter echoing in every bite.

She saw her screaming with joy on the roller-coaster rides, her hair blazing like fire against the wind. Sparkles of ambient magic swirled around her, guiding her descent in wild, unpredictable arcs. She dove through floating islands, plunged into waterfalls that burst into mist, and soared upward into skies painted with auroras. Each ride was different, chaotic and exhilarating, no path ever the same. Kyoko’s voice carried above it all — raw, unrestrained, alive.

She saw her dancing at music concerts, her body moving with reckless abandon, her voice breaking into karaoke halls where magical girls sang their wishes into song. The air shimmered with rhythm, each note a fragment of memory, each chorus a bond renewed. Kyoko's fire burned brightest here, not in combat, but in joy.

She saw her plunging into haunted dungeons with others, laughter mixing with screams as illusions clawed at their minds. Umbra's corruption seeped into the walls, twisting shadows into playful terrors. Yet Kyoko treated it like a game, daring despair to catch her, daring fear to break her. Every trap became a challenge, every illusion a chance to prove her emotional control.

It was a life of balance — fire and shadow, battle and joy, discipline and chaos.

Mami's heart tightened as she absorbed it all. Kyoko's journey in the dream-realm mirrored her own struggles in the waking world: learning emotional control, discovering Connect, forging bonds, finding joy amidst despair. But Kyoko had lived it in a place where despair could be transformed, where connection was magnified, where laughter and battle coexisted without contradiction.

Her golden eyes softened. *Kyoko... you've grown so much here. You are probably stronger than me now. And yet, you're still you. Reckless, fiery, impossible. But stronger. Clearer. More alive.*

Kyoko learns Mami is in the realm

Mami saw Kyoko seated in the grass of the garden-island, near the fountain where Kyoko had first awakened in the dream-realm.

The afternoon sky was steeped in gold, the horizon brushed with soft rose and violet, as though the realm breathed in the warmth of sunset and exhaled peace. The fountain murmured gently beside Kyoko, its water catching the light in drifting prisms. She leaned back against a tree near the pool, utterly at ease, a plate of softly shimmering food balanced on her lap and a faintly glowing drink cradled in her hand.

From behind, she heard familiar voices.

"Kyoko!" Kasumi's tone was bright, Lunaria's softer, melodic.

Kyoko turned immediately, her grin breaking wide across her face. "Hey! You two!" She lifted the plate without hesitation. "C'mon, sit. I've got plenty."

Kasumi and Lunaria accepted with easy laughter, settling beside her in the grass. The three of them ate and drank together, the fountain's spray misting the air, scattering the light like tiny jewels.

Kyoko chewed thoughtfully, then tilted her head. "So... what brings you here today?"

Kasumi's eyes gleamed mischievously. "We have a huge surprise for you."

Kyoko swallowed quickly, leaning forward, curiosity sparking in her crimson eyes. "Alright, don't keep me waiting. What's the surprise?" She lifted her drink, taking a long sip.

Lunaria smiled, her voice serene but tinged with mischief. “Your good friend, Mami, is now in the realm.”

Kyoko’s eyes went wide.

She choked.

The drink sprayed from her lips in a startled sputter. Lunaria shifted aside with effortless grace, untouched. Kasumi, however, froze in place as the liquid splashed across her front.

For a heartbeat, there was silence.

Lunaria covered her lips, laughing softly. Kasumi turned to her with a deadpan stare, her voice flat. “You did that on purpose didn’t you? You waited until she was drinking.”

Kyoko coughed hard, pounding her chest. “W-wait—are you serious?” She stared between them. “Mami’s here? In this dream-realm?”

Kasumi didn’t answer.

She just stared back, soaked and deadpan.

Kyoko burst out laughing. Kasumi looked so utterly ridiculous that the laughter spilled out of her before she could stop it. “Oh man—Kasumi, you look ridiculous.”

Kasumi’s expression didn’t change.

Lunaria, still giggling, finally spoke. “Not in this dream-realm. She is in the other realm — the place between the living and the dead.”

Kyoko’s laughter faltered. Her fingers curled unconsciously around her drink, knuckles whitening. “That’s... that’s the place you and Kasumi guide them to, right?” Her voice lowered. “For the ones who... don’t make it.”

Her gaze sharpened, urgent. “So something happened to Mami. And you were there.”

Kasumi remained silent, her drenched deadpan face unchanging.

Lunaria’s smile softened, and when she spoke again, her voice carried a quiet gravity.

“Yes. I was in Mitakihara when I sensed two magical girls inside a witch’s labyrinth. But their energies were not aligned — they were not working together.”

She looked past Kyoko, as though seeing the memory still unfolding.

“I entered quietly, unseen. Homura was trying to warn Mami about the witch Charlotte — that she was unlike the others. More dangerous. She asked Mami to leave the witch to her.”

Kyoko’s eyes flickered.

“Mami did not listen,” Lunaria continued. “She bound Homura with her ribbons. Even restrained, Homura tried to warn her again. Mami only tightened the bindings... promising to release her after the witch was defeated.”

Kyoko’s lips parted, a sharp breath slipping out.

Lunaria’s tone never wavered. “Mami advanced deeper into the labyrinth with two humans she had befriended — Sayaka and Madoka. Kyubey appeared to them earlier and offered them contracts. Mami told them not to rush. She wanted them to see what being a magical girl truly meant before deciding.”

Kyoko’s voice escaped her in a whisper, raw and unguarded.

“Mami was... so kind to me.” Her gaze dropped to the grass. “She shared grief seeds. She fought with me. She believed in me.”

Her eyes lifted again, searching Lunaria’s face, confusion trembling beneath the surface.

“So why... why would she treat Homura like that? Especially if Homura was trying to help her?” Her voice shook. “Did something happen between them?”

Then her expression hardened, something fiercer surfacing beneath the confusion.

“But more than that...” Kyoko clenched her fist. “Where was I?”

Her eyes burned, bright and searching.

“Where was my real self?” she demanded quietly. “Shouldn’t I have been there with her? Fighting witches together... like we always did?”

Lunaria’s gaze softened, her smile fading into something sorrowful.

“I do not know why your real self was not there with Mami,” she said gently. “But what happened next... may provide clues.”

Kyoko leaned forward, crimson eyes sharp with curiosity, the food forgotten in her lap.

Lunaria’s voice grew distant, carrying like an echo across still water.

“As Mami, Sayaka, and Madoka walked deeper into Charlotte’s labyrinth, Sayaka spoke her mind. She told Mami she could not stand Homura — that Homura was cold, untrustworthy, and that Mami was a far better role model for what a magical girl should be.”

As Lunaria spoke, the air before them shimmered.

Light folded in on itself, and a vision bloomed — a memory given form.

The labyrinth took shape: walls twisting like ribbons of candy, colors too bright, shadows stretched long and warped. The air itself seemed sticky, cloying, as though the sweetness of the place was meant to suffocate.

“Then Mami told them,” Lunaria whispered, “that she cried often in secret. That beneath her confident smile, she was hurting deeply. That her strength was only a mask, worn so others would not see her

loneliness.”

A pause.

“She said she was not a good role model for anyone.”

Kyoko gasped softly.

Mami... alone? Hurting?

The thought twisted painfully in her chest. How could that be? Mami had always seemed so steady, so radiant. Was her real self already gone? Had something happened after she was saved in the dream-realm? The questions tangled inside her, heavy and unresolved.

Lunaria’s voice continued, steady as moonlight.

“Madoka then spoke. She said she still believed Mami was a wonderful role model — someone who put her life on the line to protect others, even when no one was watching.”

The vision brightened, colors sharpening, the labyrinth’s walls glowing faintly as if reflecting Madoka’s resolve.

“And then,” Lunaria said, “she made her decision. After this, she would make a Contract. She would become a magical girl... so she could help Mami.”

Within the projection, Sayaka’s eyes went wide. She grinned, nudging Madoka playfully.

“Madoka! I didn’t know you had it in you to make such a big decision like that!”

Madoka pouted, her voice trembling with earnest protest.

“Please Sayaka, I am trying to be serious here!”

Mami froze.

Her eyes widened, her breath catching as though the world itself had stopped. Then she rushed forward, clasping Madoka’s hands tightly, golden eyes shimmering with disbelief.

“Mami... are you okay?” Madoka asked, startled.

Mami’s voice trembled, fragile with hope.

“Are you really going to do it? Become a magical girl? Fight alongside me?”

Her grip tightened, desperate.

“If you do, you won’t have time for friends after school, or dates, or ordinary joys. You’ll risk your life every day against witches and familiars.”

Madoka closed her eyes, smiling softly.

“Yes. I know. You showed me what it means — taking Sayaka and me on hunts. Even so... I think it’s worth it.”

She opened her eyes again, steady and sincere.

“I’ve always thought of myself as average. Someone without much to offer. But if I become a magical girl... I can help people. My life will have purpose.”

Mami stared at her, trembling. She pinched her own arm, the sting sharp.
“It hurts...” she whispered. “So I’m not dreaming.”

Her voice cracked, tears spilling freely.
“It’s real... I finally... I finally have a magical girl friend!”

She pulled Madoka into a fierce embrace, composure shattering beneath joy.

Sayaka laughed.
“Geez, Mami. Getting sentimental before a witch fight?”

Mami laughed too, wiping her eyes, apologizing for showing such weakness. Then she straightened, her smile radiant once more.

“I can’t lose in front of you now,” she said lightly. “Not after all of that.”

The three of them walked deeper into the labyrinth together, their laughter echoing through the candy-bright halls.

Kyoko’s eyes narrowed, her expression darkened with understanding.

“So let me guess...” she said slowly, “Mami was drunk on happiness. And that made her careless against Charlotte.”

Lunaria nodded, sorrow touching her smile as the projection faded into mist.
“Yes. A tragic ending... to what could have been the beginning of a joyful chapter in her life.”

The real Mami experienced everything through Connect.

The vision pressed against her heart like a physical weight, heavy and unrelenting.

I was lucky. Very lucky that Lunaria was in Mitakihara and saved me.

She cringed, a quiet ache curling through her chest.

This was not her proudest moment — to put it lightly.

Falling to a witch in front of her friends. Endangering them. Binding Homura, silencing her warnings, forcing her to intervene anyway just to save them all.

The memory burned — raw, humiliating, and yet impossible to deny.

Through the shared resonance of Connect, Mami felt her own anxiety ripple outward. Her golden eyes flickered, breath held, as she waited for Kyoko’s reaction.

Would Kyoko pity her?

Or worse — laugh? Tease her for dying in such an embarrassing way, *drunk on happiness*, as she herself had just said?

Kyoko remained silent, crimson eyes narrowed in thought.

Then she sighed.

The sound was heavy — but not cruel.

“That’s...” she muttered, scratching the back of her head. “That’s kinda unexpected from Mami.” She glanced aside, lips twisting faintly. “Guess she must’ve been really desperate for friends.”

There was no mockery in her voice. Only something softer — almost wistful.

After a moment, she added quietly, “I really hope I get to talk to her soon.”

Mami’s shoulders loosened, just a little.

Kyoko turned back to Lunaria, curiosity flaring anew. “So what happened after?” she asked. “Did you bring Mami straight to the realm when Charlotte killed her?”

Lunaria’s expression shifted.

Her smile returned — but this time it was edged with mischief, eyes glinting like moonlight on a blade.

“Yes,” she said smoothly. “I brought her here. But at that time, Mami did not yet know the truth.”

Kyoko stiffened slightly.

“That magical girls become witches when they succumb to despair,” Lunaria continued, her voice calm — almost playful. “So I decided to fight her.”

Her gaze sharpened.

“To force her to break. To push her to the very edge of becoming a witch.”

Kyoko’s eyes widened.

Then — she burst out laughing.

She doubled over, clutching her stomach, loud and unrestrained. “Mami fighting *you*?” she wheezed.

“No way — that had to be a total slaughter!”

She wiped a tear from her eye, still grinning. “You *have* to show me the replay of that someday.”

Leaning forward, fire blazing in her eyes, she added eagerly, “So? How’d she do? Did Mami do better than me?”

Mami felt her lip twitch through Connect.

Even now, Kyoko was competitive — measuring herself against her mentor’s greatest failures.

And yet... Mami found herself leaning in too, curiosity stirring despite the embarrassment.

She wanted to know.

Lunaria laughed, the sound light and clear, like silver bells chiming.

“The rivalry between you two is delightful,” she said. “But if I must answer...”

She turned her gaze to Kyoko.

“Right now, Kyoko — you did far better than Mami.”

Kyoko exploded with joy, thrusting her fists into the air.

“Yes! Finally! I’ve officially surpassed my mentor!”

Mami pouted faintly, warmth blooming in her cheeks as she watched.

But Lunaria wasn’t finished.

Her eyes sparkled as she added lightly, “However... if I compare your *first* battle against me to *Mami’s* first battle...”

She tilted her head.

“I would have to give the victory to Mami.”

Kyoko’s grin faltered instantly. “Hey—!” She crossed her arms, pouting. “C’mon, are you serious? Or are you just messing with me?”

She sighed, then chuckled, shaking her head. “Well... yeah. I guess that tracks. Mami had way more experience compared to me when I first fought you. Makes sense she’d do better.”

Mami smiled softly.

Through Connect, the warmth of Kyoko’s words reached her — not as flattery, but as honest recognition. Pride stirred quietly in her chest.

Even now, even here, the bond between them remained:
rivalry and admiration, fire and warmth, challenge and trust.

Alive.

Unbroken.

Kyoko tilted her head, crimson eyes gleaming with curiosity. “So what do you have planned for Mami now, Lunaria?”

“First,” she said, “I will teach her emotional control — and magical control. How to take the negativity that gnaws at her soul and reshape it into strength, rather than allowing it to consume her. How to wield her magic with clarity and efficiency, so despair cannot seep through unseen fractures.”

She met Kyoko’s gaze steadily.

“These are the foundations. The skills that will allow her to remain herself... and never become a witch.”

Her words shimmered in the air, and Mami felt them resonate through Connect, like threads weaving into her heart.

Lunaria continued, her tone deepening with quiet reverence. “Afterwards, I will teach her the fundamentals of magic and Connect. How magic exists in all life — in every breath, every blade of

grass, every heartbeat. I will guide her to Connect with the life around her, so she may learn to cherish all existence... including her own life as a magical girl.”

Then her lips curved, and she winked.

“And once she has found her footing, I will allow her to try Connecting with another magical girl.”

Kyoko’s eyes lit up immediately. Her grin spread wide.

“Yes! That’s perfect.” She pumped a fist, barely containing her excitement. “That’ll be my chance to finally meet Mami properly — before we Connect for the first time!”

She winked, her voice bubbling with excitement. “I want to show her the snacks I can manifest now — made from the essence of life itself. She’s gonna love them.”

Lunaria nodded, smiling warmly. “That would be beautiful,” she said. “A reunion — you, Kyoko of the past, and Mami — before you open yourselves fully to one another and Connect.”

Her gaze grew thoughtful. “Kasumi and I believe it would be best if Mami begins with the Beginner Connect training — the murals that depict the tragedy of the twelve girls, the origin of Connect, and the battle between Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, Hoshine, the two girls without soul gems ... and Umbra Ambraciel, the shadow monster.”

The names hung in the air like echoes of legend, the weight of history pressing against the garden’s serenity.

Kyoko tapped her chin, then looked at Lunaria with a sly grin. “I already know about Connect. And the story.”

Her grin widened. “So how about this — I use the arena’s memory manipulation feature, the one modeled after the **Advanced Witch, the Forgotten Queen**? The ability that lets people temporarily erase select memories during training or battle, so the experience feels fresh and organic. Then, when the training ends, the memories return, and you can compare your growth.”

Her voice burned with excitement. “I want my memories of Connect and the mural story temporarily erased, so I can enjoy the training as if it were my first time — alongside Mami. I’ll even scale myself down to my base power, back when I was first saved in this dream-realm. Then, once Mami and I Connect, the memories will return.”

Lunaria’s smile deepened, her eyes glinting with approval. “That is a wonderful idea. The arena will be configured accordingly when Mami summons you.”

Kyoko leaned back, gazing up at the sky. The golden light of sunset caught in her hair, setting it ablaze. “I can’t wait,” she whispered, her grin softening into something tender. “Seeing Mami again. Fighting by her side.”

Through Connect, Mami’s breath caught. Shock rippled through her. *So this is why Kyoko didn’t know Connect when we trained together... why she sounded surprised when we began to Connect moments ago.*

Kyoko had chosen to erase her own memories. Just so she could experience the training honestly — alongside Mami.

The thought filled Mami's heart with warmth, a fragile joy blooming inside her chest.

Her mind drifted back to yesterday, when she and Kyoko fought Aurellia during the Connect training. Aurellia had told her that she and Kyoko had agreed to erase their memories temporarily, to make the fight fair and authentic. The memories would return afterwards, allowing them to measure their growth.

At the time, Mami hadn't understood how such a thing was possible. Now she did. The arena replicated the Forgotten Queen's abilities.

She chuckled softly, golden eyes shimmering. *It's just like how the arena can replicate Umbra's corruption, allowing people to train their emotional control and endurance without losing themselves.*

The realization settled in her heart. This arena was more than a place of battle — it was a living archive, a crucible shaped by the powers of the strongest legends saved within it. Umbra. The Forgotten Queen. Titans of despair and memory, their abilities reborn as tools for growth.

Mami knew Umbra's past, but of the Forgotten Queen she knew almost nothing. Only descriptions from the list of battle opponents: a witch of memory and silence, whose magic could distort time, manipulate memories, and even erase magic itself.

Yet when Mami saw her for the first time — just before her battle with Kasumi — she had not looked like a witch at all. There was no monstrous form, no grotesque labyrinth aura. She appeared human, radiant, beautiful. Her skin pale as porcelain, her eyes a soft lavender, her golden curls shimmering like sunlight scattered across water. Sparkles of light drifted around her like pollen in spring air, and her dress flowed in silken layers that shifted with every movement, colors sliding between moonlight, frost, and dusk.

Was she truly a witch? Or a sorceress so powerful that the title had simply clung to her, reshaping her legend into something darker than truth? She looked like a dream — not a nightmare.

Mami's heart stirred. *One day, I hope to speak to her. To spar with her. To understand what it means to fight in the shadow of forgetting.*

Mami's thoughts wandered, curiosity stirring. *If the arena can replicate their powers... what other features lie hidden here, drawn from other beings? What other trials await us, shaped by the echoes of legends?*

Her heart tightened, but not with fear. With anticipation.

Chapter 5a: Kyoko and Mami vs Kasumi

Kyoko and Mami found themselves back together again, standing in a space that felt crafted solely for them. Warm crimson-gold light filled the air, clouds drifting lazily in luminous swirls, as though the

sky itself had been painted with fire and memory. The atmosphere was hushed, intimate, a sanctuary suspended between dream and reality.

For a long moment, neither spoke. They simply looked at each other, eyes lingering, hearts still resonating with the echoes of what they had just shared. Through Connect, they had walked each other's pasts, felt each other's wounds, and carried each other's burdens. Their bond had deepened, wordless yet undeniable.

At last, Kyoko stepped forward, her voice breaking the silence. "I saw it," she said quietly. "What happened after I was saved here. How my real self lost her family... how my father found out about my wish, went crazy, and killed everyone except me."

Her fists clenched, knuckles pale. "Seeing that... it was eye-opening. It felt like I *was* her. That kind of loss... it explains so much. Why she blamed herself, why she shut herself off from everything and everyone."

She hesitated, but pressed on, her voice growing heavier. "And I saw the way I... we fought each other. She tried to cut ties, while you tried so damn hard to hold on. That was... it hurt to see. She said some pretty awful things to you."

Kyoko's eyes softened, the fire in them dimmed by sorrow. "And I saw your loneliness after that. How much you bottled up during the day, only to let it all spill out when you were alone at night. I felt all that through Connect. That *emptiness*."

A quiet stillness settled between them, but then Kyoko's expression shifted. Her grin flashed back, sharp and determined. She pounded a fist into her palm, the fire reigniting.

"Even though I get it... even though I understand why my real self turned out the way she did... it still pisses me off. That damn Kyoko." Her voice dropped into a playful growl. "When I finally meet her, I'm gonna knock some sense into her."

Mami chuckled softly, her golden eyes warm. She was relieved — this Kyoko was not weighed down by the tragedy of her family's death, not broken like her real self. "Thank you," she said gently. "For sharing what you felt through Connect."

She hesitated, then added, her smile softening. "But... I don't think it's a good idea to try and beat sense into your real self. You must've seen how hard I tried to keep my bond with her, and still... it didn't work."

Kyoko winked, her grin unshaken. She gave Mami a thumbs up, as if the matter was already settled. "Oh, don't you worry. I know myself better than anyone. I've got a plan. A *really good* one." Her grin widened, fire blazing in her eyes. "And when it happens, I want you to watch. It'll be one hell of a show."

Mami laughed, the sound light and melodic against the glowing clouds. Kyoko's optimism was infectious, impossible to resist. Yet the thought lingered in her mind — the idea of Kyoko confronting her summoned self, a version of herself who had walked a completely different path in life in the

dream-realm. Mami's imagination ran wild. What would Kyoko do? What kind of "show" would she put on to reach the heart of her real self?

It will probably involve some kind of intense fight, accompanied by harsh mocking words, Mami thought to herself. She could picture it clearly — the two of them clashing, arguing like siblings, fire and stubbornness colliding until something finally broke open.

The crimson-gold light shimmered around them, as if the realm itself was listening, waiting for what would come next.

Mami stepped forward, her golden eyes shimmering softly in the crimson-gold glow. Her voice was quiet at first, but steady.

"I saw your past in the dream-realm, Kyoko. And it took my breath away. That place... it was so beautiful. Vast and alive. So many activities, so many wonders — magical girls, witches, monsters, even legends, all sharing space together. It felt endless, like a world woven from both memory and possibility."

She paused, her gaze drifting upward as if she could still see it. "I'm starting to understand more about where I am now. This realm — between the living and the dead — is meant for rest, for clarity, before moving forward. But the dream-realm... that's where the essences of those saved truly dwell. A place where despair is reshaped into joy, where bonds are magnified, where life continues in another form."

Her words lingered in the air, warm and reverent. Then she turned back to Kyoko, her lips curving into a teasing smile. "You said when we Connected that your past wasn't all 'sparkles and sunshine.' But from what I saw, Kyoko... your life in the dream-realm was exactly that. Sparkles and sunshine."

Kyoko chuckled, scratching the back of her head. "Heh. Honestly, I thought you'd see my past back on Earth. But if you only saw me after I was saved here... then yeah, it was all sparkles and sunshine. That time was fun. Peaceful. Like living in a festival that never ended."

Her grin sharpened, and she winked. "Tell you what— after our battle with Kasumi, I'll take you to the dream-realm myself. You'll get to experience it for real. The realm you're in and the dream-realm are closely connected. Slipping between them is easy."

Mami's heart quickened, her breath catching with anticipation. "I... I'd love that," she said softly, the words almost fragile.

Then her eyes brightened with a thought. "Maybe we can bring the magical girls who were just brought here too — Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe. They deserve to see it as well."

Kyoko's smile beamed, her fire blazing with joy. "Yes! The more the merrier. There are so many foods and drinks I want to share. You wouldn't believe the flavors I've found there."

Mami sighed, shaking her head with a fond smile. "Kyoko... you never change. Always talking about food."

Kyoko laughed, unbothered, her voice ringing like a spark in the glowing air. “Hey, food’s important! It’s joy you can taste. And I wanna share that joy with everyone.”

The clouds around them shimmered, as if echoing her laughter, the space alive with warmth and promise.

Mami studied Kyoko for a long moment, her smile gentle — but knowing. The golden light around them seemed to pulse with her words as she spoke softly, each syllable chosen with care.

“That’s not the only thing I learned,” she said. “I saw that you already knew Connect. I saw how you learned it in the dream-realm.”

She paused, watching Kyoko’s expression, searching for the flicker of truth in her crimson eyes. “And I saw why you didn’t know it during the beginner training yesterday. Why you sounded genuinely surprised when we Connected earlier.”

Kyoko didn’t interrupt. She only tilted her head, waiting.

“You chose to have those memories sealed,” Mami continued, her voice steady but touched with wonder. “Temporarily. You hid them until after we Connected.”

Kyoko’s grin spread, crimson eyes glinting with playful guilt. “Bingo! All my memories are back now. The mural. Connect. All of it.”

Her grin softened, her voice lowering with sincerity. “But I wanted to experience the beginner training honestly. With you. Not as someone who already knew the answers.”

She scratched the back of her head, then snorted, laughter bubbling up like sparks. “And yeah... even with that embarrassing moment where we instinctively grabbed each other’s hands when those six witches — Thornaria, Velmira, Ruinelle, Catastropa, Noctulisse, Vexaphra — overwhelmed us.”

Her grin widened, fire flashing in her eyes. “Totally worth it. Fighting alongside you like that reminded me we still make one hell of a team.”

Mami laughed, the sound light and genuine, and Kyoko joined her. Their voices echoed softly through the crimson-gold space, lingering like warmth after a fire dies down, the realm itself seeming to hum in response.

When the laughter faded, Mami’s tone grew thoughtful. “I also saw something else. You scaled yourself down.”

Kyoko tilted her head, curious.

“To your base power,” Mami explained. “The strength you had when you were first saved in the dream-realm.” She met Kyoko’s eyes, her own golden gaze steady. “Now that we’ve Connected... are you still holding yourself back?”

Kyoko winked, her grin sharp. “Yup. I scaled myself down so we’d be closer in strength and control. Emotionally, magically — all of it. It made the beginner training feel more natural. More real.”

Mami’s lips twitched into a sly grin, her voice sweet with teasing. “Ah... so my precious mentee believes she’s surpassed her mentor? You scaled down so I wouldn’t get left behind?”

She laughed warmly, shaking her head. “That’s expected. From what I saw in the dream-realm, you’ve had far more time to grow than I have.”

Kyoko gave her a thumbs up, her grin blazing. “And you’ve grown a lot yourself in just three days here. Seriously. You should be proud. If you’d been here as long as me, you’d be terrifying.”

She pounded a fist into her palm, fire sparking in her eyes. “And yeah — I’m at full power now. We’ll need everything we’ve got against Kasumi.”

She leaned closer, her grin playful but fierce. “Don’t worry about slowing me down. Connect isn’t just about adding strength together — it magnifies it. Our essences and magic are shared. I’ll show you how to fight using Connect. Prepare to be blown away.”

Her voice softened, teasing but sincere. “It seems our roles have reversed. I’m in your care now.” She inclined her head slightly, her smile tender. “Lead the way, teacher.”

Kyoko burst out laughing, her voice ringing like fire against the glowing clouds. “Guess I’ll have to get used to hearing you call me that. But hey — let’s rock and roll!”

The crimson-gold light shimmered brighter, as if the realm itself was bracing for the clash to come, the air alive with anticipation of battle.

The crimson-gold sanctuary dissolved, its warmth fading into the vastness of the arena. Mami and Kyoko exhaled gently, their breaths steady as they opened their eyes. The roar of the crowd returned, petals drifting from the flower pods above, the air alive with anticipation.

They released each other’s hands, and instinctively their gazes fell to their soul gems. Mami gasped softly, her breath catching. Her gem shone bright gold, but within its brilliance swirled streaks of crimson, flickering like flames. The pulse was unmistakable. Kyoko’s energy lived there now: fierce, restless, alive.

Kyoko smiled knowingly, her grin sharp but warm. She tilted her head, eyes glinting. “Pretty, right?”

Mami’s voice softened, her eyes shimmering with awe. “Yes... it’s beautiful.”

She turned, her gaze falling to Kyoko’s Soul Gem. Crimson light burned bright, but from its core rays of gold spilled outward, soft and steady, like sunlight breaking through dawn.

Kyoko closed her eyes, her grin easing into something gentler. Her shoulders relaxed, and her voice dropped. “I can feel *you* in it. Your magic. Your warmth.”

She paused, her lips curving faintly. “Just like when you first took me under your wing.

Above, in the flower spectator pods, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe leaned forward, their eyes wide.

The resonance between Mami and Kyoko was impossible to miss. Even among Kamihama's magical girls, this was extraordinary. For a first Connect, it bordered on unreal — their Soul Gems reflecting one another, magic and soul braided so tightly it felt *alive*.

"They're incredible..." Mifuyu murmured, reverence threading her voice. Her hands clasped together unconsciously, knuckles pale.

Kuroe nodded quickly, her eyes shining. "It's like their gems are breathing together."

Momoko grinned, her voice bubbling with excitement. She leaned forward, eyes sparkling. "I can't wait to see what they'll do against Kasumi!"

Below, Kasumi stretched languidly, rolling her shoulders before bouncing lightly on her heels. She pounded a fist into her palm, eyes sparkling with unapologetic delight.

"Well, look at you two," she sang, her tone playful. She tilted her head, her grin widening. "So close. So in sync."

She let the pause linger, then added with a teasing lilt, "How cuuute~"

The word hung in the air — deliberate, sharp at the edges, meant to provoke.

"So," Kasumi continued, her head cocked, her smile bright, "how was your first Connect?"

Kyoko stepped forward without hesitation, her boots striking the arena floor with purpose. "I saw my real self's past," she said, crimson eyes blazing. Her fists clenched, trembling with the weight of memory. "And Mami's — after I was saved in the dream-realm."

Her jaw tightened, her voice roughened. "I saw how my real self lost her family. How she cut ties with Mami. How Mami was left alone."

She drew in a sharp breath, shoulders taut. "The suffering. The sadness."

Then Kyoko's expression shifted. Her lips curled into a fierce smile, unyielding. She planted her feet firmly, her stance radiating defiance. "It pissed me off."

Her voice rose, strong and clear. "And now I'm ready to unload all of it on you. So get ready."

Kasumi laughed, bright and ringing, her delight echoing through the arena. She clapped her hands together once, eyes gleaming. "Yes! Good! That's it." She leaned forward, her grin widening. "Channel it. Let it *burn*. Show me *everything*."

Mami's laughter followed — softer, steadier, like a stream flowing beneath fire. She stepped forward, golden eyes glowing, her posture graceful but firm. "I saw Kyoko's past in the dream-realm," she said. Her voice carried quiet reverence, each word deliberate. "It was surreal. Beautiful."

She glanced around the arena, her gaze sweeping over the petals, the crowd, the shimmering air. "A place for healing. For joy. For connection."

Her eyes returned to Kasumi, her tone deepening. “Much like this realm.”

She drew in a breath, her smile softening. “And I saw your dream. Yours — and Lunaria’s.”

The arena seemed to hush, the crowd leaning in.

“To create a world where magical girls and humans could live openly. Together.”

Her voice trembled faintly, but her eyes shone with conviction. “I saw how you befriended the Kamihama High orchestra. The student rock band, Second Period Detention. How you brought them into the dream-realm to perform — before magical girls, witches, monsters, and legends alike.”

A ripple passed through the crowd, warm chuckles and laughter rising.

“Afterwards,” Mami continued, her voice warming, “those musicians were so moved that they reached out to artists across the world — people who had also performed in the dream-realm.”

Her lips curved, her tone tender. “They wanted to create music for magical girls. To encourage them. To give them strength.”

She tilted her head, a knowing glint in her eye. “So that’s how you and Lunaria appeared as guest musicians at the Kamihama talent show three days ago.”

Her smile brightened. “And that’s why your music resonated so deeply. Because of the bonds you forged.”

Above, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe gasped, stunned.

“That explains it...” Mifuyu whispered, her voice trembling. “Why it felt like the music *knew* us.” Kuroe’s eyes widened. “They interact with humans... they even bring them into the dream-realm?” Momoko leaned back, grinning crookedly, her eyes sparkling with mischief. “If humans really understood magical girls... if they supported them?”

She laughed softly, shaking her head. “Everything would change.”

Her grin widened, playful. “I can just picture my family’s reaction. My parents, my brothers... imagine me telling them I’m a magical girl. They would lose their minds. Freak out first — then brag to everyone.”

She snorted, rolling her eyes fondly. “My brothers would probably challenge me to arm-wrestling and sparring matches just to see what I can do.”

The three laughed together, their voices carrying across the pod, shock mingling with excitement.

The arena pulsed with anticipation. The petals shimmered, the crowd roared, and Kasumi’s grin widened — bright, unafraid, inviting. The stage was set.

Kyoko lifted her hand.

Crimson light bloomed around her palm, pulsing once — twice — before snapping into form.

Her spear manifested.

But it was not the weapon Mami remembered.

Mami inhaled sharply, her breath catching. The spear's shaft gleamed with a radiant golden sheen, its surface threaded with veins of light. From it unfurled ribbons of crimson and gold — not conjured, but grown, fluttering and coiling like living flame. They moved with intent, responding to Kyoko's grip, to her breath, to the rhythm of her heart.

They were unmistakably Mami's ribbons.

And yet... they burned.

Kyoko smirked, twirling the spear with ease, the ribbons trailing behind in fiery arcs. "Pretty cool, right?" she said, her voice brimming with pride. "This is what happens when our magic connects. My spear's got a whole new set of tricks now."

She lowered the weapon, planting its butt lightly against the arena floor. Her grin widened. "Your turn. Ribbons. Muskets."

Mami hesitated, her hand trembling faintly before she raised it. Golden light shimmered into existence — her ribbons — but transformed. Diamond patterns glowed across their length, intricate and luminous, echoing the crystalline walls Kyoko could conjure. And the ribbons themselves burned faintly, aflame with a warmth that pulsed in rhythm with both their magic.

Mami reached out, letting one coil gently around her wrist. She brushed her fingers against it, her eyes widening.

"They're warm," she whispered. "Alive."

She swallowed, her throat tight. "Your fire... and my light.

Then her muskets appeared. Mami froze.

They were no longer the refined, antique firearms she knew so well. Each one was different — sleek, angular constructs of metal and light. Crimson-gold lines ran along their frames like circuitry, gears and runes embedded seamlessly into their bodies. They hummed softly, resonant, as though each weapon carried its own pulse. Its own intent.

Mami picked one up, turning it carefully in her hands. The glow reflected in her eyes. "...I don't even know what these are," she admitted, a soft laugh escaping her lips. "Or what they're capable of."

She glanced at Kyoko, eyes glinting with gentle teasing. "Is this your influence? Your... admittedly childish, tomboyish tastes bleeding into my magic?" She smiled, shaking her head. "I was expecting something a bit more elegant."

Kyoko stared at her — then burst out laughing, loud and unrestrained. "Oh, come on!" she shot back. "Don't pin that on me!"

She leaned closer, ribbons flickering around her, eyes sparkling with mischief. “Maybe it’s your side of the Connect making them weird.” She grinned wide, her voice rising with delight. “To me? They look awesome. Way cooler than silly.”

Mami laughed too, her shoulders relaxing, shaking her head. “Perhaps it’s both of us,” she said warmly. “Our magic — and our selves — colliding.”

Kyoko twirled her spear again, ribbons blazing brighter, arcs of crimson-gold cutting through the air. “Jokes aside,” she said, her tone shifting to something steadier, more serious. “This is the point of Connect.”

Her voice carried weight now. “It’s not about copying each other. It’s about resonance.”

She gestured toward Mami’s weapons, ribbons flaring around her arm. “You know how I can shift my spear into different forms? That adaptability — that imagination — it carried over.”

Her grin returned, sharp and confident. “Magnified.”

She gave Mami a thumbs up, the crimson-gold aura around her spear pulsing. “Hey, don’t worry about figuring them out. You won’t have to.”

Her eyes locked onto Mami’s, unwavering. “Once the fight starts, your instincts will take over. Just let it happen. Go wild!”

Mami’s smile softened, her golden eyes glowing with warmth. “So this is what Lunaria and Kasumi meant... when they said Connect is bound only by imagination.”

She glanced toward Kasumi, who was watching with undisguised excitement, almost vibrating with anticipation, her grin wide and eager. “No wonder she’s so eager to see what we’ll do.”

Mami turned back to Kyoko, her grip tightening around the musket. The ribbons lifted around her, responding as if they had always known her, wrapping her in a halo of fire and light.

Her heart was steady. Her voice rang clear.

“I’m fired up,” she said. “Let’s go!”

Kyoko tilted her head, her crimson eyes gleaming. “Hey, Mami. Remember how you struggled with offensive magical control earlier, when you were duking it out with Kasumi?”

Mami chuckled softly, her golden ribbons flickering faintly around her like embers in the air. “Yes... very clearly.” She exhaled, amusement laced with lingering disbelief. “When Kasumi stayed still, I could time it properly.”

Her smile turned wry. “But the instant she started moving—attacking—I lost it. I had to dodge, reposition, plan my next move... and the rhythm collapsed. My focus scattered.”

Kyoko nodded, her expression knowingly sharp.

“Exactly. That’s how it goes. In real combat, there’s too much happening at once. Timing, distance,

pressure, pain.”

She rolled her shoulders, the crimson-gold aura around her spear pulsing faintly. “Offensive magical control was the technique I drilled the hardest in the dream-realm.”

Her grin sharpened, fire sparking in her eyes. “As you know, I love scrapping with opponents. Pouring magic into a strike at the exact instant it lands for explosive power—the technique suits me perfectly.”

Mami laughed, warm and genuine, her ribbons curling closer as if echoing her amusement. “I can picture it perfectly,” she said fondly. “You charging in without hesitation, reading the flow of the fight, unleashing bursts of magic at just the right moment.”

Kyoko glanced down at her spear. The ribbons coiling around it flared faintly, responding to her focus. “I’ve gotten a lot better,” she admitted. “But it’s still not automatic. I have to concentrate—feel the timing, especially when I’m tired or fighting someone stronger than me.”

She loosened her grip, her voice lowering with determination. “My goal is to make it instinct. Something my body does before my mind even catches up. To keep that explosive power going without ever losing momentum.”

Mami nodded slowly, admiration glowing in her golden eyes.

“That sounds incredibly difficult,” she said. “The kind of mastery that only comes from endless training... and real battles.”

She smiled softly, her voice carrying gentle awe. “But if you reach that point... you’ll be terrifying.”

Kyoko’s grin returned, playful and sharp all at once.

“Until then,” she said lightly, “we cheat.”

Mami blinked, tilting her head, ribbons swaying with her movement. “...Cheat?”

Kyoko smirked, twirling her spear. The ribbons followed the motion like flames tracing her path.

“Since our souls and magic are synced, only one of us has to pour energy into an attack for the explosive effect.”

She leaned forward slightly, eyes bright. “Say I’m in close quarters with Kasumi—dodging, blocking, trying to land a hit. If I throw out an attack but I’m too busy defending to charge it properly...”

She snapped her fingers, the sound sharp in the charged air. “You step in. You pour the magic in right before it connects.”

Mami’s breath caught. Her ribbons flared faintly, heat and light rippling through them.

“So that’s possible with Connect...” she whispered. “We can cover each other’s blind spots. Each other’s weak moments.”

“Exactly,” Kyoko said, her grin widening. “And that’s just the start.”

She lifted her spear, gesturing toward the space around them.

“The same goes for defensive magical control. We both sense every ribbon, every diamond wall now—no matter who creates it. Only one of us needs to harden it when an attack comes in.”

Her eyes burned brighter.

“Negativity building up in our Soul Gems? Same deal. One of us can manage it—and turn it into fuel for both of us.”

She smirked. “Connect makes everything shared.”

Mami looked down at her transformed ribbons and muskets, awe shimmering across her face.

“So not only do I have entirely new weapons to explore...” she murmured, “...I can also use the techniques Lunaria and Kasumi taught me in ways I never could alone.”

She lifted her gaze, excitement trembling through her voice.

“That’s incredible. Thank you, Kyoko. I’m even more eager for this fight now.”

Kyoko rubbed her nose with a finger, her expression turning casually proud.

“I’ve been in plenty of Connect battles back in the dream-realm,” she said. “Some of them were insane—especially the team battle royales in the coliseum.”

Mami chuckled softly, her ribbons curling around her like golden fire.

“I saw them,” she said. “When I experienced your past. They looked... overwhelming. Like full-scale magical wars.”

Kyoko’s grin widened, her spear blazing crimson-gold as she settled into a ready stance.

“Exactly,” she said.

Her eyes locked forward, sharp and eager.

“And now it’s our turn.”

Kyoko rolled her shoulder once, loosening her stance, then glanced toward Kasumi with a crooked grin.

“Hey,” she called casually, her voice carrying across the arena. “You good with tanking two hits?”

Kasumi, who had been stretching with theatrical exaggeration, froze mid-motion. She looked up, then broke into a wide, delighted smile.

“Oh?” She raised her thumb high, eyes sparkling. “Absolutely. I’d be honored.”

She winked, flame-bright and unapologetic.

“Just know—those two hits are probably gonna make my battle-lust burn way hotter. Hope you’re ready for that.”

Kyoko chuckled under her breath, unfazed. “Fair warning received.”

She turned to Mami, lowering her voice just enough to feel conspiratorial. “Alright. Let’s try offensive magical control—together this time.”

Mami straightened, her ribbons lifting slightly around her in response, shimmering like golden fireflies.

“You’re starting the attack?” she asked.

“Yeah,” Kyoko said easily. “I’ll swing from here. You pour the magic in right before it hits.”

Mami blinked, glancing from Kyoko's spear to Kasumi's position across the arena. "...But your spear isn't long enough to reach her."

Kyoko's lips curved into a knowing smirk. "Don't worry about that," she said. "You'll see. Just trust me—and watch carefully."

She winked. "Ready?"

Mami hesitated only a heartbeat—then nodded, her voice steady. "Ready."

Kyoko turned back toward Kasumi, planting her feet lightly. "Alright," she called out, voice bright with challenge. "Here we come!"

She twirled her spear once, twice—her movements relaxed, fluid, almost lazy. There was no dramatic flare of magic, no surge of power. When she swung, it was with minimal force, the arc clean and controlled.

To everyone watching, it was obvious: the spear wouldn't even come close.

Then Mami gasped.

From the tip of Kyoko's spear, a line of crimson-gold light unfurled—silent, elegant, stretching forward through the air like a blade of sunfire. It extended impossibly far, a luminous arc tracing the path of the strike all the way to Kasumi.

Mami's breath caught. "K-Kyoko—what is that?"

Kyoko didn't take her eyes off Kasumi. "The potential range," she replied calmly. "Don't worry—no one else can see it. And it's intangible unless we decide otherwise."

The beam shimmered faintly, unreal and beautiful, like a dream given shape.

"Connect unlocked it," Kyoko continued. "As long as I can see my target, I can strike. Any point along that line can become the 'hit.'"

Mami's heart thundered. "So... I just need to—"

"—focus on the moment it reaches her," Kyoko finished. "That's when you pour the magic in."

Mami swallowed, awe blooming in her chest. *So our abilities don't just add together... they evolve.*

The beam neared Kasumi. Mami's senses sharpened. Time seemed to stretch, the world narrowing to that single point of contact.

"Now!" she cried—and released her magic.

The air detonated.

Crimson-gold fire erupted exactly where the invisible beam met Kasumi's body. Flames and smoke blossomed outward in a brilliant explosion, the force rippling across the arena floor.

From the crowd's perspective, it looked as though Kasumi had been struck by sheer intent alone.

“WAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAH!”

Kasumi screamed—loud, dramatic, and completely over-the-top—as she was launched backward, spinning through the air before faceplanting hard into the ground. She bounced once, then rolled end over end, limbs flailing comically, before finally skidding to a stop in an undignified heap.

The arena exploded with cheers and laughter. Petals burst from the flower pods above, raining down in a storm of color.

Mami yelped, hands flying to her mouth. “We— we moved her?!”

Kyoko grinned, eyes gleaming. “Yup. Connect’s no joke.”

She glanced toward Kasumi’s crumpled form, her expression sharpening just a touch. “...Though moving her and actually hurting her are two very different things.”

Mami blinked. “Wait—how can she not be hurt after that?”

Kyoko snorted softly. “That’s Kasumi. You can send her flying all day. Doing real damage?” She shrugged. “That’s another story.”

She turned back to Mami, spear lowering slightly. “Your turn. Try shooting.”

Mami straightened, ribbons swirling around her like a halo. “From the muskets?”

“Yeah,” Kyoko said. “Don’t overthink it. Just imagine the kind of attack you want. The right gun’ll handle the rest.”

She smirked. “I’ll time the magic this time.”

Mami inhaled slowly, centering herself. “Alright,” she said, smiling. “Let’s test this.”

She raised one musket—and released the bare minimum of magic.

The weapon answered.

Light surged, unfolding into a cascade of energy far more complex than she had intended: interlocking arcs of gold and crimson, edged with crackling sparks, the shot twisting through the air like a living thing.

Mami’s eyes widened. “Oh—!”

Kyoko laughed, delighted. “Damn, Mami—that looks awesome!”

The attack hurtled toward Kasumi’s still-prone form.

At the last instant, Kyoko snapped her fingers. Magic surged.

“AIIIIIIIIIIIIIIIIIIII!”

The blast erupted in a violent bloom of fire and lightning, crimson-gold flames roaring outward as Kasumi shrieked again, her body launched skyward before crashing down headfirst—only to flop back onto her stomach with exaggerated finality.

The arena roared with laughter and applause.

“Yes!” Kyoko whooped. “Nailed it!”

She turned to Mami, eyes bright. “That was incredible. You’re getting the hang of this fast.”

Mami laughed, breathless, her heart glowing warm in her chest. “Thank you, Kyoko,” she said softly. “I never imagined... that we could be this powerful. Together.”

Kyoko waved a hand dismissively, grinning. “Save the sentimental stuff for later. We’ve got someone to beat up.”

She rolled her shoulders, spear flaring. “Let’s make this unforgettable.”

High above, in the flower pods, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe stared in stunned silence.

“...That,” Momoko finally said, laughing under her breath, “was insane.”

Mifuyu clasped her hands together, eyes shining. “So this is the true potential of Connect...” she murmured. “Not just shared strength—but shared mastery.”

Kuroe nodded quickly, breath hitching. “They’re applying the techniques Lunaria taught us this morning... all of them. In real combat.”

Below, Mami and Kyoko stood radiant—Soul Gems blazing, movements effortless, laughter lingering in the air. Attuning themselves to life. To each other.

Momoko leaned forward, grin widening. “If this is the ceiling...” she said excitedly, “...I can’t wait until we learn it!”

Mifuyu smiled gently. “I want to see what would happen if we Connect with Yachiyo like this, Momoko. Maybe we could summon the spirits of Mel and Kanae to Earth. It would be just like old times.”

Momoko beamed at her, eyes sparkling. “From what I’m seeing so far, that sounds totally possible. Let’s do it when we get back to Kamihama!”

Kuroe brought her hands close to her chest, her voice trembling with anticipation. “I wonder what would happen if Iroha and I Connect like this.”

The three leaned in, excitement humming between them.

Kuroe laughed softly. “I wonder how Kasumi will respond to that display of power.”

Mifuyu nodded, her tone thoughtful. “Kasumi did warn them her battle-lust would most likely get stronger.”

Momoko grinned, her voice bubbling with energy. “Kyoko did say those attacks may not be enough to hurt Kasumi. Just how strong is she?”

The fight had only just begun.

Kasumi coughed once, then twice — loud, exaggerated, almost comical.

“Arm? Check,” she muttered, rolling her shoulder with a dramatic flourish. “Spleen? Check. Ribs...” She tapped her side thoughtfully, tilting her head. “Huh. One of those might be missing. But ribs grow back, right?”

She staggered upright with theatrical flair, brushing dust from her clothes. Torn fabric fluttered loosely around her, streaks of dirt smeared across her face and hair. Her movements were half-play, half-feral energy.

Then she tilted her head toward Mami and Kyoko, and smiled. A thin trickle of blood slid down from her nose, catching the arena’s light like a crimson thread.

Mami shuddered. That smile — wild, deranged, gleaming with battle-lust — was the same expression Kasumi had worn against Umbra. Mami remembered it vividly: Umbra’s relentless barrage had sent Kasumi flying around the arena too fast for her eyes to follow, an assault that looked devastating. Yet when Kasumi rose with that smile, the tide turned. Two hits. That was all it took for Kasumi to overwhelm Umbra completely.

Kasumi rubbed her nose with the back of her hand, then laughed energetically, her voice ringing bright and sharp. “Those attacks were awesome! So pretty, so explosive. I actually *felt* them. How fun!”

She winked, her tone playful but edged with sincerity. “You two did very well for your first time Connecting. What you just showed is proof of your bond. You should be proud.”

Kyoko chuckled, but her stance shifted — weight lowering, grip tightening around her spear. “Thanks,” she said. “But the real fight starts now, doesn’t it?”

Her eyes narrowed slightly, her grin sharpening. “That smile means your battle-lust’s kicking into high gear. You’re about to charge — same as before.”

Kasumi’s laughter sharpened, cutting through the air like a blade.

The atmosphere changed. Pressure rolled across the arena, heavy and electric, petals trembling mid-fall as if the entire space was holding its breath.

“Exactly,” Kasumi said, her voice buzzing with excitement. “This is where the fun begins.”

She dropped low, like a runner at the starting line. Muscles coiled tight, her aura flaring crimson.

Her grin widened, feral and gleaming.

“Let’s see if you can still pull off those tricks when I’m the one coming at you!”

And then she moved.

The ground cracked beneath her feet, shockwaves rippling outward as her body became a blur of crimson and shadow. She was faster than before — far faster than when Mami had fought her alone.

Mami gasped, her ribbons flaring instinctively. *She’s faster... much faster.*

But then her lips curved into a smile. She spoke telepathically to Kyoko, her voice calm but eager. *Let me try something. I remember what I saw in your past — Thornaria tripping Kasumi with a vine, right as her foot landed. Maybe my ribbons, enhanced with Connect, can do the same.*

Kyoko’s laughter rang in her mind, quick and amused. *That’s a great idea. I’m curious too. Let’s see if your ribbons can actually affect her. We’ll time it together — pour magic in the instant her foot hits.*

Mami extended her hand. A ribbon snapped into existence across Kasumi’s path, diamond patterns glowing along its length. As Kasumi’s foot came down, Mami and Kyoko grinned in unison, pouring their magic into it. The ribbon blazed brighter, aflame with crimson-gold light.

Kasumi felt something catch against her foot. Her stride faltered for the briefest instant.

She glanced down mid-motion, confusion flashing across her face.

“Huh—?”

Too late.

Her momentum betrayed her.

“Wha—?!”

Her foot caught. Her balance shattered. Her body pitched forward, limbs flailing as she slammed into the ground and continued rolling across the arena floor toward Mami and Kyoko.

The crowd roared with laughter, petals raining down in a storm of color.

From above, in the flower pod, Thornaria burst into laughter, clapping her hands with delight. “Yes! That’s exactly what I like to do with my friends!” she cried. “Mami must have seen me trip Kasumi when she connected with Kyoko and saw her past. Kasumi is so prone to tripping!”

She leaned forward eagerly, eyes sparkling. “Now—what will you do next, Mami and Kyoko?”

Kasumi screamed.

Not in pain—
but in *glee*.

Her voice rose and fell wildly as she continued to roll across the arena floor, shrieking like someone trapped on a roller coaster with no brakes. Her limbs flailed helplessly, kicking up clouds of dust as she spun end over end, momentum refusing to let her stop.

“Wooooo—!”

“Ahhhh—!”

“Okaaaay this is gettin’ hard to contr—!”

Mami’s eyes widened, disbelief flashing across her face. “That... worked?!” she blurted.

Kyoko grinned, her crimson aura flickering mischievously. “Yup. Looks like our ribbons can affect her — for now, at least.”

She bounced once on her heels, loosening up. Then her stance shifted.

Sideways.

Feet planted.

Hands sliding apart on the haft of her spear.

Mami’s lips curved upward in recognition.

Kyoko drew the weapon back like a bat—and the spear *answered*.

Its form warped mid-motion, metal stretching and reshaping as the shaft thickened and the head broadened, collapsing into a massive hammer. Crimson-gold veins flared across its surface, ribbons of fire coiling tightly around it, pulsing in time with both their hearts.

Kyoko smirked, eyes blazing. “You know what to do next, right?”

Mami nodded, ribbons lifting around her like a halo of light. “Of course!”

Kasumi rolled straight into the strike zone.

“BATTER UP—!”

Kyoko roared as she swung.

Magic detonated through the hammer at the moment of impact.

WHAM.

“WAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAH!”

Kasumi yelped as the blow connected, her body launching skyward in a spiraling arc. She flipped end over end, arms and legs flailing wildly as she screamed.

Kyoko laughed, pumping her fist.

“Mami—you’re up!”

Kyoko beamed, her grin fiery. “Mami — you’re up!”

“On it!” Mami replied, already moving.

She raised her hand.

Her guns aligned around her in a perfect ring, hovering with mechanical precision. Beams of golden light burst forth, converging on Kasumi from every direction—some fast, some slow, weaving an intricate lattice of trajectories that turned the sky itself into a firing grid.

Kasumi paused mid-flail, eyes sparkling.

“Ooooh! Fireworks after a home run!” she chirped. “So preeetty—!”

Then the beams *shifted*.

Mid-flight, each ray reshaped, solidifying into tangible forms—spears, chains, segmented staves, whips, ribbons, muskets—manifestations of Mami and Kyoko’s combined abilities.

Kasumi’s smile vanished. Her eyes went wide. “Oh no—!”

Kasumi went back to screaming, limbs thrashing in panic.

Mami gasped, astonished at the transformation. Kyoko chuckled, putting both hands behind her head and whistling. “Wow. I didn’t expect you to shoot *all* of that. Let’s see what you plan to do with them!”

Then the barrage struck.

Light spears slammed into her, knocking her violently from one vector to another.

Whips cracked, snapping her sideways.

Segmented staves crashed into her midsection, rattling the breath from her lungs.

Chains and ribbons wrapped tight, binding her limbs in glowing restraints.

“Ow—! Hey—! Not another rib—!” she groaned, dangling helplessly in midair.

“Is it... over yet...?” she mumbled groggily.

Kasumi cracked one eye open—

—and froze.

Above her hovered dozens of glowing constructs, all shaped like Mami’s antique muskets. Their barrels hummed softly as they charged, aimed with merciless precision.

Mami smiled.

Not cruel.

But *theatrical*.

She raised her hand, ribbons flaring dramatically, and called out—

“Tempesta di Luce!”

The muskets fired as one.

A storm of crimson-gold light erupted, explosions blooming like cascading fireworks. Sparks and flame swallowed Kasumi whole, the blast hurling her downward in a blazing arc. She hit the ground with a

thunderous *crash*. Crimson-gold electricity rippled outward from the impact point, dust and petals spiraling high into the air.

The crowd erupted in cheers.

High above, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe leaned forward, stunned.

“Wow, did you see that?!” Momoko breathed, laughing under her breath. “That was soooo cool!” Mifuyu clasped her hands, eyes shining. “The way their attacks overlapped... it’s like their magic is reflecting each other. How beautiful.”

Kuroe nodded quickly, her voice trembling. “It reminds me when I Connected with Iroha, we gained access to each other’s abilities. But what Mami and Kyoko are doing... it’s on a whole different level.”

Down below, Kyoko whooped, pumping her fist. “Nice one, Mami! That was a killer combo!”

Then she smirked, leaning in with a teasing glint in her eye.

“But seriously—what was that name? *Tempest duh... lu-something?* Why do you always shout weird Italian stuff?”

She jabbed her thumb at herself.

“Just like when **you** named my ultimate attack *Rosso Fantasma*.”

Kyoko groaned dramatically, dragging a hand down her face.

“Ugh... I still can’t believe you made me yell that in front of people. So embarrassing.”

Mami only smiled, ribbons swirling playfully around her like golden petals caught in a breeze.

“Because it makes the attacks feel elegant. Refined.”

She lifted her chin with mock sophistication.

“And besides—” she winked, “—it’s fun. Heroic. You *have* to shout the name before you attack, my dear mentee.”

Kyoko sputtered, cheeks tinting the faintest shade of red.

“I swear, you enjoy torturing me with this stuff.”

Mami laughed softly. “Nonsense. I’m simply cultivating your dramatic flair.”

Kyoko snorted. “Some things never change. You’re still kind of a dork.”

Mami pouted exaggeratedly. “Kyoko calling someone else childish? That’s rich.”

Kyoko leaned closer, grin sharpening. “Oh? What’s that supposed to mean?”

Their laughter rang together—bright, warm, perfectly in sync.

Then both turned toward the settling smoke.

Kyoko’s eyes narrowed, excitement burning. “Alright. Let’s see how much that actually did.”

Mami nodded, her weapons glowing faintly. “Yes.”

The smoke began to thin.

Kyoko and Mami braced themselves, breaths steady, senses sharpened. Their ribbons — now extensions of their instincts — pulsed with warning.

Something was behind Kyoko.

Both girls stiffened.

Behind?

Nothing had come out of the smoke. No sound. No shift in air. No magic signature.

Yet their ribbons screamed danger.

Without hesitation, they poured magic into the ribbons. Crimson-gold light flared, diamond patterns blooming outward like fractal flowers. The air crystallized into a shimmering barrier — Kyoko's diamond walls, but softer, warmer, threaded with Mami's golden glow.

A split-second later—

CRACK—!

Something slammed into the barrier.

The impact sent shivers through the entire structure. Fractures spiderwebbed across the diamonds, racing outward. But it bought them a heartbeat.

Enough time to turn.

Enough time to see—

Kasumi.

She burst from the thinning smoke like a nightmare given shape. Her smile was deranged, stretched too wide, a thin line of blood trailing down her chin. Her clothes were even more shredded than before, torn open to reveal cuts and gashes across her arms, torso, and legs. Her eyes gleamed with feral joy.

She had thrown a punch.

And she was breaking through the barrier.

Kyoko reacted instantly, swinging her spear upward to intercept the blow.

SHATTER—!

Kasumi's punch tore through the diamond wall, ripped through the ribbons, and collided with Kyoko's spear.

The force was monstrous.

Kyoko's arms buckled. The spear slammed back into her chest, fiery ribbons flaring to soften the blow — but not enough.

She coughed, tasting blood. Her breath ripped from her lungs. Her body was hurled backward, tumbling across the arena like a ragdoll.

“KYOKO!” Mami screamed.

But before she could move—

A voice whispered behind her, low and amused:

“Is now really the best time to be worrying about her?”

Mami’s blood ran cold.

Kyoko’s voice rang in her mind, strained but urgent.

Don’t worry. I’ve got her.

Kyoko, still tumbling through the air from Kasumi’s punch, saw it: Kasumi’s leg whipping around in a brutal kick aimed at Mami’s blind spot.

Kyoko poured magic into the nearest ribbons. They flared brilliantly—diamond patterns exploding outward like a blooming star. She hit the ground hard, rolling across the arena floor, and the barrier sprang up just in time.

Kasumi’s kick struck it.

CRACK—! CRACK—!

The barrier fractured instantly, spidering like ice under pressure. But it held just long enough.

Mami snapped her hand up, summoning more ribbons, more guns. They formed a desperate lattice between her and Kasumi, a chaotic shield of fire, light, and steel.

Kasumi’s kick broke through the diamond wall—

SLAM—!

—and crashed into Mami’s defenses. The ribbons and weapons flew backward like toys, smashing into her torso. She coughed blood, breath ripping from her lungs, and was hurled across the arena.

Her guns scattered in every direction, some spinning through the air, some clattering across the grassy field. Torn ribbons fluttered away like wounded butterflies.

Kyoko stabbed her spear into the ground.

Ribbons burst from its base like fiery roots, plunging into the earth. They bit deep, carving trenches as she fought to arrest her uncontrolled tumble. Dirt sprayed behind her in a long, violent arc.

She finally skidded to a stop—
just in time to see Kasumi already there.

Right in front of her.

Grinning maniacally.

Fist already cocked back for another punch.

Kyoko's stomach dropped. *She's already here?!*

Kasumi's speed was unreal—attacking again before Kyoko even had time to orient herself. No pause.

No breath. Just relentless forward momentum.

Kyoko grimaced and moved on instinct. She jammed her spear and ribbons downward and vaulted off them like a springboard, launching herself straight up into the air. She released the spear mid-flight, letting it dissolve into a burst of crimson light.

Kasumi's punch tore through the fading weapon, shattering it into sparks.

Kyoko narrowly dodged the blow, air whipping past her face as she ascended.

She sucked in a breath, suspended in the air, thoughts racing.

Okay. A second to reset. Just a second—

A voice behind her cut through the air:

“Mami did the same thing earlier. Launched herself into the air to dodge me.”

Kyoko's blood ran cold.

“Unfortunately for you,” the voice purred, “I’m responding differently this time.”

Then something yanked Kyoko midair—hard.

Her body snapped sideways, momentum jerking like a severed rope. She twisted just in time to see Kasumi's axe kick cleave through the space she'd occupied a heartbeat earlier.

Before panic could take hold, another voice spoke—warm, teasing, and unmistakably Mami's:

“And *this* is what Kasumi did earlier,” Mami said, mirroring Kasumi's tone perfectly. “Using my own ribbons to pull me toward her for a hit.”

Kyoko blinked—then realized she was being pulled *away* from Kasumi by a golden ribbon wrapped around her waist.

Mami chuckled. “But unfortunately for Kasumi, I’m using that move to pull *you* out of danger.”

Kyoko let out a breathless laugh as she was reeled toward safety.

Mami added lightly, “And this time, I made sure there are no ribbons within Kasumi's reach. She won't be grabbing anything of ours.”

Below them, Kasumi flipped and spun through the air in chaotic, uncontrolled arcs, plummeting toward the ground. She laughed the entire way down.

“Excellent teamwork!” she called mid-fall. “Quick thinking! Improvisation! Mami, you’re learning from your past battles!”

She face-planted into the ground with her usual dramatic flair.

Kyoko landed on a floating platform of diamond-patterned ribbons, suspended midair. Mami stood there waiting, guns orbiting her like a constellation.

Kyoko exhaled, shoulders loosening, and grinned. “Thanks for the save.”

“Of course,” Mami said, smiling back warmly.

Then her expression tightened. “Kasumi is moving much faster now. And her attacks... they’re so heavy. Even when we block with ribbons, barriers, or weapons, the impact still hurts.”

Kyoko nodded, rubbing her chest where Kasumi’s punch had landed. “Yeah. She didn’t give me a second to breathe. She’s scaling up—pushing us to keep up.”

Kyoko snapped her fingers. Two steaming buns appeared in her hands.

She handed one to Mami. “Eat. It’ll heal you and give buffs.”

Mami blinked—then laughed softly. “Two days ago, while I was sleeping, I dreamt about what abilities we might unlock as we improved our magical control.”

She smiled fondly. “For you, I imagined something involving food. I called it *Combat Cooking*.”

Kyoko smirked.

“Looks like my imagination was spot on,” Mami finished.

She took a bite—

—and froze.

Her eyes softened. Her breath hitched.

The bun tasted like tea parties she and Kyoko had shared long ago—the warmth of roasted tea, the gentle sweetness of fruit pastries, delicate floral notes from afternoons spent together. A flavor woven from memory and comfort, layered with something quietly healing.

Mami looked at Kyoko, visibly moved.

Kyoko grinned. “Tasty, right? Learned it in the dream-realm. Food that changes flavor based on the eater’s mood.”

Mami laughed warmly. “I saw girls telling you about that when I experienced your past. I just... didn’t expect to taste dream-realm food this soon.”

Kyoko devoured her bun in two bites. “Mmph—we gotta change things up,” she said around the mouthful. “Or Kasumi’ll keep targetin’ us and overwhelm us.”

She swallowed, wiped her mouth, and grinned fiercely.

“Rosso Fantasma!”

Crimson-gold light burst across the sky.

Dozens of Kyokos and Mamis bloomed into existence overhead, scattered across the arena like stars.

Kyoko pointed down. “Hopefully these clones keep her busy.”

Mami smiled. “I’ll add to the chaos.”

She flicked her wrist. Ribbons spiraled outward, forming more clones of both of them. Then she fired one of her guns—

—and to Kyoko’s shock, clones of them *shot out of the barrel* like magical projectiles.

Kyoko gawked. “What—what do those even do?!”

Mami giggled. “Watch and see. It’ll be fun.”

Below, Kasumi peeled herself off the ground, shaking dust from her hair.

She looked up—

—and froze.

A rainstorm of Mamis and Kyokos descended from the sky.

The Kyokos made silly faces, sticking out their tongues and taunting, “Let’s see if you can find the real one, Kasumi!”

The Mamis raised their guns in perfect synchronization. “Get ready. We’re on the attack now.”

Kasumi’s grin widened, feral and electric. The air thickened with pressure, her battle-lust burning hotter than ever.

“Challenge accepted,” she growled, eyes blazing. “Bring it on!”

The sky filled with Kyokos and Mamis.

Kyoko’s clones dove first.

They attacked Kasumi with a dizzying array of weapons—spears, segmented staves, chains, whips, ribbons—each strike extending impossibly far thanks to the “invisible line-of-sight range” unlocked by Connect. Crimson-gold arcs carved through the air, detonating in sharp bursts of fire wherever they landed.

Mami’s clones followed close behind.

Ribbons lashed outward in overlapping patterns, snares blooming midair as Connect-enhanced guns unleashed volleys of specialized shots. No two were the same—spiraling beams, ricocheting blasts, ribbon-wrapped projectiles, shots that split and re-split mid-flight like living organisms made of light.

Kasumi looked up at the descending storm—

—and grinned.

She charged straight into it.

Explosions erupted around her as Kyoko's extended-range strikes connected. Kasumi planted her feet, grounding herself. The impacts scorched her skin, tore at her clothes, and sent violent shockwaves through her body—

—but she barely moved.

Not like before.

Not like the first time she'd tanked their attacks just to let them demonstrate their new abilities.

Now she absorbed the damage and kept going.

Mami's special shots struck next. Some staggered her. Some twisted her sideways. One even flipped her once through the air.

Kasumi laughed through it all, her grin widening with every impact.

When ribbons or chains managed to bind her, diamond patterns flashed across her body like glowing seals. Her momentum slowed—just for a heartbeat.

Then she tore free.

Bindings snapped. Ribbons shredded. Chains burst apart as Kasumi forced her way forward through brute strength alone.

Kyoko grit her teeth. Mami gasped.

Even with all these clones... it's barely slowing her down.

Kasumi reached one of the Kyokos.

She grinned. "Let's see if this one's real."

She threw a punch.

The clone tried to block—ribbons flaring, diamond barrier forming, spear snapping into place—
—but Kasumi's fist tore through all of it.

The blow landed square in the clone's stomach.

The Kyoko spat blood, eyes going glassy, and collapsed before dissolving into crimson sparkles.

Kasumi chuckled. "Not the real one, then."

She pivoted instantly and lunged at a nearby Mami clone, snapping a kick toward her neck. Guns and ribbons rose in defense—

—and were cleaved through in a single motion.

The Mami clone fell limp and faded into golden sparkles.

Mami's breath hitched.

Kyoko—she's taking them out in one hit.

Kyoko's reply came sharp and grim.

Yeah. If she hits the real us now, it's game over.

Below, the remaining Kyokos made a synchronized gesture — a small flick of their fingers.

The crimson and golden sparkles drifting from the defeated clones suddenly reversed direction, swirling upward like fireflies and sinking into every Kyoko and Mami still standing.

A warm pulse of magic flowed back into Mami.

Kyoko... what was that?

Magical control, Kyoko replied quickly. *Some of the magic used to create the clones gets recycled when they're destroyed. Keeps us in the fight longer.*

Mami chuckled in her mind, impressed.

Recycling magic from your own techniques... I never would have thought of that.

Kyoko smirked.

Heh, thanks.

Mami's tone shifted, playful.

But you aren't the only one with clone tricks.

Kyoko laughed.

Oh? Show me.

Kasumi struck another Mami clone with a sharp chop—

—and the clone exploded.

A brilliant burst of golden light detonated point-blank, blasting Kasumi backward midair. She tumbled once, coughing, eyes wide in genuine surprise.

Kyoko blinked.

Mami—what was THAT?

Mami smiled, ribbons fluttering gently.

The ones I shot from my guns are traps. They fight like normal clones... but explode when struck.

Kyoko grinned, delighted.

Bomb clones that can attack AND blow up? That's awesome.

Thank you, Mami replied sweetly.

Kasumi landed in a crouch, rolling her shoulders as she shook off the blast. Then she laughed—loud, wild, thrilled.

“So some of the clones are bombs,” she said brightly. “Those must be the ones Mami fired from her gun earlier. They look exactly like the others.”

Her gaze flicked upward, tracking the lingering sparkles flowing into the remaining copies.

“And those crimson and golden motes... recycled magic from defeated clones, right? Clever, Kyoko. Distributing it evenly so you don’t reveal your positions.”

Her grin sharpened, battle-lust flaring hot and bright.

“How interesting. How fun!”

Kasumi crouched lower, muscles coiling like a spring.

“Let’s see how long your little army lasts.”

The Kyokos and Mamis kept attacking.

Spears, chains, staves, ribbons, gunfire—
a relentless storm of crimson-gold magic crashed down on Kasumi from every direction.

Bomb-clones detonated in blinding bursts of light. Ribbon snares coiled tight around her limbs. Diamond seals flared across her body as impact after impact struck home.

And Kasumi tanked all of it.

She staggered once—twice—then steadied herself again. Each explosion, each binding, each blow only made her grin widen. The pressure in the air thickened, heavy and electric, as though the arena itself were being pulled inward toward her.

Her battle-lust burned hotter.

Brighter.

Heavier.

Like a star collapsing in on itself.

Mami’s voice trembled through the telepathic link.

Kyoko... she’s getting stronger as the fight goes on. Soon the clones — and we — won’t be able to do anything to her.

Kyoko’s reply came sharp and urgent.

Yeah. We need to do something big. Now. Before she overwhelms us.

Then Kyoko glanced at Mami with a mischievous grin.

Wanna try one of Mirielle's ideas? The craziest one she pitched yesterday — before our fight with the six witches?

Mami blinked — then laughed.

You mean the one where I shoot everything out of a giant gun... ending with shooting YOU out of it? And you ride my ribbons like a roller coaster? Loop-de-loops, corkscrews, and then you ram into the enemy like a flaming, ribbon-powered missile? That one?

Kyoko winked.

Exactly that one.

Mami sighed, covering her face for a moment.

Kyoko... you are unbearably bold. And reckless. There are probably simpler ways to achieve the same effect. You just want to get launched because it sounds fun, don't you?

Guilty, Kyoko admitted cheerfully. But hey—roller coasters build momentum, right? More speed, more power.

Mami shook her head, smiling despite herself.

Alright. Let's do it. The clone strategy isn't working—Kasumi isn't slowing down. She's accelerating.

Kyoko slammed a fist into her palm.

Then let's go all in.

She grinned wider.

And let's have some clones do it too. The rest can keep her busy.

Immediately, dozens of Kyoko and Mami clones surged toward Kasumi.

Kasumi laughed as the mob converged, charging into them head-on. She tore through clones with single blows—explosions and sparkles bursting around her like fireworks.

Meanwhile—

Mami and several of her clones raised their hands. Enormous cannons materialized around them—sleek, elegant constructs etched with glowing crimson-gold circuitry.

Kyoko and her clones scrambled inside, brimming with excitement.

“Kyoko,” Mami called, just loud enough to cut through the chaos. “Ready? You're *sure* about this?”

Kyoko laughed, bracing herself inside the barrel. “I've ALWAYS been ready for this. Fire!”

The Mamis fired.

Kyokos shot out like magical missiles.

Ribbons unfurled ahead of them—vast, dynamic tracks glowing with diamond patterns. They twisted and looped through the sky in impossible spirals, corkscrews, and vertical drops. The Kyokos screamed with exhilaration as they rocketed along them, speed climbing higher and higher.

Fire gathered around their bodies, forming blazing cones that shifted in color—red, orange, yellow, green, blue—finally deepening into searing violet as their velocity peaked.

Each Kyoko flew a different path.

Each Kyoko would strike at a different moment.

The audience erupted in laughter and cheers.

Mirielle practically leapt out of her seat. “YES! YES! THEY’RE ACTUALLY DOING IT! THEY’RE DOING MY IDEA—!”

Down below, Kasumi smashed through more clones — and suddenly, all of them vanished into sparkles.

Kasumi blinked. “Huh?”

Then she looked up.

A blazing cone of violet flame screamed toward her.

Kasumi laughed, delighted. “So THIS is your execution of Mirielle’s idea from yesterday. I love it!”

She winced, bracing herself. “... This is probably going to hurt.”

The first Kyoko clone hit.

Her spear impaled Kasumi clean through the abdomen. Kasumi yelped, blood spraying as violet flames engulfed her torso.

Then another struck—
and another—
and another.

Each impact pierced her in a different place—shoulder, thigh, ribs, arm—each adding more heat, more force, more pressure. Violet fire layered upon itself, swelling into a roaring inferno.

Finally—

The real Kyoko streaked in, wrapped in a blazing cone brighter than all the others combined.

Now or never! Kyoko shouted.

Yes! Mami answered.

Every remaining sparkle surged inward—
magic reclaimed from defeated clones, fired cannons, impaling strikes—everything they had left.

Kyoko’s spear ignited, blazing violet-white.

She struck.

The spear pierced Kasumi’s heart.

And the fire exploded outward in a massive nova—
a starburst of light, heat, and raw magical force that shook the entire arena.

The audience gasped—then erupted into thunderous applause.

Mirielle clapped wildly, eyes shining. “That violet nova—it’s just like the one we used against Umbra. What a beautiful attack... it brings back memories.”

Elira, Sylvette, and Umbra shared a quiet, bittersweet smile.

Momoko shielded her eyes. “Holy— that was incredible.”

Mifuyu’s voice trembled. “Such coordination... such power...”

Kuroe leaned forward, breath held. “Did it work?”

The smoke swirled.

The flames dimmed.

And the arena held its breath.

When the flames and smoke finally thinned, Mami and Kyoko saw her.

Kasumi was on one knee.

Her breath came ragged and uneven. The wild, crushing energy that had filled the arena moments ago was gone, leaving behind a strange, hollow quiet. Blood dripped steadily from every place she’d been impaled, pooling beneath her in dark, shimmering streaks. Faint traces of violet fire still clung to her wounds, flickering like dying embers before fading out.

And yet—

Kasumi laughed.

Soft. Breathless. Worn thin at the edges.

But unmistakably happy.

She lifted her head. First toward Kyoko, who was still gripping the spear lodged in Kasumi’s heart. Then toward Mami, standing behind her cannon, ribbons fluttering faintly.

Both Kyoko and Mami were sweating and panting, their Soul Gems dulled from the sheer amount of magic they’d poured into the fight.

“Congratulations,” Kasumi rasped, voice hoarse but bright. “That was... incredible.”

She smiled, eyes shining.

“A beautiful display of teamwork. Connection. Creativity.”

Then, with a small, satisfied exhale and a wink:

“And most importantly—that was fun! You met my expectations.”

Mami let out a shaky laugh, disbelief spilling into her voice..

“Kasumi... how are you even conscious? You were impaled—multiple times! You truly are—”

“A monster?” Kasumi supplied cheerfully. “A deranged fiery freak of nature?”

Mami gave a helpless little chuckle. “...Yes. Exactly that.”

Kyoko, however, hadn’t relaxed.

Her grip on the spear tightened. Her eyes narrowed.

“...Why are you talking like this is over?” she asked slowly. “Why do you look so weak? And that pressure— your battle-lust —it’s gone.”

She swallowed.

“Don’t tell me—”

Kasumi coughed up blood before she could finish. She wiped her mouth with the back of her hand, then smiled wider. She grabbed the spear still impaling her chest—

—and pulled it deeper through herself.

Kyoko gasped as the sudden force yanked her off balance. Exhausted and unsteady, she stumbled forward, falling toward Kasumi.

Mami’s breath caught. Her heart skipped.

Kyoko was right.

The crushing pressure of Kasumi’s battle-lust had vanished. Mami had been too shocked by Kasumi’s condition to notice.

So what is Kasumi hiding?

Kasumi drew her fist back.

“Let me show you one more thing, Mami,” she said softly, “before I disappear.”

“Disappear...?” Mami echoed, dread curling in her chest.

Kyoko gave a quiet, almost amused breath.

“...Yeah. I figured.”

Mami turned sharply toward her. “Kyoko—what do you—”

Kasumi’s fist slammed into Kyoko’s abdomen.

The impact was sudden, devastating—not flashy, not explosive. Just absolute.

Kyoko’s breath exploded out of her. Blood sprayed from her lips. Her eyes rolled back as consciousness slipped away.

And then—

Mami felt it too.

A sharp, tearing pain ripped through her abdomen. She coughed blood, staggering, vision blurring.

“W-what... was... that...?” she gasped as darkness closed in.

Before either of them collapsed fully, they saw Kasumi give them a cheerful thumbs-up.

Then her body dissolved—not violently, but gently—into drifting orange-red flames, like embers carried off by the wind. And then she was gone.

The arena erupted into applause.

Momoko stared down at the battlefield, mouth hanging open.

“...Wait,” she said slowly. “Did they actually win?”

Mifuyu shook her head, eyes wide. “But Umbra said Kasumi is stronger than her. And Umbra said she could easily defeat Mami and Kyoko even while Connected.”

Kuroe leaned forward, pressing against the pod-barrier. “And why did Mami fall too? Kasumi only hit Kyoko.”

None of it made sense.

Lunaria laughed softly beside them.

“Kyoko understood at the very end,” she said. “She’s fought Kasumi many times. Seen her fight countless others.”

The three turned toward her.

“The Kasumi you saw today wasn’t her true self,” Lunaria continued. “She was a heavily suppressed clone.”

Silence.

“...A suppressed clone?” Momoko repeated.

“That powerful...?” Mifuyu whispered.

Kuroe swallowed. “Then what is the real Kasumi like?”

Lunaria smiled, calm and knowing.

“Kasumi estimated how strong Kyoko and Mami would become through Connect. Then she created a version of herself designed to push them—hard—but still allow them to succeed if they worked together.”

She winked.

“And they did.”

Momoko let out a disbelieving laugh. “So this was a lesson.”

“A test,” Mifuyu added.

“A benchmark,” Kuroe finished quietly.

Umbra stepped forward.

“As for why Mami was affected by Kasumi’s punch...” Umbra said, “that’s because of Connect.”

The three girls leaned in.

Umbra smiled faintly. “There are multiple sides to everything. Connect is no exception. My own ability uses Connect to corrupt Soul Gems and turn magical girls into witches.”

She paused.

“Similarly, if someone with good magical control understands Connect deeply enough... they can use Connect *against* those who rely on it in other ways.”

“When Kasumi struck Kyoko,” Umbra finished, “she synced the damage through their Connection.”

Momoko’s breath caught.

Mifuyu covered her mouth.

Kuroe’s hands trembled.

“To think connect has such a dangerous weakness,” Momoko whispered.

“It can be turned against you,” Mifuyu said.

“...If you’re not careful,” Kuroe finished.

Umbra winked. “What Kasumi did is extremely advanced. Most opponents won’t be capable of it. Under normal circumstances, Mami would have been unharmed.”

The three girls exhaled slowly, staring down at the unconscious pair below.

They had witnessed new frontiers of power, technique, and Connection.

And they couldn’t wait to talk to Kyoko and Mami once they woke up.

Kyoko yawned first.

A long, unguarded, almost catlike stretch rolled through her as she blinked awake, squinting up at the sky.

Mami stirred beside her, letting out a soft, sleepy hum as she stretched her arms overhead.

They were lying in the grass of the arena’s plains.

Warm sunlight brushed their faces. A cool breeze drifted by.

No pain. No lingering fatigue.

In fact—

They felt completely refreshed.

As if the brutal, spectacular fight had never happened at all.

Mami pushed herself up on her elbows, blinking. “You up as well, Kyoko?”

Kyoko rubbed at her eyes and smirked. “Yup. Arena perks.” She flopped onto her back. “That nap was *amazing*.”

Mami let out a small laugh, then froze as her vision cleared.

Standing in front of them were only a handful of figures now:

Kasumi.

Lunaria.

Momoko.

Mifuyu.

Kuroe.

Everyone else—the cheering crowd, the roaring arena—had vanished back into the dream-realm.

Mami’s eyes widened. “Kasumi? But—you said you were going to disappear before you hit Kyoko. And... how was *I* knocked out when *she* was punched? And you felt so much weaker than when you fought Umbra...”

Kyoko groaned and cut in, crossing her arms. “Because we didn’t fight *Kasumi*-Kasumi.”

Mami turned to her.

“We fought a clone,” Kyoko continued. “A *really* suppressed one. Tuned to test us. One we could actually beat if we worked together.”

Mami stared.

Then she laughed—bright, breathless, relief spilling out of her.

“That explains everything. No wonder our attacks actually hurt you... and why your battle-lust vanished at the end.”

She looked at Kasumi, incredulous and amused.

“You did all of that just to make the fight more fun?”

Kasumi swept into an exaggerated bow, one hand to her chest.

“Bingo! And it was *delightful*.” She grinned. “Judging by your faces, I’d say you two had fun too.”

Mami and Kyoko exchanged a glance.

Then they both laughed.

They couldn’t deny it.

Kasumi straightened and turned to Mami, her expression softening.

“You know,” she said gently, “since you arrived here, you’ve lost nearly every fight you’ve been in. Except your rematch with Charlotte—your very first day. The one where you learned how deeply your emotions affect your magic.”

Mami blinked, surprised by the sincerity in her tone.

“All those fights were meant to push you,” Kasumi continued. “To throw you into the deep end. But... it must’ve been discouraging sometimes, right? Always facing someone stronger. Never getting a win.”

Mami let out a slow, honest breath.

“Yes,” she admitted. “I enjoyed them—but I couldn’t help feeling weak.”

She smiled wryly.

“I’ve ‘failed’ every ‘beginner’ lesson in this realm. So what does that make me?”

Kasumi burst out laughing.

“It makes you someone who *finally* won.” She grinned. “And victory always tastes better after a long losing streak, doesn’t it?”

Mami hesitated. “...But we were knocked out. Does that still count?”

Kasumi gave them a cheerful thumbs-up.

“You beat my clone. That’s a win.”

She winked.

“The knockout was just... part of the lesson.”

Mami tilted her head. “A lesson?”

Kasumi nodded eagerly, her twin-tails bouncing. “A weakness of Connect.”

Mami’s expression sharpened. “You mean when I felt pain after you hit Kyoko...”

“Exactly!” Kasumi chirped. “Your magic and souls were synced—so I synced the damage.”

Mami went still. “Is that... similar to how Umbra uses Connect to corrupt Soul Gems?”

Kasumi shook her head. “Similar concept, different execution. Umbra *forces* Connect. I just *exploited* the one you already had.”

Mami exhaled slowly, awe coloring her voice.

“So many interactions... so many layers. The magical world really is vast.”

She looked between Kasumi and Lunaria.

“So Connect is powerful—but dangerous. If one person falls, everyone Connected falls as well.”

Lunaria smiled warmly.

“In theory, yes. But what Kasumi demonstrated is extremely advanced. It requires deep understanding and control. Very few could pull it off.”

Kasumi winked. “Which is why you passed~! My clone only used it to teach you—not to beat you.”

Warmth spread through Mami’s chest.

Her first true victory.

After so many defeats.

She turned to Kyoko, eyes soft.

Kyoko closed her eyes, grinned, and held out a fist.

Mami smiled, closed her eyes, and bumped it.

A quiet, perfect moment.

Chapter 5b: Race against time

Mami turned toward Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe with a warm, polite smile.

“I’m Tomoe Mami,” she said, dipping her head slightly. “A magical girl from Mitakihara. It’s... truly an honor to meet all of you.”

Momoko brightened immediately. “Momoko Togame. Nice to meet you too! As you’ve heard, we’re all from Kamihama.”

Mifuyu placed a hand over her chest and bowed with graceful elegance. “Mifuyu Azusa. I’m honored.”

Kuroe gave a small, shy wave. “Kuroe. Nice to meet you.”

Their friendliness eased some of the tension in Mami’s shoulders — only a little, but enough for her to breathe.

She glanced toward Lunaria and Kasumi, silently asking with her eyes:

Should I tell them?

Should I ask for help?

Should I burden them with this?

Lunaria gave a gentle, reassuring nod.

Kasumi smiled, giving a small, encouraging gesture.

Mami inhaled slowly. Her hands trembled.

“There’s... something I need to tell you,” she began, voice soft and hesitant. “Something important. Something that’s been weighing on me.”

Momoko’s expression softened instantly. “Whatever it is, you can tell us.”

Mami swallowed hard.

“It’s about my friends back on Earth. Madoka... Sayaka... and the real Kyoko.”

The Kamihama girls straightened, sensing the shift in tone.

“Sayaka... she’s slipping,” Mami whispered. “Faster than I can reach her. No matter what Madoka or Kyoko do, she keeps pushing them away. I... I don’t know how much longer she can hold on.”

Momoko gasped.

Mifuyu’s hand flew to her mouth.

Kuroe’s eyes widened in horror.

“I begged Lunaria and Kasumi to help her,” Mami continued. “To save her the way they saved me.”

She let out a small, bittersweet chuckle and glanced at the two mentors.

“But they wouldn’t.”

“They believe in the deep-end method,” Mami explained. “They only step in after magical girls experience the harsh truths — the pain, the despair — so they can truly understand the techniques they teach.”

She looked down at her hands, fingers curling slightly.

“Madoka, Sayaka, and Kyoko... they still don’t know the truth. That magical girls become witches when despair takes them.”

Silence fell — heavy, reverent, almost sacred.

Mami lifted her head again, eyes burning with determination.

“But more than that... I want to help Sayaka myself. To save her with my own strength — and with the support of others. Not by relying on Lunaria or Kasumi to fix everything.”

Her voice softened, trembling.

“They told me about a technique called *dis-connect*... a way to siphon negativity from someone and release it into the universe as energy. But... it would take weeks to learn even a tiny part of it. Weeks Sayaka doesn’t have. She’ll become a witch long before then.”

She turned fully toward the Kamihama girls.

Her eyes glistened with hope.

With desperation.

With a plea she had carried for far too long.

She sank lower, pressing her hands to the ground, bowing deeply.

“Please,” she whispered, voice breaking. “If you have any abilities... any knowledge... anything — anything at all that could help me save Sayaka, I beg you... please help me.”

The wind rustled the grass around them, soft and mournful.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe stared at her — stunned, moved, and already beginning to understand the weight she carried... and the courage it took to finally ask for help.

For a moment, no one moved.

The wind brushed through the grass, soft and cool.

The air felt thick — not with tension, but with emotion.

Then—

Momoko stepped forward.

She knelt before Mami, gently taking Mami's trembling hands into her own.

Mami looked up, startled, and found Momoko smiling — bright, warm, steady.

Momoko lifted Mami's hands, helping her rise to her feet.

"Of course we'll help," she said, voice glowing with sincerity. "Magical girls should have each other's backs. Always."

Mami's breath hitched.

Before she could speak, Mifuyu stepped forward as well, her expression soft and reassuring.

"And," she added, "we do know of a way. Something that might be able to save Sayaka."

Mami's eyes widened — hope, relief, and disbelief all crashing together.

Tears welled up and slipped down her cheeks.

She bowed deeply, voice trembling.

"Thank you... thank you so much... truly, from the bottom of my heart."

She lifted her head again, wiping her eyes.

"What can we do? What can *I* do? Please — tell me anything."

Mifuyu exchanged a glance with Momoko, then asked gently:

"Mami... do you know what a Doppel Witch is?"

Mami nodded.

"Yes. Kasumi showed Lunaria and me her memories from Kamihama — the Memory Museum. We saw your pasts... the truths you learned. The APS. The Doppel system Touka, Nemu, and Alina created."

She took a breath.

"When a magical girl is about to become a witch, the APS activates and she becomes a Doppel instead — a manifestation of her negative emotions. Then she returns to normal, her Soul Gem purified."

Mami hesitated.

“But... Kasumi, Lunaria, and I all felt something was wrong. The Doppels looked... dangerous. Like magical girls couldn’t fully control them. We suspected there were side effects Touka, Nemu, Alina, and Mitama were hiding.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe all burst into laughter.

Mami blinked, startled.

Momoko wiped a tear from her eye. “Wow. You nailed it.”

Mifuyu nodded, smiling ruefully. “You even sensed the side effects. The same ones we had to deal with yesterday.”

Kuroe stepped forward, voice quiet but steady.

“The ones that... killed us.”

Mami gasped, hand flying to her mouth.

“You— you three—?”

Mifuyu gave Mami a forlorn, gentle smile.

“When a magical girl uses her Doppel too much, the Doppel takes over. She won’t return to normal. Mitama keeps them in isolation spheres until the Wings of the Magius can activate their final plan — which she *hopes* will turn them back.”

Mami’s eyes widened further. “So it’s true... there *is* a dangerous side effect. From what I’m hearing, those Doppelified magical girls are no different from actual witches.”

Kuroe nodded and continued where Mifuyu left off.

“That’s right. Yesterday... my Doppel took over. It was terrifying — like I was losing myself piece by piece. My Doppel used my biggest regret to twist my emotions, and eventually... it controlled me completely.”

She swallowed.

“My Doppel broke through the APS barrier — the mechanism that prevents magical girls from becoming witches in Kamihama.”

Mami’s breath caught. “That’s terrible, so does that mean—”

“Yes,” Kuroe said softly. “I became a witch.”

Mami stared at her, stunned.

Kuroe had become a witch... and yet she stood here now.

Kuroe smiled and turned toward Lunaria.

“But Lunaria saved me. She used dis-connect. And now... I’m myself again.”

She held out her Soul Gem — whole, bright, untainted.

Mami let out a breathy laugh of awe. “So dis-connect can save witches... What an incredible ability.”

She turned to Momoko and Mifuyu.

“So then... what happened to you two?”

Mifuyu smiled sadly.

“After Kuroe’s Doppel broke the APS barrier, the other Doppelified girls went berserk. Momoko and I... we sacrificed ourselves to stop them. We took their negativity into ourselves to turn them back to normal. We were on the brink of dying.”

Momoko nodded softly. “And Kasumi saved us afterward.”

At the mention of Kasumi’s name, both Momoko and Mifuyu turned toward her.

Their eyes shone with gratitude — deep, heartfelt, unguarded.

“Kasumi,” Momoko said, bowing. “Thank you. Truly. For saving us.”

Mifuyu bowed as well. “We thanked Lunaria this morning, but... we didn’t get the chance to thank you properly.”

Kasumi blinked — then broke into a theatrical twirl, her clothes flaring dramatically as she swept into a flamboyant bow.

“You’re very welcome!” she declared.

Then her voice softened, warm and sincere.

“The way you two sacrificed yourselves to save everyone... it was beautiful. A true display of strength, resolve, and — most importantly — love.”

Momoko and Mifuyu flushed, touched to the core.

Kuroe smiled shyly beside them.

Kasumi’s expression shifted — from gentle warmth to her usual mischievous spark.

“But!” she said brightly, hands on her hips. “If you really want to thank me... you should fight me. Right here. Right now. Just like Mami and Kyoko did!”

Mifuyu let out a startled laugh. “Kasumi, please— we’re nowhere near ready for that.”

Momoko grinned. “We’d get obliterated! Unless you scale your clone down even more.”

She pointed at Kasumi with a playful spark in her eyes.

“But I *will* fight you someday. Once I’m stronger.”

Mifuyu nodded. “Me too.”

Kuroe raised her hand timidly. “Um... me three. Maybe as a team.”

Kasumi winked, delighted.

“Perfect! I’ll hold you to it. I can’t wait to see what you’re capable of after some training.”

The mood lightened—warm, hopeful, full of new bonds forming.

Momoko stepped forward with that bright, sun-warm smile of hers — the kind that made even heavy topics feel a little lighter.

“Well,” she said, hands on her hips, “I think we can help Sayaka. Mifuyu and I can do what we did yesterday with the Doppelified girls. Reach into her Soul Gem. Share her despair. Pull her back.”

Mami nodded slowly.

The way Momoko said it made it sound simple — almost comforting.

But Mifuyu stepped in with a gentle shake of her head.

“There is one complication,” she said. “Yesterday, we had Mitama with us. She shared her coordinator abilities with us through Connect. That’s what allowed us to attune to the Soul Gems and reach the girls’ hearts.”

Mami’s shoulders fell slightly.

Of course it wasn’t that simple.

“So... without Mitama,” Mami asked quietly, “there’s no way?”

Mifuyu smiled — a small, hopeful smile — and lifted her Soul Gem into her palm.

“Mitama isn’t here,” she said, “but I still remember the sensation. The feeling of her magic. The way she attuned to a Soul Gem... the way she reached out to a magical girl’s heart.”

She turned to Momoko.

“Maybe we can replicate a fragment of it. Not perfectly — but enough to help Sayaka.”

Momoko scratched the back of her neck, chuckling. “It’ll probably be tricky. Really tricky. But hey — I’m willing to try.”

She nudged Mifuyu with her elbow, grinning. “And if we pull it off, maybe we can help Mitama when we get back to Kamihama. She could use the support.”

Mifuyu laughed softly. “She *did* call you selfish yesterday — in a very affectionate way — for only helping her once after becoming friends.”

Momoko groaned dramatically. “She’ll never let me live that down.”

“But,” Mifuyu continued, her tone turning earnest, “it would be nice... to share her burden someday.”

Then she turned to Mami.

“And assuming Momoko and I can reach Sayaka... this is where *you* come in.”

Mami blinked. “Me?”

She thought for a moment — then her eyes widened.

“You both died because you took too much despair into yourselves... so I could take that negativity from you. Redirect it. Use it — without letting it consume you.”

Momoko snapped her fingers and pointed at her. “Bingo! You really *are* sharp, Mami. Total veteran magical girl vibes.”

Mami laughed softly — a warm, bittersweet sound.

“Yes... I’ve been through many battles. Hard ones. Lonely ones. But they made me who I am today.”

She turned toward Lunaria and Kasumi.

“What do you two think? Will this plan work?”

Kasumi immediately put on an exaggerated thinking pose — hand on chin, eyes narrowed, lips pursed dramatically.

“HMMMMMMMM...”

She hummed loudly, swaying side to side as if weighing the fate of the universe.

“Hmmm... well...” she said slowly, dragging out every syllable. “It *does* make sense...”

She paused.

Then suddenly winked, grinned, and gave a big thumbs-up.

“So it *may* work! Good luck!”

She emphasized *may* with theatrical flair.

Mami, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe all burst into laughter.

Mami sighed, shaking her head with fond exasperation.

“Kasumi... why can’t you ever give a straight answer? I’m trying to save my friend here.”

Kasumi gasped dramatically, hand to her chest. “Straight answers are boring! And besides—”

Lunaria stepped in, smiling warmly.

“What Kasumi means,” she said, “is that there are many times in life when you simply don’t know if something will work. You try. You learn. You adjust. That’s how growth happens.”

She looked at each of them in turn.

“Your plan is thoughtful. It’s brave. And it’s worth attempting. If it doesn’t work, you’ll learn from it and try again.”

Kasumi nodded vigorously.

“Exactly! The journey of life is boring if you already know where you’re going, right?”

Momoko laughed. “That’s... actually kind of profound.”

Mifuyu smiled. “In a very Kasumi way.”

Kuroe nodded shyly. “I... like that.”

Momoko glanced at Kuroe, then at Mifuyu, then at Mami — and her smile softened into something gentler, more thoughtful.

“You know,” Momoko said, “this is... kind of how Lunaria and Kasumi treated *us* too.”

Mami blinked. “Oh?”

Mifuyu stepped forward, folding her hands neatly in front of her. “They don’t give you all the answers. They let you struggle. Let you fall. And when you finally stand up on your own... they’re there. Watching.”

Kuroe nodded, her voice small but steady. “Yesterday in Kamihama... they didn’t intervene at all. Not until the very end.”

Momoko let out a breathy laugh — half disbelief, half fondness. “Yeah. They were basically spectators. Even when everything went wrong.”

Kuroe’s eyes softened with memory. “Even when my Doppel overtook me. Even when I became a witch.”

Mifuyu looked down, fingers curling slightly. “Even when the other Doppelified girls went berserk. Even when Momoko and I were dying as we saved them.”

Mami’s breath caught — but the Kamihama girls weren’t finished.

Kuroe lifted her chin, smiling with quiet pride.

“Because they didn’t step in... Iroha and I Connected. I understood her — and myself — more deeply than ever before.”

Her cheeks flushed.

“I didn’t know someone could understand me like that.”

Mifuyu placed a hand over her heart. “And Momoko and I discovered strength we didn’t know we had. Resolve we didn’t know we were capable of. We stepped up because we *had* to.”

Momoko laughed softly. “Honestly? I didn’t think I had it in me.”

Mifuyu smiled at her. “You did. And so did I.”

The three of them looked at Mami — eyes warm, open, inviting her into their shared experience.

Mami’s expression softened. She let out a quiet, heartfelt laugh.

“Yes. That’s exactly how they taught me too. These past three days... they pushed me into the deep end again and again. It was terrifying sometimes. But—”

She placed a hand over her chest.

“I grew. As a magical girl. And as a person.”

She turned toward Lunaria and Kasumi, a bright, playful smile blooming across her face.

“Alright then. We’ll all work together to save Sayaka. And we’ll bring back good news. Just wait and see.”

Lunaria laughed warmly, her eyes shining with pride. “I believe in you. All of you. Good luck.”

Kasumi crossed her arms, grinning wide. “I like your *cough* confidence *cough*! I’ll be waiting for the *cough* good news *cough*—”

Mami narrowed her eyes. “Kasumi... why are you coughing so much? Is something wrong?”

Kasumi straightened instantly and smiled at Mami with the most innocent expression imaginable.

“Nope! Nothing wrong at all!”

Her eyes sparkled.

Mami sighed, Momoko snorted, Mifuyu covered her mouth to hide a laugh, and Kuroe giggled softly.

Lunaria turned toward Kyoko, her expression soft but purposeful.

“Kyoko,” she said, “can you take it from here? Help Mami, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe with their training?”

Kyoko cracked her knuckles, a sharp grin spreading across her face.

“Leave it to me,” she said. “I’ll whip them into shape.”

Mami blinked, then looked back at Lunaria.

“Where are you going?”

Lunaria exchanged a glance with Kasumi — a silent conversation passing between them — before answering.

“Kasumi and I are heading to Kamihama,” she said. “We plan to speak with Ui.”

Mami’s breath caught.

Kuroe stiffened beside her.

“Ui...?” Mami whispered.

Kuroe’s eyes widened. “Iroha’s sister? The girl she’s been searching for?”

Lunaria nodded.

“Yes. Ui’s soul resides within the small Kyubey. We were able to speak with her briefly—by Connecting with it.”

Mami’s mind flashed back three days.

Banbanzai. Warm food. Laughter. Iroha’s shy smile as she described the strange sense of absence—of someone she felt she should remember.

“So Iroha was right,” Mami murmured. “She really did have a sister.”

Kuroe smiled softly. “She must be so happy...”

Lunaria shook her head, gently. “Ui cannot communicate normally. She became a witch — and her witch’s body was used as the foundation for Embryo Eve, the cornerstone of the Wings of the Magius’ plan.”

Mami gasped.

Kuroe’s hands flew to her chest.

Lunaria continued, more gently now:

“Ui’s soul separated from her witch form. She kept her personality inside the small Kyubey. But she’s been silent. Until we reached her.”

Kasumi folded her arms.

“And with the Wings of the Magius activating their plan in two days, Iroha, Yachiyo, Tsuruno, Sana, Felicia, Mitama, and Rena will want answers. About Ui. About Embryo Eve. About what happened yesterday.”

She beamed. “So we’ll give them some.”

Momoko snorted. “By *some*, you mean half-answers and riddles, right? You two love your secrets.”

Kasumi winked. “We prefer suspense.”

Mifuyu’s expression grew thoughtful—then troubled.

“Lunaria...” she said carefully. “What about us? Our bodies on Earth—what happened to them?”

The mood shifted instantly.

Lunaria answered calmly, but with unmistakable care.

“Kuroe’s human body is gone. Her Doppel overtook it completely, and she later became a witch. When I used dis-connect on her witch, she came here — but her body did not return.”

Kuroe lowered her gaze, but she didn’t flinch. She had suspected as much.

“As for you two,” Lunaria continued, turning to Momoko and Mifuyu, “your bodies remain in Kamihama. Lifeless. Your Soul Gems shattered when you sacrificed yourselves.”

Momoko and Mifuyu froze.

Kuroe’s breath hitched.

“As I told you earlier,” Lunaria said gently, “you are neither alive nor dead. But what you learn here will shape what comes next—for yourselves and for your friends.”

Momoko swallowed hard.

“So... what happens when we go back? Do our souls return to our bodies?”

Kuroe whispered, “And me... would I just appear out of nowhere?”

Mami stepped forward, smiling softly.

“Actually... I’ve already been to Kamihama.”

They stared at her.

“Three days ago,” Mami continued. “Lunaria let me take on an ephemeral form—no Soul Gem, no magical signature. Just... me with the clothes and appearance I chose.”

She smiled at the memory.

“I ran into Iroha, Yachiyo, Tsuruno, Felicia, and Sana at Kamihama High. We watched the talent show. Then ate at Banbanzai—with Kasumi.”

Momoko’s eyes sparkled.

“So we can do that too?”

Mifuyu clasped her hands.

“We could see everyone again...”

Kuroe’s face lit up.

“And help them—with what we learn here.”

Hope rippled through the three of them. Outfits, hairstyles, colors—ephemeral selves already taking shape in their imaginations.

Momoko turned to Kyoko with a bright grin.

“Alright, Kyoko. Lead the way. We’re ready to train.”

Kyoko smirked.

“I like the enthusiasm—but first? Food. I’m starving after fighting Kasumi.”

Mami laughed. “I want to see the dream-realm. And try its food.”

Momoko tilted her head. “Dream-realm?”

Kyoko’s grin widened.

“You’ll see.”

She turned toward Lunaria and Kasumi.

“See you later. Happy adventuring!”

“We’ll train hard,” Mami said with a nod.

“Keep us posted!” Momoko waved energetically.

“Please tell Yachiyo I am well,” Mifuyu said with a bow. “And that I look forward to seeing her again.”

“And Iroha too,” Kuroe added quietly, smiling.

Lunaria smiled warmly. “I will.”

Kasumi saluted with dramatic flair. “Bring back results!”

Lunaria turned to Mami.

“We also plan to visit Mitakihara. We’ll watch over your friends—and let you know how Sayaka is doing.”

Mami’s smile was gentle, resolute.

“Thank you. I just hope she can hold on long enough for us to help her.”

Kyoko turned on her heel.

“Then let’s not waste time.”

She snapped her fingers.

In an instant, Kyoko, Mami, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe vanished.

Kasumi stretched, hands behind her head.

“They’re in for a treat. Kyoko’s basically a legend in the dream-realm—especially when it comes to food.”

Lunaria chuckled. “Yes. Let’s be on our way.”

Kasumi nodded.

And with a shimmer of light, the two of them disappeared as well.

Chapter 6: Lunaria and Kasumi in Kamihama

A soft breeze drifted through Kamihama as Lunaria and Kasumi appeared on the quiet street outside Mitama Yakumo's residence. The early afternoon sun cast warm light across the wooden sign hanging by the door:

Mitama Yakumo — Magical Girl Coordinator

From inside, faint voices carried through the walls — familiar ones.

“...so Ui really is inside the small Kyubey...”

“...and Embryo Eve is her witch's body...”

“...Yachiyo, your ability — inheriting the hopes of magical girls who trusted you...”

“...Momoko and Mifuyu placed their hopes in you before they—”

“...if Connect can reach the dead, maybe you can speak to them again...”

Lunaria and Kasumi exchanged a glance — a quiet, shared smile.

The girls were pushing forward.

Together.

Even after everything.

Kasumi slid the door open.

The stained-glass light washed over them as they stepped inside—blues, silvers, and soft violets dancing across the polished wooden floor. The air carried a delicate blend of tea leaves, incense, and something floral, unmistakably Mitama's signature scent.

The room unfolded around them in a surreal harmony of elegance and comfort. A massive stained-glass window dominated the far wall, casting shifting patterns that moved like living brushstrokes. Tall columns rose on either side, lending the space the quiet reverence of a cathedral. Cushions and sofas were arranged around a low table, inviting conversation or contemplation. Shelves lined the walls, each one carefully curated with bottles, charms, books, and strange magical tools—every item placed with Mitama's meticulous touch. Near the adjustment circle, a soft haze shimmered in the air, as if magic itself had settled there to rest.

It felt like stepping into a dream—one that didn't just enchant, but embraced them.

Iroha, Yachiyo, and Mitama all turned towards the footsteps.

Iroha's eyes widened, hope blooming across her face.

“Lunaria! Kasumi! You're here—!”

The small Kyubey at her feet wagged its tail rapidly, hopping in place.

“Kyu! Kyu!”

Ui was clearly thrilled.

Yachiyo's expression softened — warm, open, almost gentle.

“...Welcome,” she said. “We were hoping you'd come.”

Mitama clasped her hands together, eyes sparkling with curiosity and relief.

“Oh, perfect timing,” she chimed. “We were just talking about you two. And about yesterday. And about all the things you didn't explain.”

Her smile was sweet — but her eyes were sharp.

Kasumi leaned toward Lunaria and whispered, “She's in interrogation mode.”

Lunaria replied just as quietly, “So it would seem.”

Mitama stepped forward, her expression shifting — curiosity giving way to sincerity.

“Kasumi,” she said, “Rena and I... we're confused. In my tent realm, it looked like you saved Momoko and Mifuyu. They were fading — and then you pulled them back.”

Her voice wavered slightly.

“But when we returned... their bodies were still there. Lifeless. Still holding hands. Their Soul Gems shattered... What did you do to them?”

Yachiyo turned her gaze to Lunaria.

“And Kuroe,” she said. “You spoke to Ichizo. You used something called *dis-connect*.”

Her voice lowered.

“When we returned, there was no trace of her. No body. No witch.”

Iroha's hands clenched in front of her. She swallowed hard.

“Where is she? Is she... safe?”

The small Kyubey pressed against Lunaria's leg, tail wagging anxiously.

Kasumi lifted both hands immediately, laughing.

“Whoa, whoa — that's a lot of questions all at once.”

She grinned, unfazed.

“But before we start handing out answers,” she said brightly, “Lunaria and I want to talk with Ui first.”

Iroha froze.

“...Talk with Ui? Now?”

Kasumi nodded and tapped her cheek thoughtfully.

“We want to hear her story directly. What happened to her. How she became a witch. And how all of that ties into the Wings of the Magius’ plan.”

Her smile sharpened just a little.

“Especially since that plan activates in two days.”

Kasumi winked.

“That should answer *some* of your questions, no?”

Yachiyo nodded, calm but hopeful.

“That would be very helpful.”

Mitama exhaled, crossing her arms.

“I was hoping for answers about *you*,” she said dryly. Then she smiled. “But I suppose I should be grateful you’re offering even that much.”

Her tone was teasing — but her eyes were warm.

“Would you like tea?” she asked. “We were just about to brew a fresh pot.”

Lunaria inclined her head. “We would be honored.”

Kasumi stretched her arms behind her head. “Tea sounds perfect.”

Mitama gestured toward the sitting area, where cushions and sofas waited beneath the stained-glass glow.

“Then come in,” she said. “We have a lot to talk about.”

And as Lunaria and Kasumi stepped deeper into the room, the small Kyubey bounded after them — tail wagging, eyes bright — as if welcoming them home.

Mitama moved gracefully through her cozy, dreamlike residence, the stained-glass window casting ripples of blue and silver across the room as she prepared tea. Porcelain chimed softly as she worked, the air filling with the faint, soothing scent of herbs and incense.

Kasumi watched her with an easy grin.

“It’s really nice seeing you two like this,” she said lightly. “Yachiyo and Mitama, working together. Looks like you’ve put the past behind you. Happy times ahead, huh?”

Yachiyo and Mitama exchanged a glance — warm, knowing, unguarded. The kind of look that only forms after long-held misunderstandings finally loosen their grip.

Yachiyo gave a quiet chuckle. “We reached a mutual understanding yesterday. We realized we’re... more alike than we ever admitted.”

Mitama nodded, her smile gentle but honest. “We both wore masks. Mine was apathy — pretending not to care so I wouldn’t break while adjusting Soul Gems.” She glanced at Yachiyo. “And yours was distance. Pushing others away because you believed your wish doomed them to die in your place.”

Yachiyo lowered her gaze, but her voice remained steady. “We were protecting ourselves.” She exhaled. “But now, we’re trying to open up. To trust. To build something real.”

Mitama carried the tea over, setting the cups down before Lunaria and Kasumi.

“Please,” she said softly. “Enjoy.”

The tea glowed a clear amber beneath the stained glass. Lunaria and Kasumi lifted their cups, inhaling its scent — floral, warm, quietly uplifting.

They took a sip.

It was gentle. Comforting. Like hope, distilled.

Lunaria smiled. “Tea reflects the soul of the one who prepares it.”

Kasumi leaned closer, eyes sparkling. “Which means... Mitama’s soul feels lighter now. Clearer. Happier. Hopeful about the future. Right?”

Mitama’s breath caught. She pressed a hand lightly to her chest.

“That’s... beautifully said,” she whispered. “I did prepare it with more joy than usual. More purpose.” She laughed softly. “And you could tell... just by tasting it?”

Kasumi winked. “Of course. And that hope will show up in your work. Your future adjustments, your attunements — you’ll do things you never thought possible.”

Mitama’s cheeks warmed. “Thank you, Kasumi.”

She glanced at Yachiyo. “Perhaps I’ll even discover a few latent abilities of my own.”

Yachiyo smiled. “I hope you do. For all the magical girls in Kamihama.”

At that moment, the small Kyubey hopped off Iroha’s lap and padded toward Lunaria and Kasumi, tail wagging eagerly.

Lunaria chuckled. “You’re welcome to join us too.”

She turned back to Iroha, her expression kind. “You’d like to see Ui again, wouldn’t you?”

Iroha froze.

“...See Ui?” she whispered. “Is that... really possible?”

Lunaria nodded. “Yes.”

She glanced around the room. “Everyone, please. Let’s sit in a circle.”

They gathered on the cushions beneath the stained glass — Lunaria, Kasumi, Iroha, Yachiyo, Mitama — with the small Kyubey at the center.

Lunaria spoke gently.

“Yesterday, Kasumi and I were able to speak with Ui. When we placed our hands on the small Kyubey... we Connected. We reached her.”

Iroha’s breath hitched.

Yachiyo’s eyes widened.

Iroha leaned forward, stunned. “I didn’t know Connect could do that.”

“Most magical girls use it for combat,” Mitama added. “Or large-scale support — like saving the Doppelified girls.”

Lunaria smiled softly. “Those are applications born of necessity. But Connect, at its core, is about listening. Attuning yourself to life. Opening your heart to another.”

She extended her hand toward Iroha.

“Shall we?”

Iroha’s eyes shimmered. She placed her hand in Lunaria’s without hesitation.

One by one, the others followed — Yachiyo, Mitama, Kasumi — until they formed a complete circle, hands linked, hearts aligned.

Lunaria and Kasumi exchanged a final nod.

Then they reached toward Ui — the small Kyubey — gently resting their free hands against her soft fur.

They closed their eyes.

Warm light bloomed at the center of the circle — faint at first, then growing brighter, wrapping around them like an embrace.

It felt like warmth.

Like memory.

Like a heartbeat calling from far away.

And then—

Everything dissolved into light.

Warm light faded.

When they opened their eyes, the stained-glass glow was gone.

They were standing in a quiet hospital room.

White curtains stirred faintly in a breeze that shouldn't have existed.

Monitors sat beside the beds, dark and silent, their steady beeping long since stilled.

A small table rested near the window, its surface cluttered with children's drawings — bright crayon suns, stick figures holding hands, messy hearts colored too hard.

Three beds lined the wall.

One was neatly made, untouched.

One was slightly messy, its sheets wrinkled as if someone had only just stood up.

And the third had a small stuffed animal resting on the pillow, carefully placed.

Mitama blinked, disoriented.

"...Where are we?"

Yachiyo slowly scanned the room, her brows knitting together.

"This is... a hospital room."

Before she could say more, she noticed Iroha.

Iroha was trembling.

Her hands were clenched tight against her chest, breath coming shallow and uneven. Her eyes darted across the room, recognition crashing into her all at once — fear, longing, grief, and something dangerously close to hope.

"Iroha?" Mitama stepped toward her, voice gentle. "What's wrong?"

Yachiyo placed a steadying hand on Iroha's shoulder.

"Iroha. Talk to us."

Iroha's lips parted, but only a whisper emerged — thin, fragile.

"This... this is..."

Memories surged.

Fragments she had chased for months.

A young girl's laugh.

A presence she *knew* belonged beside her.

Visions that slipped away like mist the moment she tried to grasp them.

A missing piece of her heart.

A hollow space she could never explain.

And then—

A bright, cheerful voice rang out behind them.

"Hello, big sis!"

The room froze.

Slowly — terrified and hopeful all at once — Iroha turned around.

Mitama and Yachiyo turned with her.

Standing in the center of the room was a young girl with soft pink hair, bright eyes, and a smile overflowing with life.

Ui.

Whole.

Smiling.

Looking directly at her.

Iroha shattered.

“Ui—!”

She ran forward, tears spilling freely as she threw her arms around her sister, clinging to her as if afraid she might vanish if she let go.

“I missed you,” she sobbed. “I missed you so much...”

Ui wrapped her arms around Iroha just as tightly, pressing her cheek against her shoulder.

“I missed you too, big sis. Every single day. I wanted to talk to you so badly.”

Iroha pulled back just enough to see her face, hands trembling as she held Ui’s shoulders.

“I’ve been looking everywhere for you,” she whispered. “I kept seeing you in visions... memories I couldn’t reach. It felt like something was missing from my life. Like there was a hole in my heart.”

Ui smiled gently and brushed away Iroha’s tears.

“You never forgot me,” she said softly. “Not really.”

Iroha let out a trembling laugh through her tears.

“And to think... the small Kyubey who kept showing up to help us... that was you the whole time.”

Ui beamed.

“Yup! That was me.”

She glanced past Iroha, her gaze settling on Yachiyo and Mitama, warm and sincere.

“I watched all of you. I’m really glad Iroha has friends who care about her so much.”

Yachiyo’s expression softened, something tight in her chest finally easing.

Mitama smiled, eyes shimmering.

Ui turned back to Iroha.

“So even though we were apart... we were never really far from each other. I just couldn’t talk to anyone normally in that form.”

She winked lightly.

“Until now.”

Then she faced Lunaria and Kasumi, who had remained quietly to the side, giving the sisters space.

Ui bowed her head deeply.

“Thank you. For giving us this chance to see each other again.”

Iroha bowed as well, her voice thick with emotion.

“Thank you... truly... from the bottom of my heart.”

Kasumi planted her hands on her hips, grinning.

“Hey, no problem! You two look *way too cute* together to keep you apart.”

Lunaria smiled warmly.

“Ui... is now a good time to share your past? What happened to you — and how it connects to the Wings of the Magius?”

Ui nodded eagerly.

“Yes. I’ve waited a long time to tell someone. But it’s a long story... so everyone should get comfortable.”

She squeezed Iroha’s hands and guided her toward one of the beds — Ui’s old bed — and they sat down side by side.

Yachiyo and Mitama settled onto the nearby sofa.

Kasumi and Lunaria took seats at the small table — the same one Ui, Touka, and Nemu once used for games and crafts.

The room felt full.

Filled with memory, warmth, and truths that had waited far too long to be spoken.

Ui took a slow breath, looking around the room one last time.

Then she smiled — soft, bittersweet, and brave.

“Alright,” she said quietly.

“Let me show you everything.”

Soft sparkles of light drifted into existence around the hospital room — tiny motes like fireflies, shimmering with pale gold and rose-pink hues. They floated gently through the air, warm and weightless, as if carried by breath itself.

Iroha, Yachiyo, and Mitama gasped.

Mitama reached out instinctively, letting a cluster of sparkles brush across her palm. They passed straight through her skin like mist, scattering into smaller glimmers.

“It’s beautiful...” she whispered.

Iroha and Yachiyo reached out as well, breath catching as the sparkles swirled around their fingers.

The motes gathered — three currents of light spiraling into place: one near the window, one at the foot of the beds, one beside the small table. Each cluster brightened, spinning faster and faster until shapes emerged.

Three figures.

Three memories.

Hologram-Ui.

Touka.

Nemu.

A low hum filled the air — not a sound, but a sensation, like the echo of a thought remembered after a long time.

Touka appeared first.

She stood beside a crude toy train assembled from scrap parts and wires, her hands raised dramatically as she focused. The train jolted forward, lurched sideways, then spun in an unsteady circle.

Hologram-Ui clapped, eyes shining.

“Wow, Touka! You’re really moving it without touching it!”

Touka puffed out her chest. “Ufufu~ Naturally! This is my newest invention — a locomotive powered entirely by intent! No fuel, no batteries!”

The train suddenly zipped toward Touka and began circling her like a playful animal. She shrieked in laughter and darted around the room, the train wobbling after her.

“Hey! That’s not what I told you to do!”

“Let me try!” Hologram-Ui giggled.

Nemu sat nearby with a notebook resting on her knees, pen scratching quietly. She watched the two of them with a rare, gentle smile — one reserved only for moments like this — jotting down ideas inspired by their play. Ideas about invention. About stories. About futures that might exist beyond hospital walls.

Ui’s voice layered softly over the scene.

“I was born sick. So I lived here... in this room. This room... with Touka and Nemu... this was my whole world.”

She smiled, small and fond.

“It wasn’t big. It wasn’t free. But... I was happy.”

A chime rang.

The doorbell.

All three girls froze — then lit up.

“She’s here!” Touka shouted.

“Open it!” Nemu urged, already scrambling to her feet.

They rushed to the door and flung it open.

Hologram-Iroha stood there, smiling warmly, a bag slung over her shoulder.

“I brought lunch,” she said.

The girls practically dragged her inside.

At the small table — the very one Lunaria and Kasumi now sat at — Hologram-Iroha unpacked four bento boxes. Steam curled gently into the air.

Hologram-Ui, Touka, and Nemu’s eyes sparkled as they opened their boxes, delighted by the homemade meals.

They ate together, laughing, talking over one another, sharing stories about school, inventions, and imaginary adventures.

Ui’s narration softened.

“We waited for those visits more than anything. Iroha always brought food she made herself. Even when she was tired... even when she was busy.”

Iroha’s real self covered her mouth. Tears welled up.

“I remember this,” she whispered. “I remember how happy we were...”

The room dimmed.

The sparkles dulled.

Night fell.

The memory shifted.

Hologram-Ui lay in her bed, an oxygen mask covering her face. Tubes ran from her arms. Her breaths were shallow, uneven. Machines beeped — not steadily, but uncertainly.

Doctors and nurses spoke in hushed urgency.

Touka and Nemu stood near the wall, hands clenched tight, fear written plainly across their faces.

The door burst open.

“Ui!”

Hologram-Iroha rushed in with their parents.

They froze at the bedside.

Hologram-Ui looked impossibly small.

Too pale.

Too still.

The doctor spoke quietly.

“She’ll likely survive this episode. But her condition is worsening. We don’t know how much longer she has.”

Their mother collapsed into tears.

Their father held her, shaking.

Hologram-Iroha trembled — fists clenched, teeth grinding in helpless rage.

Hologram-Ui opened her eyes just a sliver.

She saw her family crying.

Saw Touka and Nemu watching from the corner.

Saw the pain she caused just by existing.

A tear slipped down her cheek.

She hated this.

Hated hurting them.

Hated being the reason they suffered.

Her eyes closed again.

Ui’s voice returned — quiet, fragile.

“It wasn’t always happy. I kept getting worse. Everyone had to watch me fight... again and again.”

Yachiyo’s hands tightened in her lap.

Mitama swallowed hard.

Iroha stared, breath trembling.

She wasn’t just watching anymore.

She was *inside it*.

Her Hologram’s emotions were bleeding into her.

The fear.

The desperation.

The unbearable thought of losing her sister.

“I...” Iroha whispered. “I think I remember now... my wish...”

The hospital room brightened once more as the memory shifted.

Morning sunlight spilled through the window, washing the floor in soft gold. The drifting sparkles rearranged themselves, reshaping the scene.

Hologram-Ui, Touka, and Nemu now sat together at the small table.

A large map of Kamihama City lay spread before them, nearly buried beneath colorful stickers, scraps of paper, and hastily scribbled notes.

Hologram-Ui leaned forward, eyes shining, and pressed a bright star-shaped sticker onto the map.

“I want to go here someday,” she said, eyes shining. “The amusement park! The rides look so fun on TV... the ferris wheel, the roller coasters...”

Her fingers lingered on the star.

“I want to go with all of you. And with my family.”

Her smile wavered.

“But... at this rate...”

She lowered her gaze.

“I probably won’t be able to.”

Touka and Nemu fell silent.

Nemu was the first to move. She reached out and placed a small theater-mask sticker nearby.

“Then perhaps something gentler,” she said carefully. “A play. We could attend one together. When you’re feeling better.”

Hologram-Ui’s face brightened immediately.

“A play...!” She clasped her hands. “That’s a wonderful idea! I loved the one you wrote about us, Nemu.”

She giggled. “What if we saw it in a real theater? Or—or maybe we could even perform in it!”

Touka burst out laughing.

“If that happens, I demand a rewrite. I *still* can’t believe what you did to me in that story!”

Nemu sniffed, lifting her chin with dignified offense.

“My narrative was filled with tension, meaning, and sacrifice. I refuse to change it.”

Touka crossed her arms dramatically.

“I would *never* make such foolish choices. I’m far too brilliant.”

“It was not foolish,” Nemu replied coolly. “It was narratively essential.”

“It was tragic and out of character!”

“It was *art*.”

They leaned toward each other, voices rising — sharp, familiar, perfectly synchronized.

Behind her hands, Hologram-Ui giggled.

Both girls froze and turned on her at once.

“What’s so funny?” they demanded in unison.

Ui waved apologetically, still smiling.

“Sorry! It’s just... you two always argue about silly things. But you always make up right after.”

She tilted her head.

“That’s how I know you’re really close friends.”

Touka and Nemu opened their mouths to object.

Then paused.

They exchanged a glance.

And suddenly — all three burst into laughter.

Nemu wiped at her eyes. “Speaking of arguments... Touka, where was that place we had our worst fight?”

Touka snorted and slapped a sticker onto the map.

“Right here. And it was absolutely *your* fault.”

Nemu gasped. “*My* fault—?!”

They glared again — but this time, the tension was playful, affectionate.

Hologram-Ui smiled, content.

The doorbell chimed.

All three girls lit up instantly.

“She’s here!” Touka shouted.

They rushed to the door and flung it open.

Hologram-Iroha stood there, smiling warmly, a bag of homemade food in her hands.

“Good afternoon,” she said. “I brought lunch.”

They barely gave her time to step inside before pulling her toward the table, talking over one another.

Hologram-Iroha blinked as she took in the map, now crowded with color and dreams.

“What’s all this?” she asked.

Nemu straightened proudly.

“We’re creating and spreading rumors.”

Touka nodded enthusiastically.

“Uwasa. About places in Kamihama.”

“Based on our memories,” Nemu added.

“And our dreams,” Touka finished.

Hologram-Ui looked up at her sister.

Her smile was gentle — and unbearably fragile.

“We thought...” she said quietly,

“If we made rumors about places in Kamihama... then even after we’re gone...”

Her fingers tightened on the table.

“...you’d remember us whenever you visited them.”

The room fell silent.

Real Iroha’s breath caught painfully in her chest.

Across the memory, Hologram-Iroha’s eyes widened, tears welling — grief and understanding crashing into her at once.

The image of Ui struggling to breathe the night before still haunted her.

She wanted to deny it.

To refuse the implication entirely.

But she couldn’t.

She knew Ui didn’t have much time left.

Hologram-Iroha clenched her fists — then forced a smile. It trembled, but it held.

“Then...” she said softly,

“Let me make one too.”

The three girls stared at her.

“A rumor,” Iroha continued, voice steady despite the tears,

“that one day... four girls will reunite beneath a sakura tree.”

She placed a flower sticker on the map and closed her eyes.

“A tree whose flowers bloom beautifully... and never fall.”

Hologram-Ui gasped.

Touka’s breath caught.

Nemu’s lips parted in awe.

Slowly — brightly — all three smiled, radiant and hopeful.

They held out their pinkies.

“Then it’s a promise,” they said together.

Hologram-Iroha smiled through her tears.

“Yes. A promise.”

Four pinkies linked above the map —
four small hands,
four intertwined hopes,
four hearts refusing to let go.

The memory shimmered with warmth.

And somewhere deep within it,
a sakura tree — one that would never shed its blossoms — quietly took root.

The memory of the pinky promise dissolved into drifting sparkles, leaving the hospital room quiet once more.

Yachiyo exhaled slowly, her eyes wide — not with fear, but with dawning understanding.

“So this...” she murmured, voice low.

“This is where the Uwasa began.”

She clenched her fist at her side.

“All the rumors scattered across Kamihama... the ones I’ve been tracking for months... they started here.”

Mitama nodded slowly, still struggling to process it.

“They weren’t weapons,” she said softly.

“They were memories. Dreams. A way for Ui, Touka, and Nemu to leave something behind.”

Her voice trembled.

“How did something so gentle... so pure... become something that harms people?”

Iroha turned toward Ui, her expression fragile — shaken, but searching.

“I... I couldn’t remember my wish,” she said quietly.

“And when I asked Kyubey, he didn’t know either. He said that wasn’t normal — that something big must have happened for both of us to forget.”

Her hands tightened together.

“Ui...”

She hesitated, then asked the question that had haunted her for months.

“Was my wish... to cure you? So you could live a normal, happy life?”

Ui looked at her sister — and her expression was heartbreakingly tender.

“Yes,” she whispered.

“You saw me near death. You saw how Touka, Nemu, and I were already preparing for the end... making rumors so you’d remember us.”

She reached out and gently squeezed Iroha’s hands.

“You wanted to make our promise real,” Ui continued.

“You wanted all of us to go outside together... to stand beneath a sakura tree that never loses its blossoms.”

Iroha’s breath hitched.

Ui lowered her gaze.

“But your wish... was the beginning of everything.”

Her voice was soft — not accusing, not bitter — simply honest.

“It’s how I became a magical girl.

How I became a witch.

How the Wings of the Magius were born.

And how the Uwasa changed — from memories... into tools.”

Mitama’s hand flew to her mouth.

Yachiyo’s eyes widened, horror dawning in full.

Iroha shook her head, trembling.

“My wish... caused all of that?”

Ui looked up at her quickly.

“Yes,” she said softly.

“But it wasn’t your fault.”

She squeezed Iroha’s hands tighter.

“You wished out of love. But... wishes always carry consequences. Even when they’re kind.”

Silence settled over the room.

Then Lunaria spoke — her voice quiet, but weighted with experience.

“We’ve seen this many times,” she said.

“Magical girls who wish for someone they love... only to watch that wish twist in ways they never imagined.”

Kasumi crossed her arms, her usual brightness muted.

“Most wishes are made in moments of emotion,” she added.

“Sadness. Rage. Hatred. Joy. Pleasure. Love. Without thinking ahead.”

She looked away.

“And too often... the people they wished for end up paying the price.”

Both of them fell silent.

Their expressions softened — shadows passing behind their eyes.

They thought of Kyoko.

Of Homura.

Of countless others they had encountered across different times and places.

And finally—

Of ***Hoshine***.

A memory neither of them voiced aloud.

A wound that still ached.

Mitama, Yachiyo, Iroha, and Ui all noticed the shift — the distant sorrow lingering in Lunaria and Kasumi’s eyes.

They exchanged glances.

What have they seen?

What kind of tragedies follow them?

What stories are they carrying... that they never speak of?

Ui nodded slowly.

“Lunaria and Kasumi are right,” she said.

“Wishes born from love can still lead to pain.”

She turned toward the drifting sparkles, her expression solemn.

“And now... I’ll show you what happened next.”

The sparkles brightened, swirling faster, gathering into a new shape.

The air grew heavy — as if the room itself sensed what was coming.

Ui’s voice softened.

“This... is the moment everything changed.”

The light flared.

And the next memory began to form.

Chapter 6b: Turning Point

The sparkles flared brighter, swirling and reshaping into a new scene.

It was late morning.

Hologram-Ui sat upright on her hospital bed as doctors and nurses moved briskly around her — checking monitors, reviewing charts, whispering urgently to one another.

Then—

A clipboard slipped from a nurse's hands and clattered to the floor.

Another doctor froze mid-step.

A third stared at the results in his hands, lips parted in disbelief.

Hologram-Ui blinked, tilting her head.

“Um... is something wrong?” she asked softly.

“Why are you all looking at me like that?”

The head doctor swallowed.

“This is...” He hesitated, then shook his head in disbelief.

“...impossible.”

He looked at her again — not as a patient, but as a miracle.

“Ui,” he said, voice trembling, “your illness is gone. Completely. You're cured.”

The words didn't register at first.

Hologram-Ui's breath caught.

Her eyes widened.

Her mouth fell open.

She sat perfectly still.

Touka and Nemu stared at her, equally frozen.

Certain it had to be another dream — another cruel trick of hope — Hologram-Ui reached up and pinched her cheek.

“Ow!”

She gasped.

“It's... real?”

Then the weight of it hit her all at once.

She collapsed back onto the bed, hands covering her face as tears streamed down her cheeks.

“I’m cured...” she sobbed.

“I’m really cured...!”

The doctors and nurses exchanged soft smiles, eyes shining.

“We’ll keep you a little longer for observation,” one said gently.

“But yes. You’ll be able to live a normal life soon.”

He hesitated, then added warmly:

“You should call your family. Tell them the good news.”

They left the room quietly, giving her space.

Touka and Nemu rushed to her side immediately, throwing their arms around her.

“Ui!!”

“This is incredible!”

“We’re so happy for you!”

Hologram-Ui hugged them tightly, laughing and crying at the same time.

“Thank you... both of you,” she said breathlessly.

“I promise — even after I leave, I’ll come visit all the time.”

Touka and Nemu beamed.

With trembling hands, Hologram-Ui grabbed her phone and dialed home.

Her father answered almost immediately.

“Ui? Good morning. Are you feeling alright? Did something happen?”

She looked at Touka and Nemu. They nodded eagerly.

“Dad...” she said softly.

“The doctors said I’m cured. I can come home soon.”

There was a loud clatter on the other end of the line.

“...Dad?”

“Dad?!”

Touka snorted. “He definitely dropped the phone.”

Nemu chuckled. “Let’s see how he responds.”

After a moment of scrambling, her father’s voice returned — shaking.

“U-Ui... say that again. Please.”

“I’m cured,” she said, smiling through tears.
“It’s real.”

A sound escaped him — half laugh, half sob.

“Honey!” he shouted, voice cracking.
“Come here! You won’t believe this!”

Ui giggled softly. She hadn’t heard that kind of energy from him in years.

A faint voice answered a few moments later.

“What is it? Why are you yelling? Did we win the lottery?”

“Better than the lottery!” her father cried.
“Ui is cured! She’s coming home!”

Another clatter.

Then her mother’s voice, suddenly close and breathless.

“Ui? Sweetheart? Is it true? Are you really coming home?”

“Yes,” Hologram-Ui whispered, voice trembling with joy.
“It’s true.”

Her mother broke down sobbing, joy spilling through the line.

“This is a miracle... I can’t believe it...”

Then both parents shouted at once:

“Iroha! Come here!”

Hologram-Ui’s heart fluttered.

Footsteps approached.

Then—

“What’s going on?” Hologram-Iroha asked, confused.
“Why are you both yelling?”

The phone changed hands.

“Hello?”

“Hi, big sis!” Hologram-Ui chirped.

There was a sharp inhale.

“...Ui,” Hologram-Iroha said slowly.
“Are you... cured?”

“Yes!” Ui said brightly.

“I’ll be able to live with you again! We can see each other every day!”

So it’s real, Hologram-Iroha thought.

Kyubey... really granted my wish.

Silence.

Hologram-Ui waited — expecting tears, disbelief, laughter.

Instead—

“That’s wonderful,” Hologram-Iroha said at last.

“I’m really happy for you.”

Her tone was gentle.

Too gentle.

Ui felt something tug at her chest.

No shock.

No frantic questions.

No disbelief.

It sounded like... she already knew.

Hologram-Ui shook the thought away.

“Why don’t you all come visit me now?” she said brightly.

“We can go out for lunch — there’s this restaurant I saw on TV!”

She turned to Touka and Nemu.

“You should come too!”

They cheered.

On the phone, her parents excitedly asked Iroha if she was free.

There was a pause.

“That sounds wonderful,” Hologram-Iroha said carefully.

“But... I have something important to do right now. Can we celebrate tonight instead? Dinner?”

Hologram-Ui blinked — then smiled.

“Dinner sounds perfect!”

“I’ll see you tonight,” Iroha said.

“Take care, dear.”

“We love you!”

The call ended.

Hologram-Ui turned to Touka and Nemu.

“What did you think of my sister’s reaction?”

Touka crossed her arms. “It was... calm.”

Nemu nodded. “Suspiciously calm.”

Ui sighed softly. “I thought so too. Something feels... off.”

Touka laughed. “We’re probably just overthinking.”

Nemu adjusted her notebook. “Let’s see how she acts tonight. Some people don’t react until they see things in person.”

Hologram-Ui giggled.

“Yeah... maybe you’re right.”

The three girls returned to their games and chatter, the room filled with warmth and laughter.

A fragile hope.

One that would soon twist into something else entirely.

The sparkles shifted again, soft light folding into a new scene.

It was early evening.

Warm orange sunlight poured through the hospital window, casting long shadows across the floor. Near the door stood Hologram-Ui, Touka, and Nemu, dressed neatly for the occasion.

Hologram-Ui wore a pastel dress with a ribbon tied at the waist, light and cheerful.

Touka sported a stylish jacket and skirt, clearly pleased with her appearance.

Nemu wore something simple and elegant, her small notebook tucked beneath her arm as always.

All three of them practically vibrated with excitement.

Nemu adjusted her glasses. “Ui, have you decided where we’re going?”

Hologram-Ui beamed and rummaged through a toy box, pulling out a pair of plastic spatulas.

“Yes! That teppanyaki restaurant I saw on TV! The chefs do tricks while they cook — it’s like a show *and* dinner!”

She attempted to twirl the toy utensils like the chefs she’d seen.

They flew out of her hands immediately.

Clatter.

Clatter.

Touka burst into laughter. “Let’s hope the real chef is better than you.”

Nemu smirked. “Otherwise, one of us may not survive the meal.”

Hologram-Ui winked. “Well, at least we already made rumors for Iroha to remember us by, right?”

The three girls laughed — bright and strange and a little unreal.

Just that morning, Ui had been afraid she might die at any moment.

Now she was joking about it.

Hope made everything feel lighter.

Then—

Ding-dong.

The doorbell rang.

All three girls squealed and rushed to the door.

Hologram-Ui flung it open.

Her parents stood there — breathless, smiling, eyes already shimmering with emotion.

“Mom! Dad!” Hologram-Ui cried, throwing herself into their arms.

“Ui, sweetheart!”

“It’s so good to see you!”

They hugged her tightly, almost lifting her off the ground.

Touka and Nemu bowed politely, greeting them with warm smiles.

Ui’s parents stepped back, really looking at her — and both of them broke into tears.

“You look so healthy,” her mother whispered.

“So full of life,” her father added.

“We can’t wait to bring you home. We’ll get your room ready right away.”

Hologram-Ui giggled. “I want my room filled with pictures — of everything I experienced here. And all the memories we’ll make together!”

Laughter filled the room.

But then Hologram-Ui paused.

“Where’s Iroha?”

Touka and Nemu exchanged a glance. They had been wondering the same thing.

Her parents sighed gently.

“She said she had something important to do,” her father said.

“But she’ll meet us at the restaurant. She’s taking the train.”

The three girls froze.

Again?

First the strangely calm reaction.

Now she wasn’t here to go with them?

Touka whispered, “This is weird.”

Nemu nodded. “Very weird.”

Hologram-Ui bit her lip.

Something important?

What could possibly be more important than this?

Their suspicions grew.

Ui’s mother clapped her hands lightly. “Shall we get going? Where would you like to eat, Ui?”

Hologram-Ui pushed the feeling aside and smiled brightly.

“The teppanyaki restaurant! The one where the chefs perform while they cook!”

Her parents’ faces lit up.

“Oh, that place!” her mother said.

“We’ve never been, but it looked so fun,” her father added. “We’ve always wanted to try it.”

“Then let’s go,” her mother said warmly.

Hologram-Ui walked ahead with her parents, chattering excitedly about the food, the show, and all the things she wanted to do once she was home.

Touka and Nemu lingered behind for a moment.

“Do you think we’re overthinking this?” Touka whispered.

Nemu tapped her notebook thoughtfully. “Possibly. She might have schoolwork. Or plans with friends.”

Touka let out a slow breath, shoulders loosening.

“Yeah... maybe. Let’s stop overanalyzing and just enjoy today.”

Nemu’s expression softened into a small, genuine smile.

“Agreed. Ui deserves a happy evening. Shall we?”

They walked after Hologram-Ui and her parents, their steps lightening as they caught up.

Laughter echoed down the hallway — warm, bright, and full of hope.

A fleeting, precious sound.

The sparkles shifted once more, folding into a new memory.

It was early evening outside the teppanyaki restaurant. Lanterns glowed softly along the entrance, and a warm breeze carried the scent of grilled food and soy sauce. Laughter and conversation drifted from inside, blending with the hum of the city.

Hologram-Ui stood near the doorway with her parents, Touka, and Nemu, excitement buzzing in the air.

“Iroha should be here any minute,” her father said, scanning the street.

As if on cue—

“There she is,” Nemu said, pointing.

They turned.

Hologram-Iroha was approaching from down the street. She walked quickly, but something in her posture was off — her steps stiff, her shoulders tense, as if her body hadn’t fully caught up with her will.

Hologram-Ui’s face lit up.

“Big sis!”

She ran toward her, full of energy and life.

Hologram-Iroha’s breath caught.

She’s really cured, she thought. She wouldn’t be able to run like that otherwise.

Hologram-Ui threw her arms around her, hugging her tightly.

“Iroha!”

Hologram-Iroha returned the embrace, holding on just a second longer than usual.

“It’s so good to see you like this,” she said softly. “Outside the hospital... running around... you really are cured.”

Ui nodded enthusiastically. “I feel amazing! Better than ever! I have so much energy now — I can finally live normally. There’s so much I want to do!”

Hologram-Iroha smiled and took her sister’s hand. “Shall we?”

“Yes!”

They turned back toward the others — and Hologram-Ui’s smile faltered, just for a moment.

Iroha's hand was trembling.

Her grip was weaker than usual.

And her breathing was shallow, uneven — like she'd been running from something far more frightening than distance.

Hologram-Ui said nothing. She tucked the observations away, hoping food and laughter would help her sister relax.

"Iroha!" Touka and Nemu shouted as they rushed over, hugging her.

"Touka. Nemu," Hologram-Iroha laughed, hugging them back.

Ui's parents smiled warmly. "So," her mother asked gently, "how did your important task go?"

"It went well," Hologram-Iroha replied with a practiced smile. "I'm ready to eat and have fun with everyone."

Inside, her thoughts churned.

Act normal.

Don't let them worry.

Don't tell them what you fought.

Don't drag them into this world.

Before she could steady herself, Hologram-Ui, Touka, and Nemu grabbed her arms.

"Come on!"

"Hurry, Iroha!"

"We're starving!"

She let out a startled laugh as they pulled her inside.

Her parents followed, smiling — hearts full at the sight of their daughters and their friends laughing together, just as they had always hoped.

A cheerful hostess greeted them and led them to a private room. The space was beautiful — wooden panels, soft lighting, traditional décor, and a polished iron grill at the center.

They took their seats:

Hologram-Ui in the middle, Hologram-Iroha beside her.

Nemu and Touka on Hologram-Ui's other side.

Her parents next to Hologram-Iroha.

Hologram-Ui, Nemu, and Touka ordered sweet drinks.

Hologram-Iroha asked for tea.

Her parents ordered sake to share.

The chef entered with a flourish — energetic, smiling, full of theatrical charm.

“Good evening, everyone! I’ll be preparing your special multi-course meal tonight!”

Hologram-Ui, Nemu, and Touka greeted her with matching enthusiasm.

Hologram-Iroha smiled politely.

Her parents laughed and returned the greeting.

The chef clapped her hands together with a bright smile.

“Tonight’s menu,” she announced, “is a special multi-course teppanyaki experience. I’ll be preparing each dish right here in front of you — and I hope you enjoy the show as much as the food!”

She gestured to the ingredients laid out before her:

fresh vegetables glistening with water droplets, marbled slices of beef, plump shrimp, delicate mushrooms, and small bowls of colorful sauces.

“For your first course,” she continued, “we’ll start with a light vegetable medley — crisp bean sprouts, sweet onions, and tender zucchini. After that, we’ll move on to shrimp with garlic butter, then a choice of steak or chicken, cooked to your liking. And finally... fried rice with egg and scallions, made with a little flair.”

Hologram-Ui, Nemu, and Touka leaned forward, eyes sparkling.

“And of course,” the chef added with a wink, “there will be fire.”

Touka gasped.

Nemu’s eyes widened.

Hologram-Ui practically bounced in her seat.

The chef lifted two metal spatulas and spun them effortlessly between her fingers — far more gracefully than Hologram-Ui’s earlier attempt.

“Ready?”

“Yes!!” the three girls shouted.

Hologram-Iroha smiled softly. “I’m ready.”

Her parents nodded warmly. “Let the show begin.”

The chef bowed dramatically, then struck the spatulas together with a metallic *clang*.

The show began.

She chopped vegetables with lightning speed, the rhythmic *tak-tak-tak* echoing through the room. She flipped slices of zucchini into the air and caught them on the edge of her spatula. She spun an egg like a coin, cracked it mid-air, and let it sizzle onto the grill.

Then she poured a thin stream of alcohol around the vegetables.

“Stand back,” she said playfully.

A moment later—

WHOOSH.

A pillar of flame burst upward, illuminating the room in warm gold.

Hologram-Ui, Nemu, and Touka gasped in unison, their faces glowing in the firelight.

Hologram-Ui turned to her sister, eyes shining.

“Isn’t it amazing, Iroha?”

Hologram-Iroha was smiling — small, gentle — but her eyes were distant, unfocused, as if she were thinking about something else entirely.

Something frightening.

Something she couldn’t speak about.

Hologram-Ui’s heart tightened.

She’s not okay.

Hologram-Iroha blinked, realizing her little sister was waiting for an answer.

“Yes,” she said softly. “It’s fun. The chef is amazing.”

Hologram-Ui smiled, but her worry didn’t fade.

“I’m just so happy,” Ui said, “that I can see things like this in real life now. Not just on TV. Everything feels different.”

Before Hologram-Iroha could respond, her father called out:

“Everyone, look this way!”

They turned to see Hologram-Ui’s parents standing with their phone raised.

“Smile!”

Hologram-Ui, Hologram-Iroha, Nemu, and Touka all leaned together, grinning brightly.

Click.

The parents beamed. “Isn’t it beautiful?”

Everyone agreed.

Hologram-Ui clasped her hands. “I can’t wait to put this picture in my room when I get home. My first picture as a healthy girl.”

The chef smiled warmly at the sentiment.

“And your first course is ready! Please hand me your plates.”

Hologram-Ui, Nemu, and Touka practically shoved their plates forward in excitement.

Hologram-Iroha handed hers over with a small smile.

Her parents followed.

“What are we waiting for?” Ui’s father said. “Let’s dig in!”

Everyone cheered.

They began to eat.

A perfect moment — warm, bright, and full of promise.

A moment none of them knew would be the last of its kind.

Hologram-Ui, Nemu, and Touka dug into their food with unrestrained enthusiasm.

“This is amazing!” Hologram-Ui said between bites.

“Way better than hospital food!” Touka added.

Nemu nodded solemnly. “I could write poetry about this flavor.”

Their parents laughed, soaking in the warmth of the moment — the joy, the noise, the sight of their daughter surrounded by friends and happiness.

But Hologram-Iroha...

She was different.

Her fingers trembled as she lifted her chopsticks. The shrimp slipped once. Then again. She forced a third attempt, finally managing to bring a piece to her mouth.

Calm down, she told herself. If you keep shaking like this, they’ll notice. Just breathe. Act normal.

But her body wouldn’t listen.

Her first witch fight — the terror, the pressure in the labyrinth, the blood-chilling screams, the realization that she could die — still clung to her like a shadow.

Across the table, Hologram-Ui, Nemu, and Touka exchanged glances.

Something was wrong.

Very wrong.

Hologram-Ui leaned closer to them, whispering, “Her hands... she’s shaking so much.”

Nemu frowned. “Is she sick?”

Touka shook her head. “No. That’s not it. This feels... deeper.”

The three of them watched Hologram-Iroha struggle with her chopsticks, worry tightening their expressions.

Then Touka's eyes sharpened — mischief flashing, but beneath it, purpose.

She leaned toward Nemu. "Hey, Nemu. You never finish your food in the hospital, right? Guess I'll help you out."

She reached over with her chopsticks.

Nemu — quickly realizing what Touka was doing — jerked her plate away. "Absolutely not! This is *my* food. I'm not sharing. Not today."

Touka pouted dramatically. "You're so stingy!"

"It's not every day I get to eat something this delicious." Nemu snapped. "I refuse to part with it!"

Touka huffed. Nemu glared.

And within seconds, they were bickering like always.

Hologram-Ui watched them, confused for a moment — then her eyes widened in understanding.

They were doing this on purpose.

Across the table, Hologram-Iroha blinked — then suddenly burst into laughter.

Touka and Nemu stopped mid-argument, glancing at her.

Iroha covered her mouth, still laughing softly. "Seeing you two argue like that outside the hospital room... it's so funny. You two never change..."

Her shoulders relaxed.

Her hands steadied.

Her breathing evened out.

"Thank you," she said quietly. "I feel better now."

Touka and Nemu exchanged a quick, satisfied grin.

Their plan had worked.

But they leaned toward Hologram-Ui and whispered:

"She's not sick."

"No way. Look how steady her hands are now."

"Something happened to her."

"Something bad."

Hologram-Ui nodded, her heart tightening.

They would watch her closely.

They would find out what happened.

The meal continued in a haze of laughter and spectacle.

The chef dazzled them with tricks — flipping shrimp tails into her hat, juggling spatulas, shaping fried rice into a heart.

Hologram-Ui, Nemu, and Touka were captivated, leaning forward with sparkling eyes.

Hologram-Iroha, calmer now, allowed herself to enjoy the moment.

Her parents took pictures and videos, capturing every laugh, every smile, every spark of joy.

When the final course was finished, the chef bowed deeply.

“Thank you for coming! How was everything?”

Ui, Nemu, and Touka beamed. “It was the most fun we’ve had in forever!”

The chef laughed, delighted.

Iroha smiled. “The food was delicious. And... I was able to relax. Thank you.”

But her thoughts told a different story.

This is only temporary.

I think I acted well enough. They didn’t suspect too much.

Tomorrow... I’ll be back to hunting witches.

She clenched her fist beneath the table.

I wished for this. Ui is healthy. That’s all that matters.

If I have to fight... if I have to suffer... it’s worth it.

Her parents thanked the chef warmly.

“That was a great experience, thank you for everything.”

“We’ll come back sometime. See you then!”

“Let me escort you out!” the chef said, leading them toward the exit.

It was dark when they stepped outside. The lanterns glowed softly, and the night air was cool and gentle.

Hologram-Ui turned to her family.

“The doctors said I should stay a few more weeks,” she explained. “Just to make sure the illness doesn’t come back. They said... something like this has never happened before.”

Her parents exchanged hopeful, anxious looks.

“We just want you safe,” her mother said. “We hope nothing bad happens.”

Hologram-Ui nodded, then looked at her sister.

“You’ll keep visiting me until I’m discharged, right?”

Iroha smiled — a real one this time.

“Of course. How next week?”

“Yes! See you then big sis!” Hologram-Ui practically glowing with excitement.

And with that, the group began walking back toward the hospital.

Their footsteps were light.

Their voices warm.

Laughter drifted through the night air.

The sparkles shifted again.

Daylight filled the hospital room.

Hologram-Ui sat on her bed, staring down at her phone with a small, trembling frown.

On the screen was a message from her sister:

“I’m so sorry, Ui. I can’t come today either.”

Hologram-Ui’s shoulders slumped.

“That’s the third time…” she whispered. “She promised she’d come today.”

Touka and Nemu exchanged troubled looks.

“Iroha never missed a visit before,” Touka said quietly.

“Not once,” Nemu agreed. “Not even when she was busy. Something changed.”

Hologram-Ui tightened her grip on her phone.

“It feels like she’s avoiding me,” she said softly. “And it hurts.”

After a moment, she typed back carefully:

“It’s okay, big sis. You must be busy with something important. But… please come soon. We miss you.”

Minutes passed.

Then her phone buzzed.

“I’m really sorry, Ui. I didn’t mean to delay three times. I promise I’ll come tomorrow evening. I’ll make it a priority.”

Hologram-Ui’s expression softened.

She typed:

“I’m looking forward to it. I love you.”

A moment later:

“I love you too. See you tomorrow.”

Touka let out a small breath of relief.

“So... one more day.”

Hologram-Ui slid off the bed and hurried to the calendar on the wall. With a bright red marker, she circled tomorrow’s date.

“Yes,” she said, nodding to herself. “Just one more day.”

The scene shifted again.

Evening light filtered through the hospital window. Hologram-Ui, Nemu, and Touka sat near the door, waiting eagerly.

No message.

No delay.

She was coming.

Then—

Ding-dong.

They jumped up.

They rushed to the door.

“Big sis—!”

They flung it open.

And froze.

Hologram-Iroha stood there, smiling...

But her smile was thin.

Strained.

Her eyes were shadowed, her posture sagging with exhaustion she couldn’t hide.

“Are you okay?” Hologram-Ui asked immediately.

Hologram-Iroha nodded too quickly. “Yeah. Just... a little tired.”

She lifted a small bag. “I made dinner. Let’s eat together.”

They gathered around the small table.

The food smelled wonderful — warm, comforting, familiar.

But the atmosphere wasn't.

It was quiet.

Tense.

Heavy.

Hologram-Ui clenched her fists beneath the table. She couldn't hold it in anymore.

"Big sis," she said softly. "Can I ask you something?"

Hologram-Iroha looked up, startled — then smiled gently. "Of course. What is it?"

Hologram-Ui took a breath.

"You... haven't been yourself since I got better."

Hologram-Iroha's eyes widened.

They noticed.

This isn't good.

But she stayed silent, listening.

Hologram-Ui continued, voice trembling.

"When I called home... your reaction to me being cured was too calm. Like you already knew."

Hologram-Iroha's breath caught.

"And at the restaurant," Hologram-Ui said, "your hands were shaking. Your grip was weak. Your breathing was strange. You couldn't hold your chopsticks. Your eyes were distant. You looked like you weren't even there."

Touka and Nemu nodded in quiet agreement.

"And then you delayed your visits," Hologram-Ui whispered. "Three times. And now... you look so tired."

She hesitated — then spoke the thought she'd been afraid to voice.

"It feels like... I was cured at the expense of you."

The words hung in the air.

Hologram-Ui's eyes shimmered.

"Please," she said, voice cracking. "What happened? You keep saying you had something important to do. Is that why you're like this? Is there anything we can do to help?"

Her voice broke.

"It hurts to see you suffering like this..."

Hologram-Iroha's mouth fell open.

She sat there, stunned.

Her little sister — the reason she made her wish — was looking at her with worry instead of relief. Touka and Nemu too.

All three of them had seen through her mask.

Her life had changed the moment she made her wish.

Witch hunts.

Blood.

Nightmares.

Fear.

Pain.

Loneliness.

She had grown more used to the battles, but the toll never lessened.

And now... her sister was asking her to share that burden.

Hologram-Iroha swallowed hard.

She couldn't lie.

But she couldn't tell the truth either. She couldn't drag them into this world.

Slowly, she stood and walked around the table. She knelt beside Hologram-Ui and pulled her into a tight embrace.

"Thank you," she whispered. "For worrying about me. For being honest."

She pulled back just enough to meet Ui's eyes.

"I... do have something important I'm dealing with. But I promise you — I'm okay. You don't need to worry. I'll get through it soon."

It wasn't a complete lie.

But it wasn't the full truth either.

Hologram-Ui, Touka, and Nemu exchanged uncertain looks.

They weren't convinced.

Not fully.

But they trusted her.

And they wanted to believe she would be alright.

"Okay," Ui said softly. "We'll trust you."

"But don't push yourself too hard," Nemu added.

“And if you need help,” Touka said with a grin, “I *am* a genius.”

Iroha smiled — a bittersweet smile that didn’t reach her eyes.

“Thank you,” she said. “I’ll tell you if I need help.”

She straightened, forcing brightness into her voice.

“But for now... let’s enjoy dinner.”

They did.

They talked.

They laughed.

They ate together like they always had.

But inside, Iroha’s heart ached.

They trusted her.

And she was hiding so much.

She felt like she was betraying them.

Still... she smiled.

She laughed.

She ate with them.

Just like old times.

Dinner was warm and easy — laughter, teasing, and the gentle illusion that everything was normal again. For a little while, even Hologram-Iroha seemed lighter, the weight on her shoulders easing just enough to breathe.

When the meal ended, Hologram-Iroha stood and stretched lightly.

“It’s getting late,” she said with a soft smile. “I should head home. Thank you... for tonight. I really had fun.”

Hologram-Ui, Touka, and Nemu walked her to the door.

“Good night, big sis!”

“See you soon!”

“Take care!”

Hologram-Iroha waved, turned, and began walking down the hallway.

Then—

Her ring flared bright pink.

Hologram-Iroha froze. Her eyes widened.

A witch... here?

Without a word, she spun on her heel and sprinted down the corridor.

“Wait—!” Hologram-Ui called instinctively.

But Iroha was already gone.

The three of them stared after her, stunned.

“What was that?” Hologram-Ui whispered.

Touka’s eyes narrowed, mind racing. “That has to be it. The ‘important thing’ she keeps talking about.”

Nemu nodded, face pale but focused. “We follow. Quietly.”

They hurried after her, keeping their distance.

Hologram-Iroha ran deeper into the hospital — past elevators, past staff-only corridors, down a stairwell none of them had ever used. The air grew colder. The lights dimmer.

Hologram-Ui, Touka, and Nemu exchanged uneasy glances.

“Why is she going down here?” Touka whispered.

They followed her into the lowest level — the morgue.

Hologram-Ui shivered. “What business does she have *here*...?”

Nemu whispered, “This is really suspicious.”

Before they could speculate further, Hologram-Iroha stopped in front of a blank wall.

She raised her hand.

A glowing pink tear ripped open in the air, twisting and warping reality itself.

The three of them froze in shock.

Hologram-Iroha leapt through it without hesitation — and vanished.

The portal remained, swirling softly.

Hologram-Ui’s breath caught. “What is that?”

Touka stared, pale. “Impossible... Did she just warp space?”

Nemu’s eyes sparkled despite the fear. “It’s like a story come alive...”

The portal flickered.

“It’s closing!” Hologram-Ui cried. “Hurry!”

The three of them dashed forward and dove through just as it sealed shut behind them.

They tumbled out in a heap.

“Ow—!” Hologram-Ui groaned. “Can you two... please get off me...?”

Touka and Nemu rolled away, catching their breath.

“Ui has way too much energy now,” Touka muttered.

“Unfair,” Nemu agreed.

They stood, dusting themselves off — and froze.

The world around them was wrong.

Red, fleshy stalagmites branched in impossible angles.

The ground pulsed faintly, like something alive.

Candy-striped humanoid shapes twitched in the distance, their movements jerky and unnatural. The air was heavy and suffocating.

Touka whispered, “What... *is* this place?”

Nemu swallowed. “Normally I’d be thrilled. But the pressure here... it feels dangerous.”

Hologram-Ui hugged herself. “Why did big sis come here...? I have a really bad feeling.”

A sharp cry echoed through the labyrinth.

Hologram-Iroha’s voice.

They turned just in time to see her fly through the air, slam into a red structure, and crumple to the ground.

A grotesque creature slithered toward her.

Маруся.

Its lotus-pod head pulsed grotesquely. Tentacles writhed and scraped against the ground as it advanced.

Hologram-Ui clamped a hand over her mouth to keep from screaming.

“What... what is happening...?” Touka whispered.

Nemu’s voice trembled. “She’s fighting that thing.”

“It’s trying to kill her!” Hologram-Ui cried. “We have to help!”

Touka grabbed her arm. “How? That hit would’ve killed any normal human. But she’s still alive...”

Nemu whispered, “This must be the ‘important thing’ she kept mentioning. Fighting... monsters like this. But why?”

They looked at Hologram-Ui.

“This might be connected to your cure,” Touka said softly.

“Maybe this was the price she paid,” Nemu added.

Hologram-Ui’s breath hitched.

Before she could reply—

A voice behind them said calmly:

“Correct. You two are very sharp.”

They jumped and spun around.

A small white creature stood atop a red structure, tail swaying lazily, red eyes staring at them.

Hologram-Ui whispered, “Did... did that thing just talk?”

The creature nodded. “My name is Kyubey. Iroha made a contract with me to cure you.”

Hologram-Ui’s heart pounded. “A contract?”

“I can grant a girl any wish,” Kyubey continued flatly. “In exchange, she becomes a magical girl. Magical girls fight witches.”

Touka’s eyes widened. “So Iroha is a magical girl... and that monster is a witch?”

“Yes,” Kyubey said.

Nemu asked, “Why do magical girls fight witches?”

Kyubey flicked his tail. “Watch the battle. The answer may reveal itself.”

They turned back to Hologram-Iroha.

She fired pink magic arrows from her crossbow, each shot lighting up the labyrinth. The witch shrieked as the bolts struck — but it kept advancing, relentless.

Hologram-Ui trembled. “She’s getting overwhelmed... what happens if she loses?”

Kyubey tilted his head.

“She dies. Just like any human.”

All three girls went pale.

“She’s been fighting like this... alone...?” Hologram-Ui whispered.

Kyubey nodded. “Yes. To fulfill her wish.”

Hologram-Ui’s voice cracked. “Isn’t there any way to save her?”

“There is,” Kyubey said. “One of you can make a contract. What wish do you have?”

BAM.

Маруся struck Hologram-Iroha again.

Hologram-Iroha screamed as she hit the ground hard.

The witch lunged, ready to consume her.

Kyubey’s voice sharpened. “Quickly! Someone must make a contract.”

Ui’s heart pounded.

“Okay... my wish is—”

But before she could speak, Iroha fired an explosive shot at the ground.

A burst of light and smoke filled the air.

Маруся recoiled, screeching.

A white cloak fluttered through the haze.

The witch lunged toward it.

“No—! Iroha!” Hologram-Ui screamed.

Then—

A pink magic bullet shot from the smoke and struck Маруся from behind.

The witch shrieked — a warped, echoing cry that made all three girls flinch.

More pink bullets followed, tearing through Маруся’s body.

The witch convulsed, let out one final, distorted scream—

And dissolved into nothing.

The labyrinth dissolved like smoke in the wind.

The fleshy red pillars peeled away like wet paper. The twitching familiars dissolved into ash. The pulsing ground thinned, flattened, and hardened.

In seconds, the nightmare collapsed into the cold, sterile morgue.

Touka’s eyes widened. “It’s fading. Hide—now!”

The three of them scrambled behind a tall metal storage cabinet. There was small hole in it — just enough to see through.

They pressed themselves into the shadows, hearts pounding.

Hologram-Iroha dropped to her knees.

She was panting hard, breath coming in ragged gasps. Sweat soaked her hair and collar. Her whole body shook as if she might collapse at any moment.

“I... did it...” she whispered. “That was... too close...”

A soft, unnatural glow formed in the air before her.

Something black and ornate crystallized into existence — twisted, heavy, wrong.

A grief seed.

Hologram-Iroha stared at it for a heartbeat, then exhaled in relief. With trembling fingers, she picked it up and pressed it against her soul gem.

The soul gem pulsed.

The murky shadows inside it drained away, replaced by a clean, radiant pink.

Hologram-Ui, Touka, and Nemu stared in stunned silence.

“What... is she doing?” Hologram-Ui whispered.

Touka’s voice was barely audible. “That pink gem... it’s reacting to that black thing...”

Nemu’s eyes narrowed. “She’s purifying it.”

Hologram-Iroha stiffened suddenly.

She looked around, shoulders tensing.

“...Is someone there?” she murmured.

Hologram-Ui, Touka, and Nemu froze.

Their blood ran cold.

They held their breath, terrified she would find them.

Seconds stretched into an eternity.

Then Iroha let out a weak, exhausted laugh.

“...I must be hearing things. I’m too tired...”

She forced herself to stand, wobbling, hunched, every movement slow and painful.

“I need to... get home...”

She staggered out of the morgue and disappeared down the hallway.

Only when her footsteps faded did the three girls finally exhale.

Touka slumped against the wall. “That was... way too close.”

Nemu nodded shakily. “I thought she’d find us for sure.”

A soft thump made them jump.

Kyubey hopped onto a metal table, tail swaying lazily.

“That object is called a grief seed,” he said calmly. “It sometimes appears when a witch is defeated.”

Hologram-Ui flinched.

“Magical girls use grief seeds to purify their soul gems,” Kyubey continued. “Soul gems become tainted as magical girls use magic and fight witches.”

Hologram-Ui clenched her fists until her knuckles burned.

“So she’s been suffering like this... for my sake...”

Her voice cracked.

“She never asked me. I never asked for this. If I knew... I would’ve stopped her. Why... why would she hide this from us?!”

Touka’s expression darkened. “Because she didn’t want us dragged into this.”

Nemu nodded. “A life where one mistake means death.”

Hologram-Ui turned to Kyubey, desperation in her eyes.

“She said she’d get through this soon. Does that mean this is temporary? Will she stop fighting someday?”

Kyubey blinked.

“No. She will have to fight witches for the rest of her life.”

Hologram-Ui’s breath hitched.

“For... the rest of her life...?”

Tears spilled down her cheeks.

“She already looks so tired... so scared... if she has to live the rest of her life like this...”

Touka swallowed hard. “What happens if she stops fighting and getting grief seeds?”

“She will no longer be able to use magic,” Kyubey replied.

Nemu frowned. “So what exactly *are* magical girls and witches?”

Kyubey answered matter-of-factly.

“Witches are curses. Witches lure humans into their labyrinths using a witch’s kiss, to consume them to grow stronger. Humans affected often exhibit severe mental health deterioration, including suicidal tendencies. Conversely, magical girls are blessings. They fight witches.”

The three girls fell silent.

It was too much.

Too cruel.

Too real.

Nemu finally spoke. “So magical girls... help people by defeating witches? Do normal people fight them too?”

“Most humans cannot perceive witches,” Kyubey said. “Even if they could, normal attacks cannot harm them. Their deaths are attributed to natural causes or mental illness.”

Hologram-Ui wiped her eyes and looked up.

“So... if I make a wish... I can help my sister? And help others too?”

“Yes,” Kyubey said. “Do you have a wish in mind?”

Hologram-Ui opened her mouth—

But Touka grabbed her arm.

“Wait. Calm down.”

Hologram-Ui protested, voice trembling. “I can’t let her fight alone! Not because of me!”

Nemu placed a hand on her shoulder.

“We feel the same way. But we still don’t know what magical girls or witches truly are. If we rush into this without understanding it more... we could all suffer.”

Touka nodded. “We need to research first. And act once we know enough.”

Hologram-Ui trembled — then took a slow, shaking breath.

“...You’re right. Thank you.”

Kyubey hopped down from the table.

“If you decide to make a wish,” he said neutrally, “call for me.”

He turned and vanished into the shadows.

Chapter 6c: Where it all went wrong

The sparkles dimmed, then dissolved.

The hospital room reassembled around them — quiet, still, heavy with the echoes of everything they had just witnessed.

For a long moment, no one spoke.

Iroha, Yachiyo, and Mitama sat frozen, each trapped in their own thoughts.

Yachiyo was the first to break the silence. Her voice was low, steady — but not cold.

“...So that was what happened.”

Mitama exhaled slowly, one hand pressed to her chest.

“Ui, Touka, and Nemu... learning about magical girls and witches for the very first time.”

Iroha’s hands curled into fists on her thighs. Her shoulders trembled. Tears streamed down her cheeks before she even realized she was crying.

“I... never knew,” she whispered.

Ui watched her quietly, her expression gentle, patient — giving her sister the space she needed.

Iroha lifted her head, eyes shining with guilt and grief.

“You were right,” she said, voice breaking. “I never asked you. I thought I was doing what was best. I thought... curing you was worth any price.”

Her breath hitched.

“But my wish ended up hurting you. I’m so sorry, Ui.”

Ui moved closer, gently taking Iroha’s shaking hands in her own.

“I understand,” she said softly. “You wished for me out of love. And you hid the truth because you didn’t want us to suffer like you did.”

Her grip tightened slightly.

“You wanted to protect us.”

Then her expression shifted — gentler, but heavier.

“But... part of it was our fault too. Touka, Nemu, and I should have told you what we saw that day. We should have told you what we thought.”

Her gaze lowered.

“If the four of us had faced it together... maybe things wouldn’t have turned out this way.”

Iroha inhaled sharply.

Yachiyo leaned forward, her eyes serious.

“Then what happened after that? How did you become a witch?”

Mitama nodded.

“And how did your soul end up inside the small Kyubey... while your witch became Embryo Eve?”

Yachiyo added quietly, “And Touka and Nemu became magical girls too. That means they made wishes.”

“How does this all relate to the Wings of the Magius?” Mitama asked.

Ui let out a small, bittersweet chuckle.

“After that night... we researched everything we could.”

She looked around the room.

“Magical girls. Witches. Rumors. Disappearances. Old case files. Urban legends. Anything that might explain what was happening to Iroha.”

Her expression hardened.

“And that’s when we found the truth.”

She raised two fingers.

“Two truths.”

“One,” Ui said calmly, “a magical girl’s soul gem is her literal soul. If it breaks... she dies.”

Yachiyo stiffened.

Mitama sucked in a sharp breath.

Iroha froze.

“And two,” Ui continued, her voice quiet but unwavering,
“magical girls are destined to become witches.”

Silence swallowed the room.

Yachiyo stared at her in disbelief — and something else. Respect.

“You figured that out... on your own?”

Mitama nodded slowly.

“That’s incredible. Most magical girls never learn the truth until it’s already happening.”

Lunaria smiled softly.

“You three must have worked very hard.”

Kasumi crossed her arms with a proud grin.

“And you didn’t look away, even when the truth was ugly.”

Mitama tilted her head. “But if you knew all that... why did you still make a wish? Why become magical girls at all?”

Yachiyo nodded. “If I’d known the truth back then... I never would’ve contracted with Kyubey.”

Iroha looked at Ui, her chest tight.

“You made your wishes for me, didn’t you?”

Ui’s eyes softened.

“Yes,” she said quietly. “We made our wishes for you. And for all magical girls...”

She glanced at Yachiyo and Mitama.

“We thought we were smart. That we’d outplayed the system.”

Then she looked at Lunaria and Kasumi.

“But we were too clever... and too naïve.”

Her voice trembled.

“Even knowing the truth... we didn’t think it through. Not enough...”

Tears shimmered in her eyes.

“And now,” Ui said softly,

“I’ll show you what happened next.”

The sparkles began to gather again, swirling faster — brighter — like fireflies caught in a rising storm.

The next memory began to take shape.

Sparkles swirled around them, gathering like petals caught in a rising breeze.

The world shifted.

When the light settled, they stood on the hospital rooftop. Early afternoon sunlight warmed the concrete, and a soft wind brushed against the railings. Hologram-Ui, Touka, and Nemu faced Kyubey — three girls standing together with a single purpose.

Kyubey’s red eyes blinked once.

“You called me here,” he said. “Have you decided what to wish for?”

Nemu stepped forward. “Before we answer that, there’s something we want clarified.”

Kyubey flicked his tail. “Go ahead. I do not lie.”

Nemu’s gaze sharpened. “Then explain it again. Clearly. What exactly are magical girls and witches?”

Kyubey responded without pause, as if reciting an immutable law.

“Witches are curses. They lure humans into their labyrinths using a witch’s kiss and consume them to grow stronger. Humans affected by witches often suffer extreme mental deterioration, including suicidal tendencies. Conversely, magical girls are blessings. They fight witches.”

Touka crossed her arms. “Then let’s ask it a different way.”

Her eyes narrowed. “Witches are magical girls who fall into despair. Correct?”

Kyubey tilted his head.

“I’m surprised you figured that out. Most magical girls respond with anger or denial when they learn the truth.”

A pause.

“Will you?”

Hologram-Ui stepped forward.

“No,” she said.

Her voice didn’t shake.

“We won’t get angry.”

Touka and Nemu moved to stand beside her.

“We want to make contracts with you,” Hologram-Ui continued. “All three of us.”

Kyubey blinked slowly — genuinely surprised.

“You still wish to become magical girls, even knowing that? Humans truly are difficult to understand.”

He straightened.

“Very well. State your wishes.”

Hologram-Ui, Touka, and Nemu exchanged a single, resolute nod.

Then, in unison, they spoke:

“We wish to have your power.”

“My power?” he echoed. “What do you mean?”

Hologram-Ui stepped forward first.

“I want the power to collect — the ability to gather despair and impurity from every magical girl’s soul gem.”

Touka continued without missing a beat.

“And I want the power to transform — to convert that despair into usable magical energy.”

Nemu finished, her voice calm and absolute.

“And I want the power to manifest — to release that energy back into the universe in physical form.”

For the first time, Kyubey hesitated.

“...What are you trying to do?”

A brilliant glow erupted from his body, enveloping the three girls in a spiraling column of light. Their silhouettes shifted, reshaped — their magical girl forms emerging in full clarity.

Nemu

A long black cape draped over a beige dress adorned with white circular accents. Purple pants and white boots grounded her silhouette. Her braided hair and black academic cap with gold tassels gave her the air of a scholar-priestess — someone who rewrites the laws of the world with ink and will.

Touka

A dress of deep black and crimson, accented with red bows at her neck and wrists. A gold-trimmed corset cinched her waist. Black thigh-high socks and red-and-black boots completed the look. A black ribbon crowned her long light-brown hair, and her matching parasol gave her the regal poise of a young aristocrat commanding the stage of fate.

Hologram-Ui

A small black beret-like hat with a large bow and crimson beads rested on the side of her head. Her dark gray outfit, lined with gold buttons and a thick maroon stripe trimmed in white frills, paired with gray shorts and boots, gave her a compact, determined silhouette — a quiet center of gravity for the system she was about to anchor.

When the light faded—

Kyubey was no longer standing tall.

He was small. Frail.

Barely the size of a plush toy.

He didn't move.

He didn't speak.

He simply stood there, hollow and silent.

Hologram-Ui stared. "What... happened to him?"

"This was not part of the plan..." Touka murmured.

Nemu's eyes narrowed. "Our wishes... drained him. We took the system itself."

Before they could process it—

Hologram-Ui's soul gem flared.

A torrent of darkness surged toward her from every direction — despair, grief, accumulated suffering. Across the city, magical girls gasped as their soul gems suddenly cleared, purified without effort.

Touka reached out, fingers brushing the flowing darkness.

"I can transform this," she whispered.

The despair shifted, turning into radiant magical energy that rippled outward like a heartbeat.

Nemu raised her hands, gathering the released power.

“And I can manifest it.”

The energy crystallized into countless luminous particles, scattering into the sky and dissolving into the universe like stardust.

A new system was born.

A system that rewrote the fate of magical girls.

A system that defied entropy itself.

Iroha, Yachiyo, and Mitama watched in stunned silence.

“They... eliminated the witch transformation,” Yachiyo whispered.

“And stabilized entropy,” Mitama breathed. “Incredible...”

Iroha shook her head in disbelief. “No magical girl I know could have made wishes like that...”

Lunaria and Kasumi exchanged a knowing, bittersweet look.

“Yes,” Lunaria said softly. “They were clever. Too clever.”

Kasumi nodded, eyes shadowed. “But hacking a system without fully understanding its consequences...”

She exhaled. “That never ends well.”

Their gazes lowered, memories stirring — something that echoed this moment too closely.

Then they looked back at the unfolding scene.

“Let’s see what comes next,” Kasumi murmured.

Iroha, Yachiyo, and Mitama turned back to the memory, hearts pounding, breath caught in their throats.

Whatever came next...

would change everything.

Touka and Nemu stared at the sky, breathless with exhilaration.

“It worked!” Touka cheered, spinning in place. “Magical girls won’t suffer anymore! No more despair, no more witches, and the universe won’t die of entropy. As expected of me — a genius!”

Nemu puffed her cheeks. “We did it together.”

Touka blinked, then laughed again. “Fine, fine. *Together.*”

Their joy was bright. Unrestrained.

The joy of children who truly believed they had rewritten fate.

They turned toward Hologram-Ui.

“Ui, what do you think?” Touka asked.

“Yes,” Nemu added. “Your ability is the core of this system. How do you feel?”

Hologram-Ui didn’t answer.

A faint ripple of darkness curled around her feet.

Her eyes widened. Her breath hitched. Her body began to shake.

“Ui?” Touka stepped forward. “Hey—Ui, talk to us!”

“Are you alright?” Nemu asked, voice tightening.

Hologram-Ui’s lips parted—

And she broke.

A scream tore from her throat, raw and agonized. Darkness exploded outward, violent and uncontrollable. A second voice layered over her own—warped, echoing, inhuman.

Touka and Nemu were thrown back, shielding their faces from the surge.

“No...” Touka whispered. “No, no, no — she’s becoming a witch?!”

Through the thinning darkness, Ui’s silhouette twisted and warped, her voice splitting between despair and something monstrous.

“I won’t allow this!” Touka shouted, thrusting her hands forward. “Not after everything we did!”

Nemu followed, her voice cracking. “Ui, please—hold on!”

Their powers surged—transforming, manifesting—forcing the corruption back.

For a moment, Hologram-Ui’s transformation slowed.

Iroha, Yachiyo, and Mitama watched the memory unfold, their faces pale.

“So this... this is how Ui became a witch...” Yachiyo whispered.

Mitama’s voice trembled. “The consequence of their wishes... all that hope, crushed instantly...”

Iroha clutched Ui’s hand in the present, sobbing. “Ui...”

Ui smiled through her own tears.

“It was terrifying,” she said softly. “I really thought I was going to disappear forever.”

She squeezed Iroha’s hand. “But I’m here now. So... it’s okay, right?”

Back in the memory, Touka and Nemu were shaking violently, pushed to their absolute limits.

“I can’t... hold it...!” Touka gasped.

“She’s still transforming!” Nemu cried. “At this rate—!”

A sudden flash of green light erupted around Ui.

A cube-shaped barrier snapped into place, sealing her inside.

Hologram-Ui’s scream cut off instantly.

Her transformation froze mid-shift.

Touka and Nemu stared, stunned.

“What... what just happened?” Touka breathed.

A voice answered behind them.

“I trapped her. *Ora*, now you can work on her without interruptions.”

They turned.

A magical girl stood there, arms crossed, expression sharp and amused.

Alina Gray.

“Hurry,” she said. “Before she breaks my barrier.”

Touka didn’t hesitate. She reached into the cube, her hand trembling as she grasped Ui’s cracked, corrupted soul gem.

“Come on... please...” Touka whispered, pouring every ounce of her power into the gem.

Hologram-Ui’s gem pulsed.

Then — a small, fragile light slipped free, floating into Touka’s hands.

Touka gasped. “I... I did it. I saved her.”

Nemu’s relief lasted only a second.

“Her soul can’t stay outside a vessel,” she said urgently. “We need something to hold it.”

Her eyes darted around — and landed on the small, motionless Kyubey.

“...That will work,” she said. “For now.”

Touka nodded weakly.

Nemu used her manifest ability, anchoring Ui’s soul inside the small Kyubey.

A bright light engulfed them.

When it faded—

Touka lay unconscious on the rooftop.

Alina stood nearby, arms folded.

And Nemu cradled the small Kyubey—now alive, trembling faintly.

“Ui?” Nemu whispered.

“Kyuu!” the small Kyubey chirped.

Nemu’s eyes softened. “Good... we saved you. I’m so sorry this happened. I promise — I’ll return you to normal someday.”

“Kyuu! Kyuu!” The small Kyubey nuzzled into her arms.

Touka groaned, pushing herself upright. “Ugh... what happened?”

Alina clapped her hands. “Bravissima! You two managed to tame that *bestia*. Molto impressive.”

She turned, towards the massive form nearby.

It was enormous—towering, radiant, disturbingly pristine. A white, godlike insectoid form with vast symmetrical wings etched in gold.

“What is this thing?” Alina asked, eyes gleaming with fascination.

Touka stood proudly. “That’s the artificial witch Nemu and I created! We’ll use it to spread the Automatic Purification System—APS—across the world. Soul gems will purify automatically. Magical girls will never become witches again!”

Nemu froze.

Artificial witch?

Save all magical girls?

Why didn’t she mention Ui?

“...Touka,” she said slowly. “What about Ui?”

Touka blinked. “Ui?”

Nemu’s blood ran cold.

“...Who is that?” Touka asked, tilting her head.

Her hands flew to her mouth.

Touka doesn’t remember... Ui’s existence has been overwritten? It can’t be...

Nemu turned desperately to Alina.

“Did you see her? A pink-haired girl—she was right here—”

Alina frowned. “No. I saw only the two of you and that artificial witch. You looked like you were struggling, so I helped.”

Touka’s eyes narrowed. “Nemu, what’s wrong with you? You’re acting strange. But more importantly...”

She pointed her parasol at the small Kyubey.

“Why are you holding that creature like it’s precious? He’s the enemy of all magical girls.”

Alina cracked her knuckles, smiling darkly.

“I overheard you talking to that *Kyubey* about witches. He tricked me, *capisci*? I want to make him suffer a slow, beautiful death.”

The small Kyubey squeaked and bolted, fleeing across the rooftop.

Touka scoffed. “Let him run. Once our plan is complete, Kyubey won’t matter anymore.”

She turned to Alina.

“Will you join us? Help us save all magical girls? Your barrier helped us a lot back there.”

Alina considered it, eyes gleaming with twisted delight.

An artificial witch... a system to rewrite fate... che spettacolo!
I’ll join — as long as it entertains me.

“Hmm... sì. Your plan is *interessante*. And besides, I don’t want to become a witch.”

Touka beamed and held out her hand.

“Welcome to the Wings of the Magius,” she declared proudly — a name she had invented on the spot.

Alina shook her hand with a grin.

She turned toward the artificial witch.

“And what shall we call *this* masterpiece?”

Nemu swallowed hard, forcing her voice steady.

“How about...Embryo Eve. Because it will give new life and hope to magical girls.”

Touka grinned. “Perfect name! As expected from you, Nemu.”

Nemu smiled weakly. “Yes... let’s hope this plan goes well.”

Touka laughed. “Of course it will. I’m a genius after all.”

This time, Nemu didn’t argue.

She only looked up at the sky, a single tear fell.

*It didn't go well at all.
We failed...*

Chapter 6d: New Frontiers in Kamihama

The sparkles faded.

Silence settled over the hospital room like a soft, heavy blanket.

Iroha, Yachiyo, and Mitama sat quietly, each grappling with the enormity of what they had just witnessed — Ui's suffering, the birth of the Wings of the Magius, and the terrible price paid for love.

Yachiyo was the first to break the silence.

She looked at Ui with a warm, steady gaze.

"Thank you," she said softly. "For sharing all of that with us. I know how painful it must have been."

Her voice carried quiet weight — the kind earned through years of loss she had never allowed herself to speak aloud.

Mitama nodded slowly.

"She's right. I only opened up about my own past yesterday... and even that made me nervous. I kept wondering how Momoko and Rena would react."

She exhaled. "But your memories answered so many questions — about the Uwasa, the Magius, and how all of this truly began."

Her expression shifted, thoughtful.

"But there's something that still puzzles me. Only Nemu remembered you after your soul was placed inside the small Kyubey. Even Iroha forgot."

Yachiyo fell into deep thought.

"Maybe... because Ui's soul — her essence — was moved into another vessel. That might have erased the memory of her existence from everyone except the one who performed the transfer."

Mitama tapped her chin.

"That makes sense. And the Kyubey who granted their wish... he essentially ceased functioning. I never imagined a wish could affect one of *them* like that."

Yachiyo gave a soft, incredulous chuckle.

"First the Rumors of Kamihama... and now this. The mysteries never seem to end."

Mitama smirked. "At least this time, you're not unraveling them alone."

Yachiyo raised an eyebrow. "I'm not hiring you, Mitama. You'd charge me a fortune."

Mitama laughed. "Yachiyo teasing someone? I never thought I'd see the day. You used to be distant, blunt, and downright cold."

Yachiyo grinned. “And you used to treat every interaction like a business transaction. Seeing you like this is... refreshing.”

The two of them shared a quiet laugh — a small but genuine.

Ui, Iroha, Lunaria, and Kasumi watched them with gentle smiles.
For a brief moment, the room felt lighter.

Then Iroha turned back to Ui.

Her eyes were soft, shining.

“Thank you... for telling us everything. I remember everything now. Our time together. My wish. How I tried to convince myself your cure was worth any suffering I endured.”

Ui smiled, accepting her sister’s gratitude.

“Ever since I became a witch,” Ui said quietly, “I’ve been very lonely. I couldn’t communicate with anyone normally. No one remembered me except Nemu... and she couldn’t come near me for fear of Touka and Nemu.”

Her voice trembled.

“I wanted to tell someone my story for so long. But I couldn’t. The only thing that kept me going were the moments when I saw you, big sis... and your friends. I was happy when I saw your suffering lessen. When I saw you make friends who supported you.”

Iroha pulled Ui into a tight embrace.

“That must have been unbearable,” she whispered. “To be alone like that... forgotten... unable to even say how much it hurt.”

She pulled back slightly, searching Ui’s eyes.

“But we’re together now. We won’t let that happen again. Ever.”

Hope crept into her voice.

“Ui... can you return to normal? Can we live together again?”

Ui’s expression dimmed.

“Ever since that day... I thought it was impossible. My human body is gone. It became Embryo Eve. And I’ve been trapped in this form ever since.”

The room grew still.

Iroha, Yachiyo, and Mitama looked at her with quiet sorrow.

Ui continued.

“But... yesterday, something changed.”

She turned toward Lunaria and Kasumi, who both smiled knowingly.

“I saw Lunaria communicate with Ichizo — Kuroe’s witch. And Mitama said Kasumi prevented Mifuyu’s and Momoko’s souls from fading after they saved the doppelified girls.”

Her voice grew quieter.

“But what happened after that frightened me.”

She swallowed.

“Lunaria used something called *Dis-Connect* on Ichizo. Then both of them vanished. No trace of Kuroe remained.”

She clenched her hands.

“And Mifuyu and Momoko... they were found dead. Their soul gems shattered.”

Ui looked directly at Lunaria and Kasumi, eyes filled with fear — and fragile hope.

“So... what did you do to them? To Kuroe, Mifuyu, and Momoko?”

Iroha, Yachiyo, and Mitama turned as well, breath held.

“Did you save them?”

Yachiyo asked quietly.

“Or...” Mitama whispered,

“...are they truly gone?”

The room was quiet.

Still.

Ui, Iroha, Yachiyo, and Mitama looked at Lunaria and Kasumi with open, earnest eyes — hearts caught between hope and dread, waiting for an answer that could either heal old wounds... or tear them open again.

Lunaria and Kasumi only smiled back.

Warm. Gentle. Unreadable.

After what felt like an eternity, Lunaria spoke — her voice soft, almost wistful.

“Kuroe, Mifuyu, and Momoko...”

She paused.

“They are all in a better place.”

Kasumi nodded, her voice light yet sincere, like falling snow.

“And they’re looking forward to seeing all of you again someday.”

A hush fell over the room.

Ui’s breath trembled.

Iroha’s shoulders sagged.

Yachiyo bowed her head.

Mitama closed her eyes.

They all understood the implication — or believed they did.

“Kuroe...” Iroha whispered, tears spilling freely. “So you really are gone... when we were so close to...”

“Mifuyu... Momoko...” Yachiyo clenched her fists, memories of every friend she had lost tightening in her chest. “So many people... gone before I could say everything I wanted to.”

Mitama wiped her eyes and asked softly, carefully:

“So... you didn’t save them?”

She hesitated.

“You simply... made their final moments peaceful?”

Lunaria and Kasumi exchanged a small smile.

They didn’t answer.

Not yes.

Not no.

Only silence — gentle, deliberate, impenetrable.

Mitama let out a weak chuckle, exhaling slowly.

“So that’s all the answers we get today.”

She stood and bowed to them.

“Even if you couldn’t save them... thank you for being there. Yesterday gave us something precious — hope. Strength. Joy. I’m grateful.”

Iroha bowed as well.

“And thank you... for letting me see Ui again. For helping me remember everything.”

Ui stepped forward, looking at Lunaria and Kasumi with wide, searching eyes.

“If you can’t answer that question... then can you at least answer this one?”

She swallowed.

“Is it possible for me to talk to people like this again... and maybe even regain my human body?”

Lunaria's smile warmed like sunlight through clouds.
Kasumi's grin sparked with quiet excitement.

"That," Lunaria said, "depends on all of you."

Ui, Iroha, Yachiyo, and Mitama leaned in, breath held.

Kasumi clapped her hands lightly.

"You've already experienced Connect together. If you learn to master it... then there may be a chance Ui will be able to speak with others again."

Mitama sighed, shaking her head with a fond smile.

"There you go again, Kasumi. No straight answers."

Kasumi grinned brightly.

"Think of it this way — it's your chance to explore new frontiers as a Coordinator! With your new hope and joy... the sky's the limit!"

Mitama's eyes softened.

"Thank you. I want to grow. I want to help others. That's what I've always wanted to do as a magical girl."

Lunaria nodded approvingly.

"Connect is listening. Attuning yourself to life. Opening your heart to another. Now that you've seen it from a new angle... new paths will open for all of you."

She turned to Yachiyo and winked.

"Perhaps you'll even speak again with those who entrusted their hopes to you — Mel, Kanae, Momoko, Mifuyu. Just like yesterday."

Yachiyo's breath caught.

Her eyes shimmered.

"...I'd like that," she whispered. "More than anything."

Iroha laughed softly.

"This is exactly what I expected after yesterday. No answers — just encouragement and gentle nudges."

Kasumi bowed dramatically.

"Guilty as charged! I do love suspense~"

Lunaria smiled.

"We want magical girls to solve problems together — using their own strengths. Hopefully, you've seen what Connect can become when hearts truly align."

Ui, Iroha, Yachiyo, and Mitama exchanged small smiles — fragile, but full of possibility.

“If we all work together,” Iroha said, “maybe we really can make something happen.”

“We can ask Rena and Kaede too!” Mitama added brightly.

Kasumi stretched her arms overhead.

“Well! That was quite the conversation. Enough heavy talk for today, if you ask me.”

Lunaria rose gracefully.

“We’ll meet Ui like this again soon. Until then... take care.”

Ui’s eyes sparkled.

“I’m looking forward to it! There’s still so much I want to talk about.”

Iroha walked up to Ui and hugged her tightly.

“I’ll figure out a way to talk with you like this without Lunaria and Kasumi’s help. I promise.”

Ui hugged her back.

“I know you will. Until then... I’ll stay with you in your room, if you don’t mind. Normal people can’t see me anyway — just like Kyubey.”

Iroha smiled.

“Of course! And until we can talk normally... maybe you can use paw taps, little nudges, tail flicks?”

Ui giggled.

“I’ll think of something fun. We’ll make it work.”

Yachiyo and Mitama waved at Ui.

“Nice to meet you, Ui,” Yachiyo said warmly.

“I’ll figure out something soon,” Mitama added with a grin.

“Nice to meet you as well! Please continue being my big sis’ friends!” Ui chirped.

The hospital room began to fade — walls dissolving into sparkles of light.

Ui waved happily as the world dissolved around her.

And then she, too, faded away.

Iroha, Yachiyo, Mitama, Lunaria, and Kasumi opened their eyes.

They were back in Mitama’s cozy atelier.

Afternoon sunlight streamed through the stained-glass window, scattering soft blues, violets, and silvers across the room. Threads of warm gold wove through the colors, bathing the space in a gentle glow. The faint scent of tea and flowers lingered in the air — grounding, comforting, unmistakably real.

Lunaria stretched lightly, hands folding behind her back.

“Well,” she said with a small smile, “Kasumi and I should be on our way. Thank you for having us.”

Mitama returned the smile.

“Anytime. My door is always open.”

Kasumi turned toward Iroha, Yachiyo, and Mitama with a flourish that was equal parts theatrical and ominous.

“Just remember — the Wings of the Magius will activate their plan in two days.”

She leaned forward slightly.

“Something big is coming. Something spectacular. Possibly horrifying, devastating, world ending!”

She winked.

“But you know more about the Wings now. And Ui is with you. So I’m very curious to see what you’ll do.”

Yachiyo nodded, her expression firm but warm.

“We’ll act. I refuse to let the Wings keep hurting magical girls in the name of their ideals.”

Mitama crossed her arms, eyes sharp with resolve.

“I’ll reach out to all magical girls in Kamihama. I’ll attune their soul gems with a disaster scenario in mind. This time, no one will have to sacrifice themselves... not like Mifuyu and Momoko.”

A small weight landed on Iroha’s shoulder.

Ui — in her tiny Kyubey form — nuzzled Iroha’s cheek affectionately.

Iroha laughed and stroked her fur.

“Yes. We’ll work together now. Something we should have done with Nemu and Touka from the start.”

“Kyuu!” Ui chirped happily, tail swishing back and forth.

Mitama glanced at Kasumi with a mischievous smile.

“But if things get *really* bad... you two will swoop in at the last second again, right? We can still place our hopes in you?”

Lunaria chuckled softly and looked to Kasumi.

Kasumi let out a dramatic sigh and face-palmed.

“And there it is — Mitama’s boldness.

She fixed Mitama with a deadpan stare.

“Lend a hand and they take an arm.”

She tilted her head.

“Is this how your clients treat you too? Always expecting miracles?”

Mitama laughed.

“Oh, absolutely. People always want help when they’re in trouble. It’s natural, isn’t it?”

Kasumi didn't blink.

"Sure. But that doesn't mean people should expect miracles to fall from the sky."

Then — just as suddenly — her expression brightened into a cheerful, mischievous grin.

"Buuuut I'm pretty sure you'll all be fiiiiine. Good luck!"

She gave an energetic wave, spun dramatically on her heel, and headed toward the door.

Lunaria bowed her head gracefully.

"I wish you all the best. And good luck preparing for what's to come."

She turned and followed Kasumi out.

Iroha, Yachiyo, and Mitama laughed softly and called after them.

"Take care!"

"See you soon!"

"Thank you again!"

The door closed behind Lunaria and Kasumi.

Mitama let out a breath and smiled.

"There's never a dull moment with those two."

Yachiyo nodded.

"True. But we should start planning for the Wings' activation soon."

Before she could continue—

Grrrrrgle.

Iroha's stomach growled loudly.

The room went silent — and then all three burst into laughter.

Ui chirped playfully, tail flicking.

Iroha rubbed her stomach sheepishly.

"How about we get something to eat first? Maybe... that teppanyaki place from Ui's memories?"

She smiled.

"I didn't really get to enjoy it back then. But this time will be different."

Ui perked up instantly, tail wagging so fast it blurred.

Yachiyo and Mitama exchanged warm smiles.

"That sounds wonderful," Yachiyo said.

"I haven't been there in a long time," Mitama added.

With Ui perched proudly on her shoulder, Iroha headed for the door — Yachiyo and Mitama walking beside her.

Their voices blended into easy, cheerful conversation as they stepped into the afternoon light, heading toward a meal they could enjoy together.

Chapter 7: Dream-realm training

Dream-Kyoko, Mami, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe soared through the skies of the dream-realm — an endless expanse of deep cerulean washed in molten gold. Clouds drifted lazily in hues of rose, amber, and peach, glowing like illuminated silk unfurled across the heavens. Floating islands hung suspended like jewels. Far below, pink clouds churned like oceans of rose-colored fabric, glowing faintly in the eternal light.

Dream-Kyoko took a massive bite from a multicolored magical skewer, speaking before she'd even finished chewing.

“So—how’s the food here?”

Mami laughed, her voice bright in the open sky.

“Kyoko, only you would ask about the food first. Shouldn’t you also ask what we think of the dream-realm itself? This place would shock anyone seeing it for the first time.”

She gave Kyoko a teasing smirk.

“And how many times have I told you not to talk with your mouth full?”

Kyoko snorted and took another bite.

“The food’s the best part! And you’re not my mom, so I can do whatever I want.”

She deliberately spoke with her mouth full again, just to prove it.

Mami sighed fondly and spun once in the air, letting the wind catch her ribbons.

“This place really does feel like heaven... When I Connected with you before our fight with Kasumi, I saw this. But being here fully...”

She smiled softly.

“It’s even more beautiful.”

Momoko zoomed past them in a blur of pink and gold, looping and spiraling wildly through the sky.

“WOOOOOO! Flying like this is AWESOME! This is way better than anything on Earth!”

She spun upside down mid-air.

“I wanna explore everything — every island, every cloud, every weird magical thing!”

Mifuyu and Kuroe chuckled at her unrestrained joy.

“She looks like a little kid,” Mifuyu said warmly. “It’s nice to see her like this.”

Mifuyu reached out and brushed her hand through a rosy cloud. Her fingers passed through it effortlessly — warm, soft, comforting, like dipping her hand into a dream.

“This place really *is* a dream,” she murmured. “I wonder who created it...”

Kuroe drifted closer, eyes wide as she watched groups of magical girls, witches, monsters, and mythical beings flying together in peaceful harmony.

“I wish I could bring Iroha and everyone from Mikazuki Villa here,” she said softly.

“It would be nice... to fly together like that.”

Kyoko groaned loudly.

“Wow, nobody wants to talk about the food?”

She licked a magical ice-cream cone — the cone shimmering like carved crystal, the scoop releasing a sparkling, icy mist.

Mami, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe laughed and finally indulged her, their voices overlapping in a bright, chaotic chorus.

Mami lifted a delicate, translucent fruit that hovered just above her palm.

“I tried these floating fruits,” she said, letting it drift upward before plucking it from the air. “They taste like... memories. Warm ones. I bit into one and suddenly remembered the first time I brewed tea for you, Kyoko.”

Kyoko choked on her ice-cream cone.

“Wh—HEY! Why’d *that* memory show up?!”

Mami only smiled sweetly.

“Because it was precious to me.”

Momoko nearly collided with them as she waved a bowl of shimmering noodles.

“And these noodles! They change flavor depending on your mood!”

She slurped a strand, eyes sparkling.

“Right now they taste like... excitement! And a little bit of ‘I’m-about-to-do-something-dangerous-but-fun.’”

Kyoko snorted.

“I’m pretty sure that’s just your default flavor.”

Momoko stuck her tongue out mid-air and spun away laughing.

Mifuyu held a small pastry that glowed faintly with every breath she took.

“I tried these,” she said, voice soft with wonder. “They glow brighter the more you appreciate them. It’s like they respond to happiness.”

She took a bite, and the pastry pulsed with gentle light.

“It’s... comforting. Like being wrapped in a warm blanket.”

Kyoko raised an eyebrow.

“Figures you’d pick the fancy, polite dessert.”

Mifuyu smiled serenely.

“And you’d pick the one that stains your tongue seven different colors.”

Kyoko stuck out her tongue — indeed rainbow-striped — and grinned proudly.

Kuroe, meanwhile, held a small cup of something swirling with stardust.

“I, um... tried this drink,” she said shyly. “It tastes different every time. Like... possibilities.”

She took a tiny sip, eyes widening.

“Oh! Now it tastes like... courage. And... cinnamon?”

Momoko burst out laughing.

“Kuroe, you’re adorable! Only you would describe a drink as ‘courage.’”

Kuroe flushed, but smiled.

“It really does taste like that...”

Kyoko crossed her arms, satisfied.

“So. Everyone happy with the dream-realm so far? Food and all?”

Mami giggled behind her hand.

“Very.”

Momoko pumped a fist.

“Super happy!”

Mifuyu nodded.

“It’s wonderful.”

Kuroe added softly,

“I’ve never tasted anything like this...”

Kyoko grinned, unmistakably pleased.

After a moment, Mami turned to Kyoko.

“So... we’re heading to the coliseum island to train, right? What exactly will we be doing?”

Kyoko nodded.

“Yep. That’s the plan.”

She looked at Mami, Mifuyu, and Momoko with a confident grin.

“We’re training for your plan to save Sayaka.”

She turned to Mifuyu and Momoko, her tone sharpening with purpose.

“I’ll let the coliseum corrupt my Soul Gem using Umbra’s power. Both of you will attune to it and share the negativity — just like when you saved the doppelified magical girls.”

Momoko nodded immediately.

“Got it.”

Mifuyu’s gaze steadied.

“I can handle that.”

Kyoko continued, glancing at Mami.

“And you’ll take that negativity and convert it however you want. That way, none of us break.”

Mami smiled, resolute.

“Sounds like a good plan, partner.”

Mami tilted her head slightly.

“Do you think it will work? Lunaria and Kasumi didn’t give us any straight answers.”

Kyoko shrugged with a grin.

“You’ll find out once we start training.”

Mami groaned dramatically.

“Oh no. Not you too.”

She narrowed her eyes playfully.

“Either Lunaria and Kasumi are rubbing off on you... or you don’t know the answer and you’re trying to impress us.”

Kyoko smirked.

“Heh... I’m not the same mentee you remember.”

Kuroe drifted closer, hesitant but determined.

“What about me? What kind of training will I do? I want to help Mami too.”

Kyoko’s grin widened.

“You’ve got **special training** prepared just for you. And don’t worry — it’ll help.”

Kuroe blinked, curiosity and nerves swirling in her chest.

Mami raised an eyebrow.

“Special training? Is it like all the ‘special training’ I got thrown into ever since I came here? All the times Lunaria and Kasumi pushed me off the deep end?”

Kuroe stiffened, eyes widening.

I am a weak magical girl... What I cannot handle it?

Mami noticed immediately and laughed gently.

“Kuroe, don’t worry. The training might overwhelm you, but you’ll grow a lot. That’s just how things work here. Just try your best, and most importantly — have fun!”

Kyoko nodded enthusiastically.

“And after training, we hit the onsen. Dream-realm style — magical healing, magical relaxation, the works.”

“Oooooo a magical onsen. Sign me up!” Momoko cheered.

“I loved the onsen back at Hotel Faint Hope. I wonder how the dream-realm one compares,” Mifuyu smiled.

Kuroe’s nerves eased into excitement.

“Something fun to look forward to after training.”

Together, the five of them angled their wings and soared toward the distant coliseum island — a massive floating arena where all sorts of battles took place, waiting for them like a challenge issued by the heavens themselves.

As the coliseum island came into view, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe all gasped at once.

Momoko’s jaw dropped.

Mifuyu’s eyes widened in awe.

Kuroe’s breath caught in her throat.

It was nothing like what they had imagined.

Mami chuckled softly.

“It’s just as beautiful as when I saw it through Kyoko’s memories. Maybe even more so in person.”

The island rose like a floating continent carved from marble and starlight. Vast terraces spiraled upward, each one a blend of nature and architecture — crystalline waterfalls cascading off the edges, drifting upward instead of down; lush gardens blooming with impossible colors; stone pathways lined with glowing runes that pulsed like heartbeats.

The coliseum itself crowned the island:

A colossal circular structure of white stone veined with gold, its arches open to the sky. Vines of shimmering blue flora wrapped around the pillars, blooming with flowers that glowed like lanterns. The entire structure radiated warmth, life, and a sense of ancient grandeur — as if it had existed long before magical girls ever dreamed.

Above it all, floating platforms orbited lazily like satellites, each hosting separate arenas, training grounds, observation decks, or resting spaces.

It was breathtaking.

From the coliseum summit, the sounds of battle drifted through the air — bursts of magic, laughter, shouts of strategy.

A massive battlefield stretched across the arena floor — not a single terrain, but many woven together. Forests bled into open plains. Shimmering ponds reflected spellfire. Rocky ridges rose beside rolling hills. The land *shifted* subtly as battles progressed, reshaping itself to respond to the fighters within it.

Magical girls darted between trees.

Witches vaulted across boulders.

Monsters roared, legends clashed, and magic flared in brilliant arcs.

Momoko's eyes sparkled.

"Whoa—this is the team battle royale you talked about?!"

Kyoko grinned.

"Yep. Pretty intense, right?"

Momoko stared, mesmerized.

"Intense? This looks like a full-on war! I wanna try this with Rena and Kaede! They'd lose their minds!"

Mifuyu clasped her hands together, eyes shining.

"I want to come here with Yachiyo... and with Mel and Kanae, if their essences are here. To fight together again... even just once."

Kuroe hugged her arms to her chest, smiling softly.

"I want to team up with Iroha. And everyone from Mikazuki Villa. I think... it would be really fun."

Kyoko laughed.

"Looks like the Kamihama girls are fired up."

She turned to Mami.

"And you, Mami? Interested in trying this sometime?"

Mami smiled, warm and thoughtful.

"Yes. It looks like a perfect test of magic, tactics, and teamwork."

She paused.

"If I did... I'd want to go with you and Sayaka."

Her gaze softened.

"And Homura — though I'm not sure she'd agree. She's... distant."

A faint smile touched her lips.

"And if Madoka ever becomes a magical girl... then her as well."

Kyoko's expression softened.

I'm looking forward to that.

They descended toward the entrance terrace — a wide platform of polished stone interwoven with living vines and glowing flowers.

The path to the coliseum was lined with statues: magical girls frozen mid-cast, witches mid-transformation, monsters mid-roar. Some were familiar. Others felt ancient. Each shimmered faintly, as if holding echoes of battles long past.

Floating lanterns drifted overhead, trailing ribbons of light.
The air hummed with magic, warm and welcoming.

Springs fed clear channels that wound through walkways, their surfaces shimmering with faint magical glyphs. Fountains shaped like motifs of magical girls — bows, shields, ribbons — breathed streams of water that glowed faintly, as if alive.

All around them, magical girls, witches, monsters, and mythical beings mingled freely — stretching, laughing, chatting, preparing for matches, or unwinding after them.

As Kyoko and Mami walked by, several people waved enthusiastically.

“Kyoko! Mami! Your fight against Kasumi’s clone earlier was amazing!”

“You two had such great teamwork!”

“The moves you used — so cool!”

Kyoko grinned and waved back.

“Thanks! Glad you liked it!”

Mami bowed politely, cheeks faintly pink.

“It means a lot. Thank you.”

She turned to Kyoko with a soft laugh.

“It seems we’re famous now.”

Kyoko smirked.

“Just wait. People are gonna start asking you to hang out and spar. Everyone here’s super chill — they love having fun.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe were greeted as well.

“Welcome to the dream-realm!”

“Good luck with your training!”

“You’ll love it here!”

Momoko waved excitedly.

“Thanks! We’re pumped!”

Mifuyu bowed gracefully.

“We appreciate the warm welcome.”

Kuroe smiled shyly.

“Thank you... we’ll do our best.”

They stepped through the grand archway — and the lobby opened before them like a world unto itself.

Mami, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe all stopped in their tracks.

The space was vast, airy, and impossibly beautiful.

The lobby was vast and open, yet intimate — as if it expanded gently around whoever entered.

Towering pillars rose into the air, wrapped in luminous vines. Murals of living light flowed across walls and ceiling, shifting scenes of battles, bonds, triumphs, and loss like slow-moving dreams.

Statues filled alcoves and balconies — magical girls, witches, monsters, legends — frozen mid-motion, mid-fight.

Crystalline pools reflected the ceiling like mirrors, their surfaces rippling with faint magic. Floating platforms glided silently between levels, carrying visitors to different wings: arenas, training halls, lounges, gardens, onsens, recovery chambers.

Despite the crowds, the space never felt overwhelming. It *breathed*.

Kyoko stepped forward and turned back to the group, spreading her arms wide.

“Well,” she said with a grin.

“Here we are.”

Mami, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe wandered through the coliseum lobby, marveling at every detail — the glowing murals, the floating platforms gliding silently overhead, the living statues, the crystalline pools that rippled with magic.

Momoko pressed her face against a floating window of light.

“Look! This one shows a replay of someone’s match! That’s so cool!”

Mifuyu traced a vine of luminous flowers curling around a pillar.

“The craftsmanship here is... exquisite. Every detail feels intentional.”

Kuroe stared up at a mural of magical girls soaring through a star-filled sky, the stars shifting as if breathing.

“It feels like... everything here is alive.”

Mami smiled warmly at their wonder.

“It’s easy to get swept up in it. This place is beautiful.”

Kyoko laughed, hands on her hips.

“Alright, alright — don’t get *too* carried away. We’ve got training to do if we’re gonna save Sayaka. You’ll have plenty of time to explore later.”

Mami turned toward the floating platforms drifting overhead.

“Do we need to use those to reach our training area?”

Kyoko shook her head.

“We can. Most people use them when they’re exploring or hanging out. But you can fly inside the coliseum too — same as what we did outside.”

She jerked her thumb toward a glowing circle etched into the floor nearby.

“But since we’ve got a plan, we’ll use *this*.”

The magic circle shimmered to life — moons, planets, and stars swirling in a miniature cosmos carved into the stone.

Kyoko grinned.

“Step in. This’ll warp us straight to our training zones.”

Mami, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe exchanged glances, then stepped into the circle. It lit up beneath their feet, runes flaring to life.

Kyoko hopped in last.

“Alright! Here we go!”

Light swallowed them whole.

Kuroe’s training – Regret

Kuroe landed alone.

Her breath hitched.

Cold tiles beneath her boots.

Flickering fluorescent lights.

The distant rumble of an approaching train.

Takarazaki Station.

Her heart slammed painfully against her ribs.

“No...” she whispered.

This place.

The place where she abandoned Kuro.

The moment she regretted more than anything.

The memory her Doppel had torn open just yesterday.

“K-Kyoko?” Her voice echoed. “Mami? Momoko? Mifuyu?”

No answer.

The silence pressed in on her.

She took a shaky step forward, hugging her arms to her chest.

“Is... is this part of the ‘special training’ Kyoko mentioned...?”

A voice answered from behind her.

“Kuroe.”

Her blood ran cold.

That voice —

Kuro’s voice —

but layered with something warped, echoing, inhuman.

A witch’s voice.

Kuroe froze. Sweat prickled her skin.

N-no... did Kuro... become a witch because of me? Because I didn’t help her?

She turned slowly.

And gasped.

Kuro stood there — or something shaped like her — wrapped in swirling negativity and despair. Her eyes burned with accusation.

“K-Kuro...?” Kuroe whispered, voice trembling.

Kuro cut her off sharply.

“You abandoned me when I needed you most.”

Her voice was doubled — human and witch layered together.

“And look what happened. I broke. I became a witch. Alone. With no one to help me. No one to care.”

Her gaze sharpened.

“This is all your fault.”

Kuroe staggered back as if struck.

The same nightmares surged up — the same ones her Doppel had used to drown her in regret.

But then — Lunaria’s words surfaced, steady and clear.

Life — your life, and the lives of all magical girls — is beautiful. Precious. No matter how many regrets, mistakes, or heroic deeds you carry.

You don't need to earn happiness. You're free to feel it. To embrace it.

Kuroe swallowed hard and forced herself to straighten.

"I... I regret what I did," she said, voice shaking. "It still haunts me. But I want to move forward. I want to learn from it. I want to be better — to make sure I abandon someone like that again."

Kuro scoffed.

"And what about me?"

Her voice twisted, bitter.

"I was left alone to suffer. I became a witch. And now you're here — happy, surrounded by friends."

Kuroe flinched.

Kuro stepped closer, eyes narrowing.

"How is that fair?"

Kuroe's legs shook. Her vision blurred — just like yesterday, when her Doppel was taking over her.

"I... I became a witch too," Kuroe whispered. "Because of this. Because of what I did. I suffered too."

Kuro laughed — a warped, echoing sound.

"And now look at you. Safe. Supported. Loved. Not dealing with the consequences of becoming a witch."

Her smile twisted into something cruel.

"I can't stand it."

She raised her hand.

"Justice needs to be served."

A wave of negativity and despair surged toward Kuroe, swallowing her whole.

Kuroe squeezed her eyes shut—

—and the world **collapsed**.

When she opened her eyes, she fell to her knees.

Her breath left her in a sharp gasp.

Before her stood six towering silhouettes — monstrous, elegant, terrifying.

Thornaria.
Velmira.
Ruinelle.
Catastrophä.
Noctulisse.
Vexaphra.

The six witches from her dream last night.
The six witches Mami and Kyoko had fought together in that dream.

Kuroe's mouth fell open.

"...Is this my punishment?" she whispered.

Her heart pounded painfully.

"To fight all six of them... alone?"

She stared up at the towering figures.

"What kind of training is this...?"

Kuroe's breath came in short, panicked bursts.

She spun in place, searching desperately for a magical circle — any glowing sigil, any escape route, any hint of Kyoko's "special training" being something survivable.

There was nothing.

Only the six towering witches, their monstrous silhouettes blotting out the sky.

Her stomach twisted.

I can't fight one witch alone... let alone six...

Her hands trembled as she manifested her twin batons.

Her palms were slick with sweat.

Her knees shook beneath her.

But she forced herself into a stance anyway.

"I... I have to try..."

She hurled both batons with all her strength.

But they didn't even reach their targets.

Catastrophä — the colossal storm-colossus — lazily flicked her hand.

A gust of red-black wind tore through the air, blasting the batons aside as if they were toys. They struck the ground and detonated harmlessly, their explosions swallowed by the storm.

Kuroe's heart sank.

"She... she deflected them like they were nothing..."

She barely had time to breathe before Thornaria reacted.

A forest of thorned vines erupted from the ground, lashing toward her with serpentine hunger.

Kuroe slammed new batons into the floor, conjuring a wall reinforced with magic.

The vines struck it —

—and immediately burrowed into it.

They grew.

They split.

They multiplied into dozens of writhing tendrils.

"What—?!"

The wall burst apart as vines lunged straight for her.

Kuroe hurled her batons again, detonating them mid-air.

Violent flashes lit the station in blinding bursts of light.

But the vines barely slowed.

Kuroe panicked.

She turned and ran, sprinting across the platform as thorned tendrils ripped through the ground behind her, shattering tiles and snapping pillars like twigs.

Then—

WHAM.

Something invisible slammed into her torso.

Kuroe flew backward, rolling across the tiles, pain exploding through her lungs.

"V-Vexaphra...!"

The Vanishing Blade witch flickered into view for a split second — a jagged insectoid blur — before disappearing again.

Kuroe scrambled to her feet—

And froze.

Her legs wouldn't move.

She looked down.

Her feet had sunk into the floor — the tiles liquefied around her boots, then hardened like cement.

Catastroph's influence.

“No—no no no—!”

She looked up just in time to see Thornaria’s vines descending.

“STOP—!”

The vines wrapped around her torso, arms, legs — binding her tight.

Thorns pierced her skin.

Blood trickled down her limbs.

Kuroe screamed as the vines constricted, crushing the air from her lungs.

Then Ruinelle slithered close.

Her segmented, glass-like body coiled around Kuroe, leaking corruption into the air itself.

Darkness seeped into Kuroe’s lungs.

Into her thoughts.

Into the rhythm of her heartbeat.

It was suffocating.

Her vision blurred.

Her hope dimmed.

Then Velmira descended.

A cyclone of red-black wind and screaming spirits swallowed her whole.

The spirits circled Kuroe, whispering in warped, demonic voices:

“Useless.”

“Weak.”

“You failed her.”

“You deserve to be a witch.”

“You deserve to be hated.”

“You deserve to be alone.”

Kuroe sobbed, shaking violently.

“Please—stop—please—!”

She didn’t want to be a witch.

She didn’t want to hurt anyone.

She didn’t want to be hated by the people she loved.

Then the shadows thickened.

Noctulisse’s presence swallowed what little light remained.

And from the darkness... Kuro appeared.

Or rather — an illusion of Kuro, twisted by despair.

Her eyes glowed with cruelty.

Her voice dripped venom.

“This suits you better, Kuroe.”

Kuroe’s breath hitched.

“Bound. Bleeding. Crying. Breaking. Alone.”

Kuro stepped closer, smiling coldly.

“Just like I was.”

Kuroe sobbed harder.

“I’m sorry... I’m so sorry... please... please stop...”

Kuro tilted her head.

“Pathetic. You survived this long only because you leaned on others. Hypocrite. After abandoning me.”

Kuro’s gaze dropped to Kuroe’s right thigh — to her soul gem.

She reached out and plucked it free.

“My soul gem shattered,” Kuro said softly. “I became a witch.”

She held Kuroe’s gem between two fingers.

“And since you’re begging me to end this... I’ll grant your wish.”

Kuroe’s eyes widened in horror.

“No—DON’T—!”

Kuro smiled.

And crushed the gem.

It shattered like glass.

Kuroe went limp, dangling from the vines.

Her breath stilled.

Her heartbeat slowed.

She waited for death.

Waited for the darkness to swallow her.

Waited to disappear.

...

But nothing happened.

She remained conscious.

Alive.

Barely.

Her eyes fluttered open.

Kuro was smiling at her.

Kuroe's voice cracked.

"W-why... why am I still alive...?"

Then she remembered Lunaria's words:

Fights here are real, but not permanent.

No lasting wounds. No death.

Kuroe swallowed.

"Is... is that why...?"

Kuro chuckled.

"Not quite."

She leaned in.

"You're unaffected because you're not a magical girl anymore."

Kuroe froze.

"You're a witch, Kuroe."

Her heart stopped.

Kuro continued, voice soft:

"You became a witch yesterday. Lunaria didn't turn you back. She pulled your soul out of despair and brought you here."

Kuroe's mind reeled.

"I... I'm... a witch...?"

Before she could process it—

Kuro dissolved into dark, swirling sparkles.

The six witches behind her began to unravel as well — their monstrous forms breaking apart into spirals of red-black, green, violet, and shadow.

The sparkles gathered in front of Kuroe, forming six silhouettes.

The silhouettes brightened.

Softened.

Shifted.

And then—

Six girls stood before her.

Not witches.

Not monsters.

But the six original magical girls — in their pure, untainted forms.

The first girl stood with her hair flowing as if caught in a constant breeze, long strands lifting and curling around her shoulders. A light cloak fluttered behind her, torn at the edges but mended with care. Around her drifted faint, translucent shapes — spirits, wisps of memory and wind that circled her gently, never touching, never leaving. Her expression was calm, but her eyes carried the weight of voices long unheard.

The second girl hovered just above the ground, toes barely grazing reality. Trails of soft light followed her movements — ribbons of gold, pale blue, and shifting hues that pulsed faintly with emotion. Her outfit resembled a dancer's costume, elegant and flowing, and even standing still she seemed mid-motion, as if the world itself struggled to keep up with her.

The third girl stood grounded and steady, her attire marked with storm motifs — clouded patterns, lightning-shaped accents, and rain-dark fabric that never seemed wet. The air around her hummed faintly, charged but controlled. Power slept beneath her calm exterior, vast and restrained, like a storm waiting for permission rather than release.

The fourth girl knelt instinctively near Kuroe, though she did not touch her. Flowers bloomed wherever her feet rested — not violently, but naturally, as if responding to her presence. Her outfit was soft in color, earth-toned and gentle, and her aura radiated warmth. Even without speaking, she felt like a quiet promise of renewal.

The fifth girl lingered slightly apart from the others. Her shadow stretched unnaturally long behind her, curling and shifting with subtle independence — not threatening, but aware. Her eyes were sharp and observant, her expression thoughtful, as if she'd spent years listening to truths others were afraid to face.

The sixth girl flickered faintly at the edges, her form phasing in and out of clarity like a breath between moments. One instant she was solid, the next partially translucent, as though reality had trouble holding onto her. Her clothing shimmered like a mirage, and her presence felt elusive but gentle — someone who existed between worlds, yet still belonged.

They all looked at Kuroe with warm smiles.

For a long moment, Kuroe could only stare.

The six girls stood before her like the first light of dawn after a night of unending storms — warm, steady, impossibly gentle. Where moments ago the air had been thick with despair and screaming spirits, now it felt lighter, as if the world itself had exhaled. The tight ache in her chest eased, though her thoughts still spun in dizzy circles.

They didn't feel like witches.

They felt... human.

The girl surrounded by drifting spirits stepped forward first. Her hair stirred in an unseen wind, strands lifting and falling as if breathing along with her. Her eyes were calm — old, but kind.

"It's nice to meet you, Kuroe," she said softly. Then, after a small pause, "Or rather... it's nice to meet you, **Ichizo**."

The name struck deep — not painful, but intimate. Yet there was no accusation in the girl's voice. No fear. Only quiet recognition, as if acknowledging something that had always been there.

Ichizo... my witch's name.

Then that soul gem was fake?

And I'm standing here — human — talking to witches who can do the same?

Is this because we're in the dream-realm...? Or something else entirely...?

She must have looked completely overwhelmed, because suddenly—

They laughed.

Not sharp. Not cruel. But soft, musical laughter — like older sisters amused by a younger sibling who had tripped over her own thoughts. The sound loosened something knotted tight inside her.

The wind-spirit girl placed a hand over her chest. Small spirit-lights drifted beside her like fireflies.

"I am known as **Velmira**, the Howling Spiral," she said. "But before that... I was **Kazehara Tamashii**."

The floating dancer rose slightly, ribbons of soft color trailing lazily behind her like paint in water.

"**Ruinelle** the Fractured Path," she chimed. "Though my real name is **Akari Suzume**."

A girl with bright clouds hovering faintly around her bowed with composed dignity.

"**Catastroph**a the Skybreaker. Once, I was **Kaminari Shizuku**."

Near her, flowers bloomed quietly at another girl's feet — fresh, vivid, alive. She smiled with gentle warmth.

“**Thornaria** the Blooming Maw,” she said. “But I was **Hakura Airi**.”

A girl stepped forward whose shadow didn't quite obey the light, curling and stretching like a living thing at her heels.

“**Noctulisse** the Dream-Eater. My name is **Kageura Yume**.”

And finally, a girl flickered into full clarity — as if reality itself had to focus to keep her there. She offered a small, shy wave.

“**Vexaphra** the Vanishing Blade... though I was born **Kisaragi Mio**.”

Each name settled into the air with quiet weight. Not the weight of tragedy — but of identity reclaimed.

Suzume drifted in a playful loop around Kuroe, peering at her face.

“You're making *that* face,” she said cheerfully. “The ‘I have about a hundred questions and don't know where to start’ face.”

Tamashii stepped closer, her presence calm and grounding.

“You already know part of the truth,” she said. “Magical girls are fated to become witches. When a soul gem shatters, a grief seed is born.”

Kuroe nodded faintly.

“Yes... that's common knowledge in Kamihama.”

Shizuku folded her hands in front of her.

“You're wondering whether Lunaria truly saved you,” she said. “Or if Kuro was right.”

Kuroe swallowed.

“She saved me from despair... but not from becoming a witch. That's what Kuro said.”

Airi's smile softened, filled with compassion.

“Both are true,” she said gently. “Lunaria used **Dis-Connect** to siphon despair from your soul — to pull you back from total collapse.”

Yume's voice followed, quiet but unyielding.

“But becoming a witch is irreversible. That transformation cannot be undone.”

Kuroe's breath trembled.

“Then... the soul gem I had. The one Kuro crushed—”

Akari raised a hand, grinning.

“Fake!” she said brightly. “Convincing, though, wasn’t it?”

Tamashii nodded, clearly amused.

“We needed you to experience that moment — to see that its destruction would not end you.”

Shizuku smirked slightly.

“And, admittedly, to make the reveal more dramatic. People in the dream-realm love theatrics.”

Suzume covered her mouth, failing miserably to hide her laughter.

“You should’ve seen your face! You looked like you were ready to fade out of existence.”

Kuroe puffed her cheeks, flustered.

“That was *terrifying* and incredibly mean! Couldn’t you have done it more gently?!”

She paused, then sighed.

“...Though Mami *did* say that she keeps getting thrown into overwhelming ‘special training’ here.”

The six girls laughed again — warm, easy, comforting.

“Oh, definitely,” Akari said.

Shizuku smirked.

“And Mami, Momoko, and Mifuyu? They’re probably panicking right now.”

Airi clasped her hands.

“You’ll all have plenty to talk about later.”

Kuroe let out a quiet, breathy laugh — the first since this trial began.

The training Kyoko planned for Mami, Momoko, and Mifuyu sounded very straight forward... what could possibly overwhelm them?

Kuroe looked back at them, eyes earnest.

“So... if I’m a witch now... what does that mean for my life? I still think like myself. I still feel like me. I used my magical girl abilities earlier. Can I... switch? Like you?”

The six exchanged glances, then nodded.

Tamashii spoke first.

“Yes. In this form, you are nearly identical to a magical girl — save for the absence of a soul gem.”

Airi continued gently.

“Magical girls are strongest when their hearts are clear. Negativity weakens them... unless they learn to master it.”

Shizuku leaned forward.

“But witches are a bit different.”

Kuroe leaned in, curiosity overtaking fear.

“How... different?”

Yume’s shadow curled softly around her feet.

“Witches are despair incarnate. Curses given form.”

Mio flickered, her voice soft.

“To reach your full potential, you must dive into your negativity and face it head-on.”

Akari tapped Kuroe’s forehead lightly.

“You’re calm now. At peace. That boosted your magical girl abilities. Your attacks were stronger than they ever were back on Earth.”

Suzume grinned.

“But you probably did not notice, since you were overwhelmed in that fight.”

Kuroe puffed her cheeks again.

“I was fighting *all six of you* at once. That was absolutely unfair.”

Then her expression softened.

“But... you’re all incredibly strong. Stronger than any witch I’ve ever seen.”

She looked at them, hope flickering.

“...Are you saying I can become like that?”

Airi smiled — warm and bright.

“Yup!” she said. “That is why you’re here after all!”

The six stood together before her.

“Shall we begin?”

Kuroe closed her eyes and took a steady breath.

When she opened them again, fear had given way to resolve.

“I’m ready.”

Kuroe's training – Witch

Mio tilted her head, her form flickering faintly at the edges.

“Kuroe,” she said gently, “yesterday — in the dream Lunaria gave you — you saw Mami’s and Kyoko’s punishment, didn’t you? When they had to fight all of us.”

Kuroe nodded, her expression tightening.

“Yes. I remember.”

Mio’s gaze softened, thoughtful.

“Then tell us... what did we look like before the fight began?”

Kuroe drew in a slow breath, letting the memory surface.

“You all looked... wrong. Corrupted. Your bodies were trembling, your magic felt distorted, twisted...”

She shuddered.

“And your soul gems...”

Her voice dropped.

“They were pitch black. So dark it felt like they were about to burst.”

She swallowed, the image still vivid.

“And then you all snapped. Your soul gems shattered. All that darkness exploded out of you... and then you became witches.”

Her brow furrowed as she looked at them.

“So... was all of that just for show? Those soul gems were fake too, right? Like the one Kuro crushed?”

Suzume flipped upside down in the air, clasping her hands behind her head.

“Yep! Totally fake. That whole scene was mostly for spectacle — a dramatic opening for the arena audience.”

She twirled once, ribbons of light trailing behind her.

“Six tragic girls, six shattered soul gems, six witches appearing at once? Perfect way to get everyone hyped!”

Kuroe couldn’t help the small smile that tugged at her lips.

“It was effective,” she admitted. “Going from the murals — six girls fighting six witches — straight into Mami and Kyoko fighting those same witches... it felt like history folding in on itself.”

Yume nodded, her shadow curling thoughtfully.

“Even staged moments can carry truth,” she said. “And that scene used the same principles we’ll be teaching you.”

Airi stepped forward and looked at Kuroe warmly.

“The reason we appeared corrupted wasn’t random,” she explained. “We deliberately embraced the despair we felt just before we became witches. We recalled it. Allowed it to surface.”

Kuroe’s breath caught.

She remembered her Doppel overtaking her.

The moment she became a witch.

The suffocating despair.

To willingly recall that...

To embrace it...

Her stomach tightened.

Tamashii noticed immediately.

“That’s why we showed you the illusion of Kuro,” she said gently. “And why the spirits whispered those awful things. We wanted you to feel what it’s like to relive the emotions that broke you.”

Kuroe let out a shaky laugh.

“Well... mission accomplished,” she said weakly. “Those nightmares I locked away — the ones my Doppel used to drown me — they all came rushing back.”

The six girls’ expressions softened, sadness flickering in their eyes.

Shizuku spoke quietly.

“That’s what all witches share. A despair so deep it breaks us. Memories we don’t want to relive... but can never escape.”

Mio’s voice followed, fragile but honest.

“Our families were executed because the villagers saw us using magic. They branded us as evil witches and hunted us down.”

Her form flickered once.

“We lost everything.”

Suzume gave a small, bittersweet laugh.

“Irony, isn’t it? They called us witches... before we became them. Before any of us knew the truth about magical girls.”

Yume folded her arms, her shadow shifting behind her.

“When we enter that corrupted state, our original magical girl abilities become infused with despair. They change. They gain new properties.”

Kuroe blinked.

“Is that like what Lunaria taught me this morning? About using negativity to amplify attacks? Like what Mami and Kyoko did against Kasumi?”

Airi nodded.

“Similar, but not the same. Magical girls convert negativity into power — they transform it into something usable.”

Shizuku continued:

“But witches don’t convert it. They *infuse* it directly into their magic. Their original abilities become twisted, corrupted, reshaped by the despair that broke them.”

Tamashii smiled:

“And this is the first part of your ‘special training.’ Accepting who you are now — a witch — and mastering it.”

Kuroe’s eyes widened.

She took a breath — then spoke, voice trembling but honest.

“I... always thought of myself as weak. I wanted to grow stronger so others could rely on me. Especially Iroha.”

Her fingers curled into fists.

“But no matter how hard I tried... I felt like I was always falling behind. Watching everyone else grow stronger while I struggled just to keep up.”

Her voice cracked.

“It felt inevitable. Like everyone would move on without me. Like I’d only ever hold them back.”

She swallowed hard.

“And Kuro... she was weaker than me. The first magical girl I met who was.”

Her gaze dropped.

“And I abandoned her.”

The six girls listened quietly — not judging, not pitying, simply present.

Kuroe lifted her head, something new burning in her eyes — not desperation, but resolve.

“But that ends now,” she said. “I walk a different path. As a witch.”

She placed a hand over her chest.

“I won’t try to be like Iroha, Yachiyo, or anyone else. I’ll grow strong in my own way.”

Her voice steadied.

“And I’ll help in the way only I can.”

Kuroe took a steadying breath.

“So... you said this is the *first part* of my special training. How does it go from here? Is there a lot left?”

Shizuku smiled, the faint clouds drifting around her brightening with a soft, reassuring glow.

“Oh yes,” she said warmly. “This was merely the tip of the iceberg.”

Kuroe leaned in, curiosity sparking.

“How different is this from what Lunaria taught me, Momoko, and Mifuyu this morning? How different is my path from theirs?”

Shizuku folded her arms thoughtfully.

“Once you learn to embrace your despair — to infuse it into your magic and wield the dark abilities that come with being a witch... you’ll be ready for the next step.”

She stepped closer. The clouds around her darkened, thickening.

“The step where you intentionally use that despair to *snap*”.

The word echoed.

The clouds above her head suddenly cracked with thunder — lightning flashing violently through them.

“EEP—!” Kuroe yelped, flinching backward.

Shizuku covered her mouth, giggling.

“Sorry! Couldn’t resist.”

Yume stepped forward, her shadow curling around her feet like ink.

“Kuroe,” she said evenly, “when you watched the simulation — when we fought Elira, Sylvette, Mirielle, Hoshine, and the two girls without soul gems — what did you notice? Anything different compared to when you fought us?”

Kuroe paused, replaying the memory.

“In that fight...” she said slowly, “you all acted like normal witches. Separate. Chaotic. Destructive.”

She looked up at them.

“But when you fought *me*... you worked together. Perfectly in sync. Like a team.”

Airi clapped her hands once, smiling brightly.

“Exactly! That’s the next step.”

Kuroe tilted her head.

“Next step...?”

“Yup!” Airi replied energetically. “To control yourself in your witch form. Not just existing as one — but *using* it. Fully. Intentionally.”

Tamashii stepped forward.

“Like this.”

She closed her eyes.

Negativity gathered around her, thick and heavy, like pressure before a storm. The air itself seemed to bend.

Kuroe held her breath.

Then—

Tamashii’s eyes snapped open and she screamed.

A shockwave of dark energy burst outward.

Kuroe braced herself, shielding her face — but forced herself to keep watching.

When the wave settled, her eyes widened.

Tamashii still stood in her human form...

But surrounding her was a massive spectral silhouette — her witch form, towering and half-transparent. Winds howled within it. Ghostly spirits spiraled around its limbs.

Tamashii grinned.

“Pretty cool, right?”

She lifted her hand.

Wind spiraled around her fingers — gentle, controlled.

Her witch avatar mirrored the motion, but with a violent, devouring cyclone.

The winds combined, forming an arcane vortex of light and darkness.

“Once you have enough control,” Tamashii explained, “you can use both your magical girl abilities *and* your witch abilities at the same time. And combine them like this.”

“Your witch avatar can also act as a shield,” she added. “A second body. A second arsenal.”

Kuroe gasped.

“I... I never imagined something like this was possible.”

“Oh, that’s not all,” Suzume chimed in, floating forward with a wink.

She gathered negativity around her — a soft, swirling darkness — and snapped.

Another wave of energy rippled outward.

When it faded, Suzume floated gracefully in place.

And beside her—

Her witch avatar hovered independently.

Suzume twirled mid-air, ribbons of color trailing behind her.

Her witch avatar spun in the opposite direction, leaving streaks of corrupted light.

They moved like dancers sharing a rhythm — separate, yet perfectly synchronized.

“This,” Suzume said cheerfully, “is the next level. Moving your human form and witch form independently.”

She and her witch avatar struck a pose.

“Combat options? Through the roof.”

Kuroe whispered, awestruck.

“That was... beautiful.”

She hesitated, then asked quietly:

“But... are there any drawbacks?”

Mio smiled softly.

“Good. You’re asking the right questions.”

She brought her hands together, darkness swirling around her flickering fingertips.

“A witch’s power scales with how much despair and negativity she can embrace.”

Yume nodded, her shadow tightening.

“If you take in more than you can control, you’ll lose yourself. You’ll become like the witches you fought on Earth — mindless, destructive, unreachable. You’ll become the Ichizo before Lunaria saved you.”

Kuroe shuddered.

The thought of losing herself again — of becoming that creature again — made her stomach twist.

“So... does that mean I have to stay in despair to be strong?” she asked. “Lunaria said magical girls are strongest when they’re calm, at peace, happy... that negativity shouldn’t be chased.”

Shizuku smiled reassuringly.

“She’s right. The same applies to witches. You should remain calm and at peace. Strive to live life happily and fully.”

She held out her hand. A soft cloud formed above it.

“You only embrace despair when you need to fight,” she said — and the cloud darkened, lightning crackling through it as winds swirled around her palm. “That’s the witch’s version of emotional control — the same principle Mami and Kyoko used against Kasumi.”

Airi added:

“And the other concepts Lunaria taught you still apply. You can choose how much despair to embrace for each situation. And once you’re more advanced...”

She lifted a finger.

“...you can increase the despair you channel *right at the moment your attack lands*. An explosive spike in power.”

Shizuku nodded.

“The ideal is to go right up to the edge — to the point where you’re about to lose yourself, but still have control. That’s when witches strongest.”

Kuroe let out a breathy laugh, shaking her head.

“The world of magic is... so vast,” she murmured. “So many paths. So many ways to wield the same emotions.”

Her eyes sparkled with excitement.

“Is there more?”

Suzume winked.

“Oh, there’s *plenty* more. Buuuuuut I think that’s enough for now.”

She gestured broadly.

“You’ve already got a mountain of training ahead of you!”

Suzume floated closer, ribbons of light swaying gently behind her.

“Alright, Ichizo,” she said with a playful but encouraging smile. “Your turn. Try it. Recall the moment you broke. The moment you lost yourself. Let yourself *feel* it again.”

Kuroe’s breath caught.

She closed her eyes.

Inside her mind, thoughts collided — fear, determination, doubt, longing.

I want to get stronger...

I want to help others...

But...

The memory of losing herself to her Doppel — the drowning despair, the crushing regret, the voices echoing through her soul — made her chest tighten.

Her body trembled.

But she clenched her fists.

She inhaled deeply.

Exhaled slowly.

Again.

And again.

Her shoulders loosened.

Her heartbeat steadied.

Then — with a quiet, trembling resolve — she allowed her despair and regret to seep back into her heart.

And immediately—

A distorted voice whispered behind her ear.

“Well, well... look who’s slipping again.”

Kuroe’s eyes flew open — but she didn’t turn.

She didn’t need to.

Her Doppel — wearing Kuro’s face, with muddy black wings unfurled behind her — slid her hands onto Kuroe’s shoulders from behind. The wings wrapped around her like a suffocating embrace.

The voice was Kuro’s.

And not Kuro’s.

Layered. Warped. Distorted.

“How unexpected,” the Doppel purred. “To see you succumbing to despair again.”

Black mud dripped from the wings, oozing down Kuroe’s arms, her legs, her chest — just like the day before, when the Doppel slowly consumed her.

“You were lucky last time,” the Doppel whispered, breath icy against her ear. “That Lunaria woman pulled you out. The way she talked to you made me sick.”

The wings tightened.

“All that nonsense about your life being precious... about happiness... about friends...”

Kuroe's breath hitched.

"But next time you lose yourself?"

The Doppel's voice sharpened.

"There won't be anything left to save. I'll make sure of it."

Kuroe felt her consciousness slipping — her heart heavy, her soul dimming, her sense of self dissolving.

No... not again...

Her Doppel's presence pressed harder, smothering her.

But this time—

Kuroe pushed back.

Not with her voice — but with her thoughts.

No. Not this time.

The Doppel paused, amused.

"Oh?"

Kuroe steadied herself.

I'm letting despair in so I can master it. So I can help others. You will not take over me this time.

Her Doppel laughed — a jagged, mocking sound. The muddy wings flapped with cruel delight.

"That's rich," she sneered. "You? Master this? Do you even remember who you are?"

The Doppel circled around her slowly, predatory.

"You're weak. You relied on the Wings of the Magius to survive. You needed Lunaria to save you. You've never done anything on your own."

Kuroe flinched.

Every word was true.

But she lifted her head.

I'm different now.

The Doppel raised an eyebrow.

"How so? You are still what you became yesterday, Ichizo. A witch."

The words dripped with cruelty — nothing like the way Tamashii, Suzume, Shizuku, Airi, Yume, and Mio had spoken them.

But Kuroe would not be deterred.

Lunaria showed me a new way to live. One where I don't have to be a slave to despair. And besides... Her thoughts turned to Tamashii, Suzume, Shizuku, Airi, Yume, and Mio. They're witches too. And they overcame the despair that broke them. If they can do it... so can I.

The Doppel clicked her tongue.

“Heh. Those six? They’re not weak like you,” she said. “Remember? You were the weakest magical girl you knew.”

She leaned in, face inches from Kuroe’s.

“Until you met Kuro.”

Her smile sharpened.

“Let’s see if your bravado lasts... when you see what really happened to Kuro after you abandoned her.”

Before Kuroe could react, the Doppel cupped her cheeks with both hands.

Pain — sharp, searing — spread outward as an intricate sigil formed on her neck. Two black feathered wings appeared as if drawn by invisible hands, lines etching themselves in glowing darkness before filling with inky shadow.

A witch’s kiss.

Then, the world shattered.

Tiles cracked.

Light fractured.

Reality splintered like glass.

Kuroe gasped as the dream-realm dissolved around her.

Ahead of her — a scene formed.

Takarazaki Station.

Herself, younger, running away.

Kuro behind her, waving, smiling, wishing her well.

Kuroe’s heart plummeted.

“No...” she whispered.

The moment she had always feared.

She tried to turn away.

She tried to run.

She squeezed her eyes shut.

But no matter what she did — the scene remained in front of her.

Inescapable.

She collapsed to her knees, tears spilling down her cheeks.

“No... please... stop... I can’t... I can’t watch this...”

Somewhere out of sight, her Doppel’s laughter echoed — cold, triumphant.

“That’s more like it,” she purred.

“This is the Kuroe I know.”

The laughter softened into a cruel whisper.

“Let’s see how long it takes before you break.”

The station dissolved into darkness — then reformed into a labyrinth of living walls, pulsing with sickly color. The air felt thick, heavy, as if it resisted every breath.

Kuro stood alone at its center.

Her clothes were torn. Her breathing ragged. Her soul gem flickered weakly, dim with exhaustion.

A witch loomed before her — grotesque and misshapen, its body writhing as it shrieked. The sound rattled the labyrinth itself.

Kuro fought desperately.

She fired blasts of magic.

Dodged wildly.

Stumbled.

Forced herself back to her feet.

Again.

And again.

But she was spent.

Her magic sputtered.

Her movements slowed.

Each breath burned.

The witch lunged.

Kuro staggered back until her spine hit a wall of shifting flesh. She was cornered. Trapped. Her soul gem flickered weakly.

“No—no—no—!” she cried, squeezing her eyes shut.

The witch’s roar filled the labyrinth.

Then—

A different scream tore through the air.

Kuro opened her eyes in shock.

A spear had pierced straight through the witch's core. Its body convulsed once — then dissolved into smoke, the labyrinth unraveling like mist burned away by sunlight.

A grief seed clattered onto the ground.

Kuro reached for it—

—but another hand snatched it first.

A girl stepped into view.

Red hair.

A spear dripping with witch ichor.

A sharp, guarded gaze.

Kuroe's breath caught.

Kyoko.

Not the dream-Kyoko she had met.

Not the Kyoko who laughed and joked moments earlier.

This was the real Kyoko — the Kyoko Lunaria had described that morning.

The Kyoko who had severed ties with Mami.

The Kyoko who lived only for herself.

Kyoko glanced at Kuro, her expression unreadable.

“You okay?” she asked, voice flat but not unkind.

Kuro swallowed hard.

“Y-yes... thank you. You saved me.”

Kyoko shrugged, twirling her spear once before resting it on her shoulder.

“Name's Sakura Kyoko. You?”

“K-Kuro. Just... Kuro.”

Kyoko nodded.

“Well, Kuro, be careful. Someone may not save you next time.”

She turned to leave.

Kuro's hand shot out instinctively.

“W-wait!”

Kyoko paused, glancing back.

“Yeah?”

Kuro opened her mouth.

But nothing came out.

She couldn’t ask for the grief seed.

Not after Kyoko saved her.

Not when she had failed to defeat the witch herself.

Her throat tightened.

This is my chance! I... I have to ask... I cannot let it end like last time...

She bowed deeply, mustering every ounce of courage she had left.

“You’re really strong,” she said, voice trembling. “Would you... would you be willing to work with me?”

Kyoko didn’t respond.

Kuro rushed on, words spilling out.

“We could fight witches together. Share grief seeds. I... I’d really like to have someone by my side.”

Kyoko stared at her.

For a moment, something flickered in her eyes — something old, something wounded.

But she turned away.

“Sorry,” she said. “I fight for myself. I look out for myself. That’s how magical girls survive.”

Her tone wasn’t cruel.

It wasn’t warm either.

Just... hallow.

“If that’s all, I’ll be going.”

She walked away.

Kuro lifted her head, forcing a smile through the ache in her chest.

“Thank you again!” she called after her. “Please... stay safe!”

Kyoko didn’t respond.

But her grip on her spear tightened — just slightly.

A memory tugged at her.

Someone.

A time when she wasn't alone.

A time when she was happy.

She shook the thought off and kept walking.

When she disappeared from sight, Kuro's smile crumbled.

She sank to her knees.

Tears spilled down her cheeks.

"Another failure..." she whispered. "I almost died... and even when I tried my hardest... no one wants to fight with me..."

Her soul gem darkened — a deep, suffocating black.

"Why am I so useless..."

Watching from the outside, Kuroe felt her own heart twist painfully.

This Kyoko... she's so different from dream-Kyoko. She looked so sad... This must have been shortly after she broke ties with Mami.

And Kuro...

Kuro had no one.

No Iroha.

No Mikazuki Villa.

No friends to pull her back from the edge.

Not even a dangerous organization like the Wings of the Magius to offer false hope.

Kuroe realized, with a sickening weight, just how lucky she had been.

She had never been truly alone.

But Kuro...

Kuro was standing on the brink.

And she was about to fall.

Kuro walked alone through the city.

Her steps were uneven, dragging, as though each one required more strength than she had left. With every movement, her soul gem — nearly black — pulsed faintly at her chest, its glow weak and unstable, like a dying ember struggling to stay alive. Her shoulders sagged, weighed down by

exhaustion, by fear, by the quiet certainty that no matter how hard she tried, she always seemed to fail in the end.

Around her, the world continued as if nothing were wrong.

Families strolled together along the sidewalks, laughter spilling freely between them as they stopped to peer into shop windows. Children ran ahead of their parents, shoes slapping against the pavement, their joy loud and careless. Couples leaned close as they walked, fingers intertwined, sharing secrets meant only for each other. Groups of friends lingered at street corners, voices overlapping as they talked about trivial plans and ordinary worries.

Life was everywhere.

Warm. Bright. Connected.

And Kuro moved through it like a ghost.

No one looked at her.

No one noticed her.

And she, in turn, barely registered their presence at all.

Her gaze stayed fixed ahead, unfocused, as though she were drifting through a world she could no longer touch — a place she had somehow been left behind by.

Eventually, without conscious intent, her feet carried her to Takarazaki Station.

For the first time since the Kyoko left her, something shifted in her expression. A small, fragile smile touched her lips, trembling as though it might break at any moment. She lifted a hand and wiped at her eyes, brushing away a tear she hadn't realized had fallen.

"This is where..." she whispered softly, her voice almost lost beneath the hum of the city.

"...where I was saved."

She walked slowly to a nearby bench and sank onto it, her legs shaking as if they might give out entirely. Leaning back, she tilted her head upward, staring at the open sky above the station — a sky she had once believed still held hope for her.

"By Kuroe," she murmured. "The kind-hearted magical girl."

Her voice wavered.

"I dream about her sometimes," she continued quietly. "About meeting her again. About telling her how grateful I am... that she saved me that day."

Kuroe's chest tightened painfully at the sound of her own name.

She had never imagined this — never imagined that Kuro thought of her this way. Not after she had run away. Not after she had lived with the belief that she had abandoned someone who needed her.

Kuro's hands trembled as she clasped her soul gem, its surface so dark it barely reflected the light anymore. Tears slid freely down her cheeks now, soaking into the fabric of her sleeves.

"And I wish..." she whispered, voice cracking. "I wish I'd had the courage to ask her to team up with me. Just like I tried with Kyoko."

Her breath hitched.

"But... I know she wouldn't come," she said, her tone hollow. "And even if she did... she wouldn't want to fight alongside someone like me. Not after everything."

She squeezed her eyes shut.

"She would have rejected me too," she murmured. "Just like Kyoko."

Her shoulders trembled as a quiet sob escaped her.

"No one wants to be with me."

Kuroe watched from outside the memory, her heart screaming in denial.

No— that's not true—

I would have—

The thought cut off before it could finish, tangled in guilt and uncertainty. She didn't know anymore. She didn't know what she *would* have done back then — only what she *had* done.

Kuro lowered her head, her voice barely audible now.

"So... maybe it would be better..."

"...if I disappeared."

Her soul gem cracked.

A thin fracture spiderwebbed across its surface.

Then another.

And another.

And then—

It shattered.

A violent surge of dark energy erupted outward, swallowing the station in a wave of despair so dense it felt suffocating. The world twisted, warped, drowned beneath it.

"Kuro—NO!" Kuroe screamed, reaching out instinctively.

But the darkness surged forward, heedless and merciless. It wrapped around her, crushing, smothering, dragging her under in a flood of horror and guilt she couldn't escape.

Kuro became a witch because of me.
She thought of me in her last moments.
She died alone.

And it's all my fault.

The darkness thickened, spiraling faster and tighter until it felt like it might tear her apart.

And from within it—

A figure emerged.

Her Doppel.

But not the Kuro-shaped one from before.

This time, it wore *her* face.

Her eyes.

Her smile.

All of it twisted into something pleased, something predatory. Black wings unfurled behind her, heavy and dripping with the same muddy corruption that had once consumed her entirely.

“Good,” the Doppel purred softly. “Good...”

She stepped closer, each movement deliberate, savoring Kuroe’s unraveling.

“Submit to your regrets,” she whispered. “Succumb to your despair.”

Her smile widened.

“Fade into oblivion,” she crooned.

“...where you belong.”

Kuroe wanted to fight back.

To scream.

To deny it.

But she couldn’t.

Her heart twisted violently.

Her soul buckled.

Her thoughts scattered, slipping through her grasp like water.

She was losing herself.

The Doppel leaned in close, her breath cold, her voice a venomous whisper.

“Don’t worry,” she chuckled mockingly.

“I’ll keep spreading despair...”

“...just like you.”

Kuroe's vision blurred.

Her consciousness slipped.

And then—

She faded away.

Kuroe jolted awake with a scream.

Her body snapped upright as if yanked by invisible strings, breath tearing from her lungs in ragged, uneven bursts. Sweat clung to her skin in a cold sheen. Her fingers trembled uncontrollably. Her heart hammered against her ribs, frantic and animal, as though trying to escape her chest.

For a moment, she didn't know where she was.

Then her vision cleared.

She was lying on soft, sun-warmed grass. Above her stretched a sky so vividly blue it felt unreal — a painter's sky, unmarred by clouds or distance. Around her, tall trees swayed in a warm breeze, their leaves whispering like distant voices. Stone pillars rose from the earth in a wide circle, each carved with intricate magical motifs: runes, sigils, silhouettes of magical girls mid-transformation, frozen in eternal motion.

The air smelled of flowers and sunlight.

Kuroe exhaled shakily.

She was back in the coliseum.

Back in her own body.

Back in herself.

But her mind...

Her mind was blank.

The last thing she remembered clearly was the six witches revealing their human forms, showing her the different levels of witch mastery. Then they had told her to embrace her despair — to relive the moment she broke.

Everything after that was a smear of darkness and emotion she couldn't grasp. A memory with its edges torn off.

But she felt it.

A lingering ache in her chest.

A heaviness behind her eyes.

A sense that something terrible had happened — something she couldn't quite reach.

“So you’re awake!”

The energetic voice came from behind her.

Before Kuroe could turn, flowers burst into bloom around her — dozens of them, in every color imaginable. Their petals unfurled in a soft wave, releasing a sweet, calming fragrance that washed over her like warm water.

Kuroe inhaled, her trembling easing.

“Airi...?” she asked softly, turning with a small, hopeful smile.

Airi stood there with her hands clasped behind her back, expression bright and gentle, sunlight catching in her hair like petals caught mid-fall.

“Yes,” she said warmly. “I’m glad you remembered my name.”

Behind her, the other five girls gathered — Tamashii, Suzume, Shizuku, Yume, and Mio — each radiating a quiet, welcoming presence.

Kuroe swallowed.

“What... happened? I tried to relive the despair and regret that broke me — the same despair my Doppel used to take over, the same despair that turned me into a witch. But after that... everything went blank. And I woke up here, terrified.”

Airi chuckled softly.

“Oh, you relived it, alright. You did it *too* well.”

Kuroe blinked.

“Too well? Does that mean... I passed?”

Suzume flipped upside-down in the air, laughing.

“Nope! Not even close. By ‘too well,’ Airi means you broke again. You lost yourself and turned into what you became yesterday.”

Kuroe’s eyes widened.

“W-what? Then how am I back here? Did one of you save me? Like Lunaria did?”

Shizuku shook her head gently, her clouds drifting in slow spirals.

“No. Lunaria told you, didn’t she? Magical girls can’t become witches in this dream-realm.”

Kuroe nodded slowly.

“Yes, but... how does that work?”

Mio stepped forward, her form flickering faintly like a candle in a draft.

“It’s another feature of the dream-realm — magical erasure. It’s based on the Forgotten Queen’s abilities. Just like the temporary memory-erasure feature, also based on her. And the emotional corruption feature, which comes from Umbra.”

Yume continued, her shadow curling softly around her feet.

“When you lost yourself, the magical erasure activated. It erased the despair and regret that were drowning you.”

She winked.

“Quite convenient, don’t you think? Perfect for training.”

Kuroe stared at them, awe widening her eyes.

“That’s... incredible. The more I learn about this place, the more amazing it is.”

She paused.

“So the reason I can’t remember what happened is...”

Tamashii nodded.

“Yes. The temporary memory-erasure activated too. So you can start again from scratch.”

Kuroe let out a breathy laugh.

“The Forgotten Queen must be unbelievably powerful if her abilities can do all this. I... hope I get to meet her someday.”

She hesitated.

“But... wouldn’t it be better if I tried again *with* my memories? So I’d be better prepared?”

Airi shook her head gently.

“You would do better with your memories. But that’s not the best way to grow — not when mastering witch power.”

Kuroe tilted her head.

“What do you mean?”

Shizuku stepped forward, her hair swaying in the wind.

“Almost all witches fail the first step. Reliving the despair that broke them — and controlling it — takes many attempts.”

Yume nodded.

“And over the ages, we’ve learned that the most effective method is to face that despair *fresh* until you succeed. No prior memories. No shortcuts.”

Mio added softly:

“You pass the first step by accepting who you are and what you’ve done. By accepting your failures and regrets — not as chains, but as truths you carry forward.”

Tamashii’s expression softened with sorrow, the wind spirits around her dimming in sympathy.

“All six of us... we carry deep regret. Our families were executed because villagers saw us using magic. Their cries haunted us for a very long time.”

Shizuku’s clouds darkened, reflecting her grief.

“It took us a very long time to come to terms with that. We made mistakes that had terrible consequences for the ones we loved.”

Suzume floated closer, her voice bright but gentle.

“But once we learned to carry our past not as unbearable shame, but as a scar — a reminder of who we were and what we learned — everything changed. We gained control over our witch powers. And from there, it all goes uphill!”

Airi nodded.

“If you repeated the trial with your memories, you’d succeed eventually. But each attempt would feel duller. You’d become desensitized. Apathetic. And that would make it harder to grow later, when you need to embrace even deeper despair for advanced techniques.”

Kuroe’s eyes widened with understanding.

“You want me to face my regrets head-on. To overcome the nightmares that haunted me... naturally. So I can build the emotional strength I’ll need later.”

Airi smiled.

“Exactly.”

Kuroe bowed her head gratefully.

“Thank you... all of you. I’m ready to try again.”

The six girls smiled — each in their own way.

Tamashii placed a steadying hand over her heart, her wind spirits swirling playfully around her.

Suzume spun in a bright, encouraging loop.

Shizuku’s clouds parted with a gentle breeze, letting warm light through.

Airi’s flowers bloomed in a soft ring around Kuroe.

Yume’s shadow gave Kuroe a thumbs up.

Mio flickered gently, her presence calm and reassuring.

Kuroe closed her eyes.

She inhaled deeply.

And once more...

She stepped into her despair.

Mami, Momoko, and Mifuyu's training

The light around them dimmed, folding inward like petals closing at dusk.

For a heartbeat, there was nothing—no sound, no weight, no sense of direction. Then the world unfolded again, gently, almost kindly.

Mami, Momoko, and Mifuyu landed on their feet.

They stood in the center of a vast garden.

Grass stretched endlessly in every direction, lush and impossibly green, brushing against their boots like velvet. The air carried the scent of trees and flowers that didn't exist anywhere Mami could remember. Strange plants clustered together in careful arrangements: vines bearing translucent fruit in colors that refused to settle on a single hue, blossoms that glowed faintly from within as though lit by hidden lanterns.

Warm-toned pillars rose throughout the garden, tall and elegant. They were wrapped in ivy, moss, and flowering vines so thoroughly that it was difficult to tell where stone ended and plant life began. Each pillar pulsed with a slow, steady light—subtle, rhythmic. Like a heartbeat.

It was breathtaking.

Momoko's eyes sparkled.

"Whoa—look at this!" she shouted, already bolting toward a nearby bush heavy with star-shaped fruit. She crouched, poked one, sniffed it, then poked it again for good measure. "Guys, come here! You gotta see this!"

Mifuyu followed with a soft, indulgent laugh.

"Momoko is always like this," she said fondly. "Energetic, curious... and easily distracted."

Mami didn't move right away.

She let her gaze drift across the garden, taking in the impossible beauty, the careful balance of light and color. A serene smile rested on her face—but her eyes were sharp, searching.

"It really is beautiful," she murmured.

Then her expression tightened.

"But... Kuroe isn't here."

Momoko glanced back. "Huh?"

“So she must have been sent somewhere else,” Mami continued quietly. “For her ‘**special training**.’”

The words tasted bitter.

“I hope she’s alright.”

Her gaze shifted again, this time scanning the trees and pillars.

“And more importantly... where is Kyoko? She’s supposed to be helping us.”

A voice answered from behind a nearby tree, slightly muffled.

“Mmm—yeah. This *definitely* hits the spot.”

All three girls turned.

Kyoko stepped out from behind the tree, biting into a glowing fruit nearly the size of her fist. Juice dripped down her fingers, sparkling before it vanished into the grass. She looked utterly relaxed, like this was exactly where she’d planned to be all along.

Mami let out a long, resigned sigh—then smiled despite herself.

“Of course you’d be eating.”

Kyoko shrugged, still chewing.

“Why not? Look at this place! It’d be rude *not* to.”

“We just ate—” Mami began.

“Oh wow, this is REALLY good!”

Momoko’s delighted gasp cut her off.

Mami and Kyoko turned to see Momoko happily munching on a cluster of gem-like grapes, each one a different color, shimmering faintly as she pulled them free. She handed a few to Mifuyu, who hesitated only a moment before tasting one.

Her eyes widened slightly.

“...Oh,” Mifuyu murmured, surprised. “That’s... wonderful.”

Mami groaned playfully.

“Not you too, Momoko. Are we here to train or to eat?”

Kyoko grinned and took another bite.

“Hey, food’s important. Fuel for training, right?”

She licked her lips and wiped her mouth with the back of her hand. She then glanced between Momoko and Mifuyu, her expression sharpening just a little.

“So,” she said casually, “what’s the plan for taking negativity into yourselves? You don’t have Mitama around to help you this time.”

Momoko and Mifuyu exchanged thoughtful looks.

Mifuyu spoke first, slowly, as if thinking aloud.

“When we Connected with Mitama... she temporarily gave us her ability to attune ourselves to soul gems.”

Momoko nodded, tapping her chin.

“We used it to reach the doppelified girls. To tell them they weren’t alone. To share their despair instead of letting it swallow them whole.”

Mifuyu lifted her Soul Gem, cradling it gently in both hands.

“One of my abilities involves illusions,” she continued. “I can manipulate perceptions, thoughts, memories... If I can reach them—if I can touch what they’re seeing and feeling—then maybe I can break through that despair before it hardens.”

Momoko’s eyes brightened with resolve and excitement.

“And I’ve got Encouragement,” she said. “If anyone can use that to keep them steady, it’s me. Help them feel supported.”

She clenched her fist.

“Aaaaaaaaand now that we understand Connecting better... maybe we’ll unlock something new if we Connect again.”

The thought made her grin.

“Just think about it!”

Mifuyu pressed her hands to her heart, cheeks warming with anticipation.

“Yes,” she said softly. “After what Lunaria taught us... I’m looking forward to Connecting with you again, Momoko.”

She turned to Mami and Kyoko, smiling.

“And after seeing what *you* two accomplished together against Kasumi... it was incredible.”

Momoko shot Mami a thumbs-up.

“Seriously! And we want to Connect with you too. Your emotional control’s gonna be key. You’ll take in whatever despair we absorb—and get rid of it safely.”

She winked, only half joking.

“I don’t really feel like ‘dying’ again. Even if this place won’t let us.”

Mami laughed softly.

Momoko joking about her own death so casually would have horrified her anywhere else. But here, in this strange dream-realm, it felt oddly comforting. Proof that Momoko and Mifuyu weren't afraid. Proof that they believed in their plan.

Mami turned to Kyoko.

"What do you think? Will it work?"

Kyoko smirked.

"Heh."

Mami sighed dramatically.

"So you're really not going to answer."

Kyoko shrugged, taking another bite of fruit.

"Why bother? You're about to find out yourselves."

She stretched, wolfed down the last bite, and tossed the glowing core aside. It dissolved into motes of light that drifted into the air, reabsorbed by the garden.

"Man," Kyoko said, licking her fingers, "that really *was* refreshing."

Then she looked at the three girls and grinned — her expression focused but playful.

"Well?" she said. "You ready to start?"

Mami, Momoko, and Mifuyu exchanged glances.

They nodded in unison.

"We're ready."

Kyoko stretched her arms behind her head, spine cracking lightly, a sharp grin cutting across her face.

"Alright then. First step — Connect. Get to know each other better. Power boost, emotional sync, all that good stuff."

Her tone was casual, but the air shifted around them. The garden quieted, as though the dream-realm itself leaned in to listen.

Mami felt it — that subtle gravity, the sense that something important was about to begin.

She turned toward Momoko and Mifuyu, her expression softening with curiosity and something gentler, almost hopeful.

"I'm curious what I'll learn about you two once we Connect," she admitted. "We only met today."

Momoko and Mifuyu exchanged a look — the kind that spoke of years of shared battles, shared grief, shared healing — then turned back to Mami with matching smiles.

“Right back at you!” Momoko said brightly. “This’ll be our first time Connecting since coming here — after everything Lunaria taught us.”

Mifuyu nodded, her voice quiet but sincere.

“It will be... exciting. And meaningful.”

Something in Mami’s chest loosened. Their trust wasn’t forced. It wasn’t bravado. It was genuine — offered freely to someone they had only just met.

She felt her heart lift.

The three of them stepped closer, forming a small circle. Each girl reached out with both hands, fingers intertwining with the ones beside her. Their palms were warm. Their grips steady. Their breaths synced without effort.

They inhaled together — slow, steady, grounding.

Then they closed their eyes.

They opened their hearts.

They opened their souls.

Golden light flowed from Mami’s and Momoko’s Soul Gems, warm and radiant like sunlight through stained glass.

Silver light shimmered from Mifuyu’s, soft and cool like moonlight on water.

The lights twisted together, spiraling upward like intertwined ribbons. Their magic resonated — humming, harmonizing, merging. The garden’s colors deepened, as though painted anew by their combined magic.

They Connected.

Mami’s Vision

Mami opened her eyes.

She was standing in the living room of Mikazuki Villa.

Warm sunlight filtered through the windows, casting soft gold across the tatami. The air smelled faintly of tea, wood polish, and the comforting scent of a home lived in. Laughter drifted from the kitchen — light, familiar, unburdened.

Yachiyo and Mifuyu stood in front of the oven.

“Let’s see how this turned out,” Yachiyo said, slipping on oven mitts.

Mifuyu grinned. “I think it’s going to be delicious. We all worked on it together, after all.”

She opened the oven. A wave of rich aroma — butter, herbs, roasted vegetables — flooded the room.

Mifuyu inhaled sharply. “It smells incredible.”

Yachiyo pulled out the tray. The meat glistened, perfectly cooked, juices pooling around the vegetables. She smiled with quiet pride.

“Oooooohh that smells SOOO good! Is it finally ready?” Momoko called from the dining room, practically drooling.

“Reminds me of Banbanzai’s kitchen! This is gonna be amazing!” Tsuruno added, her stomach growling loudly.

“We’ve already set the table, Yachiyo. We’re ready to eat!” Mel chimed in.

“All right, I’m bringing it out!” Yachiyo said.

As they walked toward the dining room, Mifuyu whispered:

“I’m glad we can have happy moments like this again.”

Yachiyo’s smile softened. “Yes. It feels like... back when it was just us and Kanae. When she was still alive. I... I hope it can stay this way.”

Mifuyu pressed a hand to her heart. “Our group is bigger now. We can take down any witch together. No one has to sacrifice themselves like Kanae.”

They entered the dining room and set the food down.

“What were you two whispering about?” Momoko teased. “Did you mess something up?”

Yachiyo and Mifuyu laughed — real, warm laughter.

“No, nothing like that,” Yachiyo said. “We’re just happy we can share a meal with all of you.”

“It was very lonely before you came,” Mifuyu added softly. “We hope... you’ll stay with us.”

Momoko, Tsuruno, and Mel exchanged glances — then burst into laughter.

“Of course! Magical girls should always have each other’s backs!” Momoko declared.

“You can count on me!” Tsuruno said proudly. “I’m the strongest, after all!”

“Friendship, fun, food... I have everything I want here,” Mel added with a smile.

Mifuyu’s eyes glistened. “Thank you... all of you.”

Yachiyo clapped her hands. “Enough sentimentality. Let’s eat!”

“Yes!” everyone shouted.

Warmth bloomed in Mami's chest — not her own, but Mifuyu's and Momoko's. Their gratitude. Their joy. Their fragile hope that life could stay this way.

But Mami knew deep in her heart it would not remain this way.

The scene shifted.

A witch's labyrinth.

A battle.

Chaos.

They were overwhelmed but barely managed to escape.

Mel lay on the ground, her Soul Gem nearly black.

"Mel—! Stay with us!" Momoko cried, voice cracking.

"You'll be alright," Tsuruno insisted, though her hands trembled.

"We'll find a grief seed," Yachiyo said, gripping her spear tightly.

"Please hold on!" Mifuyu begged, taking Mel's hand.

But Mel only smiled — small, sad, accepting.

"It's... too late."

Her Soul Gem cracked.

"Looks like I can't stay by your side anymore..." she whispered, tears falling.

Then her Soul Gem shattered.

A vortex of energy exploded outward, hurling the others back. When the light faded, Etteilla — Mel's witch — stood where their friend had been.

"What... what just happened?!" Momoko gasped.

"Why is there a witch here?! Where's Mel?!" Tsuruno cried.

"It... it can't be..." Mifuyu whispered, collapsing to her knees.

Yachiyo fell forward, bracing herself on her hands.

"Why... why does this always happen to me... Kanae... Mel..."

Mami's heart clenched.

Shock.

Horror.

Sorrow.

Anger.

All of it hit her at once — the raw, unfiltered emotions Mifuyu and Momoko had felt that day. She had known this story from Kasumi’s recounting... but knowing was nothing like *feeling* it.

How did they endure this?

How did they keep going?

If this had happened to me... would I have survived it?

She wasn’t sure.

A strange, guilty gratitude flickered through her — that she had “died” before learning the truth about magical girls. Before she could watch a friend turn into a monster.

The vision shifted again.

Mami was floating in a vast ethereal realm, bathed in soft starlight and endless twilight. Tents dotted the horizon, each glowing faintly with a different hue.

Mifuyu and Momoko’s final moments.

Their Connect with Mitama.

Their desperate attempt to save the doppelified magical girls.

Their souls reaching out, attuning to each girl’s Soul Gem, whispering:

You matter.

It’s OK to cry.

You’re not alone.

You are loved.

Mami felt the despair they took into themselves — the crushing weight of dozens of girls’ suffering. She felt their bodies weaken. Their consciousness fade.

She felt Mitama’s anguish — the pain of a Coordinator who had seen too much despair, who had closed her heart to survive, who had finally found hope again in the girls who called her a friend.

She felt their goodbyes.

Their wishes for Mitama and Rena to live happily.

Mitama’s and Rena’s desperate hope that they might meet again someday.

Then—

A burst of warm, energetic magic surged through the vision.

Kasumi.

Mami let out a soft, breathless laugh.

So this was how Kasumi saved them...

The vision dissolved like mist.

Mami returned to herself — but her heart was full.

Full of respect.

Full of admiration.

Full of awe.

Momoko and Mifuyu had endured so much.

They had learned the darkest truths of magical girls.

And still — they had chosen to keep going.

To save others.

To sacrifice themselves.

And now, here they were — willing to help Mami, a stranger they had only just met.

Momoko's and Mifuyu's vision

Light swirled around Momoko and Mifuyu — soft, golden, and warm — before dissolving like dust drifting through a sunbeam. When their vision cleared, they found themselves standing in a small, tidy apartment. The air smelled faintly of black tea and freshly baked pastries. A lace tablecloth covered a low table, and on it sat a porcelain tea set so delicate it looked like it would shatter under a careless touch.

Across from each other, Mami and Kyoko sat enjoying a tea party.

Kyoko was wolfing down a slice of cake, crumbs dusting her cheeks, slurping her tea with zero restraint.

“This is sooo good!” she declared between bites. “Seriously, Mami, you outdid yourself.”

Mami, in contrast, ate with perfect grace — back straight, movements refined, every gesture elegant. She smiled warmly, the kind of smile that made the room feel softer.

“I’m glad you like it. I tried a new recipe for both the cake and the tea. I wasn’t sure if it would suit your tastes.”

Kyoko reached for another slice without hesitation.

“It suits me just fine,” she said, already chewing. “It’s sweet, it’s warm, and it tastes like you put a lot of effort into it. What’s not to love?”

Mami sighed with a fond smile.

“You say that about everything you eat. It wouldn’t hurt to slow down and savor the flavors a little more.”

Kyoko grinned, licking frosting from her thumb.

“If it tastes good, then I like it. Thinking too hard about food takes the fun out of it.”

Mami shook her head, amused.

“You’re so childish sometimes.”

Kyoko raised an eyebrow. “What’s that supposed to mean?”

Mami chuckled softly.

“You haven’t changed at all since I took you as my apprentice. You’re fiery, rude, stubborn... but that’s what makes you so endearing. I hope you never change.”

Kyoko shrugged, but her smile softened, losing its sharp edges.

“Can’t see myself changing anytime soon. You’ve been good to me. And you feed me a lot of good stuff. So I’ll be sticking around for a while.”

They laughed together — a warm, easy sound that filled the room like sunlight.

Momoko and Mifuyu felt their hearts warm in response. The scene reminded them of their own days at Mikazuki Villa before Mel’s fall — the laughter, the shared meals, the sense of belonging that made even the smallest moments feel precious. And Kyoko... this Kyoko was so much like the dream-Kyoko they had met. They wondered what the real Kyoko had become after tragedy struck — after her family died, after she and Mami severed their bond.

The warmth faded.

The apartment dissolved into a darkened street, lit only by flickering lamps. The air was cold, sharp, and heavy with unspoken words. Mami and Kyoko stood facing each other — not as friends, but as opponents.

Kyoko’s spear was drawn.

Mami’s ribbons floated defensively around her.

Kyoko’s voice was sharp, brittle, cracking at the edges.

“Let me go! Why can’t you just leave me alone?!”

Mami’s voice trembled, desperate.

“Kyoko, please — listen to me. You don’t have to do this. We can still—”

“No,” Kyoko snapped. “I’ve already decided. You can’t change it.”

Every word struck like a blade.

Momoko and Mifuyu felt each one — the sting, the fear, the heartbreak. Through Connect, Mami’s emotions poured into them: confusion, grief, helplessness, the desperate need to hold onto someone slipping away.

Kyoko turned her back.

“Farewell, old friend...”

She walked into the night.

Mami remained frozen for a moment — silent, stunned — before a raw, broken cry tore from her throat. Her ribbons collapsed around her like wilted petals, falling uselessly to the ground.

Momoko and Mifuyu felt the pain as if it were their own.

Mifuyu’s breath hitched.

She knew this feeling.

The arguments with Yachiyo.

The misunderstandings.

The fights.

The moment she nearly died by Yachiyo’s hand — saved only because Yachiyo managed to control her Doppel at the last second.

The pain of fighting someone you love.

The pain of being unable to reach them.

Momoko felt it too — the ache of watching friends drift apart, the helplessness of not knowing how to fix it. The fear that one wrong step could shatter everything.

They understood Kyoko’s change.

The guilt she carried for her family’s death.

The fear of losing someone again.

The instinct to push others away before they could hurt her.

Kyoko reminded them of Yachiyo — their former teammate who pushed others away, believing her wish doomed everyone she cared about.

Their lives echoed Mami’s in ways they had never realized.

They both let out soft, bittersweet chuckles.

“Magical girls really do live similar lives, huh?” Momoko murmured.

“Too similar,” Mifuyu whispered.

The world shifted again.

Momoko and Mifuyu were back in Mami’s apartment. Morning light streamed through the curtains. Mami stood before a mirror, adjusting her uniform, smoothing her hair, checking her posture. She smiled at her reflection — elegant, composed, pretty.

But Momoko and Mifuyu felt the truth beneath the surface.

“She’s forcing herself to smile...” Mifuyu whispered.

The scene changed.

At school, people greeted Mami warmly. They invited her to go shopping, to attend concerts, to play sports, to hang out after class. Each invitation made her heart flutter with a brief, bright happiness — the kind that came from being seen, from being wanted.

But that happiness dissolved almost instantly into frustration and sadness.

Mami politely thanked them and declined, smile unwavering.

She had plans.

She always had plans.

Witch hunting didn't wait for friendship.

Despite her graceful exterior, Mami was screaming on the inside. Every refusal hurt. Every missed chance stung. She wished for friends with all her heart — but she had no time to be one.

“Wow... that's rough. Not having any friends at school,” Momoko muttered, her voice heavy.

After school, Mami walked through the streets toward a witch's labyrinth. She passed families, couples, and groups of friends laughing together, enjoying their peaceful lives. Mami felt happy for them — truly — but she couldn't help the small, sharp ache of jealousy.

These were the people she protected in the shadows.

So why couldn't she live happily like them?

After the witch hunt, she returned home and prepared dinner for herself.

Mami sat alone at her table, staring at untouched tea. Her eyes were hollow. The smile she wore at school — the polite, perfect one — was nowhere to be found.

Then she broke.

Her shoulders shook.

Her breath hitched.

Tears spilled down her cheeks in silent, trembling waves.

Night after night, she cried alone.

Night after night, she tried to hold herself together.

Night after night, she watched others live the life she longed for but could never reach.

Momoko and Mifuyu felt the ache of her loneliness — sharp, suffocating, relentless. It was a feeling they had never truly known. They had always had someone — Iroha, Tsuruno, Felicia, Sana, Yachiyo, Rena, Kaede, the Wings of the Magius. Even in their darkest moments, they were never truly alone.

But Mami...

Mami had no one.

And yet — she kept going.

She helped others.
She protected strangers.
She held onto her ideals even when no one saw her efforts.
Even when jealousy clawed at her heart.
Even when she felt invisible.

“Mami...” Mifuyu whispered with reverence, pressing a hand to her chest. “She still continued to fight witches and protect others, even after being alone.”

“I’m impressed Mami never broke and became a witch. She’s tough,” Momoko said, her voice full of genuine respect.

The world around Momoko and Mifuyu rippled, colors bleeding into one another like wet paint dragged across a canvas. The distortion deepened, spiraling into ribbons of pink, red, and sickly pastel hues. The air thickened, syrupy and warm, as though they were being pulled into the heart of a fever dream.

When the world finally settled, they found themselves standing inside a witch’s labyrinth — a warped, candy-colored nightmare of floating sweets, impossible geometry, and corridors that bent like melted sugar.

Charlotte’s labyrinth.

The air was thick with the scent of caramel and dread, cloying and suffocating. The ground beneath their feet pulsed faintly, as if alive.

A voice cut through the silence — flat, cold, almost mechanical.

“I will handle this witch.”

Momoko and Mifuyu turned toward the sound.

A magical girl stood a short distance away, her silhouette sharp against the swirling backdrop. She wore a white, gray, and black uniform, her long black hair branching out behind her like dark wings. Her expression was blank. Her voice emotionless. Her eyes...

Inhuman.

Mifuyu’s breath caught.

“Who is that girl...? She feels different from any magical girl I’ve ever met.”

Momoko swallowed, her instincts prickling.

“She gives off... strange vibes... What is her relationship to Mami?”

Before they could speculate further, Mami stepped into view. Her eyes narrowed the moment she saw the girl — a reaction so visceral it sent a jolt through the Connect.

“Homura,” Mami said sharply. “I thought I told you I didn’t want to see you again.”

Momoko and Mifuyu felt it immediately — a spike of distrust, irritation, and something deeper, older. Mami's emotions pulsed through the Connect like a heartbeat.

Mami didn't trust this girl at all...

Why?

Was it because they fought over grief seeds?

Homura did say she would take care of this witch...

Then they noticed her.

A girl standing behind Mami — small, pink-haired, trembling. Her hands clutched her skirt, her eyes wide with fear.

Momoko whispered, "That must be one of Mami's human friends... someone she brought to show what being a magical girl is like."

Mifuyu nodded softly.

"So she is either Madoka... or Sayaka."

Homura's gaze flicked to Mami, her expression unchanged, but something tense coiled beneath the surface.

"I don't have time for this. I will ensure Sayaka gets out safely. You can have the grief seed when I'm done."

Momoko and Mifuyu stiffened.

She's offering the grief seed?

For free?

That alone shattered their assumptions. Whatever conflict existed between Mami and Homura... it wasn't about grief seeds.

So what was Homura really after?

Mami's voice hardened, brittle with distrust.

"And why should I trust you?"

She raised a hand.

Ribbons shot forward, binding Homura in an instant.

Homura gasped — not in fear, but in frustration — as the ribbons tightened around her arms and torso, pinning her in place. Her breath hitched, her jaw clenched, but her eyes remained fixed on Mami

"Mami, listen," Homura said, her voice still flat but trembling at the edges. "This witch is different from the others."

"Stay there like a good girl," Mami replied coldly. "I'll free you once I'm done."

She turned to Madoka with a gentle smile that contrasted painfully with the tension in the air.

“Shall we, Madoka?”

Madoka hesitated.

Her gaze drifted to Homura — who stared back at her with something raw and desperate flickering beneath her otherwise empty eyes.

“Please don’t go,” Homura pleaded. “Don’t do it.”

The ribbons constricted further. Homura winced, her breath hitching in pain.

Madoka froze.

This was the first time she had seen Homura show any emotion.

But she didn’t understand it.

She didn’t know what to make of it.

And Mami was already walking ahead.

“I’m... I’m sorry... Homura...” Madoka whispered, voice trembling.

She turned and ran after Mami.

Homura went still.

Her body sagged against the ribbons, her head bowing. She gritted her teeth, voice barely audible — a whisper meant for no one, yet echoing through the Connect.

“You idiot...”

Momoko and Mifuyu felt a chill run through them.

This was it.

Mami’s last moments before Lunaria saved her.

Momoko whispered, “Homura... it looked like she knew Mami would die.”

Mifuyu nodded slowly, her eyes deep with thought.

“And it looked like she was trying to prevent that... So why did Mami treat her with such contempt and distrust?”

“What happened between them?” Momoko murmured.

Mifuyu’s gaze lingered on Homura’s bowed head, on the quiet desperation radiating from her.

“I don’t think this will be the last time we see her.”

Momoko exhaled, unsettled.

“Yeah... There’s just something about her I can’t put my finger on...”

The labyrinth pulsed around them, the colors shifting like a heartbeat — as if the dream-realm itself agreed.

The labyrinth shifted again, its colors softening into a hazy pastel glow. The oppressive dread loosened just enough for warmth to seep in — a deceptive calm before the storm. The candy-colored walls pulsed gently, as if the labyrinth itself were holding its breath, watching them with quiet anticipation.

Mami and Madoka walked side by side through the twisting corridors, their steps light, almost buoyant. For a moment, the world felt strangely peaceful, as though the labyrinth were granting them a brief reprieve — a pocket of calm carved out just for them.

And then—

They saw her.

Sayaka stood ahead with Kyubey perched beside her, the creature's tail flicking lazily. Her blue hair glowed faintly in the labyrinth's pastel light, giving her an almost ethereal silhouette.

“Sayaka!” Mami and Madoka called out in unison.

Sayaka turned toward them, her face lighting up with pure, unfiltered relief.

“Mami! Madoka!” she cried, waving before running toward them.

The three collided in a warm, breathless embrace. Laughter bubbled up between them — soft, fragile, but real. For a moment, the labyrinth didn't feel like a place of death. It felt like a place where friendships deepened, where hope could take root.

“Sayaka, you're so brave,” Madoka said, squeezing her tightly. “Going in first like that...”

Sayaka chuckled, brushing it off with her usual bravado.

“It was nothing. Honestly, I was getting bored waiting for you two to show up.”

Mami and Madoka laughed, their voices echoing faintly through the candy-colored halls. Even the labyrinth seemed to brighten around them, as if responding to their joy.

As they continued walking, Sayaka glanced at Mami.

“I hope we didn't call you at a bad time. We saw a grief seed starting to hatch and... well, we didn't know what else to do.”

Mami shook her head gently.

“It's alright. Truly. Protecting others is my duty. You both made the right call.”

Madoka blushed at the praise. Sayaka grinned.

“Mami, you're such a good role model. Always ready to help people.”

Then her expression soured.

“Unlike that Homura. Ugh. I can’t stand her. She’s rude, arrogant, weird, apathetic, expressionless—”

Madoka hesitated.

“Actually... Homura confronted us earlier. She told us to let her handle the witch.”

Sayaka’s eyes widened.

“She followed us here?! She always sticks her nose where it doesn’t belong. Is she still around?”

Madoka shook her head.

“No. Mami bound her with ribbons. She’ll free her after the witch is defeated.”

Sayaka pumped her fist triumphantly.

“Serves her right! Atta girl, Mami!”

Momoko and Mifuyu exchanged a look.

Sayaka’s dislike of Homura wasn’t mild. It was instinctive, visceral — the kind of dislike born from repeated friction, from misunderstandings that had calcified into resentment.

Momoko murmured, “Seems Homura has made quite a few enemies. She must be very lonely... like Mami.”

Mifuyu nodded slowly, her voice soft.

“But earlier... Homura looked truly worried about Mami dying. If others think this way of her, then she must be hiding a lot from them.”

Momoko rubbed her chin.

“Why would she though? Magical girls should be open with each other and work together.”

Before they could ponder further, Mami suddenly stopped walking.

Sayaka and Madoka halted, startled.

“Mami?” Madoka asked softly. “Is something wrong?”

Mami turned to face them.

Her eyes — usually so steady, so confident — wavered. For the first time, Momoko and Mifuyu saw her without her mask.

“I’m... not a good role model,” Mami said quietly.

Sayaka blinked. “What? Of course you are!”

Madoka nodded vigorously. “Mami, what do you mean?”

Mami hesitated — the words trembling on her tongue.

“The confidence you see... the smile I wear... they’re a mask. Deep down, I’m lonely. And I’m hurting. I’m... weak.”

Sayaka and Madoka stared at her, stunned.

Mami continued, her voice cracking.

“Every day, I fight witches alone. I risk my life in secret. I get no recognition. And no matter how many times I do it, I’m always scared. Scared I’ll die. Scared others will die because of me. Scared no one will remember me.”

She swallowed hard.

“I cry a lot at night. When I’m alone. When no one can see.”

Silence fell — heavy, tender, fragile.

Then Madoka stepped forward.

“Even so,” she said softly, “I still think you’re a great role model.”

Mami looked up, startled.

Madoka’s voice grew stronger, steadier.

“Because even when you’re scared, and lonely, and hurting... you still fight. You still protect people. You still stay true to your ideals. That’s what makes you amazing.”

Mami’s breath hitched.

Madoka clenched her fists, eyes burning with determination.

“And after this... I’m going to make a Contract with Kyubey. I’ll become a magical girl. So I can help you.”

Sayaka’s jaw dropped.

“Madoka! I didn’t know you had it in you to make such a big decision like that!”

Madoka pouted, her voice trembling with earnest protest.

“Please Sayaka, I am trying to be serious here!”

But Mami—

Mami froze.

Her entire world stopped.

She rushed forward and clasped Madoka’s hands, gripping them tightly.

“Madoka... are you serious?” she whispered. “You’ll become a magical girl... to fight alongside me?”

Madoka nodded, smiling gently.

Mami's hands trembled.

She stuttered, trying to warn her — trying to be responsible even as hope bloomed painfully in her chest.

"If you become a magical girl, you won't have time for friends, or dates, or ordinary joys. You'll risk your life every day. There's no turning back."

Madoka closed her eyes, smiling.

"I know. And it's thanks to you. You showed us everything honestly."

She opened her eyes again — bright, resolute.

"And even so... I think it's worth it."

Madoka looked upward, voice soft but firm.

"I always thought I was average. Someone without much to offer. But if I become a magical girl... I can help people. My life will have purpose."

Mami stared at her, trembling. She pinched her own arm, the sting sharp.

"It hurts..." she whispered. "So I'm not dreaming."

Tears spilled down her cheeks as she collapsed into Madoka's arms, hugging her tightly.

"It's real... I finally... I finally have a magical girl friend!"

Sayaka laughed, wiping her eyes.

"Geez, Mami. Getting sentimental before a witch fight?"

Mami laughed through her tears, wiping them away.

"Sorry... I didn't mean to show you my weak side."

She straightened, her usual confident smile returning — but this time, it reached her eyes.

"I can't lose in front of you now. Not after all of that."

They continued down the labyrinth together, laughing, chatting, glowing with newfound hope.

Momoko exhaled softly.

"So this is what Lunaria meant... Mami overflowing with joy after finally finding magical girl friends."

Mifuyu nodded, her voice warm and sad.

"It's beautiful. Truly."

Momoko's smile faded.

"But we already know what happened next."

She looked ahead, where the labyrinth began to twist into sharper, darker shapes.

“Mami was too distracted by this... and she died.”

She took a breath.

“Let’s see how that played out.”

The pastel glow dimmed. The air thickened. The sweetness curdled into something heavy and expectant. Momoko and Mifuyu felt the change ripple through the Connect — a subtle tightening, like the world itself bracing for impact.

Ahead of them, Mami stepped forward with renewed confidence, her Soul Gem shining brighter than it ever had. Madoka and Sayaka followed close behind, their faces glowing with admiration, trust, and the kind of innocent hope that made the labyrinth’s colors seem softer for a fleeting moment.

And then the witch appeared.

Charlotte bounced into view like a cute toy — a doll-like creature with dark eyes and tiny dot-features, swaying on stubby legs as if dancing to music only she could hear. Her movements were playful, almost adorable, but the air around her vibrated with wrongness.

Momoko and Mifuyu felt Mami’s focus sharpen.

Her joy didn’t fade — it *fueled* her.

Ribbons shot forward, wrapping around Charlotte’s tiny body. Mami swung her like a ragdoll, slamming her into the ground, the walls, the ceiling. Muskets materialized in bursts of golden light, firing in rapid succession. Each shot struck true. Each shot struck true, each movement precise and elegant.

Madoka and Sayaka cheered from the sidelines, their voices bright and unguarded.

“Wow, Mami!”

“You’ve got this!”

“Amazing!”

Mami’s heart swelled.

I feel so light... so happy...

The last time I felt like this was... when Kyoko and I were still together...

Momoko and Mifuyu felt that warmth through the Connect — a soft, glowing joy that made their own hearts flutter. It was intoxicating, the kind of happiness that made the world feel conquerable.

Mifuyu whispered, “This is just like yesterday... when I saw what Lunaria did to Kuroe’s witch. That feeling of hope... of strength...”

Momoko nodded. “And look at Mami’s Soul Gem. It’s shining brighter than before.”

Mifuyu chuckled softly. “Just like Lunaria taught us — magical girls are stronger when their hearts are light.”

Momoko grinned. “And it shows. I can feel it through Connect.”

But then Mifuyu’s expression tightened, her intuition prickling.

“Homura warned them,” she murmured. “She said this witch was different. What did she mean?”

Momoko frowned. “Yeah... how did Charlotte kill Mami? We’ve fought witches with strange abilities before. What can Charlotte do...?”

Their question was answered moments later.

Charlotte lay battered, barely twitching. Mami smiled, raising her arm with calm finality.

“Time to end this.”

Ribbons shot upward, binding Charlotte completely and suspending her high in the air. Mami manifested a massive gun — ornate, gleaming, beautiful — and aimed it with perfect precision.

“Tiro Finale!”

The beam pierced straight through Charlotte.

Her body wilted.

Mami dismissed her weapon, her ribbons, her stance. She looked up at the defeated witch with a proud, relieved smile — the smile of someone who believed the danger had passed.

And then—

Something moved.

A shape began to push through the hole in Charlotte’s body. A long, dark form. A mask-like face. Wing-shaped appendages unfurling like petals of a carnivorous flower.

Charlotte’s second form emerged.

Fast.

Too fast.

By the time Mami realized what was happening, it was already upon her.

Her smile faltered.

Then vanished.

Her eyes widened in dawning horror.

Charlotte’s face hovered inches from hers.

Then the mouth opened.

And Mami's head was inside it.

Momoko and Mifuyu felt the shock — the disbelief — the terror — as if it were happening to them. Mami's thoughts spiraled in a frantic, collapsing rush:

This... this is a bad dream right?

Am I... going to die?

Sayaka's and Madoka's screams echoed faintly through the labyrinth, distant but piercing, like cries heard underwater.

Mifuyu whispered, voice trembling, "So this... this is what Homura tried to warn her about."

Momoko swallowed hard. "A witch with multiple forms... the second one appearing after you 'defeat' the first. That's terrifying."

Mifuyu brought her hands to her chest, eyes soft with sorrow. "And Mami... she died right after Madoka said she wanted to fight by her side. It's heartbreaking."

Momoko let out a humorless chuckle — the kind born from too much pain.

"That's the life of a magical girl. Something terrible always happens at the worst possible time."

Mami shut her eyes and waited for the inevitable.

Madoka... Sayaka... I'm sorry...

Please run away... please stay alive...

And please... don't become magical girls...

Then—

A voice.

Melodic. Calm. Resonant.

"You will not die here."

Mami's fading consciousness jolted.

Who...?

The world around her began to warp. The labyrinth dissolved into darkness, the colors draining away like ink in water.

Momoko and Mifuyu felt the shift — the sudden pull, the unraveling of the memory — and they exchanged knowing smiles.

"So this is it," Momoko said softly. "This is how Lunaria saved her."

Mifuyu nodded.

“This is very similar to what happened to us. Kasumi came at the last moment and saved us right when we were about to die.”

The darkness swallowed everything.

Mami, Momoko, Mifuyu retro

Light returned slowly.

Warm, golden light.

Soft, silver light.

A gentle glow that pulsed like a shared heartbeat between three souls.

Mami, Momoko, and Mifuyu opened their eyes and found themselves once more in their Connect space — that serene, luminous realm where their magic intertwined, where their hearts resonated, where their souls breathed in harmony. The air shimmered with gold and silver hues, drifting around them like petals caught in a slow, eternal breeze. Everything felt weightless here, as though the heaviness of the world could not reach them.

For a long moment, none of them spoke.

They simply stood there, letting the silence settle, letting their breathing steady, letting the enormity of what they had witnessed sink into their bones. The echoes of each other’s memories still clung to them — prayers, sadness, rage, hatred, joy, pleasure, wishes — all woven together into something fragile and profound.

Then Momoko stepped forward, hands on her hips, her grin bright and unrestrained.

“Well,” she said cheerfully, “that was *something*, huh?”

The sound of her voice cracked the stillness like sunlight breaking through clouds.

Mami let out a soft laugh. Mifuyu followed, and soon Momoko joined them — three voices blending together in a warm, cathartic chorus. It wasn’t just laughter. It was the sound of new friendship forming, of walls lowering, of hearts opening.

Mami wiped a tear from the corner of her eye, still smiling.

“Yes,” she said softly. “It really was something.”

She took a slow breath, gathering her thoughts, letting the emotions settle into words.

“I saw you two in Mikazuki Villa... with Yachiyo, Tsuruno, and Mel.”

Her tone softened, her expression glowing with gentle nostalgia.

“Everyone looked so happy together. I could feel it — Mifuyu’s joy when the villa became lively again, after losing Kanae... that deep wish for life to stay peaceful. And Momoko’s happiness too, being part of a group that cared for each other.”

Mami looked upward, her smile tinged with wistfulness.

“It reminded me of when Kyoko and I were still together.”

Her voice dimmed slightly.

“But... I also knew those happy moments didn’t last. Kasumi showed me what she saw in the Memory Museum — Yachiyo’s and Mifuyu’s memories, the tragic truths of magical girls.”

She turned to them, her eyes soft with empathy.

“I knew Mel became a witch. But through Connect... I felt your emotions that day. The shock. The grief. The helplessness. It was nothing like hearing the story secondhand. It was... overwhelming.”

She hesitated, then added quietly:

“I don’t know how you two kept going after that. I don’t know how I would have reacted if I saw one of my friends become a witch right in front of me. In a way... I’m glad I never had to experience that.”

Momoko let out a bright, slightly embarrassed laugh. Mifuyu chuckled softly beside her.

Momoko scratched the back of her head. “Yeah... it wasn’t easy. After Mel... our group at Mikazuki Villa kinda fell apart. I was really down for a while. Didn’t know what to think about anything.”

Mami raised an eyebrow, teasing gently.

“You? Down? That’s hard to imagine. You always seem so cheerful and energetic.”

Momoko laughed. “Oh, trust me, I’ve had plenty of down moments. I just try not to let them drag me under. And hey — I ended up forming a new team with Rena and Kaede later, so things did get better!”

Mifuyu lowered her gaze, her voice soft and steady.

“For me... seeing Mel become a witch reopened the wound of losing Kanae. I felt lost. Depressed.”

She looked up at Mami, her expression open and vulnerable.

“Kasumi probably showed you how I became a Doppel after that, right?”

Mami nodded. “She did. It was a huge surprise — that there was another path besides becoming a witch.”

Mifuyu smiled faintly.

“It was a surprise for me too. It gave me a fragile hope that magical girls could be saved. That’s why I joined the Wings of the Magius. It became my anchor when I didn’t know what else to do.”

Mami stepped closer, her expression full of admiration.

“And I saw your final moments. Your Connect with Mitama... it was beautiful. I felt everything she felt — all the despair she carried as a Coordinator, all the pain she hid, all the joy she felt when you called her a friend... and all the anguish when she watched you sacrifice yourselves.”

She placed a hand over her heart.

“You two... despite everything you learned about magical girls, despite the Doppel system’s dangers... you didn’t break. You didn’t give up. You were willing to sacrifice yourselves to save others. That’s incredible.”

Mifuyu brought a hand to her lips, cheeks warming. Momoko closed her eyes and grinned proudly.

“Thank you, Mami,” Mifuyu said softly.

“Yeah,” Momoko added with a thumbs-up. “That means a lot.”

Mifuyu stepped forward, her eyes gentle.

“And we think *you* are incredible too, Mami.”

Momoko nodded. “Totally. You’re amazing.”

Mami blinked, surprised.

“Me? What did you... experience during Connect?”

Momoko was the first to speak.

“We saw you and the *real* Kyoko having a tea party,” she said, her grin widening. “And, I have to say... the tea and cake looked *delicious*.”

She licked her lips dramatically, hands on her hips.

“Mami, you must be an amazing cook. I’d love to try your cakes and teas sometime.”

Mami laughed — a soft, melodic sound that warmed the Connect space like sunlight.

“I’d be happy to make some for you. Though I wonder how they’d taste using the ingredients in this realm...”

Mifuyu smiled, her expression gentle and nostalgic.

“You and Kyoko looked very close. That scene reminded me of the happy days at Mikazuki Villa.”

Her smile dimmed, turning bittersweet.

“But... like me, your happy times didn’t last forever.”

She inhaled slowly.

“What we saw next was you and Kyoko fighting.”

Mifuyu's voice softened, heavy with empathy.

"We felt everything you felt. Every strike. Every block. Every harsh word. Your desperation to hold onto her... and her insistence on pushing you away."

She looked down at her hands, as though seeing the echoes of her own past there.

"It reminded me of my fights with Yachiyo. All the blows we exchanged... all the pain I felt when she refused to understand why I joined the Wings of the Magius."

She lifted her gaze again, eyes gentle and sincere.

"But just like Yachiyo and I eventually reconciled... I truly hope you and the real Kyoko can reconcile one day too."

Mami's expression softened, touched.

"Thank you, Mifuyu. I... hope for that as well."

Momoko stepped in, her tone shifting.

"What we saw afterward was... really hard to watch."

Her fists clenched at her sides.

"You living alone. Fighting witches alone. Protecting people from the shadows without any recognition or gratitude."

Mifuyu nodded, her voice quiet and steady.

"We felt your pain every time you had to turn down invitations from classmates. The ache in your heart when you saw normal people living happy lives... completely unaware of the sacrifices you made so they *could* live those lives."

Momoko's voice cracked slightly.

"And the way you cried alone every night... letting out everything you bottled up during the day... Mami, that hurt to feel."

Mifuyu added softly:

"That feeling was new to us. In Kamihama, magical girls work together. We always had someone. And the Wings of the Magius... for all their flaws... did provide support. We were never truly alone."

Momoko looked at Mami with a bright, earnest grin — the kind that could lift anyone's spirits.

"That's why I think you're amazing. Despite all that loneliness and pain, you still stuck to your ideals. You still protected people. I don't know if I could stay this cheerful if I was all alone."

Mifuyu nodded.

“I would have become a witch if I had been alone. Without the Magius’ APS system... I wouldn’t have survived.”

Mami brought a hand to her face, cheeks flushing.

“Thank you... both of you. Even after seeing me at my weakest, loneliest moments... you still say such kind things. You’re just like Madoka and Sayaka.”

Momoko winked.

“Of course! All magical girls have moments of weakness. What matters is how you keep going afterward.”

Mifuyu’s voice was soft, soothing.

“It’s okay to cry. To show vulnerability. That’s something we told the doppelified magical girls when we saved them — and it helped them feel safe.”

She hesitated, then continued gently:

“Mami... since you mentioned Madoka and Sayaka... may I ask about Homura?”

At the name, Mami’s expression shifted — softening, shadowed with regret.

Mifuyu continued carefully.

“We saw Homura warn you and Madoka that Charlotte was different. She offered to fight the witch alone... and even give you the grief seed afterward.”

Momoko nodded.

“And after you bound her... her face changed. She looked desperate. Like she *knew* you were going to die. Like she was hurting inside because she couldn’t stop it.”

She tilted her head.

“So... what happened between you two? Sayaka also seemed to really dislike her.”

Mami took a slow breath, her voice heavy.

“My first interaction with Homura was... strange. She was trying to kill Kyubey. He cried out for help, and that’s how Madoka and Sayaka got pulled into the world of magical girls.”

She looked down.

“Her personality irritated me. She was cold. Distant. Emotionless. I thought she was arrogant. And she kept insisting Madoka shouldn’t make a contract. I assumed she was jealous — that she sensed Madoka’s potential and didn’t want a strong magical girl in Mitakihara.”

Mami’s voice grew quieter.

“But... now that I reflect on it... maybe I disliked her because I wanted Madoka or Sayaka to become magical girls. I wanted someone to fight beside me. And Homura’s warnings... they threatened that hope.”

She closed her eyes.

“One day, I asked to meet her alone. I told her I didn’t want to see her again. And that if we met... I wouldn’t hold back.”

She opened her eyes again, filled with regret.

“So when she showed up in Charlotte’s labyrinth... I didn’t listen. I didn’t even try.”

Her voice trembled.

“And because of that... I died. And Homura had to save Madoka and Sayaka.”

Mami looked at Momoko and Mifuyu with a forlorn smile.

“After Lunaria saved me, she showed me projections of Mitakihara. I’ve seen Homura show flickers of emotion no one else notices. She... truly cares. And she’s carrying something very heavy. Something she keeps entirely to herself. Something she cannot share.”

Momoko and Mifuyu exchanged a knowing look.

“We think so as well,” Momoko said. “She seems mysterious.”

Mifuyu nodded.

“I wonder what happened to her.”

Momoko stretched her arms over her head, shaking off the heaviness that had settled over them like dew. The Connect space still shimmered around them — gold and silver drifting in slow spirals — but the emotional weight of everything they had shared lingered in the air. Even so, her grin returned — bright, grounding, and full of momentum.

“Well,” she said, “speculating about Homura won’t get us anywhere in saving Sayaka. Let’s get back on track.”

She turned to Mami, her expression shifting into something earnest and focused.

“Mami, what do you know about Sayaka? Why is she breaking? What happened to her? The more we understand, the better we can help her.”

Mami’s expression softened into something sadder, heavier — a quiet ache that rippled through the Connect like a tremor. She lowered her gaze, gathering her thoughts with care.

“Lunaria’s clone showed me and dream-Kyoko what happened last night,” she said quietly. “Through a projection.”

Momoko and Mifuyu straightened, listening closely.

“Madoka, Sayaka, and the real Kyoko learned one of the truths of magical girls — that they are no longer human. Their souls are literally inside their Soul Gems. Their bodies are just... shells. If their Soul Gem gets too far away, they lose consciousness. And eventually... they die.”

Momoko’s breath caught. Mifuyu’s eyes narrowed, her heart tightening in sympathy.

“All of them were devastated,” Mami continued. “But Sayaka... Sayaka was shattered.”

She paused, letting the memory settle, letting the pain of it surface.

“And then... something else happened. Sayaka’s friend Hitomi told her that she loves Kyōsuke — the boy Sayaka also loves. Hitomi said she would give Sayaka until after school today to confess. Otherwise... she would confess herself.”

Momoko winced. Mifuyu’s hand flew to her chest.

“Kyōsuke was a violinist,” Mami said softly. “A brilliant one. But after an accident, he couldn’t play anymore. Sayaka visited him constantly in the hospital. She... she wished for him to heal. She sacrificed her humanity so he could play again.”

Her voice trembled.

“And now she feels she can’t confess since she is no longer human. She gave up everything for him... and she’s about to lose him to someone else.”

Momoko and Mifuyu fell silent, their expressions stiffening with sorrow.

“That’s so cruel...” Mifuyu whispered.

Mami nodded slowly. “She became... cold. Withdrawn. Fighting witches alone. Pushing everyone away. She told Madoka and Kyoko that she’ll carve out her own path as a magical girl. She refuses help. She refuses comfort. She refuses to be vulnerable.”

Mifuyu exhaled shakily, her voice trembling with empathy.

“The Sayaka we saw in your memories — she was cheerful, outspoken, full of life. To think she would change that much in such a short time...”

Momoko’s voice softened, her usual brightness dimming into something gentler.

“A lot of magical girls react like that after learning the truth. But Sayaka... she’s also dealing with heartbreak...”

Her words trailed off.

Heartbreak...

The word echoed inside her.

Her eyes lowered. Her expression shifted — something quiet, something raw flickering beneath her usual cheer. Painful memories resurfacing.

So Sayaka is just like me...

Mifuyu and Mami noticed immediately — the subtle change in her posture, the way her smile faltered at the edges.

“Momoko?” Mifuyu asked gently. “Are you alright?”

Momoko blinked, startled out of her thoughts. She closed her eyes, shook her head, and smiled — bright, but softer than before.

“I’m fine! Really. I just... thought of something. Something I can do to help bring Sayaka back from despair.”

Mami and Mifuyu exchanged curious looks.

“What do you mean?” Mami asked.

Momoko brought a finger to her lips and winked, her grin returning with renewed spark.

“It’s a surprise. You’ll see when training starts.”

Mifuyu laughed softly, the sound like a breeze stirring petals. Mami smiled, warmth returning to her eyes — a warmth that felt steadier now, anchored by understanding and connection.

“You girls ready to go?!” Momoko asked, her energy rising like a tide.

Mami and Mifuyu looked at each other — and nodded.

“Yes,” they said together.

The Connect space brightened, golden and silver light swirling around them like a rising tide. Warmth enveloped them, lifting them gently, dissolving the space around them as they prepared to return to the waking dream-realm — stronger, closer, and more determined than before.

Mami, Momoko, Mifuyu training begins

The moment they opened their eyes, the world of gold and silver dissolved into soft daylight. The Connect space faded like a dream slipping from their fingertips, leaving behind only the warmth of shared hearts and the faint echo of intertwined magic.

When the light settled, they were back in the garden.

The air was warm and fragrant, thick with the scent of blooming vines and dream-flowers. The sky above them shifted in gentle pastels, watercolor hues drifting and blending as though painted by a living hand. For a heartbeat, none of them moved. Their bodies were here, but their minds were still

half-anchored in the emotional gravity of the Connect — the memories they had shared, the wounds they had touched, the trust they had built.

Then Momoko looked down at her chest, where her Soul Gem rested.

Her eyes sparkled.

“Whoa... look at this!”

Mifuyu instinctively reached for the gem hanging from her choker. Mami lifted the flower ornament on the right side of her head, revealing her own Soul Gem nestled within.

All three of them gasped softly.

Their Soul Gems were shining brilliantly — gold and silver spiraling together in intricate patterns, interwoven like threads of shared light. The glow pulsed gently, as if echoing the rhythm of their hearts, a quiet reminder of the bond they had forged.

A voice drifted toward them from ahead, casual and amused.

“You’re done, huh?”

They looked up.

Dream-Kyoko sat perched on a glowing rock, legs crossed, eating what looked like a fruit cake — a pastry with translucent, rainbow-colored filling that shimmered like stained glass. She looked perfectly at ease, crumbs dusting her fingers, as though she had been waiting for them for hours.

Momoko’s eyes widened. “Where did you get that? It looks amazing — and that filling...!”

Mami grinned, warmth returning to her expression. “This must be what Kasumi meant earlier. Kyoko’s famous for snacks in the dream realm.”

Mifuyu tilted her head, intrigued. “Did you Connect with the plants here to make that cake? Like what Lunaria does?”

Kyoko nodded, still chewing. “Yup. While you three were Connecting, I wandered around and Connected with the plants. They shared their essences with me. So I made this.”

She winked, a spark of mischief in her eyes.

“If you want, I can make more for you after training.”

Momoko’s mouth watered instantly. “Yes please! Trying more magical dream-realm food? Count me in!”

Mifuyu chuckled at her enthusiasm. “That would be lovely.”

Mami smiled warmly. “Then I’ll prepare tea for everyone.”

She turned to Momoko, teasing lightly.

“After all, you did say you wanted to try my teas sometime, right?”

Momoko grinned back. “Yup! So let’s get training started!”

Mami and Mifuyu nodded, their spirits lifted by the familiar banter.

“We’re ready,” they said together.

Kyoko finished the last bite of her cake and exhaled with satisfaction. “Ahh, that really hit the spot.”

Then she stood, turning toward them with a smirk — the kind that promised both challenge and excitement.

“Alright then. Let’s begin.”

She clapped her hands.

Her crimson Soul Gem flared with light — and the warm-toned pillars throughout the garden, wrapped in ivy, moss, and flowering vines, glowed in perfect sync with her. The air vibrated, humming with magic.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Mami gasped as the world around them rippled. Reality bent, twisted, and folded like a sheet of silk being pulled into a new shape.

Mami’s breath caught. “Is this... Kyoko’s illusion magic? I’ve never seen her use it like this before...!”

Mifuyu nodded, eyes wide with awe. “She’s resonating with the pillars. Look — they’re glowing with her Soul Gem.”

The world stabilized.

They were no longer in the garden.

They stood in a park. A quiet city park with benches, lampposts, and a fountain. The air smelled like early evening in a real city, cool and tinged with distant traffic.

Mami’s voice trembled. “This... this looks just like Mitakihara. I had picnics with Kyoko here in the past... and later with Madoka and Sayaka.”

Momoko’s eyes narrowed. “Speaking of Sayaka...”

Mifuyu and Mami turned to follow her gaze.

Sayaka stood a short distance away.

Her eyes were hollow.

Her Soul Gem was tainted — dark, cracked, pulsing with corruption.

Her posture slumped, her expression empty, her aura heavy with despair.

She looked like a girl whose heart had been shattered and left to bleed.

Mifuyu's breath hitched. "I... I only expected Kyoko to corrupt her Soul Gem. Not transform into Sayaka."

Momoko nodded slowly. "This reminds me of Rena's ability — transforming into others and using their abilities. Does Kyoko have access to Sayaka's magic now?"

Mifuyu chuckled nervously. "If she does... this will be interesting. We have no idea what Sayaka's abilities even are."

Mami swallowed hard. "From what I saw... Sayaka fights with swords. She also has powerful regeneration and incredible endurance."

She paused, recalling the projection.

"... And she started using a technique Kyubey taught her — how to ignore pain entirely during battle."

A shiver ran through her.

"It was terrifying. She charged into a witch's attacks laughing... as if she couldn't feel anything at all."

Momoko and Mifuyu exchanged a look — their eyes narrowing, their stances shifting into readiness.

"So," Momoko muttered, "we're dealing with a heartbroken, unstable girl who can snap at any moment."

Mifuyu nodded. "I wonder how this will compare to saving the doppelified magical girls yesterday."

Mami stared at Sayaka — at the broken reflection of the girl she once knew.

This was not just any illusion.

This was Sayaka's heart.

Her despair.

Her reality.

Mami stepped forward, her voice barely above a whisper.

"What we do here... will decide whether we can save her."

The air grew still.

Sayaka lifted her head.

Her empty eyes locked onto them.

Sayaka's head tilted slightly as she regarded them — her movements slow, almost puppet-like, as though her body were responding on delay. When she finally spoke, her voice was flat, hollow, stripped of the spark that once defined her.

"...Mami? I'm surprised to see you."

Her eyes didn't change. They remained empty, glassy, reflecting nothing.

"I saw you get killed by Charlotte."

She glanced at Momoko and Mifuyu, her gaze sliding over them like water over glass — not truly seeing them, not truly caring.

"And it looks like you've made new friends."

Mami stepped forward carefully, her posture soft, her voice gentle — every word chosen with the precision of someone approaching a wounded animal that might bolt or bite.

"Yes... Charlotte defeated me. But as you can see, I didn't die."

She offered a small, hopeful smile.

"I'm glad to see you again, Sayaka. Truly. But... are you glad to see me?"

Sayaka let out a small chuckle — but it was wrong. Hollow. A sound without warmth, like laughter echoing in an empty room.

"Of course I'm glad to see you, Mami."

But her eyes remained dead.

Mami's heart tightened.

"You don't sound like yourself," she said softly. "You don't have your usual energy. Did something happen?"

Sayaka began to walk — slow, heavy steps circling the three of them like a predator tracing the edge of its cage. Her boots scraped against the ground with a dull, dragging sound.

"A lot has happened," she murmured. "Since the day you lost to Charlotte."

She stopped behind them, her voice drifting like cold wind.

"Madoka, Kyoko, and I learned something you didn't know."

She stepped back into view, her expression unchanged, her eyes hollow.

"We learned that magical girls aren't human. We're... living corpses. Zombies."

Her hand lifted, pointing to her Soul Gem — cracked, dark, pulsing with corruption.

"Our souls are in these gems. Our bodies are empty shells. Kyubey tricked us."

She stared at Mami, waiting — testing — as though daring her to deny it.

Mami inhaled slowly, steadying herself.

"You're right. I didn't know," she said quietly. "If I had known, I would have told you and Madoka immediately. Kyubey never told me either."

She stepped closer, her eyes firm with conviction.

“But Sayaka... even if your body has changed, *you* haven’t. Your soul, your personality, your memories — everything that makes you who you are — it’s all still there.”

Her voice softened, warm and steady.

“You’re still alive. And your life still matters. Your friends still matter.”

Sayaka let out a laugh — sharp, brittle, empty.

“Life? Friends?”

She repeated the words as though tasting something bitter.

Then her voice dropped, cracking at the edges.

“I made a wish to heal Kyōsuke. I gave up my humanity for him. And now... I can’t even confess to him. I’m not human anymore. I’m a corpse wearing a skin-suit.”

Her hands trembled — not with fear, but with despair so deep it hollowed her out from the inside.

“And Hitomi... she’s going to confess to him today. I’m going to lose him. The boy I sacrificed everything for.”

She looked away, her voice splintering into something raw.

“And Madoka... I cut ties with her. I was sick of her nagging me about what I should or shouldn’t do as a magical girl when she’s too scared to become one herself.”

Her eyes narrowed, pain twisting into resentment.

“She cries and pretends she understands my suffering. But she doesn’t. She can’t.”

Sayaka’s shoulders slumped, her posture collapsing inward.

“So I’m alone now. I’ll carve my own path as a magical girl.”

Silence fell — heavy, suffocating, thick with grief.

Mami stepped forward, her voice trembling with emotion.

“You’re not alone, Sayaka. I’m here. I’ll help you however I can. Please... trust me.”

Sayaka shook her head.

“Thank you, Mami. But no.”

Her tone was final — a door closing.

“I’m carving out my own path as a magical girl. I’ll keep saving people from the shadows. Fighting witches alone.”

She looked down at her corrupted Soul Gem, her expression empty.

“That’s all this body is good for now.”

A telepathic whisper rippled through the Connect — soft, urgent, intimate.

Momoko: *She’s given up on happiness. On friendship. On herself.*

Mifuyu: *It’s like Kyoko... but worse. Kyoko isolated herself, but she still cared about her own survival. Sayaka doesn’t even have that.*

Mami: *Then it’s time. Let’s execute our plan.*

Momoko and Mifuyu smiled — small, determined smiles — and nodded.

Mifuyu: *I’m ready.*

Momoko: *Let’s do it!*

Mami lifted her hand.

Golden light shimmered around her fingers — soft at first, like the glow of a lantern behind silk — then burst outward in a radiant bloom that rippled through the air. Her ribbons manifested.

And she gasped.

So this is what my magic looks like when Connecting with Momoko and Mifuyu...

They were nothing like the ribbons she had always known. Nothing like the ones she used with dream-Kyoko. These were new — unfamiliar, yet deeply hers.

They unfurled around her in graceful arcs, each strand adorned with lunar motifs: crescents, full moons, waxing and waning phases. The ribbons glowed in shifting hues that mirrored the lunar cycle — pale silver, deep gold, soft blue, rose-pink — each one pulsing with a different rhythm, like a constellation of emotions woven into silk.

And drifting between them were floating orbs of color — tiny spheres trailing comet-like tails, spiraling around her in elegant, playful arcs.

A telepathic whisper brushed her mind, warm and intimate.

Mifuyu: *They’re beautiful, Mami. I can feel my magic flowing through them... like moonlight woven into fabric.*

Momoko: *Same here! Those little comet-things — that’s totally my magic. I wonder what they can do now.*

Mami smiled softly, her heart swelling with quiet wonder.

Momoko’s voice brightened with excitement.

Try reaching out to Sayaka with them. Since our magic and souls are in sync, Mifuyu and I will try to share in Sayaka's despair — feel what she's feeling.

Mifuyu's tone was calm, steady, grounding.

And we'll rely on you to take that negativity from us and redirect it. Otherwise we'll be overwhelmed.

Mami nodded.

I'll do it.

She raised her hand, preparing to send her ribbons forward—

But Sayaka suddenly tilted her head, her empty eyes widening just a fraction.

“...Mami? What happened to your ribbons?”

Her voice was flat, but there was a flicker of something — confusion, suspicion, maybe even fear.

“They look... different. Completely different from before. What happened to you after Charlotte defeated you?”

Mami froze.

Of course. Sayaka doesn't know about Connect. To her, this sudden transformation must look unnatural. Impossible. Maybe even threatening.

Mami inhaled, then reached out to the others.

Maybe... maybe we can get her to open up if we show her what working with others can do. If she sees what Connect creates... it might reach her.

Mifuyu: *That's a good idea. If we can save her without resorting to what we did yesterday... that would be ideal.*

Momoko: *Heh. But it'd be kinda anticlimactic if it worked instantly. Training over before it even starts.*

Mami hid a small smile, then turned back to Sayaka.

“A lot happened after Charlotte,” she said gently. “One of the things I learned is a technique called Connect.”

Sayaka's lips parted slightly.

“...Connect?”

She whispered the word like it was foreign, like it tasted strange in her mouth.

Mami nodded.

“Connect is a technique where you attune yourself to life. You open your heart to others. You listen to them. You learn about them. You understand them.”

Her ribbons floated around her like living silk, shimmering with shared magic.

“And through Connect, you share your essence — the core of who you are — with others, and they share theirs with you.”

She gestured to her ribbons.

“These ribbons contain my magic... and Mifuyu’s... and Momoko’s.”

Mifuyu and Momoko smiled and gave small waves.

“Our magic isn’t just added together,” Mami continued. “It’s significantly magnified. We gain new abilities — limited only by our imagination.”

She extended her hand toward Sayaka, her smile warm and hopeful.

“Sayaka... if you open your heart again, even just a little... you can Connect with me. You can see for yourself.”

Sayaka stared at Mami’s hand.

At the glowing ribbons.

At the comet-like orbs drifting around her.

At the impossible beauty of it all.

Her expression didn’t change — but something flickered behind her eyes. Confusion. Curiosity. Fear. Longing.

And doubt.

So much doubt.

Her thoughts churned — visible in the slight tremor of her fingers.

How did Mami survive Charlotte?

Where did she learn this?

Who are these girls?

Is there a catch?

Is this another truth Mami didn’t know?

Finally, Sayaka looked up.

“...I’ll pass.”

Mami’s hand faltered.

Sayaka continued, voice flat.

“Even if Connect is everything you say... how can it help you understand me? You made a wish for yourself — to survive. I made my wish for someone I loved. And I’m about to lose him.”

She looked down at her corrupted Soul Gem, her voice cracking.

“And Kyubey told me something else. He said you and Kyoko have more talent than I do. So it makes sense your ribbons look so different now. I’m weak. Connect won’t help me much. And I can’t offer anything to anyone.”

She smiled — a small, broken smile that hurt to look at.

“Besides... Kyubey taught me a technique so I’ll never lose a witch fight again. All I have to do is block out pain. I tried it and it worked great. Even someone like me can win that way.”

Mami’s hand dropped.

She exhaled softly — a sigh of sorrow.

It didn’t work...

Mifuyu: *At least you tried. I didn’t expect it to be that easy.*

Momoko: *Honestly? I prefer it this way. Makes training more fun!*

Sayaka turned away from them, her steps slow and heavy, as though each movement dragged a weight behind it. Her voice drifted back to them — soft, hollow, stripped of all the brightness she once carried.

“Well... if that’s all, I’ll take my leave. It was nice seeing you again, Mami.”

She began to walk.

Mami’s breath caught.

Something inside her — something warm, fragile, and fiercely protective — snapped taut.

“Sayaka—wait.”

Sayaka stopped mid-step.

Behind Mami, her ribbons flared open like wings of moonlit silk, glowing with the shared magic of three hearts. The lunar motifs shimmered, the comet-orbs pulsed, and the air around her trembled with quiet resolve.

“I can’t stand to see you suffering alone like this,” Mami said, her voice trembling with conviction.

“We’re going to save you from your despair.”

Sayaka turned her head slightly, her expression unreadable — a mask carved from exhaustion and grief.

“So that’s it? You, Momoko, and Mifuyu want to fight me now? Beat me up until I change my mind?”

She sighed — a hollow, exhausted sound that seemed to drain the color from the air.

“I don’t see how that will save me.”

A sword materialized in her hand with a flash of blue light. She pointed it at them, her posture steady but her eyes empty.

“Fine. If you insist.”

Mami’s ribbons shot forward — dozens of them — weaving through the air in spirals, arcs, and sweeping curves. They moved like living things, each one glowing with lunar phases and comet-tails, each one carrying the combined magic of three souls in harmony.

Sayaka’s eyes narrowed.

So she’s trying to bind me... I know this trick.

She summoned more swords — five, then ten, then a full ring of them orbiting her like a halo of cold steel.

I just need to intercept them before they reach me.

She flicked her wrist.

The swords shot forward.

They clashed with Mami’s ribbons in a burst of color and sound — steel ringing against enchanted silk. Each impact sent ripples of light through the air. Sayaka’s blades sliced through several ribbons, the severed pieces drifting downward like falling leaves, sparkling with gold, silver, and pastel hues.

One ribbon slipped past the barrage, darting toward Sayaka’s side.

Sayaka reacted instantly.

She spun, her sword flashing in a flurry of strokes — a blur of blue light and cold precision. The ribbon was shredded into drifting fragments.

“Give it up, Mami,” Sayaka said flatly. “I know how your ribbons work.”

She raised her sword again—

And froze.

A strange sensation pulsed through her Soul Gem.

Something was touching it.

Reaching for it.

Brushing against the core of her being.

But nothing had physically touched her.

No ribbon.

No magic she could see.

No spell she could sense.

Her eyes widened.

“...Mami? What did you do?”

Mifuyu clasped her hands, her voice drifting through the Connect like a soft breeze.

Beautifully done, Mami. You used my illusion magic to hide the ribbons that touched her Soul Gem. She can't see them — or sense them.

Momoko laughed, bright and proud.

That was awesome, Mami! Now it's our turn.

The comet-orbs around Mami flared, drifting toward Sayaka in spirals of shimmering color. The lunar lights brightened, circling her like phases of the moon.

Momoko and Mifuyu focused.

They reached out.

They attuned themselves to Sayaka's Soul Gem.

And what they felt hit them like a tidal wave.

Sayaka was drowning.

Not in one emotion — but in dozens, all crashing into each other, tangled and suffocating.

Resolve — fierce, burning, desperate.

I'll keep fighting. I'll protect people. Even if no one sees me.

Regret — sharp and suffocating.

I should have confessed to Kyōsuke.

I shouldn't have made that wish.

I shouldn't have yelled at Madoka.

Contempt — bitter, tangled, self-directed and outward.

I'm weak. I'm useless.

Hitomi... how dare she confess to him. I was the one who truly loved him.

Madoka... she doesn't understand anything.

Despair — deep, cold, endless.

I'm going to lose Kyōsuke.

I'm all alone.

What is the point of living?

Momoko and Mifuyu staggered, breath catching.

Momoko: *This... this is nothing like the doppelified girls. This is chaos. Everything's tangled together.*

Mifuyu: *I understand now... the true scope of Mitama's abilities. We could attune to the doppelified girls because Mitama had already adjusted their Soul Gems — and she shared her Coordinator abilities with us through Connect.*

Momoko grimaced.

We only thought about Mitama not being here. We didn't think about Sayaka's Soul Gem never being adjusted at all. Magical girls in Kamihama... we take that for granted.

Mifuyu let out a soft, breathless chuckle — sad, grateful, humbled.

Mitama really has been doing so much for us. We need to thank her properly next time.

Then—

The comet-orbs flickered.

The lunar lights dimmed.

And all the magic drifting around Sayaka was violently pushed away — scattering like sparks blown from a fire.

Momoko and Mifuyu were thrown back a step, the shockwave rippling through their bodies. Mami staggered as well, her ribbons trembling.

Sayaka stood unmoved.

She looked at them with empty eyes.

“I told you,” she said quietly. “You can’t understand me. You can’t understand my suffering.”

She lowered her sword.

“You should give up.”

Mami steadied herself, ribbons trembling around her like thin branches in a gentle breeze. The air still vibrated with the shock of Sayaka’s rejection, the failed attunement lingering like a bruise in the Connect. She turned to Momoko and Mifuyu, her voice low, threaded with worry.

“What should we try next...? Attuning to her Soul Gem didn’t work.”

Mifuyu exhaled softly, her expression thoughtful, her eyes distant as she replayed the chaotic emotions they had just touched.

“If Sayaka’s Soul Gem had been adjusted by Mitama, we might have had a chance. But as it is... her Soul Gem is completely different from what we’re used to in Kamihama.”

Momoko nodded, brushing dust from her skirt with a little shake of her hands.

“Yeah, that was rough. But we *did* learn something.”

She looked at Mifuyu — and grinned, bright and confident.

“We got a peek into Sayaka’s heart. And now... it’s our turn to use our own abilities.”

Mifuyu’s eyes softened with understanding, a quiet determination settling into her posture.

“Yes. My illusions... and your encouragement. We may be able to reach her in our own way.”

Momoko looked forward, her grin widening.

“All right, here I go!”

She held out both hands and concentrated her magic.

Golden flames burst from her Soul Gem — not harsh or scorching, but warm, fierce, alive. They swirled up her arms, coiling around her fingertips before rising into the air in front of her.

From those flames, two blades descended — as though forged from the fire itself. The tongues of flame wrapped around the forming metal, shaping it, blessing it, before fading into shimmering embers.

Momoko caught the blades eagerly.

Her eyes sparkled.

“There are *two* of them now?!”

The swords glowed like moonlight — one shaped like a waxing crescent, the other like a waning crescent. Their handles were wrapped in golden ribbons that extended outward, fluttering around the blades like living streamers, responding to her heartbeat.

“They’re so light!”

She swung them experimentally.

The blades cleaved cleanly through the air, leaving behind luminous after-images that faded slowly, like comet tails dissolving into the night sky.

“These feel amazing,” she said, mouth open in awe. “So full of energy. I can’t wait to see what they can do!”

Mifuyu took a deep breath and held out her right hand.

Gentle silver streams of light flowed from her Soul Gem, swirling gracefully through her body before gathering along her right arm. The light condensed above her palm — shimmering, fluid, alive.

Hovering above her hand was a sleek piece of metal, glowing with gentle moonlight. Embedded within it were tiny spheres with comet-like tails, brimming with restless energy, as though waiting for a path to open.

The silver streams began to move in an arc.

The metal grew along that arc, expanding like a crescent moon unfurling. The tiny comet-spheres flowed through the forming metal, orbiting along the path of the silver light.

As the chakram's circumference took shape, attachments formed along its edge — blades that curved like petals, gun-like mechanisms that hummed with potential, ribbon-emitters that pulsed with soft light. It was a multi-tool forged from moonlight and comets, elegant and deadly.

Mifuyu gasped softly.

"I did not expect it to look like this. How beautiful."

When the chakram fully formed, ribbons blossomed from the point where the circle closed — fluttering around her like loyal familiars, drifting in gentle spirals.

Mifuyu moved her hands gracefully.

The chakram responded instantly, flowing with her movements like an extension of her own body — weightless, obedient, perfect.

"My control... it's incredible," she whispered. "It responds to every intention."

Mami smiled, warmth blooming in her chest.

"So this is what our Connect looks like."

Sayaka's eyes narrowed as she watched them — not impressed, not intimidated, but wary.

"So now you're planning to use brute force? Since Mami's ribbons failed?"

More swords materialized around her, orbiting like a cold, metallic halo.

"It won't make a difference. You can't change my mind by beating me up."

Momoko grinned, her crescent blades glowing brighter.

"Oh no! We're not planning to use brute force."

Mifuyu spun.

Her chakram spun with her — then shot forward like a streak of silver.

Sayaka braced herself, raising her sword.

But the chakram multiplied.

One became three.

Three became seven.

Seven became a dozen — curving in from all directions, weaving through the air like a constellation coming to life.

Sayaka's eyes widened.

She sent her orbiting swords to intercept them. Some blades struck true, deflecting the chakrams' paths — but others passed through them harmlessly, slicing through illusions that dissolved into silver dust.

Each time a sword touched a chakram — solid or not — a musical tone rang out.

Soft.

Clear.

Melodic.

The tones layered atop one another, forming a haunting, beautiful harmony — a deep, moving song that resonated through the air like a memory.

Sayaka froze.

Her heart lurched.

Her soul stirred.

A warmth surfaced deep inside her — faint, fragile, but unmistakable.

Kyōsuke... playing the violin again...

His family crying with joy...

The day I thought was the best day of my life...

Sayaka's eyes widened, confusion breaking through the emptiness.

Why... why am I feeling this?

Why does this music make me feel... happy?

It should hurt.

It should make everything worse.

So why—

Mami's eyes went wide.

“It's working...! She reacted!”

Momoko beamed, her swords glowing brighter.

“Nice job, Mifuyu! Using sound as a medium for your illusions — reaching her through her memories — soooo cool!”

“Alright,” Momoko said brightly, her voice ringing with renewed confidence, “my turn. Let's see what my encouragement can do now!”

She swung her crescent swords in wide, sweeping arcs.

From each swing, beams of light burst forth — waxing and waning crescents that carved luminous paths through the air. At the same time, crescents of light shot from her blades, and mini-comets fired from the gun-attachments on Mifuyu's chakram, streaking forward in shimmering trails.

All of it converged on Sayaka.

She was engulfed in warm light — the gentle, calming glow of a full moon on a clear night. The air softened, the colors brightened, and the world around her blurred into something warm and dreamlike.

Sayaka blinked, startled.

And Momoko stepped out of the light.

Whether she was real or an illusion, Sayaka couldn't tell. The edges of her form shimmered like a mirage, but her presence felt solid — comforting.

Her smile was warm. Bright. Disarming.

“Hey, Sayaka,” Momoko said, voice gentle and encouraging. “You’re not alone in what you’re feeling. I’ve been where you are.”

Sayaka stared at her, disbelief flickering across her face.

“...You? Understand me?”

Momoko's smile softened. The brightness dimmed into something quieter, sadder.

“Yes. I’ve been heartbroken too.”

Sayaka's eyes widened — the first true emotion she'd shown since the fight began.

“...Explain.”

Momoko inhaled slowly, her voice steady but tinged with pain.

“I... I became a magical girl because of a boy I liked,” she said softly. “But I didn't make a wish for him... like you did for Kyōsuke.”

Sayaka frowned, confused.

“If you didn't make a wish for him... then what do you mean you became a magical girl because of him?”

Momoko's expression shifted — melancholy settling into her eyes like a shadow.

“I didn't think I was feminine enough. I was scared to confess. I thought... I wouldn't be able to connect with him romantically.”

Sayaka's breath hitched.

That insecurity — that fear — was painfully familiar.

That was why she herself never confessed to Kyōsuke.

Momoko continued, voice soft and trembling.

“So I made a wish. I asked Kyubey to give me courage. Courage to confess to the boy I liked.”

Golden comets shot out of Momoko's Soul Gem, swirling upward before forming a mirage beside them.

A younger Momoko stood before Kyubey — hesitant, trembling, debating.

Should I do this? Will this actually work?

Then she nodded, determination lighting her eyes.

“Okay... Can you grant me courage? I want the courage to confess my feelings to the boy I like.”

Light enveloped her as the mirage faded, leaving the comets drifting in the air like glowing memories.

Sayaka watched, transfixed.

Momoko’s voice wavered as she continued.

“After I made the wish... I went to him. I was ready. I was finally brave enough. But...”

Her voice trailed off. She clenched her fists, lowering her gaze.

The comets shifted again, forming another mirage.

A younger Momoko stood frozen, eyes wide, mouth open in shock, as the boy she loved walked away hand-in-hand with another girl.

Momoko’s voice cracked.

“But when I got there... I saw another girl confess to him. And he accepted.

I... I made my wish for nothing.”

Sayaka’s heart twisted.

Because in that moment, the mirage shifted in her mind.

The girl became Hitomi.

The boy became Kyōsuke.

And Sayaka felt jealousy, rage, regret, despair — all of it rising like a storm.

But something else rose with it.

Something small.

Something fragile.

Empathy.

This stranger — this cheerful, bright magical girl — had just shown her a wound so personal, so painful, that Sayaka felt it echo inside her own chest.

Sayaka looked at Momoko, voice trembling.

“Why... why would you share this with me? We don’t even know each other.”

Momoko winked and gave her a thumbs-up.

“Because magical girls should always have each other’s backs.”

Her tone softened, her smile warm and sincere.

“And because Mami is so worried about you. Your despair isn’t just hurting you — it’s hurting the people who care about you.”

Sayaka’s expression wavered.

Kyoko’s face flashed in her mind.

Madoka’s tearful eyes.

Mami’s trembling voice.

Momoko stepped closer, her crescent blades dimming into soft moonlight.

“Even if your friends can’t fully understand you... they can share your burden. Your pain. And you should try to understand their pain too — the pain of watching someone they love fall apart.”

Sayaka’s breath hitched.

She had been so focused on her own suffering — so convinced no one could understand her — that she never once considered the suffering she caused others.

Her mind wrestled with the weight of it.

Her despair.

Her guilt.

Her loneliness.

Her new, fragile empathy.

All of it tangled together, pulling her in opposite directions.

Sayaka lowered her gaze.

Her shoulders trembled.

Her fists clenched.

Her teeth ground together.

A storm of thoughts tore through her mind, each one contradicting the last, each one pulling her toward a different future she couldn’t bear to face

Should I open up to them?

Should I try to Connect?

Should I go back to Kyoko?

Should I apologize to Madoka?

Should I... try again?

But every path led to the same wall.

I'm going to lose Kyōsuke.

I'm not human.

I will never find love.

What's the point?

Her body slumped forward, hunched over as though the weight of her despair had finally crushed her spine.

A low chuckle escaped her.

At first it was small — a breath, a tremor.

Then it grew.

And grew.

Until it twisted into something sharp and wrong.

Momoko stiffened. “Sayaka...? Are you okay?”

Sayaka straightened slowly, her eyes still closed.

Then she threw her head back and laughed — a wild, manic sound that echoed through the illusion-park like a cracked bell. The sound was too loud, too jagged, too hollow. It sent chills down Momoko's spine.

Momoko swallowed hard. “Mami... Mifuyu... I don't have a good feeling about this.”

Mifuyu and Mami both felt it too — a cold, creeping dread that slithered through the Connect like black ink.

Sayaka placed a hand over her face.

When she lowered it, her eyes were open — wide, gleaming, unhinged.

“Thank you, Momoko,” she said, still laughing. “You helped me see things clearly.”

Momoko forced a smile, careful and slow. “I... I'm glad if it helped. What exactly are you clear about?”

Sayaka's grin widened, stretching too far.

“That nothing matters anymore!”

Momoko's eyes narrowed. “What do you mean?”

Sayaka spread her arms, her voice rising into a feverish crescendo.

“I was heartbroken before. I pushed everyone away because I thought no one understood me. I'm going to lose the boy I love. And I'll never be able to love anyone else — because I'm no longer human. My life is ruined.”

She glared at Momoko and pointed her sword at her.

“But thanks to you, I realized something. I’m not alone in that. *You* are stuck with the same fate.”

Momoko froze.

Sayaka continued, voice sharp and cruel, dripping with venom.

“You’ll never be with the boy you love. And you’ll never find love again — because you’re a magical girl. A corpse. A husk with a rock for a soul.”

Mifuyu gasped, hand flying to her mouth.

Mami’s eyes widened in horror.

Momoko’s mouth fell open — stunned, hurt.

Momoko tried to speak. “That’s not true. I… I believe I’ll find love someday—”

Sayaka cut her off with a scoff.

“Do you really think that? How cute. How innocent. Just like me back then — too idealistic, especially about love.”

Her words hit Momoko like a blade.

Because for a moment — just a moment — Momoko wondered if Sayaka was right.

Would anyone ever love her?

Could anyone accept her if they knew the truth about magical girls?

Was she doomed to be alone forever?

Darkness began to swirl from Sayaka’s Soul Gem — thick, oily tendrils of corruption rising like smoke.

Sayaka laughed louder.

“This is just like what Kyubey taught me — how to ignore all physical pain in a fight. But now… thanks to you… I don’t feel emotional pain either.”

Her grin twisted into something monstrous.

“Nothing matters anymore!”

The darkness exploded outward.

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Mami braced themselves as the shockwave hit, their hair and clothes whipping in the corrupted wind.

Momoko’s voice cracked. “I’m sorry… I tried to reach her. I shared something personal — something I thought would help. But she twisted it. She’s… she’s about to become a witch.”

Mifuyu placed a steadying hand on her shoulder.

“It’s alright. What you did was brave. People’s emotions are unpredictable — especially when they’re breaking.”

Mami's heart pounded.

"This... this shouldn't be happening. This is training. Why is she becoming a witch here? Isn't that too much?"

Then a horrifying thought struck her.

Her face drained of color.

"...Does this mean Sayaka actually became a witch back on Earth?"

Momoko and Mifuyu both turned toward her, eyes wide.

Mami's voice trembled.

"Does this training reflect real-Sayaka's emotional state? If she's becoming a witch here... then maybe... maybe it already happened. Maybe real-Kyoko and Homura... will have to..."

She couldn't finish.

The image of Sayaka's witch form — and real-Kyoko's devastated face as she and Homura fought Sayaka's witch — crushed her chest like a vice.

Mifuyu shook her head, panic rising.

"But Lunaria and Kasumi said they were going to Mitakihara to watch over Sayaka and your friends. Did something happen to them?"

Momoko's voice broke.

"I... I really hope... Lunaria and Kasumi will save Sayaka. Just like they saved us. Just like they saved Kuroe."

Sayaka's laughter echoed — distorted, layered, her witch's voice overlapping with her human one. The sound was wrong, inhuman, a chorus of despair.

Mami's ribbons flared around her as she manifested her guns.

They were different than before — transformed by Connect, radiant and terrifying.

Some had bayonets shaped like waxing and waning crescents.

Others had chakram-like rings at their ends.

Others still looked ephemeral, forged from comets and moonlight, shaped like constellations given form.

Normally Mami would have been awestruck.

But now was not the time.

"I will not give up," Mami said, determination blazing in her eyes. "Are you all still with me?"

Momoko lifted her crescent blades, her grin fierce. "Of course! Let's do this!"

Mifuyu raised her arm, her chakram floating beside her like a silver moon. “I am with you until the end.”

They stood together — three hearts united — as the darkness around Sayaka thickened, twisting, shaping itself into something monstrous.

Sayaka’s witch form was beginning to emerge from the darkness.

Chapter 8: In Mitakihara

Evening settled over Mitakihara like a heavy blanket, the sky washed in deep purples and fading gold. The park where Madoka and Sayaka always met — their safe place, their childhood refuge — felt colder than usual, as though the warmth had been drained from the world.

Sayaka stood with her back to Madoka, shoulders rigid, posture brittle.

Madoka reached out, voice trembling.

“Sayaka... please.”

Sayaka turned slowly.

The look she gave Madoka was not one emotion — but three layered atop each other like fractures in glass:

Sadness.

Rage.

And hatred — raw, seething, burning straight through her.

Madoka flinched as though struck.

“Shut up,” Sayaka hissed. “Just shut up and get out of my sight.”

Madoka’s breath caught. “S-Sayaka, I—”

“You what? Don’t pretend you care,” Sayaka snapped. “You could’ve become a magical girl a long time ago. But you didn’t. You let me suffer alone.”

Madoka’s voice broke. “That’s not— I just—”

Her words died in her throat.

“Of course you don’t have anything to say,” Sayaka spat. “You’re weak. Indecisive. A coward. You’re useless”

Madoka’s eyes filled with tears.

“Don’t follow me,” Sayaka muttered as she turned away.

The shadows of the evening wrapped around her like a cloak. Her outline blurred, flickered, and began to fade.

Madoka gasped. “No wait! Sayaka!”

She ran forward, reaching out—

But her hand passed through empty air.

Sayaka was gone.

Madoka jolted upright in her bed, panting, drenched in sweat. Her pillow was soaked with tears.

A nightmare.

But not entirely fiction.

It was a twisted echo of what Sayaka had said to her yesterday — after Madoka and Kyoko watched Sayaka defeat a witch using a technique to block out all pain.

Sayaka had fought like someone who didn’t care if she lived or died.

Laughing as she was slashed.

Smiling as she was impaled.

Swinging her sword with reckless abandon.

Madoka had been horrified. Deep in her gut, she felt that fighting like that was wrong — dangerous — a sign that something inside Sayaka was breaking.

She had tried to reach her afterward.

“Please, Sayaka... please stop. Fighting like that can’t be good for you.”

Sayaka had torn her apart with words.

“What do you know, Madoka? You have some nerve telling me how I should fight when you never had to fight yourself!”

Madoka pressed a hand to her chest, trying to steady her breathing.

And things weren’t just bad between her and Sayaka.

Today was the day Hitomi would confess to Kyōsuke — unless Sayaka confessed first.

But Sayaka couldn’t.

Not anymore.

Not after learning she was no longer human.

Madoka couldn’t imagine what would happen if Sayaka and Hitomi crossed paths at school.

She wiped her eyes and forced herself out of bed.

Madoka walked downstairs, her heart heavy.

Her mother sat at the table sipping tea.

Her father stood at the counter preparing breakfast.

Her little brother kicked his legs excitedly in his high chair.

When he saw her, he lit up.

“Doka! Mornin’!”

Her parents looked at her with warm smiles.

“Good morning, Madoka,” her father said.

“Did you sleep well? A good night’s sleep is critical for beauty,” her mother added with a wink.

Madoka forced a smile. “Good morning. I slept well, thank you.”

Her father placed breakfast on the table — rice porridge with egg and grilled fish.

“Yay!” her little brother cheered, immediately digging in with messy enthusiasm.

Madoka stared at her bowl.

She stirred the porridge.

And stirred.

And stirred.

Her parents exchanged a glance. They knew something was wrong.

Finally, Madoka lifted her head.

“Mom... Dad... can we talk?”

Her parents straightened, concern softening their expressions.

“Of course,” her father said gently. “You can talk to us anytime.”

“So what has been troubling my precious daughter?” her mother asked, leaning forward, giving Madoka her full attention.

Madoka swallowed hard.

She couldn’t mention magical girls.

She couldn’t mention witches.

She couldn’t mention Kyubey.

But she could talk about the pain.

She could talk about the fear.

She could talk about the helplessness.

“I... I have a friend,” Madoka began, voice trembling. “We used to never fight. We teased each other sometimes, but it was always fun. We were... close.”

Her hands tightened around her spoon.

“But recently... she’s going through something terrible. She’s breaking down. She’s falling deeper and deeper into despair.”

Her parents listened quietly, their faces softening with empathy.

“I want to help her. I want to be there for her. But she keeps saying I can’t understand her. That I’ve never experienced what she has. And every time I try to help... she gets angry. She tells me to leave her alone.”

Madoka’s voice cracked as she lowered her head.

“It hurts so much when she says that. But I can’t abandon her. I don’t know what to do.”

Madoka’s parents fell silent for a long moment.

What she described was delicate — a close friend who was hurting, pushing everyone away, refusing help, drowning in something she couldn’t name. The kind of pain that adults recognized instantly, even without knowing the details.

Her mother was the first to speak.

“...Is this the same friend you asked about before?” she asked gently. “The one you said wasn’t doing anything wrong, who was trying her best... but the harder she tried, the worse things became for her?”

Madoka nodded slowly.

“Yes. The same friend. And... it’s just like you said, Mom. Sometimes things don’t end well even when you put your whole heart into them. And the more stubborn someone is... the more unhappy they become.”

Her mother’s expression softened with understanding — a quiet, knowing sadness that came from experience.

“I see. And did things get worse because you did something drastic? Something you felt you had to do... even if it might upset her?”

Madoka froze.

Her mind flashed back to the bridge.

To Sayaka and Kyoko’s blades clashing.

To Sayaka screaming in fury.

To Kyoko preparing to strike.

To Madoka grabbing Sayaka’s Soul Gem — and throwing it.

That moment had changed everything.

It had saved Sayaka's life.

But it had also revealed the truth about magical girls — a truth Sayaka was not ready for.

But she could not tell her family that.

Madoka swallowed hard.

"I... I did follow your advice," she said slowly. "I did something drastic. And it revealed something my friend didn't know before. Something... painful. And now she's struggling to deal with it."

Her mother and father exchanged a look — not of judgment, but of concern, of empathy, of quiet parental worry.

Madoka forced a small, sad smile.

"It played out just like you said it might. She got angry. She... she might even hate me now."

Her voice wavered.

"But even so... I don't regret what I did. I think... I think it was the right thing."

I saved her, Madoka thought.

If I hadn't done it, Kyoko might have killed her.

Her mother reached out and brushed Madoka's cheek with her thumb — a small, tender gesture that made Madoka's eyes sting.

"Then I'm proud of you," she said softly. "Helping a friend isn't always easy. Sometimes it means stepping outside your comfort zone. Sometimes it means doing something scary."

Her father nodded, folding his hands thoughtfully.

"This happens more often than you'd think," he said. "When someone learns something that shatters their understanding of the world... they can react badly. They might lash out. They might push people away. They might fall into despair while they try to process it."

Madoka looked up, eyes shining with hope and fear.

"Then... what should I do? Should I try to reach out to her?"

Her father sighed gently — not in frustration, but in the way someone sighs when they're choosing their words with care.

"That's tricky. If your friend doesn't want help, forcing it will only push her further away. Everyone handles hardship differently."

He leaned forward, his voice warm and steady.

“I think the best thing you can do is be gentle. Don’t push. Don’t demand. If you see her, greet her kindly. Offer small gestures. If she wants to talk, listen. If she doesn’t... don’t take it personally. Give her space.”

Her mother nodded.

“Those little moments matter more than you think. A smile. A kind word. A reminder that she isn’t alone. Over time... those things can soothe even the deepest wounds.”

Her father added softly:

“And I believe your friend knows you care about her. Deep down, she knows. She’s just hurting too much right now to see it clearly.”

Her mother smiled, teasing lightly to lift the mood.

“And besides... I know how gentle and kindhearted my daughter is. I’m sure your friend knows it too.”

Madoka let out a small, shaky laugh — the first real sound of relief she’d made all morning.

“Thank you... both of you. I... I feel better now. I think I know what I should do.”

She looked down at her breakfast — and for the first time that morning, she felt hungry.

She scooped up a spoonful of porridge and ate it slowly, savoring the warmth spreading through her chest.

Her parents smiled at her, relieved to see even a small spark return to her eyes.

Madoka walked to school with her bag held close against her chest, as if it might steady the unease coiling inside her.

The morning air was crisp, sharp enough to sting her cheeks, but it did nothing to clear the weight pressing down on her thoughts. Each step felt just a little heavier than the last, as though she were walking toward something she already feared she couldn’t change.

Will Sayaka and Hitomi be there?

What will happen if they meet?

Her heart thudded painfully as she turned the corner toward their usual meeting place.

Only Hitomi stood there.

She was fidgeting with a small charm, twisting the cord over and over again. The movement was subtle but restless — the kind of nervous habit someone develops when they’re trying not to fall apart.

Madoka’s breath caught.

Relief came first. Then dread, curling in right behind it.

Of course Sayaka isn't here...

After everything that happened yesterday... she probably needs time alone.

Hitomi turned at the sound of footsteps. Her expression brightened the moment she saw Madoka, the tension in her shoulders easing—just slightly.

“Good morning, Madoka.”

Madoka forced a smile, careful to keep it gentle, natural.

“Good morning.”

They began walking together.

Their footsteps fell softly against the pavement, an uneven rhythm that made the silence between them feel all the more fragile—like something that might shatter if either of them spoke too suddenly.

After a moment, Hitomi glanced around again, as if expecting Sayaka to appear out of thin air.

“Sayaka isn't here today... but I suppose that's to be expected.”

Madoka tilted her head, feigning confusion.

“What do you mean? Did... something happen to Sayaka?”

Hitomi hesitated.

A faint blush rose to her cheeks as her hands tightened around the charm.

“Well... yesterday, I made up my mind.” She lowered her gaze slightly. “I can't suppress my feelings for Kyōsuke any longer.”

Madoka's eyes widened, just enough to sell the surprise.

“Oh... I didn't know you felt that way.”

Hitomi gave a small, self-conscious laugh, her cheeks deepening in color.

“I suppose I hid it too well.” She paused, gathering her courage. “Yesterday, I told Sayaka that I plan to confess to Kyōsuke after school today.”

Her voice softened, almost wavering.

“I gave her until then to confess first, since... well... I know she loves him.”

She swayed slightly as she walked, her hands clasped tightly in front of her now, as though holding herself together.

“Maybe she isn't here because she's preparing herself,” she continued, almost to herself. “Deep down, I hope she won't confess... but that would take a miracle.”

Madoka's stomach twisted.

A miracle...

The word echoed, heavy and bitter.

Hitomi has no idea.

Sayaka won't confess because of a miracle.

Because she made a contract with Kyubey ... and gave up something she can never get back.

Madoka forced her voice to remain steady.

"I... I don't know where Sayaka is. But... I hope things go well for you today."

Hitomi looked at her, surprised—then smiled, relief softening her expression.

"Thank you, Madoka. I just hope I didn't upset her too much yesterday." Her fingers tightened again around the charm. "I'd hate to think she's avoiding us because of what I said."

Madoka nodded gently.

"I hope so too."

But inside, her heart was screaming the opposite.

When Madoka reached the entrance of her classroom, she paused.

For a moment, she simply stood there, her hand resting lightly on the doorframe.

Then she took a slow breath and stepped inside.

Sayaka's desk was empty.

The sight of it hit harder than she expected—a quiet, hollow absence that seemed to swallow the room's warmth.

Her heart sank.

Her heart sank. She had hoped — desperately — to at least offer some small gesture of kindness. A smile. A greeting. Something to lift Sayaka's spirit.

Sayaka... I hope you're okay.

Madoka walked to her seat and sat down, her movements careful, almost mechanical. Her hands trembled slightly as she opened her bag, the faint rustle of fabric sounding far too loud in her ears.

A few minutes later, the classroom door slid open again.

Homura Akemi entered without a word.

Her eyes swept across the room once—

—and stopped on Sayaka's empty desk.

Her expression didn't change.

Not even slightly.

But inside, she already knew.

It's happening again.

She had seen this countless times.

Different timelines.

Different choices.

Different variations of hope—

—but always the same end.

Sayaka's absence meant she was already slipping.

Fast.

Homura had tried to save Sayaka before.

Again and again.

She had reached out to her. Warned her. Fought beside her. Even sacrificed time itself in desperate attempts to alter the outcome.

But every path led to the same place.

Sometimes quickly.

Sometimes slowly.

Sometimes so gradually it almost looked like salvation—

—but it always ended in despair.

So this time, she decided to abandon Sayaka.

Her gaze shifted.

Madoka sat stiffly at her desk, her fingers curled tightly around her pencil. Her eyes were unfocused, distant—like someone already bracing for pain they couldn't stop.

Homura understood that look.

Madoka hated seeing her friends suffer.

Madoka blamed herself for things beyond her control.

Madoka's heart was too gentle—too open—too easily broken.

Homura walked to her seat, her expression as composed as ever.

She had already told Madoka the truth.

That there was nothing she could do for Sayaka.
That trying to save her would only lead to more suffering.
That some fates... simply could not be changed.

And as cruel as it felt—

Homura let her gaze linger, just for a moment longer.

If you see it for yourself...

If you witness what Sayaka becomes...

Then maybe...

Maybe you'll finally stop wanting to become a magical girl.

Her fingers tightened imperceptibly at her side.

I hope you will take my words to heart, Madoka.

Classes ended with a dull, hollow chime that seemed to dissolve into the air before it ever fully rang.

It barely registered in Homura's mind.

Around her, chairs scraped.

Voices rose.

Laughter drifted lazily between desks.

The ordinary rhythm of school life resumed as if nothing in the world were wrong.

As if girls were not quietly breaking under invisible burdens.

As if tragedy were not already unfolding.

Homura stood.

Her movements were precise, silent — practiced to the point of ritual. She slipped out of the classroom without a word, her presence fading from notice as naturally as a shadow at dusk.

The moment she stepped into the hallway, she felt it again.

That pulse.

Faint —

but unmistakable.

Sayaka's magic.

It brushed against her senses like a frayed thread, tugging insistently at something deep within her chest. Unstable. Erratic. Flickering unevenly, like a candle struggling against a violent wind — threatening, at any moment, to gutter out.

Homura's grip tightened slightly at her side as she followed it.

She had done this before.

Too many times to count.

Each step she took was guided not by uncertainty, but by memory — by the quiet, suffocating certainty of how this path always ended.

No matter the variation.

No matter the choices made along the way.

The result never changed.

As she crossed the school grounds, the distant pulse grew just a fraction stronger.

Then—

“Homura-chan!”

The voice broke through the stillness behind her.

Homura stopped.

For a brief moment, the world seemed to hold its breath with her.

Then she turned.

Her expression was as it always was — calm, distant, unreadable. A perfect mask.

“Is there something you need from me, Madoka?”

Madoka slowed as she reached her, slightly out of breath, her hands drawn close to her chest as though trying to steady herself. Worry was written plainly across her face — open, unguarded, painfully human.

“Have you... seen Sayaka today?”

The question lingered between them.

Homura didn't hesitate.

“No.”

The answer came flat, immediate.

She didn't soften it.

Didn't offer comfort.

“And I've told you many times,” she continued, her voice quiet but firm, “you should forget about Sayaka. There is nothing you can do for her anymore.”

Madoka flinched — not visibly enough for most to notice, but enough.

Her expression tightened, her brows drawing together as something fragile inside her resisted.

“I still don’t believe that,” she said, her voice small but steady. “I think she can be saved. I want to show her kindness... little by little. Maybe... maybe she’ll open up again.”

For just a fraction of a second, something shifted in Homura’s eyes.

Not anger.

Not irritation.

Something far more fragile.

Something that hurt.

I believed that once too.

The thought surfaced unbidden, heavy with memory.

I tried kindness. I tried patience. I tried understanding.

I tried everything.

And every time—

Sayaka fell.

Different words.

Different paths.

Different moments.

The same end.

Always.

Madoka took a hesitant step closer, closing the distance between them.

“Homura... please,” she said softly. “You can sense her magic, right? Take me to her.”

She braced herself after saying it.

Homura could see it — the tension in her shoulders, the way her fingers curled slightly inward. She was expecting refusal. Expecting that cold, immovable wall Homura had placed between them before.

Two days ago, Homura had denied her request to be friends with Sayaka without hesitation.

But this time...

Homura said nothing.

She simply looked at her.

Behind that steady gaze, her thoughts churned.

This was the moment.

A quiet, calculated decision formed.

If Madoka saw it —

truly saw it —

if she witnessed the moment Sayaka's soul collapsed into something monstrous...

If she felt that horror not as an idea, but as reality carved into her memory—

Then maybe... she would stop.

She would abandon the path that always led to her own destruction.

Homura turned away.

“Follow me.”

Madoka blinked.

For a moment, she simply stared, as if unsure she had heard correctly.

“R-really?” she said, surprise breaking through her worry. “Thank you, Homura!”

She hurried forward, quickly falling into step beside her.

Homura didn't respond.

Her gaze remained fixed ahead, her expression once again empty, sealed away behind that familiar, impenetrable calm.

They walked in silence.

Madoka stole glances at her, again and again, searching for something — anything — in her face. Some hint of what she was thinking. Some reassurance.

But Homura gave her nothing.

The silence stretched.

Heavy.

Awkward.

Almost suffocating.

The sounds of the city filled the space instead — the distant hum of traffic, the murmur of voices, the ordinary life of a world blissfully unaware of the invisible tragedies unfolding within it.

They walked several blocks.

The pulse of magic should have been getting stronger.

Closer.

But—

Homura stopped.

Abruptly.

Madoka nearly stumbled from the sudden halt.

Homura's eyes widened.

A genuine reaction.

Her breath caught, a sharp, quiet inhale breaking the rhythm of her composure.

"Homura...?" Madoka asked, startled. "What is it?"

Homura didn't answer.

She was staring ahead.

Frozen.

Madoka followed her gaze.

Down the street, near a small ice-cream stall, two girls stood side by side.

The first girl stood with an almost unnatural stillness. Her hair flowed down her back like liquid silk, a deep indigo that shimmered faintly as though touched by starlight. Her eyes mirrored that same depth — calm, vast, impossibly steady.

Her clothing was elegant, woven from soft whites, deep indigo, silver, and hints of gentle pink. It draped around her like a quiet melody — delicate and refined.

Beside her stood her opposite.

Her crimson hair was tied into high twin-tails that bounced with every small movement, catching the light like flickering flames. Her eyes burned bright — orange-red, alive with warmth, mischief, and boundless energy.

The smile on her face was vivid and unrestrained.

Her outfit echoed that same intensity — bold, sharp, adorned with flame-like patterns in gold and black, radiating confidence and life.

If the first girl was a quiet sky at evening —
this one was the first burst of sunlight over the horizon.

Madoka blinked. She didn't recognize them.

"Homura...?" she asked quietly. "Do you know them?"

Homura didn't answer.

She continued staring ahead.

Her heartbeat thudded once, hard.

It's them...

Lunaria and Kasumi...

Kasumi leaned eagerly over the counter, her eyes practically glowing.

“I’ll have the **Flameberry Swirl**! I *have* to see what you meant by it having a kick!”

The vendor chuckled, already reaching for the scoop.

“Bold choice. But don’t say I didn’t warn you — the kick isn’t for the faint of heart.”

She turned to Lunaria, her smile softening instinctively.

“And for you?”

Lunaria studied the menu with quiet attentiveness, her expression serene, as though she were contemplating something far more profound than dessert. After a moment, she lifted a finger and pointed.

“The **Lavender Hush**, please. You mentioned it has layered calming flavors. I’d like to experience that.”

“A refined pick,” the vendor said warmly. “Quite the contrast from your friend.”

Kasumi puffed her cheeks.

“Hey, I have refined taste too! Just... spicier.”

The vendor laughed and finished Kasumi’s cone first, handing it over.

“Flameberry Swirl.”

Kasumi’s eyes widened in delight.

“Whoa... that looks amazing!”

The ice cream spiraled like a frozen flame — deep crimson and electric blue intertwining, faint wisps of chilled vapor curling upward like smoke.

Next came Lunaria’s.

“Lavender Hush.”

Lunaria accepted it with a gentle smile.

“Thank you.”

Her cone shimmered delicately, tiny crystalline facets catching the light like frozen petals, refracting soft lavender hues.

“Enjoy,” the vendor said, waving as they stepped away.

Both girls waved back, drifting down the sidewalk together — walking toward Homura and Madoka.

Kasumi wasted no time.

“Alright, moment of truth—”

She took an enormous bite.

And froze.

And then—

“Ah—! Oh—! Ow—okay, that was a mistake! That was a *huge* mistake!”

She clutched her head, hopping in place.

“It’s freezing and burning at the same time — why is it popping?! Why is it popping?!”

She stuck her tongue out, fanning her mouth dramatically.

Beside her, Lunaria took a small, composed lick.

Her eyes softened.

“Oh... how lovely. The flavors unfold so gently... it’s quite soothing.”

Kasumi groaned.

“Why does yours sound like a spa treatment while mine is actively trying to end me?”

Lunaria gave a small smile and a teasing wink.

“You were warned it isn’t for the faint of heart.”

As the two approached, Homura stepped forward.

“Excuse me.”

Her voice was calm — flat — but something beneath it quivered, almost imperceptible.

Kasumi and Lunaria stopped, turning toward her. Both smiled, open and warm.

“Yes?” Lunaria asked softly. “Can we help you?”

Homura said nothing at first.

Her eyes moved carefully over them — faces, posture, clothing.

Presence.

She searched for it.

For anything.

A flicker of magic.

The glint of a Soul Gem.

A distortion in the air.

Nothing.

Tch... just like before.

Her gaze sharpened, just slightly.

Madoka looked between them, puzzled by the sudden tension.

Homura finally spoke.

“You are Lunaria and Kasumi, correct? The adventurers who travel the world.”

Kasumi lit up instantly.

“That’s us!” she said, dipping into an exaggerated bow. “Nice to meet you!”

She leaned forward, eyes sparkling.

“Wait — are you fans?!”

Homura gave a small nod.

“My name is Homura. I’ve seen your recordings on MeTube. And your performance at the Kamihama school talent show.”

She inclined her head politely.

“It’s a pleasure.”

Madoka’s eyes widened with recognition.

“Oh! You’re the guest performers everyone was talking about? Is it really you?!”

Kasumi grinned.

“In the flesh!”

Madoka smiled brightly and bowed.

“I’m Madoka Kaname. It’s nice to meet you!”

Kasumi waved enthusiastically.

“Nice to meet you too, Madoka! And you, Homura!”

Lunaria followed with a graceful bow.

“The pleasure is ours.”

Madoka turned slightly toward Homura, her expression soft with surprise.

“I didn’t know you watched adventurers on MeTube, Homura-chan. I thought you weren’t really interested in things like that...”

Her smile grew warmer.

“I’m glad I learned something new about you.”

Homura looked at her.
Her face didn't change.
Not even slightly.
But inside—
Something shifted.
A faint warmth, fragile and fleeting.
This warmth from Madoka...
Just like that day...
when you reached out to me for the first time.
For a moment, the noise of the street seemed distant.
I'm glad... I get to see this side of you again.
Her gaze drifted back to Lunaria and Kasumi.
And hardened.
But more importantly—
I've met them before.
Again and again.
In countless timelines.
Before I became a magical girl...
And after.

Chapter 8a: The memory that never leaves her

The memory came quietly, the way spring rain touches still water—barely a ripple, yet enough to distort everything beneath the surface.

Homura remembered the fragile, aching time after she transferred to Mitakihara Middle School. Those early days felt like stepping into a world that had already decided she didn't belong. The city was too bright, too fast, too alive for someone who had spent so long tethered to hospital beds and beeping monitors.

She remembered standing at the classroom door that first morning, fingers white-knuckled around the strap of her bag. The chatter of her new classmates washed over her like static. Every lesson blurred into an incomprehensible haze—equations she had never seen, history she had missed by entire semesters.

When the teacher called on her and she could only stare blankly at the board, the sigh that followed carried the weight of disappointment.

“Looks like you cannot do this one either,” the teacher had said, not unkindly but without warmth. “Please ask one of your classmates to help you catch up.”

The whispers started immediately, sharp and casual, as if they weren’t carving pieces out of her.

“Wow, she can’t even start that problem?”

“That’s the basics. Why is she even in our class?”

In P.E., it was worse.

The other girls sprinted through warm-up laps with effortless grace, their laughter ringing across the track.

Homura tried to follow. One step. Two. Her chest tightened like a vice, breath coming in shallow, painful gasps. By half a lap her vision swam with dark spots, her legs trembling beneath her. She slowed, then stopped, one hand pressed hard against her sternum as dizziness threatened to pull her under.

“I—I’m sorry...” she whispered, barely audible.

From the sidelines came the laughter—bright, cruel, effortless.

“Wow, she’s already done?”

“That’s pathetic.”

“Is she even trying?”

She lowered her gaze to the ground and said nothing. The words that followed her for weeks were heavier than any physical exhaustion: **weak, weird, useless, failure**. They pressed into her skin like bruises that never quite faded.

One ordinary afternoon, on the quiet walk home, it happened again.

She had hoped—just for that single day—it wouldn’t. She was wrong.

“Well, if it isn’t the hospital girl.”

Homura froze mid-step. A group of classmates blocked the narrow sidewalk, their smiles thin and predatory. The late afternoon sun cast long shadows that made them seem taller than they were.

“Can you even carry that bag without collapsing?” one sneered.

“Careful, she might cry.”

Her fingers tightened around the strap until the fabric bit into her palm. “I—I just want to go home...”

“Ohhh, listen to her,” another mocked, voice dripping with false sweetness. “So polite. So **weak**.”

The laughter rose again, familiar and relentless, wrapping around her throat like smoke.

And then—

“Hey.”

The voice sliced through the air—bright, sharp, and utterly unafraid.

The group turned.

Kasumi stood a few meters away, hands planted firmly on her hips, her expression a perfect blend of annoyance and confidence. Beside her, Lunaria watched in quiet stillness, her gaze calm yet unwavering, carrying a subtle weight that made the air feel heavier.

“You know, picking on someone smaller than you?” Kasumi tilted her head, voice carrying easily down the street. “Not a great look.”

Lunaria’s addition was softer, almost gentle, yet it carried a strange authority. “We suggest you leave.”

There was something in the way she spoke—quiet certainty rather than threat—that shifted the tension like a sudden change in wind.

The bullies exchanged uneasy glances, muttered half-hearted insults under their breath, and finally stepped aside.

“Whatever. Not worth it.”

As their footsteps faded, silence settled over the three of them. Homura stood rooted in place, heart hammering against her ribs, the echo of cruel laughter still ringing in her ears.

Kasumi turned to her immediately, her entire demeanor softening like sunlight breaking through clouds. “Hey... you okay?”

Homura blinked rapidly, the words tangling in her throat. “I... I...”

Lunaria stepped closer, her voice low and reassuring, like a hand offered in the dark. “Don’t worry. You’re safe now.”

Safe.

“...Thank you,” Homura managed at last, her voice barely more than a whisper, fragile as glass.

Kasumi’s grin was immediate and radiant. “No problem! Oh—wait, I know what we need.”

Before Homura could protest, Kasumi had taken her hand—warm, confident, alive with energy—and was already pointing down the street.

“Ice cream!”

A short while later they sat together on a low bench near the river, the late afternoon light painting the water in soft golds and pinks.

Homura held her cone with both hands, as if it might vanish if she loosened her grip. The sweet coldness of vanilla melted slowly against her tongue, a small, simple pleasure she hadn't allowed herself in what felt like forever.

Kasumi was already talking animatedly, gesturing with her free hand so vigorously that a small drop of ice cream flew from her cone. "So then the bridge collapsed behind us, and I was like—'Nope! Not today!'—and I just jumped—"

"You did not simply jump," Lunaria interjected calmly, a faint smile playing at her lips. "You tripped first."

Kasumi nearly choked on her ice cream. "That... that was part of the plan!"

Homura blinked, caught off guard by the easy banter. "...Really?"

Kasumi paused, then burst into laughter. "Okay, maybe it wasn't planned," she admitted, grinning sheepishly.

Lunaria's soft chuckle joined hers, warm and melodic.

And without warning, a small sound escaped Homura's throat.

She froze.

Then it came again—soft, uncertain, but undeniably a laugh. "...pff. Hahaha!"

Kasumi's eyes lit up like she had just discovered treasure. "There it is! What a lovely laugh!"

Heat rushed to Homura's cheeks. She looked down at her melting cone, a shy smile tugging at her lips despite herself.

The conversation flowed easily after that. Homura found herself leaning forward, questions spilling out before she could stop them.

"Do you... do this a lot? Travel all over, I mean?"

"Yes we do!" Kasumi said proudly, licking a streak of ice cream from her thumb.

"We follow where the wind—and circumstance—guides us," Lunaria added, her voice gentle and thoughtful.

Homura absorbed every word, her eyes—usually so guarded—beginning to shine with quiet wonder. "You've really... done all that?"

"Yep!"

"That's amazing..." She hesitated.

“Weren’t you scared? What if something went wrong? How do you decide where to go?”

Kasumi’s face brightened further, her eyes shimmering with nostalgia. “Oh, we’ve been scared plenty of times...”

“But,” Lunaria added, lifting her gaze to the sky as if reaching for distant memories, “it’s also been a lot of fun.”

This—this easy exchange, this warmth without judgment—was something Homura had almost forgotten existed. Not ridicule. Not pity.

Just... **connection**.

When the ice cream was nearly gone and the conversation had softened into comfortable quiet, Homura gathered her courage.

“...Why?” she asked, voice trembling slightly. “Why did you help me? You didn’t know me. And still...”

Kasumi’s expression gentled, her usual energy settling into something more sincere.

“Because it hurt to watch,” she said simply. “They were saying awful things. Calling you weak, stupid... like you’re a failure.”

Her eyes sharpened with quiet conviction. “That’s not cool. At all.”

Lunaria nodded, her gaze kind. “You’ve endured something difficult, haven’t you? Something that led to all of this.”

Homura hesitated, then nodded slowly. The words came at first in halting fragments, then faster, like a dam cracking under pressure.

“I... I have a heart condition. I was in the hospital for a long time... I fell behind in everything. I can’t keep up. I’m clumsy, I get tired easily, and I...”

Her fingers tightened around the remnants of her cone. “I can’t make any friends.”

The silence that followed wasn’t heavy or awkward. It simply was.

Kasumi leaned forward, her grin warm and reassuring. “Awww. Don’t be so hard on yourself. I think you are cool!”

Homura froze. Heat flooded her face again.

Madoka said the same thing...

“You don’t have to say that,” she murmured, looking away.

“I mean it,” Kasumi replied, voice firm but kind. “You’re dealing with stuff most people never have to. And you’re still here. Still trying.”

She pointed at Homura with the last bit of her cone, smiling brightly. “That’s true strength.”

Homura’s chest tightened—but this time the sensation didn’t bring pain. It brought comfort and warmth.

“...Thank you,” she whispered.

Lunaria smiled softly. “I believe you’ll find people who see your worth,” she said. “Sooner than you think.”

They sat together a little longer as the sun dipped lower, painting the sky in deepening oranges and lavenders. Eventually Kasumi stretched with a satisfied sigh. “Ah! That really hit the spot!”

“We should get going,” Lunaria said gently.

Homura’s heart dipped unexpectedly. “Wait.”

They turned back to her.

She hesitated, fingers twisting together. “...Will I see you again?”

Kasumi winked, bright and playful. “Probably! It’s a small world after all!”

Lunaria raised her hand in a gentle wave. “Until then, we wish you the very best, Homura.”

Kasumi flashed a thumbs-up. “Next time we meet, we want to hear **your** story! The one where you overcome everything and become the star of your school.”

Homura let out a small, genuine laugh—clear and bright, deep from her heart.

“I can’t even imagine that,” she admitted, cheeks still warm. “But... I’ll try.”

“That’s the spirit!”

As they turned to walk away, Homura stood rooted in place, watching their figures grow smaller against the golden light. She raised her hand and waved, slowly, until they disappeared from her sight.

To anyone else, it might have seemed like such a small moment.

To Homura, it became something she would carry with her through time itself—one of her most treasured memories, fragile and luminous, like a single candle flame held carefully against the coming dark.

Homura tried her best ever since that day.

Every night she hunched over her desk until the numbers blurred into pale ghosts beneath the lamplight. She traced each equation until her fingers cramped, whispering them like prayers. In the

mornings she forced her frail body through slow, careful exercises — ten extra steps, five more wall push-ups — ignoring the way her heart fluttered painfully afterward.

She told herself the aching limbs and trembling breath were proof she was growing stronger.

She tried to ignore the whispers in the hallways.

The pitying glances that slid past her as if she were made of glass.

The laughter that followed her like a shadow.

Someone will see your worth.

She clung to Lunaria's gentle words like a lifeline, a single thread of silver light in a world that felt too vast and too cruel.

And she *did* improve.

Her test scores climbed by painful fractions.

She could run a little farther before collapsing.

Her voice no longer shook quite so badly when the teacher called on her.

But it was never enough.

She was still the slowest.

Still the one who collapsed against the wall, gasping.

Still the girl everyone looked at with that same quiet pity.

The doubt grew slowly, like mold in damp corners.

What if I really am a burden?

What if this is as good as I'll ever be?

What if no one will ever see me as anything more than this?

The doubt festered. It darkened. Until one gray afternoon, as she walked home from school, it finally swallowed her whole.

The world dimmed.

Colors leached away. Shadows stretched like hungry fingers. The air grew thin and sweet, heavy with the scent of old paper and melting wax.

Homura didn't notice. Her feet carried her forward on autopilot, deeper into the fog inside her own mind.

Until the labyrinth claimed her.

She stumbled to a halt when the distortion finally registered. The street had vanished. In its place stretched an impossible gallery of floating frames and warped canvases, geometry twisting like a nightmare painted by a mad artist.

The air tasted metallic. Her heartbeat thundered in her ears.

“Wh... where am I...?”

A low, whispering laugh echoed from nowhere and everywhere.

Worthless.

Useless.

Why keep trying when you only drag others down?

Maybe it would be better if you just died.

Homura spun around. From the darkness came the familiars—puppet-like things with cracked porcelain faces and jerky, marionette movements. Their hollow eyes fixed on her with terrible hunger.

She tried to run. Her legs buckled instantly.

“No—please—stay away!”

She fell hard. Pain flared through her knees. The creatures swarmed closer, clawed hands reaching—
Golden gunfire erupted from above.

Bang. Bang. Bang.

Pink arrows of light followed, streaking like falling stars. The familiars dissolved into clouds of black dust and glittering grief seeds.

Two figures dropped gracefully into the distorted space, ribbons fluttering, capes snapping.

Homura’s breath caught.

One of them was **her**.

“M... Madoka...?”

Madoka turned, her pink magical girl outfit shimmering with soft golden light. Her expression shifted from battle-ready focus to gentle warmth.

“Are you okay, Homura?”

Homura looked at her with disbelief, “Yes I am. But why do you look like that? What is going on?”

A voice answered from behind her.

“Madoka and Mami are magical girls. They hunt witches.”

Homura spun around and saw a strange white creature perched on a floating platform.

Her heart lurched.

“What... what are you...?”

Madoka chuckled softly.

“Looks like my secret is out. Please don’t tell anyone else in class, okay?”

A calm, elegant voice rang out beside her.

“That was great, Madoka. Ready to finish this?”

Mami Tomoe stood tall, golden rifle gleaming, her smile warm but her eyes sharp with experience. She offered Homura a reassuring nod before turning back toward the depths of the labyrinth.

Madoka’s face filled with determination. She gave Homura’s shoulder a quick, gentle squeeze.

“Stay right here, okay? We’ll protect you. You’re safe now.”

Safe.

The word echoed inside her —

just like when Lunaria and Kasumi stood between her and the bullies.

Then they moved.

Mami’s ribbons whipped through the air like living gold, binding and tearing through waves of familiars. Madoka danced beside her, arrows flying in graceful arcs, each shot precise and bright with hope. Their movements wove together—elegant, deadly, beautiful. Light clashed against writhing darkness in a symphony of gunfire and shattering glass.

Homura could only watch, heart hammering against her fragile ribs, tears blurring her vision.

They’re... incredible.

When the witch finally shattered in a burst of swirling colors, the labyrinth dissolved. The three of them reappeared in the normal world just as dusk painted the sky in soft violets and pinks.

Moments later, Homura found herself bundled in a warm blanket on Mami’s sofa, a steaming cup of chamomile tea cradled in her trembling hands. The apartment smelled of sugar and butter. It felt impossibly safe.

Madoka sat beside her, back in her school uniform, cheeks flushed from the fight. Mami moved gracefully around the kitchen, setting out plates of strawberry cake and madeleines.

“You were... amazing,” Homura whispered, eyes sparkling with awe.

Madoka laughed shyly, rubbing the back of her neck.

“Ehehe... I’m still pretty new at this. Mami-senpai is the real pro.”

Mami smiled as she set down another plate.

“You’ve grown so much in just a few weeks, Madoka. Don’t sell yourself short.” She turned her gentle gaze to Homura. “How are you feeling? Any injuries?”

Homura shook her head, then hesitated.

“Is this... really okay? Fighting witches like that. It looked so dangerous. Weren’t you scared?”

Madoka’s expression softened. She reached out and took Homura’s hand.

“Of course I’m scared. Every single time.” Her voice was quiet, honest. “But... when I think about the people I might help, about the smiles I can protect... it feels worth it.”

She glanced at Mami with a small, warm smile. “And having someone who watches my back makes it a lot less frightening.”

Mami chuckled softly. “The feeling is mutual.”

Another quiet sense of déjà vu washed over Homura.

The warmth in their words reminded her so much of Lunaria and Kasumi — adventurers who faced fear many times but kept moving forward.

She gathered her courage.

“Do you... know two adventurers named Lunaria and Kasumi?”

Mami’s eyes widened with pleasant surprise.

“I’ve seen their MeTube videos! They travel the world doing all kinds of wild things. Why do you ask?”

Homura’s heart warmed as she recalled the memory.

“They helped me once. When I was being bullied. They stood up for me... and then we got ice cream. They told me stories about their adventures.”

Her voice softened.

“They said they thought I was cool for trying my best despite my heart condition. And they said they wanted to hear my story next time... the story where I overcome everything.”

Homura looked at Madoka shyly.

“And... you said something similar when we first met. You said my name was awesome, so I should try to become cool like it.”

Madoka listened with shining eyes, practically bouncing in her seat.

“Wow... you actually met them in person? That’s so cool! I’m a little jealous...”

Mami laughed. “If you ever run into them again, please introduce us. I’d love to have tea with all of you someday.”

Homura smiled—small, hesitant, but real.

“I will... Maybe... someday, we can all sit together like. And... I hope I’ll have a story of my own to share.”

Despite everything Homura had hoped for, she never saw Lunaria or Kasumi again.
Not in that timeline.

That timeline ended the way so many others would:
in fire, in ruin, in the laughter of something that should not exist.

Walpurgisnacht descended upon Mitakihara like a storm of pure insanity — a colossal silhouette twisting through a sky stained crimson and violet, its body a grotesque carnival of gears and ribbons and impossible shapes. Its laughter echoed with a hundred discordant voices, rattling windows, shattering glass, shaking the city to its bones.

Against it stood two small lights:
Mami Tomoe and Madoka Kaname.

They fought valiantly.
They fought bravely.
They fought beautifully.

But this world was never a fairy tale.

Mami fell first.

The ribbon-wrapped musket slipped from her fingers as her body crumpled to the shattered rooftop. Homura collapsed beside her, knees slamming against concrete littered with glass and debris. Her hands trembled as she reached for Mami’s cooling fingers — still warm with the last traces of magic, still curled as if she had been reaching for one final shot.

“Mami-senpai...” Madoka whispered, kneeling across from her. Tears streamed silently down her cheeks, catching the flickering light of dying flames.

Homura’s vision blurred. Her breath came in broken, ragged gasps.

“Madoka... please.” Her voice cracked. “Stop fighting. Walpurgisnacht is too strong. You’ll die here.”

Madoka lifted her gaze.

The smile she offered was gentle, unbearably sad, and far too wise for a girl her age.

“I can’t, Homura-chan. If I stop now... so many people will die.”

“It’s not fair,” Homura whispered, the words tasting like ash. “You and Mami... you’ve already done so much. Why does it have to end like this?”

Madoka reached out and took Homura’s bloodied hands in her own.

Her touch was warm.

Steady.

Kind.

“I don’t think of it like that,” she said softly. “I’m glad I became a magical girl. Because of it... I got to save you. I got to become your friend.”

Homura’s breath hitched painfully in her chest.

Madoka stood slowly, turning toward the towering silhouette of Walpurgisnacht. Its laughter shook the ruins like thunder. She looked back only once — eyes closed, smile serene, as if she were simply saying goodnight after a long day.

“Goodbye, Homura-chan. I’m really glad I met you.”

The words cut deeper than any blade.

“Madoka—!”

Homura lunged forward, screaming her name, but Madoka was already running — a lone pink spark charging headlong into the hurricane of madness.

The battle ended too quickly.

When the dust and laughter finally settled, Homura found herself kneeling once more. This time over Madoka’s broken body.

The grief tore out of her in raw, ugly sobs that echoed across the empty, burning city.

“Why...?” she choked out, voice raw. “Why does someone like me get to live... while someone like you dies...?”

Her tears fell onto Madoka’s still, lifeless hand.

“I wish... I wish you were alive...”

A calm, childish voice spoke from behind her.

“Do you truly mean that?”

Homura turned sharply.

Kyubey sat perched on a broken beam, tail swaying lazily, red eyes blank and unblinking.

“If that is your wish,” he continued, tone light and conversational, “I can grant it. In exchange, you will become a magical girl. You will fight witches. You will shoulder the destiny that Madoka and Mami once carried.”

Homura froze.

Mami's gentle warnings echoed in her mind.

Madoka's worried eyes.

Be careful.

Think before you make a contract.

There are burdens you cannot imagine.

Her heart raced.

Could she really bring Madoka back?

Could she undo this nightmare?

Could she save them both?

Kyubey tilted his head, ears twitching.

“What do you truly wish for, Homura Akemi?”

She thought of Madoka's smile.

Of her kindness that never wavered, even in the face of horror.

Of her final words — warm, sincere, heartbreaking.

She thought of Lunaria and Kasumi telling her she was stronger than she believed.

She thought of the weak, fragile girl she used to be — the one who was always protected, never protecting.

Homura stood.

She wiped the tears from her cheeks with the back of her trembling hand and looked at Kyubey with a resolve she had never felt before.

“I wish...”

Her voice trembled, then steadied like steel.

“I wish I could meet Ms. Kaname all over again. But this time... instead of her protecting me... I want to be strong enough to protect her.”

Kyubey's ears perked up.

“Your wish has been accepted. Now go forth with your new magical power.”

Purple light engulfed her body, burning away the old Homura Akemi and forging something new — something Homura never imagined in her wildest dreams.

That was only the beginning.

The beginning of the endless cycle.

Homura repeated the same month again and again, desperately trying to save Madoka, desperately trying to rewrite her fate.

Each timeline was different.

Sometimes she met Kyoko Sakura early, sharing stolen apples and fierce battles.

Sometimes she fought beside Sayaka Miki, her optimism and sense of justice infectious.

Sometimes she stood with all of them — laughing over tea, fighting witches shoulder-to-shoulder, enjoying the camaraderie.

But every cycle ended the same way.

In failure.

She watched Madoka die.

She watched Mami die.

She watched Kyoko die.

She watched Sayaka die.

She watched them fall into despair and become witches.

Again.

And again.

And again.

Each death carved fresh wounds into her heart, reopening scars that had never truly healed.

And with every reset, something else broke.

The more she repeated the month, the further she and Madoka drifted apart.

Their conversations grew awkward.

Her warnings went unheard.

Her presence became a source of unease rather than comfort.

She screamed inside every time it happened.

She remembered the early timelines — the warm tea parties at Mami's apartment, the shared laughter, the quiet camaraderie of fighting side by side. She remembered the feeling of Madoka's hand in hers, Mami's gentle guidance, Kyoko's fierce loyalty, Sayaka's bright, unyielding determination.

She wanted those days back so badly it hurt.

But with every reset, those precious moments slipped further and further away.

After so many failures... so much pain... so much loss...

Homura changed.

She grew cold.

Distant.

Her heart hardened into something sharp and unyielding, like tempered glass that would shatter rather than bend.

Watching others die or transform into witches no longer shocked her.
It no longer broke her.

In many timelines, Mami, Kyoko, Sayaka — even Madoka — began to look at her with wariness.
Distrust. Sometimes outright hostility.

But Homura no longer cared.

She couldn't afford to care.

Only one thing mattered now.
Only one wish kept her moving forward through the endless sea of blood and grief:

She would save Madoka.

No matter how many times she failed.
No matter how much she lost.
No matter what she had to become.

Despite every cruel twist of fate Homura had endured — the endless rewinds, the shattering heartbreaks, the growing chasm between her and the people she once held dear — one fragile, luminous constant remained.

Lunaria and Kasumi.

She did not encounter them in every timeline.

Sometimes only one appeared.

Sometimes neither.

Sometimes they crossed her path in a different city, a different moment, under entirely different skies.
But whenever they did appear... they always treated her with the same untouched warmth.
The same gentle sincerity they had shown a frightened, bullied girl.

Time could twist, warp, and break apart.
Their kindness, somehow, never did.

When Homura rewound time for the first time, she met Madoka and Mami again — exactly as before.
Only this time, she was no longer a helpless bystander.

She was a magical girl.

A clumsy one.

An inexperienced one.

A terrified one.

But still — a magical girl.

When Mami and Madoka discovered her ability to stop time, their reactions were nothing but warm encouragement.

“That’s incredible, Homura-chan!” Madoka’s eyes sparkled with genuine awe. “Stopping time like that... it almost seems unfair!”

Mami nodded, her smile elegant and reassuring as always.

“Yes, it’s a very powerful ability. You simply need to find the right way to use it against witches. I’m excited to see what you come up with.”

Homura’s chest swelled with fragile hope.

This time... I will protect you, Madoka.

The witch Patricia’s labyrinth was a dizzying, skyward maze of endless clotheslines and floating laundry, billowing gently in an impossible wind. The air smelled faintly of detergent and something metallic, like a dream stitched together from half-remembered chores. Mami and Madoka moved with effortless grace, leaping from line to line, ribbons snapping and arrows flying as they danced through the familiars.

Homura clung desperately to a swaying rope, knuckles white, heart hammering against her ribs.

“Homura-chan! Are you okay?” Madoka called, voice bright even in the middle of battle.

“Y-yes... I’m fine!” Homura squeaked back.

“Just stay ready!” Mami added, her golden ribbons weaving a shimmering bridge through the chaos.

“We’ll create an opening for you!”

Madoka’s pink arrows struck the witch’s grotesque form, staggering it. Mami’s ribbons unfurled like silk lightning, carving a straight path toward Patricia’s core.

“Go for it, Homura!” they shouted together.

Homura swallowed hard.

“O-okay...!”

She stopped time.

The world froze.

Laundry hung motionless mid-flutter. Familiars were locked mid-lunge. Madoka and Mami remained suspended in mid-shout, expressions full of trust.

Homura released the clothesline and dropped clumsily onto Mami’s ribbon path. She nearly tripped twice, arms flailing wildly, but she forced herself forward — step after unsteady step.

Closer.

Just a little closer—

She reached into her shield, pulled out one of her crude homemade bombs, and hurled it with all her strength at the witch's core.

Time snapped back into motion.

The explosion tore through the labyrinth with a deafening roar. Patricia let out a chilling, distorted shriek before dissolving into swirling dust and shadow. The barrier shattered around them like breaking glass.

Homura stood trembling in the sudden silence, hands pressed to her burning cheeks.

“D-did I... really do it...?”

Rapid footsteps approached from behind.

Madoka barreled into her with a hug so fierce it nearly knocked her off her feet.

“You did it, Homura-chan! You were amazing!”

Mami approached more gracefully, but her smile was warm and proud.

“That was brilliant. Combining time stop with explosives... You’ve already begun to develop your own fighting style. Well done, Homura.”

Homura let out a breathless, disbelieving laugh — small, radiant, and full of fragile joy.

I... I really helped them. I protected them this time.

Then came the sound of clapping.

Soft. Elegant. Deliberate.

Followed by a calm, soothing voice.

“Three magical girls working together to defeat a witch... What a beautiful sight.”

An energetic voice chimed in right after.

“I know, right?! The trust, the teamwork, the way they used their abilities — it was soooo cool!”

Homura, Madoka, and Mami turned toward the voices.

And there they were.

Lunaria and Kasumi.

Homura's breath caught in her throat. Her eyes widened, and her heart gave a painful, hopeful leap.

It was them — the girls who had once stood up for her, who had bought her ice cream on a lonely afternoon, who had looked at a weak, trembling girl and told her she was stronger than she believed.

The girls who had said they wanted to hear her story one day — the story where she overcame everything.

But something else struck her immediately.

They knew.

They had watched the battle. Understood what they were seeing. Spoke of magical girls with easy familiarity.

Homura's senses sharpened on instinct. She reached out with her magical perception, searching for the telltale gleam of a Soul Gem, for any trace of magic, for any distortion in the air.

Nothing.

No Soul Gems.

No magical signatures.

No corruption.

No witches' kiss.

They're not normal people, Homura thought, a flicker of unease cutting through her joy.

But she tucked the suspicion away.

Right now, all she could feel was overwhelming, aching happiness.

"Lunaria! Kasumi!" Homura cried, running toward them before she could stop herself. "I've wanted to see you again for so long!"

The two girls blinked in surprise.

Kasumi laughed brightly, tilting her head with playful confusion.

"Whoa! Did we meet before? I don't think we have... but if you already know us, maybe you're a fan?!"

She twirled theatrically and offered an exaggerated bow.

"I am Kasumi Hoshizora! Nice to meet all of you!"

Lunaria smiled gently, her voice soft and composed.

"You may call me Lunaria. It's lovely to meet you three."

Homura froze mid-step, the joy in her chest fracturing just a little.

Of course.

They didn't remember her.

This timeline was different. They hadn't met her yet.

But something else was wrong.

Mami tilted her head, polite confusion on her face.

“Lunaria... Kasumi...? I don’t believe I’ve heard those names before.”

Madoka gasped.

“Mami-senpai, really? They’re adventurers! They travel the world! You should check out their MeTube channel!”

Homura’s breath hitched.

In the previous timeline, Mami had known them.

But here... she didn’t.

So the timeline isn’t only changing because of me, Homura realized with a quiet chill.

Other things are shifting too.

She wrestled with the desperate urge to explain everything — the rewinds, the previous timeline, how Lunaria and Kasumi had once helped a broken girl on a riverbank. How they had given her strength when she had none.

But she stopped herself.

Telling them she was from the future would only bring confusion.

Or panic.

Or worse — dangerous paradoxes.

Homura had seen enough stories, read enough warnings in books long ago, to know how badly time travel could go wrong.

So she swallowed the truth, buried it deep beneath her ribs, and simply smiled — small, trembling, but sincere.

Homura bowed politely, hands folded in front of her, posture straight despite the tremor in her chest.

“It’s an honor to meet you,” she said softly. “I... I’ve admired your kindness for a long time. The way you support the people you meet... it’s something I’ve always looked up to.”

She chose her words carefully.

Truth wrapped in omission.

A confession without revealing the impossible.

Madoka stepped forward next, bright and earnest.

“I’m Madoka Kaname! I watch your adventures sometimes on MeTube. You two go to so many places... and you meet so many people. It’s really amazing.”

Kasumi beamed.

“Awwww, thank you! We try our best!”

Mami introduced herself with a graceful bow.

“Mami Tomoe. It’s a pleasure to meet you both. My mentees seem quite excited to see you in person.”

Her smile was warm — but her eyes sharpened just slightly, the way they always did when she sensed something unusual.

“And... based on what you said earlier,” Mami continued, “it sounds like you know about magical girls. Yet I don’t see any Soul Gems. So I must ask — how do you know about us? And what brings you to Mitakihara?”

Kasumi placed her hands behind her head, laughing lightly.

“Well, we travel wherever the wind takes us! New cultures, new food—”

Her tone softened.

“—and most importantly... new people.”

Lunaria stepped in with her usual serene composure.

“Throughout our travels, we’ve met many girls who seemed distant... burdened... carrying pain they could not share. All of them had stories worth listening to.”

Her eyes softened, deep and steady as moonlit water.

“From them, we learned about your world. About magical girls.”

Kasumi nodded vigorously.

“And that’s why seeing the three of you fight together was so cool! Magical girls working as a team is rare. Most fight alone. Some even fight each other over grief seeds.”

Her expression gentled.

“So seeing you three... trusting each other... supporting each other... it made me really happy.”

Lunaria added quietly:

“As long as you keep your bonds strong... and do not succumb to despair... your future will be bright.”

The words hung in the air like a blessing.

Mami, Madoka, and Homura exchanged startled glances.

Normal humans didn’t speak like that.

Normal humans didn’t *know* things like that.

And yet...

There was no malice in Lunaria's voice.
No judgment in Kasumi's.
Only warmth.

Mami bowed her head gratefully.

"Thank you. Truly. Your words mean more than you know."

She looked at Madoka and Homura, her smile soft and maternal.

"I hope the three of us will always be together as well."

Madoka nodded eagerly, cheeks pink with happiness.

Homura smiled — small, shy, but real.

Mami turned back to Lunaria and Kasumi.

"If you're free... would you like to join us for tea? We'd love to hear more about your travels. And perhaps we can share some of our own experiences as magical girls."

Kasumi's eyes sparkled like fireworks.

"Tea? Stories? New friends? I'm in!"

Lunaria bowed gracefully.

"Thank you for the invitation. We would be honored."

Mami chuckled.

"Then please, follow me."

And so they walked together — four magical girls and two mysterious travelers — laughter and chatter drifting through the air like petals on the wind.

After that day, Homura researched Lunaria and Kasumi obsessively.

She combed through MeTube.

She scoured blogs, forums, travel logs.

She searched for interviews, articles, anything.

But she found nothing useful.

Every time she met them in later timelines, she asked gentle questions — trying to learn more, trying to understand who they were, what they knew, what they were hiding.

But they always responded the same way:

Warm smiles.
Gentle deflections.
Answers that revealed nothing and yet felt impossibly kind.

And deep in her heart, Homura began to wonder:

Do they know something I don't?

Something about Madoka's fate?

Something about witches?

Something about how to change destiny itself?

Chapter 8b: Madoka's plea

Homura looked at Lunaria and Kasumi now — in this timeline, in this fragile moment, with Sayaka's soul trembling on the edge of collapse — and something tightened painfully in her chest.

This was the first time they had appeared when Sayaka was about to break.

A new variable.

A hopeful one.

A chance to see what Lunaria and Kasumi *truly* knew about magical girls and witches.

Homura stepped forward.

"Lunaria. Kasumi."

Her voice was steady, but her heart pounded.

"Can you... please help us with something?"

Madoka's head snapped toward her, eyes widening in open shock.

"Homura...?"

The whisper barely escaped her lips — disbelief wrapped in a trembling breath.

Homura is asking others for help?

Kasumi grinned brightly.

"Of course! We might not be able to help, but we can try!"

Homura met Madoka's stunned gaze and gave her the smallest nod.

Go on, she sent telepathically, her mental voice calm and measured. They already know about magical girls. You don't have to hide anything. Be open and honest. Maybe... they can actually help.

Madoka's mind spun visibly.

Confusion flickered across her face like a candle in a draft.

How does Homura know them?

Why does she trust them?

Why now, when she always told me to give up on Sayaka?

For a long moment, Madoka stood frozen, fingers twisting tightly in the fabric of her skirt. Then she drew in a shaky breath, as if gathering every scrap of courage she possessed.

Lunaria and Kasumi waited with that same quiet, patient warmth — the kind that made it feel safe to speak, even when the words hurt.

Madoka drew in a shaky breath.

“My friend... her name is Sayaka Miki,” Madoka began, her voice soft and trembling at the edges.

“Before all of this, we had normal, happy lives. We walked to school together every morning. We talked about homework, music, silly crushes... Hitomi was always with us. The three of us were inseparable.”

A faint, wistful smile flickered across her face — then dimmed like a candle guttering in the wind.

“But everything changed when we met Kyubey... and Mami-senpai.”

Her voice grew quieter, more fragile.

“Mami-senpai was so kind. She taught us what it meant to be a magical girl. She protected us. Sayaka and I... we admired her so much.”

Madoka hesitated, glancing at Homura with guilt pooling in her eyes.

“But... Mami-senpai and Homura-chan didn’t get along. Homura-chan kept warning us not to make a contract. She said it was dangerous. But Mami-senpai didn’t trust her. She told us we should choose for ourselves.”

Her voice wavered.

“I... I was going to become one too. I wanted to fight beside Mami-senpai. I wanted to help people, to protect everyone the way she did.”

The next words came out small and fragile, like shards of glass.

“But then... Mami-senpai died.”

Madoka pressed a hand to her chest, as if trying to hold her heart together.

“Seeing her die... it was the first time I understood how dangerous this really is. How terrifying witches are. How easily magical girls can... can...”

She couldn’t finish.

Lunaria’s expression softened, a quiet sorrow settling in her eyes.

Kasumi’s bright energy dimmed into gentle sympathy.

Madoka continued, voice trembling.

“Even after that, Sayaka still made her contract. She wished for the boy she likes — Kyōsuke — to heal his hand so he could play the violin again.”

A sad little smile crossed her face. “It was such a selfless wish. So... exactly like her.”

Her expression darkened.

“But after she became a magical girl, another girl appeared. Kyoko Sakura. They fought constantly. Their beliefs were completely opposite — Kyoko only fought for herself, while Sayaka wanted to save everyone.”

Madoka’s hands clenched at her sides.

“When they were about to have a real battle... I panicked. I grabbed Sayaka’s Soul Gem and threw it off the bridge.”

Kasumi let out a soft gasp.

Lunaria’s eyes widened just slightly — a subtle, controlled reaction.

“That’s when we learned the truth,” Madoka continued, her voice cracking. “Magical girls are not human anymore. Their bodies are just... shells. Their Soul Gems are their literal souls.”

Tears welled up, spilling over before she could stop them.

“Sayaka was devastated. She kept calling herself a monster. A zombie.”

Madoka wiped at her eyes with the back of her hand, but the tears kept coming.

“And then Hitomi told her she likes Kyōsuke too. She gave Sayaka until after school today to confess first... but Sayaka can’t. Not when she believes she’s broken. Not when she thinks she’s not even human.”

Her voice grew smaller, more desperate.

“She’s been pushing everyone away. She even said cruel things to me — that I’m useless, that I’m too scared to help anyone because I won’t make a contract. But I know she doesn’t mean it. She’s just hurting so much...”

Madoka looked at Homura — a silent plea, a trembling hope.

“Homura-chan can sense where Sayaka is right now. I just want to reach her. Even if it’s only a smile, or a few kind words... anything to remind her she’s not alone.”

She drew in a ragged breath.

“I can’t lose her. I can’t bear to lose another friend like I lost Mami-senpai...”

Then Madoka looked up at Lunaria and Kasumi with raw, pleading eyes and bowed — deeply, earnestly, her whole body shaking with the force of her plea.

“Please... if there’s anything you can do... anything at all... please... help us save Sayaka.”

The air grew heavy and still.

Homura watched Lunaria and Kasumi with narrowed, piercing eyes, every muscle tense beneath her calm exterior.

Now... will you reveal something?

Will you speak of witches?

Will you show knowledge that no ordinary humans should possess?

The world itself seemed to hold its breath, waiting for their answer.

Kasumi and Lunaria said nothing at first

The silence that settled between them was not cold, nor dismissive.

It was *heavy* — the kind of silence that gathers before a storm breaks, or before a truth too large for words begins to take shape. Even the air seemed to thicken, as though the world itself were listening.

Madoka stood trembling, her wide pink eyes shimmering with unshed tears, her breath caught somewhere between hope and fear. She looked so small in that moment, so heartbreakingly earnest, as if she had peeled back every layer of herself and placed her heart in their hands.

Beside her, Homura remained perfectly still.

Her expression was a flawless mask — calm, composed, unreadable.

But inside, her heart hammered violently against her ribs, each beat a painful reminder of how much she had riding on this moment.

Across countless timelines, she had waited for this.

Hoped for this.

Will they reveal knowledge no ordinary travelers should possess?

Do they hold the key to breaking this endless, merciless cycle?

Kasumi was the first to move.

She stepped forward with a gentleness that felt like sunlight breaking through storm clouds. Her usual bright energy softened into something warm and aching sincere.

“Thank you,” she said quietly, her voice warm and sincere. “For telling us all of that. It must have been so painful to put into words.”

Madoka wiped her eyes with the back of her hand and nodded, a fragile spark of hope flickering in her gaze.

Kasumi’s expression deepened, touched by sadness but never losing its kindness.

“This is... a difficult one,” she murmured. “Sayaka’s despair runs very deep. Learning the truth about Soul Gems, and then losing the boy she made her wish for... that kind of cruel irony is enough to break anyone.”

Lunaria’s calm voice followed, steady as still water.

“We’ve encountered similar tragedies in our travels,” she said softly. “Magical girls who learned too much about what they truly are. Girls whose purest wishes twisted back to wound them. Girls who carried invisible burdens no one else could see.”

Her gaze drifted to Homura — slowly, deliberately — and lingered.

“That’s why you kept warning Madoka and Sayaka not to contract with Kyubey, isn’t it?”

Homura stiffened.

Every muscle locked into place.

Lunaria smiled — warm, gentle, understanding in a way that felt almost too precise.

“You’re very kind, Homura. You didn’t want them to suffer the same painful fate you endured.”

Homura’s breath caught.

The same painful fate I endured...

Did Lunaria truly know? Or was this just a vague observation about magical girls in general? Homura could not tell. She never could. Her fists clenched tightly at her sides until her nails bit into her palms.

Madoka took a shaky step forward, her voice trembling but determined. “Is there... anything you’ve learned in your travels that could help Sayaka? Any way to reach her?”

Kasumi let out a soft sigh, her expression tinged with genuine sorrow. “What you’re already planning—showing her kindness, reminding her she’s not alone—that’s a good first step. But it won’t be easy. Right now, Sayaka’s heart is closed off. She’s hurting too much to let anyone in.”

She offered a small, wistful chuckle. “Emotions really are strange, aren’t they? So beautiful... and so terrifying.”

Lunaria tilted her head slightly, studying Madoka with quiet, gentle curiosity.

“Madoka,” she asked softly, “if there is one thing you truly want Sayaka to hear—something you want her to hold onto deep in her heart—what would it be?”

Madoka blinked, startled by the question. “I... I...”

She closed her eyes. Memories, regrets, hopes, fears — all of it swirled inside her like a storm. What could she possibly say?

Something cheerful?
Something comforting?
Something about the future?
About romance?
About justice?

No.

What rose to her lips was raw. Unfiltered. Painfully honest.

“I know I’m weak,” Madoka whispered, her voice cracking. “I know I’m indecisive and scared. If I had become a magical girl sooner... maybe Mami-senpai wouldn’t have died.”

A single tear slipped down her cheek.

“And Sayaka was right. I can’t fully understand how she feels. Not completely.”

She drew in a trembling breath, pressing a hand over her heart as if to steady herself.

“But even if she resents me... even if she hates me right now... I can’t just leave her alone. I want her to know how much it hurts me to see her suffering like this.”

Her voice softened, but the emotion behind it only grew stronger.

“Sayaka is so kind. She has such a strong sense of justice. I know she’ll find someone someday who will accept her — even as a magical girl.”

She clasped her hands together.

“I just... I want her to give me a chance. To let me help her. Because I love her. And I’ll always be there for her, no matter what she does or says to me.”

The words lingered in the air like a quiet prayer.

Kasumi and Lunaria both smiled — warm, touched, deeply moved.

They stepped closer in perfect sync.

Homura’s eyes narrowed, suspicion sharpening like a blade.

What are they planning?

Lunaria looked at Madoka with quiet admiration. “That was a beautiful answer,” she murmured. “Full of genuine emotion. Full of love. Full of sincerity.”

She extended her hand.

Kasumi’s grin brightened, playful yet sincere. “And I’m pretty sure those words will reach somewhere deep inside Sayaka’s heart.”

She extended her hand as well.

Then, in perfect unison, they spoke:

“We will remember your words.”

Madoka blinked in confusion. “Remember... my words?”

Homura’s breath hitched. *What do they mean? Why would they need to remember?*

She stared at their outstretched hands, desperately reaching out with her senses—searching for even the faintest trace of magic.

But there was nothing.

Madoka hesitated only a moment before offering a tearful smile. “Thank you... both of you.”

She reached out and took their hands.

The moment their fingers met, Madoka gasped sharply.

Her eyes flew wide open.

A soft, involuntary sound escaped her lips as she felt it—unmistakably.

Lunaria’s energy flowed into her first: soothing, serene, calm as a still lake beneath moonlight—peaceful, enveloping, healing.

Kasumi’s followed like a bright spark: fiery, vibrant, playful, and impossibly warm, like laughter on a summer day.

Both energies intertwined inside her in a gentle, uplifting embrace—comforting, strengthening, and impossibly kind. For a brief moment, the constant weight of fear and grief in Madoka’s chest felt just a little lighter.

Homura’s eyes widened in alarm. She saw the shift in Madoka’s expression—the shock, the awe, the sudden warmth—and her heart lurched violently.

She reached out again with every magical sense she possessed, scanning frantically.

Nothing.

Kasumi and Lunaria definitely did something, Homura thought, pulse quickening.

As I always suspected... they have some kind of power.

Lunaria and Kasumi slowly released Madoka’s hands.

Madoka exhaled shakily, staring at them with wide, bewildered eyes, her cheeks still flushed.

“W-what... what was that?” she whispered, voice trembling with equal parts wonder and confusion.

“What did you just do?”

Madoka's breath still trembled as she stared at the two girls before her.

The lingering warmth from their hands refused to fade.

It pulsed gently against her palms — like the echo of a heartbeat that wasn't entirely her own.

Something soft and luminous had settled inside her chest, a warmth she hadn't felt since before Sayaka began to slip away.

Lunaria smiled, serene and quiet, like the first snowfall drifting over a sleeping city.

"Madoka... we wanted to take some of your burden. Even if just a little. Does it feel lighter now?"

Madoka let out a small, shaky laugh — the first real one she'd managed in days.

She pressed a hand to her chest, cheeks blooming with warmth.

"Yes... it felt like... like you were hugging my soul."

Kasumi pumped her fist triumphantly, her grin bright and mischievous.

"Mission accomplished! Then it's your turn next — both you and Homura. Go give Sayaka's soul a big hug too! She needs it more than anyone right now."

Madoka's eyes shimmered with renewed determination.

"I will. I'll try my hardest!"

Homura stepped forward, posture rigid, voice steady despite the storm raging behind her violet eyes.

"So... you can share someone's burden simply by holding their hands? How exactly does that work? Can we do that to help Sayaka?"

Her mind raced beneath the calm surface:

And more importantly... can I use it to save Madoka?

To finally change her fate?

Lunaria chuckled softly, her expression unreadable in its gentleness.

"You're welcome to test it with Sayaka."

Kasumi leaned in and nudged Madoka's shoulder playfully.

"You two are besties, right? She won't mind if you hold her hand for a while~"

Madoka flushed bright red.

"W-well..."

Homura closed her eyes and sighed.

"You're avoiding the question."

Kasumi only grinned wider, while Lunaria's eyes sparkled with quiet amusement.

Madoka shook her head, smiling despite herself.

“Even so... I feel like I have a real chance now. Thank you both.”

Homura opened her eyes, gaze sharp.

“Do you want to come with us? To where Sayaka is right now?”

Her voice remained calm, but inside, her heart hammered violently.

Please say yes.

I need to see what you’ll do.

I need to know if you can stop her from becoming a witch.

Or... if you know how to save one.

Madoka’s face lit up instantly.

“That’s a great idea! Please come with us — if you’re willing. I’d feel so much better having you there.”

Kasumi flashed a cheerful thumbs-up.

“Of course! We’ll be cheering you on!”

Lunaria nodded gracefully.

“Lead the way, Homura.”

Homura’s chest tightened with a fragile, dangerous kind of hope.

“...Follow me.”

She turned and began walking. The others fell into step behind her through the quiet afternoon streets. The setting sun painted the buildings in soft pinks and oranges, but the beauty only made the ache in Homura’s heart sharper.

After a few moments, Kasumi tilted her head, voice bright and curious.

“So! Are you two close friends?”

Madoka nearly tripped over her own feet.

“Ehh—?!”

She glanced nervously at Homura, completely caught off guard.

Homura’s fists clenched at her sides. Her jaw tightened until it hurt. She kept her gaze fixed straight ahead, back ramrod straight.

Madoka is my best friend.

My light.

My reason for everything.

But this Madoka... this timeline's Madoka... barely knew her. And Homura had been so cold to her. So distant.

Her heart ached with a familiar, unbearable pain.

Madoka swallowed, choosing her words carefully when Homura stayed silent.

“To be honest... I don't really know Homura-chan that well yet. She only transferred to our school recently.”

She continued, voice growing softer.

“And whenever we've talked... she's always been so cold and distant. Like she's carrying something enormous she can't share with anyone.”

Homura's lip trembled almost imperceptibly.

I am hiding something.

Not because I want to...

but because I have to.

Every time she told the truth before, it only brought pain... conflict... death.

Madoka's tone gentled further.

“But... even so... I do consider Homura-chan a friend.”

Homura's eyes widened — just slightly.

Her breath caught.

She hadn't expected that.

Madoka smiled softly.

“She told me she's seen so many people die that she stopped counting. I can't imagine what she's gone through. And she keeps warning me not to become a magical girl... I think it's because she doesn't want me to suffer like that.”

Madoka's smile warmed.

“And now she's leading us to help Sayaka. So... I think deep down, Homura-chan is really kind.”

Homura blinked rapidly, forcing back the sting in her eyes.

Madoka... you always see the best in people.

Even when you shouldn't.

Kasumi clasped her hands together dramatically.

“Awww! That’s so precious!”

She spun toward Homura with a teasing grin.

“And what about you, Homura? Do you consider Madoka a friend?”

Homura inhaled slowly, steeling herself. Her answer came out flat and cold:

“Madoka is someone I don’t want to become a magical girl. Nothing more.”

Kasumi burst out laughing.

“There’s that icy attitude Madoka mentioned!”

Lunaria chuckled softly, her voice warm.

“I hope the two of you grow closer from now on. You would make wonderful friends.”

Madoka lowered her gaze, smiling with quiet hope.

“I… I hope so too.”

Homura said nothing.

But inside, her heart twisted violently.

I want that more than anything.

But it’s already impossible.

I’ve repeated time too many times.

Everything between us is broken beyond repair.

She kept walking forward, shoulders rigid.

Each step felt heavier than the last.

Chapter 8c: Sayaka’s collapse

The labyrinth had swallowed the alley whole.

What had once been rain-slick pavement and flickering streetlamps dissolved into a drifting, impossible nightmare of fractured mirrors and floating glass hearts.

Warm golden-pink light shimmered through the air — the color of first love, of soft promises — but it flickered weakly, like dying embers struggling against a rising tide of bruise-colored shadows.

Everywhere she turned, faint laughter echoed.

Soft.

Distant.

Wrong.

Laughter that bled into whispered apologies, whispered regrets, whispered *Please... don't leave me...* until the words blurred into something like quiet sobbing.

Sayaka stood in the center of it all, sword hanging limply at her side.

Her uniform was torn.

Her body was battered.

But the pain felt distant — muted, forgotten.

The real hurt lived deeper. A hollow, gnawing ache that pulsed behind her ribs, too heavy to name.

She lifted her gaze.

Suspended in the warped space like a grotesque saint hung the Witch.

A massive, malformed heart—crimson flesh veined with jagged shards of stained glass. Thick iron chains bit deep into its surface, holding the broken pieces together. Thorny vines coiled through the cracks, blooming with pale flowers that smelled sickeningly sweet, like the perfume of a first love long since abandoned.

Embedded in the heart were fragments of a past life:

faded ribbons, cracked jewelry, tiny keepsakes that pulsed faintly with long-lost memories.

The heart beat.

Slow. Heavy. Melancholic.

Then faster.

Faster.

As if she recognized the same hollow ache mirrored in the girl standing before her.

Sayaka's fingers tightened around the hilt of her sword until her knuckles went white.

"...You're laughing at me too, aren't you?" she whispered, voice raw.

The Witch did not respond.

But her familiars did.

They rose from the drifting shards—surreal, elongated couples with smooth, featureless faces and exaggerated smiles. They danced in looping circles, holding hands, twirling, laughing eerie. Their limbs bent at wrong angles, their movements playful yet cruel, like memories of happiness the original girl could not keep.

Above them fluttered twisted Cupids—tiny cherubs with cracked porcelain skin and wings of torn lace and barbed wire. They nocked arrows tipped with thorns and aimed them lazily in Sayaka's direction.

Rage surged through the emptiness in her chest.

"Get out of my way!"

She charged.

The familiars swarmed her in a chaotic wave, offering grotesque parodies of affection: thorned roses that bled when touched, warped rings that tried to slip onto her fingers like shackles, ribbons that snaked toward her throat. Thorned arrows streaked past, some grazing her arms and leaving shallow, stinging lines. Others struck her armor with dull, numbing thuds that made her soul gem flicker.

Sayaka didn't stop.

She couldn't stop.

The massive heart pulsed faster as Sayaka drew near—frantic now, almost fearful.

Chains lashed out like striking serpents.

Glass shards spun through the air, sharp as broken promises.

Weaponized fragments of the Witch's old life hurtled toward her:

a silver locket that burst into glittering fragments,

a faded photograph that sliced the air like a blade.

She blocked what she could. Deflected others with wide, desperate swings.

But there were too many.

Chains snapped around her arms and torso, tightening with cruel intimacy. Vines slithered across her legs, pinning her in place. A particularly large shard drove into her shoulder — and she gasped, not from pain, but from the sudden flood of someone else's memory:

A gentle kiss under streetlights.

A promise whispered.

A promise broken.

The Witch's laughter echoed — distorted, layered, mocking.

A reflection of Sayaka's own laughter the night she realized she had lost everything.

The familiars closed in, their looping dances tightening into a suffocating circle. Featureless smiles stretched wider.

Sayaka's breath came in short, trembling bursts.

"Shut up..."

The laughter swelled.

"Shut up."

Her vision bled red at the edges.

The chains dug deeper, drawing dark lines across her skin.

"SHUT UP!"

Something inside her snapped.

A raw, unstable surge of emotion — sadness, rage, hatred — exploded outward like a broken dam. It wasn't the clean, righteous power she once felt when fighting. This was wild. Poisonous. Intoxicating.

The chains cracked with a sound like shattering bone. The vines recoiled as if burned. The familiars scattered, their forms glitching and freezing mid-twirl.

“AAAAAHHHHHH!”

Sayaka tore herself free with a scream that tore from the deepest part of her chest—half fury, half sob. She lunged forward.

Her sword came down again and again, each strike fueled by everything she had tried to bury: the betrayal, her loneliness, the aching emptiness where hope used to be.

The blade bit deep into the Witch's heart. Once. Twice. A third time. Crimson ichor and glittering memory-fluid sprayed across her face and armor.

“Heh... heheh... HAHAAHAHA!”

Sayaka laughed — a wild, unhinged sound that didn't feel like it belonged to her anymore.

The heart fractured.

Splintered.

Shattered with a final, heart-wrenching scream that sounded far too much like a girl's dying wail.

The labyrinth dissolved in a rush of color and sound. Mirrors shattered. Floating hearts crumbled to dust. The warm pink light guttered out completely.

Sayaka collapsed to her knees in the cold, real alley once more. Rain pattered against her torn uniform. Her sword clattered to the ground beside her, trembling with the aftershocks of her own power.

She stared at her shaking hands, breath ragged.

“...What... was that?”

The surge still lingered in her veins—dark, heady, liberating. For one brief moment she had felt limitless. Like she could burn the whole world down if it meant stopping the pain.

A dangerous, tempting thought.

“That power... I can be strong with power like that...”

Her voice was barely a whisper, lost beneath the rain.

The grief she had been holding back for so long pressed harder against her ribs, heavier than any chain.

Somewhere deep inside her Soul Gem—hidden from sight—a tiny new crack spiderwebbed outward, thin as a hairline fracture, but spreading all the same.

The labyrinth peeled away like dissolving paint, its impossible geometry collapsing into drifting motes of color.

And then Sayaka was back in the real world.

Cold rain greeted her.

Soft, steady droplets that slid down her cheeks like tears she no longer had the strength to shed. Her torn uniform clung to her skin, heavy with water and blood and exhaustion. She took one step, then another — each one weaker than the last — until her legs simply refused to hold her.

She collapsed onto the nearest park bench.

The wood was slick beneath her palms. Her breath came in ragged, uneven bursts, each inhale scraping against her ribs like broken glass. Her limbs felt like lead. Her thoughts scattered like shards of a shattered mirror.

Inside her chest, emotions churned violently — grief, rage, betrayal, loneliness — all tangled together into something thick and suffocating.

I'm losing myself...

Her phone buzzed weakly in her pocket.

Sayaka blinked slowly, as if even that tiny motion required effort. She fumbled for the device with trembling fingers. The screen glowed pale in the dim rainlight.

A message from Hitomi.

Hi Sayaka,

I did it. I confessed to Kyōsuke.

He said he was happy... we're going on our first date.

I hope you're okay. I still want us to be friends.

Sayaka stared at the words until they blurred.

Then something inside her — something she had been holding together with sheer will — finally shattered.

The phone slipped from her numb fingers and clattered onto the wet pavement. Her shoulders folded inward. A choked sound escaped her throat — half sob, half laugh — and then the dam broke.

Tears spilled down her cheeks in silent, shaking waves.

I made a wish for him...

And this... this is what I get in return?

Her sobs were quiet, almost soundless beneath the rain.

But the despair behind them was deafening.

“Sayaka!”

A voice cut through the downpour like a blade.

Kyoko sprinted toward her, red hair whipping wildly behind her like a streak of fire in the storm. Her face was twisted with alarm.

“I felt it — a huge burst of negativity. It reeked of your magic. I thought something happened to you —”

She skidded to a stop.

And froze.

Sayaka looked wrong.

Her posture slumped.

Her eyes unfocused.

The usual fire in her gaze reduced to a faint, flickering ember.

Her aura dim and unstable, like a candle guttering in the wind.

“Sayaka...?” Kyoko whispered, voice suddenly small.

Sayaka didn’t respond.

When she finally did, it was with a small, broken chuckle — the sound of someone who had already surrendered.

Kyoko’s brows knit sharply. She grabbed Sayaka by the shoulders, pulling her upright with rough urgency.

“Hey! Snap out of it. Look at me! Are you still in there? Say something!”

Sayaka blinked slowly, as if waking from a long, distant dream.

“I... I don’t know what to do anymore,” she murmured, voice hollow. “I can’t remember what I thought was so important. What was worth fighting for... what I was even trying to protect.”

“No,” Kyoko said fiercely, shaking her head. “That’s not you. Where’s that stubborn bravado of yours? You’re the girl who wanted to save everyone. The one who preached about justice and carving your own path. What happened to her?”

Sayaka lifted her hand weakly.

Her Soul Gem rested in her palm.

It was nearly black.

Swirling darkness churned inside it like a living storm — violent, hungry, endless.

Kyoko's eyes widened in raw horror.

"Sayaka — your Soul Gem!"

Sayaka gave her a fragile, broken smile that hurt worse than any wound.

"I finally understand what you meant... about balance. About how good and bad even out in the end."

She bent down, fingers brushing the wet pavement, and picked up her fallen phone. With trembling hands she held the screen toward Kyoko.

"I saved him. I healed Kyōsuke. I made a wish so he could be happy..."

Her voice cracked, splintering like thin ice.

"But in return... I've been cursed with nothing but misery. My heart's so full of sadness, rage, and hatred that I even cut ties with Madoka... my best friend."

Tears streamed freely now.

One glistening drop fell from her chin.

"I was stupid. So, so stupid..."

The tear hovered for a single, fragile moment in the air — like a tiny, doomed star.

Then it continued its descent toward the blackened Soul Gem.

From the corner of her eye, Sayaka saw movement through the rain.

Homura.

Madoka.

And two unfamiliar girls running toward her with desperate urgency.

Madoka's voice tore through the storm, raw and breaking:

"SAYAKA—!!"

Sayaka's lips parted, as if to answer.

But her consciousness was already slipping away.

The tear struck the surface of her Soul Gem.

And everything shattered.

A violent burst of dark light exploded outward — a shockwave of pure, concentrated despair that ripped through the rain like a scream given form.

Kyoko cried out as the force hurled her backward, straight toward Madoka and Homura.

Homura moved instantly.

She seized Madoka's hand with one iron grip and snatched Kyoko's wrist with the other, anchoring them against the blast.

"What the hell is going on?" Kyoko gasped, bracing herself.

"Sayaka's there! We have to go help her!" Madoka cried, trying to run toward the vortex.

"Don't." Homura pulled her back. "Just watch."

Kyoko and Madoka stared ahead, hearts pounding.

As the violent vortex of negativity faded, a silhouette emerged.

A Witch.

Oktavia von Seckendorff.

Her armored form loomed enormous and tragic, knightly helm bowed as if in eternal sorrow, the great sword planted point-down like a gravestone. Behind her, faint echoes of a mournful violin melody began to play — distorted, haunting — as the labyrinth barrier started to take shape around them.

Oktavia von Seckendorff straightened slowly.

Her towering armored form rose with a grinding, metallic groan that echoed through the half-formed labyrinth like the opening of a tomb. The knightly helm tilted toward the three girls—Madoka, Homura, Kyoko—its hollow gaze settling on them with the weight of a verdict already decided.

Then she raised her massive sword.

The air trembled. A mournful violin swelled from nowhere, strings tightening into a frantic crescendo that vibrated through their chests.

From the shadows, dozens of enormous wheels materialized—spinning, grinding, converging with lethal grace.

Madoka screamed, stumbling backward, hands flying to her mouth.

Kyoko's spear snapped into existence in a burst of red light.

"Damn it—!"

The wheels closed in—

And then everything stopped.

The wheels froze mid-spin, suspended like grotesque ornaments in the air. The orchestra cut off mid-note, leaving a silence so absolute it rang in their ears.

Kyoko and Madoka stared around them, breathless and disoriented.

"Wh-what just happened...?" Madoka whispered, voice shaking.

Homura's grip on their hands remained iron-tight.

"Don't let go," she said, voice steady. "If you do, you'll be frozen in time too."

Kyoko blinked, stunned, then let out a short, bitter laugh.

"So this is your trick... No wonder you always show up out of nowhere like a damn ghost."

She glanced at the motionless Witch, eyes narrow with suspicion.

"As much as I wanna grill you about it, we've got bigger problems right now."

Madoka turned to Homura, tears already spilling down her cheeks.

"Homura... why is there a witch where Sayaka used to be? What happened to her?"

Homura's expression softened—just a fraction, but enough for both girls to notice. She squeezed their hands gently, grounding them in the frozen moment.

"This is the final truth of magical girls," she said quietly. "Our destiny."

Kyoko's eyes widened as the pieces slammed into place. Her lips parted in shock.

Madoka shook her head violently, sobs breaking free.

"No... no, Homura, that can't be true. You're lying. This has to be a nightmare!"

Homura shook her head, voice low and unflinching.

"You saw it with your own eyes. When a magical girl's despair overwhelms her, her Soul Gem shatters... and she is reborn as a witch. The Sayaka you knew is gone. You saw how she attacked us."

Madoka's legs buckled. She collapsed against Homura, burying her face in her chest as raw sobs tore out of her.

"Sayaka wanted to be a hero... She wanted to save people from witches... Why—why is fate so cruel? Why did she become the very thing she fought against?!"

Homura held her gently, one hand resting on the back of her head.

"This is the fate that awaits anyone who becomes a magical girl. For every person Sayaka saved... her witch will now curse others in return. Burn this moment into your memory, Madoka. Never think about becoming one. Ever."

Kyoko's grief ignited into fury. She grabbed Homura by the collar and yanked her forward.

"What the hell is your problem?! How can you say that to her now?! Sayaka... she was Madoka's best friend!"

Homura didn't resist. Her expression softened further—something rare, fragile, painful.

"I know," she said softly. "And that's exactly why I don't want Madoka to suffer the same fate."

Kyoko froze. The anger drained from her grip. She let go with a quiet "...Tch," turning her face away.

Homura straightened.

“Let’s go. We’re leaving.”

Kyoko’s head snapped up.

“What?! There’s a witch right here! We should finish her off while we can!”

Homura met her gaze evenly.

“Can you fight her properly while Madoka is like this?”

Kyoko looked at Madoka — so weak, so fragile, so broken — and clenched her teeth, fists trembling.

“...Damn it.”

Homura turned to lead them towards the exit of the labyrinth. She expected to see Lunaria and Kasumi still standing a short distance behind them—frozen mid-step like everything else.

But the space was empty.

Completely empty.

Homura’s eyes widened.

“...What?”

Kyoko frowned. “What’s up?”

Homura forced her voice steady, though unease coiled in her chest like a tightening wire.

“Kyoko... did you see two girls behind us right before Sayaka transformed?”

Kyoko blinked.

“No? I was too busy getting blasted straight at you two. Why?”

Homura’s jaw tightened.

First they shared Madoka’s burden with a single touch...

And now they’re unaffected by my time stop?

Just what are Lunaria and Kasumi...?

Madoka lifted her head, eyes red and swollen.

“Lunaria... Kasumi... they’re gone?”

She turned, searching the frozen space desperately.

“Where did they go? They said they’d help us save Sayaka...”

Kyoko looked between them, confused.

“Hold on—who are these girls? You dragged others into this?”

Homura nodded curtly.

“We ran into them earlier. They’re travelers — adventurers. They know about magical girls. But they have no Soul Gems. No magical signatures.”

Madoka wiped her eyes with a trembling hand.

“They held my hands... I felt their energy flow into me. It was so warm... comforting. They told Homura and me to try the same with Sayaka. I invited them to come... I thought they could help...”

Her voice cracked.

“But now they’re gone...”

Homura looked away.

“Maybe they left once they realized it was too late. Maybe... there really is no way to save her now.”

Madoka’s face crumpled again.

Kyoko lowered her gaze, silent.

Together, the three girls walked out of the labyrinth, hearts unbearably heavy. As the barrier sealed behind them, the frozen world shimmered faintly.

Time resumed.

And in the heart of the newly formed labyrinth, before the towering, sorrowful form of Oktavia von Seckendorff...

Two figures stood untouched.

Lunaria.

Kasumi.

Kasumi let out a low whistle, tilting her head at the massive knight.

“Well... looks like Mami’s, Momoko’s, Mifuyu’s, and Kuroe’s situation just got a whole lot more complicated.”

Lunaria nodded, her expression calm but serious, eyes narrowing thoughtfully as she studied the Witch.

“Thankfully, Homura and Kyoko chose not to kill her. That means Mami, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe still have a little time.”

She glanced upward.

“Very little time. Tomorrow morning at the latest.”

Kasumi cracked her knuckles, a sharp grin spreading across her face.

“So we push them off the deep end, right?”

Lunaria’s lips curled into a small, mischievous smile.

“Exactly. Time to let dream-Kyoko know to turn up the heat.”

Kasumi laughed, bright and unafraid.

“This is gonna be good!”

Behind them, the Witch’s mournful violin echoed faintly through the barrier—haunting, endless, and full of longing.

Chapter 9: Dream-realm training concludes

Darkness pressed in from every direction.

Not the simple absence of light, but a living, breathing shadow — thick with emotion, heavy with memory. It clung to Kuroe’s skin like oil, seeping into her lungs with every trembling breath. The air vibrated with whispered accusations, half-formed regrets, and the echo of every choice she wished she could take back.

Kuroe drifted through the void like a leaf caught in a black tide.

Her eyes were squeezed shut.

Her hands clutched her head.

Her breath came in thin, shaking gasps.

“Please... stop...” she whispered, voice cracking. “Please... I don’t want to hear it anymore...”

But the negativity only swelled, louder and more insistent.

Her regrets bubbled up like boiling tar.

Her guilt coiled around her ribs like rusted chains.

Every mistake, every failure, every moment of weakness rose to the surface, sharp as broken glass.

A shadow shifted above her.

A figure floated there, looking down with a smile that was all teeth and cruel delight.

Her Doppel.

She was Kuroe’s mirror — same face, same eyes, same delicate features — but twisted. Muddy black wings sprouted from her back, dripping shadow like ink. Darkness clung to her like a tattered cloak. Her grin stretched too wide, too eager.

The doppel clicked her tongue.

“Tsk, ts... still struggling? Still pretending you’re something other than this?”

She spread her arms wide and spun slowly, presenting the suffocating void like a grand stage.

“This is your soul, Kuroe. All of this negativity, guilt, despair... this is who you truly are.”

Kuroe shook her head violently, tears slipping from her closed eyes.

“No... I didn’t mean to... I didn’t want to... Please, just leave me alone...”

Her voice was small.

Fragile.

Breaking.

The doppel laughed — a sound like glass cracking.

“Denial won’t save you. You know the truth. You’re weak. Pathetic. Countless people died to witches because of you... You abandoned Kuro when she needed you most... and because of you, she became a witch.”

Kuroe flinched as if struck.

The Doppel drifted closer, her voice dropping to a poisonous whisper that brushed against Kuroe’s ear.

“I am your destiny. You can’t escape me.”

She leaned in until their faces were inches apart.

“Listen to your regrets. Listen to your guilt. Listen to your despair. Submit. Let me finish what you started.”

Kuroe’s breath hitched.

Her thoughts blurred.

Her will faltered.

Because the doppel’s words weren’t lies.

They were the things she had buried deepest.

The things she feared most.

The things she believed about herself.

The Doppel saw the weakness and smiled wider, triumphant.

“Yes... yes, that’s it. Just let it all go...”

Kuroe froze.

Let it all go.

The words echoed inside her like a bell.

She had spent her entire life running from them—chaining them down, burying them deep.

But what if she stopped resisting? What if she stopped fighting?

What if she simply... accepted?

Kuroe took a deep, trembling breath. Her heart hammered against her ribs.

She didn't know if this would destroy her.

She didn't know if she would survive it.

But she made her choice.

She let go.

She surrendered.

The doppel blinked in pleasant surprise.

“Oh? Surrendering so quickly? How delightful~”

She dissolved into swirling black mist and plunged straight into Kuroe's body.

Kuroe's back arched violently.

Muddy black wings burst from her back with a wet, tearing sound. Darkness wrapped around her like a cocoon, thick and suffocating.

When her eyes snapped open again, they gleamed with a cold, wicked light.

The Doppel's voice poured from her own mouth, gleeful and victorious.

“Aha... finally. A body of my own. Now I can roam free and spread despair to—”

A calm, steady voice echoed from within the same mind.

“Yes... You were right. About me... about everything...”

The doppel froze mid-sentence.

“...What?”

Kuroe's consciousness remained—quiet, unshakably present, and strangely at peace.

“You... you shouldn't be here,” the doppel hissed. “You surrendered. You gave up. You should be gone!”

Kuroe's voice answered softly, but with iron beneath the gentleness.

“I did exactly what you told me to do. I let it all go. I accepted myself—all of myself.”

The Doppel tried to move, to spread the wings, to fly free.

But the body no longer obeyed her.

She was trapped.

“Gah! What's going on?! I can't move!”

Kuroe let out a gentle, almost sad chuckle that resonated through their shared mind.

“Looks like things reversed, didn’t they? Now you’re the one who can’t escape.”

The Doppel snarled, thrashing uselessly.

“This isn’t how it’s supposed to go!”

Kuroe continued, her tone steady and warm.

“All my life, I thought I was useless. I failed to save many people from witches because I was weak. And I regretted abandoning Kuro more than anything. Learning she became a witch because of me... it crushed me.”

The shadows around them trembled.

“And everything you said — every cruel word — was true. Those were my thoughts. My fears. My self-hatred.”

The Doppel’s expression twisted in rage and confusion.

“Then why accept it?! Why embrace the very things that broke you?!”

Kuroe smiled softly, wings spreading not in malice, but in quiet acceptance.

“Because running from them only made them stronger.”

She closed her eyes for a moment, breathing deeply.

“I’m done running. I’ll accept myself—the good and the bad, the mistakes and the growth.”

The doppel spat venom.

“What good?! You’ve never helped anyone! You survived only because others saved you — the Wings of the Magius, Iroha, everyone! If they abandoned you, you would’ve become a witch long ago!”

Kuroe nodded calmly.

“That may be true.”

The Doppel faltered, caught off guard.

“But I *did* become a witch. Even with all their support.”

Kuroe continued, voice warming with quiet strength.

“And afterwards... Lunaria, Kasumi, Tamashii, Suzume, Shizuku, Airi, Yume, Mio... they showed me a new way forward. A future where I don’t succumb to despair—but master it. Where I can use it to protect others.”

The Doppel’s eyes widened in disbelief.

“You abandoned Kuro once. What makes you think you won’t abandon the others again? People don’t change. You’ll mess up. You’ll regret everything again. And next time, I’ll take over for good!”

Kuroe's smile remained gentle, unshaken.

"Maybe I will mess up. Maybe I will regret things again."

She closed her eyes once more.

"And when that happens... I'll face you head-on. Just like I'm doing now."

The Doppel thrashed wildly, her form flickering and distorting.

"No—no! You'll regret this! I'll be back! I'll use every new regret, every new failure, every fresh drop of despair—"

Kuroe whispered, soft and final:

"Until that time comes... farewell."

The Doppel's voice dissolved into static, then silence.

Kuroe's eyes fluttered open.

For a moment she didn't move, unsure if she was awake or still drifting in the remnants of her own darkness. But then she felt it — the soft, cool embrace of grass beneath her back, cradling her like an old friend. A gentle breeze brushed across her cheeks, warm and fragrant, carrying the faint sweetness of unseen flowers.

She exhaled slowly.

Above her stretched a sky that could not exist in any real world — an endless canvas of molten gold and deep crimson, a perpetual twilight where the sun hovered just below the horizon, painting everything in soft, impossible light.

For a long moment, she simply breathed.

Then the memories returned — not as knives, but as ripples.

Every failed attempt to tame her witch form.

Every time despair had swallowed her whole.

Every brutal moment the Doppel had torn free and overwhelmed her will.

And finally — the quiet, trembling instant she had stopped fighting and simply accepted herself.

A small, breathless laugh escaped her lips.

"...That took a very long time."

She stretched her arms overhead. Her body felt light — weightless, even. When she pushed herself upright, something shifted behind her, brushing the air with a soft rustle.

Her wings.

Muddy black feathers edged in living shadow, born from the doppel that haunted and broke her. But they no longer dragged at her like anchors. They didn't press against her soul like chains. They didn't threaten to drown her in darkness.

They simply... were.

Natural.

Part of her.

Kuroe rose slowly, testing her balance. No vertigo. No rising panic. No cold wave of despair threatening to pull her under. Only a profound, humming calm.

Behind her, a cheerful, melodic voice chimed like wind chimes in a summer breeze.

"Oh? So you are finally awake."

Kuroe spun around — and froze.

There, standing just a few paces away beneath the golden-red sky, was the Forgotten Queen.

Porcelain-pale skin that seemed to drink in the twilight. Soft lavender eyes that sparkled with ancient mischief. Golden curls cascading down her back like liquid sunlight spilling over water. Her dress shimmered with shifting layers of moonlight, frost, and dusk, the fabric flowing and reforming with every subtle breath. Tiny motes of light drifted lazily around her, like pollen made of stardust.

Kuroe's heart slammed against her ribs. She bowed so quickly she nearly toppled over.

"Y-You're—! I mean—Forgotten Queen! I... I saw you earlier today, before Mami-san fought Kasumi. I didn't think— I never expected—!"

The Queen let out a bright, bell-like laugh that seemed to make the air itself sparkle.

"Oh, relax, Kuroe. I'm not here to toss you off a cliff or anything so theatrical. Your 'special training' for today is already over."

Kuroe sagged with visible relief.

"Oh thank goodness..."

"But," the Queen continued, stepping closer with a curious tilt of her head, "you didn't need the dream-realm's memory reset this time."

Her eyes gleamed with delighted pride.

"Which means... you finally succeeded in controlling your witch form. Congratulations!"

Kuroe nodded shyly, cheeks warming.

"Yes... I think I did. Thank you!"

The Queen circled her once, slow and graceful, studying the black wings, the faint aura of shadow clinging to Kuroe's silhouette, and the relaxed steadiness of her shoulders.

"Hm. This is your doppel-witch form, isn't it? Not your complete witch transformation."

Kuroe nodded again.

"All my attempts today were with my doppel. When I was still... alive, I used it so often. But the more I relied on it, the more it slipped out of my control. This is the first time it feels..." She exhaled softly. "Completely at ease. Like it belongs to me."

The Queen's smile softened, warm and approving.

"Fascinating. It seems the Wings of the Magius' APS inadvertently created an intermediary step just for you. Most magical girls must master their full witch form first — a long and painful process. You, however, mastered the doppel-witch form instead."

Kuroe blinked, processing the words.

"...I mastered the intermediary step?"

The Queen winked, playful.

"Exactly. And for most witches, even reaching full control of their complete form takes far longer than what you just achieved in one session. The APS has its flaws, certainly... but it also has its quiet merits. Most things do, when approached with the right heart."

Kuroe pressed a hand over her chest. After the nightmare of yesterday — the doppelified magical girls, the chaos, the overwhelming fear — she had never imagined she would feel anything close to gratitude toward the APS.

And yet... she did.

The Forgotten Queen clasped her hands behind her back, beaming brightly.

"Well then! Since you've finally made peace with this part of yourself... why not try it out properly? Show me what you can do now."

Kuroe's eyes widened for a moment, then sparkled with hesitant excitement.

"R-right. Okay."

She drew in a steadying breath, spread her wings, and—

SWOOSH.

Her right wing sliced through the air with effortless power. A powerful gust rippled outward, bending the tall grass in wide, shimmering waves.

Kuroe gasped, eyes wide.

"That was... so easy."

She swung her left wing.

CRACK—POP—SPATTER.

A controlled barrage of mud bullets erupted along the arc of her swing, striking the ground in neat, precise patterns. Not wild. Not chaotic. Just... hers.

She stared at her wings in open awe.

“These were my doppel’s abilities... but now they feel so natural.”

Emboldened, she experimented further. Her wings shifted fluidly — hardening into armored shields, sharpening into wicked spikes, flattening into broad barriers — each transformation as simple and instinctive as flexing a muscle she had always possessed.

Her grin grew wider, brighter.

Then she jumped.

One powerful flap —

And she soared.

“W-whoa—!”

She spun through the golden-red sky, twirled, dove, and climbed with unrestrained laughter bubbling from her throat. This wasn’t the borrowed flight of the dream-realm. This was her own power lifting her.

She summoned her magical girl batons. They materialized larger than before, heavier, their surfaces coated in glistening purple mud with shadows curling around them like living smoke.

Kuroe hurled them downward.

They struck the earth and melted into two shimmering violet puddles.

With a focused thought, the puddles rose, twisting and reshaping themselves. One became a perfect statue of herself, wings proudly spread. The other formed Iroha standing gently in front of Mikazuki Villa, a soft smile on her face.

Kuroe burst into delighted laughter.

“I can control their shapes too! This is... amazing!”

Far below, the Forgotten Queen chuckled, voice carrying clearly through the twilight air.

“You look like you’re having the time of your life~”

Kuroe beamed down at her, glowing with pure joy.

“I am! I never knew my doppel could do all this. Combining my magical girl powers with the doppel’s... it unlocks so much more. I wonder what else I can—”

She trailed off, eyes sparkling with possibility.

Kuroe hovered in the air a moment longer, wings spread wide, letting the golden-red twilight wash over her. The warm breeze carried her laughter across the endless dream-realm fields — light, bright, and freer than anything she had ever felt in life. Her wings caught the light like ink dipped in fire, shadow and glow blending in a way that felt impossibly natural.

Below her, the Forgotten Queen watched with a serene, knowing smile — the kind of smile that held centuries of quiet understanding, as if she had witnessed countless souls reach this same fragile, luminous turning point.

A cheerful voice chimed from above, bright as a bell.

“If you love flying that much, Kuroe, we should go **Dreamweaving** together sometime!”

Kuroe blinked upward just in time to see **Suzume** spiraling into view. She moved with effortless grace, ribbons of shimmering color trailing behind her like comet tails. She twirled once, flipped mid-air, and struck a dramatic pose, her laughter ringing like silver chimes.

Kuroe’s eyes widened.

Those movements... they were almost identical to the Dreamweavers she had seen earlier — the dancers who soared through the skies during the tour with dream-Kyoko, Mami, Momoko, and Mifuyu.

“Is Dreamweaving... based on your ability?” Kuroe called, half in awe, half in disbelief.

Suzume flipped backward in a graceful arc and landed lightly on a cushion of invisible air, winking.

“Very sharp, Kuroe! Yep — the dream-realm borrows a little from all of us.” She bowed with theatrical flourish. “Remember how you and the others could fly so easily during the tour? That was thanks to yours truly~”

She twirled again, sending spirals of vibrant color dancing around her.

“And Dreamweaving? Just a fun little sport I invented. Flight, dance, challenges — all rolled into one!”

A soft rumble of thunder rolled overhead.

Kuroe turned to see Shizuku drifting toward them atop a fluffy white cloud, legs crossed elegantly as if lounging on a luxurious sofa. A sly grin curved her lips.

“The sky and weather are my domain,” she said, voice smooth and teasing. “So try not to upset me... or the dream-realm might experience a little... reckoning.”

A tiny lightning bolt crackled behind her, sparkling like a mischievous firework.

Kuroe laughed nervously — and then a gentle floral scent drifted through the air, sweet and calming.

Airi glided in on a floating flower pod, its petals opening and closing beneath her feet like a living platform.

“And I take care of the nature here,” Airi said warmly, her voice like sunlight on leaves. “The forests, the fields, the hidden gardens... I’d love to show you and your friends around sometime. There’s still so much beauty you haven’t seen yet.”

Before Kuroe could reply, three more figures descended gracefully from the golden sky.

Tamashii arrived wrapped in swirling spirits that flickered like lantern flames.

Yume stood atop a rippling platform of living shadow, dark and fluid like ink.

Mio balanced effortlessly on an invisible platform, posture calm and perfectly poised.

They spoke in perfect unison, their voices overlapping into a haunting, melodic chord:

“And we built the haunted dungeon!”

Tamashii grinned, eyes sparkling.

“A true test of wit, bravery, and combat.”

Yume added softly, “Perfect for thrill-seekers.”

Mio finished with quiet confidence, “You and your friends should try it sometime.”

Kuroe’s jaw dropped slightly.

The dream-realm... this entire world... wasn’t just a magical place.

It was a collaboration.

A living tapestry woven from the abilities, memories, and imaginations of everyone who called it home.

She looked at all of them — Suzume with her bright energy, Shizuku with her playful power, Airi with her gentle warmth, and the trio of Tamashii, Yume, and Mio radiating pride and joy. Each of them carried a deep sense of belonging she had never truly known while she was alive.

The Forgotten Queen chuckled softly from below, the sound warm and fond.

“There will be plenty of time for you and your friends to explore everything the dream-realm has to offer. The more you interact with its people, the more you’ll come to understand it.”

She lifted her gaze to Kuroe, lavender eyes softening with gentle encouragement.

“And I look forward to seeing what you will eventually share with this world.”

Kuroe blinked, suddenly flustered. She scratched the back of her head, wings fluttering uncertainly.

“M-Me? I... I don’t know if I can contribute anything worthwhile. The dream-realm is already so incredible...”

Suzume floated closer and tapped Kuroe lightly on the forehead with a playful grin.

“Silly girl. Everyone brings something unique. You just haven’t discovered yours yet.”

Airi nodded gently, her smile kind and reassuring.

“And when you do, we’ll all be here to help you shape it.”

Kuroe’s wings gave a small, involuntary flutter. A warm tightness bloomed in her chest — not anxiety, but something far gentler.

“Thank you,” she said softly, voice trembling with emotion. “All of you. For helping me today... for helping me accept myself, and for helping me master my doppel.”

The words carried gratitude, belonging, and fragile new hope all at once.

Kuroe descended from the sky in a slow, drifting glide, her dark wings folding neatly against her back as her feet touched the ground with barely a whisper. The twilight fields shimmered around her, every blade of grass catching the golden-red light like tiny lanterns. One by one, the others arrived in their own graceful ways: Suzume spiraling down in a vibrant ribbon of color, Shizuku reclining on a drifting cloud, Airi’s flower pod floating like a blooming cradle, and Tamashii, Yume, and Mio descending like falling stars streaking across the sky.

The Forgotten Queen stepped forward, her expression warm yet thoughtful — as if she carried secrets too vast to share all at once.

“There is one more thing I wish to share with you, Kuroe.”

Kuroe blinked, tilting her head. “What is it?”

The Forgotten Queen’s lavender eyes gleamed with quiet intensity.

“Kuroe... what do you know about the witch’s kiss?”

Kuroe paused. Memories flickered through her mind — the marks she had once feared, the tragedies she had witnessed.

“It’s a mark witches leave on humans,” she said slowly. “It twists their emotions, deepens their negativity... sometimes it drives them to do terrible things. Witches use it to lure people into their labyrinths.”

The Forgotten Queen nodded approvingly.

“Correct. On Earth, it is seen as a curse — a harbinger of misfortune.”

She lifted her hand toward Kuroe, palm open in invitation.

“But now that you have mastered your doppel-witch form... yours will be different.”

Kuroe hesitated, unease flickering across her face.

“...Different how?”

“Take my hand,” the Forgotten Queen said gently. “And mark me.”

Kuroe’s eyes widened. “W-Wait, I don’t even know how—”

“You don’t need to know the steps,” the Forgotten Queen replied with a soft laugh. “You are a witch now. It will come naturally.”

Kuroe swallowed hard, nerves twisting in her stomach — but trust won out. She reached forward and took the Forgotten Queen’s hand.

A warm pulse traveled up her arm, like sunlight spreading through her veins. Her magic stirred instinctively — gentle, steady, unmistakably hers. She closed her eyes and let it flow.

When she opened them again, she gasped.

An intricate emblem was blooming across the Forgotten Queen’s neck, drawn by invisible threads of power. It unfurled like ink dissolving in water: two elegant black feathered wings curving protectively around a pair of glowing purple batons, each radiating a soft, warm light. The design shimmered with hues of twilight and quiet resolve.

“It’s... beautiful,” Kuroe whispered.

The Forgotten Queen conjured a mirror of shimmering light and brushed her fingers over the mark with evident delight.

“What a lovely witch’s kiss,” she said warmly. “It suits you perfectly.”

Kuroe stared, still stunned. “But... what does it do?”

The Forgotten Queen turned to her, expression gentle but serious.

“Unlike the curses you knew on Earth, yours grants others a temporary blessing. Anyone who bears your mark will gain access to a portion of your magic — much like how magical girls share power when they Connect.”

Kuroe’s breath caught.

“And most importantly,” the Forgotten Queen continued, “those who carry your kiss can communicate with witches. Even the ones who have lost themselves completely.”

Kuroe’s hand flew to her mouth.

“I... I can help people talk to witches? Even the dangerous ones back on Earth?”

Airi stepped forward, her smile soft and encouraging.

“Yes. You’re a witch now, Kuroe. You can reach any witch — controlled or not. And your kiss lets others do the same.”

Kuroe’s eyes widened further as realization dawned.

“So... it’s like when Lunaria reached me. When I became a witch. She spoke to me... and pulled me back.”

Tamashii nodded solemnly.

“That’s right. You can do the same now.”

Kuroe froze.

A sharp, startling thought pierced through the wonder.

*Lunaria... was able to speak to my witch. She does not have any soul gem nor witch’s kiss...
And I assume Kasumi is the same...*

Her heart pounded.

“Lunaria and Kasumi... they don’t have Soul Gems. Just like me now. And they can talk to witches without any mark. Does that mean they’re... are they witches too?”

The question hung in the air like a spark ready to ignite.

For a moment — silence.

Then the Forgotten Queen, Tamashii, Suzume, Shizuku, Airi, Yume, and Mio all burst into warm, affectionate laughter.

Kuroe puffed out her cheeks, pouting. “H-Hey! What’s so funny?”

Suzume wiped a tear from her eye, still giggling.

“Countless people have asked that exact question the moment they learn what a witch’s kiss truly does.”

Yume added softly, “It’s a very common assumption.”

Mio finished calmly, a hint of a smile on her lips:

“But whether they are witches... we cannot say.”

Kuroe slumped, exasperated but fond.

“That’s the same gentle deflection I always get when I ask about them. I can’t tell if you’re hiding something or if you really don’t know.”

Shizuku grinned mischievously.

“Who knows~? Keep exploring the dream-realm and the people within it. Maybe you’ll uncover something interesting.”

Kuroe huffed — but a small smile tugged at her lips despite herself.

“I will. I wonder what Mami, Momoko, Mifuyu, and dream-Kyoko would think about all this...”

The Forgotten Queen’s smile brightened, warm as starlight.

“You’ll get the chance to find out very soon.”

Kuroe blinked. “Wait — are they done with their training too?”

Shizuku burst out laughing again.

“Oh, absolutely not. As I told you earlier, Mami, Momoko, and Mifuyu are probably panicking right about now.”

Kuroe’s eyes went wide with alarm.

“P-Panicking?! Why? What kind of training are they even doing?!”

Before anyone could answer, a magic circle shimmered into existence at her feet — moons, planets, and stars swirling in a miniature cosmos, identical to the one at the coliseum that took Kuroe here.

Mio gestured toward it gracefully.

“Step inside. It will take you to them.”

Airi added with a playful grin,

“And they could really use your help right now — especially with your new abilities.”

Kuroe froze.

Her heart fluttered with a mix of nerves and something brighter — anticipation, maybe even quiet determination. She was used to being the one who needed help. The one who faltered. The one who, in one painful moment, had abandoned Kuro.

But now...

She took a deep breath, steadying herself.

“...Okay. Here I go. Wish me luck.”

The group smiled at her warmly, their voices overlapping in gentle encouragement:

“Good luck, Kuroe.”

“Show them what you’ve learned.”

“We believe in you.”

Kuroe stepped into the circle.

Light rose around her like a blooming star — radiant, enveloping —

And swallowed her whole.

Chapter 9a: To save a witch

The clash of steel rang through the illusionary labyrinth like a funeral bell.

Each strike echoed against the fractured walls, blending with the distant, mournful wail of violins. The air shimmered with sorrow — a grief so thick it felt like fog.

At the center of the labyrinth stood the towering knight of despair:

Oktavia von Seckendorff.

Even as an illusion crafted by dream-Kyoko, she was terrifyingly faithful to the real thing — armor forged from heartbreak, a colossal sword dragging trails of sapphire flame, chains rattling like broken promises.

Yet the three magical girls were no longer the desperate fighters they had once been.

Mifuyu spun through the air, her chakram slicing a perfect silver arc. A spinning wheel shattered into harmless motes of light. She landed lightly, breath steady, but her eyes were shadowed with frustration.

“Nothing reaches her,” she said quietly. “I can cut through her familiars, her wheels, even her armor... but her soul stays locked away.

Momoko met a crushing overhead strike with effortless grace. The impact boomed across the labyrinth like thunder. She twisted, twin blades singing, and drove a precise slash into the witch’s side.

A sad, hollow laugh escaped her.

“It’s almost funny. Back then, I would’ve been over the moon to fight with this kind of power. If all we wanted was to beat Sayaka’s witch... we could’ve killed her a dozen times.”

Oktavia lunged again, sword whistling. Momoko caught the blade on one arm — almost casually — and shoved the witch back with a surge of Connect-enhanced strength.

“But that’s not why we’re here.”

Mami raised her arm, celestial ribbons unfurling like constellations. Oktavia’s massive hand reached for her — only to be ensnared and hurled aside.

Mami lifted her rifle and fired a measured volley.

Not to kill.

Not to wound.

But to weaken.

To open a path.

“We’re not here to destroy her,” she said softly. “We’re here to reach her.”

Mifuyu closed her eyes and released a gentle wave of illusionary comfort: soft golden lights, warm fragments of shared memories, whispers of friendship and forgiveness drifting toward the witch like lullabies. At the same moment, Momoko slashed forward, her blades trailing beams of pure Encouragement—raw, sincere emotion meant to anchor a breaking heart.

Oktavia only answered with a distorted, echoing laugh that cracked through the labyrinth like shattering glass. Distant. Unreachable. Lost.

Mifuyu's voice trembled. "Sayaka won't hold much longer. At this rate... we'll kill her before we can save her."

Momoko lowered her blades, shoulders slumping. "This training made me realize something. Lunaria and Kasumi... they're incredible. The way Lunaria reached Kuroe's witch... it was like breathing. How did she make it look so easy?"

Mami's gaze softened as she recalled Lunaria's calm words before the training began:

Try your plan. If it fails, learn from it. And try again later.

She exhaled slowly, ribbons fading.

"Maybe... it's time to end this session."

Mifuyu nodded, weary but resolute. "We've learned a lot. We'll regroup and rethink our approach."

Momoko glanced at Mami. "You want to do the honors?"

Mami lifted her guns, expression solemn. "Yes. I'll end this."

She took aim at the witch's grief-armored chest.

But before she could fire—

A shimmering magic circle bloomed on the ground beside them.

Moons, planets, and constellations swirled within it like a living galaxy, growing brighter and brighter until the light condensed—

And Kuroe stepped out.

Momoko's face lit up. "Kuroe! You're here!"

Mifuyu's stance shifted, cautious. "You're in your Doppel form... Are you fully in control? Yesterday ___"

"I'm fine," Kuroe said, smiling gently. Calm. Confident. "That's what my training was for. I'm in complete control now."

Momoko grinned. "That's incredible! You've gotta teach us how to do that someday."

Mifuyu's shoulders relaxed, relief softening her features. "It would change everything for the girls in Kamihama."

Kuroe turned toward the towering knight. Her expression grew solemn as she took in the grieving armor, the dragging sword, the endless sorrow radiating from the witch.

"...Is that... Sayaka Miki's witch?"

Mami lowered her weapons. “Yes. Dream-Kyoko created this entire illusion—Sayaka as she is breaking. Our goal from the start was to reach her. To attune ourselves to her soul, to share her burden.”

Momoko let out a quiet sigh. “But when I shared my own story... my heartbreak... something in her snapped. She became a witch. And ever since, we haven’t been able to get through.”

Mifuyu finished softly, “We can defeat her easily. Saving her... that’s another matter entirely.”

Kuroe’s eyes widened.

A quiet, startling warmth bloomed in her chest as the pieces clicked into place.

This is why my training was separate.

This is why I had to master my Doppel.

This is why I learned I could speak to witches.

She was the missing piece.

For the first time in her life, Kuroe felt something fragile and radiant bloom inside her—not fear, not doubt, but purpose. She wasn’t used to being needed. She wasn’t used to being someone’s hope.

But right now, standing before these three veterans, she realized she was exactly that.

Kuroe looked at Mami, Momoko, and Mifuyu, her smile small, warm, and steady. Her dark wings unfurled slightly, catching the twilight hues of the illusionary sky.

“I know how to reach Sayaka.”

Her voice was quiet, but it carried the weight of newfound certainty.

“For the first time... I can actually help.”

Mami rushed forward, eyes bright with desperate hope.

“Is it true, Kuroe? Can you really reach Sayaka?”

Before Kuroe could answer, Oktavia’s massive sword came crashing down with a deafening roar. A storm of spinning wheels hurtled toward them like blades forged from pure grief.

Mami didn’t hesitate.

“Nastro Celeste—**Santuario!**”

Her ribbons erupted outward in a blaze of golden light, weaving themselves into a radiant dome around the four girls. The witch’s wheels slammed against the barrier and dissolved into glittering stardust. Oktavia’s sword struck next, sending deep ripples of moonlight across the surface, but the sanctuary held firm.

Inside the dome, the world transformed.

Kuroe’s breath caught.

Mami's evolved magic was breathtaking. Her ribbons shimmered with intricate lunar motifs—crescents, full moons, and every phase in between—glowing in a living palette of silver, soft gold, twilight blue, and rose pink. Tiny comet-orbs drifted between them, trailing elegant tails of light as they spiraled in graceful arcs. The air felt warm, sacred, and strangely peaceful.

Mami's guns had changed too. Some bore elegant crescent bayonets, others were ringed with chakram-like halos, and a few seemed woven from pure moonlight and constellations.

Momoko's twin blades glowed like paired moons—one waxing, one waning—while golden ribbons fluttered from their hilts like living banners.

Mifuyu's chakram hovered beside her, transformed into a versatile masterpiece of moonlight and shadow: petal-curved edges, humming barrel mechanisms, and soft-glowing ribbon emitters. Delicate ribbons bloomed from it like loyal extensions of her will.

Kuroe stared in open awe.

“So this... is what your magic looks like when you fully Connect,” she whispered. “It's beautiful.”

She reached out and brushed one of the drifting comet-orbs. It felt warm and almost playful against her fingertips.

Momoko grinned. “Hey, look at you! Those big black-and-purple wings dripping with shadow... You look like a total harbinger of doom!”

Mifuyu studied Kuroe carefully, then nodded. “I can sense the negative energy... but it's calm. Controlled. Nothing like the unstable Doppel forms we've seen before.”

Mami stepped closer, her expression earnest and full of quiet urgency.

“Kuroe... what exactly did you learn? How can we reach Sayaka?”

Kuroe took a steadying breath.

“A lot happened during my training. First... I met the six witches. In their human forms. With their real names.”

She listed them softly:

“Velmira — Kazehara Tamashii.

Ruinelle — Akari Suzume.

Catastrophia — Kaminari Shizuku.

Thornaria — Hakura Airi.

Noctulisse — Kageura Yume.

Vexaphra — Kisaragi Mio.”

Her voice grew quieter.

“And... I met the Advanced Witch. The Forgotten Queen.”

Mami's eyes widened. "You actually spoke with them in their human forms? Even the Forgotten Queen?"

Kuroe nodded. "The six witches can shift between their magical girl and witch forms at will. No corruption. No despair. They can even combine both powers freely."

Mami's breath hitched. "I never thought something like that was possible... If they can do it, then maybe Sayaka—"

"I think she can," Kuroe said gently. "As for the Forgotten Queen... she came to congratulate me after I mastered my Doppel. She didn't transform in front of me, so I don't know much about her."

Mifuyu leaned in, intrigued. "Did they teach you how to communicate with witches?"

"Yes," Kuroe answered. She smiled, a little bittersweet. "Because... I am a witch now."

She gestured to her right thigh.

No Soul Gem.

"The gem I woke up with this morning was fake," she explained. "The six witches broke it during training to show me the truth."

The other three girls froze.

Momoko whispered, stunned, "So Lunaria... didn't turn you back into a magical girl. She just pulled you out of despair."

Kuroe gave them a soft, reassuring smile. "And that's okay. Because now I can do this."

She spread her dark wings wide, wrapping the three girls in their shadow.

A gentle pulse of magic rippled outward.

Mami, Momoko, and Mifuyu gasped as a warm sensation bloomed on the sides of their necks. An intricate emblem formed like ink blooming in water: two elegant black feathered wings curving protectively around a pair of glowing purple batons. The mark shimmered with deep twilight hues.

Mami touched the emblem, eyes wide with wonder. "This... is a Witch's Kiss."

"But it doesn't feel evil," Mifuyu murmured, amazed. "No despair... only calm."

Momoko flexed her fingers, feeling new power thrumming through her veins. "Whoa... I can feel your magic mixing with mine. What did you do?"

Kuroe's smile was steady and bright.

"It's my Witch's Kiss. But because I'm in control, it's a blessing—not a curse. You now carry a portion of my power. You can use my Doppel abilities alongside your own."

The sanctuary shimmered with a faint purple tint.

Mami's guns glowed violet.

Mifuyu's chakram pulsed with shadow-light.

Momoko's blades gained a sharp, dark-purple edge.

"But most importantly," Kuroe said, her voice soft but full of quiet conviction, "you can now speak to witches. Even those who have completely lost themselves."

Mami's eyes shimmered with relief and gratitude. "So this is why Dream-Kyoko said your training was special... You were meant to help us save Sayaka."

Mifuyu smiled gently. "And perhaps why Lunaria waited until you became a witch before saving you. So that someone among us could do this."

Momoko let out a short laugh. "I wouldn't put it past those two. What insane foresight!"

Mami looked at each of them, determination burning in her golden eyes.

"Are we ready?"

Her ribbons fluttered like excited constellations.

Mifuyu nodded, chakram spinning gracefully beside her. "Ready."

Momoko twirled her blades with a grin. "Let's do this."

Kuroe stepped forward, her dark wings spreading wide, catching the light of Mami's sanctuary.

"Then let's see how this ability works."

The celestial barrier dissolved in a shower of sparkling light.

Oktavia roared, sword raised.

The orchestra swelled.

What had been a mournful lament twisted into a frantic, spiraling crescendo, as though Oktavia von Seckendorff could sense the presence of another witch within her labyrinth and recoiled in fury.

Then she *lashed out*.

Her massive sword cleaved through the air toward Kuroe, the impact shaking the entire illusionary labyrinth. The ground cracked like shattered glass beneath the force.

Kuroe launched upward in a burst of shadow-purple light, wings flaring wide as she twisted out of the blade's path. Oktavia's sword slammed into the floor, shattering tiles and sending shockwaves rippling outward.

Oktavia's hollow eyes snapped toward her, burning with murderous intent. Dozens of spinning wheels erupted from the shadows, converging from every direction—grief-forged buzzsaws screaming through the air.

Kuroe spread her wings.

“Let’s try this.”

A volley of heavy purple-shadow mud bullets erupted from her feathers, slamming into the wheels mid-flight. Each impact carried crushing weight, drenching the wheels in thick, sticky mud until they plummeted and crashed motionless to the ground.

Momoko’s jaw dropped.

“Holy— Kuroe, that was awesome!”

Mifuyu stared, stunned.

“I’ve never seen her fight like this...”

Oktavia swung again—a sweeping arc of sapphire flame. Kuroe dove straight towards it. Her wings sharpened into sleek, obsidian blades. She blocked the strike with one wing, then spun her entire body and slammed the second wing into the flat of the witch’s sword.

BOOM.

The impact rang out like a struck cathedral bell. Oktavia staggered, armor screeching in protest, and toppled sideways with a thunderous crash.

Kuroe landed lightly atop the witch’s helm.

“Okay... just like what Lunaria did,” she whispered.

She knelt and pressed her palm gently against the cold metal of Oktavia’s head.

And then—

Kuroe gasped.

Beneath the crushing layers of despair, something fragile flickered.

A soul.

Sayaka’s soul.

Not the mad laughter of a witch, but quiet, broken sobs.

“I don’t know what to do anymore...”

“Nothing matters...”

“I’m useless...”

“It would be better if I just disappeared...”

The raw anguish crashed over Kuroe like a tidal wave. For a moment she froze, overwhelmed by the sheer weight of Sayaka’s despair.

That single heartbeat of hesitation was all Oktavia needed.

The witch let out a blood-chilling, distorted scream. The orchestra music spiked into a furious, chaotic frenzy. Oktavia surged upright, hurling Kuroe violently into the air.

“Kuroe!” Mami shouted, panic cutting through her voice.

Kuroe snapped back to reality just in time to see Oktavia’s massive clawed hand closing around her.

She curled her wings inward, forming a protective cocoon. The witch’s grip clamped down, squeezing, trying to crush her.

Kuroe gritted her teeth. “Not... happening!”

Her wings exploded outward in a shockwave of shadow and purple light, shattering the witch’s grip. She broke free—just in time to see the massive sword already descending from the corner of her eye.

She crossed both wings in front of her—

CLANG!

The force sent her flying backward.

“Kuroe!” Mami, Momoko, and Mifuyu cried out in unison

Kuroe spun mid-air, wings flaring to kill her momentum. She came to a graceful stop, hovering, completely unharmed. Her body trembled—but not with fear.

A breathless, exhilarated laugh escaped her.

“I’m fine! Really! That was... actually kind of *fun*.”

She looked down at her hands, then at her powerful wings. The shaking was different now—alive with excitement instead of terror.

“I used to be so scared of fighting witches... I’d shake so badly I could barely hold my batons. But now? I want to see what else I can do.”

Mami, Momoko, and Mifuyu exchanged knowing smiles.

They knew that exact feeling—the intoxicating thrill of newfound power.

Mami stepped forward, voice gentle but urgent.

“Kuroe... when you touched her, you froze. What did you see?”

Kuroe’s expression softened, eyes distant.

“I felt her. Sayaka’s soul. It’s faint... buried so deep under all that despair... but it’s still there.”

The three girls inhaled sharply.

“She was crying,” Kuroe continued, voice trembling. “She said she doesn’t know what to do anymore. That nothing matters. That she’s useless... and that it would be better if she just faded away.”

Mami let out a shaky laugh—half relief, half heartbreak. “Sayaka... you stubborn girl. You’re still in there.”

Momoko grinned fiercely, blades igniting with renewed determination. “So all we have to do is make contact and talk to her, right?”

Momoko grinned fiercely, blades igniting with determination.

“So all we have to do is make contact with her witch form and talk to her, right?”

Mifuyu nodded, though her expression remained cautious. “We must be careful. When Kuroe reached out, Oktavia reacted violently. That scream, the sudden aggression... even the music changed. It’s almost like the witch is trying to protect Sayaka from being touched.”

Kuroe nodded. “I think you’re right. But we *can* reach her.”

The four girls turned as one toward the towering knight.

The orchestra surged into a thunderous, desperate symphony.

Oktavia rose to her full, imposing height. Armor trembling, sword dragging sparks across the broken ground. Her helm tilted toward them, and she unleashed another piercing scream that shook the labyrinth to its core.

Mami’s golden eyes sharpened with unyielding resolve.

“Contact, right? Then let’s make it happen.”

She thrust her arm forward.

Her celestial ribbons erupted outward in a brilliant cascade, streaking toward the towering witch like shooting stars. They wove through the air in elegant, spiraling arcs—beautiful, deadly.

Oktavia reacted instantly.

A storm of grief-forged wheels erupted from the churning shadows of the labyrinth, spinning toward the ribbons like vicious buzzsaws, their edges screaming with distorted orchestral fury.

But Mami’s ribbons did not falter.

They danced between the deadly projectiles with precision, snapping and twisting to bat the wheels aside in showers of golden sparks.

The witch roared—a sound like a symphony collapsing in on itself—and brought her massive sword crashing down. The blade severed several ribbons in one brutal swing.

But the cut strands did not vanish.

They dissolved into dozens of glowing orbs: tiny luminous moons and comet-tailed lights that spiraled through the air, painting the darkness with soft radiance.

Momoko grinned fiercely, excitement crackling through her like electricity.
“Our turn!”

Mifuyu nodded, eyes glowing with quiet, razor-sharp focus.

The comet-orbs shot forward first, circling the massive witch in dizzying spirals. From their blazing tails, beams of pure, searing light erupted, slamming into Oktavia’s armor. Each blade pulsed with Momoko’s Encouragement magic—warm, sincere, and stubbornly unyielding, like a cheerful pep talk given physical form.

At the same moment, the lunar orbs brightened to a silvery glow. Elegant chakrams of moonlight manifested from them, wrapping around Oktavia’s limbs, waist, and sword arm. They hummed with Mifuyu’s illusion magic—softening despair, easing pain, whispering comfort into the cracks of Sayaka’s breaking heart.

Mami’s remaining ribbons surged forward, layering over the bindings until Oktavia was almost completely immobilized—a prisoner of light and will.

The witch thrashed wildly.

Her armor screeched in protest.

The orchestra shrieked in dissonant agony, the music fracturing into something painful and wrong.

Then the purple glow began.

It started with Mami’s ribbons.

Then Momoko’s twin blades.

Then Mifuyu’s glowing chakrams.

The beams of light lodged in Oktavia’s armor.

All of them shimmered with soft, ethereal violet—Kuroe’s power flowing through the connection.

The Witch’s Kiss emblems on each girl’s neck pulsed in perfect, synchronized rhythm.

And suddenly...

They felt her.

A faint, trembling heartbeat.

A fragile, flickering soul.

Sayaka’s soul—raw, exposed, no longer completely drowned beneath layers of crushing despair or lost behind the mad laughter of a witch.

Mami inhaled sharply, her chest tightening.

“Sayaka... are you there?”

Silence answered at first—heavy, suffocating.

Then—

A soft, broken sob echoed through the magical connection, fragile as a dying flame.

Mami's eyes filled with tears.

"Sayaka... it's me. Mami. Can you hear me?"

Oktavia convulsed violently, the sword arm straining so hard it began to fracture.

Kuroe stepped forward immediately, wings spreading protectively.

"Keep talking to her, Mami. I'll watch her."

A weak, confused voice filtered through—trembling, distant, like someone calling from the bottom of a well.

"Who... who's there...? What voice...?"

Mami staggered back a half-step, stunned. Hearing Sayaka's real voice—so small, so lost—hit her like a physical blow.

Mifuyu covered her mouth, eyes wide.

"No way..."

Momoko clenched her fists, barely containing her joy.

"We did it! We actually reached her!"

Mami forced her voice to soften, pouring every ounce of warmth into it.

"It's me, Sayaka. Mami Tomoe. Do you remember? Our tea parties... the witch hunts I dragged you and Madoka on? You always complained the sweets were too fancy, but you still ate three plates every time."

A long, fragile pause.

"...Mami...?"

Sayaka repeated the name slowly, hesitantly, as if tasting something half-forgotten and painfully sweet.

"...Mami... we were... together..."

Mami's breath caught in her throat. Hope bloomed in her chest—bright, painful, and desperately fragile. Sayaka was remembering. She was still in there.

And then—

A completely different voice cut through the connection, bright, teasing, and utterly out of place:

"Wait—did Sayaka actually say that about your sweets? I'm giving her a piece of my mind later."

Dream-Kyoko.

Mami's eyes flew wide.

Momoko's mouth dropped.

Mifuyu blinked rapidly.

Kuroe's wings drooped in pure confusion.

CRACK.

The entire labyrinth shattered like glass.

Shards of distorted reality exploded outward, and a blinding white light swallowed everything.

When the brilliance faded, the four girls stood in a vast, endless garden breathing with quiet magic.

Lush velvet grass stretched in every direction, soft enough to brush gently against their boots.

Translucent fruits hung from glowing vines, shifting colors like oil on water. Lantern-like blossoms floated lazily through the air, casting a warm golden radiance. Shimmering moss pulsed faintly beneath their feet, and elegant pillars wrapped in flowering ivy rose throughout the garden, each one glowing with a slow, steady heartbeat of light.

Grass rustled behind them.

They turned.

Dream-Kyoko strolled toward them casually, chewing on a star-shaped fruit glowing like a tiny nebula. She waved lazily, juice sparkling on her fingers.

“That’s enough for today. You all pass~”

The four girls stared, dumbfounded.

Mami found her voice first.

“Kyoko—what in the world?! Why stop right at the climax!”

Momoko threw her hands up.

“We were so close! We finally reached her and then—boom! Training over?!”

Dream-Kyoko laughed lightly, taking another juicy bite of the glowing fruit. A trail of sparkling nectar ran down her chin as she grinned.

“The point wasn’t to beat Oktavia or finish the rescue inside some illusion,” she said, licking her fingers with casual satisfaction. “It was to give you everything you need to save the real Sayaka. Illusions can only simulate so much. The real thing is gonna be messier, scarier... you’ll have to improvise like hell.”

The girls exchanged glances—frustration melting into reluctant understanding—then burst into relieved laughter.

Mami bowed her head slightly, her voice full of genuine gratitude. “Thank you, Kyoko. We learned far more than I ever expected from this.”

Dream-Kyoko grinned, tossing the fruit core over her shoulder where it dissolved into sparkles.

“Good. Because Lunaria and Kasumi already filled me in on Sayaka’s situation.”

Mami’s eyes widened.

“So you *do* know what happened to her?”

“Yep,” Dream-Kyoko said, turning on her heel and waving for them to follow. “But first—let’s eat! I’m starving.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe chuckled.

Mami groaned, shaking her head with fond exasperation.

“Kyoko... can’t you tell us something important before thinking about food?”

Dream-Kyoko glanced back with that signature playful smirk.

“Relax. We can talk while we eat. You’ve got a ton of questions, right? Besides, the food at the coliseum is amazing. Perfect for recovery.”

Mami sighed, but a warm smile tugged at her lips.

“Fine. Lead the way.”

Dream-Kyoko snapped her fingers.

Familiar magic circles bloomed beneath their feet, shimmering with the same ethereal light that had carried them across the coliseum before.

Warm, gentle light engulfed them all and they vanished.

Chapter 9b: Nighttime fun

The five of them sat upon a wide, open terrace suspended high above the coliseum grounds — a floating platform shaped like an enormous, softly glowing flower petal drifting lazily in the warm twilight breeze. Far below, the dream-realm coliseum shimmered like a distant jewel, its lights pulsing gently like a heartbeat.

A massive flower pod, plush and cushioned like a living sofa, cradled Mami, Momoko, Mifuyu, Kuroe, and Dream-Kyoko. Its velvety petals adjusted subtly to each girl’s posture, warm and comforting, like a gentle embrace.

Dozens of small plates, bowls, and delicate cups floated around them at the perfect height, drifting like tiny, obedient satellites.

There was noodle soup whose color, temperature, and flavor shifted to match whatever the diner desired in that moment. Tempura and dumplings came in every imaginable shape and hue — each bite a delightful surprise. Rainbow tea, a gentle blend of countless subtle flavors, carried a soothing warmth that eased the soul itself. Even the utensils floated gracefully, adjusting their height and angle so no one had to lift a finger unless they wished to.

Above them, the twilight sky rippled like water.

Then the projection began.

The sky unfurled into a vast, living tapestry of memory and light.

They watched as Lunaria and Kasumi's day unfolded across the vast canvas of the sky, like a living tapestry woven from memory and light.

First came Kamihama City.

Lunaria and Kasumi meeting Iroha, Yachiyo, and Mitama.

The five of them Connecting with the small, strange Kyubey.

Ui appearing — fragile, luminous, heartbreakingly gentle.

Ui sharing her story: how she, Nemu, and Touka had learned the cruel truth of magical girls... the desperate wishes they had made to save them... how everything had spiraled horribly out of control... how Ui herself had become a witch... and how her soul now resided within that tiny, innocent-looking Kyubey.

The projection shifted seamlessly.

Now it showed Mitakihara City.

Homura and Madoka hurrying towards Sayaka.

The unexpected encounter with Lunaria and Kasumi along the way.

The brief flash of genuine surprise on Homura's face — the first time Mami had ever seen Homura look truly caught off guard.

Then the horrifying moment of Sayaka's transformation: the raw grief, the overwhelming despair, the crushing helplessness as Oktavia von Seckendorff was born.

They watched Homura stop time itself.

They watched Madoka break.

They watched Kyoko's face twist in horror.

They watched Homura's quiet, brittle resolve as she offered genuine sorrow and comfort to both Madoka and Kyoko before the three of them finally walked away from the newly born witch, hearts heavy with grief that would not soon fade.

When the projection faded, the sky returned to its gentle twilight hues.

Silence settled over the floating terrace — deep, contemplative, almost sacred.

Except for Dream-Kyoko, who was loudly slurping noodles, the glowing broth leaving faint sparkling trails as she inhaled it with unrestrained gusto.

The contrast was almost comedic.

Momoko was the first to speak, her voice soft with awe.

“...Wow. That’s... a lot to take in. Lunaria and Kasumi really did a lot today.”

Mifuyu nodded slowly, eyes still fixed on the empty sky.

“And that doesn’t even include yesterday — infiltrating the Magius headquarters, Kuroe becoming a witch, the APS breaking down, the doppelified magical girls going berserk...”

Kuroe hugged her knees, staring at the fading afterimages.

“Are all their adventures like this...? I wonder what they’ve seen. What they’ve lived through.”

Mami exhaled softly, her poise tinged with quiet melancholy.

“It’s no wonder they know so much about magical girls and witches. They must have experienced tragedies like this countless times.”

Dream-Kyoko lifted her bowl and drank the remaining glowing broth straight from it, sighing in satisfaction. She slammed the empty bowl down onto a floating plate with a cheerful clack and immediately reached for a large, spiky piece of tempura.

“Oh! That’s a flavor I’ve never had before!” she exclaimed brightly as she bit into it, eyes lighting up.

“So,” she continued between enthusiastic crunches, “what do you think? Gonna change your plan after seeing all that?”

Mami, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe exchanged glances — and nodded.

“No,” Mami replied. “Our plan to save Sayaka remains the same. What we practiced today should still work — we’ll simply have to adapt in the moment, just like you said.”

She lifted her gaze back to the sky where the projection had played.

“But what stood out to me most... was Homura.”

Dream-Kyoko grinned. “Homura huh?”

Mami nodded slowly.

“Homura looked like she knew Lunaria and Kasumi personally. She trusted them. Deeply. Enough to ask for their help without hesitation. That’s... very unlike the Homura I know.”

Mami’s eyes narrowed slightly, a flicker of unease crossing her face.

“And then there’s her ability... stopping time for anything not touching her. I’ve never seen anything like it.”

She continued carefully, piecing her thoughts together.

“What if Homura doesn’t just stop time? What if she can see across it? Visions... simulations... futures... endless possibilities.”

Mifuyu’s eyes widened.

“That... would explain everything. Her coldness. Her distance. If she’s witnessed countless tragedies... countless failures...”

Momoko shivered visibly, hugging herself.

“And she hasn’t become a witch yet? That’s insane. What in the world did Homura wish for...?”

Kuroe raised her hand timidly, voice gentle.

“But... there must be limits, right? She looked genuinely surprised when she saw Lunaria and Kasumi. If she could truly see across time, she would’ve known they’d be there.”

She let out a soft, rueful laugh.

“Then again... Lunaria and Kasumi are complete enigmas. And it didn’t look like Homura’s time stop affected them at all.”

Mifuyu nodded in agreement.

“So many mysteries...”

All four girls turned their eyes toward Dream-Kyoko.

The red-haired girl popped a puffy dumpling into her mouth, chewing contentedly before swallowing.

“Hey, why are you all looking at me like that? I barely know anything about Lunaria and Kasumi either.”

The girls burst into tired but genuine laughter together comforted by one another’s presence.

The floating plates drifted closer, silently offering seconds of the ever-changing delicacies.

Mifuyu lifted her bowl with practiced grace, watching the shimmering broth swirl like a captured nebula. When she took a sip, the flavor shifted into something impossible to define — a nostalgic blend of the meals she and Yachiyo used to cook together. She exhaled, a small cloud of silver mist escaping her lips.

“What we saw about the Wings of the Magius...” she murmured, voice soft and contemplative. “It was... interesting. And heartbreaking.”

Momoko reached for a piece of tempura shaped like a flickering flame. It crackled with heat, smelling faintly of summer festivals and woodsmoke. She bit into it, savoring the crisp crackle before speaking.

“It’s wild to think all of that — the Wings of the Magius, the APS, the whole Doppel system — started with three girls. Ui, Touka, and Nemu. Just kids trying to save someone they loved.”

Kuroe picked up a diamond-shaped dumpling, its translucent surface shimmering with soft violet light. She bit into it, and a gentle sweetness bloomed across her tongue.

“That’s what makes it unbearable,” she whispered. “Knowing how lonely Ui must have been... trapped in the small Kyubey, unable to speak to anyone, while the world simply moved on. And Nemu carrying that secret alone... it’s a wonder they didn’t break sooner.”

Momoko looked up at the sky where the projection had been moments ago, her expression tightening.

“And their big plan is in two days...” she said quietly. “Mitama herself said she doesn’t know if it’ll work. After everything that went wrong yesterday — our ‘deaths,’ the APS breaking, the doppelified girls going berserk — I can’t help but feel uneasy.”

Mifuyu traced the rim of her Soul Gem. It felt heavier than usual, a reminder of the crushing negativity she felt yesterday while saving the doppelified magical girls.

“I don’t want to imagine what could happen if the plan fails,” she said. “If yesterday was just a preview... there could be so many more sacrifices. So many more deaths.”

Mami set her cup of rainbow tea on a floating saucer, watching the colors swirl gently inside it. She could see the worry etched into Momoko’s, Mifuyu’s, and Kuroe’s faces — the same worry she carried for her own friends in Mitakihara.

“I think things will be alright,” she said softly. “Yachiyo, Iroha, Mitama, Ui... they’re all working together. They’re preparing.”

The three girls looked at her.

Mami smiled — warm, steady, hopeful.

“And I want to help too. You’ve all been so kind to me. You helped me without hesitation, even though we’d just met. I want to return that kindness.”

She looked at each of them in turn, her voice gentle.

“And we’ve all grown so much today. Who knows what we’ll be capable of two days from now.”

Dream-Kyoko let out a sharp, jagged laugh as she crunched on a piece of spiral tempura.

“That’s the spirit! Though honestly? You guys should worry less about the Magius and more about the heart attacks you’re gonna cause.”

She leaned forward, smirking.

“Think about it. Everyone in Mitakihara saw Mami bite it. Everyone in Kamihama saw you three dead. You’re going to walk back into the world like a bunch of undead in magical girl outfits. It’s gonna be one hell of a reunion.”

The tension snapped, replaced by a sudden, hysterical wave of laughter.

“I can already hear it,” Mami giggled, pressing a hand to her burning cheek. “Sayaka will start apologizing nonstop for becoming a witch and needing me to save her. And Madoka... Madoka will probably tackle me so hard we’ll both end up in the hospital.”

Her eyes softened, a wistful light touching her face.

“As for Kyoko... the real Kyoko... she seemed different in the projection. Softer. Trying to help Sayaka. I hope she’ll show me that side too. I hope we can be friends again... like before everything went wrong.”

She hesitated.

“And Homura... we never got along. But now that I understand her better... now that I’ve seen how much she cares... I want to start over. I want to be her friend too.”

Kuroe hugged her knees again, voice gentle.

“I can see Iroha hugging me so tightly I can’t breathe,” she said with a shy smile. “Making me promise never to leave her behind again. And I... I want to get closer to everyone at Mikazuki Villa. Yachiyo, Tsuruno, Sana, Felicia... all of them.”

Mifuyu let out a soft, wistful chuckle.

“Yachiyo and I reconciled before I ‘died.’ And she’s finally starting to open up to others after learning the truth about her power. She’ll be shocked to see me again — but for once, it’ll be a happy shock.”

Momoko grinned.

“Oh, totally. I can already picture her face.”

Then her expression softened.

“I want to see Rena and Kaede again. Kaede will probably break down apologizing for becoming a doppelified magical girl... thinking it’s her fault I died. I hope those two aren’t arguing while I’ve been gone.”

Then Momoko froze, a glowing shrimp tempura halfway to her mouth.

“...Wait. Our bodies. They’re still down there, aren’t they?”

Mifuyu blinked — then laughed nervously.

“Yes. I suppose we’ll have to... prepare ourselves for that.”

Momoko buried her face in her hands, wailing dramatically.

“Oh, god! I don’t want to see my own corpse! That is so gross!”

The absurdity of it — the sheer, dark comedy of being a magical girl — sent them into another fit of laughter. It was the kind of laughter that healed, washing away the grime of the battlefield.

Dream-Kyoko stretched, her joints popping like tiny firecrackers.

“Alright, alright, enough of the existential dread and corpse-talk.”

She stood, red hair whipping in the wind, eyes sparkling with mischief.

“Who’s ready for that magical onsen?!”

The shift in energy was instantaneous.

“Yes!”

“Absolutely!”

“Let’s go!”

“I’ve been waiting for this!”

“Then move it!” Kyoko shouted, leaping off the flower pod and soaring into the twilight sky. “Last one there pays for the post-bath milk!”

The four girls took flight, their magic trailing behind them like streaks of neon light against the darkening horizon.

The onsen nestled in a wide basin of polished moonstone, its waters glowing with a soft, pearlescent light that seemed to breathe in time with the night. Above them stretched an impossible sky — an endless velvet ocean of stars where constellations drifted like slow schools of silver fish, and nebulae unfurled in delicate spirals of rose, indigo, and gold. Galaxies turned lazily overhead, so close it felt as though the girls could reach up and trail their fingers through cosmic dust.

The surface of the hot spring mirrored every shimmer perfectly, turning the pool into a liquid galaxy. Bathing here felt less like soaking in water and more like floating among the heavens themselves.

Around the spring, the dream-realm forest hummed with gentle life. Luminescent moss carpeted the stones in waves of teal and emerald. Bioluminescent vines draped from crystalline branches, swaying like living strands of starlight in the warm breeze. Soft chirps, melodic trills, and distant, echoing calls drifted from deeper in the woods — the voices of creatures who wandered the dream-realm freely.

And in the water, the animals had made themselves at home.

Silver-dusted otters floated on their backs with blissful, half-lidded eyes. Round, golden-furred capybaras lounged half-submerged, humming contentedly. Ducks and geese with feathers swirling in impossible pastel hues paddled lazily, while sleek seals glowed faintly as they glided through the deeper sections. Ravens whose black plumage shimmered with pinpricks of starlight perched on warm rocks, and slender water snakes with scales that shifted like phases of the moon wove playful patterns beneath the surface. Luminous koi trailed ribbons of soft light as they circled gracefully. Even a pair of gentle foxes with star-tipped tails and a luminous deer with antlers like branching constellations had wandered close, watching the girls with calm curiosity.

Dream-Kyoko sank deeper into the water until only her head remained above the surface, a lazy, utterly satisfied grin spreading across her face.

“After the food,” she declared, voice thick with bliss, “this is the single best thing the dream-realm has ever created.”

A small flock of colorful ducks immediately swam over, quacking softly as they nuzzled against her arms. One particularly bold goose climbed onto her shoulder and puffed up proudly, as if declaring Kyoko its personal territory.

Momoko, floating nearby, wore an identical expression of pure relaxation — eyes half-closed, mouth curved in a dreamy smile. Two otters had claimed her hands, holding them like they were all participating in some synchronized relaxation ritual. A plump capybara leaned against her side, its contented humming vibrating gently through the water.

“Tell me about it...” Momoko sighed. “I could close my eyes right now and sleep for a week. Maybe a month. Someone wake me up after Sayaka is saved.”

Mami and Mifuyu exchanged an amused glance from across the spring, both failing to suppress soft laughter at the sight of their companions — and their animal entourage — looking equally blissed-out.

Mifuyu leaned back against a smooth, warmed stone, letting the water lap gently at her collarbones. She took a slow, deep breath, her lashes fluttering shut.

“My whole body feels... light,” she murmured. “Like every knot of tension just melted away into the steam. I can’t wait to see what my skin feels like after this. Maybe I’ll finally look as refreshed as I feel.”

As if summoned by her gentle voice, a trio of glowing seals drifted closer. They nudged her hands with cool, whiskered noses until Mifuyu giggled — a light, airy sound that sparkled in the air — and began stroking their sleek heads.

Mami sat a little apart, though not distant. Her long golden hair floated around her like a halo of sunlight in the pearlescent water. Slender water snakes coiled playfully up her arms, their moon-phase scales glinting as they draped themselves across her shoulders like living ribbons. She laughed warmly, the sound bright and fond.

“They really do remind me of my magic,” she said softly, watching one snake flick its tongue against her cheek. “All delicate, but surprisingly strong. ...It’s strange. Just moments ago we were fighting so desperately, pushing ourselves to reach Sayaka. Now it feels like that was a lifetime ago.”

Kuroe floated peacefully on her back, her body perfectly still except for the gentle rise and fall of her breathing. Only her face broke the surface, her dark hair fanning out like spilled ink across the glowing pool. Two ravens had claimed her shoulders, their starry feathers brushing her cheeks, while a third perched regally atop her head like a tiny, feathered crown.

She gazed up at the drifting galaxies above, her voice quiet and full of awe.

“The night here is so beautiful... You can see so many stars. So many lights. It makes me want to make a wish...”

Dream-Kyoko cracked one eye open, a familiar mischievous glint cutting through her relaxed expression.

“Oh? Speaking of wishes...” She stretched lazily, sending slow ripples across the spring. “We’ve been training hard together all day. Might as well get to know each other a little more. Why don’t we share them? Our original wishes, I mean.”

The others exchanged quick, curious glances. Small smiles bloomed, and one by one they nodded.

Kyoko took a slow breath, her gaze drifting upward to the star-filled sky. When she spoke, her usual sharp energy softened into something quieter, almost tender.

“My dad was a preacher,” she began. “Back then, the church was full. People came to listen. Life felt... happy.”

Her voice stayed steady, but the water around her glowed a little brighter, as if the dream-realm itself leaned in to listen.

“But he started questioning things. Preaching ideas that didn’t match the old doctrine. He was excommunicated, and the congregation disappeared.”

She inhaled slowly.

“I got so angry. His words made sense to me. I wished that everyone who heard him would really listen — that they’d believe in what he was saying. Because no one came to our church, we were starving.”

Her eyes softened.

“So I made my wish. And it worked. People came back. Dad was happy. My family was happy. Life was good again.”

She closed her eyes.

“And that was when I was saved in this dream-realm. It was a happy ending.”

She paused, her expression tightening, not with fresh pain but with the careful weight of something she had learned to carry.

“Later... I saw what happened to my real self on Earth after I was saved. Dad found out the truth — that the followers only came back because of my wish. He broke. He... killed my mom, my little sister, and then himself. Only the real me survived.”

The onsen grew still. Even the animals quieted.

Kyoko’s expression softened — not with fresh grief, but with a distant, gentle empathy for the girl she once was.

“After that, my real self shut everyone out. She decided to live only for herself. She cut ties with Mami. She became... someone colder. Harder.”

She grit her teeth and clenched her fists, her voice tinged with anger.

“When I saw all of that through the Connection, I got so mad I told Mami I’d knock some sense into her if we ever met again.”

Momoko and Mifuyu nodded with quiet understanding.

“We felt it too, when we Connected with Mami,” Mifuyu said softly. “The loneliness... the pain of that sudden break. It reminded us so much of Yachiyo.”

“But yesterday,” Momoko added, “Yachiyo finally started opening up again. She learned the real nature of her power and let herself trust others. We’re really glad for her.”

Mifuyu smiled toward Kyoko. “We hope the same can happen for your real self, too.”

Kyoko flashed a wide, sharp grin — playful and stubborn.

“Heh. I’m ridiculously stubborn, so I doubt she’ll change that easily. Buuuut...” She tilted her head, eyes sparkling. “She does look like she’s starting to soften up a little lately. So maybe I won’t have to punch her too hard.”

Laughter rippled across the glowing water — bright, warm, and relieved. It echoed softly against the stones and vines, mingling with the distant calls of dream-realm creatures and the gentle splash of animals drifting closer, as if they too wanted to join in the easy joy of the moment.

The warm water rippled gently around Kuroe as she floated on her back, her body half-submerged, only her face and the slow rise and fall of her breathing breaking the surface. Two ravens perched quietly on her shoulders, their dark feathers dusted with pinpricks of starlight, eyes half-lidded in patient silence. Steam curled lazily through the air like a soft veil, carrying the faint scent of minerals and cherry blossoms from the dream-realm’s onsen.

For a long moment, she simply breathed, letting the heat seep into her bones, letting the galaxies above drift slowly across her vision like a lullaby written in light. Then, in a voice so soft it almost blended with the steam, she spoke.

“I suppose... it’s my turn.”

The words hung delicately in the air, fragile as dew on a spider’s web. Kuroe’s gaze drifted upward toward the endless star-sea sky, her eyes reflecting its faint glow.

“For most of my life, I didn’t really know who I was,” she began slowly. “I was always anxious... always second-guessing myself. Every choice felt terrifying because I was convinced that no matter what I did, no one would truly understand me. I felt like I was drifting through the world, invisible to everyone around me.”

The water beneath her glowed faintly, as though echoing the quiet ache in her chest.

“Then I met a boy who... changed that. He listened to me. He praised the things I said. For the first time, someone made me feel seen. Like I wasn’t just background noise in someone else’s life.”

A faint, wistful smile touched her lips.

“Kyubey kept appearing, asking me what I wished for. And I had no answer for the longest time. But eventually... I started wondering if being close to someone — if letting myself love and be loved — might help me finally figure out who I was supposed to be. So... I wished to go out with the person I liked.”

Momoko’s expression softened with quiet understanding, but she didn’t speak. None of them did. They simply listened, letting Kuroe’s voice fill the warm, star-lit air.

“At first, it was wonderful,” Kuroe continued, her voice barely more than a whisper. “We talked every day. I felt like I finally belonged somewhere. He made my troubles feel smaller. For a little while, I even started to believe I could become someone stronger... someone who could help others, like the heroes in the movies we watched together.”

Her smile grew tender for a moment — then dimmed, as though a cloud had passed over the moon.

“But then the fighting started. I was so weak. Every witch battle terrified me. I watched people die... and I couldn’t stop it. The horror of it all crushed me. At night I would pray for a peaceful life where I didn’t have to fight anymore — where I wouldn’t have to see anyone else suffer.”

The surface of the water trembled faintly, disturbed not by movement, but by the weight of memory itself.

“The guilt became unbearable. I lost all confidence in myself. Even when my boyfriend tried to support me, I pushed him away. I convinced myself that no one could possibly understand what I was going through. So... I broke up with him.”

A small, rueful laugh escaped her — fragile, self-deprecating, but honest.

“I feel terrible about it now. He was trying so hard... and I hurt him anyway. I think, in a way, he must have felt something close to what Sayaka felt. That kind of deep, helpless heartbreak.”

Kuroe closed her eyes, letting the warm water cradle her like a gentle embrace.

“One day, I sensed a witch near the train station. When I entered the labyrinth, I found another magical girl — a girl in a white hood named Kuro. She was even more inexperienced and frightened than I was. I managed to save her... but the witch escaped. And when she asked me if I had a Grief Seed to spare...”

Her voice cracked — just barely, but enough to make the ravens on her shoulders shift, feathers rustling softly as though mourning with her.

“I lied. I told her I didn’t have one. Then I left her there.”

The onsen grew profoundly still. Even the steam seemed to pause its lazy dance.

“That moment haunted me constantly. I kept imagining that she must have died because of me. My doppel used that memory like a blade, cutting me open again and again. It was one of the heaviest regrets that finally broke me... and turned me into a witch just yesterday.”

Kuroe drew in a slow, shaky breath, the steam brushing against her lips like a gentle caress.

“During today’s training... my doppel dragged every failure, every selfish choice, every moment of weakness into the light. I broke down so many times. I lost control over and over.”

Then — slowly, shyly — a different kind of smile bloomed across her face. Small, but genuine. Peaceful.

“But at the very end... I chose to accept it all. The scared girl who ran away. The selfish girl who lied. The weak girl who failed. All of me. And when I stopped fighting against those parts... something inside me finally settled. My doppel panicked. For the first time, I wasn’t the one losing control — she was.”

Kuroe lifted one hand from the water. Droplets slid down her fingers like liquid starlight, sparkling faintly before falling back into the onsen.

“That’s how I can control my doppel form now. I’m not at war with myself anymore.”

A bright, delighted laugh broke the heavy silence — Momoko’s voice ringing out with her usual warmth.

“So it’s really that simple huh? Just... accept yourself? I need to try that with my doppel sometime!”

Mifuyu smiled too, her eyes shimmering with quiet admiration.

“If we can bring that realization back to Kamihama... if magical girls can learn to accept their doppels instead of fearing them... it really could change everything.”

Momoko winked, splashing her lightly.

“For sure. It’ll make Mitama’s job way easier. I wonder how many Grief Seeds she’d give us for that...”

Momoko let out a soft, contented sigh as she stretched her arms upward in a slow, languid arc. Warm water cascaded down her skin in glistening trails, sending gentle ripples across the onsen’s surface that caught the light of distant galaxies overhead. A pair of otters floated lazily beside her, their luminous eyes blinking sleepily before they nestled closer against her side with small, trusting murmurs. One rested its head on her shoulder like a drowsy child; the other held her hand with its tiny paws.

Steam rose in delicate spirals, wrapping around the girls like a living veil. The air smelled faintly of minerals and starlight, soothing, as though the dream-realm itself was exhaling with them.

After a quiet moment, Momoko smiled — the kind of steady, reassuring smile that came so naturally to her.

“I suppose it’s my turn,” she said gently, her voice carrying that dependable warmth that always made others feel safe.

She leaned back against the smooth, heated stone edge of the pool, letting the water lap at her collarbones. The otters mirrored her posture, floating on their backs with blissful little sighs.

“I’m the middle child of three. Older brother, younger brother... and me stuck right in the middle.” A soft laugh bubbled up from her chest, light and self-deprecating.

“I picked up a lot from both of them. Their roughhousing, their loud voices, the way they’d wrestle over the last piece of meat at dinner. I never really minded it. Honestly, it was fun. But... it made me wonder sometimes if I was too boyish. Not soft enough. Not delicate or feminine in the way girls are supposed to be.”

Her fingers trailed idly through the water, drawing slow, glowing patterns that shimmered for a moment before fading into the ripples.

“There was a boy I liked. A lot. The kind of crush that made my chest hurt every time I saw him.” She paused, a wistful little smile touching her lips.

“I wanted to confess so badly, but every time I tried, my heart would start pounding so hard I thought it would burst. I kept freezing up, convinced he’d laugh at me... or worse, that he’d think I was weird.”

Her gaze drifted upward toward the swirling constellations above them, the stars reflected in her eyes like tiny lanterns

“Then Kyubey appeared. He asked if I had a wish. And without thinking too deeply, I told him... I wished for courage. Just enough courage to tell that boy how I felt.”

The water around her glowed faintly in response, reflecting the quiet ache beneath her gentle tone.

“When I finally gathered that courage and went to find him... he was already being confessed to. By another girl.”

A small, breathy laugh escaped her — not bitter, but softened by time, like an old wound that had healed into a pale scar.

“I stood there watching, feeling like the biggest fool in the world. I’d used my one miracle on something that didn’t even matter in the end. I didn’t know whether to laugh or cry, so I did both right there on the sidewalk.”

One of the otters nudged her arm sympathetically. Momoko stroked its damp fur with a grateful smile, her eyes softening.

“I told part of that story to Sayaka earlier today during training. I wanted her to know she wasn’t alone... that I became a magical girl because of a boy too. That she wasn’t the only one who experienced heartbreak.”

She turned her head toward Dream-Kyoko, eyes narrowing in playful accusation.

“But her response was so harsh! ‘You’re stuck with the same fate as me.’ ‘You’ll never find love again.’ ‘You’re just a husk with a rock for a soul.’ Seriously, Kyoko? Did you have to go that hard?”

Dream-Kyoko grinned, stretching her arms behind her head as a duck waddled onto her knee and puffed out its chest proudly, mirroring her sass.

“Hey, I was channeling Sayaka as best I could. I used my illusion magic to really feel what she’s feeling right now. And yeah... that’s one way she’d bite back in that state.”

Momoko puffed her cheeks out for a second, then dissolved into quiet laughter, warm and forgiving.

“Okay, fine. That’s fair. But still... ouch.”

Dream-Kyoko shrugged lightly, though her crimson eyes softened.

“For what it’s worth, I think you’ll find someone someday. You’ve got that easy, warm, older-sister energy. The kind that makes people feel safe. A lot of guys would be lucky to have that.”

Momoko blinked, caught completely off guard. A delicate blush bloomed across her cheeks, visible even in the soft starlit glow of the onsen.

“W-wow... I wasn’t expecting you to say something like that.”

She giggled shyly, raising both hands to cover her warming face.

“Thank you, Kyoko. I... I hope so too.”

A comfortable silence settled for a moment, broken only by the gentle lapping of water and the soft breathing of the creatures around them. The night sky shimmered above, galaxies drifting like slow-moving lanterns.

Mami, who had been listening with a quiet, gentle smile, tilted her head slightly.

“Kyoko... how did you manage all of that today? The illusion of Mitakihara Park, mimicking Sayaka... it felt so real. Almost too real.”

Dream-Kyoko smirked, flicking a droplet of water into the air where it burst into a tiny shower of sparkling light.

“Lots of practice with magical control. Lunaria wasn’t kidding when she said our abilities could evolve once you get better at it.”

She leaned forward, eyes gleaming with that familiar mischievous spark.

“But I also cheated a little. Did you notice the pillars in the garden? The ones that glowed and resonated with my Soul Gem?”

Mifuyu nodded immediately, her voice soft but eager.

“They pulsed in perfect sync with your magic. It was beautiful.”

“Exactly,” Dream-Kyoko said, snapping her fingers. “Those are called lullprisms. They amplify illusion magic like crazy. I didn’t strictly need them, but I wanted the training to hit as hard as possible. Full immersion.”

Mami’s eyes widened slightly, a mix of disbelief and amusement crossing her face.

“So that’s why you dragged us to that garden for training? I thought you just wanted to eat the glowing fruit there.”

Dream-Kyoko threw her head back and laughed, bright and unashamed.

“That was definitely one of the reasons!”

She turned toward Mifuyu, her expression softening into genuine encouragement.

“You use illusion magic too, right? You should try the lullprisms sometime. There are plenty of places in the dream-realm with them. I think you’d get a lot out of it.”

Mifuyu’s eyes lit up with quiet excitement, a small but sincere smile forming on her lips.

“I’d really like that. I want to see how far I can take my magic here.”

Dream-Kyoko glanced around at all of them — Mami, Momoko, Mifuyu, and finally letting her gaze rest warmly on Kuroe.

“And trust me... the dream-realm is full of magical curiosities like that. You’ll all get your chance to play with them soon enough.”

Mifuyu leaned back against the smooth, heated stone of the onsen, letting the magically warm water lap gently at her collarbone. Steam curled around the group like a living thing, carrying the sweet scent of cherry blossoms and glowing moss that drifted down from the vines overhead. For a long moment she simply breathed, eyes closed, gathering herself.

Then she exhaled, long and quiet, and opened her eyes.

“I suppose... I’ll go next,” Mifuyu said softly. Her voice was gentle, but there was a quiet tremor beneath it.

She opened her eyes and gazed up at the dream-realm sky, where galaxies spiraled slowly like living lanterns and stars drifted in lazy, tidal waves. Their light shimmered across the surface of the water and danced across her skin.

“I come from an old, established family in Kamihama’s Mizuna Ward,” she began. “A family full of rules. Expectations. Traditions that had been carved in stone long before I was born. Almost every part of my life was decided for me—what I wore, how I spoke, who I was allowed to spend time with. I never had any freedom. I only knew how to obey.”

The water around her glowed faintly, as if responding to the quiet ache in her voice.

“When Kyubey appeared and offered me a contract... deep down, I wanted freedom more than anything. I wanted to live a life that belonged to me.” A small, pained smile touched her lips. “But I couldn’t even wish for it properly. I didn’t know what freedom looked like. I’d never had the chance to imagine it.”

She let her fingers drift through the water. The ripples shimmered like liquid moonlight, scattering soft light across her collarbones.

“So instead... I wished that I could at least be free in my dreams.”

Her eyes softened, warmed by a distant glow.

“That wish let me shape illusions and create entire worlds inside dreams,” Mifuyu continued. “But after I became a magical girl, I quickly learned how cruel this life could be. That’s when I met Yachiyo. We became best friends... partners who swore to protect each other. Over time, we lived together at Mikazuki Villa with other magical girls.”

Her voice warmed at the memory — then dimmed, like a candle flickering in a draft. “But that was when the painful memories began. We lost so many teammates. One after another. Girls we laughed with, fought beside, promised we’d save.”

The onsen fell quiet. Even the animals seemed to still, as though honoring the weight of her grief. A luminous deer lowered its head respectfully. The seals drifted closer, silent and attentive.

“Yachiyo... she changed. She grew cold. Distant. She came to believe her own wish—to survive and lead as a model—was cursed. That every time she kept living, another magical girl would die in her place.”

Mifuyu’s eyes shimmered with old grief. “Even then, she still wanted to stay with me until the end.”

She submerged her hands deeper into the water, as if trying to anchor herself.

“But I had my own breaking point. My magic began to weaken as I grew older. Watching so many girls die, watching Yachiyo suffer... it destroyed something inside me. I started desperately searching for salvation—for any way out for magical girls. That search led me to the Wings of the Magius.”

A soft, rueful laugh escaped her.

“Yachiyo was devastated. Her best friend — the one she wanted to stay with until the end — left her. Joined an organization she despised.”

Mami lowered her gaze; she knew the ache of a friend leaving all too well.

Mifuyu shook her head gently, water rippling around her shoulders.

“I thought about leaving the Wings so many times... going back to her side... but so many magical girls joined because of me. They looked up to me. If I left, they would fall into despair... I still wasn’t free. I wasn’t able to do what I truly wanted.”

The water around her glowed brighter, responding to the swirl of emotions.

“But yesterday... Yachiyo and I finally reconciled. We reached a mutual understanding. Something I’d longed for, for so many years.”

Her voice softened into something warm and luminous.

“And when I saw Lunaria’s quiet, graceful strength — the way she faced Kuroe’s witch with such gentleness — I knew I couldn’t hesitate anymore. For the first time in my life, I made a choice that was truly mine. I sacrificed myself to save the doppelified girls.”

Mifuyu lifted her hand from the water and touched the Soul Gem resting against the choker at her throat. The gem glowed faintly, reflecting the starlight above.

When she looked up again, her eyes held a new steadiness — a quiet, radiant certainty.

“Here, in this dream-realm... after learning what magic and Connect truly are, after seeing what’s possible... I feel stronger than I ever did before. I’m no longer the girl whose magic faded with age. I’m no longer trapped by expectations or fear.”

She smiled—soft, radiant, and genuinely free.

“I can finally live with confidence. With freedom. And I can choose, without hesitation, what I believe is right.”

Mami listened to Mifuyu’s final words with a soft, luminous smile — the kind that held pride, tenderness, and a quiet ache all at once. The glowing water of the onsen reflected in her golden eyes, turning them into warm lanterns beneath the star-sea sky.

“I’m happy for you, Mifuyu,” she said gently. “Truly. To live with confidence and freedom... that’s a dignity every magical girl deserves. I’ve also had a bit of a shift myself since coming here.”

She drew in a slow breath, letting the restorative heat settle into her bones. The water-snakes — ethereal ribbons of liquid light — curled around her arms with affectionate hisses, their scales shimmering like crushed pearls. She stroked one absentmindedly, her fingers trailing through its translucent form.

“Well,” she said with a small, self-deprecating laugh. “I suppose that leaves me. The final confession.”

The others turned toward her.

Momoko leaned forward, her usual boisterous energy channeled into a look of open, sisterly warmth. Kuroe offered a quiet, focused attentiveness, her eyes wide with the respect she held for the legendary veteran. Mifuyu watched with the heavy-lidded empathy of a fellow leader—one who knew exactly how much effort it took to keep one’s hair perfectly curled while the world was ending.

Dream-Kyoko, however, watched with a steady, piercing gaze — one that held a history the others couldn’t yet fathom.

Mami’s smile faltered, turning fragile.

“I didn’t have the luxury of time when I made my wish,” she began. “When I was younger... I was in a car accident with my parents. Both of them died instantly. And I was... I was fading. I could feel the cold coming for me.”

The onsen fell utterly silent. Even the dream-creatures stilled. The otters paused mid-float, their luminous eyes widening as they drifted like furry stars. The star-sea above seemed to slow its rotation, as though the entire realm were leaning in to hear the rhythm of her heart.

“Kyubey appeared in that red haze,” Mami continued, her voice dropping to a silver whisper. “And I... I simply wished to live. I didn’t think. I didn’t weigh the cost. I just begged for one more breath.”

“Dang... that’s heavy,” Momoko muttered, her usual bravado softened by a look of genuine hurt.

“Mami...” Kuroe whispered, her hands tightening on the edge of the spring.

“Thank you,” Mami murmured, touched by their immediate sorrow. She closed her eyes, and a single tear slipped down her cheek. When it hit the surface of the onsen, it didn’t splash; it rang out with a chime like a funeral bell, ripples of gold spreading outward. “If only I’d been smarter. If I had thought about my wish for even a second more... I could have saved them. I could have kept my parents. I could have wished for a future where I wasn’t the only survivor.”

She opened her eyes.

They shimmered with sadness — but the bitterness was gone.

In its place was a polished, gentle acceptance.

“But I didn’t. And for years, I believed I had to pay for that survival. I tried to justify why I was the one who walked away from that wreckage by being the perfect, selfless veteran. But... it was a lonely path. Most magical girls I met... They didn’t care about people. They only cared about the seeds.”

Her gaze drifted toward Dream-Kyoko, and her expression warmed significantly, a spark of maternal nostalgia lighting up her face.

“But then, I met a *little* girl with a huge spirit.”

Dream-Kyoko blinked, her cool, detached facade cracking. “Wait. Mami, don’t—”

Mami’s grin turned suddenly mischievous, the sadness evaporating into a playful spark. “I still remember how you looked after I pulled you out of that witch’s barrier. Those big, watery puppy-eyes. The way you clutched my ribbons like they were a safety blanket. You practically begged to be my disciple on the spot. You were *absolutely adorable*, Kyoko-chan.”

Splash!

Dream-Kyoko lost her balance and slipped into the glowing depths. She emerged a second later, her face a violent shade of crimson that rivaled her hair, steam practically hissing off her cheeks.

“H-hey! Don’t tell it like that!” she barked, frantically splashing a wave of warm water at Mami. “I wasn’t ‘adorable’! I was... I was just assessing the tactical situation! I wasn’t that pathetic!”

The tension snapped.

Mami, Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe all burst into genuine laughter—the kind that starts in the stomach and makes the eyes water. The sound echoed across the dream-scape, and even the otters chirped in rhythmic, giggling bursts, splashing their tails in sync.

When the laughter faded into the rising steam, Mami's expression softened once more, though the light stayed in her eyes.

“Kyoko was the first one who shared my ideals. We saved so many people. We were... family. But as she told you earlier... her father broke. The truth of her wish destroyed him.”

The water around them dimmed responsively, the light turning a somber, bruised purple.

“After that, Kyoko vowed to live only for herself. She left me. We broke apart... just like you and Yachiyo did, Mifuyu.”

Mifuyu nodded slowly.

“Yachiyo must have felt the same void you did. When we Connected earlier... Momoko and I felt the echoes of your loneliness, Mami. It was... a heavy thing to carry alone for so long.”

Mami took a slow breath, the steam curling around her golden curls.

“Later, I met Madoka and Sayaka. I was so desperate to have friends again — to have a tea party that wasn't for one. When Madoka told me she wanted to fight by my side... I felt like I was finally, truly alive again. It was the happiest moment of my life.”

Dream-Kyoko smirked, leaning back against a smooth rock, her embarrassment settling into a teasing glint.

“And then you got drunk on friendship and forgot the first rule: keep your head on a swivel,” she quipped, though her voice held a hidden streak of protectiveness. “Charlotte took you out in one bite. Seriously, Mami — getting chomped because you were too busy being a ‘cool senpai’? If I'd been there, I would've crushed that oversized doll before it could open its mouth.”

Kuroe, Momoko, and Mifuyu bit their lips, trying—and failing—to stifle their giggles at the sheer, unvarnished honesty of the remark. It was harsh, but coming from Kyoko, it was practically a love letter.

Mami's lips twitched. She looked between the laughing girls and the grinning Kyoko, her expression caught between mock-annoyance and pure amusement.

“Alright, I suppose I set myself up for that one,” she sighed, laughing despite herself. She brushed a wet strand of hair behind her ear, her face settling into a deep, unshakable serenity. “When I was falling into that darkness... I heard Lunaria's voice. And waking up here... it's changed me. I'm not the same Mami Tomoe who died in that labyrinth.”

She looked around at her companions, the glowing water, and the impossible sky.

“I have friends now... I am truly grateful.”

“Hey, don't get too sappy yet. You've just touched the tip of the iceberg,” Dream-Kyoko said, standing up and stretching, her silhouette dark against the glowing mist. “There is plenty more to see in this realm, and plenty more people to meet.”

The laughter echoed again, lighter this time. Above them, the sky shimmered with soft, ever-shifting dream-realm light, as if the realm itself was quietly watching over them.

The five of them are at the entrance of the coliseum. The night air was warm and fragrant, carrying the soft hum of dream-realm insects and the murmur of flowing water. Firefly-like creatures drifted lazily through the air, their bodies glowing in soft blues and golds. Moss-lit statues cast gentle halos across the stone path, and the sky above shimmered with constellations that pulsed like slow heartbeats.

Dream-Kyoko stretched her arms high above her head, letting out a long, unrestrained yawn that ended in a sharp, satisfied grin.

“Man... I'm beat,” she groaned, rolling her shoulders until the joints popped with satisfying clicks. She glanced at the others with a lazy, proud tilt of her head. “So? How was it today? Hope you all had fun.”

Momoko grinned back, giving her a bright, enthusiastic thumbs-up.

“Fun? I had a *blast*! Honestly, this morning feels like it was a week ago. Waking up in that cabin... it feels like a dream inside a dream.”

Mifuyu chuckled softly, her eyes warm with a mixture of exhaustion and newfound wonder.

“We learned so much today,” she said, her voice steady. “About magic. About the way our souls can *Connect*. About what it truly means to live as magical girls without the shadow of fear or the weight of despair.”

Kuroe nodded, her expression glowing with a quiet, fragile joy.

“And we saw things I never thought were possible,” she added. “Witches and magical girls living in harmony... the way I can communicate with witches now... everything in the dream-realm and the forest felt like a miracle unfolding.”

Mami stepped closer to Dream-Kyoko, her smile gentle and sincere.

“I hope we can spend time like this again soon, Kyoko-chan. Today was... special.”

Dream-Kyoko's grin widened, bright and toothy.

Dream-Kyoko's grin widened, bright and toothy. “Oh, we definitely will. Next time with even more people. I'm already planning the next round of chaos.” She clapped her hands together, the sound echoing through the starlit plaza like a starting pistol. “But for now... time for some shut-eye. The dream is closing up shop.”

Before any of them could respond, their bodies began to sparkle—tiny motes of light rising from their skin like drifting embers from a hearth. Momoko yelped in surprise, watching her hands turn to stardust. Mifuyu blinked rapidly, her form softening into a golden haze, while Kuroe reached out to touch the shimmering air around her, a look of peace on her face. Mami let out a soft, contented gasp as the world around her dissolved.

“Night everyone! Rest up for the big day tomorrow!” Dream-Kyoko called as they vanished into light.

They reappeared in front of the forest cabin — the same peaceful haven where their morning had begun. The night air was cool and fresh, filling their lungs with the sweet scent of wildflowers and the rich, earthy fragrance of moss and soil. Tall trees arched overhead, their leaves swaying gently in the breeze. Moonlight filtered through the canopy in soft silver ribbons, and the stars above glittered like scattered diamonds.

The forest felt alive—not loud, but quietly breathing, a sanctuary welcoming them home.

Mami inhaled deeply, letting the cool air settle her racing heart. “So,” she murmured, the gold of her ribbons catching the moonlight. “It looks like we’re back.”

Momoko, Mifuyu, and Kuroe turned in slow circles, taking in the serene beauty.

“This realm is gorgeous,” Momoko whispered, her voice barely audible over the rustle of the leaves.

“Both realms are,” Mifuyu added, looking up at the diamonds scattered across the dark velvet sky.

“Day or night... everything feels like it was made for us to find peace.”

They stepped inside the cabin, where the scent of cedar and tea greeted them. Warm lamplight spilled across the floor—soft, golden, and profoundly comforting. Lunaria and Kasumi sat on floor cushions in their sleepwear, looking relaxed and cozy. When the door opened, both girls turned toward them with bright, knowing smiles.

“Welcome back,” Lunaria said, her voice as melodic as a chime.

Kasumi waved a hand cheerfully. “Dream-Kyoko told us everything! Sounds like you all had a great time—and that you’ve finally got a solid plan to save Sayaka.”

Mami returned the smile, bowing her head slightly in respect. “That’s right. And Dream-Kyoko showed us what you two did today as well. How you learned Ui’s story... and how you saw the moment Sayaka fell.”

Momoko plopped onto a cushion with a dramatic, exaggerated sigh of relief. “You two did and saw so much today. Are all your adventures like that?”

Kasumi laughed brightly, her eyes sparkling.

“Oh, absolutely. Action, connection, chaos, and fun — no two days are ever the same!”

Mami looked between Lunaria and Kasumi, her expression turning thoughtful, the weight of the coming mission returning to her eyes.

“From what Dream-Kyoko told you... do you think we have a chance of saving Sayaka? Can we really save her from that fate?”

Kasumi leaned forward, her eyes gleaming with a touch of playful, yet serious, mischief.

“Well, what you went through today was just a simulation. A taste of the battle to come.” She wiggled her fingers dramatically, casting dancing shadows on the wall. “The real thing will be much more *chaotic*. *Real* stakes. *Real* consequences.”

Mami chuckled softly. “Thank you for the warning. Dream-Kyoko told us something similar. She doesn't sugarcoat things.”

Lunaria's expression softened into something serene and deeply reassuring. She reached out, her presence radiating a calm that seemed to banish the last of their doubts.

“Even so... I believe you will succeed. All of you learned so much today. You didn't just gain power; you grew in the ways that truly matter. You learned more about yourselves and each other. Believe in that strength.”

Mifuyu placed a hand over her heart, her Soul Gem glinting with a clear, steady light.

“Yes,” she said firmly. “I learned more today about magic and the power of *Connect* than I have in my entire life as a magical girl. It's incredible... for the first time, I don't just feel like I'm surviving. I feel like I'm growing.”

At Mifuyu's mention of learning and growing, Kuroe's eyes widened as though a spark had ignited behind them. She sat up straighter, the golden lamplight catching the subtle, iridescent sheen of her raven-black hair.

“Oh—right,” she breathed, her voice gaining a rare, focused clarity. “There's something I've been meaning to ask.”

Mami, Momoko, and Mifuyu turned toward her, sensing the shift in her energy. Lunaria and Kasumi exchanged a knowing glance, their smiles softening with a patient, ancient kind of warmth.

Kuroe clasped her hands together in her lap, gathering her courage against the natural instinct to remain quiet.

“Earlier today... after I finished my special training, I spoke with the others,” she began, ticking the names off like a litany. “Tamashii, Suzume, Shizuku, Airi, Yume, Mio, and even the Forgotten Queen. I asked them something.”

She swallowed hard, her gaze flickering between Lunaria and Kasumi. “I asked if... if you two were Witches.”

The air in the cabin seemed to vibrate. Momoko nearly choked on her breath, her eyes bulging. Mifuyu's jaw tightened in a silent gasp, and Mami's hand flew to her mouth, her tea-set elegance momentarily forgotten.

Kuroe continued, her cheeks warming to a soft rose, but her voice remained steady.

"I mean... it makes sense, doesn't it? I learned today that I'm a Witch now. Lunaria pulled me out of the depths of my despair, but she didn't turn me back into a Magical Girl. I've mastered my Doppel. I can talk to witches now. I can bestow my Witch's Kiss on others to let them communicate with witches."

She looked directly at Lunaria, her expression trembling with a mix of hope and profound realization.

"And yesterday... Lunaria, you talked to my witch. But you don't carry a Witch's Kiss. You don't have a Soul Gem. Neither of you do. So... does that mean...?"

Her voice dropped to a silver whisper that seemed to carry the weight of the entire forest. "Are you Witches too? Both of you?"

The room fell into a heavy, breathless silence. Mami, Momoko, and Mifuyu stared at their guardians with wide eyes and a soul-deep wonder. The theory fit perfectly. It explained the impossible power, the lack of Gems, the intimate understanding they had of despair.

Kasumi leaned forward, her eyes dancing with a playful, mischievous light.

"Wow Kuroe, what a bold question!" she said with a cheeky wink. "A lot of witches start asking that same question once they learn what you did today."

Lunaria's smile was different—smaller, gentler, and tinged with a melancholy that was as beautiful as falling petals.

"Maybe..." she murmured, the word echoing like a distant bell. "Maybe another time."

The four girls groaned in perfect, frustrated unison.

"Oh, come on!" Momoko barked, though her grin gave her away.

Mami pouted with dramatic flair, crossing her arms. "We're getting the usual treatment again. The gentle deflection. The legendary 'maybe next time.' You're keeping us in suspense on purpose!"

Kasumi laughed, a bright, melodic sound that filled the cabin.

Kuroe giggled too, the tension leaving her shoulders as she rubbed the back of her neck. "The people I asked... they encouraged me to find the answer for myself. I can't tell if they're sworn to secrecy or if they're just as in the dark as we are."

Momoko shook a fist with fiery, playful determination. "Well, we'll find out eventually. You two can't stay enigmas forever. We're magical girls—uncovering secrets is what we do!"

Mifuyu nodded, her gaze lingering on the way the lamplight didn't quite seem to cast a normal shadow behind Lunaria. "And after all... yesterday, when Mitama asked for the truth, you said 'at least not yet.' That implies a 'yes' is waiting for us down the road."

Kasumi stood up with a dramatic, theatrical flourish, spinning once like a dancer before stretching her arms toward the rafters.

"There will be a day when the veil drops!" she declared, her voice ringing with mock-grandeur. "But until then... keep guessing! It keeps the soul lively."

She followed it with a massive, unrefined yawn, flopping her arms back down. "Anyway, I'm pooped. I'm calling it. Nighty-night, everyone!"

With a cheerful twirl, she padded off toward her room, her footsteps silent on the wood.

Lunaria rose more gracefully, her movements fluid and ethereal.

"Goodnight, everyone," she said warmly. She paused at the hallway, looking back at the three newest arrivals. "Feel free to choose any room that calls to you. We kept you together last night so you'd feel safe on your first morning, but tonight... rest where your heart feels most at peace."

She bowed her head in a gesture of deep respect, then slipped away, the click of her door sounding like a final punctuation mark on the day.

Momoko yawned so hard her eyes watered. "I can barely keep my head up," she mumbled. "I'm hitting the hay."

One by one, the girls exchanged quiet, sleepy goodnights. The cabin lights dimmed automatically, responding to the settling energy of its inhabitants.

Outside, the forest whispered—a low, rhythmic rustle of leaves that sounded like a lullaby.

As they drifted off, their thoughts wove together like threads in a tapestry.

Mami fell asleep thinking of her new magical girl friends — and the new people she would meet in the dream-realm.

Momoko dreamt of the dream-realm's vast horizon, itching to see what else there was to explore.

Mifuyu replayed the mechanics of Connect, imagining a future where Kamihama's girls didn't have to hide in the shadows.

Kuroe clutched her blanket, thinking of her complete Witch form — not as a beast to fear, but as a power she would soon call her own.

Tomorrow, they would return to the world that had broken them, ready to face Sayaka and the shadows of their past.

But tonight... they slept with the rarest of magical girl treasures.

They slept with hope.

And the starlit night embraced them all.